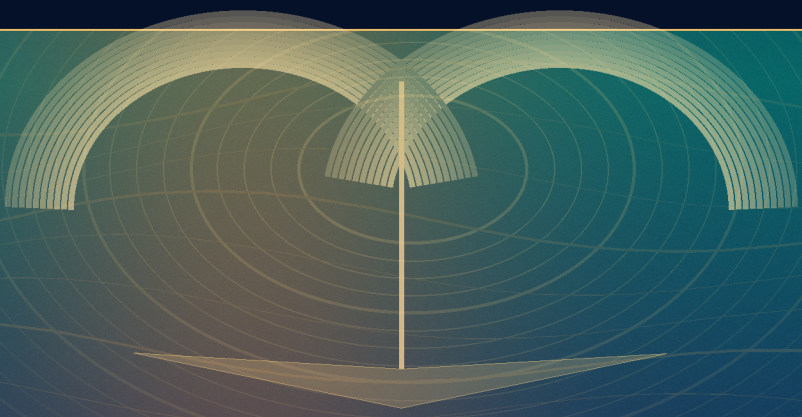
VIDEHA · FICTION

82 SELECTED STORIES

FROM TEN MAITHILI COLLECTIONS



GAJENDRA THAKUR

Selected and Edited by Ashish Anchinhar

TRANSLATED FROM ORIGINAL MAITHILI INTO ENGLISH
BY THE AUTHOR HIMSELF

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VIDEHA / SELECTED FICTION

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AN ENGLISH-LANGUAGE COLLECTION

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Rights in the original works remain with their respective author and rights holders. The stories in the Maithili selection were drawn from the texts of their source volumes.

English translations of Stories 1–80 have been assembled from the English-language volumes supplied for this edition. Stories 81–82 have been translated from the Maithili selection for this collection.

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The editorial introduction and the contents are separate from the stories.

Editorial Introduction

This selection of eighty-two stories by Gajendra Thakur brings together works from ten original books or volumes. The internal sequence follows the source collections. The purpose of the selection is not merely to display a range of subjects, but to offer an opportunity to examine how narrative achieves its artistic effect through language, material circumstances, characters' decisions and the incompleteness of events.

The five selections from The Black Bee Is Sleeping Atop the Mountain explore religious standing, rights over a homestead, social relations, the language of learned tradition and questions of caste in different ways. A long story and a very short piece of microfiction cannot be read by the same measure; yet what remains unsaid, the moment of decision and the social perspective matter equally in both.

In the selected stories from The Other Side of Memory, recollection, documents, family promises and social evidence repeatedly disagree with one another. The Copyist and The Last Reader raise questions about texts; The Dry Kamala addresses geography and public memory; and The Sisters and House Number Five give narrative form to the history contained within a home.

The five works from Light — Stories Across Lifetimes employ distinct narrative approaches to lineage, musical expression, justice, labour and identity. They should be read not as illustrations of a moral lesson, but through their independent endings and the choices made by their characters.

Thirty selections from the three volumes of The Hundred-Story Trilogy and thirty from the three volumes of Three Streams of Stories are drawn from different original story cycles. Subjects and incidents may resemble one another, but preserving each work's original number, narrative circumstances and narrative form is an essential principle of the selection.

Throughout this fictional world, the distance between village and town, the social experience of Mithila, Vajji and Anga, schools, hospitals, offices, fields, taps, ponds, verandas, labour accounts and family relationships are more than background. In many stories these objects and institutions determine the characters' decisions and the movement of the plot.

The two stories for younger readers selected from New Wings place literary craft alongside social dignity, curiosity and shared responsibility. In Life on Crutches, the order in which readers form their assumptions matters; in The Book Saved in the Flood, a thoughtful relationship develops between preserving human life and safeguarding written memory.

In making this selection, the editorial decisions of the comparative assessments previously completed for each original collection have been accepted. The titles,

original numbers and texts of the Maithili works were checked against their source books, and interpretation and introductory commentary were kept separate from the stories. Literary excellence here is a reasoned editorial judgment, not a universal or final ranking.

Readers may approach these eighty-two stories in their original sequence, or look for connecting threads across the collections. Allowing an unresolved question to remain unresolved, and distinguishing documented events from characters' fears and suspicions, are among the critical responsibilities of this selection.

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FROM THE BLACK BEE IS SLEEPING ATOP THE MOUNTAIN

STORY 01

Siddha Mahavir

1

By the side of the embankment stood the house of Anmana Didi (the Distracted Sister).

"House" would be an overstatement; let's call it a single-room shed (Ekchari). In almost every courtyard of the village, there resides a widow's hut. However, as families expand, someone turns the face of their house away, or someone builds a partition. Occasionally, the very location of that widow's dwelling is shifted—such was the state of Anmana Didi's home.

Yet, Anmana Didi's hut was by the embankment. Originally from the Majkothia ward, she had gradually shifted toward our house. She was a woman of self-respect.

The young girls of the neighborhood would visit her during the day or afternoon to help comb her hair and pick out lice. To whom she truly belonged would only be known after her death. At the time of the funeral rites, whoever is closest will light the pyre and inherit the homestead. But even that possibility seemed bleak now. Anmana Didi's in-laws were in Jhanjharpur. There, she had adopted her sister's son as her own. Yet, her attachment to her paternal village (Naihar) remained unbroken.

She would come to her single-room hut at least once a month. She managed everything herself—cooking and chores. Despite having a large house and a proper courtyard in Jhanjharpur, she never brought her son or daughter-in-law here.

In the village, a widow is called "Didi" if she stays in her paternal home, and "Kaki" (Aunt) of such-and-such village if she stays with her in-laws. Thus, the entire village knew her as Anmana Didi.

Beside her hut, she had built a temple for the Lord—Mahavir Bajrangbali. Initially, it wasn't a concrete structure, but she eventually turned it into a small room by selling her grain and savings. Earlier, it too was just a shed. Whenever Anmana Didi went to Jhanjharpur, she would pull the shutter of her hut close. Later, she began securing it with a chain and padlock. But the temple of Bajrangbali always remained open—day and night—for the people. The village girls would clean and sweep it regularly.

The temple eventually became a brick structure with a stone-slab roof. She wanted to plaster the floor, but the estimate exceeded her budget. Could the Lord's house be left to leak? But where would the money for the concrete casting and plastering come from?

Today, I feel as though we all work incredibly hard. we have no concern for others. "Oh, there's just no time," we say. But look at Anmana Didi's routine—from dawn to dusk, dedicated to the Lord. Yet, she still found time for her adopted son. She would occasionally visit her village near the Jhanjharpur market to manage affairs there, then return to her paternal village.

Consider our own struggles to become 'Sthitaprajna' (equanimous) by reading the Gita. And then, look at Anmana Didi. "I bow to you, Didi." "Be well," she would reply. No visible joy, no apparent sorrow. No desire for hospitality, and no aspiration for assistance of any kind.

She would go to Dhanuktol or Dusadhtol to find laborers. The people there respected her; after all, she wasn't there to take away their land. I would even see her laughing there. She strictly avoided asking the people of her own neighborhood for any work. If one did a task for her, he would go home and tell his wife, and then for the next ten years, that wife would never let her hear the end of it.

"Didi, this is Hanuman Ji's work, and he is right by the road. We all bow our heads in prayer whenever we pass by. So, I will do this work without taking any wages," a local once offered.

"No, sir," she replied. "One should not perform or solicit acts for pilgrimages or God for free. I am no Queen or Great Lady that I would build a temple or dig a pond by forced unpaid labor (Begari)."

But the concrete casting and the plastering... how?

2

Adjacent to the temple by the road lay one Bigha (unit of land), all belonging to Anmana Didi. She intended to transfer the land to the Lord's name once the concrete casting was completed. Whatever grain was harvested from it would then fund the whitewashing, repair, and maintenance of the Lord's house.

For days, a neighbor—her nephew—had been persistently cornering her.

"Didi, I am your closest nephew. This land is right next to my house. In the old days, people used to let the marginalized or widows build huts by the embankments and roads. But times have changed. Now, land by the roadside is gold. You will pass away today or tomorrow. After that, this land will only become a bone of contention among us kinsmen."

"You will pass away today or tomorrow"—imagine saying this to a woman whose husband is alive. But one feels entitled to say it to a widow, regardless of her having an adopted son, daughter-in-law, or grandchildren. Fine, son, she thought.

"This land is dedicated to the Lord. It's what I live on. Whatever I save by cutting back on my own meals is for the Lord's house—for the casting and the plaster. The property in Jhanjharpur belongs to my son and daughter-in-law. How can I...?"

"Again, Didi, you miss the point. Keep it as long as you live. Use it for your livelihood. I'm just saying—will you like it if the kinsmen fight over this after you're gone? And I am your most devoted nephew..."

See how he talks! This nephew works away from the village. Those who stay in the village usually avoid her, fearing they might have to give her something. But whenever this one visits the village while I am there, he makes sure to meet me. This time, he even tracked me down in Jhanjharpur. I wondered how he had suddenly become so mindful; now I understand.

But how will the casting be done? The plastering can wait, but the leakage is unbearable. It's leaking even more this year. The thatched roof didn't even last two years. Only when Karim Mian and Lakhmi Mistri strip it off and do the concrete casting will it be fixed. Let's see.

The nephew's visits have become more frequent lately.

"Fine, Didi, just give me half the land. Ten Katthas are enough for your nephew's home, and you'll still have land left for the Lord."

"But it's not enough for a proper homestead on the embankment. What will you gain from it?"

"Don't worry about that. I still have to come through the ward anyway. My homestead isn't exactly by the road; it's the land behind it. Building houses at crossroads and by embankments is a new trend. And at such a junction, only a House of God looks graceful. I will give you ten thousand for the ten Katthas whenever you say. The registry can happen later."

"Fine. I will think about it. Let me ask my son and daughter-in-law once."

There seemed no other way. Moss had started covering the temple walls. Not just the walls—even the idol of Bajrangbali was turning green with moss. Anmana Didi kept thinking. She thought until the break of dawn.

I'll give him the land. What other choice is there? No!

The son and daughter-in-law said, "Mother, that land belongs to the Lord; we have known that from the start. But be careful. See if he is playing some trick."

"What trick? He is actually paying a bit more than the market rate."

Ten Katthas aren't exactly a small piece for a temple. I've exhausted myself trying to gather the funds. Will this half-finished temple remain like this forever? I should talk to Lakhmi Mistri and Karim Mian.

With ten thousand, the casting, plastering, and even a boundary wall could be built. The estimate was ready. Work would begin the day after the registry. And it would be finished before the month of Bhadav (monsoon peak).

3

Well, the registration was completed. Das Ji is a man highly skilled in paperwork. No need to even question it! Rest assured, the documents must be solid.

"This is the first time I've had the opportunity to prepare documents for the Lord, Didi," Das Ji said, his words leaving Anmana Didi deeply moved and grateful.

People wrongly claim that faith in God is declining. Look at this man, Das Ji. No prior meetings, no prior acquaintance. Two sets of registration papers—one for the ten Katthas in the nephew's name and the other in the name of the Lord—yet he charged for only one. He said clearly, "Didi, I will absolutely not take a single penny for registering the Lord's land. After all, those who stand by you in your hour of need are your true kin." Truly, the elders were right; they must have witnessed such kindness to have said those words.

Anmana Didi was overwhelmed with emotion. She returned to the village on foot. Her mind was a blur of joy. She cleared the temple; the work was to begin tomorrow. Lakhmi Mistri had already left his trowel, measuring cord, and tools there. Anmana Didi had already ensured the water troughs were ready to be filled. The pond was nearby; though filled with weeds, the villagers had cleared a small patch at the edge for the buffaloes to drink.

But the next morning brought a sudden storm. Karim Mian was stopped from working. Who stopped him? "Inform the nephew!" someone shouted. But the nephew had left for his job straight from Jhanjharpur yesterday. Although Anmana Didi held a copy of the registration papers, it was the nephew's brother-in-law who was obstructing the work. He wouldn't allow the boundary wall to be built.

"But he was present yesterday during the registration! Then why now?"

He claimed that the land by the embankment belonged to the 'Guest' (the brother-in-law/nephew's kin). "Wait, if that's the case, then doesn't the temple fall into his portion too?" Could there be a mistake in understanding the boundaries? The nephew wouldn't return until the start of next month after collecting his salary. For a whole month, Anmana Didi shuttled between her village and Jhanjharpur. Her son and daughter-in-law asked, "Mother, could this be a ploy by the nephew himself?"

"No, don't say that," she replied. "Das Ji seemed like such a good man."

We shall see.

4

"Didi, you are under some kind of delusion."

"Then I suppose this temple belongs to you now as well?"

"No, Didi. The temple belongs to the Lord. It will remain His. And the land behind it—the Lord is its owner too."

"In that case, I suppose this hut of mine is yours now as well?"

"No, Didi. You may stay here as long as you live. Who would stop you?"

"That is a great kindness of yours, son. But there is no access to the land at the back—neither from the embankment nor from the village side."

"Didi, you are free to walk across my land; who is stopping you? Everyone walks along the ridges of the fields. Just because someone's field isn't by the embankment doesn't mean they can't reach their land. You are talking like those modern people who create walls over every little division."

"But you never mentioned any of this before."

"Didi, I told you everything. But it seems you are confused. If you don't believe me, let's call Das Ji. He is an outsider; he has no stake in this."

"I see... so he is in on this too."

"That poor man prepared two registration documents and charged you for only one, and here you are accusing him of being 'in on it'!" The nephew's voice rose sharply. He began to pant with feigned indignation and walked away, grumbling loudly.

5

For Anmana Didi, this morning in her paternal village felt exactly like that morning in her in-laws' house when she had become a widow. Today, the village girls did not come to help her pick lice from her hair. Her night-long conversation with Lord Bajrangbali had only just ceased with the break of dawn. In the courtyards nearby, people were patting their children to sleep. Some had come by earlier, suggesting a Panchayati (village council meeting) to settle the matter. But Anmana Didi's resentment was directed entirely at Bajrangbali.

"I thought I would sell half of the Lord's land to build the Lord's house. But he (the nephew) got the land adjacent to the temple registered in his name, and the land that remains has no access left for the temple. Forget the access; he has blocked the very path leading to it. And this Bajrangbali... Mahavir! What power does he truly possess? For forty years, I stinted on my own food to move him from a thatched hut into a brick house. My only wish was to see the concrete casting done and a boundary wall built—and that too, was for him alone. Ha..."

6

That morning, Anmana Didi stood at her nephew's doorstep. People expected a fierce confrontation to break out. But what was happening instead? Lakhmi's brother had brought a rickshaw. Anmana Didi was leaving for Jhanjharpur with her nephew. Who told them? No one had even spoken to her. I had suggested holding a Panchayati, but she had silently declined. Ah, it was Lakhmi's brother who told us; he was the one sent to fetch the rickshaw, and he mentioned they were headed for Jhanjharpur.

Das Ji had to prepare yet another set of registration papers. Upon seeing Anmana Didi, he turned cold with apprehension, wondering what earful the old woman might give him. But Anmana Didi was possessed by such a silent,

towering rage that she uttered not a single word. She swallowed her fury. She registered the remaining back-lot of the land to the nephew as well. Then, turning away from Jhanjharpur station, she set off on foot toward Jhanjharpur market, toward her son and daughter-in-law.

Lakhmi's brother returned. He had taken two passengers but returned with only one. He brought back a message—a message for Lakhmi Mistri and Karim Mian. The work was to begin tomorrow morning.

Again?

7

The boundary wall was built. It enclosed both the temple and Anmana Didi's hut. The nephew had assured her—as long as she lived, no one would touch her home.

The home—or rather, the shack—began to crumble within a year. By the following monsoon, its wooden pillars rotted and collapsed.

But Anmana Didi did not return. Someone from her paternal village had sent word. The concrete casting for Bajrangbali's roof was never done. Anmana Didi returned from Haridwar. People asked her, "What did you ask of Mother Ganga?"

"That she remove this superstition from my mind," she replied.

"And what did you offer to Mother Ganga?"

"I gave her my rage."

Anmana Didi would only say this: "What would He do anyway? There is no power in Bajrangbali. Let the shack collapse. How long can a house plagued by white ants and decay stand?"

8

Several years passed. To be precise, it was the fifth year. The nephew had come to the village after collecting his salary. He sat by the handpump near the pond with his brass water-pot when a sharp pain gripped his chest. He could not be saved.

The villagers began to whisper, "Look, it's Anmana Didi's curse. She had wept bitterly that day. Before this, perhaps there was no power in the idol of Bajrangbali, but a curse delivered from the depths of the heart always strikes. Bajrangbali became 'awakened' (active) that very day, and today, He has shown His power."

However, Anmana Didi said to the messenger, "Do you really think stones have life? It must have been a heart attack. Just the day before yesterday, a Marwari gentleman here suffered an attack. These attacks are caused by worry and stress. Since there are doctors nearby, the Marwari man survived. In the village, delays cost lives. That is exactly why, in my old age, I choose to live here in Jhanjharpur with my son and daughter-in-law."

9

The village is Mahisbar, a village of Brahmins. After witnessing the game of Huda-Hudi (bull-baiting/chasing) played by these Mahisbar Brahmins on the day of Sukhratri, one would lose all interest in a game of Polo. It involves a buffalo, intoxicated with bhang and goaded into a frenzy by a pig bought from the Dom community of Samiya.

The artistry of the herder, perched skillfully while holding the buffalo's tail, was extraordinary. The role of the Dom community is indispensable during festivals—from making wicker baskets (Petar) to winnowing fans (Sup) and hand-fans (Biani). And for the goats slaughtered to welcome guests and wedding parties, the services of the Mian-toli (Muslim quarter) are essential.

But I digress.

During the sacrifices of Durga Puja, the committee takes the goat's head. The Mian who slaughters the goat performs the Halal; the neck hangs halfway, but while dressing the meat, he takes the neck and the hide as well. Then, those Mahisbar Brahmins who sing hymns and perform Ashtajam at the Hanuman temple buy drums (Dholak) made from that very hide. And a kirtan was indeed underway.

Right in front of the Siddha Mahaveer temple. A massive pennant (Dhuja) hoisted on Ramnavami. The rhythmic clanging of bells and gongs. The flag of Hanuman Ji flutters in the evening breeze. The Mahisbars have gathered. Whatever the festival—be it Huda-Hudi or Ramnavami—kirtans are always held before Siddha Hanuman. It's a matter of the villagers' faith, sir. And it continues even today.

The smoke from the communal fire (Ghur) attempts to drive the mosquitoes away from the cattle. One man has come with another to take an oath. The villagers have finally plastered the Hanuman temple. The concrete casting is also done. The number of people who touch the temple veranda to swear off their debts is negligible, yet there is an exception—one who says, "Oaths are taken only to be broken." Indeed, if a single oath could liberate one from debt, where is the harm? But he is the only exception.

The people now refer to Anmana Didi as Anmana Baba. It has been several years since her passing. She never returned. To ward off the "evil eye" from the nephew's homestead, a priest suggested tying a cow to a post. Passers-by always see it grazing there, ensuring the site remains protected from ill omens.

Hanuman Ji's flag flutters. It is evening. Gonar Bhai is striking the drum in the kirtan, beat after beat.

People have now begun to accept Anmana Baba's perspective. True. Two groups of devotees have formed before the idol of Hanuman Ji. One group holds a somewhat scientific view—that Anmana Didi's registration of the remaining ten Katthas (to the nephew) was the very thing that triggered the fatal stress in

the nephew's chest. He simply couldn't withstand her psychological counter-attack. They believe stones possess no inherent power.

However, the second group believes in the "proven" (Siddha) and "awakened" nature of Mahaveer Hanuman. They argue, "Sir, if you bury an ant under the soil, it will die, but it won't die without first biting you with all its might. And Anmana Didi gave this very soil (the land) to Mahaveer Ji—so how could He let it go?"

Gonar Bhai continues to strike the drum with relentless rhythm; it seems he won't stop until he has moved Siddha Mahaveer. The ball of bhang is taking effect; his eyes are glazed, his hands refuse to tire. And if you look through his eyes, the stone idol of Siddha Mahaveer will appear awakened—as if life has suddenly breathed into it!

STORY 02

Doma, Budhan, and...

1

Budhan's younger brothers used to die almost immediately after birth. To save the next newborn, Budhan's parents performed a ritual: they symbolically "sold" the infant to a member of the Dom community (traditionally associated with crematoriums and basket weaving) and then "bought" him back with some money. This ritual was meant to ward off the evil eye or planetary ill-effects. The child, who was twelve years younger than Budhan Paswan, survived.

Because of this ritual, everyone started calling him Doma.

Budhan worked as a sharecropper (Harwaha) alongside his parents, but he nurtured a deep desire to educate his younger brother. "I've heard that in our community, even a little education can get you a job. I will definitely make him study, even if I have to starve or beg for it," Budhan resolved.

He didn't resort to begging, but instead, he took the road to Chandigarh. "I want to educate Doma and make him someone important," Budhan whispered to himself.

In Chandigarh, Budhan now pulled a rickshaw. Back in the village, farming no longer provided a livelihood. He would pull the rickshaw all day, and in the evening, when his companions went to the local country-liquor shops to ease their exhaustion, Budhan would make excuses and head home.

"Hey mate, what's wrong? You look restless. Can't you sleep?" "No, brother. I've been pulling the rickshaw in the wind all day, and now every joint in my body is aching." "Listen, come to the liquor shop. You always make excuses. Look at us—we drink and snore all night. One sound sleep and all the tiredness vanishes by morning."

Budhan would listen to Koraila's words and remain silent. A doubt often gnawed at him—would Doma actually study? If he told his friends today that he was sacrificing his comforts for Doma's education, and if Doma failed to become something, what then? These same companions would mock his sacrifice tomorrow. So, he kept his secret to himself, saved every penny he could, and sent it back home. And with that, Doma continued his studies.

However, in the village school, not a single child from the Dalit or poor communities was studying. The government launched a scheme to distribute free books to Dalit children. Master Sahab, a Yadav Ji, went door-to-door to summon the children to school. He enrolled them without any fees. For a week or ten days, children from the Dusadh, Chamar, and Dhobi colonies attended. Doma was among them. Everyone received books, but after ten days, they all vanished from the school. Seeing this, children from the Kumhar (potter) and Hajam

(barber) colonies also came, hoping for free books. But they were told, "You belong to 'upper' castes; this free book scheme isn't for rich people like you."

"Is 'caste' something that stays small or grows big, sir? To date, the best Chief Minister of the state has been Karpoori Thakur, hasn't he, Asin Jha?" Jayram Thakur asked, peering through his tattered roof as he cut Asin Ji's hair in the sunlight. "You're right about that, sir."

Eventually, apart from the Brahmins and Bhumihars, no one else was left in the school. The local 'upper' castes started buying those free books from the Dalit children at half-price. "I won't give you more than half. Granted, the books are new, but you got them for free anyway, didn't you?"

And so, the books were swept out of the Dusadh, Chamar, and Dhobi colonies. And no one knew whether Doma actually studied or not.

2

But Doma stayed in the village and eventually became a Teacher. And Budhan's son received his education in Chandigarh. And finally, Budhan returned to his village.

3

I met Budhan's son in Gurugram, where he serves as the Head of the Northern Region for Amazon's logistics team. He had heard about my condition, and I had heard of his success. He had come specifically to ignite my fading memory; he knew that only a story could reconnect the frayed wires of my mind.

Everything was hazy—like twilight. I knew I had heard of him, but... let it be. My memory failed me once more.

"My father told me a story about your father," he began. I looked at him expectantly, wondering which fragment of the past he would revive. "My father passed away in 1995," I noted.

"At a community feast in Kahandan, my father was serving rice. Jagannath from Mishratoli sneered, 'No one will eat what you touch!' But then, you stepped in and embraced him—who speaks of such things now?"

"Yes," I recalled faintly, "I was the one who asked him to serve because I couldn't manage it alone."

"And when my uncle offered water to your maternal uncle, and your uncle asked, 'Have you brought this?' my uncle firmly told him to drink it quietly. He pointed at you and said, 'It was his father who started the tradition of us sharing water.'"

"Yes! I remember now. My maternal uncle had said, 'Give it to me, I never refused. My brother-in-law established this path, I know.' Both of them are gone now, but that act remains."

"Do you remember now?" "Yes. Old memories return when nudged; it's the recent ones that trouble me."

The new generation of India. "Is the village still the same, or has it changed?" I asked him. "It has changed a lot—for better and for worse." "Better and worse?"

"Look," he explained, "in all three village schools, Dalit and backward-class children now study and eat together. Earlier, they only got books; now they get meals too." "That's good. But what's the 'worse' part?"

"Earlier, 'Caste' existed, but I feel it had a socio-cultural and economic base. Everyone had their own heroes and elders. But now, it is being hardened into a rigid 'Caste System.' I had an inter-caste marriage; my wife is a Brahmin. But the opposition came more from my own community than from hers or mine. Then there's the complication of government reservations. Politicians tell people to marry within their caste to save the reservation, but the new generation doesn't care for it."

Caste and the Caste System are two different things!

"The priest of the Rigveda was the Hota, of the Samaveda the Udgatri, of the Yajurveda the Adhvaryu, and of the Atharvaveda the Brahmin. Together with the assisting priests, there were seventeen kinds of priests in the Vedic period. Your communities have priests too. How, then, did the Brahmin become the one and only priest? The title 'Hota' still survives in Odisha. Even there, Rigvedic, Samavedic and Yajurvedic Brahmins do not enter into marriages with the Atharvavedic Brahmins of the Pippalada Samhita, whom they describe as violent. In discussions of Dalit questions, people repeatedly cite Shambuka's killing in the Uttara Kanda of the Valmiki Ramayana: he practised austerities, someone complained that he might rise in station, and Lord Rama killed him to answer that complaint.

"While telling a story in the Purusha-Pariksha, Vidyapati offers an authorial observation that Rajput women lack character. Both these instances resemble a claim circulated on social media and the internet and attributed to the Atharvaveda: that a man may take a Shudra's wife by the hand without her consent. Search the original Atharvaveda for the cited passage and you will not find it. Whoever made the claim has thrown a spark and disappeared without giving a reference. The burden of proof is shifted away from the accuser and onto you. Your energy is spent answering him. Later the internet may correct itself, while the original text remains unchanged.

"But return first to the Purusha-Pariksha. Vidyapati wrote in Sanskrit and Avahatta and served as a court poet. Would he have had the courage to speak this way about the women of the very caste to which his royal patron belonged? If a later copyist, his mind tainted by prejudice, altered the text to express his own sentiments, today's editors, commentators and translators ought to explain the matter in a note. Did Rama kill Shambuka, or did a prejudiced copyist, hostile to Shambuka, kill him in the text?

"Now consider the Atharvaveda. There are words there addressed to a woman: 'I am the Samaveda and you are the Rigveda.' And to a bride: 'I take your hand for prosperity.' The Atharvaveda and Samkhya are also associated with the Vratya tradition. The Vratyas did not recite the Gayatri mantra through three generations and were therefore regarded as forest-dwellers, people living apart. There was a rite called the Vratyastoma, rather like the present-day idea of 'homecoming', intended to bring people of this parallel tradition back. Some accounts describe Vratyas as given to violence, sexual transgression or intoxication, yet the Atharvaveda presents them as yogis. Elsewhere they are described as protectors of truth, devotees of Shiva and healers. Atharvavedic Brahmins themselves were likewise called violent. Prejudiced copyists inserted interpolations even into Vedic texts; linguists are now identifying such intrusions."

"Do you mean that even the Vedas could have been altered? Aren't they divine utterances?"

"In translations of the Vedas into foreign languages the names of the rishis were removed, but in the originals you will still find them."

"Yet the rishis are called seers, drashtas. Even if their names are there, aren't these still the words of God?"

"But among those Vedic seers were women and Shudra rishis too. Then who introduced compositions directed against women and Shudras? The Shudra rishi Kavasha Ailusha was the seer of Vedic verses; the woman Apala was another. Why should they have been pushed to the margins? The Vedas give three things alongside each hymn number: the rishi, the deity and the metre. You and I call the rishi a 'seer', but the Vedic rishis also called themselves, and their deities, poets. Vedic literature as a whole is an embodiment of this poetic consciousness. Spiritual awareness rises into the divine and takes form in the language of the material world. And even at that time, the Atharvaveda could liken groups who recited hymns together throughout the year to frogs croaking in welcome to the rain. That means a dissenting voice was admitted into song. The Rigveda, too, contains the song of the frogs."

"But if someone says 'whatever is in the Vedas is proof', does that not make an interpolation proof as well?"

"Patanjali's scientific principle for interpreting a mantra was 'yac chabda aha tad asmakam pramanam': for us, the evidence is what the word, or the word of the mantra, actually says. I cannot see how that later came to mean that the Veda itself, without qualification, was evidence. For me the rishi of a hymn and its deity are there; both are poets, the makers of its text. That is my evidence."

"Think of the peoples of Africa. Those who came to convert them told them that they were savages who needed to be civilised. Yet even communities that had conflicts possessed ways of settling them. The Abenaki, an Indigenous people of Canada living on the Odanak reserve, have a remarkable saying about the environment: 'Only when the last tree has been cut down, every stream poisoned

and the last fish killed will you realise that you cannot eat money.' Yet such peoples are called backward. Don't you think our arrangements and those of other countries are alike in some ways and different in others? Can distance and isolation alone solve the problem?"

"You work for Amazon, don't you? You people have even sent up a rocket from America, a private rocket. Soon there may be tourism. Fly in a rocket and look down at the green planet Earth. The farther away you travel, the dearer your own people will seem. When you draw near again, an embankment along a little stream may loom larger than a mountain. From far off, the Earth looks like one whole, and we are only a faint existence in this universe. Come closer, and you see land and water. A little closer, and you see white people and black people, people of many colours; so too birds, animals, trees and plants in many colours. On land and in water there are insects, fish and reptiles. Some creatures are so small that we cannot even see them. We do not understand their world, and they do not understand ours. Those who remained in cold regions for hundreds of thousands of years became light-skinned, and those who lived in hot regions became dark-skinned.

"Now send the rocket farther away once more, and look again. Human beings appear simply as human beings. They share the same DNA. Sometimes truth is disclosed only when we gain distance. A thousand years of enslavement and imperial power turned your caste or community into an element of the caste system. Empire will always search for a theoretical basis for ruling. It will always describe a caste as a caste system. But if you accept its account, its arrangements, its culture and its claims about what is good or bad, have you not yourself helped to turn caste into a caste system? The same thing was done in Australia, in America and in Africa.

"When no gold was found in Mauritius or on the Caribbean islands, the colonisers began cultivating sugarcane. They took bonded labourers from India for the sugar fields. Yet over there no one is designated Dalit or Backward. People from your village, from many communities and especially from Dalit and backward communities, were also taken away, chained and put aboard ships. But there they came to be regarded as forward. The people there did not allow the distinctions carried from India to become the same caste system. So the change is not impossible. Sometimes going far away is necessary too. Introduce yourself once more. While I am speaking, I have begun to forget people lately."

He was silent. I tried to recognise him. My thoughts turned towards the dreams I had in the night. On waking, I become anxious for no good reason. My wife's maternal cousin died; her son became an engineer, and if she had arranged his marriage, then… Now even when my car's diesel gauge moves into reserve, I grow anxious. There is no petrol pump on the road ahead; the one that exists lies below the flyover. Will the car stop before I can reach a pump on the return journey in the evening?

Pollution had risen in Delhi, Stage Three emergency restrictions had been imposed, and Bharat Stage III petrol vehicles and Bharat Stage IV four-wheeled

diesel vehicles were barred for a week. So I had come by Uber. Two-wheelers, in the speaker's reckoning, contribute thirty-four per cent of the pollution, but they are the government's voters and were not restricted. There are fewer four-wheeler owners, and they are thought not to turn out to vote; so the burden of reducing pollution was placed upon them. The government seems to think they are not voters at all.

"Introduce yourself again," I said. "I am Budhan's son." "Yes."

"The problems you see are being resolved," I told him. "I wasn't happy with the solutions either—free meals in school, housing, cheap rice. But look deeper. Self-respect has arrived. Train a fisherman for the Olympics; give the leatherworker a company like Bata; make the blacksmith the owner of a plywood factory. Just as you took your rights, no one can stop a blacksmith from owning a furniture factory."

"How much longer will that take?"

"Until my daughter was ten she did not even know what caste she belonged to. She always had a Kindle in her hands and loved reading books. Once, while watching a television serial, she saw two or three Brahmins wearing dhotis and large tufts of hair. 'These are Brahmins,' she said. Her mother asked, 'Do you know what caste you belong to?' She did not. When her mother explained that her daddy was a Brahmin too, she exclaimed, 'No way!' She then learned that her brother, her mother and she herself were Brahmins; she fell silent, apparently thinking her mother might be deceiving her.

"Then there is Barbareek in the Mahabharata. Everyone admires Arjuna; others admire Karna. I admire Barbareek. He had pledged to stand always on the side of the weaker party; his guru had required that promise of him. That was when I made the same pledge to the Barbareek within my own mind. Janaka organised a disputation with a thousand cows as the prize. Was Yajnavalkya about to drive the cows away when Gargi began her questions? She followed each answer from Yajnavalkya with a further question. He warned her that her head might break into many pieces if she went on questioning him. But Gargi persisted: 'Under whose authority do time and space exist?' Yajnavalkya answered, 'Under the imperishable, the Akshara.'

"The questioning between Yajnavalkya and Gargi continues in my mind even now. The question you have asked is the same as the one put by the Gargi within me. And there is Barbareek's pledge. Between that inner dispute about life under the Akshara and that pledge, my mind has become forgetful, as you can see. If I were satisfied, like Gargi, why would it become so forgetful? Please introduce yourself once more. These days I start forgetting even as I speak."

STORY 03

Shabdashastram [The Science of Words]

The sun in Leo — *Simha Rashi* — roughly from the sixteenth of August to the sixteenth of September. If anything is to be dried, this is the fiercest sun of the year. In Leo, the palm-leaf manuscripts of Mitu's father would be spread out — an annual preservation ritual, breathing life back into those leaves. Ananda would carry out this preservation of Mitu's father's manuscripts with devoted care. Ananda spreading the manuscripts in the blazing sun — Mitu can picture it still. Ananda's whole life passed alongside Mitu. But this year, before Leo had even arrived, Ananda was gone... And now that she is no more, how will life itself be preserved. Mitu's life, and the life within those palm-leaf manuscripts...

Illusion. The illusion of words. We ourselves construct the meanings of words. And then the illusion begins.

✦ ✦ ✦

In the courtyard of Lukesari stands a dense grove of sandalwood
Beneath it, a cuckoo has made her nest
I shall cut the sandalwood, I shall fence the courtyard
The cuckoo will lose her nesting place
She wept, she grew restless, that forest cuckoo
Broken now is the cuckoo's nest
Weep then, weep — O cuckoo of youth
She will go to the forest, the cuckoo
Whatever forest you go to, cuckoo
A mark will remain
Let not your eyes shed tears
With gold I will bind your two wings, cuckoo
With silver I will adorn your two lips
Whatever forest you go to, cuckoo, O beloved
The mark of the blood-garland will remain

✦ ✦ ✦

A young woman's voice seemed to come from the Cobbler's Quarter — Ananda's voice.

But Ananda is gone. Bachhlu had just come from seeing her body. He told Mitu the news and returned to the *Domasi* quarter. And Ananda — she died in old age. Then this voice, a young Ananda's voice. Illusion. The illusion of words. Mitu's father Shrikar Mimansak would say so many things about

Shabdashastram. We ourselves construct the meanings of words. And then the illusion begins.

I

Shabdashastram

There was a great commotion.

Uproar had broken out. A body was floating down the Balan river. It had caught against the bank near the washermen's ghat.

How far it had come, no one knew. It was the body of an elderly woman. The washerwoman recognised the body. She told the villager the name and address. Which villager? Bachhlu of the *Domasi* quarter of that village. Word had reached the dead woman's house. Only one old man lived in that house alone — Mitu.

Mitu's fellow villagers had brought the body to the village ground, and then Mitu himself had performed the last rites.

This was the talk of the village. Old Bachhlu knows more. He knew the person whose body that was. The newer generation does not know many things.

Ananda's body.

— Ananda was a very good person. Wise. Her daughters are all settled in comfortable homes — her son too is learned. Mitu, Ananda's husband, was also extraordinary — the son of Shrikar Mimansak. Yet never once did Mitu or Ananda stretch their hand before anyone in a time of need.

Bachhlu too has grown old now — a stooped, shrunken old man. Only Mitu is older than him. People address both of them simply as *old men*.

And this old Bachhlu knows a great many things.

Conversations between Mitu and Shrikar. Some I understood, some I did not.

— Mitu. In the *Bhamati*, Vachaspati says that *avidya* depends upon the individual self and has become its object. What method will you accept for self-realisation? How can something non-existent be the cause of anything? How can the mere existence of a thing make it true — how can its presence be proved across the three times? That which is neither true nor untrue, nor a combination of both — that is the *anirvachya*, the inexpressible. Without some thing and a knower of it, how can the concept of void be understood?

— Mitu. Kumarila says that the self is conscious matter — aware when awake, without awareness in sleep.

— Mitu. Vachaspati in the *Bhamati* says that a person learned in scripture but lacking self-realisation behaves with the people around them like an animal — they run from the one approaching with a stick, they draw close to the one approaching with grass. That is to say, they are governed purely by fear.

"A person learned in scripture but lacking self-realisation behaves with the people around them like an animal — they run from the one approaching with a stick, they draw close to the one approaching with grass." — This thought, however, came to me with clear understanding.

It was the mango season.

Monkeys and wild donkeys were ravaging the fields and orchards all around.

— They've destroyed everything, Bachhlu. You can't see a thing at night. I go and check the orchard first thing in the morning. The wild donkeys have eaten all the crops, now the monkeys are after the mangoes.

I knew that in the mango season, the monkeys and wild donkeys had both come that year simultaneously.

It was the mango season. Mitu would be busy guarding the orchard now. The raw mangoes were growing larger. A watchtower had to be built. I was with him. I was returning after cutting bamboo.

We were coming along by the side of the pond. It was early dawn. The red streak in the sky seemed to have turned slightly pale.

— Keep to the ridge path, Bachhlu.

We walked forward along the field's boundary ridge.

Just then I saw blood. My body went cold at the sight of it.

But I breathed again. A sharp bamboo leaf had scraped along a young girl's hand and face. Mitu's bamboo had cut her.

Mitu threw down the bamboo from his hand and went to that girl.

He wiped the blood from that tearful girl's eyes and rubbed earth on her cuts.

— What are you doing?

— The bleeding will stop.

The girl ran forward along the ridge.

— What is your name?

— Ananda.

— Which village are you from?

— This very village.

— This very village?

The two of us asked together.

Yes — her name was Ananda. And that was Mitu's first meeting with her.

The watchtower had been built too. But Ananda did not appear again.

Mitu kept asking.

— Which quarter is she from? Not from Misar-Toli, not from Pachimha-Toli, not from Thakur-Toli.

— If she were from the *Domasi* quarter, I would have known her.

— Then how is she from this very village? And if she's from this village, why have we never seen her until now?

But a coincidence occurred in the meanwhile. There was an *upanayana* ceremony for the son of Fude-bhai in Mitu's quarter. On the bamboo-cutting

day, I had gone to the Cobbler's Quarter at the edge of the village to summon the *pipahi* player.

— Hiru-bhai, Hiruwa-bhai.

— He's coming.

A girl's voice. A familiar-sounding voice.

— Who are you?

— I am Hiru's daughter. What is the matter?

— Your father hasn't arrived yet with the *pipahi*. I've come to call him.

— He's busy getting ready for that.

— What is your name?

Just then, pushing aside the creeper on the wicker screen, that same girl stepped forward into view.

— I am Ananda. I recognised you. What is your name?

I was going quite cold. But an answer had to be given.

— Bachhlu.

— And your companion?

— Mitu — the son of Pandit Shrikar.

I told Ananda Mitu's father's name as well. She hadn't asked for it — but I don't know why — I told her.

Just then Hiruwa came out carrying his *pipahi*. Together with him I came back to the quarter.

On the way I asked Hiruwa: Is Ananda your daughter? I've never seen her before.

— She used to live mostly at her maternal uncle's village. But now she's grown up. I've brought her home.

— Will she go back to her uncle's village again?

— No, she's grown up now. She'll stay with us.

Pandit's son Mitu, my friend Mitu — what would go through his mind hearing this? He'd been asking about her for many days. I had been thinking: let Ananda stay at her uncle's village — then after a few days Mitu's questioning would give me some peace.

But now Ananda would be in the village, and Pandit Shrikar's son Mitu —

Bah — I'm thinking it all upside down. After all, Mitu has asked about Ananda only two or three times. That doesn't necessarily mean —

But what if it does mean exactly that?

A Brahmin's son and a cobbler's daughter.

Would Pandit Shrikar accept it? Would the village and household accept it?

Bah. I'm thinking upside down again. The *pipahi* had begun to play, and keeping to the ridge, Mitu and I, along with all the men and women of the quarter, had reached the bamboo grove. On the way I kept glancing at that spot — listening near the place of Mitu and Ananda's first meeting — some sound seemed to be coming — only music — no voice.

The elder had marked the bamboo stalks and everyone had begun cutting. The *marabthattha* feast was today. Sweating and weary, the mind found some contentment. With bamboo on our shoulders, Mitu and I set off back by the same path — the same ridge.

But Mitu began nudging me constantly now. Because there was no task I had ever delayed so long in doing. He was my Ram and I his Hanuman.

So one day on the watchtower I told Mitu plainly:

— Mitu, forget her. Why would you bring dishonour upon her? Ananda is Hiruwa's daughter. Mind you, when she asked your name from me, I told her your name and your father's name as well.

— She asked for my father's name?

— She didn't ask. But —

— Then why did you tell her?

— Sooner or later she would have found out-

— Whenever that had happened would have been the time — now she'll keep her distance from me — you've only added to my difficulty —

— What difficulty? You're the son of Pandit Shrikar and she's the daughter of Hiruwa the cobbler. Why would you bring dishonour upon her?

— I'll marry her, man. Why would I dishonour her?

— Who are you fooling?

— Nobody, man.

Mitu always made his decisions like this — without warning. Mitu, the logician, son of Shrikar Mimansak. I had seen the palm-leaf manuscripts spread about in his house. I couldn't quite believe it.

— You've never seen her in the village?

— When have you ever been in the village? You've only just come back from the teacher's school.

— But you — had you seen her?

— She used to be at her uncle's village.

— She won't go back to her uncle's village then?

— No — I asked. She'll stay in the village now.

The previous year, Mitu's mother had passed away right here in the village.

Shrikar Mimansak had become somewhat distracted and absent — the neighbours in the quarter were saying this. How will the palm-leaf manuscripts

be preserved in this Leo season? This was Shrikar's worry, and because of it he had become distracted and absent — this too the neighbours were saying.

Hirr... hirr... hirr...

From the *Domasi* quarter, chasing a pig, Mitu and I arrive at the Cobbler's Quarter crying *hirr-hirr*. But Ananda appears right before us. I move ahead with the pig. When I turn around, I strain my ears to hear Ananda and Mitu's conversation.

Hirr... hirr...

This time Ananda cries *hirr* and I walk on ahead with a smile, following the pig.

This happened several times and word spread everywhere. Hiru came to me many times.

Hiru had grown agitated. Hiru's wife began to pray for her daughter's fortune.

How many miles, O mother of Mandilba

How many miles, O Lukesari of Mandilba

How many miles has the plea fallen

Look upon us even briefly, O Mother

Two miles to Mandilba

Four miles to Lukesari of Mandilba

Five miles has the plea fallen

Look upon us even briefly, O Mother

What flower, O mother of Mandilba

What flower of Bandi Mandilba

Upon what flower has the plea fallen

Look upon us even briefly, O Mother

The aili *flower, O mother of Mandilba*

The jasmine flower, O Lukesari of Mandilba

Upon the marigold has the plea fallen

Look upon us even briefly, O Mother

Hiru began coming to the *Domasi* quarter.

— What will happen, how will it happen?

— It's all false hope —

I agreed to go with Hiru to Pandit Shrikar.

And I took Hiru to Shrikar Mimansak. Shrikar's wife had died after the Leo season of the previous year. And after that Shrikar Mimansak had become distracted — people were saying. Which people? Those same neighbours of the quarter. The learned people of the village, the scholars of the surrounding region,

all held him in very high regard. I speak only of what I have seen with my own eyes.

— Come in, Bachhlu. Hiru — come, sit. — Shrikar falls silent. After his wife's death, he would be like this — present one moment, then gone into silence.

— Uncle, the house feels empty. How long will it be like this? Why don't you arrange Mitu's marriage?

— Mitu has already arranged his marriage.

— Where? — I asked, alarmed. Hiru looked at me with a composed expression.

— With Ananda. The prospective father-in-law Hiru has come with you himself.

Oh, Pandit Shrikar.

And oh, Mitu. He had already won his father over beforehand. But some neighbour passing on the embankment had caught wind of this.

We were all still sitting when he gathered a few more people and assembled on the veranda. The debate with Shrikar Mimansak began. Word cutting word.

— Shrikar, what base act are you committing?

— What base act?

— Have you lost all sense of high and low, Mimansak?

— Learned ones. What is this high and low? Merely words. Having heard these words, their meaning has entered your minds in one way or another. Having formed a compound expression, you have mixed your own self-interest into it —

— So high and low is merely word-meaning. And the analysis you made by forming that compound — that has become self-serving.

— If you don't believe it, surrender the self-interest from within that compound and see. All illusion will flee.

— So you are determined to get Mitu and Ananda married?

— Learned ones. The reason I see a rope as a snake is that both have a separate existence. When I squint and see two moons, I still project those two moons onto two actual portions of the sky. The cause of illusion is not the object but the conjunction — though both the subject and predicate are true. And here, the knowledge of any object cannot give knowledge of the self. From contemplation of the self arises *ahamvritti* — awareness of the truth of one's own being. The self is both the doer and the object of knowledge. The meaning of substance is obtained through conjunction. After a word is heard, its meaning is approximated through inference.

— You are generating an illusion of words. We all see in this your wish to marry Mitu and Ananda.

— A resolve is desire, and its non-fulfilment is enmity.

— So it is from enmity that we are saying all this? In your view does caste have no importance?

— Look — Ananda is endowed with every quality, and her caste and mine are one and the same — and this is continuous and evident to all. She can protect my heritage — this is my conviction. And this is my decision.

"And this is my decision." — These words did not enter my and Hiru's ears at the same moment. I knew Shrikar and Mitu — I had grown accustomed to hearing such sudden decisions from them. But Hiru seemed to hear the echo of these words a moment later. His astonished eyes turned towards me.

Then Shrikar Mimansak pointed a finger at one of the debaters — the astrologer:

— Jyotishi-ji, find an auspicious day. Let this sacred marriage be solemnised in this very pure period — before Leo arrives. Does anyone have any objection?

All bowed their heads and stood. Who would stand in opposition to Shrikar Mimansak?

— We had come to advise you. But since you have already made your decision —

Mimansak-ji raised his hand and all fell quiet again.

Hiru and I also took our leave from there.

I had sensed Hiru breathe a deep sigh of relief.

It was not that no more obstacles came.

But he was a determined scholar. And so Ananda became his daughter-in-law. And the water touched by her hand began to be accepted not only in my quarter or Mitu's quarter but among the scholars of the entire surrounding region.

The wedding was solemnised in Ananda's parents' home. The songs I heard there — full of joy — I remember them still:

On the mountain the bumblebee slept
The gardener's daughter slept in the flower garden
Rise, gardener — weave the mountain-jasmine garland
With what flower will the Lukesari be adorned
What flower for adornment
With what flower will the ornament be made
Rise, gardener — weave the mountain-jasmine garland
With jasmine flower the bandi *will be adorned*
With chameli the adornment
The arhul *flower is Lukesari's ornament*
Rise, gardener — weave the mountain-jasmine garland

Shrikar Mimansak, having entrusted to Ananda the responsibility of preserving the palm-leaf manuscripts, had grown at peace. After his wife's death, the poor man had been anxious.

Divine intervention — Ananda had come to that house as if for the preservation of those very manuscripts. Unexpectedly.

Mitu told me how he had won Pandit Shrikar over. A Brahmin girl would spend her days making clay saucers and clay idols of Mahadev, and the palm-leaf manuscripts would get eaten by insects —

Let no insect eat the manuscripts — Ananda will come to this house. Shrikar Mimansak had made his decision.

Mitu seemed grateful his whole life for this decision made on his behalf.

Shrikar's life seemed to lengthen. There was always conversation between Shrikar and Ananda in that house.

Ananda kept talking, and kept singing.

When twelve years had passed, the thirteenth was upon her

When twelve years had passed, the thirteenth had spread

My mother-in-law calls me a tigress, dear one

A tigress she says she'll drive from the house

She who was your creditor in the outer courtyard

Bring me ground aak *and* dhatura *berries — I shall drink the poison*

My beloved has returned and sits upon the bed

Tell me the desire of your heart — then I shall drink the poison

When twelve years had passed, the thirteenth had spread

My mother-in-law calls me a tigress, dear one

A tigress she says she'll drive from the house

My mother-in-law strikes me with Anoop, sister-in-law pokes with a finger

Let all the family go home in happiness — all the wealth shall be mine

Hush now, hush — my dear, you are the great wealth itself

Hush now, hush — my dear, you are the great wealth itself

Beloved, I shall perform the Tulsi-worship — and scatter all wealth

Beloved, I shall perform the pond-worship — and scatter all wealth

Shrikar Mimansak laughed: — Ananda, you have no mother-in-law — then how would the poor woman call you a tigress?

— That is exactly why I sing it — everything else is complete and full, but —

Ananda's eyes had filled with tears. I remember it still.

— I have pained you by saying this.

— What pain? If there is no mother-in-law, there is a father-in-law.

Seeing Shrikar happy, Mitu felt a deep contentment.

And even after Shrikar Mimansak's death, Ananda kept breathing life into the palm-leaf manuscripts.

Then Mitu had two daughters — Vallabha and Medha.

I saw Ananda's happiness. She had gone to her parents' home. Both the twin daughters were born there —

Red fairy, rose fairy

Red fairy, rose fairy

In the sky dances the celestial nymph

On the rose dances the celestial nymph

And then came a son. When he grew older, Mitu sent the son Megh to Banaras for his studies.

And the days passed, the daughters grew up, and Mitu saw both daughters — Medha and Vallabha — married off and felt at peace.

He brought up his son and saw him married too. Megh began teaching in Banaras. Megh, Medha and Vallabha — all three would come for at least one month every year.

People forgot many, many things.

II

Bhamati Prasthanam

Ananda was carrying out the preservation of Mitu's father's palm-leaf manuscripts with devoted care. The blazing sun — Mitu remembers it still.

Ananda's whole life passed alongside Mitu. And now that she is no more, how will Mitu's life be preserved... Mitu drifts away somewhere in the middle of the discourse.

The discourse is going on. Mitu will not listen to the *Garuda Purana*. Mitu will listen to Mandan's *Brahmasiddhi*, to Vachaspati's *Bhamati* — if he listens at all. If his daughters insist, he will listen to Kumarila's philosophy on the subject of the self. And that discourse is now going on.

Illusion. The illusion of words. Shrikar would say so much about *Shabdashastram*. About *Bhamati Prasthanam*. We construct the meanings of words ourselves. And then the illusion begins.

— Teacher. After my wife's death I am in profound despair. What is this life? Where will Ananda be?

— Mitu. Be patient. This reading of mine from the *Brahmasiddhi* will dispel all your illusions. The *Brahmasiddhi* has four sections: *Brahma*, *Tarka*, *Niyoga* and *Siddhi*. The *Brahma Khanda* discusses the nature of Brahman, the *Tarka Khanda* discusses proof and epistemology, the *Niyoga Khanda* discusses the liberation of the individual self, and the *Siddhi Khanda* discusses the evidence of Upanishadic statements.

— Mitu. Liberation is not something separate from knowledge. Liberation *is* knowledge itself. Mandan never dismisses human limited intelligence anywhere. He understands the importance of action. But liberation cannot be obtained through that alone. Mandan saw the *sphota* as giving meaning in the form of sound-word. He differs from Shankara in this respect — he establishes an identity with this *sphota* while Shankara accepts no identity short of Brahman itself. Thus Mandan is a purer non-dualist than Shankara. Mitu — Mandan does not regard the simultaneous presence of capacity and incapacity as opposing elements. This is sometimes a difference created by *arthakriya* — purposive action — but how did that difference become a foundational principle? Therefore Brahman, even while present in all differences, can perform all functions. Consider — the thought in Vachaspati's *Bhamati Prasthanam* corresponds with Mandan Mishra's thinking. Vachaspati wrote the *Tattvasamiksha* on Mandan Mishra's *Brahmasiddhi*. Though the *Tattvasamiksha* is no longer available.

— Then how is the *Tattvasamiksha* discussed at all?

— It is mentioned in Vachaspati's *Bhamati*.

— But before I understand Mandan's thought, there comes to my mind — when he was defeated by Shankaracharya, how will recitation of his defeated doctrine bring peace to my mind?

— Look — there is no evidence in Mandan's own writings that he was defeated. Mandan supports *sphotavada*, while Shankaracharya refutes *sphotavada*. Mandan, unlike Kumarila Bhatta, supports *khyativada* — the doctrine of recognition — but Suresvara, the disciple of Shankaracharya whom people identify with Mandan Mishra, refutes this.

— That is right. If Mandan had truly been defeated, his philosophy would have followed Shankaracharya's.

— Now consider — Suresvara, whom Shankaracharya appointed as the head of the Sringeri Matha, is opposed to the idea that *avidya* can be of two kinds, but in his work *Brahmasiddhi*, Mandan names two forms of *avidya* — *agrahana* and *anyathaagrahana*. Mandan calls the individual self the locus of *avidya* and Brahman the object of *avidya*, but Suresvara does not accept this. Mandan opposes Shankaracharya's thought, but Suresvara is in support of his position.

Monkeys and wild donkeys were ravaging the fields and the orchards. Now because of me, the villagers won't stop keeping buffaloes. The monkeys and wild donkeys are causing great damage.

— Four monkeys in the orchard. They've grabbed and shaken all the mangoes. I went there. By the time evening came, all the monkeys had taken hold of the branches. Father and I guarded the orchard all day, chased them off with a scare, but then they moved towards your orchard. — I tell Mitu.

— They've destroyed everything, Bachhlu. You can't see at night. I go check the orchard first thing in the morning. The wild donkeys ate all the crops, now the monkeys are after the mangoes. Let them —

— The wild donkeys had cleared out completely. Don't know where they've come from again. There was a celebration in Gajpatha village and they swam the river across overnight from there.

— That's not it. These wild donkeys came floating down from the Nepal direction. Let them come —

— I'd told you about the monkeys.

— It will happen.

— It will happen, brother — I'll be going then. — I know that in the mango season, the monkeys and the wild donkeys had both disappeared that year — the year Ananda and Mitu had first met. And after Ananda's going, the monkeys and wild donkeys have come again from somewhere unknown — not even fifteen days have passed since Ananda's death.

Bachhlu left, and on Mitu's forehead several thick lines of worry began to move up and down — like waves in a surge, overlapping one another, old waves becoming new and growing. He calls out in the courtyard.

— Buchchi, Buchiya. Jayakar and Vishwanath went to the orchard today. Have they both come back on foot? Didn't you hear — there's been trouble with the monkeys. Tell them not to go to the orchard from tomorrow. The monkeys came to the orchard today and I didn't even say a word. What use is saying anything when —

— I was telling you, Babujee, but you're lost in your own thoughts — my mouth got tired of speaking so I fell silent.

Yes, Mitu is indeed lost in his thoughts. These mangoes too have begun to ripen after Ananda's death. And after so many years, what memory have these monkeys and wild donkeys come to revive?

Jayakar's mother is Vallabha and Vishwanath's mother is Medha. Both sisters have come home after so long. They are meeting each other after so long. Ananda's two daughters and both sons-in-law have come. Vallabha's husband Visho and Medha's husband Kanh. Megh has come with his wife and children.

Mitu is calling out for his wife, calling her by name — Ananda. Then he remembers — where will she be found now. Then — where are you Vallabha, where are you Medha, where are Jayakar and Vishwanath — he begins to call out.

Vallabha and Medha come and Mitu begins to sing. Ananda's song. What Ananda used to sing for Vallabha and Medha —

Red fairy, rose fairy

Red fairy, rose fairy

In the sky dances the celestial nymph

On the rose dances the celestial nymph

The Raktamala stands poor at the threshold

The Raktamala stands poor at the threshold

O Mother — give wealth to the poor, celestial one

O Mother — give wealth to the poor, celestial one

Red fairy, rose fairy

O Mother — the Raktamala stands blind at the threshold

O Mother — give the blind their sight quickly

O Mother — give the blind their sight quickly

Father and both daughters break into weeping.

— Mitu. Ananda's death has come upon you as a calamity. You are of Brahmin caste and Ananda was a cobbler woman. But the love between you both is beyond measure. Do not grieve for her death. Brahman is without sorrow. The form of Brahman is *ananda* — bliss. Therefore it is improper for you to grieve for Ananda. Brahman is the witness. That which is witnessed — the visible — keeps changing; what does the witness have to do with it? This worldly illusion is not mere illusion — it does have a pragmatic reality. But this pragmatic reality is not ultimate truth. Mitu — there is a difference between the conscious and the unconscious, but that is not ultimately true either. There are many kinds of individual selves, and there are many kinds of *avidya. Avidya* is a deficiency — but how can its locus be Brahman, how can it be a complete self? Its locus will be an incomplete self. *Avidya* then is not true but it is not altogether untrue either. Mitu — remove this *avidya*, and that is what is called *moksha*. The same *moksha* that Ananda has attained.

And peace seems to spread across Mitu's face.

Mitu is as if going to meet someone.

He remembers the tender conversations with Ananda.

— Ananda. Even as we talk, a small fear has come into my mind. Father's greatest weakness is the preservation of his palm-leaf manuscripts. So keep this in mind. When Father asks how the palm-leaf manuscripts are to be preserved, tell him — protect the books from water, oil and coarse binding. Dry them in the shade. Books of five or six hundred leaves. I'll show you one day. Each leaf is a *hath* long and four fingers wide. Wooden boards are fixed above and below. On the left side a hole is made and it is bound with thread.

— Will Father accept it?

— Why wouldn't he? Does he have the means to arrange a Brahmin girl's marriage? I had given someone two rupees as an advance to buy agricultural land. But Father went and returned the advance. He is saving up one-one, two-two rupees. He plans to give seven hundred rupees to a girl's family — then his son can be married and a daughter-in-law will come. And would a Brahmin woman protect the palm-leaf manuscripts?

After Mitu's mother's death, Shrikar had become distracted. The neighbours were saying this.

And then illness came — plague. Two quarters of the village were entirely wiped out — Misar-Toli and Pachimha-Toli. In the surrounding villages, how many people died, no one knew.

Mitu introduced his father to Ananda. Shrikar Mimansak saw something in Ananda — full of knowledge about preserving palm-leaf manuscripts — that he could not quite name.

Mitu had won. Mitu the logician had won over Shrikar the Mimansak, and Shrikar the Mimansak had defeated his own neighbours.

And Ananda and Mitu's marriage was solemnised.

He remembers the tender conversations with Ananda. Mitu is as if going to meet someone. Ananda's death has come. On the Balan, Ananda's feet had slipped on the bank. The same marks of slipping can be seen still.

Mitu looks at those marks and his heart surges — he slips back into the wave of emotion.

Ananda and Mitu had begun meeting more and more — at the fields, the mango orchard, the *chauri* meadow, and by the riverside. And both of them would slip — in the fields, in the mango orchard, in the *chauri* meadow, and at the riverside too.

Mitu did not jump across the river. This sloping muddy bank that today's young people use — it was Mitu who made it. He would plant his pole here and with a swift rush Mitu would cut through the water and move ahead.

— Hey — come on, slip in and let me see.

— What great thing is that?

— Show me — then you'll understand.

Ananda would try to move forward uncertainly but — *he, he, he* —

She could not stop herself — not in the fields, not in the mango orchard, not in the *chauri* meadow, and not here at the riverside either.

And why would Ananda have come here — only to slip and drown?

She must have come to remember some memory.

Yes — Ananda has come, Bachhlu. Look — hear this song:

In the back garden stands an arhul flower tree

The tree laden with fruit and flower

A parrot came from the northern direction

The parrot perched on the arhul flower tree

Neither eating the fruit, parrot, nor eating the flower

He stripped away the branches and leaves

Neither eating the flower, parrot, nor eating the fruit

He stripped away the branches and leaves

In the back garden lives a female mongoose

Give the perched parrot a fright

One snare has been set

Two snares have been set

At the third snare the parrot flies away

He's not a devotee-parrot

Nor a partridge

This one's just a sparrow's alibi

— Brother, can you not hear this song?

— Brother, I hear it. I see it too. Ananda is our *bhauji* — our elder brother's wife.

Even when she died I had heard — it was she — she was singing —

In the courtyard of Lukesari stands a dense grove of sandalwood

Beneath it, a cuckoo has made her nest

— That was no illusion of words.

It is the day after the fish-feast and the Satyanarayan *puja*. Ananda had neither had the sandalwood tree cut, nor had she fenced the courtyard.

The next day, in the Cobbler's Quarter, beneath that sandalwood tree, the villagers saw two bodies. And these words too spread into the sky — all the villagers heard them — in Ananda's voice:

Whatever forest you go to, cuckoo, O beloved

The mark of the blood-garland will remain

That was no illusion of words.

STORY 04

The Village of the Mahisbar [Buffalo-Grazer] Brahmins

Trees and groves all around, and ponds. In the village — one, two, three, and one more — four ponds.

Though there are three more besides. One, to the north of the northern pond, is the great Dakahi pond. People say some dacoit dug it out in a single night. But if you ask for proof, you will learn that there is no other evidence except that while digging, morning came upon him, and for that reason the dacoit could not plant a boundary post in the pond. In his haste, a sandal — or call it a slipper — eight hands long, belonging to that dacoit — or call him a demon — was also left behind on the bank of the pond. It stayed there on the bank for a long time, but then that too was washed away in a flood. So the one piece of evidence that existed did not survive either. This pond is far from the village, and on that account no connection between it and the *Chhath* festival has been established to this day. Yes, it is certainly used in the rituals accompanying the sacred thread ceremony. All manner of fish are to be found in this pond. There is no shortage of fish. There has never been a need to stock the Dakahi pond with fingerlings. The annual fishing festival takes place, and on every day of the festival, all the quarters of the village — excepting the southern quarter, which is to say Garh Arar-Neba — are given their respective shares of the catch.

To the south of the southern quarter lies the Buchiya pond.

It is distant from the village but has a landing-post right in the middle. When this wooden post was being planted, the yellow-child — the now ancient great-great-grandfather of today's zamindar — had organised a grand ceremony. Because it is far from the settlement and sits in the middle of the fields, people come here for bathing rather rarely. The fishing festival is also held here, but that is exclusively for the southern quarter. This pond has one more distinction. When, at the time of the Durga Puja, Durga-ji departs once more from her parents' home to her husband's on the tenth day — which is also called *jatra* — her idol is immersed in this very pond. Not the men — but the women weep and wail at the immersion of Durga-ji. Who in this quarter would ask after Durga-ji — she is not even made in this village. She is made in the neighbouring Garh Tol. The people of this village are altogether beyond-the-pale. Until the sixth day the idol of Durga is kept covered; only the sculptor can uncover and look at her — for if he does not look, how will Durga-ji get made? If anyone else looks, they will go blind. Yes, after the *belnouti* on the sixth day, following the unveiling of the idol, people may take her *darshan*. And from that day the fair also begins. If Durga were made in this village, how many people would go blind even before the sixth day! And is the neighbouring village any less beyond-the-pale? But in the name of a *puja*, watch how everyone becomes perfectly solemn and proper.

The name has *Tol* attached to it — Garh Tol — but it is actually a village. A village just like this one, the village of the Mahisbar Brahmins. In being beyond-the-pale, am I ahead or are you — this kind of competition goes on constantly between the two villages. Pass by Garh Tol's village and the young men sitting on the veranda by the embankment will make sure to say something or other to you. But the troublesome young men of this village will stubbornly take the route through that very village. Yes, the sensible and cautious all consider it wiser to go by way of the Buchiya pond, even if the road is a little out of the way — so what of it?

There is one more pond in the village. But on both sides of the village are the Kamala-Balan and the Kosi — the talk of building two embankments on each to control both rivers keeps coming up sooner or later. Tucked close to the village on the west, running north to south, will be one embankment, then will come the Balan river — brother of the Kamala Maharani — then Kamala Maharani herself, and then further to the west another embankment running north to south — such discussions go on. But that is not the Kamala river, that is the Chharan; further ahead it meets the Kamala-Balan river, and that is not the Balan alone but the Kamala-Balan. Very sharp fellows, the villagers — you won't find this level of geographical knowledge even in books, father. Between the embankments will lie Balli pond. How the government will fill in this pond is not known. This pond is connected to the Balan by a drain; when the river rises, the people open the mouth of the drain and the pond fills with the silt-laden water from above the river — the sand stays lower in the river, so it cannot enter. And in any case, the Balan carries more silt than sand. Irrigation is done from this pond. Around the *Baisakh-Sakrainti* season the villagers form work-parties and clean out and dredge all the ponds. And the fair on the full moon of *Pus*. Fish and *makhana* are plentiful.

At the very entrance to the village, two old wells. Some people developed goitres from the well water, so people mock and nickname it the Goitre Village, the Fat-Headed Village.

Right beside the river and the vast Balli pond there was once a football ground — a vast *ramna*. Through the machinations of the zamindar, this *ramna* was subsumed into the yellow-child's fields — that is to say, it was absorbed. The big zamindar Barbariya Roy had also at some point, for reasons unknown, insisted that a cultivator's land should all be in one consolidated plot. Surju Bhai's field fertilised with cow-dung was also in this process absorbed into the yellow-child's fields — or rather, made to be absorbed.

Between the Kamala and the Balan lies the *bauwa-chauri* — the meadow where the Mahisbar families bring their buffalo to graze and feed. The buffalo-herders come here, play, and swim in the Kamala. Sometimes they let themselves float downstream in the Kamala without resistance, and sometimes they swim against the river's current. These are the graduates of the Bauwa-Chauri school.

Between the two rivers lies the Guar Toli.

On the embankment too there are four houses of Baudha Malik and other Doms. These two quarters also fall within the boundaries of this village. The Doms call themselves Malik or Sopach. Baudha Malik tells stories...

Four Brahmins were going to the pond to bathe when they saw a dead cow. Who would remove a dead cow? The burden was placed upon the youngest brother, and when he returned he was excommunicated from his caste.

The work of every caste is needed at festivals, rites and ceremonies.

The dancer Bakhkho asks for this gift at the courtyard: dance and movement

The Pamriya asks for this gift: the toy of chilka**

The Dagareen asks for this gift: stripping the naar**

The Nau-ani asks for this gift: the lighting of lamps

The Dhobiya asks for this gift: the dissolving of the khir**

The work of every caste is needed at festivals, rites and ceremonies.

The Dom's work too is needed at festivals and rites.

From making baskets to making winnowing fans and fans of all kinds — this is the Dom's work. And for the goat to be slaughtered for honoured guests and for the wedding party, the work goes to the Mian Toli.

The head of the goat at the Durga Puja sacrifice is taken by the committee. But Jainul Mian who slaughters the goat does so in the *halal* manner. The neck is left half hanging, but he takes away the neck — made golden — and the hide as well.

Then, from among the Mahisbar Brahmins, those who perform devotional singing and the eight-watch *ashtajam* worship buy drums made from that very hide.

In Kunja Toli, Mohammad Shamsul. On the embankment. He tells stories...

Dilari Nagar. There was a Sayyid there. He had a wife and several sons. Warriors, all of them.

The battle of Nunjagarh. But this time the Sayyid and all his sons were killed. But his widow was with child. Some time later a child was born. He was named Miran.

He too was a warrior — but the mother did not like this. He was married off young, thinking it might turn his mind away from war. But...

The mother and wife pleaded with him greatly, but Miran went to Nunjagarh alone, avenged his father and brothers, and returned to Dilari Nagar.

By the power of his soul, long after his death, peace prevailed in Dilari Nagar.

The sight when they return to Garh Narikel after the *daha* — the mourning procession — is remarkable. At the *daha* they play with the *jharni* — a bamboo sieve.

Listening to the *marsia*, the men break into weeping and wailing just as the women weep and wail on the day of Durga-ji's immersion.

At this the bamboo grove of the Sayyid was cut, O hai hai

That bamboo grove too has become a place of remembrance, O hai hai

The people of Garh Narikel are all singers, all storytellers. Listen on...

During the *bhav-khelai* performance, Miran Saheb comes and grants boons.

How many times will you tell the same story?

Keep listening — it is Garh Narikel. However many times you hear it, it will seem new.

In Dilari Nagar there lived Harphool Sayyid.

Isn't it Dilari Nagar they call Delhi?

What would I know of that?

Harphool's wife was Aatam.

In the battle of Nunjagarh, Harphool was killed, and Aatam was with child.

A child was born — he was named Miran.

Aatam arranged Miran's marriage while he was still a child, but Miran came to know sooner or later of the battle of Nunjagarh and of his father Harphool's death there. And he attacked Nunjagarh, defeated it, and returned to Dilari Nagar.

Falling and tumbling in the procession the war-drum sounds, O brother, the war-drum

Brother, the sound of the war-drum cannot be told in words

Hacking and cutting, in the procession the battle-horn calls

Brother, the battle-horn calls

Brother, the whirling sword flashes

The black, the bay horse in the procession stamps and snorts

O brother, the horse

Brother, on the horse's back sits the fire-like rider

Then there is yet another quarter.

Cobblers — Mukhadev Ram and Dayaram Ram. Earlier this quarter was outside the village, beyond the bamboo grove. But now all the bamboo has been cut down and finished, and with the spread of habitation this cobbler's quarter has been reached. Thatched roofs and brick kilns keep falling side by side. Their cooperation is expected for everything from providing the drum-skin to playing the drum and *pipahi*. Until they come and carry away a dead animal, the house where it died remains in a state of ritual pollution. Mukhadev is a companion of Jageshwar Jha.

Lala Maharaj — the community deity of the cobblers. He used to catch fish from the *chauri* marsh. Everyone has rights over the fish of the *chauri*. Anyone can fish there. But Sonayamani used to say that only he could fish from that *chauri*. Lala Maharaj was powerful and would not accept this. One day he was

returning after catching fish when Sonayamani found out. Earlier there used to be tigers in these parts. Sonayamani had several tigers. He sent a tiger to kill Lala Maharaj. But Lala Maharaj killed it with his staff. Sonayamani was greatly enraged — he worshipped the *Gahil Devi*. The *Gahil Devi* sent a tigress and had Lala Maharaj killed.

At the foot of the khashiya *tree, mother is wandering*

O hai — no one is searching for Lala

If you search for Lala and come

Weeping, weeping, she says — I cannot understand

Nowhere is he to be seen, O Lord, go now

Nowhere is Lala, O now

Whom shall I ask, whom shall I console

To whom shall I tell my grief, O

Lala Maharaj's friend Nath Mishra stopped giving milk to Lala Maharaj's parents.

Scolding and reproving, he began to speak

Rupa-mai cannot understand Mishra

By whose grace are you Nath Mishra

A body like a washed piece of pat *cloth*

Like a plantain trunk you are, Mishra

You have no strength even in your thighs

Thin and spindly arms, Nath Mishra

It is by Lala's grace alone that you are what you are

Lala Maharaj's soul grew wrathful, killed Nath Mishra, and killed Sonayamani and his family too. Then Lala Maharaj was appeased through worship and prayer, and only then did he become calm.

The people of Garh Narikel are all singers, all storytellers. Listen on...

Mansaram Chamar and Chhechhanmal Dom. Both brave — Mansaram was the commander-in-chief of the Raja of Morang, and Chhechhanmal was the commander-in-chief of the Raja of Siri Rajkhand.

The Raja of Morang knew that no one could defeat Chhechhanmal, commander of Siri Rajkhand — not even Mansaram.

The Raja of Morang summoned Chhechhanmal to his court and tempted him. But he would not be moved. Betray Siri Rajkhand? Never.

The Raja of Morang had him seized and bound. But Chhechhanmal broke all his bonds in a single moment. The Raja of Morang was frightened — where Chhechhanmal was such a commander, the army would be equally powerful. He abandoned any thought of attacking Siri Rajkhand.

Nothing will happen to you, Mansaram

Even if the head were to come off
Still I will not let you cross
Into my king's territory
If you still have any fear for your life
Then go back home
I will not leave a single duty undone
I will be the guardian of this frontier
If you take even one step forward
I will take your head in an instant

Keep listening to the stories of Garh Narikel... One story has many forms. From wherever the brides came, they brought their stories with them.

Lukesari was the daughter of a cobbler. She fasted on *Ekadashi* to obtain Chhechhanmal as her husband. But she had a dream that Chhechhan had become a monk. And when Chhechhan and Lukesari met, Chhechhan regarded her as a goddess, received teachings from her, and made Lukesari a goddess. Lukesari became a goddess.

Then the Dhanuk Toli. Bhagwandatt Mandal and Adhikalal Mandal — Dhanuk. Earlier these people used to carry loads, but later the people of Dusadh Toli also began carrying loads. Farming is the traditional occupation of both the Dhanuk Toli and the Dusadh Toli. Yes, earlier they only worked for wages, now they work on sharecropping. Raising goats and selling them for sacrifice at Durga Puja — that you can count as livestock-keeping for both these quarters. A few people have also begun keeping bullocks, and in pairs they use them for farming.

Whenever there is a quarrel, you will not find a month in the year when you cannot see a woman from some quarter of the Mahisbar Brahmin families breaking a tile with her black *khapar* shard. If you ask her reason, they will say that these people are shameless, and that is why when they are born a jet of spittle is shot at them from behind, so that no part of the body will retain any shame.

In Garh Narikel, if someone has caused harm to society, no mourning is observed when they die; on the contrary, when such a person dies, the women break a tile and throw it on the embankment.

Though it has only three houses, the Dhobi Toli has become a quarter in its own right. The Marwari merchants' clothes all the way from Jhanjharpur are washed here. The Mahisbar Brahmins who go off to weddings with bell-bottoms pressed and spick-and-span — do they wear their own clothes? Those very expensive borrowed clothes — the Marwaris'. Safi Bhai lends these Marwari clothes to them for two days on hire. Koraail, Budhan and Domi Safi — the washermen. Domi Safi is now Domi Das, for he has taken to ploughing, being a follower of the Kabir Panth. When the *Guru Gosain* comes, Domi Das's *Saraswati* — his learning — goes quiet. He has a treasury of Maithili Kabir-vani.

At first I was with the primal man, and then I remained a virgin

Brother, when the husband was born I became joined in marriage

With whom did I savour, with whom did I dwell, with whom did I make my vow

With whom did I roam from land to land, whose woman am I

With five I savoured, with twenty-five I dwelt, with three I made my vow

Together did I roam from land to land — one man, one woman

In the form of a serpent I settled in the city and bit all four Vedas

Father-in-law and elder brother-in-law, combined in one mind — a wonder that cannot be told

One Aadya*, taking three forms — intelligence, wisdom, expansion*

Says Kabir — one who enchants all minds, a saint alone can cross over

Domi Das holds a gathering of saints in Garh Narikel once a year. He travels all year round. Wherever he goes — the Sahaj Yoga Satsang Centre in Madhubani, Ared Barahi Tol, Ared Haat, Kabir Jaago Ashram in Andhrathadi, Kabir Ashram in Brahmottara, Sadguru Kabir Ashram in Suratganj; the Kabir Math in Samastipur, Satmalpur, Kabir Ashram in Ladaura; the Kabir Ashram in Turki in Muzaffarpur, Kabir Math in Krishna Toli, Brahmpura; the Kabir Ashram in Bharwara, the village of Gonu Jha; and the Kabir Dharma Sthan, Duhabi, Nepal — not one of these places has been left unvisited by him. At the ceremonies in which many a *gurugaddi* confers the *chadar* and installs a *mahant* at a monastery, his presence is considered indispensable.

The memory of every person in Garh Narikel is very sharp — ask one thing and then just keep listening...

The Nau Toli too has three houses. Jairam Thakur, Laxmi Thakur and Male Thakur — barbers. Great talkers.

Jogindar Thakur — from the most prosperous family among the carpenters and blacksmiths of Garh Narikel's *Kamarsari*. Jogindar Thakur is a *chharidaar* — a staff-bearer. But when the *Maain-jan* or his *diwan* comes for a feast, it seems Chharidaar Jogindar Babu's *Saraswati* goes quiet and he produces only *haan* — yes — in response to both good sense and nonsense alike. Jogindar has three children — Bihari, Arjun and Shivnaren. All are engaged in the timber trade, but Bihari also does ironwork alongside, and Arjun has become a bicycle mechanic too — from minor repairs to patching punctures on rickshaws and bicycles, he does everything. For children, from rubber balls to the iron-ring-and-stick game where a bent wire is used to roll a wooden wheel, and many other inventions of play — Shivnaren has devised them all. So people say: look, it's the notion that only a job comes from education — change that idea. Look at Shivnaren. What things keep coming to his mind, what he makes from scraps of wood. But Bihari's skill with his hands is unmatched by anyone — in *aaraakat* straight-cutting, diagonal cutting, standing cut, *phentakaati* — he is ahead of Shivnaren. Shivnaren invents something, and after that, seeing it, Bihari makes

the same thing better. Now in a village, will the inventor get any copyright? On *pattharauti* wood, Shivnaren's saw and adze give up, but Bihari somehow manages it in ways no one understands. From knotted wood too he makes things and sells them at fairs and markets. When a long saw is not at hand for splitting a plank, he splits it with even a small saw. At separating the usable part of wood from the waste, Bihari has no equal.

For the thick-threaded *anchari* — the cloth offering for Bhagwati — the weaver Jagdish Mail is sought out; the *patmini* is very industrious.

Bhola Pandit the potter — the arrangements are in place for everything from earthen water-pots to little birds and sparrows for children. None can match him in clay work.

Basu Choupal — *Khatawe* by caste. He used to carry loads; he carries fish too, becomes a *kahar* when needed. And he has also taken to selling fish.

Chailttar Sahu and Laddulal Sahu — confectioners — they set up shop during Durga Puja. In their enterprise they have also begun taking contracts for preparing vegetables and curries.

Shivnarayan Mahato — *Suri*. Lachhmi Das — *Tatma*. Lal Kumar Ray — *Kurmi*.

Bhola Paswan and Mukesh Paswan — *Dusadh*. Relatives of Gena Hazari of the lower *khadhi*. The same Gena Hazari who, seeing a cow come and give milk on a *kush* blade at Kusheshwar Sthan, began to dig at that spot. Mahadev kept going deeper and deeper, and was finally found. This Mahadev, established by Kush — Lav's brother, son of Sita — was discovered by Gena Hazari.

Now listen to a story... in Garh Narikel there is a story for every single thing... not stories — history...

In Puhpi Nagar, in a ploughed field, Kirti Paswan found a child. The name given was Joti.

— Found in the ploughed field, and so named accordingly, right?

He raised and nurtured the child into adulthood.

Joti's companion was Hariya. The two were always together. One day when Hariya went with Joti to tend the pigs, Joti began to dance. The world of Indra trembled. Kalidasa met Joti, and Kalidasa gave him great powers and asked him to spread the message of dharma and truth. In Puhpi Nagar, Joti began to propagate dharma. He would give children lumps of clay in their hands, and those lumps would become Shankar-chura sweets.

Live, O innocent child Joti
Become immortal in this world
Every day perform acts of power
O, conduct the affairs of dharma
Whatever you desire, O child
Dharmaraj the giver will fulfil it

Amrita's son Kalidasa came in the guise of a Brahmin to meet Joti, but for some reason Joti did not meet him. Kalidasa cursed him, and Joti was afflicted with leprosy.

Kalidasa disguised himself as an astrologer and told Joti to remain in the forest for twelve years, hungry and thirsty. Joti was ultimately successful.

Satyanarayan Kamat — *Kiot*, he lived on the estate of the Darbhanga zamindar as a *kamat*.

Ramdev Bhandari. A type of *Kiot*, a *Bhandari* — one who managed the kitchens of the Darbhanga zamindars.

Satyanarayan Kamat was also a mahout — for Barbariya Roy. In constructing a howdah for an elephant, none in the region could match him. The vocabulary of the elephant — *agatt*, *pichhu*, *thait*, *mail-biri* — all of these words he had practiced so much that he would use them in other contexts too, out of habit.

Kapileshwar Raut and Ramavatar Raut — *Barai*. Paan-selling is their ancestral profession.

Jibachh Mukhi — fisherman. Once a year at the Dakahi pond, the fishing festival — for fifteen days to a month the fishermen cast the great net here. The fishermen's quarter assembles together.

For a month an outside fishermen's village settles on the bank of the pond. Earlier this annual fishing festival used to run for over a month, but now it has been pulled tight to twenty days. Then the fishermen's head announces: the fish are now exhausted. If we cast the great net now, not a single large fish will come in. If we use a gill net, all the small fish will die, and next year we will have to stock fingerlings. During those fifteen to twenty days the atmosphere in the village is festive. On the occasion, the cleaning and clearing of the pond also gets done. From four in the morning until midday the fishing goes on. Then by the afternoon all the quarters of the village — excepting the southern quarter — are given their respective shares. Everyone takes their share and comes back to the village. There the families of each quarter divide up their respective portions among themselves. How many lots the quarter's fish will make — sometimes disputes arise on this very matter. While she was alive, one might not have had a cross word with Widow Aunt; one might have strangled her dying wish to give her daughter something from her share; and one might have gotten her dead body's thumbprint on a stamp paper. Her memory may not come to you at other times, but at the time of claiming one's share of the Dakahi pond fish, everyone's Widow Aunt comes to mind. Protest is also expressed on this score. And no one gets this kind of extra share except the wrestler — whom everyone affectionately calls *Khaliffa* — even if Khaliffa's Widow Aunt in his courtyard died twenty years before.

The Dakahi pond has one more distinction. In it, fish and turtles multiply on their own. On the banks, wild *malkoka* and innumerable varieties of leeches and shed skins. At the banks, the water-kand bulb — food for the Mahisbar children.

The Kamala's boatmen, in exchange for ferrying the villagers, take grain from them. From outsiders — yes, for ferrying across the river, they take money.

Listen to a story...

Dulra Dayal Mallah of Bharaura. From the village of Gonu Jha.

Now that Gonu Jha has come up, first the story of that great master of trickery, Gonu Jha...

A terrible drought fell upon the kingdom of Mithila. The king had the drum beaten out announcing that whoever could offer a solution would receive a reward.

A huge old man, with ten or more *tilak*-marks on his forehead, came to the king's court saying he had performed tapasya for a hundred years in the Himalayas and could bring rain through a *yajna*. By evening he had been given a place and the necessary materials. Gonu Jha had gone somewhere to stay as a guest. When he returned in the evening and heard everything from his wife, he was astonished and set out to meet the man.

Meanwhile, before dawn, word had spread all over that another *baba* with twenty or more *tilak*-marks had also arrived.

Now when the twenty-*tilak* baba met the ten-*tilak* baba, the ten-*tilak* baba said: you are a twenty-*tilak* baba — then I am Sri Sri 108 twenty-*tilak* baba. Tell me, by what method will you bring rain?

— I have a bamboo by which I will poke the clouds and rain will fall.

— Where do you keep such a long bamboo?

— In the mouth of a fraud like you.

Now the ten-*tilak* baba made an excuse of going to relieve himself and departed.

— Hoi. At least take your *kharama* sandals and *kamandal*!

But he had run, and people chased him trying to grab his beard. But that beard was false and so it was torn off. And the fraud seized his chance and escaped. Then Gonu Jha too removed his false moustache and beard and returned to his own form. The king honoured his cleverness.

Now that story — of Dulra Dayal Mallah of Bharaura. From that same village of Gonu Jha.

Now hear the real story...

Son of Dukhharan Sahni. As a child, his marriage was arranged with Dhania Marauti, daughter of Bahuara Gaurheen of Bakhari. But something happened — all the wedding party was locked up by the bride's side, and Dukhharan took his son and fled back to the village. Dulra Dayal was accomplished in song and dance, so people called him Natua Dayal too. When he grew up, he asked his father why his *gauna* — the ceremony of bringing home the bride — had not yet taken place. When he found out everything, he set out for Bakhari. And at

the boundary of Bakhari, by a well, he meets his bride. After many obstacles, he brings his bride home.

Bichkun Sadaay — Musahar. The small ponds and marshy, quaking bog-ground beside the Dakahi pond — in these the Musahars dig and eat water-roots. In times of famine when all other ponds and small water-bodies dry up, the Dakahi pond alone does not dry.

Bhumihars — Radhamohan Ray. *Koir* — Dukhan Mahato. *Sonar* — Ashok Thakur. *Teli* — Ramchandra Sav, Bawku Sav and Kari Sav.

The village's mango orchards — several. The great orchard. The new-orchard of *Kharhauri*. The morning-side orchard. The orchards on the ridges of the ponds. In grafting mangoes from discarded seeds, these villagers are very skilled.

Bambai, *Doma Bambai*, *Sobhja* (*Sobja Bambai*), *Najara Bambai*, *Nengra Bambai*. Bambai mango of so many kinds. *Baramasiya* — twelve months a year. *Kalami Bhadaiya*, *Bathua* (*Bhadaiya*). *Rair* is very sweet. *Kariamma* is poor in both appearance and taste. *Dhumnaha* grows large but is a rotter. *Rohniya* is also a rotter — it falls off the branch in the rains, it ripens earliest of all mangoes in Mithila. Throw away a Bambai seed and a *Tipiya* will grow. The *Kalami* does not grow from a thrown seed — it is grafted. The *Kalami* has flesh — it is heavy on the stomach; the *sarahi* has juice and is easily digestible, and is also slightly tart — for that reason the tart *ammat* pickle is made from the *sarahi*. Wedding parties are given *Bambai* in the early season and *sapeta* in the late season — these two mangoes are considered the finest. Pickles and *amail* are made from the *Kalkattiya*, though they are made from other mangoes too. From the unshelled mango — *kachua* pickle, and from the shelled mango — sliced pickle. People tire of cabbage and *parhaud* eventually but never of mango. Every taste from every mango.

In *Kharhauri* too there used to be fields. But one person who planted a new orchard found that its shade suppressed the paddy crop of the neighbouring fields. So he too, muttering something at the crossroads, planted a mango orchard there.

There is a *jamuni* grove too. Tall, spreading trees — the *jom* — and slender, fine-leaved *jomni*. And the small, small *gulab-jamun* berries.

Peepal trees are scattered here and there from the *Dihari* shrine all the way to the school grounds. The roots of the peepal reaching out in all directions. Cacti, *pakari*, bel, *tetair* trees are also here and there.

On the embankments — wild betel-nut trees, thickets of *sahar datmani*, bamboo groves and countless flowers and thorns. *Lajbijji* — the sensitive plant — in every orchard. On the broad-canopied mango trees, watchmen have spread out their bedding and sleep. Banyan trees — but only one, near the *peech*, close to Mian Toli. *Duddhi* banana is very beautiful to look at, *Gauriya* banana is very sweet, *Bagnar* banana is large and thick but not that flavorful. If the buffalo does not get its fodder-leaves on time, *menagobhi* leaves are fed to warm it up.

Kharahi is used for thatch and fence-making; the betel vine creeps along *kharahi*, and its use is seen in *baraib* ritual.

In Garh Narikel, the varieties of trees, fruits, grains and vegetables outnumber the human castes.

Vegetables are plentiful — *jhingli*, *sim*, *bhatta*, *muninga*, wild *arar*, *ol*, *kachu*, *chhatail*, *kaita*, *kamalkakri*, *khajba* jackfruit, *khambharu*, *barhar*, *parhaud*. *Ghera* — its flower is fried in batter. Greens of yet more kinds — *genhari* white and red, *aktaa*, *misiya*, *raja rani*. *Muninga* (*sahjan*) greens. Wild *palakki*.

In *Chait*, neem's new spring leaves are used together with *bhatta*.

In lentils: *kurthi*, *masuri*, *kherahi*, *rahari*, *rahariya*, *aktaa*, *misiya*, *bhatpurni*, *ramjhumni*, *sim*.

Rahari dal is eaten by the wealthy, *rahariya* dal by the poor.

Dabra, *Dasariya*, *Malida*, *Belour* — these varieties of paddy, even when submerged, do not become hollow-kernelled.

Bori paddy has a creeper — this creeper trails over the water's surface and a plant grows from every node; barely ten plants fit in a *katha* of land, and from those the whole field fills up.

Many types of paddy grow in the *chauri* marsh — at the time of transplanting there is no water, but later knee-deep, thigh-deep water is always in the *chauri*. The rice grains are somewhat thicker, that's all. *Hapsa* is fragrant. Among the paddy grown in Garh Narikel's *chhaapi* land — the *chauri* — there is *sattokhari*, *padabapankhi*, *tatto*, *kasaham*, *umatth*. In medium-level fields: *satriya*, *panijhali*. Paddy for the higher fields: *jasba*, *kamalkaathi* — with these, good paddy cultivation is possible even with less water.

Paddy is ready in *Agahan*.

The paddy is harvested bit by bit, carefully, by everyone.

Seed-paddy is kept aside for the seed-bed.

The seed is scattered in the *biraar* seed-bed and the seedlings are readied.

From the *Ardra* festival day, transplanting begins.

Curd, day-old rice, jaggery-molasses, *kajal* — all mixed together and fashioned into three or five balls on a *kanchu* leaf — are placed in the field as an offering by everyone. If the Brahmin farmer has three *pravara* lineages, he calls the farmer and the farm-labourers — three cows, three *paan*; and three balls are placed in the field. If the Brahmin farmer has five *pravara* lineages, he calls — five cows, five *paan*; and five balls are placed in the field. These are recited in the field, and the day-labourers set the seedlings uprooted from the seed-bed into the paddy field.

In Jeth *the seed-ball fell, in* Ashadh *it was born*

In Sawan *we transplanted, in* Bhadon *the tillering was done*

In Asin *the paddy flowered, in* Kartik *the grain formed*

In Agahan *the paddy was cut and threshed*

Having threshed, poured into the granary — pounding and eating we shall

When half the transplanting is done and the rest remains, people pause to catch their breath.

Bhadai is sown broadcast; the villagers are skilled in this *chhituaa* paddy cultivation.

Bhadai too of many kinds — *Lakkhhi*, *Jalli*, *Jharha*, *Bachchiya*, *Rangba*, *Gamhari Ujra*, *Gamhari Kariya*. This is ready in *Bhadon*.

Chilli seed-bed. *Biraar*.

Banana rootstock-garden.

In fruits: lychee, banana, jackfruit, *latam*, *mahua*, *jilebi*, *buniya*, *bair*, *aata*, *shariffa*, *sapota*, *barhar*, *jom*, mulberry, pomegranate, coconut, *tabhnebo*, bel, *kadam* — trees of all these are all around. Banana too of many kinds — *Marichmaan*, *Gauria Malbhog*, *Jhurkutiya*, *Dudhi*, *Banshicat*, *Anupan*, *Dudhmungar*, *Batisa*, *Malbhog*, *Singapori*, *Baghnar*, *Barhari*, *Chiniya*, *Malbhog*, *Kapuriya*.

Forests of *kaas*, *pater*, *jhauna* grass. *Khagraa* grass.

Oil from *kera* lentil, mustard, *tori*, *reinchi* and castor. *Til* plants are abundant everywhere — the stalk is used for making *bareri* and the stem for burning *bajrakeraai*. *Aam baanjhi* makes fine charcoal. *Jamain* tree is useful in the *Dhoeen Dhekar* purification rite. *Mangrel* increases the milk yield of cows and also of women. *Suwa*, *jamain-ajmain*, *mangrel* are used as spices. *Mothi*, *mohali-saunf*, *dhoni*, *pudina*, *lahsun-rasun*, *piyauj* and *methi* plants. *Kagji* and *Jamiri* lemon. *Tetair*.

Birds — such as *kachbachiya*, *vanchar* (forest starling), *tithi* (lapwing), *gachhkhodahi* (woodpecker), *chamgadar* (bat), *munhdussi* (owl), *chilhoriya*, *lalsar*, *dighaunch*, *deshi kawa*, *kar kawa* (crow, obstinate crow), *khanjnichirayya* (wagtail, autumn season), *chakeba*, *chaaha-cheha*, *chilhori*, *chuhchuiya*, *dakhar*, *tittir*, partridge with red stripe on the throat, *dhanes*, *dhobiniya* bird, *parba*, *panidubi*, *banmurga*, hill *myna* (red on the face), *paudki*, *phuddi*, *bagra*, *badar* (red-tailed), *baajh*, *maini* (white patch on black, red tongue), *munhdussa*, *laalmuniya*, *nilkanth*, *hariyal* — the green pigeon, which is hunted and eaten. The *fatinga* that strikes the eye (*ankh-phora*); butterfly (two-winged, colourful, without a tail); *tukili* (four-winged, with a tail). The green praying mantis — God Hanuman's horse; another one also exists — like an English machine, it seems the English saw this and made the JCB machine from it.

Khariya, deer, blue bull, green turtle, green conch, *bijji* badger, *khikhir*, *shahi* porcupine — also in abundance.

The meat of snails is made into a side-dish and eaten; it is also drunk as a hot broth; placed in a vessel, the water released after five or seven hours is given to

children to drink in a *mamrakha* earthen bowl, and it is beneficial for urinary problems as well, cools the stomach.

Fish too of many kinds — *rekha*, *tengra*, *kawa*, *garai*, *garchunni*, *gaincha*, *chenga*, *singhi*, *bhunna*, *rauh*. Even rotten *bhunna* fetches double the price of fresh *rauh*.

Chichor — the most abundant species of useless grass in Garh Narikel — notable by name. *Paainik keshour*. Trees with dreadlock flowers. *Hardi* tree. *Agiya grah* tree — to prevent the evil eye and *guzri*, its branch is tied on the arm.

Bread of many kinds — *marua*, rice, *khuddi*, *jao*, almond, *khesari*, *kaun*, *cheen*, maize, millet, *janer*, *alhua*, *aktaa*, *misiya*, *masuri*, *phakua*, *kherahi*, *gura*, *singhar*, *makhaan*, *bhaint*.

On a *katha* or so, the well-off also cultivate wheat, and *sohary* flatbread is also made from it.

The same things keep coming round again and again...

Don't interrupt — the people of this village speak in a rhythm... the same thing comes round many times, but how many new things also come in that rhythm.

Games too of many kinds — the Sanskrit *atkan-matkan* and *kabaddi*. *Champa-Champa* is played with *kanaial* berries; *kariya-jhumri khele chhi dhil patapat mare chhi, samachakeba khele chhi chugla dhoti phare chhi, chugla kothi chhaar bhayya kothi chaaur, chugla rau tohar e kon baani...* from *salau nichhai paani*. Let's go play *jharni*. Come let's play *bansi*. *Amman chhu amman chhu, Chait kabaddi aaba de*. *Bhagavatlila* — the *hathiyasur* and *ujji-ujji*, *Lal Chhadi — jakere naam lal chhadi saahi chali aabay thokar maari parray*. *Jhijhia*, *Jat-Jatin*, *Jharni*, *Huriyaha-Huriyahi*, *Hura-Huri*, *Chhutiya*, *Koili Daud*, *Chor Police*, *Hukka-Loli*, *Kansupti*, *Singi-Patahi*, *Jhijhirkona — jhijhir kona jhijhir kona... kon kona*, *Gadha-Gurkhan*, *Chausa*, *Satghariya*, *Dolpatta*, *Hathi-Chukka*, *Guri Kabaddi*, *Ghoda Kabaddi*, *Juaa*, *Kauri-Kauri*, *Kit-Kit*, *Dori Kud*, *Gharba-Duarba*, *Kho-Kho* — this is local *Kho-Kho*, not Bombay's — *Choranukki*, *Gulli-Danda*, *Pingla*, *Lathmaar*, *Lukka-Chhippi*, *Sona-Dubbi*, *Kushti* wrestling, *Pachisi*, *Ghaas-Ghaas*, *Pachgotba*, *Pitto*, *Ghoghorani*, *Aankh Michhouni*, *Kaniya-Putra* — dolls — *Marua-Maruaini*, *Marua Dheri*, *Banrphaan*, *Maaldari*, football, chess, cards, *Antakshari*, *Pithiyathok*, *Gobarkanna*, *Jhilam Jhaar*, *Solhgotiya*, *Jhilhari*, *Chhuli-Chhuli*, *Dhengapaani*, *Chikka Kabaddi*, *Akro-Makro*, *Goli-Goli*. And: *Rau chhora rabrhakna, Raja beti ka byaah heta ekta kathar maangai chhi, abhin ta ropba kailain hain... abhin ta khijja chhai...*

Good heavens...

The chutneys and *sanna* of Garh Narikel too are of countless kinds. Raw *latam*, *arikauncha*, *ol*, garlic, onion, *tetari*, *kadam*, *methi*, coriander, mint, sesame, *tisi*, *amadi*, tomato, *kutrum*, *dhaatri* (*dhaatriy*), mango piece, mustard, poppy seed, *chatail*, *pirar*, *bhaata* brinjal, *ghera*, *jhumni*, *ramjhumni*, *karaila*

bitter gourd, potato (*sanna*/mash), *parhaud*, *kurli* (*madhkurmi*), *murai* radish, spinach *patauara*, banana (*sanna*), *barhar*, *karona*, *amarora*, *amra*, ginger, *tuuit*, mango blossom (*baur*), *muninga* flower, *ghorjaur* — buttermilk dregs — *sarifa*, *khamhrua*, *penchi*, *aurbi*, coconut, salt-chilli-*kasauni* mixed, fish (*sanna*), *kaankor* (*sanna*), *doka* (*sanna*), *mochhi* — of jackfruit — *poro*, jackfruit pod.

In oils: mustard (*karu tel*), *tori*, sunflower, *reinchi*, *tor*, castor, *kushum*, *murai*, sesame, soybean, coconut, groundnut, *mahua*, *kataiya*, *tissi*.

Fields and farmland too of many kinds. The fields between the two rivers — everyone calls them *oi-par* — the fields across. Sandy fields and silt-laden ones too. The Kamala brings sand and the Balan brings silt. *Paror*, watermelon, *fuit* and *alhua* cultivation — the cheapest land available for purchase anywhere. But after a flood, the field's ridges and boundaries will be found changed. If some year after a flood a field's area has shrunk, don't stand arguing. In the next flood, Kamala Maharani may well increase its area back. Farming is of paddy too, but that depends on luck. Some years, even after planting three times over, each time it will be washed away in floods; some years Kamala Maharani will fill the field with so much silt that if you think in terms of two *mon* per *katha*, you will get even more than that.

To buy slightly more expensive land, buy the land by the *mor* — the curve — or where the *gambhari* tree grows, or by the fig tree. Here people are buying land more for habitation than for farming.

The fields beside the Dakahi pond are called *Badhmaotar*. Earlier they may have been given as *Brahmottara* — a gift to Brahmins — by some king. Earlier one heard that good farming was done there but these days water stands in them. In this region, the *chhituua* paddy cultivation all happens in this *baadh*.

On the death of a buffalo, wailing will also be heard once every month or two. And *jaadoo-tona* — a *puja*-flower thrown at someone's doorstep at night — is also seen once or twice a year. But now people have understood too that this is some youngster's mischief.

Agriculture-fishery-cattle-rearing-based, this village overwhelmingly inhabited by Mahisbar Brahmins is surrounded by educated, not-so-educated and taciturn villages all around — but there is also one village of thieves nearby. Pure thieves — of objects, things and beings. But that they will steal in Garh Narikel — that is not usual. But in this village there is an orchard — *Channa Gaachi*. Even in daytime it is dark. Ghosts, demons and corpses all play *kabaddi* at night — the clear sound of thighs being slapped in the game reaches as far as the road at night; many people have listened to that sound — but they do not accost passers-by; they are absorbed in their own game. Bah, how would a corpse play *kabaddi* — it would just fall flat. Better to have seen for yourself — why go so deep into hearsay? The thieves too, in this very *Channa Gaachi* where even in daytime people are afraid to go, divide up their stolen goods at night. How do I know that? Father — the Mahisbar Brahmins of this village are themselves

demons. They go to the *Channa Gaachi* in daytime and bring back whatever stolen goods have been left behind in the dark by the thieves. Once, some relative's belongings were stolen and found here — whose relative and what belongings, don't ask. I hear that one Mahisbar Brahmin's grandfather, when he was young, had gone there to search for stolen goods and found six corpses of thieves — they must have quarrelled over the division and all killed each other. All the stolen goods were scattered everywhere, and everything came to him. In search of another such windfall, they have been going to the *Channa Gaachi* by three different marsh routes — but such a windfall has not come again.

In other villages, every kind of thief — of literature, of conduct, of thought, of publicity.

The neighbouring thieves do not have the courage to steal in any household of any caste in Garh Narikel. Whoever's marriage takes place in this village has all their troublesome land disputes settled. Becoming a kinsman of this village makes a person prosperous. From here, the *haseri* — the work-party — goes far and wide. The *haseri* comes out for everything from settling disputes over a kinsman's land to many other occasions. Land that costs a thousand rupees per *katha* in this village costs only a hundred rupees per *katha* in the neighbouring *Banaraha* village. High-lying land is cheap in the village because the rain-water cannot irrigate the elevated land. In *Banaraha* village, on high-lying land, these *Banaraha* people grow paddy varieties *jasba*, *kamalkaathi*, *doodhraj*, *bhalsari*, *mansuri*, *bhola mansuri*, *kankshimansuri*; and maize, *kurthi*, *rahari*, *madua*, *kodo*, *kheri* and mustard.

Banaraha — you wouldn't know, that village's orchards are full of monkeys and the people are also yellow-ochre like monkeys!

But you will certainly find a *baari* — kitchen garden — behind every house in Garh Narikel; *bhatta*, lemon, leafy greens, radish — all these are found in the *baari*, and many other kinds of herbs and medicinal plants too.

Until now Durga Puja has not started in this village. It has started in the taciturn village and in *Banaraha* village too — but here! If one wanted it, why wouldn't it happen? Didn't we do the *Ramlila* for a full month? Bah — the embankment clique made everyone fed up. Better that Durga Puja doesn't happen. First there will be the trouble of arranging *liyaun* for the daughters-in-law; and what harmony remains will be destroyed by party politics.

With a *khurpi* the Brahmin of this village can fill many sacks of grass in a single breath, half a mile's worth. The Brahmin of this village keeps all the finest breeds of buffalo. If even the cattle of this village's quarters are touched by someone from another village, the *haseri* comes out — knowingly or unknowingly, an outsider does not have the daring to raise a staff against this village's cattle.

Garh Narikel does not lack for artists. The *khurd* player Jangal Ram, the cornet player Jitan Ram, the devotional singer *Bhagait* — Ruplal Yadav; storytellers — Chhutaharu Yadav and Tahal Mukhi. Dance company opened by

Khushilal Sahu, manager Phusan Yadav. Better than the dance companies of both Simraha-Saptari and Simraha-Supaul. *Alha Rudul*, *Lachhiya Rani — Sati Lachhiya*, *Sheet Basant*, *Gugli Ghatma*, *Raja Kunwar Brijbhan*, *Dhul ka Phool*, *Sultana Daku*, *Raja Harishchandra*, *Raja Nal*, *Raja Salahes*, *Kaanch Taag*, *Andhar Kanoon*, *Loha Singh*, *Maai ka Kaleja*, *Chudi aur Sinoor*, *Jangal Badshah*, *Vansh Ujaaran*, *Piya Deshaaantar* — Jyotirishwar's *Videshiya*, preceding Vidyapati — *Lorik Maniyar*, *Baap ki Hatya*, *Damaad Vadh*, *Nishad Vadh*, *Gopichan*, *Shankar Shosila / Utimchan / Sundar Van ka Sundar Phool*, *Vijay Singh*, *Pita Hatya*, *Jangli Badshah*, *Ras Lila*, *Runa-Jhuna*, *Kabir Lila*, *Kalyug Prem* — and countless other ballads. *Naagarchi* (*nengera* — large drum player) Guneshwar Ram; *khaujri* player Sukdev Safi. *Ghunaamunaa* (*sarangi*) player Khattar Mallik — far better than the Dom-Malliks of his maternal village Kamaraail on the *ghunaamuunaa*. *Jhalibah* (*jhaal* player) Asharphi Mandal. *Kathajhaal / Ramjhaal / kartaal* player Chhedi Mandal. *Bausli* player Gullab Paswan / Jhotan Mandal. Horse dance and labourer's dance performers — Mahadeo Baniya from the line, Dasain Thakur, Durgalal Thakur, Ghuran Pandit. *Jhunjhunna* (*majira*) player Arjun Mandal. *Jhaalar* player Ramjani Paswan; *jaltarang* player Malabhogi Das; *kathtarang* player Bhayalal Das; *mridang* player Chhotakani Das; *been* player Dukhharan Yadav; *tanpura* — Gangaay Sahu; *tarsa* (*taasa*) — played at *Huriyahi* and at the *daha* procession by Kallar Mallik and Mo. Aajam. *Jhaalar* — Bachcha Mandal. *Bipta* is made by Sitaram Ram. The *Digri* player is often also a *Bhariya* — he carries loads on his head, a *digri*-sounder; Satan Mukhi plays the *digri* and Jhotan Mandal sounds the *digri* and also does the work of *bhariya*. From the *digri* comes a small thin sound. From the *nengera* comes a thick sound — when it strikes, you know the dance has begun. *Gumgumiyan* (bass drum), *Babaji's dhuthu* (trumpet) — Domi Das plays it. *Singhariya*, *dhudhubaja* — the big variety, you have to spit while playing it, so much breath is required. *Benjo*. Dancer (Raghunath Sadaay); female roles (Ashok Singh). Male roles, acting, singer, lead, *thekaaita* (tabla player). Organ — Dubbi Mukhi; *naal* — Sunar Choupal; cornet — Phusan Ram; *nengera* — Asharphi Gosain; *dholak* — Hiyalal; *mridang* player — Jharilal Sadaay. *Alha / Maharai*. *Jogira*, *paraati* (*prabhaati*) singer — Lelhu Das. *Jharni* — Mo. Aakuf. *Naal* player — Khattar Mandal. Drum set, harmonium — you may say everyone in Garh Narikel plays these. *Danka / dhol / tabla* — Chunaai Ram. On the *dampha* at *Holi*, no one can match Biku Ram.

Bhagait singer Bichkun Sadaay — the *Bhagait* party of Rasuaar is nothing before him; he sings *Bhagait* and plays the *khajuri* alongside.

The mat-weavers of Deepgaon, craftsmen of *mota* mat-weaving, have also taught some people here their art.

The *aripan* and Mithila painting of the Sahebganjwali and Balatwali; the folk songs of the Belmohanwali and Belahiwali; needlework and embroidery of the Macchhdhiwali. Clay saucers and thousands of tiny clay Mahadeva idols — a one-handed game for the girls and women of this place. Thousands upon thousands of clay Mahadev idols immersed in the garden will be found here and

there. The courtyard and house properly cleaned and plastered — from husking and grinding to transplanting and irrigation, the women of Garh Narikel are not behind in anything. Whether it is the *Saptadora* story or *Madhusvravani* — the women of this place tell every story in a single breath, and when the daughters of this place are married off to other villages, they spread their gifts there too.

The Mahisbar Brahmins of Garh Narikel call the Bhumihars *pachhima*. Those people call themselves Bhumihaar Brahmins, but the Mahisbar Brahmins don't consider them Brahmins. They were Brahmins once but became Buddhist, out of greed for land. Wherever there is land near a Buddhist monastery, Bhumihars will be found — in Bihar, in the Terai of Nepal, and in eastern Uttar Pradesh. In Madhya Pradesh there is the Sanchi Stupa, but there was no land near Buddhist monasteries there, hence Bhumihars are not found there. The Buddhist *siddha* Mehtapa was from Garh Narikel itself. Both his birthplace and place of work were here — he was a *siddha*, he had travelled everywhere, as far as Tibet, and come back. And when Buddhism ended, the Brahmins who had become Buddhist returned to the Sanatan Dharma — but the Mahisbar Brahmins do not consider them Brahmins. The Mahisbar Brahmins — educated or not — will give you knowledge of history and culture that will shake you. But as to why they call the Bhumihars *pachhima*, at that moment they will only say: must have come from the west.

But the *pachhima* people are hurt when called *pachhima* — they call themselves the *dihi* — the original settlers — of this village. But one particular community among the Mahisbar Brahmins also calls itself the *dihi* of this village, and they have reason too — the largest population belongs to the *dihi*, and so it is theirs. But Misartoli's *bhaginmaan* Suryanarayan Thakur says: no, how can the *pachhima* have a larger number? In the plague, their entire quarter was wiped out, one or two survived; half of Misartoli too was wiped out, and then the plague ended, so the *ekaharey* ones all survived. The *dihi* could be either the *pachhima* or the *ekaharey* community of the Mahisbar Brahmins. But this village is known as the village of the Mahisbar Brahmins alone. There is a *Tikulhara Tol* too — that too of Mahisbar Brahmins — in the evenings, like *tikulhara* they all buzz and hum, that's why.

These are the ones who call this village their own.

And the village is Garh Narikel — the village of the Mahisbar Brahmins.

STORY 05

Caste

A drinks party was going on at Hyderabad Police Academy.

"No one will say anything — only I will speak."

Beating his chest: "This is a Rajput's chest — no one will say a word."

"Brother, that's exactly the difference. Both of us are IPS, both of us have been drinking. But can I beat my chest and say — I am a Dom, let no one say a word!"

FROM THE OTHER SIDE OF MEMORY

STORY 06

The Copyist

Two lanes in from Darbhanga's old high road stood the "Folk Manuscript Conservation Room." Half the letters on the outer gate had flaked away, but inside, the smell of dust, the brittle whisper of old paper, and the slow turning of a fan were enough for Sudhindra Das to understand on his very first day that this was no place for hurried work.

Sudhindra's true profession was writing letters clearly. His father had written wedding invitations, shop signs, and sometimes school certificates by hand. Sudhindra knew typing too, but he had never been able to abandon the rhythm of the hand. He was appointed to the conservation room as a "copyist": he would read old manuscripts and prepare clean copies so that researchers would not have to touch the original paper again and again.

In his first week he was given a slender manuscript wrapped in cloth. A small slip on top read: "Songs of Seven Courtyards. Estimated Samvat 1966. Writer/compiler: Ramdulari Devi; name on final page."

The officer in charge, Ishan Jha, looked at him over his spectacles and said, "This is a difficult manuscript. It is in a woman's hand; lines of songs, household accounts, children's names, measurements for dishes - everything is tangled together. Write only what is clearly visible to you. Do not guess."

"And what cannot be read?"

"Leave a blank. You may write 'unclear' in brackets. But do not improve it according to your own judgment."

Sudhindra smiled. "I do not suffer from the disease of correcting things."

Ishan Jha laughed. "The copyist's first disease is correction."

The first page of the manuscript bore a turmeric-yellow stain. The edge of the second had been eaten by insects. On the third page the songs began. Some lines were clear:

"Leaving her father's veranda,along the narrow path the daughter went..."

The initial letter of gel - "went" - was very clear, but the rest of the word was blurred. Sudhindra bent closer. For a moment it looked like del - "gave" or "was given" - then again like gel. Without moving the thin glass strip that protected the page, he tilted his head. Was one ink-stroke forming the belly of a g, or the upright of a d? It was difficult to be certain.

In his working notebook he wrote, "along the narrow path the daughter went," and placed a tiny dot beneath gel. It was his private sign: check again.

At the end of the day the work stopped. The original manuscript was wrapped in cloth and returned to the iron cupboard. The key remained with Bhawani

Babu, the oldest employee in the conservation room. His work was to join torn edges with Japanese paper, remove dust, and flatten pages. He used to say, “Paper too is a body. Touch it too much and it hurts; do not touch it at all and it decays.”

The next morning Sudhindra came back to the same line. His hand stopped.

“Along the narrow path the daughter was given…”

He no longer felt certain that he had seen gel the day before. Today the letter was unmistakably d: a thick upright stroke, a small curve. There seemed no reason to doubt the reading del.

He turned to his working notebook. There was yesterday's gel, with his dot beneath it.

“Did I read it wrongly?” he asked himself.

At noon Bhawani Babu came in. Sudhindra showed him the page.

“Was this gel yesterday, or del?”

Bhawani Babu narrowed his eyes at it for a long time. “Del.”

“Yesterday?”

“How could I remember so many letters from yesterday?”

“The ink looks almost fresh.”

“Old ink changes with the light too.”

It was an ordinary answer. Sudhindra let the question go.

That day, on page five, he encountered the line: “She weeps, measuring the threshold of her marital home.” The p in napi - “measuring” - was half erased. At first Sudhindra read it as nachi - “dancing” - because, although “dancing and weeping” sounded strange in the rhythm of the song, it was still possible. Looking more carefully, he thought he could make out the bowl of the p. He wrote napi.

The next day, the p in the original was unusually clear.

Now he became suspicious.

From the third day onward, he kept a private register: page number; the letter he had seen in the original; his transcription; his doubt. He did not photograph any letters, because photographing the original manuscript required permission. Instead he described their shapes: “upright broken,” “lower curve absent,” “right-hand dot possible.”

Within a week he found five places where, on the following day, the original came to agree with Sudhindra's transcription - even though the reading had not been clear on the first day.

It did not feel like a miracle; before miracles there is usually an office. Sudhindra first doubted his memory, then the light, then wondered whether the removal of dust might be making the letters clearer. But why were all the changes in precisely the letters he had chosen?

He thought of conducting a test, but experimenting on the original manuscript seemed to him an offence. So he selected a place where little meaning would be lost. On page twelve, a song contained the line:

"The sister-in-law took the kaner flowers..."

The r in kaner was blurred. It could also have been read as kanel, which meant nothing. Sudhindra did not deliberately write kanel in the transcription. He did not have the courage to break the rule. But he wrote the r of kaner with an unusually wide flourish, giving it the distinctive curve of his own hand.

The next morning, over the blurred r in the original, there was a small curve in new, dark ink.

The curve was not in Sudhindra's hand. But it bent in the same direction in which Sudhindra had curved the letter in his copy.

A shiver ran down his back.

"Is the original looking at my copy?" The thought was so foolish that he laughed at himself. The laughter stopped at once.

That night, when he went home, he spoke to his mother about Songs of Seven Courtyards. His mother, Phulkumari Devi, had sung at weddings until the 1990s. Her knees hurt now, so she sat on the veranda listening to younger daughters-in-law sing and occasionally interrupted them: "That line is not sung like that."

Sudhindra asked, "Ma, have you heard 'along the narrow path the daughter went'?"

Phulkumari immediately sang the next line:

"Behind her the mother stood,ahead the daughter went."

Sudhindra's attention fixed on the word "went."

"Not 'the daughter was given'?"

Phulkumari looked at him as though he were proposing to put salt in the rice instead of jaggery.

"Who gave the daughter to whom? In the song the daughter walks by herself. At a farewell people may go on talking of giving and taking, but the woman in the song goes on her own feet. It is gel - 'went.'"

"Could it be del in some places?"

"People change things as they sing. But my grandmother sang gel."

Sudhindra fell silent. The first change in the manuscript was suddenly no longer a grammatical slip. A single letter had altered the woman's action. Gel: she herself went. Del: she was given away by someone.

The next day he examined the original page again. The d in del was certainly in newer ink. Amid the brownness of the old letters, its blackness shone separately.

He wanted to tell Ishan Jha, but he did not want to make an accusation without proof. He observed that Bhawani Babu rarely handled the original

manuscript during the day. His work was usually done in the evening, after the reading room had emptied.

That Friday Sudhindra made the excuse that he needed to check two pages of his transcription again. It was past seven in the evening. Ishan Jha had gone home. The cleaner swept the floor and left. Sudhindra remained in the small room at the back, where mesh racks were kept for drying paper.

At around eight o'clock, the lock of the cupboard clicked.

Bhawani Babu took out the manuscript.

Sudhindra watched through the crack.

Bhawani Babu placed Sudhindra's clean transcription on the table. He opened the original page. He took out a fine brush, extremely thin ink, and a magnifying glass. Reading the line in the copy, he began retracing tiny strokes over the faded letters of the original.

Sudhindra stepped out.

Bhawani Babu's hand froze in the air.

For a long time the two looked at each other.

"What are you doing?" Sudhindra did not raise his voice.

Bhawani Babu lowered the brush. "What I have been doing for twenty years – saving letters."

"By looking at my transcription?"

"Your writing is clear. What you read, I use as a basis for restoring the vanished strokes."

"You are adding to the original what is not there."

"It was there. It has faded."

"What proof is there?"

Bhawani Babu was silent.

Sudhindra opened page three. "This was gel. On the first day I wrote gel. Why did you later make it del?"

Bhawani Babu took off his spectacles. "Your transcription said del."

Sudhindra was startled. His first working notebook did say gel, but in the first clean draft he had indeed written del – on the morning when the original itself had appeared to read del. He had later corrected it back to gel, but Bhawani Babu must have seen the earlier draft.

"You transferred my mistake into the original."

"I did not know it was your mistake. You are the copyist. Your work is to read."

"My work is to follow the original. The original is not supposed to follow me."

Bhawani Babu laughed wearily. "Original? Sudhindra, when this manuscript came into my hands, the edges of thirty pages were broken. Before that someone

had used paste, then someone had retraced letters in red ink, someone had added words in pencil. What looks ‘original’ to you is itself the result of many hands.”

“So mine should be added too?”

“I am not adding your hand. I am completing the letters.”

“And the letters you complete wrongly?”

Bhawani Babu gave no answer.

That night they remained seated on opposite sides of the table. The fan was off, because strong air could not be allowed near an open manuscript. Dogs barked on the road outside. Inside, the smell of paper grew dense.

Bhawani Babu said slowly, “There is an exhibition next month. Ramdulari Devi's great-granddaughter is coming from America. Her family donated the manuscript. The director has said it must be made ‘readable.’ People do not donate so that they may look at soot-black marks and holes behind glass.”

“So if something cannot be read, we make it look as though it can?”

“If we do nothing, these letters will disappear completely in five years.”

“A faded letter and an invented letter are not the same thing.”

Bhawani Babu closed his eyes. “You are new. When one saves old things, purity is sometimes a luxury.”

Sudhindra was angry, but Bhawani Babu did not look like a thief to him. The man had spent thirty years joining torn paper. Perhaps, to him, a clear letter was an act of mercy. But mercy too can alter things - Sudhindra understood this for the first time.

The next day he told Ishan Jha everything.

Ishan Jha was silent at first, then sat down holding his head.

“I said explicitly: nothing in ink on the original.”

“Did the director say anything about the exhibition?”

“Making it readable means support, cleaning, proper lighting. Not rewriting the letters.”

“Bhawani Babu says he has been doing this for twenty years.”

Ishan Jha's face changed. “Twenty years?”

The cupboard key was changed that day. But Sudhindra's problem was not solved by changing a key. On page three, del was now in the original. On page five, napi was clear. The r on page twelve shone in new ink. If all those new strokes were now erased, the original would be damaged again. Reversing bad conservation could itself become another injury.

Work stopped for three days.

On the fourth, Ramdulari Devi's great-granddaughter arrived earlier than expected. An elderly woman named Anupama Chaudhary, hesitant in speaking Maithili, she had brought several letters from an old family trunk for the exhibition.

Ishan Jha told her the entire story.

Anupama looked at the manuscript for a long time. Her eyes stopped on del.

"My grandmother used to sing this line," she said softly.

Sudhindra asked, "How?"

Anupama closed her eyes and hummed: "Along the narrow path the daughter went..."

A shiver passed through Sudhindra again, but this time it was not the thrill of mystery. It was the force of evidence.

Bhawani Babu was present too. His face remained lowered.

Anupama said, "I cannot say that Ramdulari Devi herself wrote gel. Songs changed from household to household. But I can say that in our family it was gel."

Ishan Jha said, "Then we will state in the exhibition that there are later interventions in the original."

Bhawani Babu suddenly spoke. "Then people will think the manuscript is fake."

Anupama looked at him. "Why fake? When wrinkles came onto my grandmother's face, did she become fake?"

No one answered.

The exhibition was not postponed. But beside the manuscript a small notice was placed: "Earlier and modern interventions are present in the manuscript. The present form of some letters does not necessarily represent the original writing with certainty."

The sentence gave Sudhindra half satisfaction and half dissatisfaction. His own transcription too was hidden inside the phrase "modern interventions."

He resumed work, but changed his method. He now created three sections: "What is directly visible," "Possible reading," and "Oral form." If only half a letter survived in the original, he wrote only half and placed the rest in brackets. If the living form of a song differed, he recorded it separately.

Ishan Jha said, "This transcription will become difficult to read."

Sudhindra replied, "The original is difficult."

Bhawani Babu stayed away from work for several days. Then one morning he returned quietly. He carried no brush box, only his spectacles and an old cloth bag.

He sat beside Sudhindra.

"Show me page twenty-seven."

On page twenty-seven, half a song had been eaten by insects. In one line only four letters survived: "...house not..." Sudhindra had left the space for the possible reading blank.

Bhawani Babu said, "It could be 'not my house.'"

"It could."

"Will you write it?"

"Under Possible Reading."

"In the main line?"

"No."

Bhawani Babu kept looking at the page. "Earlier, I would have filled it in."

"I know."

"When I see an empty space, my hand itches."

Sudhindra smiled. "Mine too."

They both laughed. The tension had not disappeared completely, but their voices had grown lighter.

Time passed. They approached the final pages of the manuscript. There were fewer songs there and more household accounts: "two seers of rice," "a quarter seer of ghee," "the younger one's fever," "letter from Pachrukhi." Ramdulari Devi's life suddenly descended from poetry into the everyday.

On the penultimate page there was a sentence, half of it faded away:

"What is written will remain; what … will …"

Sudhindra brought the magnifying glass close. Of the word in the middle only two upper curves survived. The final word might have been badalat – "will change"; perhaps bhulat – "will forget / be forgotten"; perhaps chalat – "will go on."

Bhawani Babu sat beside him.

"What do you make of it?" he asked.

Sudhindra looked for a long time.

"Nothing."

"Nothing at all?"

"Not nothing. There are three possibilities."

"Then write all three."

"I will put them under Possible Reading."

In the main transcription Sudhindra wrote:

"What is written will remain; what […] will […]"

Between the brackets he left the spaces blank.

Bhawani Babu watched the tip of his pen. "Does leaving a blank no longer feel difficult?"

Sudhindra said, "A blank space is something to read too."

A few days later, the manuscript was displayed in a glass case. Visitors read Ramdulari Devi's name, looked at the lines of songs, and noticed the stains along

the edges. Sudhindra's full transcription was not displayed beside it; only a printed extract was shown.

A student came to the conservation room for research. Reading the line on page three, he said, "Here it says 'the daughter was given.'"

Sudhindra said, "That is what is on the original now."

"What do you mean?"

Sudhindra showed him the three sections of the transcription: Directly Visible, Possible Reading, Oral Form.

The student asked in surprise, "Then which one is the real one?"

Sudhindra paused before answering.

Bhawani Babu, who was examining the edge of a torn sheet nearby, said softly, "That question used to seem very easy to me."

The student did not laugh. He bent closer over page three.

That evening, after everyone had left, Sudhindra turned through the final transcription again. He looked at his own clean lettering. Once he had taken pride in it: every letter the same height, every stroke at the same angle, no trembling anywhere. Now he understood that clear lettering too could be dangerous; people trust clear things too quickly.

He opened the final page:

"What is written will remain; what [...] will [...]"

The original manuscript was inside the glass case. Under the exhibition light, in the middle of that half-erased sentence, Sudhindra could see an extremely fine dark line. Perhaps it was old. Perhaps it was one of Bhawani Babu's earlier interventions. Perhaps it was an illusion made by the light.

Sudhindra rose and went close to the glass. He could have guessed. By now his hand had learned the habits of Ramdulari Devi's lettering. Filling in one word would not have been difficult.

But he returned to the table.

The empty brackets in the transcription remained exactly as they were.

That night, in the original manuscript, many letters had already followed the copy. But one place remained where, instead of commanding the original, the transcription preserved the original's old inability to speak.

Sudhindra switched off the lamp. In the darkness, the empty brackets could no longer be seen, but he knew there was nothing written there.

And this time, the unwritten thing was the most exact copy of all.

STORY 07

The Last Reader

When the doors of Sonbarsa's "People's Reading Room" opened for the first time after the fire, there were no books inside - only wet ash, twisted iron shelves, and a black layer of paper on the floor that crumbled to powder beneath a footstep.

The fire had broken out three nights earlier. Rainwater had leaked from the roof down to the old wiring, or perhaps a rat had gnawed through a cable - the electricity department offered two different explanations. The fire itself had not been very large; the building survived. The books did not. Paper took the smoke first, then the flame, then the water from the fire engine.

A collection one hundred and thirteen years old turned into wet black pulp in three hours.

No one was injured.

For that reason the incident remained in the newspapers for no more than two days.

But Raghupati Mishra was still sitting on the veranda of the reading room on the third day.

He was seventy-two years old, a retired postal worker. All his life he had delivered letters, and in his spare time he had read books. His membership card in the People's Reading Room was number 047. It had been issued in 1968, when he was fourteen.

The librarian, Madhavi Kumari, almost forty years younger than Raghupati, said to him on the third day:

"Go home, Kaka. There is nothing left here now."

Raghupati kept looking at the heaps of ash.

"Something remains."

"What?"

He tapped his forehead with a finger.

Madhavi did not answer.

Raghupati said again, "I have read them."

"All of them?"

"Almost every book that stood on those shelves."

Madhavi did not laugh. She knew this was not an empty boast. Old members of the reading room said that if Raghupati did not take a book home, he sat there and read it. Children's books, poetry, novels, agricultural pamphlets, travelogues, old magazines, plays - whatever came to hand.

Madhavi asked softly, "Do you remember them?"

Raghupati could not answer at once.

"Some."

Everything began with that "some."

The principal accession registers had not been completely destroyed. Two survived inside a small iron safe in the office - one covering 1951 to 1988, the other 1996 to 2014. The register for the eight years in between was missing. A digital list of newer books survived as a copy on Madhavi's phone, because a week earlier she had taken the list home to revise it.

From these sources, much of the information about titles, authors, and publication years could be rebuilt.

But the text inside the books?

No.

At first Madhavi thought they could search for replacement copies. Some books would be found in the market, some in other libraries, some with authors' families. But when she examined the accession registers she realised that nearly three hundred books had been printed fifty or sixty years earlier by small presses, without anything like a standard book number and without reprints.

Some titles appeared nowhere except in this reading room's catalogue.

One Day's Rain - Shashikala Chaudhary, 1962.

Three Windows - Neelambar Jha, 1957.

Letters of Earth - Jagdish Kamat, 1971.

Wooden Wings - Rameshwar Mandal, year unclear.

Half a Heron - author's name blurred in the register.

Two Bamboo Leaves - a children's story?

The River's Door - a play or a novel?

Seven Kathas of Sky - poetry?

The register preserved the title, not the genre.

And not a single sentence from inside.

On the fifth day after the fire, the district library officer came. He inspected the damage to the building, took photographs, and promised reconstruction. As he was leaving he said:

"Prepare a list of the old collection. Send a proposal for whatever can be bought again."

Madhavi said, "Some books will not be found at all."

"Then mark them 'unavailable.'"

Raghupati had been listening from the veranda.

He suddenly said, "Why unavailable? I remember them."

The officer looked at him.

"What do you remember?"

Raghupati said, “In One Day's Rain, a woman places an earthen pitcher on the roof. The whole story takes place during one day's rain. At the end the pitcher fills, but her husband does not return home.”

Madhavi looked startled.

Raghupati continued, “In Three Windows there is a house where three generations look at the same pond through three different windows.”

“You remember books that old?” the officer asked.

“Not all of them. Fragments.”

The officer became enthusiastic. “Excellent! Prepare memory-based descriptions. At least we will have some idea of the contents.”

Madhavi said at once, “We will not call an estimate the contents of the book.”

The officer laughed. “Call it whatever you like. But do the work.”

He left.

Raghupati looked at Madhavi.

“Shall I write?”

Drying the damp edge of the register, Madhavi said, “Write. But make it clear from the very first line: ‘According to Raghupati Mishra's memory.’”

“What if I remember wrongly?”

“Then we will write that the memory may be wrong.”

Raghupati did not like that sentence.

“I am the one who read them.”

“Which is why you will be the one to write. But what was read and what is remembered are not the same thing.”

Raghupati fell silent.

From the next day he began working in the reading room's temporary quarters. The room was behind the panchayat building. One table, two chairs, a thin strip of sunlight through the window.

Madhavi read titles from the accession register; Raghupati closed his eyes and tried to remember.

“One Day's Rain.”

Raghupati answered at once:

“Shashikala Chaudhary. Blue cover. A drop of water on it.”

Madhavi said, “The colour of the cover is not in the register.”

“I remember it.”

“All right. The story?”

Raghupati wrote:

“A newly married woman in a town in Mithila, perhaps Malati, places an earthen pitcher on the roof during the first rain…”

Madhavi asked, “Are you certain the name was Malati?”

Raghupati stopped.

“Possibly.”

“Then write ‘possibly Malati.’”

“If I write ‘possibly’ this many times, the story will become lame.”

“We are not writing the story. We are writing memory.”

Raghupati wrinkled his nose.

Five titles on the first day.

Seven on the second.

Only two on the third.

Some books seemed to open the moment he closed his eyes.

“Wooden Wings.”

Raghupati began:

“A boy makes a wooden bird. His father is a carpenter. The child wants the bird to fly. The father says wood does not fly; it becomes boats. At the end the child ties paper to the bird's wings and lets it go from the roof.”

Madhavi asked, “Does it fall?”

“No. It catches the wind.”

“How far?”

“As far as the mango tree.”

“The boy's name?”

“Manoj.”

“Certain?”

Raghupati smiled. “This time, certain.”

Four days later they came to Letters of Earth.

Raghupati dictated:

“A postman reaches a village with letters during a flood. The bridge is broken. He carries the letters above his head and crosses the water. One letter belongs to a house where the recipient has already died. He buries the letter in the earth…”

Madhavi suddenly stopped him.

“Kaka.”

“Yes?”

“This sounds like your own life.”

“So what if I was a postman?”

“You told me that in the flood of 1987 you crossed water carrying letters above your head.”

Raghupati stopped his pen.

"That was a different incident."

"And the letter to a dead recipient?"

Raghupati thought for a long time.

He remembered a scene: rain, a mud house, an elderly woman saying, "He died three days ago." The letter in his hand. But had he buried that letter?

No.

Probably not.

"I gave the letter to the people of the house," he said slowly.

"Then was it buried in the book?"

"It may have been."

Madhavi wrote a note: "Memory may be influenced by personal experience."

Raghupati disliked it.

"Will you doubt everything?"

"Where the two do not match."

"You do not trust me?"

"I do. But a claim about a book requires more than trust."

That night at home, Raghupati tried again to remember Letters of Earth. Lying in bed, he closed his eyes.

The story began:

The postman.

The flood.

The letter.

The dead man.

But the postman's face was Raghupati's own younger face.

He opened his eyes.

The next day, on the page for Letters of Earth, he himself wrote in red:

"My own life as a postman may have entered this recollection."

Madhavi said nothing.

By the end of a week they had made memory-notes for twenty-seven books.

News spread.

People in the village began saying, "Raghupati Kaka is writing the books again."

The remark gave Raghupati both pride and fear.

He kept saying, "I am not writing them again. I am writing what I remember."

But for people's convenience the two were the same thing.

A local newspaper ran the headline:

“Three Hundred Books Alive in the Memory of a Seventy-Two-Year-Old Reader.”

Madhavi slapped the newspaper down on the table.

“Three hundred?”

Raghupati said, “I didn't say that.”

“‘Alive’?”

“I didn't say that either.”

“Now people will think you can recite entire books from memory.”

Raghupati folded the newspaper. “People will think whatever they want.”

“No. This will spoil the work.”

It did.

The next day the district office telephoned. The officer was delighted.

“There is so much interest! I am thinking we should publish selected books under the title Reborn from Memory.”

Madhavi said, “The descriptions have not even been verified yet.”

“This is literature, not a court of law.”

“But a new text under an old author's name?”

“We will clearly say it is memory-based.”

Raghupati listened in silence.

After the call ended, Madhavi asked, “What do you want?”

Raghupati took time to answer.

“If the books could be read again…”

“They would not be the books.”

“What about what I remember?”

“That would be the book inside you.”

The sentence kept Raghupati awake all night.

He kept thinking: the book inside.

Does a reader create a second copy of a book within himself?

Or, in the act of reading, does the book mix with the reader's life and become something else?

The next day an event made the question more difficult.

Madhavi's friend Suchitra, who was doing research at the university, came from Patna. After hearing about the fire, she had brought an old book with her.

“Look.”

On the cover was written:

Wooden Wings

Rameshwar Mandal

Second Edition, 1982.

Raghupati almost rose from his chair.

“It survived?”

“In the Patna University collection.”

Madhavi immediately took out Raghupati's memory-note.

Raghupati was excited.

“Let's see! Is Manoj in it or not?”

Suchitra opened the book.

The central character was not Manoj but “Chandan.”

His father was not a carpenter; his maternal uncle made toys.

A wooden bird? Yes.

The child wanted it to fly? Yes.

Paper wings? No. He tied thin strips of cloth.

Did he release it from the roof? No. From the high embankment of a pond.

And at the end?

The bird did not catch the wind and reach the mango tree.

It fell straight into the water.

Chandan did not cry. His uncle took the bird out of the water and said, “The wood did not fly, but your eyes saw the sky.”

Raghupati remained silent for a long time.

Madhavi placed his memory-page before him.

“You wrote that the bird flew as far as the mango tree.”

Raghupati kept turning the pages of the book.

“I remembered it clearly.”

“Yes.”

“Manoj too.”

“Here it is Chandan.”

Raghupati lowered his face.

Suchitra said gently, “Memory is like this.”

“No,” Raghupati said. “I made an error.”

Madhavi said at once:

“An error. But not a lie.”

“What is the difference?”

“With a lie, you know what you are saying is false. Memory showed you a scene that felt true.”

Raghupati closed the book.

"And the mango tree?"

Madhavi asked, "Did you ever try to make a wooden bird fly when you were a child?"

Raghupati did not smile.

"Once. With a neighbour named Manoj. Near a mango tree."

Madhavi and Suchitra looked at one another.

Raghupati leaned back in his chair.

Manoj.

The mango tree.

Paper wings.

All of it had entered the book from his own childhood.

They stopped work for the day.

That evening Raghupati went to the burned reading-room building. The shattered glass had already been removed. The shelves had been taken out. Only black smoke marks remained on the walls.

He thought: if the real copy of Wooden Wings had never been found, his Manoj, mango tree, and paper wings would have become "Rameshwar Mandal's story."

Twenty years later someone might quote it.

What the author had never written would circulate under the author's name.

Raghupati felt afraid - not of Story 16, but of his own life: afraid of certainty.

The next morning he told Madhavi:

"At the top of every note, write in red: 'This is not a reconstruction of the original book.'"

Madhavi laughed. "I have been saying that since the first day."

"And underneath: 'memory-text.'"

"That is a good name."

"Do not remove the book's title. But below the author's name write: 'in Raghupati Mishra's memory.'"

Madhavi nodded.

The nature of the work changed.

Earlier Raghupati had tried to remember the "correct story." Now he also wrote down the structure of his remembering.

Three Windows:

"I remember three women - grandmother, daughter-in-law, granddaughter. The relationships in the book may have been different. The pond feels certain. I remember the western window as red, but the window in my maternal grandparents' house was red too."

One Day's Rain:

"The pitcher on the roof – certain? A very strong image. The husband does not return – possibly. Low confidence in the name Malati. My mother had an acquaintance called Malati Mausi."

Two Bamboo Leaves:

"Two child brothers? Or two sisters? In memory, one leaf speaks to the other. Perhaps it was not a story but a poem."

Half a Heron:

"Title certain. Nothing remembered from inside. Only a white cover with half a bird."

Earlier Raghupati had wanted to fill the blank places.

Now he marked them as blank.

But memory did not stop playing its games.

One day, for The River's Door, he wrote five pages. The story centred on a woman boatman named Jyoti, who altered the height of her doorway according to the rising and falling river. At the end the river changed course and the doorway was left in the wall.

Madhavi read it, enthralled.

"This is very good."

Raghupati smiled with pride.

Three weeks later a copy of The River's Door was found in a private collection in Kolkata.

It was a play.

The principal character was an elderly scholar.

There was no woman boatman.

No Jyoti.

"Door" was only a metaphor: "Rivers open every door."

Raghupati's five pages were entirely wrong.

He began tearing them up.

Madhavi caught his hand.

"Why?"

"This is not the book."

"That is true."

"Then why keep it?"

"It is your story."

"Where did I write it? I remembered it."

"But what you remembered is not in the original. Then it is a new story born from Raghupati's memory."

Raghupati became angry.

"It is theft."

"If you print it under the old author's name, that would be wrong. But what if you say: I remembered it incorrectly, and from that mistaken memory this story was born?"

Raghupati kept holding the pages.

"You want to make me an author?"

"Not I. Memory is doing that."

Raghupati did not tear the pages.

On the file he wrote:

"The River's Door – a separate story born from false memory. Does not correspond to the original play."

From that day there were two files.

One: "Memory-text: verification pending/partial."

The other: "New writing born from memory: not representative of the original."

Raghupati felt embarrassed by the second file, but slowly it grew thicker.

In remembering a book called Yellow Bus he wrote of a ten-year-old child inside a bus – later the recovered book turned out to be a travelogue.

In remembering Little Bell he wrote a school story – the original was a veterinary pamphlet.

In remembering The Salt Tree he imagined a widow growing a plant in the saline soil of her courtyard – the original book was a scientific agricultural leaflet.

Madhavi laughed. "You turn every genre into literature."

Raghupati replied, "In old age the mind turns even a farming booklet into a story."

But behind the laughter lay a serious question.

Why does memory fill empty places with story?

Suchitra sent some articles on psychology. Madhavi read aloud from them: memory is often reconstruction, not exact storage; present experience can alter an old recollection.

Raghupati listened and said, "Scholars took a long time to understand. My mother used to say: 'The mind is not an empty room, it is a kitchen; whatever you put in, something will get cooked.'"

Madhavi immediately began writing it down.

"Which book is that from?"

Raghupati burst out laughing. "This time, from my mother. Write that clearly."

Two months later the reconstruction committee met.

The district officer, a panchayat representative, Madhavi, Suchitra, two teachers, and Raghupati.

The officer's primary objective was still to buy the books again.

Madhavi presented the report:

Total listed titles: 2,748.

Copies found elsewhere: 1,936.

Repurchase possible: 1,422.

Only photocopy/digital copy possible: 418.

Still unavailable: 392.

Raghupati's memory-notes:

238 titles.

Partially verified: 87.

Clearly mixed/incorrect: 41.

Impossible to verify: 110.

The officer asked, "Can we publish these 110?"

Madhavi said, "As memory testimony."

"Not as reconstruction of the books?"

"No."

"People will be disappointed."

For the first time Raghupati himself said:

"Let them be."

Everyone looked at him.

"At first I too thought that if I remembered something, the book had survived. Now I understand: what survived in me was not the book but the experience of reading it. To call that the book would be unjust to the author."

The officer looked disappointed.

"Then what use is this work?"

Raghupati answered:

"Which books people read, which images stayed with them, how time altered them - is that of little use?"

Suchitra added, "And wherever the original has been found, the comparison is valuable in itself."

Madhavi showed the second file. "And some mistaken memories have become new stories."

The officer laughed. "Then the project has turned from a library project into a literary conference."

"Perhaps," Raghupati said.

The committee finally agreed that the project would not be called “Reconstructing Books from Memory.”

Its new title was:

“Behind the Books Once Read: One Reader's Register of Memory.”

Raghupati found the title somewhat heavy, but approved it.

Meanwhile repairs to the reading-room building had begun. The burned shelves were removed. New plaster went up on the walls. The panchayat decided that one room would preserve the history of the old collection.

Madhavi wanted Raghupati's memory-pages displayed there.

Raghupati said, “Not all of them.”

“Why?”

“The mistakes too?”

“Especially those.”

“People will laugh.”

“Then they will read.”

Raghupati agreed.

The first display panel placed two versions of Wooden Wings side by side.

Left:

Raghupati's memory:

Manoj, father a carpenter, paper wings, flight as far as the mango tree.

Right:

Available 1982 edition:

Chandan, maternal uncle a toy-maker, cloth wings, bird falling into the pond.

Between them a small line:

“Memory is not a copy of the original; the reader's life may alter it.”

Schoolchildren came to see the exhibition.

One child asked, “Kaka, why did you write a lie?”

Raghupati's face reddened, but Madhavi did not intervene.

Raghupati bent toward the child and said, “Do you remember yesterday afternoon exactly?”

“Yes.”

“What did you eat?”

“Rice and lentils.”

A friend standing behind him laughed. “You ate khichdi at school.”

The child fell silent.

Everyone laughed.

Raghupati said, “See? The mind sometimes fills an empty place. The difference is that when you find out, you admit it.”

The child asked again, “Then is your story bad?”

Raghupati was about to say “No,” then stopped.

“As the story of the old book, it is bad. If you look at it as my story, that is another matter.”

Satisfied, the child moved on to the next panel.

That same day a Class Twelve student named Neha stopped at Raghupati's mistaken memory of The River's Door. She read all five pages.

“This isn't in the original?” she asked.

“No,” Raghupati said.

“Then who wrote it?”

“I remembered it wrongly.”

“How can a wrong memory be this complete?”

Raghupati laughed. “That is my question too.”

Neha said, “May I write a play based on this?”

Raghupati answered at once, “The original play The River's Door is something else. Change the title.”

“I want to use the story of the woman boatman.”

“Then make it your own story. You do not need to give my name.”

Madhavi was listening from a distance.

Three weeks later Neha brought a short four-page play:

“The Door Left in the Wall.”

Its principal character was not the woman boatman but her daughter. After the river changed course, the daughter painted the old doorway inside the new house so that her mother would not forget direction in the new place.

Raghupati read it and remained silent for a long time.

“This is not my story,” he said.

Neha became nervous. “Is it bad?”

“No. That is why it is good.”

“What do you mean?”

“You changed even my mistaken memory again.”

Neha laughed.

Raghupati suddenly felt that once a book is read, change cannot be prevented. The only question is whether the change will be hidden under the original's name, or accepted under its own.

That night at home he opened the second file.

The Salt Tree – mistaken memory.

He began completing the story.

The first five pages had come from memory. Now he wrote deliberately.

He gave the widow a name: Champa.

The saline soil was no longer a scientific error; it was the dried bed of the village's old pond.

The tree did not literally grow salt; the white mineral crust spreading on its leaves was what Champa called "salt flowers" when she spoke to the children.

At the end she did not cut the tree down. She changed the soil.

Raghupati completed the story in three days.

On the file he wrote:

"An original story born from confusion over the old title. Not a reconstruction of the lost unknown book."

He stared for a long time at the word "original."

For the first time in his life, he wrote his own name as an author:

"Raghupati Mishra."

His hand trembled.

The next day Madhavi read it.

"This should be published."

"Let the library be rebuilt first."

"Both can happen together."

Raghupati laughed. "You people are always in a hurry."

"You waited seventy-two years."

"Not to become a writer."

"Memory waited."

The People's Reading Room reopened seven months after the fire.

It kept its old name.

The new shelves held repurchased books, photocopies, donations, and rare works printed from digital copies. The total collection had not yet reached its former size, but the room again smelled of paper.

On one wall were written three words:

"Original." "Memory." "New Writing."

Madhavi's insistence.

"So that people do not mix them up," she said.

In the room devoted to the old collection's history, a selection of Raghupati's notes was displayed. "Certain," "doubtful," "mixed with personal memory," "inconsistent after original located" - every label was clearly marked.

At the opening, the district officer gave a speech.

“Fire may destroy books, but not ideas.”

Raghupati did not applaud that sentence. It seemed too beautiful to him, too easy.

Some ideas truly had been destroyed.

Of some books, not a single sentence remained in anyone's memory.

Some authors' names were blurred in the register.

Some things would not return.

It was necessary to admit that.

After the speech, the officer called Raghupati to the stage.

“Our last reader!”

Everyone laughed and applauded.

Raghupati stood at the microphone.

“I am not the last reader,” he said.

The officer kept smiling, assuming it was a modest phrase.

Raghupati continued:

“I am only a reader who had read many books from the old collection. I remember some correctly, some wrongly, and much not at all. What I do not remember, I will not invent and place under the name of an old author.”

The hall became quiet.

“And when a wrong memory gives birth to a new story, we will call it a new story.”

Neha, sitting in the front row, smiled.

“Saving books is necessary,” Raghupati said, “but so is preserving the limits of one's own memory.”

He stepped away from the microphone.

The speech was short.

Later Madhavi said, “It was good.”

Raghupati replied, “In a long speech, memory adds things again.”

In the evening, after the opening crowd had thinned, Madhavi brought a small bundle.

“This is for you.”

On top was a newly printed booklet:

The Salt Tree

Raghupati Mishra

People's Reading Room Publication Series, 1.

Raghupati did not reach for it.

“Without asking me?”

"On the manuscript you wrote, 'if it is worth publishing.'"

"Was that consent?"

"I read it as consent."

"See? Not only memory - reading changes things too."

They both laughed.

Raghupati opened the booklet.

On the first page was an editorial note:

"This story was born from the author's mistaken memory of an unavailable title from the destroyed collection. It is not a reconstruction of the old book."

Raghupati let out a long breath.

"Good."

"Will you read it now?"

"Something I wrote myself?"

"Become its first reader."

Raghupati sat in a chair on the veranda. Outside, evening was descending. Light fell on the glass doors of the new shelves.

He began reading The Salt Tree.

After two pages he stopped.

"Did I write this sentence?"

Madhavi called from a distance, "Three months ago."

"I don't remember it."

"Then be careful. Tomorrow you may say some old writer wrote it."

Raghupati burst out laughing.

He went back to reading.

The story was both familiar and unfamiliar. Some sentences he remembered writing at the time and now had forgotten. Some scenes acquired new meanings when he read them now.

Suddenly he understood: even an author eventually becomes a reader of his own writing, and the reader's memory goes on rewriting.

Neha came in through the doorway, carrying a copy of her own play.

"Kaka, have you read it?"

"Half."

"Read mine too."

"First let me finish this one."

Neha sat opposite him.

For a while both read in silence - an old reader reading his new story, a teenage girl reading her new play.

The ashes of the old books had by then been mixed into the earth behind the building. Raghupati could have turned them into a symbol if he had wished - words from ashes, seeds from ashes, rebirth from ashes. But he thought nothing of the sort.

Ash was ash.

What was gone was gone.

What lay on the table was something else.

Some of it from memory.

Some of it from error.

Some of it deliberately written.

Some of it waiting to change again because of the next reader.

Raghupati turned the final page of The Salt Tree.

Neha asked, “How is it?”

He closed the book.

“Different from what I remembered.”

Neha laughed. “You wrote it yourself.”

“Exactly.”

Madhavi heard them as she was closing the shelves. “So?”

Raghupati ran his hand over the cover of the new book.

“Then this is not a book that survived.”

He looked at Neha.

“This is the first book after the fire.”

Neha placed her play on the table.

“The second as well.”

Raghupati opened her manuscript.

Outside, a new light came on over the reading room's signboard.

There was no last reader anymore.

STORY 08

The Shot at the Border

Half a kos south of the Rekhapur post ran a narrow drainage channel. In the rains it swelled; in winter the water came up to the knees; in summer only patches of mud remained. On the map, that channel was not the border. The actual border ran like a straight line between old white boundary stones - in some places ten cubits north of the channel, in others twenty cubits south.

The villagers trusted the stones more than the map.

That was why, after the incident, when the survey team arrived and said, "Boundary stone number 47 has shifted seven cubits east-south-east from its original position," half the village spoke at once:

"Who shifted it?"

No one had an answer.

Rain? A plough? Bullocks? Border guards? A farmer? Children at play? Or had the stone itself tilted over the years as soil washed away and gathered again?

But when the shot was fired, no one was thinking about that question.

That evening, only the worlds of four people, coming from four different directions, stopped at one point.

A soldier. A farmer. An officer. A child.

And one bullet.

* * *

Constable Arun Tamang's shift ran from four in the afternoon until ten at night. He and Constable Imran Ali took turns guarding the western tower of the post. For the previous two weeks the border strip had been declared "sensitive," because illegal consignments of fertiliser, diesel, and tobacco had been intercepted three times at night.

Arun's orders were clear: "If you see activity in the restricted strip after sunset, first call out, then give a light signal, then stop the person according to the situation. The weapon is the last resort."

The sequence had been repeated so often in training that Arun could recite it without thinking:

First warning. Second warning. Third warning. Stop. Safety. Fire only in the face of an immediate threat.

At 5:58 that day the sun was sinking. A strong wind blew from the north-west. Dry reeds swayed. From the distant village came the continuous grinding sound of a paddy-threshing machine.

At 6:05 Arun saw a figure through the binoculars.

Between boundary stones 46 and 47. A bent body. Something long over the shoulder. Behind it, a dark shape like an animal.

He spoke into the radio: “Activity in the western strip.”

The post replied: “Distance?”

“About one hundred and fifty yards.”

“Keep watch.”

The figure did not cross the drainage channel. It stopped near the stone. Then bent down and began pulling something.

Arun's first thought: a sack. Second: a pipe. Third: a rifle?

In the wind, among the reeds, the shape of the long black object kept changing.

He came down from the tower and moved along the lower earthen line of the post. Imran followed five or seven yards behind.

6:07.

Arun shouted: “Stop where you are!”

The wind was strong. The paddy machine roared. A tractor sounded in the distance.

Whether the figure turned or not was unclear.

He shouted again: “Border security! Stop!”

The figure kept pulling.

Arun's hand went to the torch. He flashed the red signal.

The figure stood upright once. The long object at its shoulder rose for a moment.

Arun says that in that instant it looked like the barrel of a gun.

He shouted a third time: “Hands up!”

Then the figure turned back and began walking quickly.

Arun raised his rifle.

He says that he aimed not at the body but at the ground ahead.

One shot.

The figure fell.

The animal behind it leapt away.

Arun ran.

When he came close he saw the farmer Sadanand Mahato on the ground, clutching his right arm.

The “long object” on his shoulder was a length of iron irrigation pipe. The animal behind him was his calf.

At first it was unclear whether the bullet had struck the ground and then grazed the arm, or had directly skimmed past the arm.

Sadanand's kurta was torn; his arm was injured. There was not much blood, but the wound was serious.

Arun felt his stomach turn empty.

"Where is the weapon?" Imran asked.

There was nothing.

Only the pipe. A rope. A small hammer. The broken tether from the calf's neck.

Arun spoke into the radio: "One civilian injured. Medical assistance required."

The post's first question was: "Cross-border activity?"

Arun looked at Sadanand's feet.

White boundary stone 47 was almost beside his knee.

Which side?

At that moment Arun thought: south.

That meant inside the restricted strip.

Later the survey would say that the stone itself had shifted.

But at that moment, the stone was the border.

* * *

Sadanand Mahato had three kathas of land beside the border strip. It had belonged to the family since his father's time. Half the field was irrigated; the other half depended on rain.

On the morning of the incident his pump had failed. A thin iron pipe had come loose from the tube-well joint. Sadanand meant to repair it during the day, but there were guests at home, then the market, then the calf got loose.

At 5:45 in the evening his son said, "The calf has run toward the western field."

Sadanand took a rope and went out.

He knew one should not go into the border strip after sunset.

But to him, "sunset" meant after it had become dark. Villagers measured time less by the clock than by the remaining light.

He found the calf near the drainage channel. Its neck rope was tangled in a bush. While freeing it, his eyes fell upon the pipe - the iron length lay beside the field ridge.

"Better take it now than come again tomorrow."

He put the pipe over his shoulder and caught the calf's rope.

Then came a voice.

The first call did not reach him clearly. The paddy machine was loud.

He turned and saw someone waving from the direction of the post.

He thought perhaps the soldier was saying, "Not that way."

Sadanand himself says that he stopped.

The soldier says that he did not.

At that one moment their two accounts separate.

According to Sadanand, he put the pipe down and cupped a hand to his ear: "What?"

Then the red light flashed.

He became afraid.

Why?

Because there were two small containers of diesel in his pocket.

For the pump.

Half a litre in each. Bought from the village shop. Not for illegal trade.

But he knew that walking around with diesel in the border strip could look suspicious.

He thought: "The guards will catch me, question me, confiscate the containers."

He began moving back toward home.

Quickly? He says no. Arun says yes.

Sadanand says the calf pulled, making his steps quicker.

Then came the voice: "Stop!"

This time he heard clearly.

Instead of stopping, he tried to take the pipe off his shoulder.

Because he thought it unwise to turn toward a soldier with an iron pipe still on his shoulder.

His hand went upward.

From a distance Arun saw it as "raising the long object."

Then the shot.

According to Sadanand there was not even one breath between the clear warning and the bullet.

According to Arun, even after the third warning he was still turning away.

The moment the bullet hit, Sadanand first felt no pain, only a hard blow. He fell. The calf pulled free and ran.

When the soldiers reached him, Sadanand's first sentence was: "I am in my own field."

Arun's first sentence: "Show me your hands."

Both agree on those words.

On the rest, they do not.

Sadanand stayed in hospital for three days. The bullet grazed the flesh of his arm and passed on; the bone was spared. The doctor said he was fortunate.

In the village people said: “A farmer has been shot at the border.”

Some said: “Brutality by the soldier.” Others: “He broke the rules.”

At first Sadanand told no one about the two containers of diesel.

His wife Shanti knew. She said, “Don't tell them. People will turn it into smuggling.”

Sadanand agreed.

His first statement said: “I had gone to catch my calf. I was picking up the pipe. I had nothing else with me.”

“Nothing else” was a lie.

A small lie born of fear.

But in an inquiry, a small lie can become heavy.

* * *

Deputy Commandant Devvrat Sen received the official notice of the incident from the radio log at 6:14.

“Suspicious person in border strip. Warning ignored. One controlled shot. One civilian injured. No weapon recovered.”

Devvrat was in his office. He reached the site at 7:10.

By then it was dark. The injured man was in hospital. The soldier had been separated. Thirty or forty villagers had gathered near the border. There were no slogans, but there was anger.

Devvrat's first act was not to disperse the crowd, but to arrange lights. He wanted to see the ground.

Stone 47. Pipe. Rope. Hammer. A container of diesel?

No.

No diesel was found there.

Later Shanti Devi would say that the containers had been in Sadanand's pocket and that a boy from the family had removed them when he was taken to hospital.

Devvrat did not yet know this.

He took Arun's statement.

“How many warnings?”

Without hesitation Arun said: “Three oral warnings, one light signal.”

Devvrat wrote it down.

“The prescribed sequence?”

“Yes.”

Devvrat paused for a moment.

Trained personnel often speak in trained sentences. That does not necessarily make them lies. But sometimes the standard sequence and the remembered sequence merge into one another.

"The words?"

Arun said: "Stop. Border security. Hands up."

"In that exact order?"

Arun fell silent.

"Are those the training phrases, or the exact words you used that night?"

Arun's face changed.

"Approximately."

Devvrat wrote in his notes: "Verbatim memory uncertain."

Imran's statement: he heard the first call. Heard the second. The third?

"Possibly."

"Before the shot, did Arun say 'hands up'?" Devvrat asked.

Imran thought. "He said something. The wind was strong."

"So three warnings?"

"I heard two clearly."

Devvrat nodded.

At nine that night headquarters telephoned: "Preliminary report immediately."

Devvrat sat down to write.

There was little time. Questions from above: "Were rules followed?" "Was there infiltration?" "Was there smuggling?" "Any local tension?"

Devvrat drafted:

"At approximately 18:07 a person was observed engaged in suspicious activity within the restricted border strip. The sentry issued prescribed oral warnings and a light signal. Instead of stopping, the person changed direction and raised a long metal object in his hand. Perceiving an immediate potential threat, the soldier fired one controlled shot, injuring the person in the right arm. Subsequent examination identified the object as an irrigation pipe."

He had written the word "prescribed."

Did that word mean that the prescribed procedure had been followed in full?

Arun himself did not clearly remember the exact order of three warnings. Imran had clearly heard only two.

But "prescribed oral warnings" was a phrase in the office's standard template.

Devvrat stopped his pen for a moment.

Then headquarters telephoned again: "Has the report been sent?"

He sent it.

The next morning the official statement in the news said: “After suspicious activity continued despite warnings, one shot was fired in accordance with procedure.”

“In accordance with procedure.”

Devvrat had not written those exact words in his preliminary report, but they had appeared in the departmental statement.

The phrase spread through the village like fire.

Reading it in hospital, Sadanand said: “In accordance with procedure? I wasn't even allowed to hear them!”

Reading it at the post, Arun thought: “Did I break procedure or not?”

Reading it in his office, Devvrat held his head.

The official sentence had become cleaner than the facts.

* * *

The fourth viewpoint belonged to twelve-year-old Rani.

Rani was the daughter of Sadanand's neighbour Ramsevak. At the time of the incident she had been grazing goats east of the drainage channel.

No one took her statement on the first day.

Why? A child. “What would she understand?”

On the second day she told everyone at school: “I saw the whole thing.”

Children gathered around.

“The soldier fired without saying anything.”

By evening the sentence had reached the village.

Sadanand's supporters said: “An eyewitness child says there was no warning.”

The inquiry team went to her house.

Rani was excited, frightened, proud – all three.

Devvrat asked, “Where were you standing?”

Rani showed the place beside the channel.

“How far?”

About one hundred and twenty yards.

“What did you see?”

“Sadanand Kaka was taking the pipe. The soldier came running. Red light. Kaka turned. Shot.”

“Sound?”

“I heard the shot.”

“The soldier calling out?”

“No.”

"Was the paddy machine running?"

"Yes."

"Could you see the soldier's mouth?"

"Small, from far away."

"Could you see whether he was shouting?"

Rani paused.

"His mouth... looked open."

"Then how can you say 'without saying anything'?"

Rani's face reddened.

"I did not hear him."

"You did not hear = he did not speak?"

Rani fell silent.

Devvrat said gently, "Tell only what you heard. Do not fill in what you did not hear."

Tears came to Rani's eyes. "I am not lying."

"I am not saying you are."

Rani's mother interrupted: "Don't frighten the child."

Devvrat moved back. "All right. You tell us yourself."

Rani began again.

She saw the red light. Sadanand lowering the pipe? "Possibly."

The soldier raising the rifle. Yes. One shot. Yes.

"Was Kaka running away?"

Rani answered immediately: "No."

Then stopped. "The calf was pulling him."

"Were his steps quick?"

"Yes, a little."

"Was there a container in his hand?"

"I saw something shiny."

Sadanand's mother, who was present, immediately asked: "What container?"

Rani became frightened. "I don't know."

Devvrat wrote: "Object identification uncertain because of distance."

Rani went inside the house.

That night her father asked: "Did you really see something shiny?"

"Yes."

"Did Kaka take diesel?"

"I don't know."

“Don't say that to anyone.”

“Why?”

“People will turn it around.”

Rani's mind became tangled.

The next day at school the teacher asked: “Was there a warning before the shot?”

Rani said: “I did not hear one.”

The teacher said: “Good. Say only that much.”

But her friends said: “You said before that he shot without warning.”

Rani became irritated. “If I couldn't hear anything, then for me it was without warning.”

That was a child's logic. Not a complete lie. Not a complete fact.

* * *

Five days later the inquiry became formal.

The team consisted of Devvrat, a representative of the district magistrate, local police, the survey department, and a medical officer.

The first surprise was boundary stone 47.

The survey officer used old coordinates, new instruments, and a 1989 map.

“The stone was in the wrong place.”

Devvrat asked: “By how much?”

“About seven cubits east-south-east.”

“Since when?”

“I do not know.”

“Then where was the farmer at the time of the incident?”

The survey line was drawn.

The place where Sadanand had fallen lay about three cubits inside his own country according to the original border line. But according to the shifted stone, it lay inside the restricted strip.

There was an uproar in the village.

“See! He was shot in his own field!”

The security side said: “Is a soldier supposed to look at the stone or carry old coordinates?”

The question was difficult.

Devvrat asked: “How often are the boundary stones verified by the post?”

The survey officer replied: “Annual joint inspection.”

“The last one?”

The file was searched.

Eighteen months earlier. The stone had then been recorded as correct.

But the document said only: “Stones 40-50 in normal condition.” There had been no individual measurement.

“Normal” - another government word.

The second surprise concerned the direction of the bullet.

The doctor said the bullet had grazed the outer part of the arm. Its angle might have been downward toward the ground. A metal fragment was found in the soil, possibly from the same bullet. If that match were established, Arun's claim of aiming “at the ground ahead” would be plausible.

But not certain.

Third: the diesel.

After Rani's statement about something “shiny,” the police questioned the family. Shanti Devi eventually produced two containers.

“For the pump,” she said.

No receipt.

The village shopkeeper said: “I gave it to him. Half a litre each.”

“When?”

“That same evening.”

“Receipt?”

“Who gives receipts for that amount?”

Sadanand had to give another statement.

“Why did you hide it before?”

He was silent.

“Smuggling?”

“No.”

“Fear?”

“Yes.”

“Of whom?”

“Of all of you.”

Devvrat wrote: “Small quantity of diesel; claim of local motor use partially corroborated independently. Concealed in first statement.”

Sadanand's lawyer said: “The diesel did not cause the injury.”

Devvrat replied: “Correct. But it is relevant to understanding why the farmer moved away when confronted.”

The lawyer was dissatisfied.

Fourth: the radio log.

Time: 18:05 activity. 18:07 constable on patrol. No entry such as “person unresponsive” at 18:08. At 18:09:38 the radio log said: “One shot, civilian injured.”

How much time had there been for warnings? Arun said about a minute. Imran said thirty to forty seconds. The farmer said one clear warning and then immediately the shot. Rani did not hear the calls.

Were all clocks set to the same time? No.

The post's digital clock was about twenty-two seconds fast. The chemist's camera was thirty-seven seconds slow. Rani had no watch.

Exact seconds collapsed.

But one point remained stable: at least about two minutes separated the first radio report from the shot.

So it had not been wholly “sudden.”

The phrase “immediate potential threat” in the officer's preliminary report now seemed too compressed.

Devvrat wrote that himself.

* * *

Arun's second statement was the most difficult.

Devvrat asked: “The stone was in the wrong place. You did not know that.”

“No.”

“Sadanand did not cross the original border.”

Arun's face tightened. “But the stone was in front of me.”

“Correct.”

“I don't patrol with a map in my hand.”

“Correct.”

“He raised a long object.”

“A pipe.”

“I know now that it was a pipe.”

“At that moment?”

“No.”

“Are you certain about the third warning?”

Arun fell silent.

“This is important.”

“I remember the training sequence.”

“The event?”

Arun lowered his head.

“I remember the first ‘stop.’ I remember the second ‘border security.’ I remember the red light. The third... I think I said it.”

"You think?"

"Yes."

"Then why did your first statement say 'three oral warnings'?"

After a long time Arun said: "Because that is what I was supposed to do."

The room fell silent.

That sentence became the centre of the inquiry.

"What you were supposed to do became what you remembered doing?" Devvrat asked.

Arun's eyes were red. "Possibly."

"The decision to fire?"

"I have no doubt about that. The pipe rose, the man turned, the distance was decreasing..."

"The distance was more than a hundred yards."

"Darkness, wind. It felt like a threat."

"Possibility of escape?"

"Yes."

"Threat and escape are different."

Arun was silent.

"Did he advance toward you?"

"No."

"Throw anything?"

"No."

"Point the pipe toward you?"

Arun took a long breath. "For a moment it appeared so to me."

"Now?"

"Now, looking at the photographs, it is a pipe."

Devvrat made a note.

Arun suddenly said: "Sir, what if it really had been a gun?"

"That question is not the inquiry's answer."

"But that is the question inside a guard's mind at that moment."

Devvrat nodded. "So I will record the circumstance. But not turn a possibility into a fact."

Arun pushed his chair back. "Will the report make me a criminal?"

"I do not know yet."

"Sadanand lied about the diesel."

"That will be written too."

"The stone was in the wrong place."

"That too."

"Then?"

Devvrat said: "Then every inconvenient fact will be written together."

Arun did not laugh.

* * *

Sadanand's second statement.

"Did you hear the first warning?"

"Unclear."

"The second?"

"Something like 'border security.'"

"Then did you stop?"

"For a moment."

"Then moved again?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because of the diesel. Fear."

"You say the diesel was lawful."

"Yes."

"Then why fear?"

Sadanand snapped: "At the border they ask for papers. The shop gives no receipt. They can keep you all day. Farmers know this."

"So you wanted to get away from what looked like the restricted strip?"

"Yes."

"Did you raise the pipe?"

"To take it down."

"Toward the soldier?"

"No."

"Rani says the pipe went up."

"What could she see from that distance?"

Devvrat remained calm. "That is why I am asking."

"I was in my own field."

"According to the original border, yes."

"That's all."

"But could you see stone 47?"

Sadanand was silent.

"You knew people treated that stone as the border?"

"Yes."

"Then, in your own understanding?"

Sadanand's face changed.

He told the truth: "I thought this side of the stone was my field. The pipe was there."

"Which side of the stone?"

They looked at the map.

Sadanand placed his finger according to memory.

Possibly, by the shifted stone, he himself had taken one or two steps into what appeared to be the restricted strip while chasing the calf or picking up the pipe.

"Then your statement, 'I was in my own field'?"

"The land is mine."

"The border line?"

"I do not know."

That was the difference.

Ownership of a field and a national border do not share the same geometry.

Sadanand's land papers did not cross the border, but the ridge was irregular; the border line cut near the edge of the field.

He owned the field. But not every footstep within it fell under the same administrative permission.

The original stone was displaced. Memory was old. The rule was new. The border was hard.

Sadanand sat holding his head.

"Am I a farmer or a cartographer?"

Devvrat did not answer.

* * *

Rani's second statement was taken differently.

This time only a female teacher, Rani's mother, and the survey officer's large map were in the room.

"You were here," the teacher said. Rani put down a red dot.

"Sadanand here?" A green one.

"The soldier?" Blue.

Seeing the distances, Rani herself said: "Was it that far?"

"You saw it."

"It did not feel far."

"After the shot?"

Rani drew a line on the paper.

"Did the soldier call out three times?" the teacher asked.

"I did not hear."

"His mouth?"

"It looked as if it opened twice."

"Twice?"

"Possibly."

"Then why did you first say 'without saying anything'?"

Rani lowered her eyes. "Everyone kept asking whether the soldier spoke or not. I didn't hear him. So I said no."

"And now?"

"Now I will say: I did not hear."

"Did Sadanand Kaka run?"

Rani thought. "The calf was pulling. He walked quickly."

"The pipe toward the soldier?"

Rani acted it out with her hands - first on the shoulder, then down, then perhaps to one side.

"I am not certain."

"Good."

Rani breathed with relief.

Then the child herself asked the next question: "Didi, if I said it wrongly before, am I a liar?"

The teacher said: "No. You quickly made a meaning out of what you saw. Now you are separating what you are not certain about."

Rani thought. "Sadanand Kaka too?"

"Ask him."

"The soldier?"

"Ask him too."

A faint smile came to Rani's face. A child was not an angel of truth, only a human being learning how to tell it.

* * *

The final report took eighteen days.

Pressure came from two directions above.

Headquarters: "Will the use of force be declared compliant with procedure or not?"

District administration: “Compensation to the civilian?”

The village: “A case against the soldier.”

The soldiers' association: “Do not make the jawan a scapegoat.”

Political parties? Devvrat did not want to admit them into the report. Their meetings continued outside.

He divided the document into four sections:

1. Established facts. 2. Uncertain/disputed elements. 3. Procedural lapses. 4. Conclusions regarding responsibility.

Established facts:

- One shot was fired.

- Sadanand was injured; his life was not in danger.

- No weapon was found; the object was an iron irrigation pipe.

- Boundary stone 47 at the site had shifted about seven cubits from the original survey position.

- According to the original border line, the place where Sadanand fell was within his own country.

- The soldier made the first radio report at least about two minutes before the shot.

- A red light signal was used.

- At least two oral calls are supported by both Arun's and Imran's statements.

- The third call is not certain.

- Sadanand had a small quantity of diesel with him and concealed it in his first statement.

- There is no evidence that the diesel was intended for illegal trade.

- Because of the distance, Rani's position for hearing the calls was limited.

- The object in Sadanand's hand was a pipe, not a gun.

Disputed:

- The soldier's third warning.

- Whether Sadanand's movement was “running away” or “moving quickly because of the calf/toward home.”

- The direction of the pipe.

- Whether the shot was aimed directly at him or downward toward the ground as a stopping shot.

- How far, at the moment of the incident, Sadanand had gone inside the restricted strip as indicated by the shifted stone.

Procedural lapses:

- Boundary-stone verification had not been performed on time.

- Local marking of the restricted area was unclear.

- The first departmental statement used the expression “in accordance with procedure” before the inquiry was complete.

- Arun's first statement presented the standard training sequence as though it were exact memory.

- Sadanand concealed the diesel.

- Child witness Rani's first sentence, “without saying anything,” circulated through the village with greater certainty than her actual experience, which was “I did not hear.”

When he came to the final conclusion, Devvrat's pen stopped.

“Soldier guilty”? “Soldier innocent”? Both sentences were smaller than the document's complexity.

He wrote:

“The available evidence does not establish that the injured person was about to mount an immediate armed attack on the soldier. The soldier's perception of the pipe as a possible weapon may have been situationally understandable; however, because of the distance, direction of movement, uncertainty regarding warnings, and confusion created by the displaced boundary marker, it cannot be said with certainty that the decision to fire met the expected standard of restraint. The incident cannot be explained solely as the civilian's disregard of rules or solely as deliberate aggression by the soldier.”

Then:

“The civilian is eligible for compensation for treatment and loss of income because the injury occurred within an official border-security operation; such compensation does not constitute an admission of criminal liability.”

Departmental discipline for Arun? “Review of use-of-force training, temporary removal from armed duty, final administrative decision by higher committee.”

For Sadanand? “Warning regarding instructions for the restricted strip; no case relating to diesel trade.”

The stone? “Immediate reinstatement, reflective markers, signs in the local language.”

The report went upward.

For three days there was no reply.

Then headquarters said: “The language is excessively uncertain.”

Devvrat asked: “Which part?”

“The conclusion.”

“The evidence is uncertain too.”

“The public wants a clear answer.”

Devvrat was silent.

“Was the jawan compliant with procedure?”

"I have written that it cannot be established with complete certainty."

"That is the problem."

For the first time, Devvrat laughed in his office chair. "Is the problem the event, or the language?"

There was silence at the other end of the phone.

In the end, the report was not accepted in full exactly as written, but was retained as a "factual annexure." The public summary was milder:

"A civilian was injured in the incident. The inquiry identified displacement of a boundary marker, communication/visual confusion, and questions concerning the use-of-force process. Compensation approved; departmental review continuing."

The words "in accordance with procedure" had disappeared.

Sadanand read it and said: "What about the soldier?"

Shanti said: "Nothing is clear."

Arun read it and said: "What about me?"

Imran said: "Nothing is clear."

Both sides were dissatisfied.

Perhaps, this time, the document was closer to the truth.

* * *

Compensation arrived - medical expenses, five weeks' loss of income, damage to the field.

Sadanand took the money. Some people said: "The government has admitted its mistake."

Devvrat said: "Compensation is not a legal admission of error."

No one in the village paid much attention to that distinction.

Arun was removed from armed duty for one month. Then came retraining. During firing practice the instructor asked:

"Long object = weapon?"

The jawans answered: "Not necessarily."

"Person in a strip that looks like the border = infiltrator?"

"Not necessarily."

"Remember the standard sequence?"

Arun's face tightened.

The instructor continued: "Remembering the sequence and remembering the event are two different things."

Arun recognised Devvrat's sentence.

He could not say that he completely regretted the decision to fire. At that moment, the danger had felt real to him.

But neither could he now say: "The protocol was completed, therefore the decision was right."

There was a gap between the paper and the instant.

* * *

Boundary stone 47 was reset in its proper position.

The old hole was filled. A new reflective sign read: "Border Line - Entry Prohibited After Sunset."

In the local language too.

The ridge of Sadanand's field now visibly divided into two clear areas. He laughed: "My field is in my own country, but if I go three cubits nearer the strip, I need permission."

The survey officer said: "A border does not see fields."

Sadanand replied: "A field does not see borders."

Both were right.

On her way to school, Rani would stop to look at the stone.

One day Arun was patrolling there. Rani saw him. Arun recognised her too.

Both were uncomfortable.

Rani spoke first: "Now I say: I did not hear the warning. Not that there was no warning."

Arun was startled. "Good."

"Did you call out three times?"

Arun could not laugh. "Twice for certain."

"The third?"

"Not certain."

Rani nodded as though she had solved a difficult sum.

"And the pipe looked like a gun?"

"At that moment."

"Now?"

"Now it is a pipe."

Rani smiled.

"At that moment it looked to me as though the soldier fired without saying anything."

"Now?"

"Now I know only that I did not hear."

For the first time Arun gave a faint laugh. "We both changed."

Rani said: “The incident did not.”

The sentence stayed inside Arun.

* * *

Sadanand and Arun met face to face three months later.

The place was the panchayat building, for the final signatures on the compensation papers.

Sadanand's arm was almost healed, though lifting heavy things still caused pain.

Arun was not in civilian clothes; he wore his uniform.

They nodded their heads to one another, something like a greeting.

The papers were completed. People went outside.

Sadanand suddenly said: “I hid the diesel.”

Arun said: “I know.”

“You read the report?”

“Yes.”

“Do you think I am a smuggler?”

After a long pause Arun said: “No.”

“That night?”

“I was suspicious.”

“I thought you had wanted to shoot from the start.”

Arun's face tightened. “No.”

Sadanand kept looking at him. “Now... I don't fully believe that, but I believe it more than before.”

Arun said: “I thought you were running.”

“I was moving away because of the diesel.”

“I did not know that.”

“I didn't tell you either.”

Both were silent.

Sadanand asked: “If that same moment came again?”

Arun did not answer immediately.

“Possibly no shot. I would take cover, keep more distance, call the other jawan.”

“Possibly?”

“Yes.”

Sadanand laughed. “You have caught the report's disease.”

Arun laughed too.

But this was not reconciliation. Not friendship. Not a ceremony of forgiveness.

Only two men seeing the edges of their own sentences.

* * *

A year later, the incident became a small exercise in the school's social-studies class.

The teacher gave the students four documents: Arun's first statement. Sadanand's first statement. Rani's first account. The final register of facts.

The students read them separately.

One student said: "The soldier was lying; he invented three warnings."

Another: "The farmer lied too; he hid the diesel."

A third: "The child was the most truthful."

Rani, now thirteen and in the same class, immediately said: "No."

Everyone looked at her.

"My first statement was not completely right either."

The teacher smiled. "Then who was most truthful?"

Rani said: "The document?"

The teacher held up the register of facts. "A human being made this too."

Rani thought. "Then... the things that agree everywhere?"

"The beginning."

"And the rest?"

"Questions."

One student was troubled. "Then the conclusion?"

Rani looked through the window toward the boundary stone.

"One shot was fired. Kaka was injured. The pipe was not a gun. The stone was in the wrong place. I could not hear all the calls. The soldier felt threatened. Kaka hid the diesel."

"Then the fault?"

Rani shrugged. "I am a child, not a judge."

Everyone laughed.

Rani did too.

This time she did not mind being called a child.

* * *

A new iron post was installed beside boundary stone 47. At night a solar lamp glowed on it. The red line was clear.

One evening Sadanand went to inspect his field. Arun was patrolling in the distance. Rani was returning home with the goats.

All three saw one another, but no one stopped.

The stone stood firm in its new position.

Yet when villagers told the story of the incident, they still pointed by turns toward the old place: “The shot was fired there.”

The survey officer would say: “No, the actual border is here.”

Sadanand would say: “The incident happened near the stone's old position.”

Arun would say: “What I saw was according to the old stone.”

Rani would say: “I was east of the drainage channel.”

All four statements made the place different, though the earth was one.

A shifted stone can be reset. A shifted memory?

There is no single instrument with which to measure it.

Even so, some things were reset:

“I did not hear” should not be turned into “he did not speak.”

“Standard procedure” should not be taken as “what actually happened.”

“My field” should not be mistaken for “the border line.”

“It felt like a threat” should not automatically become “there was a threat.”

The sound of the shot lasted only a moment.

Its meaning went on for a very long time.

STORY 09

The Mason's Fall

The new five-storey commercial building rising at the western edge of town had already been named "Samriddhi Sadan," though half its walls had not yet been plastered.

A blue board hung at the main gate:

"SAFETY FIRST."

Directly beneath it, workers entered along a narrow path between cement, sand, and iron rods.

Mason Budhan Sada usually arrived before seven in the morning. He did so that day as well, but stopped as soon as he looked at a bamboo in the fourth tier of the scaffold.

One of its nodes had split.

The rope was wet from the night's rain too.

Budhan told the guard:

"It is not safe to climb on this tier today."

The guard, Kanhaiya, replied:

"How would I know? Tell Munshi ji."

Site clerk Rakesh Ojha was on his phone trying to locate a delivery truck.

Budhan repeated:

"The upper bamboo needs to be replaced."

Without looking up, Rakesh said:

"The engineer will inspect at nine. Work below until then."

Budhan began work at ground level.

But at eight o'clock the contractor's representative, Anil Sah, arrived and said that the outer wall of the second floor had to be completed by afternoon.

"A client is coming to inspect tomorrow," Anil said. "We are behind schedule."

Rakesh said quietly:

"One bamboo on the scaffold is damaged."

Anil looked upward.

"Will we stop the whole day for one bamboo? Replace it, but keep the work going too."

No clear order followed about who would replace the bamboo.

The separate subcontractor responsible for erecting the scaffold had had no workers on site for three days.

Budhan and his fellow worker Chhotelal continued arranging their tools.

Chhotelal asked:

“Are we going up?”

Budhan said:

“I don't want to.”

“Will they cut the day's wage?”

Both fell silent.

They were daily-wage workers.

Even after attendance had been marked, half a day's wages could be cut if “no work available” was entered.

At home Budhan had his wife Manju, two children, and his elderly mother.

The previous week, medicines for his younger son had cost extra.

* * *

A little after nine, site engineer Praveen Kumar arrived.

He carried a file in one hand and was looking toward an interior beam.

Rakesh told him about the scaffold.

Praveen came outside, looked up from the ground, then opened the inspection register.

“Who does the daily scaffold inspection?”

Rakesh said:

“The subcontractor's supervisor.”

“Is he here today?”

“No.”

Praveen frowned.

“Then exterior work should remain stopped without a written inspection.”

Anil Sah immediately intervened.

“Sir, it is only one bamboo. The rest is strong. We can do the work carefully.”

Praveen said:

“‘Carefully’ is not a certificate.”

He wrote something in the inspection register.

Later, that one line became the most disputed sentence in the case.

It read:

“Defective member of upper scaffold section to be replaced; reinspection required.”

The words “work stopped” were not there.

Nor were the words “work may continue.”

Praveen went inside to inspect the concrete work.

Anil said to Rakesh:

"Where will we find people to change the bamboo?"

Rakesh replied:

"The scaffold crew's phone is switched off."

"Then brace it from below."

An extra bamboo was fitted diagonally as support.

The guard and two workers tightened the rope.

Budhan looked at the arrangement.

"This is not an inspection," he said.

Rakesh did not snap at him.

In a tired voice he said:

"I know. But this is all we have today."

Budhan asked again:

"What if I don't climb?"

Rakesh was silent for a moment.

"I won't mark you absent. But who will do the outer wall?"

There was no direct command in the sentence.

Budhan understood its weight all the same.

At 10:20 he climbed onto the scaffold.

Chhotelal went up behind him.

They began lifting bricks, spreading mortar, and extending the outer wall along the edge of the second floor.

At about eleven the wind strengthened.

A sheet of plastic blew away from the sand pile below.

Budhan touched one of the scaffold ropes and said to Chhotelal:

"It is loosening."

Chhotelal said:

"Shall we go down?"

At that moment Rakesh called from below:

"Finish five bricks on this course and come down in ten minutes."

Rakesh would later say that he had meant only to "secure the unfinished section."

Chhotelal would say that he had clearly heard:

"Finish five bricks."

The mixer was making a great deal of noise below.

How clearly anyone heard which words could not be established.

At 11:27, one joint of the outer scaffold shifted.

The mortar pan fell first.

Chhotelal grabbed the wall.

The plank beneath Budhan's foot tilted to one side.

Budhan fell.

There is no need to describe the accident further than that.

Work on the site stopped immediately.

Praveen Kumar ran out from inside.

Anil Sah called an ambulance.

Rakesh telephoned Manju.

Budhan did not regain consciousness before reaching the hospital.

At 1:45 in the afternoon, the doctor declared him dead.

That evening the blue "SAFETY FIRST" board still hung exactly where it had been.

* * *

Four kinds of story began to form immediately after the accident.

The contractor's office issued its first written notice:

"Unexpected scaffold failure; preliminary investigation under way."

Among the workers the story was:

"They made him climb without replacing the damaged bamboo."

The engineer's note said:

"Instructions had been given to replace the defective member and reinspect."

At Budhan's home, Manju had only one question:

"If instructions had been given, why did the work continue?"

* * *

The next day labour-department inspector Seema Jha arrived.

The first thing she asked for was not photographs of the site.

It was the attendance register.

Budhan's name was marked for a full day.

"He died at 11:27. Then why a full day's attendance?" Seema asked.

The site clerk said:

"The decision to pay the whole day's wage was made afterwards."

"A decision or an entry in the record?"

Rakesh fell silent.

Seema asked for the scaffold subcontract.

The main contract belonged to Shubhnirman Private Limited.

Scaffolding was the responsibility of Aaradhya Support Service.

The subcontract clearly required daily supervision.

The supervisor's signature was absent for the previous two days.

Anil Sah said:

“I was not aware of this absence.”

Seema asked:

“You are the site representative?”

“Yes.”

“Then who was supposed to know?”

Before answering, Anil began drinking water.

Praveen Kumar produced his inspection register.

Seema read the disputed line again and again:

“Defective member to be replaced; reinspection required.”

“Why did you not issue a written stop-work order?” she asked.

Praveen said:

“I understood that exterior work would automatically remain stopped until reinspection.”

“Understood by whom?”

“Site management.”

“The workers?”

Praveen was silent.

He said:

“I had told both Rakesh and Anil in front of them.”

Anil's account was different.

According to him, the engineer had merely said:

“Check the upper section.”

He denied any complete work stoppage.

Rakesh's position lay somewhere in between.

He said:

“I understood it as a stop. But the interior work was not stopped. I told them to complete five bricks on the outside for safety.”

Seema asked:

“For safety, you kept workers on a defective scaffold?”

Rakesh lowered his head.

"At that moment I thought five minutes posed less risk."

"Does risk check the clock before arriving?"

Rakesh did not answer.

* * *

Chhotelal's statement was the hardest.

He was not merely a co-worker.

He had been on the scaffold during the accident.

Again and again he said:

"If I say we were forced, why did I climb too? If I say it was voluntary, why did Budhan keep raising the bamboo problem?"

Seema asked him to state only facts.

Chhotelal said:

Budhan pointed out the defect in the morning.

Rakesh heard him.

The engineer wrote it down.

The bamboo was not replaced.

A diagonal support was fitted.

The two workers discussed their fear that wages might be cut.

Then they climbed.

"Did anyone explicitly threaten you?" Seema asked.

"No."

"Did anyone explicitly say, 'If you do not climb, you will be dismissed'?"

"No."

"Then where did the fear come from?"

Chhotelal looked directly at Seema.

"Madam, fear is not always spoken in a sentence."

Seema copied those words exactly into her file.

* * *

On the third day Manju came to the site.

The company had called her to complete compensation forms.

She wore a blue sari.

Her brother-in-law Raju and her twelve-year-old daughter Rani came with her.

Anil Sah expressed his sympathy.

"The company will provide full cooperation," he said.

Manju asked:

“How much is ‘full’?”

Anil paused.

“According to the law: insurance, outstanding wages, additional assistance – everything.”

Manju said:

“I am not asking about money. I am asking whether ‘full cooperation’ includes the truth.”

The room went silent.

Manju asked for Budhan's bag.

Inside were:

a hammer,

a trowel,

a measuring tape,

a gamchha,

a half-eaten box of flattened rice and jaggery,

and a small notebook.

The notebook was mainly for wage accounts.

On some pages Budhan had added brief notes about the day's work:

“three window frames,”

“north wall,”

“half plaster,”

“scaffold loose.”

The day before the accident he had written:

“Told them upper rope needs changing.”

Manju handed the page to Seema.

The company's lawyer said a private notebook was not a “formal safety record.”

Seema replied:

“Correct. But where formal records are incomplete, it is supporting evidence for the sequence of events.”

To Manju, the important word was not “evidence.”

It was “told.”

Budhan had told them.

Between who heard, who wrote, and who postponed, his life had become trapped.

* * *

On the fifth day of the inquiry, a scaffolding expert was called.

He examined the broken bamboo, ropes, joints, and planks.

His preliminary opinion was that the accident was not caused by a single bamboo alone.

Vertical support was insufficient.

The rope at two joints was old.

One end of the plank was inadequately tied.

And the temporary diagonal bamboo had altered the direction of the load.

In other words, the defect lay not in one object but in the whole assembly.

Anil Sah treated this finding as helpful to his side.

"See? It was not only that bamboo."

Seema said:

"Multiple defects do not reduce responsibility. Sometimes they increase it."

Praveen Kumar also stated his position.

"I had identified the defect."

Seema asked:

"After identifying it, did you ensure an effective stop-work measure?"

Praveen answered:

"No."

It was the first clear "no" that any senior person had spoken about his own role in the inquiry.

* * *

Rakesh's position was different.

He was not a permanent company employee.

He was a site clerk on a monthly honorarium.

He said:

"The deadline was not mine.

The scaffold subcontract was not mine.

The engineer's instruction was above me.

The attendance register was in my hand.

Half of every responsibility came to me, but complete authority over nothing."

Seema asked:

"Then why did you call out for them to finish five bricks?"

After a long silence Rakesh said:

"Because at that moment I used the small authority I did have, and I used it wrongly."

Manju was present when he gave this statement.

She did not abuse him.

She asked only:

"What would have happened if Budhan had climbed down?"

Rakesh said:

"The wall would have been five bricks short."

"That's all?"

"Perhaps the day's work would have remained incomplete."

"And now?"

Rakesh lowered his eyes.

Manju asked nothing further.

* * *

Gradually the inquiry moved beyond the accident and into the structure of employment itself.

The workers had no appointment letters.

Safety training was certified by a single collective signature sheet.

But five workers, including Chhotelal, said they had merely been handed helmets, not trained.

There were enough helmets.

There were too few safety harnesses.

In several places the permanent lifeline to which harnesses should have been attached was broken.

The daily inspection register was supposed to be completed by the subcontractor's supervisor.

But site management had no clear procedure for stopping work when that supervisor was absent.

The schedule showed that the exterior wall was three days behind.

The client-inspection date had already been fixed.

An email from the contractor company said:

"Ensure visible progress."

That sentence was not an order to cause an accident.

But Seema noted that administrative pressure does not always say:

"Take the risk."

It may only set targets for time, payment, and reputation.

And as that pressure travels downward, the risk can eventually reach the worker's body.

The company's lawyer objected to this interpretation.

"That is inference."

Seema replied:

"That is why I am recording it as work context, not as the immediate cause."

Manju listened carefully to the distinction:

cause,

context.

She felt that inquiry language placed every fact into a separate box.

Grief had no such boxes.

At home Budhan's mother kept asking at night:

"Why did he fall?"

At first Manju would say:

"The scaffold broke."

After a few days:

"The scaffold had not been inspected."

Then one day:

"There were many things."

The old mother said:

"Will many things bring back one son?"

Manju had no answer.

Rani wrote her father's occupation in her school notebook:

"Mason."

Her teacher had read the news about the accident.

She advised Rani to take leave.

Rani said:

"At home I hear everyone saying the same thing again and again. At school I can at least read about something else."

Manju did not stop her.

* * *

Ten days later the workers were called back to the site.

A new scaffold had been erected.

The blue board at the gate had not changed.

But below it a new notice was pasted:

"Before climbing the scaffold, check today's inspection mark."

Chhotelal read it and stopped.

"What if there is no inspection mark?"

The new supervisor said:

"Stop work."

"Wages?"

The supervisor did not answer.

Chhotelal did not laugh.

"Without an answer to that question, the rule is only half a rule."

The remark reached the labour department.

In her interim order Seema wrote:

"When work is stopped for safety reasons, the period shall not be treated as worker absence for the purpose of wage deduction."

The company argued that this would increase costs.

For the workers, it was the first time that the sentence "I will not climb" had become valid inside the rule itself.

* * *

Manju went to the bank to receive the first instalment of compensation.

On the way she felt guilty that seeing the money brought her a sense of relief.

Then she stopped herself.

Budhan's death and the household's expenses were not contradictory truths.

The payment was not the value of a life.

But when one life stopped, the expenses of those who remained did not stop.

* * *

At the final hearing, four principal sides were present:

the contractor,

the engineer,

the workers' representative,

and the family.

Seema read the sequence of events.

The defect was noticed in the morning.

The subcontractor's supervisor was absent.

The engineer wrote that the defective member should be replaced and reinspection carried out.

The defective member was not formally replaced.

A temporary support was fitted.

Exterior work continued.

The workers climbed.

The scaffold failed.

There was no single moment in that sequence at which all responsibility settled entirely on one person.

But that did not make anyone's responsibility zero.

The main contractor was held responsible for failing to ensure a safe system of work.

The scaffold subcontractor was cited for the absence of daily inspection and a qualified supervisor.

The engineer was recorded as professionally at fault for failing to verify an effective stop-work measure after identifying the defect.

The site clerk's oral instruction to finish five bricks was treated as an immediate factor increasing risk, while the deadline pressure and authority structure were recorded as context.

A proposal to describe Budhan and Chhotelal's decision to climb as an "equal share of safety responsibility" was rejected by Seema.

The report said:

"Within economic dependence and workplace hierarchy, workers' consent cannot be treated as a completely free choice."

Manju read that line three times.

She asked Seema:

"Where in this does it say Budhan made a mistake?"

Seema said:

"He saw the risk and still climbed - that is a fact. But fact and blame are not the same thing."

"Then does his decision mean nothing?"

"It means something. But the circumstances in which that decision was made mean something too."

Manju nodded slowly.

She remembered Chhotelal's sentence:

fear is not always spoken in a sentence.

* * *

Two months later, the exterior wall of Samriddhi Sadan was complete.

The client-inspection date had already been changed.

Invitations for the building's inauguration were printed.

Budhan's name appeared nowhere.

One day Rani asked her mother:

"How many bricks did Babu lay in this building?"

Manju said:

"There is no count."

"Then no one will know he worked here?"

Manju took out Budhan's little notebook.

"This knows."

Rani turned the pages:

north wall,

window frames,

plaster,

told them the rope needed changing.

She asked:

"Will we put this notebook in a museum?"

For the first time Manju smiled faintly.

"No. First we will build the roof of our own house. Then we will see."

She decided to use part of the compensation to complete their unfinished roof.

Raju called a mason he knew.

* * *

On the day work began, Manju climbed the steps and inspected the bamboo scaffold.

The mason said:

"Sister, don't worry. It is strong."

Manju replied:

"Worry is my job. Inspection is yours."

She began looking at the bamboo, rope, and planks one by one.

At first the mason was uncomfortable.

Then he said:

"All right. Let's look together."

Rani called from below:

"Ma, have you become an engineer?"

Manju answered:

"No. I have learned to ask questions."

One day while the roof was being built, rain began.

The workers came down.

The mason said:

"Half the day is gone."

Manju asked:

"Will you pay the full wage?"

"Only half the work was done."

Manju looked toward Budhan's notebook.

"The day may be half. A body is not."

After some argument, full wages were paid.

It was no great reform.

In the next lane, work might still be going on in the old way.

At Samriddhi Sadan too, who knew how long the new rules would survive on paper?

But later Chhotelal said that once, when there was no inspection mark, he refused to climb the scaffold.

His day's wage was not cut.

Rakesh found a job at another site.

He began carrying a red pen in his pocket.

When he saw a defect, he no longer wrote merely:

"Replace."

He wrote:

"WORK STOPPED - UNTIL REINSPECTION."

Praveen Kumar changed the language of his inspection register too.

Anil Sah's company appointed a permanent safety supervisor.

The reasons included legal pressure, insurance conditions, and reputation.

Whatever the reasons, the result was recorded.

* * *

None of this brought Manju peace.

Peace is not something that arrives with a signature on the final page of a report.

But she understood one distinction.

Responsibility can be divided.

The shares of fault can be different.

But saying "everyone was at fault" cannot be used to erase anyone's fault.

And saying "he climbed himself" cannot be used to make invisible the circumstances within which his choice was formed.

The final line in Budhan's notebook had been written the day before the accident:

"Told them upper rope needs changing."

Manju wrote nothing beneath it.

She left the page exactly as it was.

Because sometimes an unfinished sentence asks the clearest question of an entire system.

STORY 10

Kohl

The morning light had not yet fully spread.

A thin strip of yellow sunlight was climbing the eastern wall of the courtyard, and in Sharda Devi's room, before the old wooden mirror, Ira had already drawn kohl twice along her eyes and wiped it away with cotton both times.

When she raised her hand for a third attempt, Sharda Devi spoke from the cot.

"Give it to me. I'll put it on."

Ira laughed.

"You? What if the line goes crooked? My first-day photographs will be ruined."

"My hand does not tremble that much yet," Sharda Devi said, sitting up with the help of a pillow. "And on a first day, the eyes should look straight, not the photograph."

Ira had been appointed as a history teacher in the district school.

Today was her first day.

Since the previous evening, the house had been full of small preparations:

a file of papers,

copies of certificates,

a steel water bottle,

two pens,

the bus timetable,

and Neelima asking again and again whether she would forget her lunchbox.

In the middle of all those preparations Ira kept looking at herself in the mirror.

Was the sari right?

Was the braid too tight?

Should she wear the small bindi on her forehead or not?

Should she put on kohl or leave it off?

Neelima, Ira's mother, appeared in the doorway.

"Ma, don't start the old rule again. No thick kohl to ward off the evil eye."

Without looking toward her, Sharda Devi said:

"I don't put it on for the evil eye."

"Then for what?"

"For the eyes."

Neelima smiled and walked away.

* * *

Ira placed the small brass kohl box in Sharda Devi's palm.

Blackness had gathered around the lid.

Sharda Devi stroked it with her thumb.

"Is this bought from the market?"

"Yes. The one you make spreads too much."

"The one I made stayed with the eye. The market one stays with the photograph," Sharda Devi said, and laughed softly at her own sentence.

With her left hand she gently lifted Ira's chin.

In the mirror Ira could see her grandmother's face above her shoulder.

The eyes looked smaller among the wrinkles, but the gaze was steady.

Holding her breath, Sharda Devi drew a line from the inner corner of the right eye outward.

The touch was very light.

Suddenly Ira remembered childhood:

school plays,

wedding ceremonies,

the first time she stepped outside after a fever.

Each time Sharda Devi would place a dot of kohl at the corner of her eye.

Back then Ira believed that her grandmother knew the reason for everything.

Now she knew that her grandmother too had done many things by instinct and guesswork.

"Don't close your eye," Sharda Devi said. "As far as the line travels, keep your gaze steady."

Ira asked:

"Who taught you?"

It was an ordinary question.

Sharda Devi's hand stopped for half a moment.

"My mother. But the first time I put it on properly, I did it on myself."

"When?"

"When I was supposed to leave home for teacher training."

Ira immediately took her eyes away from the mirror.

"You had been selected for teacher training?"

Sharda Devi finished the line on the other eye, closed the box, and said:

"I had been selected. I did not go."

* * *

For a moment, the sound of birds outside became very clear in the room.

Ira wanted to ask many questions at once.

Why didn't you go?

Who stopped you?

When was this?

Why didn't you tell Ma?

But her grandmother's face was not one on which answers should be demanded immediately.

Sharda Devi wiped a line of dust from the mirror with her finger.

"I was nineteen then. Six months of training in Madhubani. There was even a small monthly stipend. The headmistress at school had helped me fill in the application. I had thought that after six months I would teach in the village school, I would have my own earnings, and most of all, there would be a few hours in the day for which I would have to account only to myself."

Ira kept listening.

What surprised her was not that her grandmother had once wanted to become a teacher.

What surprised her was that her grandmother remembered the desire in the language of "my own time."

"Then why didn't you go?"

"There was no single reason." Sharda Devi's voice remained very ordinary. "Nani fell ill. Your younger uncles were both in school. There was little money in the house. Babuji did not like the idea of my staying away. And I..."

She stopped.

"You?"

"I learned to say 'all right' too quickly."

Ira said nothing.

There was no single face to blame in that answer.

There was her father's fear.

Her mother's illness.

The lack of money.

The needs of the household.

And among all of that there was a nineteen-year-old girl who had learned to read the faces around her before she learned to object.

"The day you were supposed to leave for training?" Ira asked.

"Not the day I was supposed to leave. The day I first thought I would go." Sharda Devi smiled. "After submitting the papers, I came home and put kohl on

myself properly for the first time. The line was so thick that my mother looked at me and said, 'Are you going to become a teacher or perform in a dance?' I became angry. Then she herself wet a little cotton and wiped half of it off. She said, 'Let the line remain, but don't let it cover the eye.'"

Ira looked at her eyes in the mirror.

The line Sharda Devi had drawn was very thin.

So thin that from a distance perhaps no one would notice it.

Yet to Ira, her own face seemed a little clearer.

"What happened to the training letter?"

"It stayed in a trunk for a few days. Then under some clothes. Then there was marriage. Then children. Then the trunks changed. I don't know where the paper went."

Something like pity rose suddenly in Ira, and she immediately felt embarrassed by the emotion.

Sharda Devi read her face.

"Don't look at me like that. Life is not only the name of the one road I did not take."

"I wasn't looking at you with pity..."

"I know. But when the new generation hears an old desire, it immediately wants to write a judgment on our behalf." Sharda Devi laughed. "Many things in my life were good too. Saying that does not make the old desire false."

* * *

Neelima appeared again at the door.

"Twenty minutes until the bus."

Then she saw Ira's eyes and said:

"Ma, you really have done it beautifully."

Sharda Devi looked at her daughter with a questioning expression.

"So my hand has finally received recognition?"

"It was recognised long ago. Only you never showed me your certificate," Neelima said.

The moment she saw Ira's face, she understood that the old story had been opened.

"You knew?" Ira asked her mother.

Neelima nodded.

"A little. Ma had told me she had given up some training. I always thought it was because of the household. Not all this detail."

Sharda Devi said:

“Details are not always necessary. Sometimes one generation gives the next only the conclusion:

‘Study.’

‘Keep your own earnings.’

‘Do not be afraid to go away.’

The reason stays inside.”

Neelima sat on the corner of the bed.

“So when Ira was little and you refused to let me leave my job, was this why?”

Sharda Devi did not answer immediately.

“Half the reason. The other half was that I knew your nature. If you had left the job, five years later you would have blamed me.”

All three laughed.

There was no glorification of old sacrifice in the laughter.

Only the knowledge of one another's nature.

* * *

Ira lifted her bag.

When she bent to touch her grandmother's feet, Sharda Devi stopped her.

“Don't become so serious on the first day. Go to school. Learn the children's names. And don't try to change the world in the first week.”

Ira said:

“Keep my eyes straight?”

“When necessary.”

“And when it isn't necessary?”

“Then let your eyes rest.”

Ira went outside.

While crossing the courtyard, she turned once and looked toward her grandmother's window.

Sharda Devi waved.

Neelima was hurrying after Ira with the lunchbox she had forgotten.

The morning of the house suddenly became ordinary again:

the smell of milk coming to a boil,

water falling from the tap,

a low song from the neighbour's radio,

the first cart on the road.

* * *

After Ira had left, Sharda Devi returned to her room.

The brass kohl box lay before the mirror.

She picked it up and opened the lid.

On the black surface was a fresh circular mark from Ira's use.

For many years Sharda Devi had not applied kohl to her own eyes.

At first there had been no time.

Then spectacles.

Then the easy sentence:

"What need is there now?"

At festivals she might still wear a bindi.

But the kohl box was opened mostly for children and grandchildren.

She went very close to the mirror.

Without her spectacles, her face blurred.

Fine lines around her eyes seemed to merge into one another.

She laughed.

There was no point in searching for the face of nineteen.

Even so, she took the thin kohl stick between her fingers.

The first line went crooked.

She reached for cotton.

Then stopped.

She let the crooked line remain.

The line on the other eye came out a little better.

She put her spectacles back on.

The mirror became clear.

Her face had not changed into some earlier version of itself.

No lost young woman had returned.

No unfinished training had been completed.

Only Sharda Devi's present eyes had become a little clearer along their dark edges.

Neelima entered and stopped.

"Ma?"

"What?"

"Nothing." Neelima smiled. "It looks good."

Without taking her eyes from the mirror, Sharda Devi said:

"If it looked good on Ira, why shouldn't it look good on me?"

Instead of answering, Neelima opened the curtain at the window.

The morning sunlight filled the room.
The line of kohl was straight on one eye and slightly crooked on the other.
Sharda Devi made no attempt to even them.
For the first time she felt that every line did not need to be equal.
What mattered was that the line did not cover the eye.

STORY 11

The Dry Kamala

Gopi, if you were here, I would not have to stop so many times to ask directions.

You remembered everything.

Which field came after which ridge, where the footpath turned behind which clump of bamboo, how far the ghat was from which mango tree - everything.

I remember names, not directions.

Now I am standing beside this dry channel and wondering - is this the same Kamala or not?

There is no water.

There is sand.

Grass has sprung up here and there.

At two places children are playing bat and ball.

A goat is licking the wood of an old boat buried in the sand.

You would have laughed if you had seen it.

You would have said, 'Do people play in a river's belly?'

I would have said, 'When the river has left its water behind, people are hardly going to leave the space empty.'

Then you would have said, 'A river does not abandon a place. It only closes its eyes for a few days.'

I remember that sentence of yours.

Much else is blurred.

I have turned seventy-eight, Gopi.

You stopped at fifty-six.

That is why I still feel you are my younger brother.

Time stopped adding years to you; it did not stop adding them to me.

From the railway station to the village, one once had to take a bullock cart.

Now there is a road.

Concrete.

Shops on both sides.

Where we used to say there were paddy fields, there are now three motorcycle-repair shops.

A chemist's shop.

A marriage hall.

A tea-and-milk stall.

The village has the same name, but the face of its entrance has changed.

The first thing I looked for after getting down was the peepal tree.

It was not there.

You used to say, 'When you see the peepal, you will know you are home.'

The peepal has been cut down.

An electric pole stands in its place.

A blue board on the pole says: 'Pipra Panchayat.'

I had to read the name to know that I really had returned.

Otherwise the road recognised nothing for me.

Gopi, I have come this time to see the land.

Yes, the same old five kathas.

On paper, the names of our descendants are still entered against yours and mine.

My son said, 'Babu, go and see it once. Then we will decide whether to sell it or keep it.'

I asked, 'What am I to see?'

He said, 'The boundaries.'

Boundaries!

If you were alive, you would laugh until your stomach hurt.

Look for the boundary of land beside the Kamala from a piece of paper?

Even so, I have come.

The file is in my bag.

There is also a photocopy of the old map.

The paper says: Kamala to the north, Ramcharitra Yadav's field to the south, a mango orchard to the east, and a public footpath to the west.

Three of those four things have disappeared.

I cannot tell whether 'Kamala' means this dry channel or the new channel in the distance.

Ramcharitra Yadav is dead. His son divided the field and built five houses on it.

The mango orchard has been cut down.

The footpath has been absorbed into the road.

The paper is still straight.

The earth has gone crooked.

First I went toward the old ghat.

It is hardly right to call it a ghat now.

Where the ghat stood, there are two brick houses.

Clothes were drying in the courtyard of one of them.

I asked, 'Was there a river here before?'

The woman of the house looked at me in surprise.

She said, 'A very long time ago.'

I laughed when I heard 'a very long time ago.'

What seems like yesterday to me is, for her, a very long time ago.

She must be thirty-five or forty.

The river must have moved away from here before she was born.

I said, 'There was a ghat here. One stone step.'

She said, 'I have heard about it.'

Heard about it.

Gopi, something I saw with my own eyes has now become something another person has only heard about.

What is old age, if not this?

The woman offered me water.

I did not sit down.

I went on.

The sand in the dry channel is hard.

In some places the feet do not sink at all.

Do you remember how, even in Jeth, the middle of the channel used to be soft underfoot?

We would take off our shoes and carry them in our hands while crossing.

You would stop halfway and splash water.

I would scold you - the books will get wet.

You would say - the books can be dried; where will we find Jeth's water again?

It is not Jeth now, but Ashwin.

Even so, there ought to be at least a thin ribbon of water.

There is none.

Far to the east the new channel is glinting.

People say the river has shifted over there.

'Shifted' - as though an old woman had moved her cot and sat in another corner.

I saw how a river shifts.

In the first monsoon the bank was cut.

The next year the current split into two.

In the third year sand filled the old bend.

After that, in no year did the water return.

By then I was no longer in the village.

I was in Darbhanga for my job.

You were here.

You had written in a letter: 'This year the Kamala has turned its face away from our house.'

I did not understand the sentence then.

I thought perhaps the flood had been smaller.

Now I understand.

For a river to turn its face away means the entire geography is written anew.

I do not know where your letter is now.

It was in the large trunk.

When the boys moved house, they may have thrown the trunk away or given it to someone – I have not been able to ask.

I learned the value of papers late.

You were a map without paper.

Look, there is a shami tree here.

I think the old deep pool used to be somewhere near this spot.

The place where we used to catch fish.

You would say, 'This is not a deep pool. It is the Kamala's eye.'

Why did you say that?

You were very fond of inventing names for things.

The people of the village laughed.

So did I.

You never took offence.

You would say, 'Give a thing a name and you remember it.'

You were right.

The pool is gone now, but 'the Kamala's eye' remains in my memory.

The name has survived; the thing has not.

A little farther on I met a boy.

He was pushing a bicycle.

He asked, 'Baba, where are you going?'

I said, 'I am looking for the old Mishra Tola.'

He asked, 'Whose house?'

I told him my name.

He did not recognise it.

I told him your name.

He still did not recognise it.

I felt nothing.

Why should a sixteen-year-old boy recognise the name of someone who died thirty-three years ago?

Then he asked, 'Whose grandson are you?'

I told him Babuji's name.

His face lit up.

'Oh! The old pond-house?'

I was startled.

Pond?

When had our house become the pond-house?

The boy said, 'Where the pond is now, your family's orchard used to be, didn't it?'

Gopi, just understand this.

Where there was an orchard, there is a pond.

Where there was a river, there are houses.

Where there were fields, there is a road.

Which map am I to believe?

The boy began walking with me.

His name was Vishal.

He said his grandfather had known you.

'Gopi Kaka?' he asked.

I stopped.

'You have heard the name?'

'Dada used to say he was a very fast swimmer.'

I laughed.

You really were a fast swimmer.

But I was less pleased by the story of your swimming than by the fact that your name had not vanished entirely.

It had survived in somebody's grandfather's story.

Vishal said, 'He helped many people across during the flood too, didn't he?'

I nodded.

Yes, that year.

Was it eighty-seven or eighty-eight?

I do not trust myself with years any more.

The water had crossed the threshold of the house.

You had tied bamboo together into a raft.

You ferried across three children, two old women, and a calf.

I reached from the city two days later.

By then you had become a hero.

You had said, ‘Not a hero. There simply was no boat.’

I remember that too.

How many sentences remain, while the face itself is growing blurred.

Is that an injustice or not?

Vishal took me toward the new embankment.

He said, ‘Climb up here. You can see the old channel from above.’

I climbed slowly.

My knees hurt.

Vishal pushed the bicycle with one hand and tried to support me with the other.

I said, ‘No. I can walk by myself.’

If you were here, you would say, ‘Even old age has not cured you of pride.’

I would say, ‘It would not cure you either.’

You would laugh.

The wind was strong on the embankment.

From above I saw the dry old Kamala on one side and the glinting new channel far away on the other.

Between them lay fields, houses, a brick kiln, scrub, a pond, a road.

Gopi, a river is not only water.

The old path of a river is also part of the river’s history.

I understand that now.

Vishal said, ‘Baba, look over there. Behind that tin roof - your family’s old land should be there.’

‘Should be?’

‘Dada used to say so.’

Again - a geography heard from someone else.

I opened the map.

The wind nearly carried the paper away.

Vishal somehow held it down.

On the map, the Kamala was a blue line.

Not straight, but fixed.

On the earth, the Kamala was not fixed.

A river does not grow old on paper.

Its course does not change.

Beside it, my five kathas lie equally fixed.

I said to Vishal, 'According to this paper, I am beside the river.'

He looked down at the dry channel.

'It must have been so when the paper was made.'

'Yes.'

'It is not so now.'

'Yes.'

That ought to have ended the matter.

But the mind would not accept it.

I began telling you - see, Gopi, the land stayed and the river went away.

Then I thought to myself - where is the land the same either?

Sand was deposited.

Soil was cut away.

Someone shifted a ridge.

Someone filled a hollow.

Someone built a house.

The name stayed the same; the substance changed.

If you were alive, perhaps you would say, 'The world runs on names.'

Or something else?

I do not want to invent your answer.

It is easy to put one's own wisdom into the mouth of the dead.

I will not say in your name what you never said.

I take care about that now.

I did not before.

How many times after your death did I tell people, 'Gopi used to think this way.'

Did you really think that, or was I speaking on your behalf?

How much was mine?

How much yours?

The dead slowly dissolve into the language of the living.

It is not right, but it happens.

Vishal asked, 'Who are you talking to?'

I was startled.

'My brother.'

'Where is he?'

I looked down toward the old channel.

'He is no longer here.'

Vishal was silent for a moment.
Then he said, 'My Dada is gone too. Sometimes I talk to him.'
That was all.
He said it so simply that I felt no need to explain myself.
The two of us walked farther along the embankment.
Below us, kans grass had grown in one place.
There Vishal said, 'The old cremation ground was on this side.'
I stopped.
'The old one?'
'The new ghat is over there now.'
He pointed east.
Gopi, you were cremated here.
I understood all at once.
The river flowed here then.
I was here, Babuji, your two sons, the whole village.
Smoke above.
Water below.
The cold of Magh.
Your body in the fire.
Even now I remember that I could not cry.
Everyone kept saying - he is the elder brother, he must hold himself together.
I kept looking at the wood.
You were fifty-six.
A fever worsened.
Three days in hospital.
Then it was over.
No river accident.
No heroic death.
An ordinary death.
The man who had saved people in a flood died of a fever.
Life does not choose its ending according to the story.
That day I had released your ashes into the Kamala.
Now that place is dry.
Gopi, the thought struck me in a strange way.
I had always thought - the river carried your ashes away.
Now the river itself is no longer here.

Then did the river carry you too toward its new channel?
A meaningless question.
I know.
Who can know how far ashes travel?
Even so, the mind makes questions.
Vishal asked, 'Shall we sit?'
I said, 'Yes.'
We sat on the grass of the embankment.
There was less smell of earth in the air than of dust.
Someone was burning paddy stubble in the distance.
The smoke slanted away.
It reminded me of the smoke from your pyre.
Then I stopped myself.
Not every smoke is death.
Stubble is stubble.
Does one need old age to learn even this?
Vishal gave me his bottle of water.
I drank.
He asked, 'Will you sell the land?'
'I don't know.'
'Prices are rising here.'
I laughed.
'You know the prices?'
'Everyone does.'
True.
A village boy knows the market price of land; I do not know where my land is.
Time apportions its tasks well.
I opened the file and read out the khata number.
Vishal said I could get a copy of the records at the panchayat office.
My son had told me the same thing.
But before seeing the papers, I had wanted to see the earth.
Without the earth, the papers make no sense.
And the earth does not obey what the papers say.
It was nearing noon.
Vishal had to go home.
He said, 'Shall I drop you at Mishra Tola?'

I said, 'You go. I will come slowly.'
'Do you know the way?'
I laughed.
'No. But today it is necessary for me to lose my way.'
He looked at me, perhaps not understanding the sentence.
'All right, Baba.'
He mounted his bicycle and rode away.
I went down into the old channel again.
I looked at my footprints in the sand.
The wind had already erased half of them.
Gopi, I thought - I will not be foolish enough to look for your footprints.
The earth does not preserve anyone's feet for so many years.
The earth is not a memorial.
It is used - by water, sand, grass, houses, paths.
I began looking for the place where my five kathas might now lie.
I kept the paper's north and south in my head.
An old farmer was in a field.
His name was Jagdish Mahto.
The moment he saw my face he asked, 'Are you Dharnidhar Babu?'
I stared in surprise.
'You recognised me?'
He laughed.
'Not by your face. By the way you walk.'
'By the way I walk?'
'Your Babuji too used to walk with his neck slightly thrust forward like that.'
Babuji came back to me all at once.
His neck forward?
I had never noticed.
Jagdish must be seven or eight years younger than I am.
He knew you well.
'Gopi Babu used to talk a great deal,' he said.
I laughed.
'That is true.'
Jagdish led me to the edge of the field.
'Your family's land used to begin from here.'
'Used to?'

‘The boundary has changed now. After the new survey, it was fixed again.’

He pointed out three houses, a pond, and a small mustard field.

‘All this?’

‘Some of it was sold. Some divided. Some is still under an old dispute.’

I opened the file.

Jagdish raised a hand to stop me.

‘Look at the papers in the panchayat office. You will not find the old boundary here with your eyes.’

I closed the file.

He was right.

Then I asked, ‘When did the Kamala move away from here?’

Jagdish thought for a long time.

‘It is hard to name one year. Slowly.’

That was the answer I needed.

Slowly.

The river did not disappear in one night.

Just as a family does not split in a single day.

Just as a village does not become the edge of a town in one year.

Just as a brother’s voice does not end on the day he dies.

Slowly, things leave their places.

And one day, when you look back, the geography has changed.

Jagdish asked, ‘Why have you come after so many years?’

‘The land.’

He laughed.

‘Land brings people back.’

I said, ‘Or memory?’

He said, ‘Is there a difference?’

I did not answer.

Gopi, Jagdish still asks questions like that.

Did he ask them before too?

You would remember.

I do not.

He took me home for a meal.

Rice, dal, potato curry, curd.

His daughter-in-law asked, ‘Do you live in the city?’

I said, ‘In Patna, with my son.’

'You do not come to the village?'

'Rarely.'

'Rarely' was easy to say.

The truth was that I had not come for ten years.

For the first two or three years after you died, I kept coming.

Then Babuji went.

Ma went.

Half the house collapsed in a flood.

My son got a job.

I retired.

One reason after another.

No single reason was enough; together they made a distance.

After the meal Jagdish said, 'Will you see the old pond?'

I went.

Where our orchard used to be, there truly was a pond.

Green water.

Ducks along the bank.

A little girl playing beside her mother, who was washing clothes.

I asked, 'How did this pond come to be?'

Jagdish said, 'They dug out the soil. Bricks were made from it. Water collected in the pit. Later the panchayat had it deepened.'

I kept looking for the orchard.

There had been four mango trees in it.

One guava.

Once you fell while plucking mangoes.

Your right hand split open.

Ma did not let you climb a tree for seven days.

On the eighth day you climbed again.

Now ducks swim in that place.

Gopi, I felt sorrow.

Then, after a while, I felt something good too.

The land became a pit, the pit a pond, the pond filled with water, and ducks came into the water.

Not every change is a loss.

That is difficult to accept, especially when the loss is one's own.

Jagdish said, 'This pond is used for irrigation now.'

I nodded.
Our orchard has become water for other people.
That sentence came to my mind.
I will not put it into your mouth.
It is my sentence.
Evening began to fall.
I went to the place where our old house had stood.
There is no house.
Half a wall remains.
Moss on the bricks.
The doorframe is gone.
The tulsi altar in the courtyard is gone.
Ma used to tend it.
I touched the wall.
Nothing on it was recognisable.
At one place the limewash was blue.
I remembered – one year you had said we should paint the outer wall blue.
Babuji had refused: 'A house is not a temple.'
You had secretly painted one corner blue.
Was this the same blue?
I do not know.
How many layers of colour can lie beneath moss?
I took my hand away.
Not every mark needs to be turned into evidence.
In the last light of evening, the new Kamala glinted in the distance.
I decided to go there.
My feet were tired, but I went.
To reach the new channel, one must cross the old Kamala.
Across the sand between them, the fields, the road.
A culvert.
An embankment.
Then water.
Here the Kamala was not narrow.
It flowed slowly, dark in colour.
A new ghat stood on the bank.
Two women were washing clothes.

A man was casting a net.

Some children were bathing.

Life had moved with the river.

The old channel dried, but the river did not go alone.

The ghat, the nets, bathing, stories - all of them changed place.

I sat down on the bank.

Gopi, your ashes were not released into this water.

This is new water.

Or is it the same river?

The name is the same.

The water is different.

The path is different.

The question is old.

I put my hand into the water.

Cold.

You would say, 'You recognise a river not with your hand, but with your feet.'

Or am I inventing that sentence?

See, I have started again.

Dead brother, it is not difficult for you to remain silent; what is difficult is for me to let you remain silent.

I took my hand out of the water.

For a while I sat without speaking.

For the first time all day, I said nothing to you.

I watched the water.

That was all.

The sun sank lower.

The sky went from yellow to red, then grey.

A boat crossed the river.

The sound of its small motor travelled a long way.

I remembered the old dinghy, but I did not compare them.

It is not always right to measure a new thing by the measure of the old.

That night I stayed at a relative's house in Mishra Tola.

After I lay down on the cot, sleep took a long time to come.

Dogs barked outside.

Someone was singing far away.

I said to you again, 'Gopi, should I sell the land?'

Naturally, no answer came.

Earlier I would have invented the answer you might have given.

Today I did not.

I thought for myself.

The five kathas have a market value.

My son needs the money.

I am not going to farm.

I have no intention of returning to the village permanently.

Then selling it would not be wrong.

But the boundaries must be clear.

I will not claim as mine and sell what is not mine.

Whatever the river took, whatever changed in the new survey, whatever went in the partition – all of it must be understood.

The decision will not be yours; it will be mine.

Saying that brought a lightness inside me.

It is all right to speak to a dead brother.

It is not all right to make him take decisions for you.

At dawn I went again toward the dry channel.

There was a light mist.

The sand was damp with the night's dew.

Some of yesterday's footprints remained; some had vanished.

I reached the place where Vishal had said the old cremation ground used to be.

The kans grass moved in the breeze.

I had brought no flowers.

No incense.

No water.

I only stood there.

I said to you, 'I will have the land measured. I will act according to whatever turns out to be true.'

That sentence had nothing to do with your death.

Even so, it felt necessary to say it to you.

Perhaps because we had thought through so many decisions together.

That too was one meaning of being brothers.

Then I looked around.

At the place where you were given to the fire, there is grass now.

A house a little distance away.

A child untying a cow.

Two women gathering cow-dung cakes on the dry channel.

The sky clear.

No sacred silence.

Life moving in its ordinary sounds.

I liked that.

Memory does not need a temple every day.

Sometimes grass is enough.

I turned back toward the road.

The dry Kamala receded behind me.

The new channel was not visible ahead, but I knew it was there.

Gopi, until yesterday I thought the Kamala had dried up.

Today I understand - the channel I kept looking at has dried up.

Not the river.

The whole village can fit inside that difference.

The old peepal is gone.

But the village remains.

The house is gone.

But people remain.

The orchard is gone.

But there is a pond.

You are gone.

But your name is in the story told by Vishal's grandfather, in my sentences, in Jagdish's memory.

I stopped as soon as I had said that.

Then I added silently - and in some places, it is not there at all.

It would be wrong to call something preserved where it has not been preserved.

Some things truly do end.

I am forgetting the exact sound of your voice.

It hurts to admit that.

But it would be more wrong to put my own voice in your place.

When I reached the road, I took the file from my bag.

I looked once more at the map.

The blue line of the Kamala still flowed in its old place.

I took out a pencil and changed nothing on the map.

Why should I draw my memory onto a government document?

I wrote only a small note in the margin: ‘Land seen: Ashwin.’

I wrote the date.

That was all.

When it was time to catch the passenger train, the sand of the old channel was shining in the distance.

I said to you one last time, ‘Come, Gopi.’

Then I laughed at myself.

Where would you come from?

I walked on by myself.

I learned this late, brother.

The dead begin some roads with us.

But in the end, it is the living who must lift their feet and walk.

STORY 12

The Scent of Earth

The first rain came to the city at five in the evening.

First the wind.

Then the dust.

Then large, heavy drops.

Sudhanshu was returning from the office.

Traffic stopped.

People ran beneath awnings.

The hot dust of the road released its smell the moment the first water touched it.

With that smell came his mother.

Not all of her.

At first, only her hands.

Hands lifting sacks of wheat spread out in the wet courtyard.

Two glass bangles at her wrist.

One bangle broken.

Was it really broken?

Sudhanshu was not certain.

He stood beneath the awning.

People were sheltering from the rain.

He could not shelter from the smell of wet earth.

His mother had been dead nine years.

He knew this by counting.

Not by memory.

Memory does not keep time in a straight line.

The first fragment was of her hands.

The second was of her voice.

“Bring that sack inside!”

Whom had she been calling?

Sudhanshu?

His sister Shobha?

Babuji?

Perhaps all of them.

At the first rain, his mother would set the whole house running.

Clothes.
Grain.
Cow-dung cakes.
Wood stacked beneath the eaves.
The charpoy in the courtyard.
The lamp beside the tulsi platform.
Bring something in.
Cover something.
Lift something.
Leave something.
For her, rain was a list before it was a fragrance.
Sudhanshu remembered that now.
As a child, he had thought of the first rain only as play.
His mother had not.
A young man beneath the awning said, “Ah, the smell of wet earth!”
Sudhanshu looked at him.
He was smiling.
Perhaps Sudhanshu too had once smiled like that.
His mother would say, “First bring in the sack. Smell the earth afterwards.”
Did he remember that sentence exactly?
Perhaps.
Or was Sudhanshu making it now?
He asked himself.
There was no answer.
The rain grew heavier.
Water ran along the road.
The first smell of earth began to thin.
With it came another fragment.
His mother stood at the threshold.
Watching the rain.
All the work had been brought inside.
Her hands rested on her hips.
Her face was calm.
She drew a deep breath.
Sudhanshu, still a child, asked, “Do you like the smell?”

His mother said, "What is there to like or dislike about a smell? The earth is getting wet."

That answer had annoyed Sudhanshu.

He had wanted her to say: Very much.

Why did his mother never turn everything into poetry?

Now he thought: when had she had time to make poetry?

Then another fragment.

His mother entered the kitchen with mud between her toes.

She said, "Will no one sweep? Will everyone just stand and watch the rain?"

Shobha laughed.

Sudhanshu ran away.

Babuji folded his newspaper.

His mother mopped the floor alone.

That scene was clear.

But had the floor of the house been red earth, or cemented?

Sudhanshu stopped.

Half of the old house had once had an earthen floor; later it had been cemented.

Which year was this?

Memory was joining two different times.

He shifted beneath the awning.

The rain was slanting in.

His clothes were beginning to get wet.

He felt no hurry to reach home.

For a moment he wanted only to wait for the fragments.

His mother was arriving without order.

Once very young.

Once with white hair.

Once irritated.

Once laughing.

Once silent.

Once as she had been the year Sudhanshu left for the city to study.

Was it raining then?

No, that fragment was not of rain.

Yet it came.

The railway station.

His mother putting sattu into his bag.
Saying, “Eat less of the food outside.”
Sudhanshu, irritated: “I’m not a child.”
His mother: “Did I call you a child?”
Then the smile.
Why had the smell of earth opened this scene?
There was no logic to it.
Memory does not obey fragrance.
The first smell only opens a door.
Which room will open beyond it, no one knows.
The rain eased a little.
Sudhanshu began walking.
Water had collected in the unpaved strip beside the road.
A child, sandals in hand, splashed through it.
From a distance his mother scolded, “Don’t run in the first rain!”
Sudhanshu stopped.
With that sentence came a third clear fragment.
His mother too used to say, “Don’t go barefoot in the first rain.”
“Why?”
“The earth is hot. Worms and insects come out.”
“All the children are going.”
“Did all their mothers ask me?”
That sentence was certain.
Sudhanshu laughed.
Here he trusted his memory.
His mother spoke exactly like that.
She did not like comparing her rules with other people’s children.
He reached home.
The staircase of the apartment building was wet.
Inside the lift there was no smell of rain.
Only perfume, metal, and wet shoes.
Sudhanshu got off on the seventh floor.
His wife, Mrinalini, opened the door.
“Completely drenched?”
“A little.”
“Umbrella?”

"At the office."
"Every year the same thing."
Sudhanshu laughed.
Mrinalini handed him a towel.
"Shall I make tea?"
He was about to say yes.
Then he remembered his mother.
Not because of tea.
Because of the kitchen window.
Did his mother make tea on the first rainy day or not?
Probably.
Tea was made every day.
Memory fastens ordinary things onto special days.
He said, "Please do."
He opened the balcony door.
The city below was wet.
Among the concrete stood a few flowerpots.
From their damp soil rose a faint smell of earth.
Not as strong as the first smell outside.
Mrinalini asked from behind him, "What are you looking at?"
"I'm remembering Ma."
She paused.
"Because of the rain?"
"Because of the smell."
"Did your mother like the rain?"
Sudhanshu opened his mouth to answer.
Then closed it.
"I don't know."
Mrinalini looked surprised.
"You remember so much, but not that?"
"Perhaps she liked it. Perhaps she didn't."
"Both?"
"Yes."
Mrinalini set down the tea and left.
She did not press the question.
Sudhanshu was relieved.

He sat in the balcony.
The rain had become thin.
The city lights stretched long in the water.
His mother came again.
This time on a hot afternoon.
No rain.
She was sieving earth in the courtyard.
Why?
To plaster the hearth?
To fill a crack in the wall?
For the tulsi platform?
He did not remember.
His mother rubbed the soil between her palms to test it.
She said, "This earth isn't right. Too much sand."
Sudhanshu asked, "Can earth be good or bad too?"
"Not every soil is right for every task."
That sentence felt certain.
Sudhanshu closed his eyes.
Earth on his mother's palm.
Dust under her nails.
Bangles at her wrist.
The hands from the first fragment again.
Was one bangle really broken?
He thought of telephoning his sister Shobha.
It was half past six.
He called.
Shobha answered.
"So late in the evening?"
"The first rain came."
"It came here yesterday."
"I'm remembering Ma."
There was a brief silence at the other end.
"I remembered her yesterday too."
"What did Ma do in the first rain?"
Shobha laughed.
"What sort of examination is this?"

"I'm only asking."

"First she ran to the roof. Wherever it leaked, she put a bucket underneath."

Sudhanshu started.

"Yes."

"You'd forgotten?"

"No... I remember now."

The leaking roof.

That fragment opened.

The old tiled roof.

Heavy rain.

Four vessels set out inside the house.

A brass bucket.

A metal pot.

A broken tub.

And, in one place, a lota.

His mother saying, "Not the lota. Bring a bigger vessel."

Babuji insisting on climbing onto the roof.

His mother stopping him: "Not now. You'll slip."

Babuji saying, "If not now, when?"

His mother: "When the rain stops."

The two arguing.

Sudhanshu and Shobha laughing.

"Shobha," Sudhanshu said, "did Ma like the first rain?"

"Why wouldn't she?"

"Are you sure?"

"It seems so to me."

"She was always annoyed."

"With the work. Not with the rain."

"Is there a difference?"

"A great one."

Sudhanshu fell silent.

Shobha said, "Do you remember? After all the work was done she would sit at the doorway and breathe in the smell."

"Yes!"

"You used to ask, 'Do you like the smell?'"

Sudhanshu sat up straight.

"You remember that?"

"A little."

"What did she say?"

Shobha thought.

"Perhaps: 'The earth is wet.'"

Sudhanshu laughed.

"That's what I remember too."

For a few moments they were silent.

The same sentence in two separate memories.

Did that prove the sentence true?

Not necessarily.

But it strengthened their trust in it.

Shobha said, "Once Ma cried in the first rain."

Sudhanshu was startled.

"When?"

"After you had gone to the city."

"Why?"

"Don't you remember?"

"No."

"A large branch of the mango tree broke."

Sudhanshu went quiet.

The mango tree.

Behind the house.

Had Babuji planted it?

Or Grandfather?

Shobha said, "A storm at night. Rain in the morning. Half the branch came down. Ma cried when she saw it."

"For the tree?"

"Perhaps."

"Ma cried for a tree?"

"Why shouldn't people cry for trees?"

Sudhanshu felt foolish for asking.

Shobha continued, "She said your swing used to be tied to that branch."

"I don't remember."

"That's why I do."

The sentence did not hurt Sudhanshu.

It relieved him.

What he did not remember, someone else did.

Memory is distributed within a family.

No one person holds the whole house.

"And the bangle?" Sudhanshu asked suddenly.

"What bangle?"

"I remember one broken glass bangle on Ma's wrist. In the first rain, while she was lifting a sack."

Shobha laughed.

"You remember such tiny things!"

"Was it true?"

"I don't know."

"Did Ma wear broken bangles?"

"Who would wear a broken bangle? It would cut the hand."

Sudhanshu fell silent.

"Then I'm wrong?"

"Maybe the bangle wasn't broken. Old glass sometimes has a white line through it."

Sudhanshu saw the first fragment again.

Perhaps the bangle had not been broken.

Had his memory added a mark of damage?

His mother had died, and so the bangle in an old scene had broken too?

The thought made him uneasy.

Memory paints later sorrow onto earlier scenes.

"All right," he said.

Shobha asked, "Are you about to cry?"

"No."

"Your voice sounds like it."

"It's the smell."

"Does smell go into the eyes?"

They both laughed.

The call ended.

The rain had stopped.

Drops clung to the balcony railing.

The smell of earth had almost vanished.

The memory had not.

At dinner that night, his son Aniruddh came in.

He was seventeen.

He asked, "Babu, why are you sitting here in the dark?"

Sudhanshu switched on the light.

"I was watching the rain."

"It's stopped now."

"Yes."

Aniruddh looked at the soil in the flowerpots.

"This plant is drying up again."

From the kitchen Mrinalini said, "If either of you ever watered it, it wouldn't dry up."

Sudhanshu laughed.

His mother came to mind.

Had she complained in exactly the same way?

"Who will water the tulsi?"

Perhaps.

Mrinalini called, "What are you laughing at?"

"Nothing."

Aniruddh asked, "Are you remembering Dadi?"

Sudhanshu was surprised.

"Your mother told you?"

"Yes."

"Ma told him," Mrinalini corrected from the kitchen.

Aniruddh smiled.

"All right. Which thing about Dadi?"

Sudhanshu began searching for an answer.

There were many fragments.

Which one should he choose?

He said, "At the first rain she would run about saving the house."

Aniruddh laughed.

"Saving the house?"

"Clothes, grain, wood, the roof leaking..."

"Oh."

Sudhanshu said, "And afterwards she would sit at the doorway."

"Why?"

"Perhaps for the smell."

Aniruddh said, "Dadi liked the smell of wet earth?"

Sudhanshu answered at once, "The smell of earth."

"Yes, that."

"I don't know."

Aniruddh laughed.

"So much story, and then 'I don't know'?"

"That is the right answer."

Aniruddh looked at him in surprise.

Sudhanshu liked his own answer.

That night he took out the box of old photographs.

His mother in many forms.

At her wedding.

Young.

With the children.

In the courtyard.

In a city hospital during her final year.

He set aside the photograph from her last year.

Today he did not want his sick mother.

Then he felt uneasy with himself.

Why should he choose which version of his mother he wanted?

Illness too had been part of her life.

He put the photograph back among the others.

In one old photograph his mother stood in the courtyard.

Was the earth behind her wet?

The photograph was black and white.

There was no knowing whether it had been taken after rain or on an ordinary day.

Sudhanshu began imagining the smell.

Then he closed the photographs.

A picture cannot give off a smell.

And imagination is not evidence.

The next morning the city was clean.

A few leaves lay on the road.

There was no smell of earth.

Sudhanshu went to the office.

He worked all day.

His mother came now and then without the smell.

One fragment—

His school results were poor.

His mother silent.

Babuji scolding him.

At night his mother saying, "So you failed once. What of it?"

"Why don't you say that to Babuji?"

"He will say what he has to. That is his way. I am saying mine."

This was not a rain-memory.

Still, it came.

Another fragment—

His mother bargaining in the market.

Half an hour over one rupee.

Sudhanshu embarrassed.

Back home, his mother saying, "Do you think money grows by itself for you?"

This too had nothing to do with rain.

A third—

His mother on her sickbed.

She asked, "Is the earth behind the house still the same?"

Sudhanshu had said, "The house has been sold."

His mother replied, "I know. I asked about the earth."

Sudhanshu had not been able to answer.

He had not gone to the village that last year.

With this fragment came guilt.

He wanted the smell of earth to open only tender memories.

Memory did not obey his wish.

At noon in the office he messaged Shobha: "Did Ma ask about the earth behind the house near the end?"

The reply came late.

"Yes. She asked me too."

Sudhanshu kept looking at the screen.

Then the question had not been meant only for him.

The guilt shifted a little.

It did not disappear.

Perhaps his mother had not been asking about the house, but about the state of the soil.

Why?

What was special about that earth?

He called Shobha.

"Why do you think Ma asked?"

Shobha said, "The smell of the first rain was always very strong in the earth behind the house."

"All earth smells in rain."

"Maybe."

"And?"

"Ma used to grow vegetables there."

"I remember now."

"You're remembering everything now."

Shobha laughed.

So did Sudhanshu.

"And after the land was sold?"

"The new owner paved it."

Sudhanshu fell silent.

"All of it?"

"Almost. I saw it the last time I went."

"You went?"

"Yes, two years ago."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"Tell you what? That the courtyard was paved?"

Sudhanshu understood: what was heavy news to him now had been an old fact to Shobha for two years.

Memory does not move at the same pace within a family.

There was no rain on the third day.

The heat returned.

The smell of earth disappeared.

His mother did not.

Sudhanshu now began deliberately noting the fragments.

Then he stopped.

Why?

To make a story?

To preserve his mother?

To prevent his own forgetting?

He opened a notebook.

On the first page he wrote: “The Scent of Earth.”

Then for a long time, nothing.

The title seemed too beautiful to him.

That made him suspicious.

Could his mother’s life fit inside a beautiful title?

He did not tear out the page.

Below it he wrote: “Fragments. No sequence.”

Then, one thing at a time.

“First rain—bring the sacks inside.”

“Leaking roof—buckets.”

“No bare feet in the first rain.”

“Different soil for different work.”

“Mango branch—Shobha’s memory, not mine.”

“Broken bangle? Not certain.”

“Earth behind the house—final question.”

That was all.

He closed the notebook.

He understood that paper would not correct memory.

It would only show the boundary—how much was known, how much was not.

On the fourth day, while returning from the office, he saw a dry earthen flowerpot in the market.

The shopkeeper said, “Plant in the rains; it will take root quickly.”

Sudhanshu bought one.

When he brought it home, Mrinalini asked, “Another plant?”

“Yes.”

“Who saved the last two?”

“This time I’ll water it.”

Aniruddh laughed.

“Dadi’s influence?”

Sudhanshu said, “Perhaps.”

Then at once, “No. For the plant.”

He smiled at his own answer.

It was not right to connect everything to his mother.

A week later, the second rain came.

The smell was not as sharp as the first.
Sudhanshu looked at the dry soil in the balcony pot.
The first drop fell.
The soil darkened.
The smell rose.
He deliberately did not close his eyes.
He kept looking straight ahead.
His mother came.
This time not as one scene.
Fragments.
His mother drying wheat.
His mother searching for her slippers.
His mother sweeping.
His mother on her sickbed, asking about the back of the house.
His mother braiding Shobha's hair.
His mother arguing with Babuji about climbing onto the roof.
His mother bargaining over one rupee in the market.
His mother putting sattu into his bag at the railway station.
His mother sitting silently at the doorway, watching the wet courtyard.
No order.
No single meaning.
This time Sudhanshu did not try to arrange the story.
Whatever fragment the smell brought, he let it come.
Whatever did not come, he did not go searching for it.
The rain grew stronger.
Aniruddh stood at the balcony door.
"Babu, should we bring the plant inside? It'll get too much water."
Sudhanshu started.
"Yes."
Together they moved the pot inside.
Water dripped from the soil onto the floor.
From a distance Mrinalini said, "Put a cloth down first!"
Sudhanshu burst out laughing.
Aniruddh asked, "What?"
"Nothing."
Mrinalini handed them a cloth.

Sudhanshu bent to wipe the water.
His hands were dark with wet soil.
Suddenly the first fragment of his mother's hands again.
The bangle.
The sack.
The mud.
He kept looking at his hands.
Aniruddh said, "Babu?"
"Yes."
"Are you all right?"
"Yes."
Then Sudhanshu said, "I remember a bangle. Perhaps it wasn't broken."
Aniruddh did not understand.
"What?"
"Something old."
He stood up.
Washed his hands.
That night he sent Shobha a photograph of his hand smeared with earth.
Shobha replied: "Like Ma?"
Sudhanshu wrote: "Perhaps just a hand."
Shobha wrote: "Right."
Whether that "right" meant agreement or amusement, he could not tell.
A week later Sudhanshu decided to go to the village.
Mrinalini asked, "Only to see the soil?"
"No."
"Then?"
"I'll meet Shobha. Some of the old people."
"And the soil?"
Sudhanshu laughed.
"I'll see."
The old family house in the village now belonged to another family.
Sudhanshu informed them in advance.
The new owner, Vinod Yadav, said easily, "Come."
Sudhanshu arrived on Saturday morning.
The house stood between recognition and unfamiliarity.
The main wall was now brick and cement.

The old doorway had been widened.

The courtyard was paved.

The strip at the back was covered with stone slabs.

Only one corner of earth remained, where two banana plants and a lemon tree grew.

Sudhanshu stood still.

Vinod asked, "Vegetables used to grow here?"

"Yes."

"When I came, half of it was still bare. Later I paved it."

"You did right."

Vinod looked at him, perhaps expecting the old owner to show pain.

Sudhanshu truly was saddened.

But he had no right to say, "You did wrong."

The house was Vinod's now.

Vinod said, "I left this corner unpaved because my wife wanted plants."

Sudhanshu did not touch the lemon tree.

The soil was dry.

The sky was clear.

The first rain had already passed.

He did not bend down to smell the earth.

He laughed at himself.

Without the smell, earth was simply earth.

Vinod's wife brought water.

"I saw your mother once," she said.

Sudhanshu was startled.

"When?"

"I was a child. At the haat."

"What do you remember?"

She laughed.

"What could I remember from so long ago? She spoke very loudly."

Sudhanshu laughed aloud.

His mother did speak loudly.

This was not a memory brought by smell.

A small fragment belonging to someone else.

She said, "My mother used to say your mother saved a lot of vegetable seeds."

Sudhanshu remembered none of this.

"Which seeds?"

"Bottle gourd, ridge gourd... I don't know."

In his mind he wrote: "Seeds—someone else's memory."

He did not take out the notebook.

In the remaining patch of old earth behind the house, Vinod's grandson was playing.

He was running a toy car through the soil.

Sudhanshu felt the urge to look for his own childhood there.

He stopped himself.

The child's play belonged to the child.

There was no need to lay an old scene over it.

Shobha arrived in the afternoon.

The two sat outside the old house in the shade of a neem tree.

The neem was new.

The old neem had been cut down long ago.

Sudhanshu said, "Do you see Ma here?"

Shobha said, "Sometimes."

"Where?"

"Nowhere in particular. Suddenly."

"From a smell?"

"Not always."

"Yesterday I remembered her while heating oil."

"What oil?"

"Mustard. She used to put it in our hair, remember?"

For a moment Sudhanshu almost smelled it.

Can suggestion manufacture a smell inside memory?

He laughed.

Shobha asked, "What?"

"Nothing."

They kept talking about the old house.

On one point they agreed.

On another they did not.

Did their mother bring the stove inside on rainy days?

Shobha: yes.

Sudhanshu: the stove was fixed.

Then they remembered there had been two stoves.

One fixed, one portable.

Did their mother make pua in the first rain?

Shobha said, "Sometimes."

Sudhanshu did not remember.

Did their mother ever step outside to be drenched in the first rain?

Sudhanshu said, "No."

Shobha said, "Once she did."

"When?"

"Babuji had gone to town. It rained after a very hot spell. She stood in the courtyard for two minutes."

"You saw her?"

"Yes."

"Where was I?"

"Probably at college."

Sudhanshu fell silent.

There was a mother in Shobha's memory standing in the rain, and not in Sudhanshu's.

Were they two different mothers?

No.

Different moments of one life.

Clouds gathered over the village that evening.

Shobha said, "It'll rain again."

Sudhanshu laughed.

"Another examination for the smell?"

"You're still asking questions."

The first drop struck the neem leaves.

Then the earth.

The small surviving corner behind Vinod's house grew wet.

The smell rose.

Different from the city balcony?

Sudhanshu drew a deep breath.

He wanted to compare them.

Then stopped.

Measuring fragrance could not prove the past.

Shobha asked, "Remember anything?"

"A lot."

"What?"

Sudhanshu thought.

The first fragment?

The sack?

The bangle?

The roof?

The mango branch?

The final question?

He said, "I didn't remember Ma only once."

Shobha smiled.

"What sort of answer is that?"

"The right one."

The rain grew heavier.

Vinod's wife called from inside, "You'll get soaked!"

Shobha got up.

Sudhanshu remained standing for two more moments.

The smell of earth was strong.

His mother came—

but this time Sudhanshu did not want to hold on to her.

Not a complete story.

Not a complete face.

Not a complete voice.

Fragments were enough.

He went inside.

That night, in the village guest room, he opened the notebook.

The first page: "The Scent of Earth."

Below it: "Fragments. No sequence."

He added a few new things.

"Seeds—Vinod's wife; not my memory."

"Ma stood in the rain for two minutes—Shobha's memory."

"Earth behind the house almost entirely paved; one corner remains."

Then he wrote: "Did Ma like the rain?"

After a long time, the answer: "Not in one word."

He stopped there.

Closed the notebook.

In the morning, when he left for the city, the earth was still wet.

The smell was faint.
Sudhanshu looked back once from the doorway.
The day before, he had thought of taking a handful of soil with him.
Now he did not.
Taking the earth away would not preserve its smell.
And memory did not need to be turned into an object.
He left empty-handed.
On the way Shobha said, "Will you come again next year?"
"If I feel like it."
"For Ma?"
Sudhanshu said, "For myself. Ma turns up everywhere."
Shobha laughed.
"Well said."
When he reached the city, Aniruddh asked, "Did you bring any soil?"
"No."
"Why?"
"Whose soil?"
Aniruddh did not understand.
Sudhanshu laughed.
"Never mind."
Mrinalini asked, "How was the village?"
"Changed."
"The house?"
"Someone else's house."
"The smell of the earth?"
Sudhanshu thought for a moment.
"It was there."
"Like your mother's?"
He laughed.
"Ma wasn't a smell."
Mrinalini said nothing.
Sudhanshu went to the balcony.
The potted plant was doing well now.
The soil was faintly damp.
He touched it with a finger.
There was almost no smell.

His mother came to mind again.
Without rain.
This time she was laughing.
At what?
He did not remember.
Sudhanshu did not try to complete the memory.
Let the laughter remain.
Without its cause.
That was enough.
A few weeks later the rains became regular.
The sharpness of the first smell was gone.
The city earth was wet every day.
Sudhanshu did not remember his mother every day.
At first this had felt like guilt.
Now it did not.
Memory is not a duty.
The first rain had opened a door.
The door did not need to remain open every day.
Sometimes a hand.
Sometimes a voice.
Sometimes a broken bangle that might never have been broken.
Sometimes his sister's different memory.
Sometimes only an empty space.
His mother was not complete within these fragments.
But neither was she absent.
One evening Sudhanshu opened the notebook again.
He wrote one last line:
"Do not write as remembered what is not remembered."
Then he closed the notebook.
Outside, it was raining.
There was no smell of earth, because the ground was already wet.
Sudhanshu sat in the balcony.
He remembered his mother.
This time, for no reason at all.
He smiled.
Perhaps memory had finally become independent of fragrance.

STORY 13

The Sisters

Mridula and Neera met for the third time on the veranda of a school.

Both had grown old.

A mat was spread across the veranda. Eight or ten adolescent girls sat in a circle. In the middle lay cotton cloth, coloured thread, needles, scissors, and round wooden embroidery hoops.

The school was holding a three-day folk-craft workshop.

Neera had been invited as an old member of the village women's group. Mridula as a former art teacher.

The organiser perhaps did not know that the two were sisters.

Even after seeing each other's names on the list, neither had mentioned the fact.

"Make the border first," Neera told the girls. "The flower in the middle can come later."

Mridula immediately said, "It is not necessary to make the border first."

Neera looked at her.

"When did I say it was necessary? It is easier to learn that way."

Mridula picked up a piece of cloth.

"If you understand the central form first, the border will come into proportion by itself."

The girls began looking from one face to the other.

One girl laughed and asked, "Whose advice should we follow?"

Neera said, "Whichever one leaves you with less ruined cloth."

Mridula said, "If you are afraid of ruining something, you will never make anything new."

The two were silent for a moment.

Then Neera smiled.

"See? Even after forty years, she still jumps straight into the middle first."

Mridula laughed too.

"And she is still measuring the border."

To the girls, it sounded like an old joke.

In fact, it was the surviving tone of a very old quarrel.

Their first encounter of this kind had been when both had, for the first time, become women of separate households.

Mridula had been married for two years.

Neera was twenty then and still living in her parental home.

In the month of Sawan, Mridula had come to her parents' house for four days.

Their mother was drying mango leaves in the courtyard.

Neera was in the back room embroidering a vine pattern on cloth with needle and thread.

Mridula went inside and stopped the moment she saw the hoop.

Along the edge of the cloth was a small eye-like shape between two leaves. Then two leaves. Then an eye. Then two leaves.

Mridula took the cloth in her hand.

"Where did you get this from?"

Neera did not raise her head.

"What?"

"This vine."

"A vine is a vine."

"I made this."

Neera pushed the needle into the cloth.

"Yours?"

"Yes. It was in my notebook."

"There were many things in your notebook."

"This was exactly like this."

Only then did Neera raise her head.

"Not exactly like this."

"Two leaves, an eye in between."

"Nani's pillowcase also had two leaves."

"It did not have the eye."

"I made the eye."

Mridula laughed.

"You saw my notebook, then made it, and now you say the eye is yours."

Neera stood up.

"I saw your notebook, yes. But the vine is not yours."

"Then whose is it?"

"Whoever makes it, theirs."

That answer had stung Mridula.

Two years earlier, Mridula had spent hours sitting by the window of that very house making vines and floral motifs. On paper, on the empty margins of old newspapers, on the back pages of books.

Neera used to follow her around then.

"Teach me too."

"First learn to draw a straight line."

"I want flowers."

"Without the line, the flower will come out crooked."

"Let it be crooked."

Mridula used to get irritated.

Now, looking at Neera's cloth, she felt that her younger sister had taken something of hers.

Not only the vine.

Also that earlier time, when both had lived in the same house and no one needed to call anything separately their own.

Neera began gathering up the cloth.

Mridula asked, "Who are you making it for?"

"For the market."

"To sell?"

"Yes."

"My vine?"

"Do not start again."

Neera said that three women in the village were making cloth bags, pillowcases, and tablecloths together. A trader would take them at the market. If they got a good price the first time, they would make more.

The word price made it worse for Mridula.

Seeing a form she had made in someone else's hands was one thing.

Money being earned from that form was another.

"Did you tell them my name?"

Neera was startled.

"Whom?"

"The trader."

"Why would I tell him your name?"

"Because I made the vine."

Neera's face flushed.

"So because you married and left, everything in this house must still carry your name?"

Mridula let go of the cloth.

"How did the house come into this?"

"You brought it in."

"I am only talking about my vine."

"The vine was made in this house."

"I made it."

"And I changed it."

"A little."

"As much as it needed."

Their mother called from the courtyard, "What are you two fighting about again?"

Both answered together, "Nothing."

The four-day visit ended in three.

Mridula returned to her marital home a day early.

When she left, Neera was not on the veranda.

Mridula did not look for her either.

To Mridula, the meaning of that first encounter was clear: Neera had appropriated her design.

To Neera, the meaning was different: even after leaving the house, Mridula was unwilling to give up her claim over things that belonged to the house.

Their stories took different directions.

Neera's vine began selling at the market.

The group of three women became seven.

Seven became twelve.

The colours of the cloth changed.

The leaves became thick or thin.

The eye in the middle was sometimes round, sometimes long.

Someone began calling it "Neera's vine."

Neera did not stop the name.

Mridula kept hearing the news in fragments.

Sometimes their mother would say, "Neera's group's cloth now goes as far as Madhubani."

Sometimes a relative would say, "Your sister's vine is doing very well."

Mridula would reply, "That vine was in my notebook first."

People would laugh.

"These things happen between sisters."

She did not like that laughter.

She felt people did not understand what the matter meant.

But as the years passed, she herself also became less certain of what its real meaning was.

She became an art teacher.

At school she taught children line, form, colour, proportion.

Sometimes, if a small eye appeared between two leaves, her hand would stop.

Then she would erase it.

Neera continued working with her group.

She married.

She had two children.

She moved back and forth between her marital home and her parental home.

The vine kept moving too.

The two sisters met at weddings and deaths.

They exchanged news of each other's children.

They spoke on the phone too.

But not about the vine.

Twenty years later, their second encounter took place at a district craft exhibition.

Paintings by children from Mridula's school were displayed there.

So were textiles made by Neera's group.

Mridula went into one corner and stopped short.

A large piece of cloth hung on the wall.

Two leaves.

An eye in between.

Two leaves.

An eye in between.

On a small label below was written: "Neera-Leaf Vine: a recognised design of the local women's group."

The heat of twenty years earlier returned inside Mridula.

Neera was at the back speaking with a customer.

Pointing to the label, Mridula asked, "So now it has acquired a name too?"

Neera saw the customer off and came over to her.

"I did not name it."

"But you did not have it removed either."

"How many people was I supposed to chase after to have it removed?"

"You could have said something once, at the beginning."

"To whom?"

"Whoever wrote it first."

In a tired voice Neera said, "No one wrote it first. At the market people started saying, 'Give me the leaf one by Neera.' Then the trader wrote it on the bill. Then the women in the group began saying it. That is how the name travelled."

Mridula said, "Very convenient."

Neera looked at her face.

"You are still stuck on the same thing?"

"Where has the thing changed?"

"Twenty years have changed."

"That makes the matter old, not wrong."

Neera was silent for a while.

Then she said, "Come."

"Where?"

"I will show you something."

In a small room behind the exhibition, bundles of the group's materials were kept.

Neera opened one bundle.

Inside was an old, yellowed pillowcase.

The cloth had worn thin in several places.

Along the edge ran a vine of two leaves stitched in faded thread.

Between the two leaves was a round dot.

Not an eye.

But something like the beginning of an eye.

Mridula took the cloth in her hands.

"Was this Nani's?"

"Yes."

"Where did you get it?"

"Ma gave it to me."

For a long time Mridula kept looking at the vine.

Neera said, "What was in your notebook was different from this. The leaves were thinner. You lengthened the round dot in the middle and made it into an eye. You alternated the colours."

Mridula raised her head.

Neera continued, "I took your eye. The leaves were Nani's. I changed the border in my own way. The flowers from the group were added later."

Mridula asked, "Then why did you not tell me earlier?"

Neera laughed.

"I did tell you earlier. You wanted to hear that the entire vine was yours."

Mridula wanted to object.

But the old room came back to her.

"Two leaves, an eye in between."

"I made this."

"Nani's pillowcase also had two leaves."

Neera really had said that.

Mridula had heard her.

She had not accepted it.

"You also said, whoever makes it owns it," Mridula said.

"Yes."

"That is not entirely right either."

"I understand that now."

Neera folded the pillowcase again.

"There are twelve women in the group now. The same vine becomes twelve different things in twelve pairs of hands. Whose should we call it?"

Mridula said, "The one who made the first form?"

"Then Nani?"

"Nani too must have seen it somewhere."

Both fell silent.

For the first time, in that silence, the ground beneath the quarrel shifted a little.

But not entirely.

Mridula looked again towards the label.

"Even so, I do not like 'Neera-Leaf'."

Neera said, "Neither do I."

"Then change it."

"Next time I will tell the organiser."

"What will they write?"

Neera thought.

"'Two-Leaf Vine'?"

Mridula said, "Too ordinary."

"Is being ordinary bad?"

"A name should have identity."

Neera burst out laughing.

"See? You were the one asking to remove the name, and now you want identity in the name."

Mridula laughed too.

The second encounter did not end with that laughter.

They sat down to drink tea - Neera with little sugar, Mridula with none.

Twenty years of things did not open all at once.

Some came out.

Some remained.

Mridula acknowledged that the version with the eye had been in her notebook.

Neera acknowledged that she had learned a great deal from Mridula's alternating colours.

Mridula asked, "You earned money from it. Did it never occur to you to give me a share?"

Neera laughed.

"Are we getting stuck there again?"

"It is a question."

"For the first five years, half the money went into thread. The rest was divided among the group. How much should I have given you?"

Mridula laughed too.

"One rupee per leaf?"

"Extra for the eye."

After a very long time, the two laughed until their stomachs hurt.

Then Mridula grew serious.

"I did not want the money."

"I know."

"The name?"

"Perhaps."

"Not perhaps."

Neera nodded.

"All right. The name."

That one word became the centre of the second encounter for Mridula.

For the first time she felt that Neera was not making her hurt seem small.

At the same moment, her own first accusation also began to seem smaller: "The entire vine is mine."

Time does not erase a quarrel.

Sometimes it measures it correctly.

After the exhibition, the sisters' relationship changed, but not like a miracle.

They spoke on the phone more often.

Sometimes about cloth.

Sometimes about school.

Sometimes about the children.

Sometimes only, "Where are you?"

Neera would sometimes send a photograph of a new design.
Mridula would say, "The border is too heavy."
Neera would reply, "Your old illness."
Mridula would sometimes show a child's drawing.
Neera would say, "Leave the middle empty."
Mridula would reply, "Your old illness."
It became a joke.
But beneath the joke lay history.
Then another twenty years passed.
Today, at the school workshop, this was their third encounter.
The girls kept practising.
One girl, Aarushi, made two leaves.
In place of the eye in the middle, she made a small triangle.
The moment Neera saw it, she asked, "What is this?"
Aarushi became nervous.
"Did I do it wrong?"
Mridula quickly said, "No."
Neera pulled the cloth closer.
"Not wrong. I asked, what is this?"
"I made it from my own mind."
"Why?"
"Everyone was making the eye. I liked the triangle."
Mridula looked at Neera.
Neera smiled.
"All right. Now you will have to make this triangle the same size everywhere."
Mridula said, "Not necessary."
"Starting again?"
"If some are large and some small, it will look like movement."
Aarushi laughed.
"Whose advice should I follow now?"
This time both sisters answered together, "Your own."
The girls burst out laughing.
In the afternoon, a teacher came with a printed sheet.
There was to be a small exhibition on the final day of the workshop.
Every item had to be given a name.
The teacher asked, "What should we write as the name of this vine?"

Neera said casually, "Two-Leaf Vine."

Mridula said, "There is a triangle in the middle."

Aarushi said excitedly, "Then a new name!"

Neera looked at her.

"You name it."

Aarushi thought for a long time.

"Three-Corner Leaf?"

Mridula wrinkled her nose.

"Naming is difficult work."

Neera said, "That is why people fight over names."

Mridula looked at her.

It was hard to tell whether the sentence was a joke or a comment.

The teacher asked, "Shall I write both your names with the old vine?"

Both sisters were silent.

"'Mridula-Neera Vine'?"

Neera spoke first. "No."

Mridula too said, "No."

The teacher was surprised.

Mridula said, "I changed one part."

Neera said, "I changed another."

Mridula added, "The vine existed even before that."

Neera said, "And after that, twelve pairs of hands changed it."

Aarushi said from between them, "Now thirteen."

Neera patted her head.

"Yes, now thirteen."

The teacher asked, "Then the name?"

Mridula said, "Write: 'Two-Leaf Vine: the village's evolving form.'"

Neera thought for a moment.

"'Evolving' is good."

Mridula asked, "Why?"

"Because it did not stop."

The two looked at each other.

Forty years earlier, Mridula had wanted the vine to stop inside a notebook with her name written beneath it.

Neera had wanted the vine to belong to whoever held the cloth in their hands.

Twenty years later, both had understood that each position was half right.

Today they could see that the vine had already gone beyond both of them.

That understanding did not make the old quarrel ridiculous.

Mridula still believed that Neera should first have acknowledged her name.

Neera still believed that Mridula had claimed more of the whole design than she should have.

Neither had entirely abandoned her own position.

The relationship changed; the positions did not disappear.

As the workshop ended, Aarushi showed them her cloth.

Two leaves.

A triangle in between.

Then two leaves.

Then a small circle.

Then two leaves.

"Why not the same symbol each time?" Neera asked.

Aarushi said, "I changed my mind."

Mridula laughed.

"This vine will last."

Neera asked, "Without rules?"

"By changing the rules as it goes."

Neera took the cloth in her hands.

"The border is still crooked."

Mridula said, "Let it be crooked."

Neera looked at her.

Forty years earlier, that sentence had been Neera's.

Mridula remembered.

So did Neera.

Both laughed.

Evening was falling as they came out of the school.

At the gate their roads separated.

Mridula would take a vehicle towards the town.

Neera would go towards the village.

After their first encounter, Mridula had left a day early.

After the second, they had taken separate buses.

Today too they were to go in separate directions.

Neera took a small piece of cloth from her bag.

An unfinished vine was stitched on it.

"This is for you."

Mridula took it.

Two leaves had been made.

The middle was empty.

"Where is the eye?"

"You make it."

Mridula laughed.

"Then you will say again that I took your vine."

"This time there are plenty of witnesses."

"Shall I make a triangle?"

"Your cloth."

Mridula put the piece into her bag.

"Not yours?"

Neera asked.

Mridula stopped.

Then she said, "It is in my hands. For now, it is mine."

Neera smiled.

"We will ask again after twenty years."

Mridula said, "Do not wait that long."

"Then we will meet sooner."

The two walked away in different directions.

After going some distance, Mridula turned back.

Neera had turned back at the same moment.

Neither raised a hand.

There was no need.

Each simply saw that the other was still on the road.

That night, when Mridula reached home, she took the piece of cloth out of her bag.

She placed the hoop on the table.

She threaded the needle with dark green thread.

Between the two leaves she did not make an eye.

Nor a triangle.

She made a small crooked line, half like a leaf and half something else.

Looking at that line, Mridula remembered Nani's pillowcase.

Neera's market cloth.

The label at the district exhibition.

Aarushi's triangle.

And her own old notebook.

No single person's memory contained the whole design.

Perhaps the relationship between sisters was like that too.

One sister kept saying: I made this line.

The other kept saying: it was already there.

After forty years, both understood that the line had existed before them and would remain after them, but in between, both their hands had changed its direction.

Mridula pushed the needle into the cloth.

She did not fill the empty middle completely.

She left some spaces empty.

This time she was in no hurry to give it a name.

STORY 14

House Number Five

In the monsoon of 1997, Sarita Sah looked closely for the first time at the north wall of House Number Five.

There was a strange window in the wall - its lower half filled in with brick, above it an old sakhua-wood frame, and inside that an iron grille.

When she had been shown the house, the broker had called it "a passage for air."

At the time Sarita had thought only that little afternoon sunlight came through it.

Three months after buying the house, she discovered another use for the window.

Sarita ground spices at home and packed them into small packets.

At first, orders came from five neighbouring houses.

Later, two small shops in the market also began taking packets of turmeric, coriander, and cumin.

When customers came through the main door, there was constant movement through the sitting room, courtyard, and kitchen.

Sarita's mother-in-law grew irritated.

The children's studies were disturbed.

Sarita herself wiped her hands and ran to the door twenty times a day.

One afternoon she stood beside the grille in the north wall.

From outside, the lane behind the market could be seen directly.

She put her palm on the bricks below the grille and measured the height.

Almost level with her waist.

Sarita called a mason.

A few of the upper bricks in the filled-in lower portion were removed, and stone slabs were fitted on both the inner and outer sides.

The grille remained above.

The window had now become a small counter for transactions.

Customers came from the lane and collected their packets.

Sarita wrote down the accounts from inside.

No one needed to enter the house.

Her younger daughter called it "Ma's shop-door."

Laughing, Sarita corrected her: "Not a door, a window."

Pointing to the old frame, the daughter would say, "It must once have been a door."

Sarita would reply, "Maybe. How would I know?"

At that time she truly did not know that it had once been a full doorway.

Nor did she know which woman had made that doorway, or why.

Go back twenty-nine years.

In 1968, this house had not yet been assigned a municipal number.

People called it the red-tiled house behind the pond.

On the deed, the owner's name was Devaki Devi.

Devaki's mother had provided half the money for buying the house.

Devaki had said plainly that if money from her parental home was being used, the house would remain in her name.

A subdued argument over this continued for three days in her marital home.

On the fourth day, the deed writer read the document aloud.

Hearing her own name, Devaki said only, "All right."

After that day she never discussed the deed.

But her tone changed when decisions about repairing the house had to be made.

Instead of saying, "Ask first," she began saying, "This is what will be done here."

Three days a week, Devaki taught needlework to four adolescent girls.

The girls entered through the front sitting room.

If the men of the family were sitting there, the girls adjusted their veils, lowered their eyes, and hurried through to the courtyard.

Devaki did not like this arrangement.

One day she looked towards the narrow lane on the north side.

On the other side of the wall was exactly the corner of the courtyard where the girls sat.

Devaki said, "There will be a door here."

Her husband asked, "There is already a main door, isn't there?"

Devaki replied, "Not every door is the main door for everyone."

The following week the wall was cut open.

A sakhua-wood frame was fitted.

A small threshold lay between the earth of the lane and the bricks of the courtyard.

On the first day the girls entered through it, none of them had to cross the sitting room.

Laughing, they came straight to Devaki.

Devaki's classes did not continue for very many years.

Two of the girls were married.

One moved away with her family.

The fourth enrolled in teacher training.

Devaki's eyesight too began to weaken.

But the northern door remained.

The milkman came through it, the children went to school through it, the vegetable seller called from there.

Sometimes in the evening Devaki sat on the threshold and enjoyed the air.

She never imagined that the next woman who owned the house would have that door closed.

2010.

The stone ledge of the northern window was now free of the smell of spices.

Sarita's work had ended long before.

The house had been sold for the fourth time and was now in Neelima Karn's name.

Neelima taught economics at a college.

Her mother came to live with her and, because of her knees, could not walk much.

In the very first week, her mother placed a chair beside the northern window.

The stone ledge stood at exactly the right height for her elbow.

She kept her cup of tea there.

In the evening, when neighbourhood women passed through the lane, they would stop for two minutes and talk.

The vegetable seller put her bag on the ledge while settling the account.

Children returning from school peered inside, called "Nani," and waved.

At first Neelima paid no attention to any of this.

To her, the window was merely an odd feature of an old house.

Once, while having the house painted, Neelima said, "Shall we fill in this window?"

Her mother objected at once.

"No."

"Why? Hardly any sunlight comes through here."

Her mother said, "Sunlight can come from another direction. People come from this one."

Neelima laughed.

"Are you keeping watch?"

"No. I listen to the news of the road."

Two years later, her mother's mobility decreased further.

The northern window became a small edge of the outside world for her.

She did not know anyone's whole life.

But by their voices she began to recognise the milkman, the vegetable seller, the postman, and the schoolchildren.

It was then that Neelima understood that all the uses of a house cannot be written into its plan.

What the mason called "the old window" was, for her mother, evening companionship.

After her mother's death, Neelima did not place a chair there for several months.

The stone ledge remained empty.

One day she put a stack of books there, then removed it.

It seemed to her that if she put objects there, they would cover her mother's place, and if she left it empty, the house itself would turn into a memorial.

In the end she decided nothing.

Life moved forward through use.

Sometimes keys lay there, sometimes a bag of vegetables, sometimes an umbrella wet from the rain.

Her mother's memory remained among these small uses, without a plaque, without a name.

Neelima did not know that spices had once been sold from that ledge.

Nor did she know about Devaki's doorway.

Now, 1984.

Devaki had already left the house.

When the new owner, Chandrakala Jha, came to see it, she opened the northern door and looked into the lane.

The lane that had been quiet in Devaki's time was now full of handcarts, bicycles, and traffic moving behind the market.

Chandrakala had two adolescent daughters.

At night, unfamiliar voices came from the lane.

The old wooden latch was loose.

Within a week of buying the house, Chandrakala said indoors, "I will have this door closed."

Her husband argued that a new lock could be fitted.

Chandrakala said, "Why keep the fear of something that has no use?"

A mason was called.

Removing the entire frame was difficult.

The sakhua wood above was still strong; taking it out would damage too much of the wall.

So the lower part of the doorway was bricked up.

A space about two cubits high was left above, and an iron grille was fitted there.

The doorway became a ventilator.

Afternoon air came through that grille.

Chandrakala's elder daughter, Meenu, placed her study table against that wall.

When the electricity failed in summer, she picked up her books and sat beneath the grille.

The younger daughter would laugh and say, "Ma closed the door, but opened half of it again for the air."

Chandrakala would say, "I have no quarrel with the air."

Both daughters later went away to study.

Chandrakala never learned why the old frame had originally been put there.

For her, the doorway was a question of security.

For Devaki, it had been a route of independent movement.

The two women never saw one another.

Their decisions were opposite.

Yet between those opposite decisions, the grille remained – and thirteen years later, beneath that same grille, Sarita made her little transaction counter.

Sarita did not know Chandrakala's name.

History did not move through this house carrying an identity card.

2026.

Anamika Mishra became the fifth owner of the house.

On the day of registration, her attention was not on the list of former owners but on the loan instalments and the handing over of the keys.

She was going to live in the house with her elderly father.

Her father needed a walking stick, but while seated he greatly enjoyed listening to sounds from outside.

On the first evening, Anamika noticed the old stone ledge beside the northern window.

The slab was chipped at one edge.

The grille carried three layers of paint.

She told the mason, "Replace the slab and repair the grille."

The mason asked, "Shall I make the whole window new?"

Anamika said, "Only as much as necessary."

She had no curiosity about the old form of the place.

She merely wanted her father to be able to sit there safely, with somewhere to rest his elbow.

A new stone slab was fitted, but the old sakhua-wood frame above was not removed.

The mason said, "This is still strong."

Anamika replied, "Then let it remain."

There was no feeling in this small decision of preserving a heritage.

The old wood was simply useful.

A few days later her father began placing a chair beside the window and sitting there.

When the vegetable seller called out, Anamika answered from the kitchen, but her father would first raise a hand in acknowledgement.

Schoolchildren passed through the lane.

Sometimes someone's ball came and struck the grille.

Her father pushed it back outside with his walking stick.

One day Anamika laughed and said, "This has become your guard post."

Her father said, "Not a guard post – a place for air and talk."

Anamika liked the phrase.

She did not know that about sixteen years earlier Neelima's mother had sat there listening to the news of the road.

Nor did she know that Sarita's customers had bought spices at that ledge.

Chandrakala's daughter had studied beside that grille.

And earliest of all, when it was still a full doorway, four adolescent girls had entered through it for Devaki's needlework lessons.

For Anamika, none of these was a story.

To her, the window was simply a useful part of the house that had already been there.

That year the municipality conducted a new survey.

The old blue number plate was removed.

On a white plate, in black numerals, it was written again – House Number 5.

The worker asked, "Is the plate all right here?"

Anamika said, "Yes."

That was all.

No former owner's name was written on the wall.

Not Devaki's, not Chandrakala's, not Sarita's, not Neelima's.

A few days later two adolescent girls came through the lane looking for someone's house.

One said to the other, "Turn left after House Number Five."

Anamika heard them from inside.

Her father was sitting beside the window.

Air was coming in through the grille.

The girls walked on without stopping.

The same house had been different things for different people at different times.

For Devaki, a doorway.

For Chandrakala, a boundary to be closed.

For Sarita, a work counter.

For Neelima's mother, companionship with the street.

For Anamika's father, a place for air and talk.

None of these five uses was the "real" one.

Nor was one decision a preparation for the next.

Each woman had acted according to the needs of her own time.

The connections were formed later - without acquaintance, without memorial, without any knowledge that one person's old decision might someday become useful in another woman's daily life.

Evening fell.

Anamika closed the main door.

She left the northern window open.

Her father said, "The air is good."

Anamika said, "Yes," and went inside.

Outside, the number five on the white plate slowly disappeared into the dark.

The house remained where it was - one number, changing uses, and a subtle connection among the unknown decisions of five women, a connection none of them ever fully knew.

STORY 15

The Music Teacher

That day, on the third floor of the Women's Skills Centre, the final practical examination for the electrical-repair course was being held.

Nalini Jha had been in the building since half past eight that morning.

She was the head of the centre, but on examination days her work mostly consisted of checking papers, obtaining the inspectors' signatures, and finding solutions whenever some arrangement stalled.

By ten o'clock, the first two groups had entered the examination room.

The practice boards were fixed to the wall at the same height.

The wires, connectors, switches, test lamps, and tools had all been counted beforehand.

Outside in the corridor, the women trainees waited for their turns.

Nalini first noticed a problem when Shabnam Khatoon, in the third group, stood before her practice board.

Shabnam was short.

She could raise her hand above her head, but she could not comfortably reach the upper connection on the board.

She rose onto her toes and began the task.

Twice, a tool slipped from her hand.

The external examiner, Arun Babu, looked at the clock.

“The time is running,” he said.

Shabnam nodded and rose onto her toes again.

Nalini stood near the door.

At first, it seemed to her merely an inconvenience.

Then the trainer, Rita, came up to her and said softly, “Nalini ji, shall we put a wooden platform underneath?”

Arun Babu heard her.

“The examination arrangement should be the same for everyone,” he said.

Rita fell silent.

Nalini said nothing either.

Her eyes went to Shabnam's heels.

Again and again, the heels left the floor.

At that moment, she remembered a harmonium from thirty years earlier.

Light from the window used to fall across its black polish.

She had been sixteen then.

In the small room at Sharda Di's house, four girls practised one after another.

Nalini kept trying to reach the highest notes.

The effort arose less from her own desire than from comparison.

Her cousin Meenu could reach the upper notes with ease.

People at home used to say, “Meenu's voice opens beautifully.”

By hearing this again and again, Nalini had come to believe that good singing meant reaching higher.

Sharda Di had never said that.

One winter, Nalini's voice began to change.

Notes that had once come easily began to tremble midway.

When she climbed higher, the sound grew thin and broke.

Nalini increased her practice.

The harder she pushed, the more tired her throat became.

One evening, Sharda Di stopped the harmonium.

“Enough for today,” she said.

Nalini felt humiliated.

“I'll do it again,” she said.

“Again tomorrow.”

“Once more now.”

Sharda Di looked at her face.

“Are you trying to find the note, or your old voice?”

Nalini did not understand the question.

Sharda Di changed the harmonium key.

Then she began a simple alap in a lower pitch than before.

Nalini began to sing.

This time, the note did not break.

She felt more anger than relief.

“So I am singing lower now?”

Sharda Di did not laugh.

“You are singing in your own voice.”

“But this wasn't the key before.”

“Your voice wasn't where it is now before either.”

Nalini fell silent.

Sharda Di placed a hand on the harmonium lid.

“The instrument is for the person,” she said, “not the person for the instrument.”

Then she added, “The note must stay true; the key can change.”

That day, Nalini understood only half of what the sentence meant.

It seemed to her that Sharda Di was relaxing the rules merely to spare her feelings.

After returning home she told Ma, “Sharda Di has moved me down to a lower key.”

Ma said, “So?”

“Meenu sings higher.”

Stirring the dal, Ma said, “Meenu is Meenu. You are you.”

That answer did not satisfy Nalini either.

At that age, comparison feels like fact.

For the next three months she practised in the new key.

Her voice slowly became steady.

But as examinations drew near, her studies increased and the time for music diminished.

After she went to college, regular lessons stopped.

She also went to Sharda Di's house less often.

A few years later, work, marriage, children, transfers, and household duties entered her life.

Music did not leave her life in any tragic fashion.

It simply slipped gradually to the edge, the way many things do.

Sometimes, when she sang at a wedding, people would say, “You have been trained.”

Nalini would laugh.

“A very long time ago.”

Sharda Di's sentence remained in her memory, but not like a rule.

Sometimes only when she saw a harmonium.

Sometimes while talking with Meenu about old days.

Sometimes when her own daughter stopped singing in adolescence.

Nalini did not force her daughter to continue.

Even then, she did not know whether that decision came from Sharda Di's influence or merely from the leniency of a tired mother.

Years passed.

Nalini went for teacher training.

She first taught in a school.

After that, she moved into administration at the skills centre.

She liked rules.

Clear rules especially.

Because clear rules leave less room for argument.

How much attendance was required, how long the examination would last, how many tools there would be, how the marks would be divided - when everything was written down, work became easier.

Nalini had long taken that ease for justice.

Sometimes it was justice.

Sometimes it was not.

She understood the difference only gradually.

Once, a trainee had been absent for three days because her child was ill.

Nalini had issued a warning according to the rules.

Later she felt some guilt, but she did not withdraw the warning.

Another time, a trainer had asked for different timings for different students.

Nalini had refused - "There will be one rule for everyone."

At the time, the sentence had seemed right to her.

Today, as she watched Shabnam's heels, that same sentence sounded again.

"The examination arrangement should be the same for everyone."

Arun Babu said again, "If we give her a platform, the others will ask for one too."

Nalini turned towards him.

"If someone else needs one, we will give it to her too."

Arun Babu frowned.

"Then where is the equality?"

Before answering, Nalini looked at Shabnam.

Shabnam was not taking part in the conversation.

She was trying to tighten the end of a wire while standing on her toes.

Suddenly Nalini saw Sharda Di's hand on the harmonium key.

The memory was not clear like a picture.

Only the movement of a hand, the black polish, and a fragment of a sentence.

The instrument is for the person.

Nalini said to Rita, "Bring the wooden platform."

Arun Babu was about to say something.

Nalini added, "The measure of the work, the time, and the marks will remain the same. Only the reach will change."

"That is not written in the rules."

"Nor is it prohibited in the rules."

Nalini had not thought out that answer beforehand.

It came into being at that moment.

Rita brought a broad wooden platform.

Nalini checked its stability.

Two trainers pressed it from both sides to make sure it did not wobble.

Then Shabnam stood on it.

Now her elbow was at a comfortable height.

Nalini looked at the clock.

The time spent in the discussion was not counted as part of Shabnam's examination time.

Arun Babu agreed to that.

The examination began again.

Shabnam did not hurry.

She first switched off the main supply, then checked the wire connections, and only after that completed the circuit.

At one point, she made a mistake.

The test lamp did not light.

She opened the connection again and corrected it.

Nalini went outside.

She felt no anxiety to know the result.

Her decision had not been to make Shabnam pass.

It had been only to give her an equal opportunity to reach the work.

She heard that distinction clearly inside herself.

At lunch, Rita asked, "How did you decide so quickly?"

Nalini went on mixing dal into her rice.

"Not quickly," she said.

"Then?"

"It took thirty years."

Rita laughed.

"What?"

Nalini smiled too.

"Nothing. I remembered something old."

She did not explain further.

She herself still had to put the whole story together.

After returning home that evening, Nalini had no reason to open the old cupboard, yet she opened it.

She was not looking for any old music files.

Nor did she remember any written advice from Sharda Di.

She only wanted to see whether the old harmonium was still there.

The harmonium was not there.

A few years after Nalini's marriage, Ma had sent it to Meenu's house.

Nalini knew this, but had forgotten it while opening the cupboard.

She was about to close the cupboard when she saw an old cloth bag on the upper shelf.

Inside it were some song sheets, two thin books, and a small notebook of musical notation.

On the first page of the notebook was Sharda Di's handwriting.

“Vocal range changed.”

That was all.

No philosophy.

No grand sentence.

Nalini sat for a while with the notebook in her hand.

She remembered her anger at sixteen.

At the time, it had seemed to her that the teacher was reducing her ability.

Thirty years later, she understood - Sharda Di had changed not the ability, but the measure.

Nalini knew that even this understanding required caution.

Changing every rule to suit every person is not justice.

Some rules preserve the truth of the task.

The note must remain true.

But the key need not be the same.

The examination ended the next day.

Shabnam's result was slightly above average.

She lost marks on one question, made two connections cleanly, and followed the safety procedure fully.

Nalini signed the result sheet.

When Shabnam met her outside, she folded her hands and said, “Thank you for the platform yesterday.”

Nalini said, “It was an examination-room arrangement, not a favour.”

Shabnam probably did not think about the significance of that sentence.

She walked towards the next room where certificates were being processed.

Nalini did not stop her.

That afternoon Nalini called an administrative meeting.

This time the subject was not Shabnam alone.

She proposed a checklist for every practical room: adjustable and fixed heights, lighting, seating arrangements, and access to tools.

Arun Babu was not present.

Rita was.

Rita asked, “Will all the tables be changed?”

Nalini said, “Where necessary, the arrangement will change. The measure of the work will not.”

In the meeting record, the reason for the decision was written in two lines.

Sharda Di's name was not there.

Nor was there any mention of music.

Nalini felt that was right.

Influence does not always travel with a name attached.

Sometimes a student forgets a small adjustment made by a teacher.

Then, years later, the hand remembers it before making a decision.

That night Nalini placed the old notation notebook back in the cupboard.

She did not sit down to sing.

Nor did she want to turn Sharda Di's sentence into a principle for life.

She understood only this much: thirty years earlier, a teacher had changed the key on a harmonium.

And today, in an examination room, Nalini had allowed a wooden platform to be placed.

The two events were not the same.

But there was a subtle note between them.

After all these years, she heard that note clearly for the first time.

FROM LIGHT — STORIES ACROSS LIFETIMES

STORY 16

The Maternal Line

1

Ishani was not afraid of the key to her grandmother's house. What frightened her was the sentence always handed over with it: "This house goes to the eldest daughter."

As a child, the sentence had sounded like pride. In other houses in the village, when land was discussed, sons' names were counted; in this house, daughters'. Her grandmother, Urmila Devi, would run a hand over a pillar of the veranda and say, "For four generations this courtyard has passed from mother to daughter." Ishani had been ten then, and the story felt like magic.

Now she was twenty-nine. She had studied architecture in Patna and Delhi, worked in the conservation of old buildings, and had come to the village on three days' leave for her grandmother's eightieth birthday. The house was the same—the red-earth courtyard, the tulsi platform to the north, the old wooden chest in the western room, the black film of smoke along the veranda beam. But Ishani had changed.

When the birthday meal ended, Urmila Devi called all the women inside. Mrinal—Ishani's mother—already knew what was about to happen. Aunt Sudha, cousin Riddhi, two distant kakis who felt like aunts, even eight-year-old Anshu crowded in.

From beneath her pillow Urmila Devi took out a heavy brass-coloured key with a red thread tied through its hole. "Who knows how many days this body has left," she said matter-of-factly. "Let us decide the next hand for the house."

Mrinal looked at Ishani. Every eye turned toward her.

Without preparation Ishani said, "I will not take it."

The silence that entered the room was not the silence after death. It was the silence of insult, surprise, fear, and incomprehension. Urmila Devi closed the key inside her fist.

"What did you say?"

"Not the house. Not in this manner."

Mrinal's face went pale. Sudha Mausi said quietly, "At least listen first."

Ishani said, "I have grown up listening."

That night had begun with a birthday. It was going to end with an accounting of the maternal line.

2

In this family the word “matriline” was not very old. The old phrase was “the line of the mother’s house.” In the days of Urmila Devi’s grandmother, Bhuvaneshwari Devi, no one spoke the language of genealogy. People only knew that Bhuvaneshwari’s husband died young, her two sons went east in search of work, and three daughters remained at home.

That year the Kamla rose twice. Half the crop was lost. The rear wall of the house collapsed. Bhuvaneshwari sold her jewellery, raised the wall again, saved seed grain, and exchanged two pregnant cows for a lease on a pond. Her eldest daughter, Surmai, managed field, accounts, and household beside her.

The sons sent letters. Money came now and then. But the daily body of the household rested in Surmai’s hands. Two years before Bhuvaneshwari died, she went to the village scribe and had the house papers made out in Surmai’s name.

People said many things. “Her sons are alive.” “The daughter will marry.” “The land will go to another house.”

Bhuvaneshwari had only one answer: “The one who raised the wall has a right to the wall.”

Generation after generation turned that sentence into a line of pride. But its original cause was less a doctrine of inheritance than justice for labour. Later generations made an exception into a tradition.

Surmai received the house. Then Surmai’s eldest daughter Janki. Then Janki’s eldest daughter Kamla. Then Kamla’s eldest daughter Urmila. Urmila’s eldest daughter Mrinal. And now Mrinal’s eldest daughter, Ishani.

A straight line. A beautiful line.

Straight lines are always beautiful—until one notices the heads bent inside them.

3

The next morning Ishani woke late. Her grandmother was already sitting in the courtyard with an old sujani stitched in red, green, and black thread into little square houses. Some squares held people; some were empty.

“Do you recognise this?” Grandmother asked.

“Surmai Nani’s?”

“Yes. Half of it. Janki added the other half.”

Ishani spread the sujani out. It did not look like a museum object, but like cloth worn through daily use. The edge was torn in several places. One corner had been patched with newer cloth.

“I’ll take this,” Ishani said.

Urmila Devi was startled. “Not the house, but the sujani?”

“If you give it to me.”

“The sujani goes with the house.”

“Then I will not take it.”

Grandmother's eyes hardened. "Will you pick and choose from tradition?"

Ishani paused. "Yes. Why not?"

Urmila Devi folded the sujani. "Tradition is not cloth in a shop."

"And tradition is not a shackle either."

Their first clear collision occurred there. Mrinal had been listening from the veranda but did not enter. There was hurt on her face—and something else, as though her daughter had spoken aloud, without permission, a thought buried inside her own life.

4

At noon Mrinal called Ishani to the roof. The sun was sharp; they sat in the shade of the water tank.

"Do you think we are trying to bind you?" Mrinal asked.

"You?"

"All of us."

Ishani did not answer at once. "I think everyone likes this rule because it favours daughters. But a rule is still a rule."

"Receiving a house has become bondage?"

"Not receiving the house. Receiving a life already decided along with the house."

Mrinal was silent.

Ishani said, "Nani says if I take the house, I must come four times a year, look after ritual songs, keep account of the chest, be the first doorway in deaths and weddings, keep track of the old people who are left alone. This is not the key to a house. It is an entire office."

Mrinal said softly, "Is an office necessarily bad?"

"Not bad. But did I choose it?"

For the first time Mrinal looked directly at her daughter. "Did I choose it?"

Something stopped inside Ishani.

Mrinal tried to smile. "Your grandmother's argument was that I would receive the house, so I was fortunate. I believed that too. I never thought about how much work came attached to being fortunate."

"Did you ever want to leave it?"

"No."

Ishani exhaled.

Mrinal added, "But that is not the whole truth either."

5

When Mrinal was in college she had wanted to stay in Darbhanga and pursue postgraduate study. At that time Kamla—her grandmother—fell ill, and pain began in Urmila Devi's knees. The family farm was small, but the flow of people

through the house was constant. Mrinal's younger sister Sudha was preparing for marriage.

"I had filled out the form," Mrinal said. "I had even written the hostel address. Then Nani said: if the eldest daughter leaves the house, who will tend this line?"

"Did you tear up the form?"

"No. I put it in the chest."

"Is it still there?"

"Perhaps."

Ishani did not laugh. "You never told me."

"What would telling have changed?"

"I would have understood."

"I did not understand it myself. It did not seem like sacrifice to me. It was family work. Later, after I moved to Patna with your father, I resumed my studies. Late, but I did."

Mrinal taught history at a school. Ishani knew that. She had not known that her mother's first attempt at study had been interrupted by the family tradition.

"Then do you want me to take the key?"

After a long silence Mrinal said, "I want you not to abandon the house. But perhaps—" She stopped and corrected herself. "Perhaps I also want you to have the right to abandon it."

6

That evening Sudha Mausi told her own story. She had not been the eldest, so the house was never meant to be hers. As a child she had been jealous of that.

"Your mother got the key, I got bangles," she said, laughing. "I thought she would inherit history and I would inherit only marriage."

After marriage Sudha moved to Muzaffarpur, worked in a bank, raised two children, and cared for her husband through five years of illness. Distance from the house gave her freedom as well as guilt.

"If Ma fell ill, the first phone call went to Didi," she said. "If anyone in the village needed something, Didi. If the roof over the old room leaked, Didi. I sent money, but the actual name of responsibility was Mrinal."

Ishani asked, "Did you want the house?"

"I wanted it then. Now I understand I wanted the honour of the house, not its whole weight."

"Then was the tradition unjust?"

Sudha shook her head. "It is not that simple. This family put a daughter's name on paper at a time when many households did not. That was no small thing. But to give the right and load the work only on that daughter—that is another matter."

Mrinal listened from a distance. Mother, aunt, daughter—three women like three sisters—were looking at the tradition for the first time not as a tale of glory, but as a distribution of labour.

7

For three days Urmila Devi did not discuss the matter with Ishani. On the fourth morning she called her into the western room.

“Open the chest.”

The brass key turned in the lock. Inside were sujanis, old dhotis, letters, papers, a brass lamp, two songbooks, and a thin wooden roller shaped almost like a flute, wrapped in cloth.

“Do all these go with the house?” Ishani asked.

“Not all.”

Grandmother took things out one by one and told their stories. The first pages of the songbook were not in Surmai’s hand; she wrote poorly. Janki had listened and written. The middle pages were Kamla’s. Corrections ran along the margins in Urmila’s hand. Mrinal had added two new songs.

“Then this is not one person’s book,” Ishani said.

“When did I say it was?”

“But the key goes to one person.”

Urmila Devi glared. “Again the same thing.”

Ishani fell silent.

Grandmother lifted the brass lamp. “This is said to have belonged to Bhuvaneshwari.”

“Proof?”

An unwilling smile appeared on Grandmother’s face. “Have those archive people taught you to question every story?”

“I only asked.”

“There is no proof. My mother told me.”

“Then ‘it is said’ is accurate.”

“You will not take the key, but you will correct the language?”

For the first time they both laughed again.

8

At the bottom of the chest lay a thin notebook. On the cover was written: “The House’s Mother-Line.” Ishani was surprised. It held no family tree, but brief notes.

“Bhuvaneshwari—raised the wall. Surmai—saved seed. Janki—had songs written down. Kamla—recovered the pond. Urmila—replaced the roof.”

No husband’s or father’s name beside the women. Names beside deeds.

Ishani’s eyes lit up. “I like this.”

Grandmother said, “Do you think all we did was carry keys?”

“No.”

“Because of this house, women’s names survived. Otherwise in many genealogies a daughter disappears after marriage.”

Ishani turned the pages. In one place it said: “Kamla—did not attend teacher training; mother ill.”

She stopped. “Who wrote this?”

“I did.”

“Why?”

“If the account records what was done but not what was lost along the way, it is only half an account.”

On the next page: “Urmila—wanted to study nursing; application not sent.”

Ishani looked at her grandmother.

Urmila Devi looked away.

9

Urmila Devi had been seventeen when a notice appeared for assistant-nurse training at the district hospital. She was good at science. The schoolmaster had brought the form. Kamla Devi was then managing both field and household, but her mother Janki had become bedridden.

“I did not fill in the form,” Urmila Devi said.

“Did anyone stop you?”

“Not directly.”

“Then?”

“Everyone said: if the eldest daughter lives away, who will look after Nani? No one issued an order. There was no need for one.”

Ishani asked softly, “Were you unhappy?”

“At the time? A little. Then I married, and your Nana came to live here—I did not leave the house. Children were born. The field survived. The songs survived. Many good things happened. A life is not the name of one missed chance.”

“But the form?”

“Sometimes I used to dream of white clothes and the smell of a hospital. Then at dawn I would rise and milk the cow. Which of the two lives was the ‘real’ one?”

Ishani did not answer.

For the first time Urmila Devi stopped seeing her granddaughter’s rebellion only as ingratitude. “If you take the key, will you leave Delhi?”

“No.”

“Then the house?”

“We will divide the work.”

"Among whom?"

"Among everyone who calls it their own."

Grandmother laughed. "Easy to say."

"That is why we will write it down."

"Paper again!"

"This time the paper will divide the work."

10

Ishani worked in the conservation of historic buildings. On the fifth day she took out a measuring tape and began drawing the house—rooms, courtyard, beams, drains, wall thickness, patches of damp.

Anshu followed her everywhere. "Didi, will the house fall?"

"No. But if everyone only tells stories and nobody repairs the roof, it will."

Mrinal laughed. Urmila Devi did not. The sight of the measuring tape made her feel as though the house had become a patient in a hospital.

Ishani prepared a report: damp in the north wall; western beam requiring replacement; rainwater outlet blocked; soot on the surface of old paintings. She added an estimated cost.

The report went to the family group chat. Sons, daughters, grandsons, granddaughters—scattered across cities—responded. Someone wrote "too expensive", someone "look for a government grant", someone sent only folded-hands emojis.

Ishani sent a separate message: "If the house belongs to the maternal line, why should the eldest daughter alone bear the cost?"

At first there was silence. Then Uncle Alok wrote: "I'll pay my share."

Sudha Mausi: "Me too."

Younger uncle Vineet: "Not 'share'. Let us divide whatever is needed."

Urmila Devi could not read the messages. Mrinal read them aloud. Grandmother only said, "Money is easy. What about time?"

Ishani wrote back: "There will be a schedule for time too."

11

The family's first "house meeting" was held on Sunday. Ishani gave it that name; Grandmother said, "We have always had meetings."

"This time with an account."

Ten people sat on the veranda; others joined by phone. Ishani wrote four headings: repairs; care of elders; preservation of songs and objects; annual gathering.

Alok Mama said, "I can come for two days once every six months."

Sudha said, "If hospital work is needed, I can manage from Patna."

Vineet: "One-third of repair expenses."

Riddhi: “I will record the songs.”

Mrinal: “For now the principal key will remain with me.”

Everyone looked at Ishani.

“I will make a conservation plan, inspect at least twice a year, and prepare a digital catalogue of the songbooks and objects. But I will not be the permanent keeper.”

Urmila Devi asked, “And if the house catches fire?”

Ishani answered, “Then whoever is closest will run. A lineage cannot take a flight from Delhi to put out a fire.”

Alok laughed. Grandmother did not, but the corner of her eyes softened.

12

After the meeting, the real quarrel was raised by Riddhi. She was Sudha Mausi’s daughter, five years younger than Ishani, and after marriage lived in a town near the village. Interested in folk craft, she ran a small group teaching sujani embroidery.

“If Ishani is not taking the house,” Riddhi said, “I can hold a workshop here two days a week.”

Urmila Devi replied at once, “The house is in Ishani’s line.”

Riddhi smiled, but her voice was firm. “Then this matriline too becomes a kingdom of eldest daughter to eldest daughter. Am I not a daughter?”

The room became silent again.

Ishani felt relief and shame at once. Even in her rebellion she had kept herself at the centre.

Sudha Mausi said softly, “My line has always been second.”

Urmila Devi’s face tightened. “The rule has existed since your grandmother’s time.”

Sudha replied, “Bhuvaneshwari did not make that rule. She gave the house to Surmai because Surmai had cared for it. Later, we turned that into birth order.”

That sentence struck hardest. For the first time the origin story of the tradition testified against its present rule.

13

Urmila Devi ate little that night. Everyone understood that she had been hurt. Ishani went to her room on the pretext of bringing water.

Grandmother was awake.

“Was Riddhi right?” Ishani asked.

“A house does not run according to arithmetic of right and wrong.”

“Then how?”

“By habit.”

“Habits change.”

“They do. But those who change them often understand later how difficult it was to save what was saved.”

Ishani sat by the bed. “Are you afraid the house will fragment?”

“Not the house. The story.”

“Why must the story live in one key?”

“When one person is responsible, work is forgotten less.”

“And one person becomes tired more.”

Grandmother was silent.

After a while she asked, “Was your mother very tired?”

Ishani’s throat tightened. “Sometimes.”

“She never said.”

“You never spoke of the nursing form either.”

Urmila Devi closed her eyes. “It seems silence too has descended through our mother-daughter tradition.”

“Let us leave that part of the tradition behind.”

Grandmother opened her eyes. “That part can be left.”

14

The next day the songs were recorded. Riddhi had brought not a phone but a separate microphone. Urmila Devi laughed at first. “The song will be frightened by so much equipment.”

The first song was said to be Surmai’s, though the words in the songbook were in Janki’s hand. While singing, Urmila Devi changed two lines. Riddhi did not stop her. When the song ended she asked, “Nani, the book has different words.”

“My mother used to sing it this way.”

“Then what shall I write in the recording?”

Ishani almost said, “Variant.” But she stopped.

Urmila Devi herself said, “Write: version heard from Urmila. Janki’s version in the book is different.”

Riddhi smiled.

Mrinal sang the second song. Sudha the third. In the fourth, everyone forgot the words halfway. Anshu began searching on the phone, but Grandmother stopped him. “Search memory first.”

Everyone laughed. Three different lines emerged. All three were kept in the recording.

Ishani wrote: “One song, many memories.”

Urmila Devi read it and said, “Is that not like the maternal line?”

“Yes. If we do not call one form the only authentic one.”

Grandmother said, “You add conditions to everything.”

"Not conditions. Space."

15

Riddhi's workshop met on the veranda for the first time. Five women, two girls, one boy. Seeing the boy, an elderly neighbour asked, "A boy will learn sujani?"

Riddhi replied easily, "He has hands, so he will learn."

Urmila Devi heard. She said nothing.

Anshu could not tie the thread on the first day. On the second he stitched a small fish. Grandmother looked at it and said, "The tail is very fat."

Anshu replied, "It is my fish."

Grandmother laughed. "Then let it stay fat."

Ishani watched from a distance. A skill of the maternal line had crossed toward a grandson for the first time, and the sky did not fall.

Later Riddhi said, "I did not ask for the house. I asked for space."

Ishani asked, "If Nani said you should take the house?"

Riddhi thought. "Not alone. My work can continue here, but I will not abandon my own house either."

"Then the key?"

"Keys can be copied."

Ishani laughed. As an architect, why had this not occurred to her sooner? One lock, many keys. Why had tradition kept searching for one hand?

That evening Alok Mama sat with Ishani. For a long time he watched the children's stitching in the workshop. Then he said, "There is something I must admit."

Ishani asked, "What?"

"Since childhood I have heard: the house belongs to Didi. At first I thought it was unfair. Later I understood that the sentence also gave me leave. Roof leaks—Didi will see to it. Nani sick—Didi will run. Guests—Didi. I went away to study, changed cities for work; no one said, 'Why are you leaving your mother's house?'"

Ishani listened silently. The matrilineal rule gave women property, but could also become an excuse for freeing men from responsibility—this side had not yet fully entered the argument.

Alok added, "I am not here to ask for a share of the house. But I want a share of the work. Otherwise we men keep taking the benefit of the old rule while giving women all the glory for it. That is not fair."

Ishani asked, "Then what will you take on?"

"Before the rains, the roof. Twice a year, inspection by a mason. And one whole month of fetching Nani's medicines is my responsibility. Write it down."

Ishani laughed. “The first male inheritance in the maternal line?”

Alok laughed too. “Not inheritance. Arrears.”

Ishani kept the word in mind. Lineage was not only an account of what one received; it also carried arrears of work that had been pushed to one side generation after generation.

16

The paper question was difficult. Legally the house stood in Urmila Devi’s name. There was an old family understanding that after her it would pass to Mrinal, but no written will had yet been made.

Ishani said clearly, “We will not invent law to suit the story. Let us go to a lawyer and understand what is actually possible.”

The family went to a lawyer in the district town. He examined the papers, heard what the family wanted, and said ownership, rights of use, duties of maintenance, and future transfer were separate matters; whatever they chose, they should write it clearly.

The story did not become a court case. No one sued anyone. But one question from the lawyer stopped them all: “Is your goal to preserve the house, or to preserve one fixed line of succession?”

Urmila Devi did not answer immediately.

The lawyer added, “They are not the same thing.”

On the way home Grandmother kept looking out of the car window. Fields moved in the westerly wind. After a long time she said, “Bhuvaneshwari saved the house. Have we, in trying to save the line, forgotten why the house was saved?”

Mrinal took her hand. Ishani gave no answer. Some questions, answered too quickly, merely become new rules.

17

The decision did not come in one day. For three months there were phone calls, letters, meetings, a lawyer, and arguments among themselves. At last the family arrived at an arrangement: Urmila Devi would remain full owner during her lifetime. After her, the house would pass into Mrinal’s name, accompanied by a written family agreement dividing maintenance, expenses, use, and care of cultural objects among willing members. After Mrinal, she would not automatically designate the eldest daughter; the family would meet again and consider willingness, work, and circumstances.

Ishani said, “This is not a complete solution.”

Urmila Devi replied, “Do complete solutions exist anywhere but stories?”

“Not in my story either.”

“Then good.”

Two days a week on the veranda were fixed for Riddhi’s workshop. Alok Mama took responsibility for inspecting the roof before the rains. Sudha for

hospital assistance. Vineet for expense accounts. Ishani for conservation. Mrinal for the principal key.

Three duplicate keys were made. The first time Urmila Devi held one, she said, "How small the original has become."

Ishani said, "It is still the original."

"But no longer alone."

"That is the relief."

18

A few months later Ishani returned to Delhi. Her grandmother's house had not become hers, but its task list lived on her phone. Riddhi sent the first photograph of the rainy season—the damp on the north wall had reduced. Alok Mama sent the mason's estimate for the beam. Mrinal sent scans of the songbook. Anshu sent his sujani fish with the fat tail.

At work Ishani drew plans of old havelis, mosques, schools, and railway quarters. One day a colleague asked, "Who will inherit your ancestral home?"

Ishani no longer answered, "I will." "It belongs to Nani now. The later arrangement is shared."

"Meaning a trust?"

"Not exactly."

"Joint property?"

"What the lawyer has written on paper is one thing. Within the family we call it the house."

The colleague laughed. "Very vague."

Ishani laughed too. She remembered Niranjan's story: vagueness was not always a defect; sometimes it was honesty.

That night she listened to Grandmother's recording. Urmila Devi's voice trembled now and then, but the melodic line held. Riddhi had named the file: "Mother-Line_Form-1."

Ishani was pleased by "Form-1". It meant there was room for Form-2.

That night Ishani drew the family on paper. At first she tried a tree—ancestors above, descendants below. Then she folded the paper. Once again the tree was producing the same straight line.

On a second sheet she wrote names in circles and drew arrows between them: who cared for whom in illness, who paid for whose schooling, who taught whom a song, who rebuilt the roof, who looked after children, who ran to the hospital at the end of a life. There were so many arrows the page became a web.

Mrinal saw a photograph of it on the phone and asked, "Is this a family tree?"

"No. A work-web."

"Are these things written in lineage?"

"Why not? If lineage records only birth, half the relationships of life disappear."

After thinking, Mrinal said, "Then your grandmother's 'Mother-Line' notebook was an early version of this idea—work beside names."

Ishani understood that rebellion did not always mean throwing away everything old. Sometimes a new principle had already been seeded inside an old object; it only needed to be taken out of the shell of the rule.

19

Six months later Urmila Devi suddenly fell ill. Ishani took a night flight to Patna and then a car to the village. Ambulance, hospital, medicines—for several days everything was disorder.

Under the old rule, the principal burden would have fallen on Mrinal and Ishani. This time Sudha managed hospital papers, Alok the night watch, Vineet medicines, Riddhi the house, Mrinal stayed beside Grandmother, and Ishani spoke with the doctors.

Urmila Devi recovered and returned home. On the first evening on the veranda she looked at everyone for a long time.

"When my mother fell ill, one daughter did everything," she said.

Mrinal asked, "Was that good or bad?"

"At that time perhaps it was necessary. Now it is not."

Ishani said softly, "Then changing the rule was not wrong?"

Grandmother glared. "Will you win arguments against a sick body?"

Everyone laughed.

After a while Grandmother herself added, "But dividing the work was good."

In that small admission Ishani felt no victory, only rest. The family's change had been proved not by winning an argument, but by relief in a tired body.

20

After she recovered, Urmila Devi added a new page to the "House's Mother-Line" notebook. Ishani saw that the title had changed: "The House's People-Line."

Under it she had written: "Bhuvaneshwari—raised the wall. Surmai—saved seed. Janki—had songs written. Kamla—recovered the pond. Urmila—replaced the roof. Mrinal—taught history. Sudha—support in illness. Alok—roof. Vineet—accounts. Riddhi—sujani and recordings. Ishani—measurement of the house and new arrangement. Anshu—first fat fish."

Ishani stared at the page for a long time. "Has the matriline ended?"

Grandmother said, "The name changed. Have the mothers disappeared?"

"No."

"Then?"

Ishani said, “But I love the word ‘matriline’.”

Urmila Devi smiled. “Keep beloved things in titles. Not in rules.”

Ishani wrote that sentence in the margin.

21

A year later a small exhibition was held on the veranda of Bhuvaneshwari’s house—for the family, not the market. Sujanis were hung, copies of the songbooks displayed, old and new plans of the house, photographs of the pond, brief life sketches of the women—and of the men too.

No one wrote “great matriarchal tradition.” Ishani was wary of the phrase. The introductory panel said only: “In this family, for a period, the house passed in inheritance from mother to daughter. Across generations this practice became security, right, labour, and burden. The family is now changing it toward consent and shared responsibility.”

Urmila Devi read the panel and said, “Too long.”

“Shall I shorten it?”

“No. Truth is difficult to shorten.”

A village girl at the exhibition asked, “Then who does the house belong to in the end?”

Before Urmila Devi answered, she looked at Ishani.

Ishani said, “At present, to Nani.”

The girl asked, “And afterwards?”

Grandmother laughed. “Those who care for it will sit together and decide.”

“Not the eldest daughter?”

“If the eldest daughter wants it, her voice will be there. If she does not, her ‘no’ will be there too.”

Ishani listened. A year earlier they had quarrelled over that sentence. Now Grandmother herself was saying it.

22

In the evening the exhibition was taken down. The sujani was folded again, but this time not locked in the chest. Riddhi kept a replica at the workshop; the original remained inside the house under a cloth cover. Digital copies of the songbooks existed in three places. Mrinal held the paper originals.

The brass lamp was brought into the courtyard. Until then Urmila Devi always had the eldest daughter light it. This time Anshu ran up. “May I light it?”

Everyone paused a little.

Urmila Devi said, “If you can keep your hand steady, light it.”

Anshu touched flame to the wick. The first time it went out. The second time Riddhi shielded his hand. The third time the flame stood.

Ishani joked, “Whose lineage does the lamp belong to now?”

Grandmother answered, “To everyone who supplies oil, changes the wick, and wishes to light it.”

“And those who do not wish to light it?”

“They too have the right to choose darkness.”

Everyone laughed. Urmila Devi too.

The flame fell upon the red thread of the sujani. The square houses were separate, yet joined on one cloth. Some squares were empty. Ishani no longer saw the empty houses as absence; they looked like space.

23

After everyone slept, Ishani sat alone on the veranda. Three duplicate keys hung from a nail. The original key was no longer beneath Grandmother’s pillow; it lay openly in a small wall niche.

Mrinal came. “Not sleepy?”

“It is coming.”

“Do you still not want the house?”

Ishani thought. “I want the house. Not the entire story of ownership.”

“The difference?”

“A great deal.”

Mrinal sat beside her. “I understand now. At first I thought you were diminishing the work of my mothers.”

“On the contrary, I take their work more seriously. They made decisions under particular circumstances. We turned those decisions into rules without looking at the circumstances.”

Mrinal nodded. “In history class we make the same mistake—turning events into formulas.”

Ishani rested her head on her mother’s shoulder. “You completed your postgraduate degree. Nani could not become a nurse. We will write both.”

“Write my achievement and also what did not happen?”

“Both. The maternal line is not only the history of what survived; it is also the history of what was left behind.”

Mrinal gently squeezed her hand.

24

The next morning Ishani left for Delhi. Urmila Devi did not come to the doorway; her knees hurt. From inside she called, “Do not take the sujani.”

Ishani laughed. “I won’t.”

“Take the scan.”

“I already have it.”

“The songs?”

“On my phone.”

“The key?”

Ishani stopped. Riddhi held out one duplicate.

She took it and weighed it in her hand. A year earlier that weight had frightened her. Now it was not an order, but a means of access.

“Will you take it?” Riddhi asked.

Ishani put the key in her bag. “Yes. A copy.”

From inside came Grandmother’s laughter. “The original has lost its pride.”

The car moved. The house grew small in the rear window. For the first time Ishani felt neither that she was leaving the house nor that the house was holding her back. Between them was a road—the road to return, not return, return again.

On the veranda the brass lamp stood unlit in daylight. At evening someone would light it. A daughter, a son, a granddaughter, a grandson; perhaps no one. Light no longer meant a command of lineage.

It was only a possibility—that if anyone wished to see another person in the dark, there was still room beside the flame.

STORY 17

Raga

1

On the fifth day after Chhath, Pipra's ghat had become an ordinary ghat again. The four bamboos had been removed, the marks of the ropes remained in the earth, and on the steps lay only as many dried flower stalks as the wind had failed to carry away. The river had receded a little. At evening, on the third step, Harihar Mahato sat with his eyes closed, the first two fingers of his right hand tapping against his knee.

He sounded from a distance as though he were singing. Come closer and there were no words—only a long note, first very thin, then full, then rising with a slight tremor until it stopped abruptly in the middle. After the note ceased, the river could be heard more clearly.

At that moment a young woman came down to the ghat. A bag hung from her shoulder; in her hand was a small sound recorder; a black cable looped at her throat. She stopped on the first step and waited. Harihar did not open his eyes. The note rose again. This time the young woman switched on the device. A small red light came on.

When the note ended, Harihar opened his eyes and looked straight at the red light.

"How much did you save?"

The young woman was startled. "Forgive me. I should have asked first."

"I asked—how much did you save?"

She stopped the recorder. "One minute and eighteen seconds."

Harihar laughed. "And where will you keep the remaining twenty years it took?"

The young woman laughed too, though not at once. "I am Naina. I have come from Patna. I am working on the songs and melodic forms of Pipra."

"Write down the song, catch the tune, and leave the singer out?"

"No. That is why I have come to you."

Harihar looked toward the river. "Then sit. Listen first. The machine later."

2

Harihar Mahato was known in Pipra as "Harihar the Singer," though he described himself less as a singer than as a farmer. Only half his land remained; both sons worked away from home, his grandson went to school, and an old harmonium lay covered with cloth in the back room. His singing did not belong to a single profession's discipline. He sang at weddings, at collective rituals and festivals, with boatmen on flood nights, sometimes while ploughing, sometimes in the silence after a death.

Naina had found his name in a list made from an old cassette. The person who made the list was dead, and no one knew where the cassette was. On the paper alone was written: “Harihar Mahato, Pipra, Uttarahi Raga, 1994.” The words “Uttarahi Raga” had brought Naina there.

She had studied music in the city but had left the direction of the classical stage and begun working on sound archives of folk melodies. She believed that a voice disappeared not only when a singer died; if the next generation did not hear it, the path of the melody itself would break. So she recorded, wrote names, dates, places, contexts, the singer’s consent—everything.

At the word “Uttarahi,” Harihar remained silent for a while.

“Who said this is a raga?”

“It is written in the old list.”

“Did the person who made the list sing?”

“I do not know.”

“Then he called it a raga, and you accepted it as a raga.”

Naina took a notebook from her bag. “What do you call it?”

“I say it was first an evening movement. When wind came from the north, the note bent like this. People asked for a name; I called it Uttarahi. Tomorrow if the wind blows from the south?”

“Will the name change?”

“The name will remain. The tune will change a little.”

Naina stopped writing. “Then what exactly am I to preserve?”

A faint gleam came into Harihar’s eyes. “That is why you have come, is it not? You are asking me?”

3

The next morning Naina reached Harihar’s house before sunlight had entered the courtyard. His daughter-in-law Sarita was making tea on the hearth. Harihar was opening the cracked case of the old harmonium. The leather had hardened; two reeds were out of tune.

“Do you sing with this?” Naina asked.

“Not much now. It has grown older than I have.”

“Why not have it repaired?”

“If it is repaired, will it become a new instrument or will the old one be saved? You answer that question.”

Naina understood that the old singer turned everything into an examination. She smiled. “If sound comes out again, the instrument survives. But what if its sound changes?”

“Then a new sound in an old box. Life is no more difficult than that.”

Sarita set down the tea. “Babuji, let the girl sing first. Philosophy later.”

Harihar laughed. “See? My standing in this house.”

Naina first found a clean sa, then held it. Harihar shook his head. “That is a stage sa. In Uttarahi, do not place the first note on the ground. Place it on the wind.”

“How does one place a note on the wind?”

“If you sang as many questions as you write, you would already know.”

She began again. Harihar stopped her midway. “Not straight. Turn a little backward.”

“Backward in the note?”

“Yes. As if you have stepped out through the door and then remembered you left the key inside.”

Naina burst out laughing at the comparison. But the third time, the note truly curved a little. Harihar tapped his knee.

“That is it. Now do not clutch it. Let it go again.”

“If I do not hold it, how will I learn it?”

“Learning and tying down are not the same thing.”

4

For three days Naina’s recorder remained in her bag. Harihar first taught her to listen without it: at the ghat, in the mango grove, on the veranda of the empty school, once behind the oil mill after the machine had stopped. The same melodic movement sounded different everywhere.

Naina grew irritated. “You change it every time.”

Harihar would say, “You want to hear the same thing every time.”

“If there is no foundation, how is this a tradition at all?”

“There is a foundation. A foundation is not a wall.”

One day Naina took out her phone and played a passage she had sung from memory the day before. Harihar listened closely.

“You made a mistake here,” he said.

“Where?”

“At the third turn. You came down too quickly.”

“Then there is a rule!” Naina said almost triumphantly.

“There is a rule, but writing it down will not make a raga.”

“You refuse to state the rule, and then you call something a mistake.”

Harihar rested a hand on his knee and thought for a while. “Have you watched a river’s current? You may say the water will go downhill. That is a rule. But can you measure in advance which drop will turn around which stone?”

“A recording will at least show how you sang.”

“How I sang on one day.”

"That too is necessary."

"Yes. I do not deny that."

It was the first time Harihar had said anything in favour of Naina's machine. Naina did not switch on the red light. She understood that she had received a sentence of agreement, not yet permission.

5

Word spread through Pipra that Naina had come. People began saying Harihar's music was "going to the city." Manoj, who ran the photo shop in the market, proposed one day, "Didi, make a video. River behind, Baba in front. It will run on YouTube."

Harihar asked, "Run where?"

Manoj showed him the phone. "All over the world."

"If a song sung at the ghat goes all over the world, will the ghat become empty?"

Manoj assumed the old man was joking. "No, Baba. You will become famous."

Naina remained silent. Fame was one of the hardest words in her work. If a voice was saved, it should also be heard; if it was heard, someone might attach it to his own name; if it was kept shut, an archive could become a dead room.

She told Harihar plainly, "Before making any recording public, I will take written permission. If you wish, it may remain only for study. If you wish, some part may be open. If you wish, none of it."

"Who will read the written permission?" Harihar asked.

"You. Your family. The institution."

"And permission from the people whose old lines are in the song?"

"From those who are alive, if possible. For older collective portions, I will identify the source."

"And those whose names no one remembers?"

"Then 'unknown' or 'folk tradition.'"

Harihar said slowly, "Calling someone unknown does not make that person nameless."

Naina had no answer. She closed the notebook.

6

That evening Harihar took Naina up to the loft of his house. An old tin box sat on a bamboo beam. Inside were clothes, wedding invitations, two broken pairs of spectacles, his sons' school certificates, and a black cassette. Half the label had peeled away; in blue ink only "Hari... 9..." remained.

"Could this be the one?" Naina asked, holding her breath.

"Who knows. I have not listened to it in many years."

Finding a machine in the village that could play a cassette became a story in itself. At last an old tape recorder was found with a retired clerk who lived behind the post office. Its belt was loose, the sound wavered. There were no batteries, so wires were connected.

The cassette played. First came static. Then two men talking. After that, a voice—young, sharp, very different from Harihar's present voice. Naina looked at him. He listened with his eyes closed.

In the middle of the song, another woman's voice appeared. It was not very clear. She raised a line and young Harihar followed it.

"Who is that?" Naina asked.

Harihar did not open his eyes. "My elder sister."

"Her name?"

"Kusuma."

"She sang too?"

"I learned from her."

Naina fell silent. The old list had named only "Harihar Mahato."

The cassette made a sound as though it were about to jam. Harihar immediately had the machine stopped. "Enough."

"Shall we hear the rest?"

"Tomorrow."

"May I make a digital copy?"

After a long time Harihar said, "Write Kusuma's name first."

Naina opened her notebook. This time Harihar spelled the letters for her himself: Ku-su-ma.

7

Kusuma had died fifteen years earlier. After marriage she had gone to another village and had never sung on a stage. But in Harihar's account, the first turn of Uttarahi was hers.

"Didiya used to say—release the first note as if the boat's rope is slipping from your hand."

Naina laughed. "You say a forgotten key. She said a boat rope."

"Then see—the raga is one, the metaphors are two."

"Or are there two ragas?"

Harihar did not answer.

That day the first formal recording was made. The courtyard was swept, the fan switched off; Sarita asked the neighbour to keep dishes quiet. Naina's recorder sat on the table, its red light on. Sitting before it, Harihar first spoke Kusuma's name: "I learned this movement from my elder sister Kusuma Devi. Whether she learned it from her mother or from someone else, I do not know for certain."

Naina did not interrupt.

Harihar began singing. The first take went well. In the second he coughed. In the third, a motorcycle passed outside. In the fourth, his grandson came in looking for a ball. The fifth time Harihar himself stopped. “No. The wind has changed.”

Naina looked at the clock. Two hours had passed. Her professional patience began to fray. “For a recording, I need one clean take.”

Harihar’s face grew serious. “What does clean mean?”

“Less outside noise. No interruptions in the middle.”

“I have never had a day in my life when there was no outside sound.”

“But the listener needs to hear the melody clearly.”

“The listener needs a melody separated from life?”

Naina too grew firm. “If nothing can be heard clearly, how will the next person learn?”

Harihar looked at the machine. “Will the next person learn from this machine, or from someone’s mouth?”

This time Naina had an answer. “From both.”

Harihar softened a little. “Then make one clean take. And then one in which the house keeps its own voice.”

8

The clean take was made. Window shut, grandson outside, Sarita standing guard on the motorcycle road for five minutes. Harihar sang the entire movement. Headphones over Naina’s ears. The tone was clear, the turns were clear, even his breathing could be heard. The red light remained steady.

When the recording ended, Naina smiled. “That was very good.”

Harihar asked, “Very good singing, or a very good recording?”

“Both.”

“Then keep the distinction.”

For the second take, the window was opened. Far away came the millstone, Sarita’s rolling pin, the grandson’s laughter, a crow in the tree, once the village loudspeaker. Harihar sang. Strangely, his voice was more natural this time. In the headphones Naina felt that the background was not covering the raga; instead, it was giving the raga a place.

She named the file UTARHI_HARIHAR_TAKE2. Then stopped. She changed it to UTARHI_KUSUMA_HARIHAR_HOME.

Harihar could not read the screen. Naina read it aloud to him.

“Kusuma first?”

“You said you learned from her.”

“Then her mother?”

Naina laughed. “Now you are making me draw a genealogy.”

“A raga’s lineage is more difficult than a Panji.”

Hearing this, Naina thought for a while. In the file notes she wrote: “Attribution incomplete; tradition depends upon collective memory.”

After hearing it read aloud, Harihar said, “That is right. Write incomplete. Making it complete is the greatest lie.”

9

A week later, Naina received a call from the city. Her colleague at the institution was excited. “Send a sample. We will put a short clip on the project website. We can let the funder hear it.”

Naina told Harihar.

“Who is the funder?”

“The one whose money keeps this work going.”

“He will listen to the song?”

“Yes.”

“Before giving the money, or after?”

“Both times.”

Harihar smiled. “Then he will want the cleanest take.”

Naina started. “Are you being sarcastic?”

“No. The one giving money will also want pleasure for his ears. But you will write that to make the clean take we stopped every sound in the house.”

Naina agreed to that condition. Then she brought out the consent form and read it aloud in simple Maithili—how much could be made public, how his name would appear, no commercial use, further permission required for reuse.

Before signing, Harihar asked, “If ten years from now someone sings a song over this tune and earns money?”

“This permission form may not prevent that. Ownership of a melody is a separate question.”

“Then you used to say ‘preserved.’”

Naina folded the paper and set it on the table. “Yes. The word was a little too large.”

Harihar laughed. “Now you are learning.”

“You too.”

“What am I learning?”

“That recording is not only theft.”

Instead of answering, Harihar picked up the pen and signed. But only two minutes were approved for public release. The rest would remain restricted in the archive.

10

The following Sunday a cultural stage was erected at Pipra's weekly market. The organisers had heard that someone from the city had come to "save an old raga." They summoned Harihar to the stage. "Baba, five minutes. Let Pipra hear its authentic raga."

Harihar asked, "Will it become authentic in five minutes?"

The organiser laughed. "People will not listen much longer."

A sponsor's cloth banner hung behind the stage. Plastic flowers stood before the microphone. The announcer proclaimed, "Now you will hear Pipra's ancient, pure, endangered Uttarahi Raga."

From behind the crowd Naina heard every word. No one had evidence that it was "ancient"; "pure" was itself contested; and after calling it "endangered," Harihar was sitting on the stage alive and ready to sing. For one moment she thought that an introduction could be more dangerous than a recording.

Taking the microphone, Harihar began with this sentence: "Whether this raga is ancient, I do not know. What 'pure' means, I do not know either. My elder sister Kusuma taught me one movement. Today I will sing what I remember."

From behind the stage the organiser looked at Naina as though the event were slipping out of his hands. Naina said nothing.

Harihar began to sing. A vegetable seller called out from the market, a child laughed, the microphone shrieked once. When five minutes were up, the organiser signalled. Harihar stopped in the middle of a turn and said, "Time is over."

People burst into laughter. Someone applauded. Someone called, "Go on!"

Harihar looked at the organiser. Helplessly, the organiser waved his hand. The song ran for seven minutes.

After he came down, Naina said, "You did not object to the word 'endangered.'"

"If I correct every long introduction, when will I sing?"

"But people will remember precisely that."

"Then you write. I sing."

Naina did not like this answer. For the first time she understood that the work of a documentarian was not only to capture sound, but also to watch the true and false sentences being built around it. She went to the organiser and asked him to remove "pure" and "endangered" from the next notice. He asked, "Then what attraction will remain?"

Naina answered, "The music."

The organiser looked at her as though the answer were impractical.

11

Naina now wanted to test her own learning. One evening she said to Harihar, "Today I will sing. Do not stop me in the middle."

Harihar agreed. Evening was descending over the ghat. The decorations left from Chhath had been removed. In one corner a round mark from the leg of Badri Kaka's red chair still remained in the earth, though the chair itself was gone. A last thin line of sunlight lay over the river.

Naina raised the first note. Harihar closed his eyes. She tried to push out of mind Kusuma's old recording, Harihar's clean take, the household take, and three days of practice. She tried to place the note on the wind. The first turn was good. In the second her voice returned a little toward the straight line of her city training. In the third she let it loosen by itself.

It was not a whole song, only the movement. After five minutes she stopped.

Harihar opened his eyes.

"Where were the mistakes?" Naina asked.

"In two places."

"And the good parts?"

"In three."

"So altogether five places?"

"A raga is not arithmetic."

"You escaped again."

Harihar laughed. "What you did at the third turn, I do not do."

Naina's face fell. "Then it was a mistake?"

"No. If you do it again, we will see whether it is a mistake or your path."

Naina could not decide whether this was praise or warning. But for the first time she understood that learning did not mean becoming an exact copy. If exact copying were the aim, a machine would be more qualified.

12

The next day Harihar's granddaughter Munni came home from school and began looking at Naina's recorder. She was twelve. She asked Naina, "Will Baba stay inside this?"

"His voice will."

"Not Baba?"

"No."

Munni looked a little disappointed. Then she put on the headphones and listened to the clean take. After half a minute she removed them. "Baba does not sing like this."

Naina was startled. "How does he sing?"

"At home he says 'hmm' in the middle, coughs, scolds me. In this he is too straight."

Harihar had been listening from the veranda. “See?”

Naina played the second take. This time Munni smiled. Her own laughter was caught in the background.

“That is me!”

“Yes.”

“Did you write my name?”

Naina stopped. In the file notes she had written “child laughter.” She opened the notebook and asked, “Your full name?”

“Mrinalini. But everyone calls me Munni.”

Harihar said slowly, “The lineage of a raga is more difficult than a Panji.”

This time Naina did not write down the sentence. She simply added Munni’s name.

Munni wanted to learn the tune from her grandfather. Harihar said, “First listen.”

Munni listened for five seconds and immediately imitated him. Her note climbed too high. Harihar did not stop her. She did it a second time. Then he said, “Turn back a little here.”

Munni asked, “Forgot the key?”

Naina burst out laughing. The metaphor had reached the household.

13

Once Naina understood that the Uttarahi in Harihar’s account came through Kusuma, she also asked to listen to older women in Pipra. Sarita invited three to the courtyard one evening—Sonvati Kaki, Jagrani Devi, and Phulkumari. All three had known Kusuma; all three remembered differently.

Sonvati said, “Kusuma used to sing this movement at a bride’s farewell.”

Jagrani corrected her at once. “Not at a farewell—when the rains were coming.”

Phulkumari laughed. “Neither of you remembers the time. She slipped it into whatever she felt like singing.”

Harihar sat silent on the veranda. Before taking out the recorder, Naina asked permission from all three. Sonvati asked, “My voice is bad. Will it be played in the city?”

Naina said, “If you do not want it to be, it will not. It can remain only in the archive.”

“Then what is the use of singing?”

Jagrani said, “Leave aside the use. First let us see who remembers what.”

All three began singing. Through the first line they were almost together. At the second turn Sonvati went up, Jagrani stayed low, Phulkumari changed a word

in the middle. Naina's ears, which had spent all these days searching for a "foundation," suddenly grew very alert.

"Which version is right?" she asked without thinking.

All three laughed together.

Sonvati said, "If Kusuma were alive we would ask her, and perhaps she too would sing a fourth."

For the first time Harihar spoke from the veranda. "That is why I stopped you earlier over 'one clean take.'"

Naina remembered her old insistence. Yet the clean take no longer seemed useless; it simply was not the sole truth. She kept all three versions in separate files and did not call them merely "variant 1/2/3"; she recorded names, contexts, memories, and disagreements.

When the recording ended, Phulkumari asked, "Will writing so much save the song?"

Naina said, "Not completely. But what we heard will not disappear."

Jagrani smiled. "And what you did not hear?"

Naina answered, "I will leave an empty place for it."

From a distance Harihar nodded. It was praise.

14

At night in her room, Naina also tried to write the Uttarahi melody in notation. Her musical training gave her some device for nearly everything—symbols for notes, curved lines for meend, measures for pauses. She kept adding sa, re, ga, arrows, curves, dots. After half an hour the page was so full of signs that it looked more like a map than a song.

The next morning she placed the paper before Harihar.

"What is this?"

"Your melody."

Harihar put on his glasses and studied it for a long time. "Do I do this much work while I sing?"

"Not work—movement. Look, here the note rises."

"On the paper."

"In the song too."

Harihar put a finger on one curved line. "This?"

"Where you bend the note."

"And this small dot?"

"A pause."

Harihar held the paper farther away. "Good. If someone can read it."

Naina asked, "You think it is useless?"

“No. A map of a field is not the field. Does that mean the map should be torn up?”

Naina fell silent. This time Harihar’s metaphor was on her side.

He called Munni. “Look at this. Didi says you can read it and sing the raga.”

Munni spent five minutes learning the symbols, then sang the first line. Seeing the arrow, she pushed the note too high. Harihar laughed. Naina corrected her. The second time was better. The third time Munni left the page and watched her grandfather’s mouth.

In her notebook Naina wrote: “Notation is a support; not a substitute for living performance.” Then she crossed it out. “Not a substitute” sounded too final. She wrote another sentence: “Notation is one path; listening another.”

Harihar heard her read it aloud. “And singing?”

Naina added a third: “Singing is a third.”

“And changing?” Munni asked.

Naina laughed. “That is the fourth, which arrives by itself.”

This time Harihar laughed loudly. “Now you may return to the city.”

15

The day of Naina’s departure from Pipra drew near. Her bag held a dozen files; her notebook held names, consent forms, a digital copy of Kusuma’s cassette, Harihar’s two takes, Naina’s practice, Munni’s first attempt. In the technical sense, much had been “preserved.”

But on the morning of her departure, Harihar refused to sing. “Not today.”

“Why?”

“I do not feel like it.”

At first Naina was concerned—health? voice? Then she understood that sometimes the reason was simply desire. She did not take out the recorder.

Before catching the bus, she went to the ghat. The mist was thin. Tarini the tea seller was opening his cart. Two boats lay at the bank. In the distance Munni came running in her school uniform.

“Didi!”

Breathless, she said, “Baba sent this for you.” In her hand was a small piece of paper.

In Harihar’s trembling hand were only four lines—no full lyrics, only memory cues: “First note on the wind. Do not hurry the second turn. At the third, find your own path. Listen before naming.”

Naina read the note and asked, “Baba did not come?”

“He said farewell is not done by singing.”

“Is that his rule?”

Munni shrugged. “Tomorrow he will say something else.”

Both laughed.

16

Three months later Harihar went to sing at a wedding in Pipra. Naina was not there. Munni sat beside him. In the middle of the song, when Harihar's breath caught, Munni picked up a line. Her voice was raw, her pronunciation still carried childhood, and at the third turn there was the very new twist Naina had once made on an evening at the ghat. Harihar looked at her for a moment. He did not stop her.

Someone was making a video on a mobile phone. Someone else was simply listening. Someone got up to see the food line. Someone asked, "Which raga is this?"

Harihar answered, "Call it Uttarahi."

"The real name?"

"The name is as real as any of us."

Lamps burned in the wedding courtyard. The flame trembled in the wind and straightened again. A red dot glowed on the mobile-phone screen. Far away in the city, the files on Naina's archive server remained still in their places—with date, name, duration, consent, and notes. In Pipra at that moment the melody was not still. From Harihar's mouth to Munni's, from Munni's to the ear of another child sitting nearby, and from there perhaps onward.

Something had been saved; something was changing. The answer to which of these deserved to be called "preserved" was not written in the file.

As night deepened and they walked home, Harihar said to Munni, "Sing the third turn again."

Munni sang it.

"Like this?"

Harihar listened for a while. "Again."

Munni sang it a second time. This time it was different from the first.

Harihar smiled. "Good. Remember now—every difference is not a mistake. But every difference is not a new path either."

"How will I know?"

Harihar looked up at the sky, then toward the ghat in the darkness, where the light from a small lamp at someone's house trembled upon the water.

"Sing, listen, then sing again."

They kept walking. Behind them the wedding song faded. The road ahead was not fully in light, but there was as much light as they needed to see.

STORY 18

The Court

Testimony 1 — Badri Narayan Jha, President, Pipra Ghat Committee

Question — Since when do you first remember seeing the disputed strip?

Answer — It is difficult to say since when I have been seeing it. For as long as I can remember, people descended to the ghat from that spot. When I was a child, my father would take me by the hand to offer arghya at Chhath. The line of people went down to the right of the peepal tree. The bamboo posts driven there now are new; the path is old.

Question — Are you saying that the land belongs to the committee or to the public ghat?

Answer — I am saying that it is used by the people. You will examine whose name stands in the papers. I am not giving testimony about the papers. But the people of Pipra never treated that strip as anyone's courtyard. Chhath, cremations, boarding boats, unloading relief sacks during floods—all took place there.

Question — Were you president of the committee during the last Chhath?

Answer — I was. If you have already assumed that this means I shall lie, why ask me to testify?

Question — Did the committee drive four bamboo posts into the disputed strip and tie a rope between them?

Answer — To manage the crowd. Not to establish permanent possession. The rope was removed the day after the worship ended.

Question — But an iron post was also driven there.

Answer — The contractor put it in for his own convenience. I had objected. It was removed later.

Question — Ramdev Mandal's family says that their ancestors once grew mustard there.

Answer — Mustard used to be grown at many places along the river. It may once have been grown there too. But the fact that it was a field does not mean the path to the ghat should be closed.

Question — Does your committee place its donation box on that strip?

Answer — For the four days of Chhath. Beside my red chair.

Question — How old is your red chair?

Answer — Will the age of a chair decide who owns the land? Then write this down as well—the chair is three years old, my knees are seventy years old.

Question — Just answer the question.

Answer — I have. But if you try to understand the ghat only by measurement, the river will become the greatest witness of all. If you can summon it, do so.

Testimony 2 — Ramdev Mandal, Plaintiff

Question — What is your claim?

Answer — The six-dhur strip southeast of the peepal was cultivated by my grandfather, Shivlal Mandal. We have old revenue receipts. After Grandfather died it came to Father, and after Father to me. When the river cut the land and when it laid down sand are separate matters. Land does not disappear from a name simply because the river changes.

Question — How old are the receipts?

Answer — One is from 1968, one from 1972, and there was a later receipt in Father's box that was half ruined in a flood.

Question — Is the plot number legible on the receipts?

Answer — On the first one, yes. On the second, the ink has spread.

Question — The plot number on the first receipt does not match the present map.

Answer — The present map was made after the river had changed. Look at the old map.

Question — Have people continued using that strip to reach the ghat?

Answer — They have. I did not stop them. Grandfather did not stop them either. Does allowing someone a path mean donating the land?

Question — Was any fee ever taken?

Answer — Not for unloading goods from boats. But some people putting up temporary stalls would drive bamboo poles there, and Father would take rent from them. Tarini, the tea seller, has paid it.

Question — Tarini has also paid fees to the committee.

Answer — The committee came later. People holding a function on someone else's land can also collect money in the name of cleaning. That does not make them owners.

Question — During the last Chhath, did you cut the rope?

Answer — I untied the rope at one end; I did not cut it. People had driven bamboo into my field.

Question — Was there an argument in the crowd?

Answer — Yes. Badri Kaka called me a 'seller of the ghat.' I called him the 'committee king.' That was all.

Question — What do you seek from this suit?

Answer — First, it should be recorded that the land is mine. I have never said the path to the ghat should be closed. If people have always walked there, let them continue. But it is not right to erase someone's name merely by saying, 'people walk here.'

Testimony 3 — Subhadra Devi, approximately seventy-five years old

Question — Do you remember use of the disputed strip?

Answer — I first went down that way for Chhath after my marriage. My mother-in-law told me, 'Walk slowly on this side; the sand is soft.' That was about fifty-five years ago. The peepal was large then, but the present peepal is not the same tree.

Question — Is the present peepal a different tree?

Answer — Yes. The old tree was half uprooted in a flood. It stood for a few more years, then fell. The present tree was planted near it. I never measured how many cubits this way or that.

Question — Did Shivlal Mandal cultivate that land?

Answer — I have seen mustard there. But along the river, wherever sand rose up, people sowed it. Women did not discuss exactly where one man's field ended and another began. Our work was to clear the path for worship, carry thekua down, and mind the children. Men discussed ownership in their gatherings.

Question — Were you ever stopped?

Answer — Not on Chhath. Once on an ordinary day Shivlal's son said, 'Do not walk through the crop.' I went around to the ghat. If I were now to say whether that crop stood on the disputed strip or beside it, I would be lying.

Question — In your memory, was that strip public?

Answer — We did not use the word 'public' then. There was a path. It would also be wrong to say that people of every caste descended by exactly the same way. Some families went down from the lower side. Everyone going down together now is something new. It is difficult to make the past perfectly clear in today's words.

Question — Whose side are you on?

Answer — My knees are on my side; if they let me descend the ghat, I shall descend. You decide whose land it is. But do not turn what I say into anyone's flag. I have told you what I saw.

Testimony 4 — Jagdish Prasad, Retired Amin [Land Surveyor]

Question — Have you examined the old maps?

Answer — By order of the court I examined the three copies available: a photocopy of the survey map, a later copy from the Circle Office, and a hand-drawn demarcation sheet. The reference points of the three are not identical. The main difficulty is the river. In the old survey the channel is shown farther west; it has now shifted east.

Question — Does the disputed six-dhur strip fall in Plot 217 or in the ghat path?

Answer — A one-word answer would be technically wrong. If you take the old peepal as the reference point, you get one result; if you take the present peepal,

another. But according to Subhadra Devi's testimony, the two trees are different. The map says 'peepal'; it gives no coordinates.

Question — Does river erosion alter plot boundaries?

Answer — A paper boundary and the physical ground are different matters. A river may cut away land and later deposit sand. The court will decide the legal consequence for ownership; I can speak to the landform.

Question — Are Ramdev Mandal's receipts useful?

Answer — They indicate payment of land revenue. But the area entered on the receipts belongs to a larger holding; they do not independently identify this small disputed strip.

Question — And the old photograph produced by the committee?

Answer — It shows steps and a crowd, not a boundary.

Question — Did you inspect the site?

Answer — Yes, twice. The water was low the first time; the river had risen the second. Between my first measurement and the second, the waterline was seven cubits farther forward. If anyone treated the waterline as the boundary, the owner of seven cubits would change in seven days.

Question — Then you will give no conclusion?

Answer — Giving a conclusion is my work, but stating the limits of that conclusion is also my work. I can say only this: from the maps available, the disputed strip cannot be identified on the present ground with complete certainty. Anyone who says it is 'absolutely clear' is reading his own confidence more than the map.

Testimony 5 — Tarini Sah, Tea Seller

Question — How long have you sold tea at the ghat?

Answer — Seventeen years. First from a basket, then from a cart. During Chhath I hardly sleep for three nights.

Question — Who gave you permission to place your cart?

Answer — The answer changes by year. The first time, Ramdev's father said, 'Do not break the field ridge; keep it there for two days.' I paid him twenty rupees. No receipt. Later the committee was formed and there were cleaning fees, electricity fees, bamboo fees—the names changed, the money kept being paid.

Question — Did you regard Ramdev's family as the owner?

Answer — When I paid twenty rupees, what I thought was that there should be no trouble. Whether I regarded him as owner or simply as the powerful neighbour is difficult to say now. A small shopkeeper first looks at who can overturn his cart.

Question — And when you paid the committee?

Answer — The committee gave a receipt, but it said 'sanitation contribution,' not land rent.

Question — Has your cart stood on the disputed strip?

Answer — During two Chhaths. The third year Badri Kaka said, 'The crowd will turn here,' and moved me ten cubits north. The next year Ramdev said, 'My mustard used to grow here.' I told him, 'If mustard grew here, it could have come to drink tea.' He laughed. There was not so much litigation then.

Question — Whose side are you on?

Answer — My side is wherever I can place my stove. If the court gives it to the committee, I shall pay the committee; if it gives it to Ramdev, I shall pay Ramdev. But if the path is closed, my customers will decrease, so I want the path open. Write down that self-interest. Let no one later say Tarini was an impartial saint.

Testimony 6 — Budhan Sahni, Boatman

Question — What do you know about the disputed land?

Answer — Less about the land, more about the water. I have run a boat for twenty-four years. The ghat has one name; the ground does not stay in one place. The steps that are in the middle now had boats mooring to their right ten years ago. Before that, farther east.

Question — According to Ramdev Mandal's claim, the strip was his field.

Answer — It may have been. When the river retreated, people sowed. When it advanced, boats came in. Have I seen fields cut away? Yes. Which field was Ramdev's and which belonged to his agnates, I never examined the papers.

Question — The committee says this has always been the ghat path.

Answer — A boatman does not say 'always.' The river would laugh at that word. But it is true that people have descended in this direction for many years.

Question — An old stone slab is said to be a boundary marker. Have you seen it?

Answer — I have. But the stone now near the peepal used to be a little lower down.

Question — Who moved it?

Answer — The flood. Or people after the flood. I did not see the stone moving with my own eyes. After the 2019 flood it was found higher up. Four men can lift it; water can too.

Question — Did you see anyone lifting the stone?

Answer — No.

Question — Then saying 'people' is an inference.

Answer — Yes, an inference. Write 'inference.' With a river, calling inference truth is dangerous.

Question — Why do you want the path open?

Answer — To moor boats. Corpses will come, passengers will come, relief sacks will come in floods. If a wall goes up across five cubits, I shall moor

somewhere else. The river will not stop me, but old people will have to walk ten cubits farther. Whoever owns the land, the question of use of the path is separate.

Testimony 7 — Champa Paswan, Sanitation Worker

Question — What is your relationship with the ghat committee?

Answer — Before Chhath, my group and I clean the place. Sweeping, removing mud, picking up broken glass, washing the steps. The committee pays wages—sometimes on time, sometimes two weeks later.

Question — Have you worked on the disputed strip as well?

Answer — More there than anywhere. People set up carts, throw leaf plates, flowers rot. Before the bamboo was driven in last Chhath, we levelled the soil there.

Question — Did the committee tell you the land was public?

Answer — Badri Babu used to say, 'This ghat belongs to everyone.' But I did not hear the word 'everyone's' in childhood. My mother observed Chhath, but she was made to use the lower slope. Some people objected to her using the upper steps. The committee now says everyone is equal. That is a good thing. But if I testify about old usage, I must also say that usage was not equal.

Question — Did Ramdev Mandal's family ever stop you?

Answer — Not from cleaning. Once we piled mud on the disputed side and Ramdev said, 'Do not dump it in my part.' The committee said, 'It belongs to everyone.' I asked, 'Then why does everyone not pay our wages?' Both went silent.

Question — In your view, whose land is it?

Answer — If you ask for my view: the name on the land will be decided by the papers. My testimony is that my hands worked there, but my hands did not become owners. People worshipped there, but worship is not a seal of title. Ramdev may have sown mustard, but mustard does not grow carrying a certificate either.

Question — Whose side are you on?

Answer — I am on the side of not letting the court hear the old word 'everyone's' and assume everyone had equal rights in the old days. For the rest, read the papers yourselves.

Testimony 8 — Shivanand Jha, Priest

Question — How old is the religious use?

Answer — Since my guru's time; his guru spoke of it too. Chhath, water for shraddha, bathing after cremation—the use of the ghat is old. People descend through the disputed strip.

Question — Is there any record in the temple registers of land being donated?

Answer — One old ledger says 'donation for repair of the ghat.' There are three donor names. It is a donation of money, not land.

Question — The committee cites this ledger as evidence that the land was public.

Answer — Then the committee is reading too much into it. I will say what the ledger contains, not what it does not.

Question — Is the name of Ramdev's grandfather Shivlal in the ledger?

Answer — Yes. Five rupees one year for repairs to the steps.

Question — Does that mean he accepted it as a public ghat?

Answer — A private landowner may donate to repair a public ghat; and someone who is not a private landowner may donate too. A donation reveals intention, not boundary.

Question — Was the peepal tree treated as a ritual boundary?

Answer — People placed lamps there. But the old peepal fell and a new one was planted. I heard that from my guru; I did not see it myself.

Question — What is your personal wish?

Answer — That the ghat remain open, that temple-goers have access. But wish and testimony are separate. If in the name of religion we take someone else's land, that is not service to religion. And if a private name is used to block an old path, that too seems wrong. Both questions are before the court.

Testimony 9 — Malati Devi, Seller of Flowers and Worship Materials

Question — Do you set up a stall beside the disputed strip?

Answer — On Chhath, on Mondays, sometimes on wedding days. Not permanently. My shop is as wide as the cloth I spread.

Question — Who gives permission?

Answer — I listen to whoever comes first and scolds me. Sometimes the committee, sometimes Ramdev. You may laugh at the answer, but that is how rules at the ghat have operated.

Question — Have you ever paid rent to Ramdev?

Answer — Not directly. Twice I gave flower garlands free to his wife. Whether that was rent or neighbourliness, I cannot say.

Question — To the committee?

Answer — Fifty rupees for cleaning. I have the receipt.

Question — What happened on the day of the dispute?

Answer — Bamboo was being driven in. Ramdev came and said, 'Drive it two cubits inward.' Badri Kaka said, 'Not by a finger.' The contractor stood between them. I kept selling flowers. Customers began watching the spectacle. In the end the bamboo was not uprooted; it was tilted a little and driven again.

Question — On whose instructions?

Answer — That is exactly what I did not understand. Badri Kaka said it was his instruction; Ramdev said his demand had been accepted. The contractor said,

'The ground was firm here, so I put it here.' All three went home believing they had won.

Question — Was the strip used as a path?

Answer — Yes. But to me 'path' and 'ownership' are not the same thing. My neighbour has crossed my courtyard for twenty years to fetch water; that has not made the courtyard hers. But if I suddenly put up a wall, she will say, 'You have blocked my path.' Both things can be true together.

Testimony 10 — Shashikant Thakur, Assistant, Circle Records Room

Question — Describe the condition of the available government records.

Answer — An old copy for Khata 41, Plot 217 is available. The edge of the original register was damaged by floodwater. The names are legible—Shivlal Mandal and two agnates. The area is clear. But the boundary description says, 'North—the old channel of the river.' The present channel is different.

Question — Is there a separate plot for the ghat path?

Answer — The map shows a narrow public path, but its position on the present ground is disputed.

Question — Has Ramdev Mandal obtained mutation?

Answer — An application was filed. It was not fully approved. The note says, 'Boundary verification required.'

Question — Has the committee filed any application calling the land government land?

Answer — There is an application for a ghat beautification scheme. It describes the land status as 'under public use,' not 'government-owned.'

Question — Who wrote those words?

Answer — Whoever prepared the application. The office did not verify ownership.

Question — Then what do the government papers establish?

Answer — They establish that papers too leave questions. The khata points toward private names; the path symbol toward public passage; the old river channel makes the boundary uncertain; mutation is incomplete.

Question — When were the records damaged?

Answer — In a flood year. Some pages were dried; some copies were made later.

Question — Is there a possibility that the copies were altered?

Answer — It is easy to speak of possibility. Evidence is required. Writing in different ink may also date from restoration. I saw records being preserved, not falsified. But the original page is incomplete, so I would not claim complete certainty.

Testimony 11 — Deepak Kumar, Photo-Shop Owner

Question — Is the photograph of the 1998 Chhath produced by the committee from your father's studio?

Answer — Yes. The negative was found in an old box at my shop. Father used to take photographs at the ghat.

Question — Does the photograph show the peepal, the steps, and the disputed strip?

Answer — It does, but from an oblique angle. The print had been cropped to wedding-photo size. The full negative shows more on the right.

Question — Did you digitally enhance it?

Answer — I removed dust and increased contrast between light and dark. I added no object.

Question — The committee says the photograph proves there was no field then.

Answer — The photograph is from Chhath in Kartik. Mustard is small at that time; the picture shows sand and people. No field is visible, but the photograph does not show all six disputed dhurs.

Question — Ramdev says the peepal in the photograph is the old tree and the present peepal is another.

Answer — The trunk in the old photograph is very large. The present tree is smaller. It is difficult to believe they are the same tree.

Question — Can you measure the distance?

Answer — No. The camera lens, angle, and cropped frame all matter. If you try to measure land from the size of someone's head, the result may be entertaining, not useful.

Question — Does your shop receive work from the committee?

Answer — I print posters for them. I also photographed Ramdev's son's wedding. Both are customers. If being a customer makes one a party, I belong to both sides.

Question — What does the photograph say?

Answer — It says that people were there that day; there were lamps, a peepal, and steps. It does not say whose name stood on the land papers. Trust the photograph for what it shows; do not ask it what lay outside the frame.

Testimony 12 — Harinandan Yadav, Construction Mason

Question — What work did the committee give you before the last Chhath?

Answer — Two temporary bamboo railings, a small wooden platform, and filling a broken corner of the steps. A permanent iron post was not in the order.

Question — Then who drove in the iron post?

Answer — I did. The bamboo kept coming loose, so I hammered in an old iron pipe. I thought I would remove it after Chhath.

Question — Did Badri Kaka give permission?

Answer — He said, 'Make it strong.' He did not say the word 'pipe.'

Question — Did Ramdev object?

Answer — He did. He said move it two cubits back. Badri Kaka said, 'The old line is right here.' I asked where the marker for the old line was. One said the peepal, the other the stone. The peepal and the stone are not on one straight line.

Question — What did you finally do?

Answer — I removed the pipe and drove it again one and a half cubits north because the ground was harder there. To tell the truth, reducing the quarrel was also a reason.

Question — Did you later take measurements for the court?

Answer — No. I am a mason, not an amin. But both sides told me, 'You know where the line was.' I know where I drove the pipe. I do not know who owns the land.

Question — Did the committee pay you in full?

Answer — Half remains due.

Question — Then you are angry with the committee?

Answer — My wages are due, so yes, I am angry. That does not move the place where I drove the pipe. You are entitled to think that if Ramdev paid me, I would lie for his side; but keep the account of my stomach separate from the account of my eyes.

Testimony 13 — Rekha Kumari, Teacher at the Local School

Question — Why has the school's old project map come before the court?

Answer — Nineteen years ago, students made a hand-drawn map of the settlement called 'Our Pipra.' I was a new teacher then. The children marked the ghat, temple, post office, old peepal, boat landing, and fields. One copy survived at the school.

Question — The disputed strip is labelled 'ghat ground' on the map.

Answer — The children wrote that. It is not a government survey.

Question — Is it not evidence of local memory?

Answer — It is evidence of memory, not ownership. Children write the names by which they know places. My student Manoj wrote 'Badri Kaka's Square' even though the square was not Badri Kaka's private property.

Question — Where is Ramdev's field on the map?

Answer — A green area marked 'Mandal Field' lies south of the disputed strip. The boundary was drawn with a thick coloured pencil; an error of five cubits would be easy.

Question — Whose accounts did the students listen to while making the map?

Answer — Their families', their neighbours', and their own experience. I corrected some things, such as the direction of the post office. Not land boundaries.

Question — What do you personally remember?

Answer — During the school's pre-Chhath cleaning, children used to paint on the disputed strip. Once Ramdev's father said, 'Do not let the paint spread toward the field.' I moved the children two cubits away. That day I assumed the field was nearby. Whether the field reached into the strip or lay beside it, my memory is blurred now.

Question — Your student Manoj is now a member of the committee?

Answer — Yes. He posted this map on social media calling it 'old evidence.' I wrote beneath his post, 'School project, not revenue map.' That comment later disappeared. I do not know who removed it.

Testimony 14 — Manoj Kumar, Young Member of the Ghat Committee

Question — Did you share the school map online?

Answer — I did, so people could see an old memory.

Question — Did you write, 'Here is the proof that the ghat has always been public'?

Answer — In enthusiasm, the words may have grown larger than they should. I edited the post later.

Question — Did you remove Teacher Rekha's comment?

Answer — It may have disappeared when I changed the post. Not deliberately.

Question — Did you make a video of Ramdev during the dispute at the last Chhath?

Answer — Yes. He was untying the rope.

Question — The video is before the court. The first thirty-two seconds are missing.

Answer — It took me time to start the phone.

Question — A video from another phone shows that committee members had first extended the bamboo toward Ramdev's field.

Answer — There was a crowd. The angle is different.

Question — Did you say, 'This time we shall settle the boundary'?

Answer — I may have. I meant the boundary for crowd management, not the legal boundary.

Question — Does your committee want a grant for beautification of the ghat?

Answer — Yes. Railings, lights, waste bins, toilets.

Question — Would it help the grant application if the land were undisputed?

Answer — Certainly.

Question — Then you have an interest in having the strip treated as public.

Answer — Call it self-interest or Pipra's convenience. I want the ghat developed. But that does not make what I have seen false. I have seen people walk there. I have not read the land papers.

Question — Does Badri Kaka's red chair stand on the disputed strip?

Answer — Sometimes on Chhath.

Question — Where will you place it next Chhath?

Answer — If the court says so, outside it. A chair can be moved; a river cannot.

Testimony 15 — Bhagirathi Devi, approximately eighty-two years old

Question — What do you know about the old peepal?

Answer — I did not see it being planted; by the time I became aware of the world, the tree was large. I played among its roots as a child. The present peepal was planted when my sons were young men. Not after the old tree fell—some time before, because half the old tree had dried out.

Question — Where was the new tree planted?

Answer — To the southeast of the old one.

Question — At what distance?

Answer — Four cubits? Six? Do not rely on the measure of my hands now. Nobody was measuring for a court case then.

Question — Who planted it?

Answer — Shivlal Mandal, Badri's father, and two or three young men. Together.

Question — Ramdev's grandfather Shivlal?

Answer — Yes. No one asked caste or faction while planting a tree.

Question — And the stone said to be a boundary marker?

Answer — There was a flat stone on which women rested their water pots. Later people began calling it a 'boundary.' It may have been a boundary too; no one told me so then.

Question — Did Shivlal cultivate there?

Answer — He did. When the river retreated, mustard and khesari. Badri's father also sowed nearby. The men may have known which line belonged to whom. But for the three days of Chhath, Shivlal himself cut through the ridge to widen the path.

Question — Was that a donation?

Answer — No one used the word donation. It was a path for worship. The next week he might raise the ridge again. Sometimes he did, sometimes not.

Question — In your view, was the land private or public?

Answer — You have made two boxes—private and public. In the old village some things operated between the two. A name could belong to one person, use to many; responsibility to one, a right to another; fear of the river to everyone. If the law now requires two boxes, you may put it into one of them. My memory will not fit completely inside either.

Question — Is Ramdev related to you through your daughter's family?

Answer — Distantly. Badri is also distantly related. Pipra is small; if relationship ruins testimony, summon a crow from outside the village to testify.

Testimony 16 — Anita Devi, Wife of Ramdev Mandal

Question — Where did you find the old receipts?

Answer — In my mother-in-law's iron box. When the roof of the house was being replaced, I separated the papers. Cloth had rotted, the ledger was wet. Two receipts were stuck between sheets of paper. I dried them slowly and separated them.

Question — Did you know about this land before?

Answer — After I married into the family I used to hear that the 'field by the ghat' belonged to us. But which five cubits and which seven, no. Men discussed land in the household. When floods came, women first saved grain and children. Papers came later.

Question — After finding the receipts, did you advise filing the suit?

Answer — I said, 'Look at the papers first, then quarrel.' Ramdev first wanted a village meeting with the committee. Three meetings were held, with no conclusion. Then came the suit.

Question — The committee says your family used to take money from people setting up shops at the ghat.

Answer — During Chhath my mother-in-law took straw, bamboo, or a rupee or two from two or three families. Whether that was rent or the price of materials, I was not present every time. There was no separate household ledger for it.

Question — Do you want to close the path?

Answer — No. My daughter observes Chhath. If the path is closed, how will she go down? But when the committee put up a board saying 'Pipra Public Ghat Area,' the line of that board reached into our mustard. After seeing it I told Ramdev that if we stayed silent, one day even our name would disappear from the papers.

Question — Is the board still there?

Answer — No. It fell in a storm, and the committee took it away.

Question — Your self-interest is to preserve the land?

Answer — Yes. Why hide it? But having an interest does not make the receipts forged; and the receipts being genuine does not prove that all six dhurs still lie in exactly the same place. That much I understand.

Question — Do you know where the old peepal stood?

Answer — My mother-in-law used to say the new peepal was east of the old one. But when she said it, I did not pay attention. Now that same sentence has acquired value in court. Memory asks no price at the time; later everyone wants to buy it.

Testimony 17 — Rajkishore Yadav, Former Panchayat Secretary

Question — Are there any panchayat records concerning the ghat?

Answer — Two. A 1994 resolution for voluntary labour to repair the steps, and a 2004 approval of expenditure for cleaning and lighting the Chhath ghat.

Question — The first resolution calls the land 'village ghat.'

Answer — Yes. But panchayat resolutions often use the name of the use. Writing 'village ghat' does not automatically make revenue ownership belong to the panchayat.

Question — Was Shivlal Mandal present at that meeting?

Answer — There is a mark in the attendance sheet resembling his signature. An expert would be required for a definite identification; I am not an expert on his signature.

Question — If he was present and raised no objection, did he not accept public ownership?

Answer — The resolution concerned repair of steps, not determination of ownership. In old meetings many people signed without hearing every line. That was the panchayat's old practice; I am not praising it, merely describing it.

Question — Does the 2004 paper contain a measurement of the disputed strip?

Answer — No. Only, 'cleaning from the peepal to the ghat steps.'

Question — The present committee cites that resolution as the basis of its authority.

Answer — The present committee is not the panchayat. It is a community body. Panchayat cooperation with its Chhath arrangements does not transfer land to it.

Question — Did Ramdev's family ever pay tax to the panchayat?

Answer — Land revenue belongs to the Revenue Department. Panchayat house tax is separate. My records contain no separate tax for the ghat strip.

Question — Your personal relationship with Badri Kaka?

Answer — Twice we were on the same panel in panchayat elections, once on opposing sides. Ramdev's father cultivated my field. If you cut every web of relationship in Pipra, only migrants will remain to testify.

Question — What conclusion would you give?

Answer — Panchayat papers show long public use, but there is no line in any resolution saying that private ownership was extinguished. Any side that reads half a sentence for its own convenience will find its own truth. Read the full page and the question remains.

Testimony 18 — Nagina Khatun, Fish Seller

Question — Since when have you been coming to the ghat?

Answer — Since childhood with my mother. She sold river fish. Even now I come in the morning with my basket. I do not set up a stall in the Chhath crowd; those days are for different work.

Question — Did you use the disputed strip for passage?

Answer — I do now. Earlier, not every day. My mother used to say the upper path was crowded on worship days, so we should use the lower side. Sometimes someone stopped us, sometimes not.

Question — Who stopped you?

Answer — It would not be right to name one family. In the old days the ghat too was divided like society. Some looked at caste, some occupation, some only at their own convenience. Now people say 'the ghat belongs to everyone.' It is good to hear, but if you paste that sentence unchanged onto the past, my mother's experience disappears.

Question — What dealings did you have with Ramdev's father?

Answer — He bought fish. Once in the rains I put my basket on his ridge and he said, 'Save the paddy seedlings.' I moved it. I do not know whether that ridge was within the disputed strip.

Question — And with the committee?

Answer — The committee now calls women from my group too on cleaning days. Earlier only families who performed the worship made decisions. There has been change. That is why I want the path to remain open.

Question — Does an open path mean public land?

Answer — Not to me. On my way to market I pass in front of three houses; that does not make the three houses mine. But if a path used for twenty years is closed one day, my life changes. The name on the land and a right of passage may be two separate questions.

Question — For which side are you testifying?

Answer — The committee summoned me, but I do not know whether it will be pleased by what I say. Ramdev's family knows me too. I sell fish; from the smell of water I can tell whether fish is fresh or stale. From the smell of land papers I cannot tell the owner. That is your work.

Testimony 19 — Dayakant Mishra, Commissioner Appointed by the Court for Site Inspection

Question — What did you observe on the day of inspection?

Answer — The date was the eighteenth of Paush. I arrived at ten in the morning. Both sides were present. North of the disputed strip stood the present peepal; south, a small mustard field; east, the upper part of the steps; west, an unpaved path. The sides indicated different lines. The committee drew a straight line from the western roots of the peepal to the steps; the plaintiff drew another line beginning about five cubits north of the peepal.

Question — Was there any permanent boundary marker?

Answer — One flat stone, half buried in earth. Each side assigned it a different meaning. There were no letters on the stone. A hole from an old iron pipe was also visible, but according to the mason's testimony the pipe had been temporary.

Question — What was the measurement?

Answer — The maximum distance between the two claimed lines was five cubits and seven fingers. The total dispute is small, but it is important because it concerns entry to the ghat.

Question — What about public use?

Answer — During the two hours of inspection, fourteen people went toward the river through the strip—four women, five men, three children, and two boatmen. Two people, after being told by the plaintiff, did not step onto the mustard side. No one paid an entry fee. This is an observation from one day, not history.

Question — Any structure?

Answer — Wheel marks from a temporary tea cart, two old holes from bamboo poles, a heap of rotting flowers, and a fragment of a small clay lamp.

Question — Did you give an opinion on ownership?

Answer — No. My order was to record the condition of the site. The report also says: 'Conclusion on ownership is a matter for the court.'

Question — Did you inspect a second time?

Answer — Yes, in the evening, because both sides objected to the first report's description of the waterline. Seven days later the river had risen a little. Two steps were wet. The eastern corner of the disputed strip was damp.

Question — Did you see anything else that evening?

Answer — The temple arati had ended. Two women placed lamps at the ghat. One lamp caught at the corner of a step; the other entered the water and began drifting. The shadow of the present peepal did not reach the water; there was no visible sign of the stump of the old tree. Ramdev stood at a distance, and so did Badri Kaka. Neither spoke to the other.

Question — What relevance does that scene have to the suit?

Answer — None directly to ownership. You asked what else I saw, so I am telling you.

Question — Read the final line of your report.

Answer — 'The signs of use at the site are multiple; the boundary markers are not undisputed; the present river, the old map, and oral memory do not sit perfectly upon one and the same line.'

Question — Would you like to add anything?

Answer — Only this: during the first inspection everyone was showing me his own line. On the evening of the second inspection, no one tried to show me a line. Darkness was increasing. Lamplight trembled on the water, and the dispute

of five cubits and seven fingers became hard to distinguish with the eye. But because it was hard to see, I am not saying the line ceased to exist. Nor can I say that because the line exists on paper, it is perfectly clear on the earth.

STORY 19

Dom

1

In Pipra, water first arrives as news, then as sound, then as smell, and only after that inside the house.

For three days in the last week of Sawan there had been news that the Kamla was rising. At the market tea stall people counted the bridge piers, showed one another pictures of the upstream current on their phones, then went home and cleared the drains in their own courtyards. Sumitra listened too, but her work continued in the spaces between the listening. First she lifted the sacks of paddy onto the cot. When her back strained, she paused, then put the spices, oil, matches, and bundle of papers on the mud shelf in the room. She set bricks beneath the utensils. She tied the cow to a peg on the higher ground behind the house.

Her son Neelu received news of water as though it were news of a holiday. Fear of the river had not yet fully entered his nine-year-old body. With the other children of the lane he floated paper boats in the flowing water, then ran ahead to catch them. Sumitra called him inside twice. The third time, without calling, she took off his wet half-pants and spread them on the peg by the door.

By evening water glimmered in the southern corner of the courtyard. Whether it was drain water or river water was difficult to tell. Tiny bubbles rose through the ash of the hearth. Sumitra put rice on the stove, set aside one lota of clean water, and placed Neelu's schoolbag on top of the old iron trunk.

When her husband Raghav returned from the market, half his feet were caked in mud. He came inside, wrung out his wet gamchha, and said only, "We'll have to watch through the night."

Sumitra did not even say "yes." She was draining the starch from the rice.

Neelu opened his exercise book and sat at the table to write something. The electricity went once, returned, then went again. Sumitra took out the lantern and checked the oil. The wick was half gone. She cut a new wick from an old piece of cloth.

By ten at night the courtyard water had reached the ankles. By then neighbours had begun moving goats, children, grain, and bedding toward the high school building. Sumitra first lifted two sacks. Raghav stood one cot upright against the wall. Neelu wanted to walk in front holding the lantern. Sumitra took the lantern from his hand and slung a small bag on his back.

The bag held two sets of clothes, a steel bowl, his mathematics exercise book, and half a packet of flattened rice that Sumitra had stuffed in hurriedly.

By then the flood was no longer merely water. It had reordered the house. Things that always stayed below had been moved upward; the people who owned the house were preparing to leave it as guests.

2

On an ordinary day the way to the school took ten minutes. That night it took more than half an hour.

In the lane the water reached the knees. In some places it was shallower; in others it deepened suddenly. People walked holding bamboo poles. Someone had a sack on his head, someone a child against the chest. An old woman held a basket of hens tight to her stomach. From time to time someone raised a torch, then swept its light down over the water.

Sumitra kept hold of Neelu's arm. In her other hand was a bundle of clothes. Raghav followed carrying rice and a plastic sack of papers.

At one turn the water ran fast. There the cover of a municipal drain that had been dug earlier was missing. People had planted bamboo to mark the path. Sumitra set one foot beside a bamboo pole, then the other. Neelu between them. The boy had never been so quiet.

The school veranda was packed with people. They found space in Class Five. Four families were already on the floor. Sumitra spread a mat near the window. Before laying the bedding she touched the ground with her hand; it was damp. She spread newspaper and placed the mat on top. Neelu took off his bag and put it in a corner.

Sumitra did not sleep for the rest of the night. One moment she wiped Neelu's feet, another she checked the knots of the sacks, another she went to the veranda to see how high the water had risen. Outside in the dark there were only streaks from torches, and whenever lightning flashed the school field turned white for an instant.

By morning the water in the field was chest-deep.

Raghav wanted to go and see the house. Sumitra did not stop him. She only handed him an empty sack and a rope. Neelu held the iron bars of the window and watched outside. Wood, grass, plastic, cow-dung cakes, a broken shoe drifted past on the water.

Raghav returned in the afternoon. Water inside the house stood above the waist. A neighbour had untied the cow and sent it to the high embankment. Two sacks of paddy were soaked.

The moment Sumitra heard about the wet paddy, she pulled an empty sheet of plastic from beneath her mat. "It can be dried," she said.

That was all.

Neelu asked for flattened rice twice that day. The third time he wanted to wash the bowl himself. The school tap had gone under water; tanker water was limited. Sumitra took the bowl from him and wiped it with cloth.

On the second night the wind strengthened. The classroom filled with the mingled smell of bodies, wet clothes, oil, earth, and fear. Sumitra rested Neelu's head in her lap. The child slept. One hand hung outside the blanket. Sumitra gently lifted it and tucked it inside.

3

On the third day the water seemed still, but current keeps moving inside still water.

In the morning a relief boat arrived. Flattened rice, jaggery, candles, medicine. A crowd gathered on the school veranda. Raghav went to help with distribution. Sumitra did not stand in line; they still had flattened rice from the day before. To wash Neelu's clothes, she brought a bucket of relatively clean rainwater that had collected behind the school. The boy's half-pants, vest, towel —three things. She scrubbed carefully, saving soap.

Neelu was with the children at the other end of the veranda. Someone was setting bottle caps afloat and racing them. Someone had cut up a relief carton to make a boat. Sumitra looked up twice. The third time she did not.

At noon people shouted near the wall behind the school. It was not the main river current, but the water in the field had suddenly begun pulling in one direction. Perhaps some part of the earthen embankment behind had broken. People began calling the children inside.

Sumitra was wringing out the half-pants. She spread the cloth over the bucket and looked up.

Neelu was not where he had been five minutes earlier.

At first it did not seem unusual. Children change places. She walked from one end of the veranda to the other. Checked Class Four. Checked the stairs. Checked the way to the roof. Swept her eyes over the groups of boys. She quickened her step at the sight of a yellow shirt, then saw it was another child.

She reached Raghav. The wet vest was still in her hand.

"Where is Neelu?"

Raghav's face first understood the question, then the fear.

They went in different directions.

Someone said the children had gone behind the school. Someone said he had been seen in the crowd near the boat. Someone said he had gone inside the school. No one was certain.

Sumitra went to the back wall. The water there was flowing faster than before. Three children were crying at one corner of the wall, but Neelu was not among them. A young man had gone into the water with a bamboo pole. Another held the rope.

Sumitra took off her slippers. Someone stopped her. She did not stop. Knee, thigh, waist—the water rose. The current began taking her footing away. Raghav caught her arm from behind.

Sumitra tried to free her arm, but the strength of her body was less than the current.

At that moment someone shouted that something red was floating farther ahead. Four men ran. A boat was launched.

The red thing turned out to be a plastic bag.

Sumitra stared at that bag for a very long time.

4

The search began first with the name.

"Neelu."

People threw the name across the water. The school roof, the fields behind, the embankment, the mango grove, the old road, the temple mound. The boatmen called the name. Sumitra too could call, but after two or three times her voice closed up. After that she kept working with her hands.

She opened Neelu's bag. The mathematics exercise book was not wet. The bowl, two clothes, the flattened rice. She took everything out and tied it in one cloth. Someone said they needed a photograph. Sumitra took out the small school identity card kept behind the exercise book. The photograph was two years old. Neelu's front tooth was broken then; a new one had since grown. Sumitra looked at the photograph, then had his present identifying marks written on a sheet—an old cut mark on the right knee, a small mole behind the left ear.

The young man writing asked, "Age?"

Sumitra said nine. Then thought. The school paper said eight. The exact date of birth? She looked at Raghav. Raghav had lowered his head. In the end they wrote "about nine."

Even the age of a child lost in water became an estimate.

The first time Sumitra climbed into a boat it was growing dark. They seated her in the middle. Four men on the sides with bamboo poles and oars. River water and floodwater had merged; where there had been road and where field could be known only from people's memory. Electric wires sagged low. Of one roof only the upper edge was visible.

Sumitra kept watching the water's surface. Her eyes searched for colours—Neelu's blue shirt, black half-pants, skin, hair. But whatever floated on the water became for an instant something belonging to a child. A cloth. A sack. A box. A dead goat. A bamboo mat.

At the sight of the dead goat the boatman turned his eyes away. Sumitra did not.

When they returned to the school at night, someone gave her food. She took the plate. Broke off one mouthful of rice. Did not bring it to her mouth. Then pushed the plate toward Raghav.

She sat on Neelu's mat. A child's sleeping place had been so small; once empty, it seemed enormous.

5

For the next four days Sumitra's day ran not by the clock, but by the boats.

The first boat at dawn. The second at noon. Walking until evening wherever the water had receded. School at night.

Everywhere she repeated the same work. Showing the photograph. Saying the colour of the clothes. Describing the marks. Having the name written. Looking at hospital lists. Walking among children in relief camps. Turning whenever any name sounded familiar.

On the fifth day news came—a child had been found in a village downstream. Sumitra climbed into a boat. Halfway there rain began. She did not cover her head. When she arrived, the child was seven, not Neelu. His mother too had arrived searching. The two women looked at each other. Neither said anything.

On the way back, Sumitra straightened the wet sheet around that child.

On the sixth day there was news of a body. The age was similar. Raghav wanted to go; Sumitra went too.

What she saw there does not ask to be described. Only this: Sumitra looked at the right knee, looked behind the ear, then shook her head.

Not Neelu.

After returning, she lit a stove for the first time. A temporary hearth behind the school. The wet wood smoked. Sumitra blew on it again and again. Water ran from her eyes. Some thought it was smoke. Some thought another reason. Sumitra corrected no one.

She cooked rice. For Raghav, for herself. She took out a third bowl as well. After a while she put it back into the bag.

On the seventh day the boatman said the current might have carried him very far.

Sumitra did not answer. With her fingernail she kept scraping the mud dried on the boat plank.

6

On the tenth day the water began to recede.

People started returning to see their houses. The school slowly emptied. Families whose houses had collapsed stayed. Those whose walls had survived went to search for their belongings in the mud.

Sumitra and Raghav returned too. Inside the house a grey line ran across the wall above chest height—a straight mark of how high the water had reached. The cot overturned. The trunk shifted. The smell of swollen, rotting paddy. The calendar hanging on the wall half dissolved.

Sumitra did not pick up the broom first. She opened the door of Neelu's room. Mud inside. The trunk had been high enough to survive. She took down his schoolbag. The bag he had carried to the school was another one; this was his everyday schoolbag. The edges of the books had curled from damp. On the first page of one exercise book Neelu had written his name five times, each in a different size.

Sumitra closed the exercise book.

Then the work began.

She shoveled the mud from the courtyard. Scraped silt from the wall. Boiled utensils. Wet clothes separate. Rotten grain separate. Salvageable grain in the sun. She cleaned the stove three times. Changed the ash.

Women from the neighbourhood came to help. One picked up a broom without asking. One took the stove. One the clothes. Sumitra gave Neelu's clothes to no one.

She began washing them one by one. The white school shirt, its collar now grey. Blue trousers. The vest he wore at home. A small gamchha. A red sweater that was not for the season but had been wet at the bottom of the trunk.

She rubbed in soap, wrung them out, then put them in clean water. The muddy water was black at first, then pale. One stain on the white shirt would not come out. She soaped it again. The stain lightened a little. She rubbed it a third time.

A neighbour gently tried to hold her hand. Sumitra did not pull away; neither did she stop scrubbing.

The cloth of the shirt grew thin.

At last she wrung it out and spread it over a bamboo pole.

The sun had come out. Sunlight in Pipra after many days. Clothes lay spread on every roof, wire, bamboo, bush. The whole town seemed to be drying its soaked body.

Neelu's shirt too was taking the air.

7

There was no single date on which the search ended.

The boats gradually shifted to distributing relief. The police lists filled with newer incidents. News of searches in the downstream villages grew sparse. At first people asked Sumitra whenever they saw her, "Any news?" Then the question came less often. In the end people asked only with their eyes.

Sumitra herself did not search less; the form of her search changed.

When she went to the market, she looked into crowds of children. Boys getting off buses at the stand. Temple steps. The school prayer line. Groups of outside labourers who had arrived after the flood. If someone from behind walked like Neelu, she quickened her pace by two steps. As she came nearer, the gait changed.

One day in the market she saw a blue shirt. She left her vegetable basket and followed. The boy turned. Not Neelu. Sumitra came home without buying anything. Only then she remembered the basket was still at the shop. She did not go back. In the evening the shopkeeper's son brought it to her house.

At home Neelu's plate remained in the same place for three weeks. Sumitra washed it, dried it, put it away. She did not take it out at mealtime.

Raghav spoke little at night. Once he began putting Neelu's schoolbag on the upper shelf. Sumitra brought it down and placed it in its old place.

Raghav said nothing.

That night Sumitra stayed awake for a long time. Outside, water remained only in the drains. Frogs. A dog far away. She got up and stirred the ash in the stove. A small ember remained inside. She did not blow it back to life. She simply covered it again with ash.

The next morning the same ember lit the stove.

8

Government papers reached the house after the water had gone down.

A young man came with a list. Damage to the house, grain, livestock, household members. A name beside "missing." On paper Neelu fit into one box. The young man spoke respectfully, but he had to move on.

Sumitra looked at the paper. Not "dead." "Missing."

She took the pen. Earlier she used to make a thumbprint rather than sign, but while helping with Neelu's school matters she had learned to write her own name. Slowly she wrote "Sumitra Devi." The "tra" leaned slightly.

The paper went away.

A few weeks later there was talk of compensation. Which category, what proof, after how many days a missing person would be considered dead—people said different things. Raghav went to the block office. Brought papers.

Sumitra kept the papers wrapped separately in cloth, with Neelu's birth paper, school identity card, and photograph.

That day she cleaned the room for a long time. Bedding in the sun. Books dusted. She opened Neelu's pencil box. Inside were three short pencils, an eraser, a broken ruler, a glass marble. Holding the marble, she sat in the courtyard. In the sunlight green and blue turned inside the glass.

She put the marble back in the box.

The paper said—missing.

The house said—absent.

Her hands said—dust is settling on this box; clean it.

Sumitra kept working on the third thing.

9

By Kartik the roads of Pipra had dried. Flood silt turned to dust. Shops opened again. The waterline remained on the school wall, but classes resumed.

One day a teacher came to return Neelu's books. Another set was available at school; these were his own books from home. The teacher had a small bag in his hand. He sat on the veranda. He seemed to have prepared many words, but when Sumitra went inside to make tea, the words perhaps scattered.

He only put down the bag.

Sumitra took out the books. Mathematics, Maithili, environmental studies. One page in the Maithili book had been folded. She straightened it.

The teacher said, "In his studies, he…"

The sentence did not finish.

Sumitra placed the cup of tea in front of him.

After a while the teacher left. Sumitra began washing three cups. She did not remember why she had taken out the third. She washed all three.

That evening two neighbourhood children came asking for Neelu's glass marbles. They used to play together. Both stood silently at the door. Sumitra opened the box. Gave one marble to each. Kept the rest.

The children ran away. In the courtyard the marbles struck—tok. Then another—tok.

Sumitra went on stirring the dal on the stove.

After that sound, whether the house felt a little less empty or more, she could not decide.

10

As Chhath approached, the ghat began to be cleaned again. After the flood there was much more work this year. Silt on the steps, old bamboo stakes torn out, the edge altered. The committee gathered again. Someone's donation, someone's list, someone's quarrel.

Sumitra used to go help prepare the ghat for Chhath. This time she did not go for three days. On the fourth morning she left carrying a broom.

Raghav did not ask.

At the ghat women were scraping mud. Men were driving bamboo poles. On one side Badri Kaka's red chair lay covered in dust. Sumitra spoke to no one. She took up the work of clearing silt from the fifth step. Broom, basin, water.

After a while a small plastic wheel came out beneath her hand—the wheel of a toy car. Blue.

Sumitra's hand stopped.

She washed the wheel in water. The blue brightened. Neelu's toy? She remembered Neelu had a red car, with black wheels. This was not his.

She threw the wheel onto the rubbish heap.

The work began again.

By noon five steps were clean. When she returned home her palms were cracked. She rubbed in mustard oil. Neelu's shirt was no longer on the bamboo; she had folded it away in the trunk long before.

On the first evening of Chhath she did not go to the ghat. The smell of thekua came from neighbouring houses. Before dawn on the second day she woke suddenly. The courtyard was dark. She filled a lota with water, but not for worship. Set it by the stove. Then opened the door and went out.

She did not go as far as the ghat. She stopped by the peepal tree halfway. From far away came fragments of song, the dholak, people's voices, long trembling lines of lamps upon the river.

Sumitra stood there for a very long time.

Her hands were empty.

11

At the beginning of winter Raghav put a cot in Neelu's room. The old cot had rotted in the flood. A new cot was necessary; guests would come, the room would have to serve some use.

Sumitra pulled the cot ropes with her hand. They were loose. She tightened them again.

She did not spread bedding on it.

A few days later her sister's five-year-old son came. He was put to sleep in that room. The child found Neelu's old box of glass marbles. Sumitra watched for a moment, then did not take the box from his hand.

In the morning three marbles lay in the courtyard. As she swept, Sumitra set them aside and put them on the shelf.

A house slowly rewrites the meanings of things. The cot that belonged to a son becomes a guest's cot. The bowl that belonged to a child begins measuring spices. The bag that went to school can hold paddy seed.

But not everything changes.

Neelu's white school shirt remained in the upper layer of the trunk. From time to time Sumitra took it out to air. The smell of soap had gone long ago. The mud stain remained as a faint yellow shadow. Whenever she saw the stain her hand wanted to look for soap again, then stopped.

One day she did not wash the shirt. She only spread it in the sun.

No one noticed this small change.

12

By Phagua, people in Pipra talked less about the flood. New crop in the fields. Potholes filled. On the old waterline on the school wall, children began drawing with chalk—boats, fish, the sun.

One day Sumitra went to the school because a paper bearing Neelu's name needed the headmaster's signature. She sat on the veranda. The bell rang.

Children came out of their classrooms. So many nine-year-old bodies. The same height, different faces.

She lowered her eyes.

The headmaster signed the paper. The word “missing” was still there. The period required by government rules had not yet been completed.

Sumitra did not fold the paper. She placed it straight in the folder.

On the way back she went behind the school, to the place where the water had run fast on the day of the flood. Now the field was dry. Grass was growing again. The bamboo stake people had planted for the rope was gone.

Sumitra bent to the ground. She found a small rusted clip. Whose, from when —no mark. She picked it up, then threw it far away.

She returned home.

That afternoon she opened the window of Neelu’s room fully for the first time. It had remained half closed all winter. Air came in, papers moved, dust rose. She swept. Rearranged the books. Put a tin of dal on an empty shelf.

Raghav saw it in the evening. Said nothing.

13

Before the year was complete, Sawan came again.

On the first night of heavy rain Sumitra woke. Water on the roof. The sound of drains filling. Her body rose before memory did. She checked the paddy sacks. Put the matches up high. Documents into plastic. Tested the torch.

Raghav woke too. Without speaking they began moving things upward. This time there was practice. Fear too.

By morning water had not entered the courtyard. Only rain. The river had risen, but there was no danger.

Sumitra brought the sacks down again. One by one. She left the papers on the shelf where they were.

Neelu’s folder too had been in the plastic. She took it out, looked at it, then placed it in a separate trunk.

When the day had risen she sat to wash clothes. Raghav’s dhoti, her sari, the small trousers a guest child had left the previous week. At last Neelu’s white shirt came into her hands.

She looked at it for a while.

Then did not dip it in the water.

She folded the shirt and put it back in the trunk.

The bar of soap remained in her hand. Sumitra used it to scrub her own sari.

14

One morning in Jeth, news came that many things from the flood had been exposed on a sandbar downstream—clothes, boxes, wood, toys, animal bones,

pieces of houses. No one knew exactly whose mouth the news had come from. The moment Sumitra heard, she covered the water lota, took the milk off the stove, and left without eating breakfast.

Raghav had gone to the field. Sumitra left the house key with a neighbour. Walked to the bus. Two kos by bus, then sand.

There truly were things on the bar. Dried in the sun, caked with mud, colours bleached. Someone recognized a door panel. Someone an iron trunk. Someone bedding. Many objects had no owner. The river had gathered things together without genealogy.

Sumitra walked slowly. Her eyes searched colours again—blue, black, white. A child's slipper in one place. Small size. She picked it up. Neelu's slipper had a broken heel strap; this strap was intact. She put it down.

An iron box held three coloured pencils. She opened it, then closed it. A torn book cover. A blue button. A plastic whistle. Each object became a possibility for one moment, then the remnant of someone else's life.

At noon the sun grew harsh. People began searching for shade. Sumitra sat beside an overturned boat. With her foot she scraped away sand. Dampness beneath. After a while she rose and walked again.

By evening she had found nothing.

On the bus home her lap was empty. But sand filled the spaces beneath her fingernails. When she reached home she washed her hands first. The sand would not come out all at once. With the back of a needle she cleaned it slowly.

The next morning she kneaded flour with those same hands.

15

Between rain and flood, one other thing changed in Pipra—the way people watched children.

Before, if children in the lane played near the river, someone would shout from a distance, then return to his own work. After Neelu, whenever Sumitra went toward the ghat, her eyes involuntarily counted the children. Five went, did five return? Four climbed into the boat, did four get down? She tried to stop herself, but the counting happened on its own.

One day two small boys were floating paper boats in a pit left by the flood. The water was knee-deep. There seemed no special danger. Sumitra was returning with vegetables. She went some distance past, then turned back. Moved the boys aside. Pressed the bank of the pit with her foot to test it. The earth was hollow underneath.

She planted two pieces of bamboo so the place could be seen from a distance.

The children watched her. One boy had studied with Neelu. For an instant recognition came into his eyes. Sumitra turned her gaze away.

Before reaching home she told the young man who did sanitation work in the ward about the pit. The next day it was filled with earth.

Sumitra did not mention this work at home. But after that, whenever it rained, she began checking not only the courtyard drain but the mouths of the lane drains too. If a sack was blocking one, she removed it. If a child stood beside fast-running water, she gestured him back.

People said—after the flood Sumitra had become very cautious.

The sentence was half true. Caution is a thing whose result can be seen. Much of what moved inside Sumitra had no result. Waking and sitting upright at the sound of heavy rain in the night; hearing Neelu's voice in some child's cough; having her breath catch at a blue shirt in an unknown crowd—none of these made anyone safer.

Yet when morning came she cleaned the drains.

16

On the day a year was completed, the family performed no fixed ritual. The date itself was disputed—the third day of the flood? The day he disappeared? The day he was recorded missing on paper? How does one observe a death anniversary without a date of death?

Raghav's mother came from the village. An old body, hearing weakened. She wept very little while speaking Neelu's name; mostly she sat looking at his things. Schoolbag, books, cot. Once she lifted the white shirt, rubbed a finger over the stain, then folded it and put it back in the same place.

In the evening she sat to pick stones from rice. Sumitra beside her. The two women on the same low stool. There were very few stones in the rice, yet the old woman examined each grain carefully.

After a long time she said only, "This stain never went?"

Sumitra shook her head.

That was all.

The next day the old woman returned. As she left, whether she touched the threshold of Neelu's room or merely put her hand there for support, Sumitra could not decide.

That week Raghav came back after speaking with a priest. Some rites could be done, some not; opinions differed. Sumitra listened. She neither objected nor insisted. For her the main question was not ritual correctness. She simply did not want anyone to say after some ceremony—now it is finished.

In the end a small lamp was lit at home. No announcement. Raghav sat silently. Sumitra made kheer in the kitchen and distributed it among neighbourhood children. Whether in Neelu's name or without naming him was not clear either.

One child licked the bowl and came back asking for more. Sumitra filled it a second time.

She put the remaining kheer in the refrigerator at night. In the morning she ate the cold kheer herself. After many months she ate something sweet and tasted it. When taste came, she did not feel guilt. She felt surprise.

The body often begins its work before the mind does.

17

In the next flood season the municipal school held a disaster drill. Children were taught lines, ropes, high ground, the order of boarding boats. Parents too were called.

At first Sumitra did not want to go. Still, she went.

The same veranda. The same classroom. The old waterline on the wall now covered with limewash, though parts still showed through. A new teacher demonstrated how to tie a rope. The children laughed and pushed one another. The trainer repeatedly straightened the line.

Sumitra stood at the edge and watched.

A small girl could not open a knot in the rope. Sumitra stepped forward. Took the rope in her hand. Tied the knot again—not loose, not so tight that it would be hard to open. The girl repeated it. Wrong the first time. Right the second.

Sumitra let go of her hand.

At the end of the drill everyone was told: in a disaster, children and old people first. Keep essential household papers separately. Drinking water separately. Beware of rumours.

Sumitra listened. Some of this was exactly what she had done instinctively on the first night of the flood; some were things that, even had she known them then, no one could say whether the outcome would have changed.

On the way back from the school she did not stop at the field behind. Came straight home.

At home she took out a large plastic bag. Documents, matches, a small torch, two bottles, a tin for dry flattened rice. On top, in thick letters, she wrote: "FLOOD."

She did not put Neelu's folder inside. Left it in a separate trunk.

Necessary things and remembered things are not the same. She did not write down this distinction; she made it only in the order of her hands.

18

After the flood Sumitra began making a list at night. Not on paper. In her mind.

Door closed? Stove out? Cow tied? Torch? Matches? Water? Papers?

Earlier the list would have ended there. Then one question began adding itself —are all the people of the house inside?

She listened for Raghav's breathing. If there was a guest, she checked his place. Sometimes a neighbour's child stayed playing until evening; her eyes followed the path until the child reached his mother.

This habit sometimes irritated the family. Once Raghav returned late and Sumitra went as far as the lane turn three times. When he came back, she took his wet shirt, hung it on the peg, served food. Said nothing.

Raghav understood. From the next day onward, if he was late he began making a short phone call.

Because of these short calls, for the first time after the flood a new rule formed between them. They still spoke little about grief, but they began reporting time. "I'm at the field." "I'm in the market." "Half an hour." These sentences were not declarations of love, yet they reduced the empty boxes in the household's night list.

When Sumitra herself went out, she began telling someone first. Market. Ghat. School. Block office. The woman who once felt no need to account for her own errands now left the name of a place behind. It did not feel like restraint to her, but like a marker—knowing where a person is can sometimes be very small and very necessary knowledge.

One evening she herself was late. On the way back from the market she saw an accident; a crowd. When she reached home, Raghav stood at the door. For the first time Sumitra saw in his eyes the same unease she carried within herself day and night.

She came inside. Put down the vegetable bag.

"I'm late," she said, only that.

Raghav nodded.

Then Sumitra went to wash her hands and face.

19

Very slowly, some of Neelu's clothes began serving other household purposes.

A torn vest became a wiping rag. The small gamchha dried utensils. An old pair of trousers was given to a poor child in the neighbourhood. Before giving them away, Sumitra checked the pockets. Inside were a dry peepal leaf, half a pencil shaving, and a two-rupee coin.

She kept the coin aside. The leaf broke in her hand. The shaving flew away with the dust. She washed the trousers and spread them in the sun, did not iron them. The next day the child's mother took them.

From the window Sumitra saw—the trousers were a little long on the child. His mother folded the cuffs. The child ran. The cloth began moving again with a body.

Sumitra did not cry at the sight. Something inside her tightened, then loosened.

She did not give away the white school shirt. She kept it outside use.

There was no rule for how many things could be given away and how many could not. Sumitra's decisions changed from day to day. One day she thought of giving Neelu's books to the school library; the next she arranged them again on the shelf. She gave one toy to a neighbour's child, wanted to ask for it back that night, but did not.

Perhaps being a mother now lived in these small decisions. The child was absent, but the hands of motherhood did not become absent at once. She still measured—which child would fit this garment, who would read this book, where should this bowl be kept. The direction of the work had changed; the work had not ended.

One day she spread the white shirt in the sun again. The stain was the same. Sumitra watched from a distance. Wind filled the shirt's empty sleeves, then flattened them. For an instant its shape resembled a body; the next instant it was only cloth.

Sumitra did not go forward to straighten the sleeves. The wind continued its own work.

20

Neelu was not found.

This sentence slowly took different forms inside the family. On paper: "missing." In people's speech: "went in the flood." In Raghav's silence: a place without a name. In Sumitra's work: one fewer bowl, one garment kept apart, one window opened wider, haste to move things upward as soon as rain began.

One day someone asked, "Have you accepted it now?"

Sumitra did not answer. She could not quite understand what "accept" meant in the question. Accept what—that the child would not return? That the body would not be found? That the search was over? That memory was fixed? That life went on? These questions did not have one answer.

That day she had put dal on the stove. It rose to a boil. She skimmed off the foam with the ladle. Lowered the flame. Lifted the lid of the rice. There was a little too much water; she left the lid half open.

The woman who had asked the question sat for a while, then left.

Sumitra served the meal. Two plates.

At night the rain stopped. The electricity was out. She brought out the lantern—the same one she had prepared on the first night of the flood. The wick had grown very old. She cut a new wick from cloth, filled oil, lit it.

The light was small, but it had not been given the task of removing all the darkness from the room. Its work was only to show whatever lay within the reach of its glow—the flood line on the wall, books on the shelf, the cot ropes, the closed trunk, the black smoke marks of the stove, Raghav's tired face.

Sumitra carried the lantern into the courtyard. Rainwater moved slowly through the drain. The river was far away, but in the dampness of the night its smell perhaps reached even here—or perhaps it was only memory.

She set the lantern down, bent, and pulled a leaf caught in the drain. The water began moving again.

Then she came inside, closed the door, and measured out rice for the morning.

STORY 20

Videha

1

On the day the old iron trunk was opened in Jagdamba Devi's house, there was no electricity. Rain fell outside; water dripped through the roof in two places inside, and the courtyard drain had filled. Naina first set down a bucket, then switched on the light on her phone. Jagdamba Devi immediately said, "That light will spoil the colour of the papers. Bring the lamp."

Naina laughed. "Can paper tell the difference between a phone's light and a lamp's?"

The paper may not. The eyes can.

Anupama, who had been wringing out wet clothes on the veranda, came inside and brought out a small brass lamp. It was not the lamp from Jagdamba Devi's wedding, as she sometimes claimed; it had come much later. But there was an old scratch along its rim whose story three different members of the family told in three different ways. Naina had never decided where the lamp had truly come from. She liked that an object could hold a fact while stories changed around it.

The trunk had been locked for years. The key used to stay inside Jagdamba Devi's pillowcase, but the pillow had been changed, and no one remembered whether the key had been moved into the new cover. In the end Anupama found it in an old spice tin. "Why here?" Naina asked. Anupama said, "Perhaps Mother put it there." Jagdamba Devi answered at once, "I did not."

When the lock opened, what rose from inside was not the smell of metal but a mingled smell of old paper, cloth, and damp. On top lay a white dhoti, beneath it a sari with a red border, and under that a tied bundle of papers. Two words were written on the bundle: "House Papers."

Naina wondered—which part of a house lives in its papers? Land? Birth? Marriage? Debt? Letters? Recipes? A woman's grief written in her own hand? She did not ask the question then. First the window was shut, another bucket was placed beneath the drip, and the lamp was moved to the right side of the trunk.

2

The first bundle was a copy of the Panji. The family did not possess the original volume; these were pages copied at some point from a Panjikar, with later additions in newer hands. Men's names ran in sequence—father, son, grandson. Women appeared in marriage notes: "daughter of so-and-so," "married at such-and-such place," "two children." Sometimes a name was written in full, sometimes only its first letter.

Jagdamba Devi asked for her spectacles. "Where is my name here?"

Anupama turned the page. “Here—‘Devnath married in the Madhubani pargana…’ and then…”

“Am I a pargana?” Jagdamba Devi laughed.

Naina reached for her phone to take a photograph. Jagdamba Devi stopped her hand. “Read first.”

In the middle of the page one branch was incomplete. After two names, the record jumped directly to the next generation. The ink there had not faded; the paper was not torn. There were simply no names. Naina immediately began to infer—had someone been removed? Jagdamba Devi read her face. “Do not make a story the moment you see a blank. I do not know either.”

Then she took a thin notebook from the bottom of the trunk. Its cover was blue, its corners worn. On the first page, in Jagdamba Devi’s hand, were the words: “Names on Mother’s Side.” Then came a succession of women—mother, grandmother, grandmother’s mother, aunt, sister, daughter, daughter’s daughter—alongside not illnesses but songs and skills: “knew how to dry makhana,” “rowed a boat during the flood,” “told the stories of Saurath beautifully,” “first to send her daughter to school,” “kept the household going by sewing.”

Anupama looked at the page for a long time. “When did you write this?”

“When I understood that half the house was not in the book.”

“Did you ever show it to anyone?”

“I did not write it to show anyone. I wrote it so I would remember.”

Naina did not photograph the Panji just then. She first read every page of the blue notebook under changing light. She began to understand that lineage was not only what had been written down; it was also what some woman in the household had quietly taken into her own hands to record.

3

The second bundle contained letters: postcards, inland letters, blue airmail envelopes, some without stamps, some without addresses. The moment Anupama opened one she recognized it. “Mama sent this from Kuwait.”

Jagdamba Devi corrected her. “The first time, from Doha. Kuwait came later.”

The letters spoke less about money than about weather. “The air here is hot.” “At night we go up to the roof.” “I miss the smell of the village pond.” “Mother, do not send pickle; it gets held up at customs.” One line would be in Maithili, the next in Hindi, followed by a broken-English address. Migration bundles language too, Naina thought, like belongings tied for a journey.

Some letters were Anupama’s from Delhi, from her first year at college. “Mother, here people hear my speech and then ask—say that again.” In one letter she had written, “Sometimes I speak my language softly so no one will hear.” In a letter from the following year the sentence had changed: “Now if someone laughs, I say it again, louder.”

Anupama took the letter from Naina's hand. "This will not be published."

Naina looked startled. "When did I say I was going to publish it?"

"Your eyes are saying it."

Jagdamba Devi laughed, but Anupama did not. "Finding a paper does not give everyone a right to it. Some things were written because they were meant to be sent. Some things were written because they could not be said to anyone. Those are not the same."

In that bundle there was also an unsent letter. Only "Didi" was written at the top. Inside were words about a broken marriage, returning home, other people's questions, and being unable to tell one's mother anything. No names appeared. The last line said: "I want someone to let me tell my story in my own mouth."

Naina put the letter back into its envelope. Anupama watched her. "That too?"

"Not unless the writer gives permission."

Jagdamba Devi straightened the lamp wick. "Good. Write down that rule."

4

The rules really were written down—at first not on paper but in an empty file on Naina's computer. She titled it: "House Papers: Rules of Work."

1. If the writer is alive, no private paper without the writer's permission.

2. If the writer is dead, whether a paper should be published will not be decided merely in the name of "history"; its effect on living family members must also be considered.

3. Do not fill blank spaces with conjecture.

4. If a person cannot write, transcribe their speech, then read it back or play it back and obtain approval.

5. While "cleaning" language, do not erase the voice.

6. Do not leave a woman's name reduced to "so-and-so's daughter/wife."

On hearing the sixth rule, Jagdamba Devi said, "And do not reduce a man's name to someone's husband or father either. Everyone has a name of their own."

A seventh rule was added.

Naina had thought of the work as a digital archive of the family. Anupama stopped her. "First decide what we are preserving. Papers? Stories? Evidence? Or our own feelings?"

Naina did not answer. The question had never seemed difficult to her before. To a scanner, every page becomes an image of one size; not so to a life.

That night the three of them scanned only ten pages. The incomplete branch of the Panji was left exactly as it was. In the file note Naina wrote: "Gap in the original; reason unknown." The first page of the blue notebook was scanned, but pages containing private remarks went into a "family-restricted" folder. Anupama's old letter was scanned, but not placed in the public folder.

The work was slow. Jagdamba Devi was pleased. “Truth does not ask for hurried work.”

5

A week later the water rose again. It was not a flood, only the monsoon spread of the Kamala and the smaller channels, but water climbed into the low ground behind the house. It was no longer safe to keep the trunk in the inner courtyard. All three bundles were carried to the upstairs room.

Devnath Babu’s old wooden box was there too. Jagdamba Devi said, “Leave it. Termites have already eaten it.”

Anupama opened it anyway. Inside were two cassettes, a small diary, a lump of earth tied in red cloth, and newspaper clippings. The diary was not Devnath Babu’s. It belonged to his younger sister Vimala.

In the family Vimala had been known as “very quiet.” In the diary, that silence appeared in another form. She had written down women’s songs from the household, market prices, how far floodwater had risen, which child had gone to school, which woman had spoken for the first time in the panchayat hall—things of that kind. Between them were her own sentences: “Where will my name remain on paper?”

Jagdamba Devi took the diary in her hands. For a long while she said nothing. “She never showed me this.”

“Shall we publish it?” Naina asked.

Jagdamba Devi did not answer at once. “Ask her daughter first.”

Vimala’s daughter Seema lived near Janakpur in Nepal. On the phone Naina told her everything. Seema was silent at first, then said, “I knew Mother wrote. But there may be private things in the diary.”

“There are.”

“Do not print everything. Read the songs and the village notes and send them to me. I will give permission for whatever seems right.”

After ending the call, Naina placed a slip over the diary: “Permission pending.”

Outside, the water touched the first brick at the doorway and receded. Anupama watched from the window. “Water does not read paper, but it does select—the one kept lower gets wet.”

Naina said, “That is why copies must be made.”

Jagdamba Devi added, “And that is why you must not imagine that the copy has taken the place of the original.”

6

The work might have remained inside the family had Shashank’s voice message not arrived. Shashank was Anupama’s cousin and had worked in the Gulf for twenty years. Naina had sent him a photograph of an old letter—not

one containing anything private, but a postcard in which Shashank had written that from his first earnings he would send “red slippers for Mother.”

Shashank sent a voice message: “I do not remember writing anything like that. Did Mother ever wear the red slippers?”

Jagdamba Devi remembered. “She wore them for two years. They were washed away in the flood.”

Naina sent back the answer. In his next message Shashank spent five minutes telling the story of his first night abroad: eight men in one room, one fan, everyone speaking a different language, no mobile phones, a queue to call home. At the end he said, “If you want to write this, write it. But when you make my speech better, do not erase my fear.”

That sentence changed the direction of the work. Naina no longer wanted only to scan old papers; she wanted to preserve living voices too.

Naina transcribed Shashank’s speech. She did not turn “I could not cry the first night” into “I was deeply distressed.” She did not turn “earning money” into “economic opportunity.” She kept the Maithili in Shashank’s mixed speech, and left the Arabic words that had entered his everyday work without explanatory notes.

Anupama read the transcript. “This is moving beyond family history.”

Naina said, “Perhaps family history was already beyond the family. Only the papers had been kept inside.”

Jagdamba Devi listened to Shashank’s voice again. “He told his own story himself. That is good.”

The next day Seema gave permission to publish five pages from Vimala’s diary —the songs, flood notes, the account of a daughter going to school, and that line: “Where will my name remain on paper?” The pages about the private marital dispute remained closed.

Now Naina had two voices—one of a dead woman, with the family’s permission; one of a living migrant, with his own permission. For the first time she understood that building a platform was harder than building a museum.

7

Anupama did not like the idea of a platform. “The moment you say platform, people think performance. Are we going to turn people’s suffering into an exhibition?”

“Then what?”

“A booklet.”

Jagdamba Devi said, “The word booklet makes me think of a pharmaceutical company’s leaflet.”

All three laughed.

They began searching for a name. “House Papers” was too narrow. “Our Voice” sounded too much like a proclamation. At “Soil,” Anupama asked,

“Where did the water go?” At “Water and Soil,” Naina said, “Where did the people go?”

Jagdamba Devi got up in the middle of the discussion. It was time for her evening medicine. When she returned, she brought an old envelope. On it, in Devnath Babu’s hand, there was only one word: “Videha.” Nothing was inside.

“What is this?”

“Your grandfather used to talk about bringing out a journal. He never did. He had made the envelope.”

Anupama smiled. “Then are we completing his unfinished work?”

Jagdamba Devi shook her head. “No. His work was his. Your work is yours. If you like the name, keep it. Do not make it a burden by calling it ‘Grandfather’s dream.’”

Naina turned the envelope in her hand. Inside the word “Videha” lay a region, an echo of old philosophy, and also the sense of being beyond the body; but the meaning that seemed most useful to her now was that no single body, family, or lineage could contain the whole story.

Anupama said, “We can keep the name, but on the first page we must state clearly—this is not a lineage register, not a certificate of proof.”

Jagdamba Devi added, “And not the mouthpiece of a single household either.”

That was how the name “Videha” was settled. There was no vote. Agreement formed slowly, the way silt settles in a pond after rain.

8

For the first issue, more material came from outside the family than from within it. Anupama told people she knew from her old school not “Send us a story,” but “Send whatever you yourself wish to say.” The difference between those two sentences became clear very quickly.

From Pipra, Champa sent a short piece: an account of the women’s group cleaning the Chhath ghat—gloves, rubbish, and the way the women made rules for their own work amid the men’s committee meetings. She mentioned the red chair in one sentence, without naming anyone.

Munni, the disciple of an elderly folk singer, sent a voice message. “I do not know the full name of the raga, but at this turn my grandmother used to lower the note.” She sang the song and sent it. Naina wanted to make a written version, but Munni said, “Half of it will remain if only the notes are written. Keep an audio link too.”

After retirement, a postal worker gave two pages from his route book—names removed, only addresses in which houses were identified by a tree, a ghat, a temple bend, and “the house with the red door.”

A woman wrote about returning home after a failed marriage, but on the condition that the village name be changed. Anupama asked, “If we change the

name, will the story become false?" The woman replied, "No. My body will remain safe." The name was changed.

A student in Delhi wrote one page: at home the household language is spoken on the phone, not in the hostel. Seema in Janakpur wrote a note beside Vimala's song: "I do not know from whom Mother learned this song; therefore I will not call it 'our family's song.'"

Some material was rejected too. One man sent a claim that he would expose another family's "secret lineage." There was no evidence, no permission, and many accusations. Naina wrote back: "It cannot be published in this form." The man telephoned. "Are you afraid of the truth?"

Anupama took the phone. "We are afraid of claiming power over another person's life in the name of truth."

The man became angry. Before the first issue had even appeared, "Videha" had acquired its first opponent. Jagdamba Devi was not pleased by this; she simply remained steady. "Good. If there are rules, they will be tested."

9

The first difficulty of editing was language. One person wrote one form of Maithili, another a different form; someone sent an entire Maithili piece in Roman letters. One migrant woman shifted among three languages in a voice message. At first Naina wanted to make everything uniform.

Jagdamba Devi stopped one transcript midway through listening. "That woman did not speak like this."

"The meaning is the same."

"Meaning alone is not voice."

Anupama agreed, but she did not want to abandon editing either. "If the spelling stays this scattered, the reader will tire. But if we erase the voice, we erase the writer. Work somewhere between the two."

A rule was made: spelling would be regularized according to the house style; the local rhythm of the sentence would be kept as far as possible; unusual words would not be removed if their meaning was clear; translation would be made only if the writer asked for it. Editorial notes would be brief.

Naina sent Shashank his transcript. He sent back three corrections. First, not "I lived with eight men," but "All eight of us lived in one room." Second, one companion was from Nepal, not Bihar. Third, instead of "I was afraid," he wanted "I felt fear." Naina accepted all three.

In her piece, Champa struck out the line "We were allowed to speak in the meeting" and wrote, "We sat down in the meeting." On the phone she laughed: "Allowed by whom?"

Those small corrections became lessons in editing for Naina. Voice was not only grammar; language also concealed who acted and who was imagined to possess permission.

10

The family's greatest dispute was over whether to include the incomplete branch of the Panji in the first issue. Devnath Babu's younger brother Raghubir said plainly on the phone, "It is not right to make an ancestral Panji public. Who knows what people will cut out of it and what they will make?"

Naina said, "Not the whole Panji. Only one page, where women's names are missing and where there is a gap. Along with an excerpt from Grandmother's maternal-line notebook."

"Then people will think there was something wrong in our family."

Jagdamba Devi took the phone. "Can I say there was nothing wrong in our family?"

Raghubir was silent.

"A gap is a gap. Why be ashamed of it?"

"But your notebook about your mother's side is hardly a Panji."

"When did I call it a Panji? I wrote names."

The argument lasted two days. In the end it was decided that the identifying details of the family would be removed from the original Panji and only a structural excerpt printed; beside the incomplete branch would be the note: "Reason unknown; no conjecture." Alongside it would appear five women's names from Jagdamba Devi's notebook, with her own consent. The title: "Two Kinds of Lineage Memory."

Naina wanted to write a short essay called "The Silences of History." Anupama stopped her. "Let the reader first look at the papers. The editor does not have to explain the meaning of everything."

Naina removed the essay. A blank space remained. To her surprise, the page felt stronger.

11

By the time the first issue was being assembled, "Videha" had moved out of a family meeting and become a small public undertaking in the town. There was no money for a large press. A photocopy shop in Pipra bazaar agreed to print a small number of eighty-page booklets. The shopkeeper said, "A colour cover will cost more."

Naina gave up colour. The cover became a black-and-white line drawing—a lamp reflected on water. Jagdamba Devi looked at it. "Whose lamp?"

"No one's."

"Then it is fine."

The money came through contributions—some from Shashank abroad, some from Anupama's salary, some from Seema in Janakpur; Champa's group said they would buy five copies rather than take them free. Jagdamba Devi wanted to give some of her old savings. Anupama stopped her. "You gave the name, you gave the rules, and now money too?"

Jagdamba Devi said, “I did not give the name. I gave the envelope.”

In the end her contribution was treated as advance payment for five copies.

On printing day the machine produced the first four pages in reverse order. The shopkeeper held his head. Naina laughed. “The region will write its own story, the machine its own sequence.”

Anupama said at once, “Do not put that line in the editorial.”

“Why?”

“Too contrived.”

The three of them laughed. The wrongly ordered pages were set aside. New ones were printed. The staples were put in by hand. No launch platform was arranged. The first copy was placed in Jagdamba Devi’s hands. She did not look at the cover but at the contents. She read the names. “Vimala—good. Seema—good. Champa—good. Shashank—good. Why does this say ‘Anonymous’?”

“That is all the writer wants.”

“Then good.”

12

The first copy of “Videha” left the house on a Jeth afternoon. Naina had thought she would place it in the school, but on the way she met the retired postman near the post office. He found the excerpt from his route pages, cleaned his spectacles, read it, and then said, “My name isn’t here?”

“You had said you did not want your name.”

“Yes, right. I was checking whether the editor remembered.”

The second copy reached a tea stall in Pipra. By evening there were tea stains on its pages. The third went to the school library. The fourth to Champa’s group. The fifth went by post to Janakpur. The sixth travelled abroad to Shashank as a scanned file.

Responses came at once. Someone said, “There is too much sorrow.” Someone else, “Why so little poetry here?” Another asked, “Where is our neighbourhood?” Someone said, “Printing the Panji was not right.” An elderly man complained, “Too much about women.” Champa replied, “You write next time. Then there will be less.”

The hardest response came from an old acquaintance of Vimala’s. She said, “The flood date printed in the diary is off by a year.” Seema said, “Mother wrote it.” The acquaintance replied, “Then Mother wrote it wrong.”

Naina first wanted to defend the diary. Then she remembered the rules. For the next issue they prepared a note titled “Correction / Difference in Memory”: “The diary date was published as in the original; local memory gives another year; no decisive record is available.”

Jagdamba Devi heard the note. “Good. Do not turn memory into a courtroom.”

Thus, with its very first issue, the journal learned its first correction. If a region writes its own story, the region will also disagree with itself—this proved more useful than any manifesto.

13

Three months later a small pile of material had accumulated with Naina. A boatman wanted to write about a raft made by children, but did not want to give the children's names. A schoolmaster sent an account of students imitating him on the day of his retirement, adding, "What I remember, the students may remember differently." A painter agreed to let words about market pressure on colour be printed on the condition that no photograph be used.

One woman sent five pages—her experience of returning home twenty years after her father's death. As she read, Naina thought: this is a story no single voice can complete. She telephoned the woman. The woman said, "Then ask my neighbour too, but do not make her account final over mine."

The journal's work grew. Anupama feared Naina would once again take everything onto herself. "Editing is not a hereditary office," she said plainly.

So a small editorial group was formed—Naina, Anupama, Champa, Seema from afar, a school student, and Munni, disciple of the elderly folk singer. Jagdamba Devi refused to accept a formal place on it. "I will advise. I will not take a post."

At the meeting, the first question was not money but permission. The second was language. Third—written material only, or audio too? Fourth—children's material would require consent from both the child and the guardian. Fifth—material containing accusations would require evidence.

Naina laughed. "The journal is becoming more rules than stories."

Champa replied, "Without rules, the voices of people with less power will once again be taken over by people with more power."

Munni added, "And not so many rules that a voice cannot enter at all."

Between those two sentences the next work of "Videha" began.

14

Jagdamba Devi gradually began to hear less. Voice messages had to be played twice for her. One day Naina asked, "Would you like to write your own story?"

"I have already written what I had to write."

"The names on your mother's side?"

"That is not a story. It is a list."

"A list can be a story too."

"You have caught the disease of turning everything into a story."

Naina laughed. "Then you tell it and I will write."

Jagdamba Devi agreed, but on one condition—few questions. She spoke of the flood of her childhood, of her mother rowing a boat, her first school, marriage,

the first night in her husband's home, people's reactions after a daughter was born, and her husband Devnath Babu's unfinished plan to bring out a journal. At many points she said, "Do not write this." Naina did not write those parts.

At the end Naina asked, "What was the biggest thing in your life?"

Jagdamba Devi grew annoyed. "What sort of question is that? Is life an examination with one answer?"

Naina struck out the question.

After a while Jagdamba Devi herself said, "Write one thing. Keep account of what I did not do as well. There were many times I remained silent where I should have spoken. Do not turn silence into a virtue."

Naina wrote it down and read it back. Jagdamba Devi changed one word —"many times" to "some times." "To say many would also be unjust to myself."

In that small correction Naina saw an entire philosophy of editing—neither glorification nor self-punishment; whatever was said should be measured no larger and no smaller than it was.

15

While preparing the second issue, the old trunk was opened again. The papers were now arranged in envelopes: Panji, maternal-line notebook, diary pages for which permission had been obtained, private sealed letters, a list of scans. Naina saw that the disorder of the first day had become order, but order itself held a new danger: once categories were made, people could be shut inside them.

She changed the folder called "Women's Voices" to "Voice/Writing," because women did not write only about women's subjects. In the "Migration" folder she placed a woman's migration story alongside Shashank's. Under "Lineage," "rejected lineage" and "maternal memory" were not kept separate; they were cross-linked in the same place.

Anupama looked at it. "A Panji can be made on a computer too."

"Yes. And someone can be left outside here too."

Jagdamba Devi said, "Then do not make a god of the list."

That evening a teenage girl arrived. Her name was Saloni. She carried four pages. Her father worked as a labourer in Punjab; her mother sewed in the village. Saloni had not written about her father's absence but about the sound of her mother's sewing machine—the machine running late into the night, electricity cutting out, the wheel turning by foot, studying for examinations, taking clothing measurements, household expenses.

Naina read the pages and asked, "Did you write this yourself?"

Saloni frowned. "Why?"

Naina immediately felt the weight of her own question. "I'm sorry. I only meant to ask whether you are giving permission for us to edit it."

"Yes. But do not write 'daughter of a poor family.'"

"I will not."

"And let my mother read it first."

"Of course."

After Saloni left, Anupama said, "See? If the region is to write its own story, the editor must learn language too."

16

After the second issue another question arose—the boundary between lineage memory and legal proof. An elderly woman named Kaushalya Devi wrote down seven generations of names on her mother's side. At the top of the page she wrote, "These are my mothers." Beside some names she gave villages; beside others only notes such as "sang sweetly," "grew betel vine," "educated two daughters."

Naina was delighted. "This is just like Grandmother's notebook."

Kaushalya Devi said at once, "But write one thing clearly—this is not a claim to land."

Naina was surprised. Once the reason was explained, it was simple. There was an ongoing dispute over land belonging to the old house on Kaushalya Devi's maternal side. She wanted the names preserved in memory, but did not want any lawyer or agnate to turn this page into proof of inheritance.

The editorial group met. Champa said, "What if we state clearly that this is oral/family memory, not a legal record?"

Anupama said, "And nowhere use the words 'verified genealogy.'"

Naina changed the title of the page to "Kaushalya Devi's Memory List." Beneath it she added: "Published solely for preservation of memory; no claim is made as evidence of property, caste, inheritance, or legal right."

Kaushalya Devi read it again. "Now print it."

Jagdamba Devi heard about it and said, "See? Preserving a name and creating a claim are not the same thing."

Naina remembered her first excitement, when the blank in the Panji had instantly made her mind invent a story. Now she understood that sometimes editing was not the work of adding words, but of reducing the claims words made.

17

For the third issue of "Videha," Naina went to see a woman whose child had disappeared in an old flood. People kept saying that if her life story were written, it would become a great work. Naina felt uneasy the moment she heard this; the woman's suffering had already begun to be called "material."

The woman's name was Kamli. Naina first gave her the journal, explained the rules, then asked, "If there is anything you want to say, I will listen. If you do not want to, that is all right too."

Kamli turned the pages of the journal for a long time. “People told you about my son?”

“Yes.”

“You want to write it?”

Naina paused before answering. “I want to listen. Whether it is written or not will be your decision.”

Kamli looked out of the window. “I do not want it.”

That was all.

As Naina rose to leave, Kamli spoke again. “People will think I cannot speak. That is not right. I can speak. I simply do not want this matter printed.”

Naina asked, “May I print that sentence—that you can speak, but do not wish it published?”

Kamli thought for a moment. “Without my name.”

In the next issue a small box appeared: “A writer also has the right to decide that some stories will not be published. Do not mistake silence for incapacity.” No name, no incident, no description of grief.

One reader wrote, “What is the use of this empty note?” Naina did not reply. Jagdamba Devi read it and said, “It is not empty. It is a boundary.”

Naina then understood that the journal bore responsibility not only for the stories it printed, but also for the stories it did not print. If the region was to write its own story, the right “not to write” had to live inside that sentence as well.

18

The question of language returned in another form. A young man of Mithila, born in Saudi Arabia, sent his grandmother’s story in Roman letters. He spoke Maithili but could not read Devanagari well. He wrote, “Preserve the pronunciation of my words; you may change the script.”

Naina first transcribed the whole text into Devanagari. Problems appeared at once—where did Roman “ai” mean “ai,” where “aï,” and where only a drawn-out spoken sound? Where did “chhai” mean one form of “is,” and where was an honorific form intended? The levels of respect in the grandmother’s quoted speech were unclear in Roman script.

Naina asked the young man for an audio recording. He also sent old fragments of his grandmother’s voice. Anupama, Seema, and Jagdamba Devi listened. Sentence by sentence, the text was transcribed again.

The young man saw the final text and wrote, “Now this sounds like my grandmother’s voice.”

The editorial group decided: when material arrived in Roman script, the original file would be preserved; the published Devanagari version would be made with the writer’s approval; a brief note would be added if necessary. Change the script, not the voice.

Munni asked, “And if someone sends something in Tirhuta script?”

Everyone fell silent. No one could read it well enough.

Anupama said, “Then we find someone who can. We cannot proceed by pretending to know what we do not know.”

Jagdamba Devi laughed. “Write that rule into all your work.”

Naina actually wrote in her notebook: “Do not hide ignorance.”

Preserving a language no longer seemed to her merely a matter of choosing pure words; whose pronunciation, whose script, whose ease of reading, whose consent—all of these together were what kept a language alive.

19

At a public discussion, the first hard question about “Videha” came. A college student asked, “You say the region should write its own story. But you are the ones who print. You are the ones who choose. You have the power to decide who remains outside and who comes in. So where is the ‘own’ in ‘its own story’?”

Before answering, Naina looked towards Anupama. The question was fair.

Naina said, “We are not the region. The journal is not the region either. We make selections, so the responsibility is ours as well. ‘Its own’ means only that, as far as possible, people are given space in their own voices rather than turned into objects. But the power of selection does not disappear.”

The student asked again, “Then editorial bias?”

Champa answered, “It will exist. That is why the rules must be public, corrections open, and the editorial group must keep changing.”

Seema sent an added voice message from afar: “Print letters from people who disagree too—provided they are not abusive or making false accusations.”

In the next issue a page titled “How We Choose” was added. It listed subject, permission, evidence, privacy, language, balance of place, and active invitations to less-heard voices such as women, Dalits, migrants, and children; it also acknowledged that editorial selection was not infallible.

Jagdamba Devi read the page. “Now your journal publishes its limits too. Good.”

Naina said, “Printing a limit does not erase the limit.”

“Erasing it is not the work. Keeping it visible is.”

Naina wanted to make that sentence an editorial title, then stopped herself. Not every good sentence has to become a title. Some remain in the house and do their work there.

20

By the end of a year, three small issues of “Videha” had appeared. Not one had appeared on time. Sometimes money was short, sometimes material arrived late, sometimes permission was held up, sometimes the printer’s machine failed. Yet

the journal continued. Even “continued” did not mean a grand success—only continuity.

One copy went to Delhi, one to the Gulf, one to Janakpur, some to Pipra, some to nearby villages. Someone read the whole issue, someone only their own name, someone looked only at the cover, someone sent a correction. Some copies got wet, some survived in libraries, some lost pages in tea stalls.

Jagdamba Devi’s hearing weakened further, but she always read the contents page. In the third issue she saw Saloni’s “Sewing Machine.” “Was this name anywhere before?”

“Not in our Panji,” Naina said with a laugh.

“Then now it is.”

One night the electricity failed again. There was no rain. The courtyard was dry. Naina shut down the computer and lit the brass lamp. On the table lay an empty folder for the next issue. A new voice message had arrived on her phone—an elderly woman from a distant village wanted to tell her story of the river. Naina did not begin writing immediately. First she sent a reply: “I will transcribe your story and play it back to you. Any part you do not want will be removed. You will decide whether your name is printed.”

The reply came: “Good. Play it back to me first.”

From inside Anupama asked, “New material?”

“Yes.”

“Whose?”

Naina looked at the phone. “She will tell it herself.”

From the cot Jagdamba Devi called, “Lower the lamp wick. It is smoking.”

Naina lowered the wick a little. The flame grew smaller but steadier. On the table before her lay the scan of the Panji, the permission page from Vimala’s diary, Shashank’s corrected transcript, Saloni’s essay, Champa’s ghat account, and the blank page for the next issue.

She wrote no editorial sentence on the blank page. Not “our region,” not “our truth,” not “all our voices.” The page remained empty—for the next writer.

Outside, beside the doorway, a little water from the day remained in a shallow hollow. The lamp’s light did not form one line on it; whenever the wind moved, it broke into many small pieces, joined again, then broke again. Naina watched for a few moments.

Inside the house, three generations breathed in different rhythms. The trunk was closed, but the key was no longer hidden in the spice tin—it was in the table drawer, and everyone knew where it was.

The next issue of “Videha” had not yet been written. Even so, its first blank page was ready.

FROM THE HUNDRED-STORY TRILOGY · VOLUME I

STORY 21

Two Letters

Sudhanshu Babu always kept the umbrellas hanging behind the door. One black, one blue, one light grey. The black umbrella was his, the blue one belonged to his wife, Malati Devi, and the grey umbrella belonged to no one—at least, no one in the house called it their own.

The grey umbrella had hung there for six years. Its cloth had faded in places, fine rust marks had appeared on two of its metal ribs, and the wooden handle had grown smooth. Just below the handle, two letters scratched with a small knife were still visible: “R. C.”

Ramakant Chaudhary.

Sudhanshu Babu read the full name in his mind, but did not say it aloud.

Clouds had gathered since morning that day. It was September rain—neither a full downpour nor a complete pause. Water stood between the courtyard bricks, the tulsi platform was wet, and heavy drops fell now and then from the edge of the roof.

Malati Devi asked, “Is it necessary to go to college today?”

Folding the newspaper, Sudhanshu Babu said, “I have a class. Second period.”

“Will students come on a day like this?”

“Some will certainly come.”

He rose and began getting ready. A year and a half remained before the end of his service in the Maithili Department. Once, failing to reach college on a rainy day had seemed to him a breach of discipline. That conviction had loosened a little now, yet sitting at home still did not come naturally to him.

At a quarter to nine he came to the door. He tried to open his black umbrella. It opened halfway, then one rib slipped loose from inside. He forced it again. The cloth sagged crookedly to one side.

Watching from behind, Malati Devi said, “I told you yesterday to get it repaired.”

“I forgot.”

“Then take the blue one.”

Sudhanshu Babu reached for the blue umbrella, but Malati Devi said, “Its catch is loose too. If there is wind, it will turn inside out.”

Their eyes went to the grey umbrella at the same time.

Without saying anything, Malati Devi went inside. Sudhanshu Babu stood there for a few moments. The drops in the courtyard had begun to fall more heavily.

He took down the grey umbrella. There was no dust on it; Malati Devi wiped it from time to time. The moment the handle came into his hand, there rose the mingled smell of old leather and damp wood. Sudhanshu Babu felt he had known that smell somewhere before.

From inside Malati Devi called, “Does it open or not?”

Sudhanshu Babu opened it in the courtyard. The umbrella trembled once, then spread fully. There was a small hole in one corner of the cloth, but it would serve.

“It is all right,” he said.

Malati Devi came to the door. Her eyes fell on the letters on the handle, then on Sudhanshu Babu’s face. “You have taken it out after a long time.”

“Mine is broken.”

“I did not say anything.”

“Nor did I.”

After those words both felt a little awkward. Malati Devi went back inside. Sudhanshu Babu opened the umbrella and stepped into the lane.

Ramakant had been dead for six years. Very few people at the college now remained who remembered him as “Ramakant Sir.” Some of the newly appointed teachers had heard the name; some had not. Two books written by him were still in the department’s old cupboard, but dust settled quickly now on their spines.

Sudhanshu Babu and Ramakant had been appointed in the same year. They sat in the same room, drank tea at the same tea stall, and often walked together to the station after college. In thirty years of acquaintance there had been so much between them that it was difficult to tell it like a story, from a clear beginning to a clear end. Their friendship had formed slowly, and its ending too had not come suddenly on any one day.

Yet in his mind Sudhanshu Babu had marked one day.

That day too, it had rained.

Water had collected at the bend in the lane. Sudhanshu Babu walked with the rim of the umbrella lowered slightly. Two schoolchildren were splashing barefoot through the water. One child looked at the grey umbrella and said, “Babu, that umbrella is very old.”

Sudhanshu Babu smiled involuntarily. “Yes. It is old.”

The child ran on.

On the main road he found a rickshaw and got in. The rickshaw-puller reached to fold the umbrella and place it behind the seat. Sudhanshu Babu said at once, “I’ll keep it.”

The rickshaw-puller withdrew his hand.

By the time he reached college the rain had eased a little. Ramvilas, the peon, stood beneath the awning by the main gate. Shaking the umbrella, Sudhanshu Babu went in. Ramvilas stared at it.

"That looks like Ramakant Sir's umbrella."

Sudhanshu Babu's hand stopped for a moment. "You still remember?"

Ramvilas laughed. "He had scratched letters on that handle. He used to say all umbrellas in a college are the same colour; if there is no name, people exchange them."

Sudhanshu Babu looked at the handle. The letters "R. C." were very small.

Ramvilas said, "Once he took my umbrella home too. The next day he came saying, 'Ramvilas, your umbrella is healthier than I am.'"

He laughed. Sudhanshu Babu laughed a little too, then immediately walked towards the department.

In the room, Praveen, a young assistant professor, was already seated with his laptop open, writing something. Sudhanshu Babu placed the umbrella in a corner. Praveen looked up and said, "Sir, very few students have come today."

"We shall teach however many have come."

Looking at the umbrella, Praveen said, "That is a beautiful old design. You do not get handles like that now."

Sudhanshu Babu merely said, "Hmm."

The class began at ten past ten. There were fourteen students. The subject was memory and the present in modern Maithili fiction. It was an old unit in the syllabus, one Sudhanshu Babu had taught for many years. As he wrote on the blackboard, "Memory changes the present," the chalk broke in his hand.

He took another piece of chalk.

A girl asked, "Sir, is memory true, or do we change it later?"

Sudhanshu Babu paused before answering. Usually, when asked such a question, he gave an example at once. Today the words did not come quickly.

"Both," he said at last. "The event is one thing, but the form in which we keep it in the mind can change with time."

The student asked again, "Then which one is the truth?"

There was a little laughter in the room. Sudhanshu Babu smiled too. "That is a good question for a storyteller, and a difficult one for an examination."

Everyone began to write.

He turned towards the blackboard, but before his eyes there suddenly appeared that rainy day from six years earlier.

Ramakant had come to his house that afternoon. It was the same grey umbrella. The cloth had looked almost new then.

For three months the two of them had barely spoken. The cause was so slight that now, even to state it fully in his own mind embarrassed Sudhanshu Babu. On

a college selection committee, Ramakant had supported a young candidate, while Sudhanshu Babu had pressed particularly for one of his former research students. The younger candidate had been appointed.

Sudhanshu Babu had never openly said that he was hurt. He had merely stopped going for tea with Ramakant, stopped walking with him to the station, and limited himself in the department to whatever conversation was necessary.

At first Ramakant had tried two or three times to laugh the matter away. Then he too had fallen silent.

On that rainy afternoon Ramakant had appeared unexpectedly at the house. Malati Devi made tea. Sudhanshu Babu sat on the veranda. The lower part of Ramakant's pyjamas was wet.

"There is a lot of water on the road," he said.

Sudhanshu Babu replied, "That happens in the rains."

Ramakant was silent for a few moments. Then he took a paper from his pocket and said, "I have to go to Patna tomorrow."

"Why?"

"I have to see a doctor."

Sudhanshu Babu did not take the paper. "There are no doctors here?"

Ramakant gave a faint laugh. "There are. One of those doctors has sent me to Patna."

Malati Devi set down the tea and went inside.

Holding the cup, Ramakant watched the steam for a long time. Then he said, "Can you come with me?"

For years Sudhanshu Babu kept that sentence in his memory in a form that made Ramakant's question seem merely polite: "Can you come with me?"—like an ordinary invitation to which it was easy to say no.

That day Sudhanshu Babu had answered at once, "I don't have time just now."

That was all.

Ramakant nodded. "All right."

After a while he got up to leave. The rain was very heavy by then. From inside, Malati Devi said, "Stay a little longer in this."

Ramakant said, "I'll get a rickshaw."

The umbrella remained hanging in a corner of the veranda. No one noticed.

The next morning Sudhanshu Babu saw it. He thought of taking it to college, then did not. "He will come and take it," he told Malati Devi.

Ramakant went to Patna. Two weeks later came the news that he had a serious blood disorder. Treatment began. Sudhanshu Babu telephoned twice. The first conversation was brief; the second time Ramakant's son answered.

"Babuji is asleep," the son said.

Sudhanshu Babu said, “When he wakes, tell him I had called.”

He kept thinking that he would call again.

Three months later Ramakant was gone.

The class bell rang. The students began to rise. Sudhanshu Babu looked at the sentence on the blackboard—“Memory changes the present.” He wiped the board clean with the duster.

On her way out, the girl said, “Sir, the answer to the question is still incomplete.”

“Which question?”

“Which one is the truth?”

Sudhanshu Babu smiled slightly. “Next class.”

By afternoon the rain had grown heavy again. The sound of drops filled the roof of the department. While eating, Praveen asked, “Sir, Ramakant Sir was an old friend of yours?”

“Yes.”

“I once read an article of his. The language was very simple.”

“He wrote simply.”

“What was he like personally?”

Before answering, Sudhanshu Babu looked at the umbrella. “Very talkative.”

Praveen laughed. “The opposite of you.”

“In some ways.”

Praveen opened his lunch box again and continued eating. The conversation ended.

Sudhanshu Babu suddenly remembered that Ramakant had not been a talkative man. Not, at least, in his last ten years. He had simply talked more in front of Sudhanshu Babu. Sudhanshu Babu understood the difference only now.

College ended at three. The rain showed no sign of stopping. Students stood along the veranda. Some had motorcycles, some umbrellas; some were calling home to ask for a vehicle.

Sudhanshu Babu opened the grey umbrella. As he reached the gate, a voice called from behind, “Sir!”

He turned. Vishal, a first-year student, came running with a book held over his head. “May I walk with you as far as the bus stand? I didn’t bring an umbrella.”

Sudhanshu Babu was instinctively about to say, “I am in a hurry.” The sentence reached his throat, but did not come out.

He lifted one side of the umbrella. “Come.”

They walked together. The umbrella was a little small for two people. Sudhanshu Babu’s right shoulder was getting wet, and Vishal’s left arm too.

Along the way Vishal kept talking about the college—the hostel roof leaked, no new books had come to the library, he wanted to stage a Maithili play. Sudhanshu Babu answered now and then with a "Hmm."

Near the bus stand Vishal said, "Sir, you got wet."

"So did you."

"The umbrella is small."

For the first time Sudhanshu Babu looked at the umbrella as a whole. "It did not seem this small before."

Vishal did not understand. His bus arrived. He bowed and got on.

Sudhanshu Babu went and stood beneath the awning of a tea stall. The rain fell across the road like a curtain. Visibility had shortened.

Suddenly he remembered one part of that last meeting which, for six years, he had never remembered completely.

Before saying, "Can you come with me?" Ramakant had been silent for a long time. He had put down his teacup and rested both hands on his knees. His eyes had not been on Sudhanshu Babu but on the rain in the courtyard.

And after asking the question, when he heard Sudhanshu Babu say, "I don't have time just now," he had not immediately said, "All right."

There had been a moment between the two.

A very small moment.

In that moment Ramakant had looked straight at Sudhanshu Babu. Directly. As though he wanted to say something. Then he had looked away.

Sudhanshu Babu understood clearly now that the moment had not vanished from his memory; he himself had repeatedly cut it away. He had kept reducing the event so that his own answer too might seem like a smaller offence.

The tea seller asked, "Tea?"

Sudhanshu Babu started. "Yes."

As he held the tea, his other hand remained around the grey umbrella's handle. His thumb moved again and again over the letters "R. C."

He thought—if he had gone to Patna that day, what would have changed? The illness would still have been there. Perhaps death would still have come. Whether the friendship would have become what it had once been, he did not know that either.

It was also true that Ramakant himself had not telephoned him during those three months. They had both been adults; the silence had belonged to both of them.

And yet a sentence does not remain merely a sentence. "I don't have time just now."

Sudhanshu Babu finished his tea. The rain had eased a little.

When he reached home, Malati Devi came to the door with a towel. “Your shoulder is completely wet.”

“A student walked with me.”

Malati Devi took the umbrella. “The hole has grown. Shall I have it stitched?”

Sudhanshu Babu was about to say, “Leave it. What use is it now?” But after a moment’s thought he said, “Yes. Have it stitched.”

Folding the umbrella, Malati Devi asked, “Will you hang it in the same place again?”

Sudhanshu Babu looked behind the door. There were three hooks there. For six years the grey umbrella had hung separately on the middle hook, like some object in the house meant not for use but only for remembrance.

He said, “Take the black one down. We’ll have that repaired. Keep this one in front.”

Malati Devi looked at him. “In front?”

“Yes. The umbrella that works should be in front.”

Malati Devi said nothing. She opened the wet umbrella and left it in the veranda to dry.

After dinner Sudhanshu Babu took out his old diary. Ramakant’s home number was still written there, though the number might have changed. His wife, Sharda Devi, lived in Patna with their son.

Sudhanshu Babu picked up his mobile. Ramakant’s son Amit’s number was in his contacts. In six years they had spoken only twice—once after the shraddha, once about a copy of a book.

He opened the number and stared at the screen for a long time.

From beside him Malati Devi asked, “Will you call?”

“I don’t know.”

“Then why have you been looking at the number so long?”

Sudhanshu Babu did not switch off the phone. “I’ll ask how Sharda Bhabhi is.”

Malati Devi simply said, “Ask,” and got up to take her medicine.

Sudhanshu Babu moved his thumb towards the call button, then stopped. It was ten o’clock. “It has become late,” he said to himself.

He placed the phone on the table.

In the veranda the grey umbrella stood open. Its cloth was drying. Through the small hole, the yellow light of the bulb fell on the floor like a single point.

Sudhanshu Babu went as far as the door. He looked at the umbrella. Then he picked up the phone again.

He did not call. He merely wrote Amit a short message: “It has been a long time. How is Sharda Bhabhi?”

No reply came immediately after the message was sent. Sudhanshu Babu put the mobile in his pocket; the umbrella was still open in the veranda.

At night the rain began again. Amid the sound of the drops, the mobile chimed once. Sudhanshu Babu reached towards his pocket, then paused for a moment. In the veranda, the old umbrella was slowly drying.

STORY 22

Photo Studio

Jyoti Photo Studio at Benta Chowk in Darbhanga had been there for thirty years. The blue signboard outside had faded in many places, but ‘Passport Photos in Ten Minutes’ could still be read in thick white letters.

Inside, the owner, Pankaj Jha, still kept the wooden counter from his father's time. Beneath the counter glass were dozens of small photographs—someone's school identity card, someone's job application, someone's pension papers, someone's passport.

In the age of mobile phones, the work of the studio had changed. Fewer large wedding albums were made now; more photographs were taken for Aadhaar cards, examinations, bank documents and passports.

Pankaj used to say that people generally came to a studio not for their face, but for some piece of paper.

At around half past ten that Thursday, an elderly couple came in.

The man's name was Aniruddh Jha. His wife was Shail Devi. Both were past seventy.

Aniruddh carried a brown cloth bag; Shail Devi held a small purse.

Pankaj pulled two chairs forward. ‘Please sit. What would you like?’

Aniruddh said, ‘Passport-size photographs. Separately.’

‘How many copies?’

‘Four each.’

Opening the computer, Pankaj asked, ‘For passports?’

‘No.’

‘Visa?’

Shail Devi laughed. ‘Where are you sending the two of us at this age?’

Pankaj smiled too. ‘Then pension papers?’

Aniruddh said, ‘Not for papers.’

Pankaj stopped asking questions. A photographer did not have the right to know every reason.

He pulled down the white backdrop at the rear. Aniruddh was seated first on the stool.

‘Head a little straighter.’

Aniruddh straightened his head.

‘Keep the glasses on?’ Pankaj asked.

Aniruddh looked at Shail Devi.

Shail said, ‘Keep them. Without the glasses, you don't look like yourself.’

Pankaj lowered the light slightly. ‘There is glare on the lenses. I'll change the angle.’

There was a small old scar above Aniruddh's right eyebrow. Pankaj noticed it on the screen.

‘Shall I soften this scar a little?’

Before Aniruddh could answer, Shail Devi said, ‘No.’

‘All right.’

‘It has been with him for forty-five years,’ Shail said. ‘Let it remain in the photograph too.’

Aniruddh smiled. ‘I fell off a bicycle. The story won't be written in the photograph.’

‘If the scar stays, the story will be remembered,’ Shail replied.

Pankaj raised the camera. ‘Try to look natural. Not too serious.’

For a moment Aniruddh's face grew stiff, then relaxed. The shutter clicked.

Pankaj turned the screen towards them. ‘Have a look.’

Aniruddh looked. ‘Fine.’

Shail Devi leaned slightly forward. ‘The eyes are right. Keep this one.’

Now Shail Devi sat down. She straightened the end of her sari. The vermilion in the parting of her hair was very faint.

Pankaj asked, ‘Shall I fix this stray section of hair?’

‘As much as can be done by hand. Not by computer,’ Shail said.

Pankaj laughed. ‘All right.’

From behind, Aniruddh said, ‘The mole on the left cheek must stay.’

Shail turned at once. ‘Where will the mole go?’

‘These photographers make a great many things disappear.’

Pankaj said, ‘Nothing disappears here unless someone asks for it.’

The shutter clicked.

Shail looked at the screen.

‘The lines beneath my eyes show too much,’ she said.

Pankaj asked, ‘Shall I soften them a little?’

Shail was silent for two moments. Then she shook her head slightly. ‘No. Let them stay.’

Aniruddh said softly, ‘Let the photograph show the face that exists today.’

Hearing this, Pankaj looked again at the image on the screen.

Many customers said: remove the mark, brighten the complexion, fill in the hair, reduce the darkness under the eyes.

These two were worried about the opposite—that something might be removed.

Pankaj arranged four copies of each photograph. 'It will take twenty minutes.'

Aniruddh looked at his watch. 'We'll have tea and come back.'

They both went out.

While preparing the printer, Pankaj said to Deepak, 'Take out the photo paper.'

Deepak was in college and helped at the studio in the afternoons.

He looked at the elderly couple's pictures on the screen. 'Passport?'

'No.'

'Then?'

'They said it isn't for papers.'

Deepak laughed. 'What else is a passport-size photo for, apart from papers?'

Closing the printer tray, Pankaj said, 'Wait twenty minutes. I haven't understood either.'

The photographs came out of the printer.

Pankaj lifted each sheet and examined it in the light.

The lenses of Aniruddh's spectacles were clear. So was the scar above his eyebrow.

Shail Devi's mole, the fine lines beneath her eyes, the greying part of her hair —all remained in their places.

Technically, Pankaj did not find the photographs especially beautiful. But both faces looked as though they had not come to be made into photographs; they had come to have their presence recorded.

Twenty minutes later the couple returned.

Aniruddh carried two earthen tea cups. One was empty; a little tea remained in the other.

Shail Devi said, 'The tea across from your shop is still far too sweet.'

Pankaj cut the photographs into four-copy sets.

'Shall I write the names on the back?'

Aniruddh said at once, 'Yes.'

Shail added, 'And today's date with the name.'

Pankaj looked at her. 'The date?'

'Yes. The full date.'

Pankaj took a fine pen. On the back of the first set he wrote: 'Aniruddh Jha — 19 September 2026.'

On the second set: 'Shail Devi — 19 September 2026.'

Deepak was watching from behind the counter. His curiosity had grown.

Pankaj placed the two sets in separate white envelopes.

He held Aniruddh's envelope out towards Aniruddh.

Shail Devi extended her hand. ‘Give that to me.’

Pankaj paused.

Then Aniruddh took the envelope containing Shail Devi's photographs.

Deepak's eyes widened a little.

Pankaj smiled. ‘Now I understand. Photographs of each other.’

Aniruddh said, ‘Yes.’

‘Some special occasion?’

Shail Devi sat down again. ‘Call it special, or call it ordinary.’

Aniruddh opened the brown bag. From it he took out an old plastic album.

The corners of the album were worn.

He opened the first page.

A black-and-white wedding photograph. Aniruddh thin, his hair thick; Shail Devi's face round and full of shyness.

On the second page was a group photograph with the children. On the third, a school function. On the fourth, a Chhath ghat.

In almost every photograph they were together, or among several other people.

Aniruddh said, ‘After our marriage, very few photographs of us were taken separately.’

Shail Devi said, ‘There are thousands of photographs on the mobile. But whose hand the phone will be in, who will know the password, which photograph is where—I don't understand any of that.’

Pankaj asked softly, ‘So this is why?’

Shail Devi pointed to an empty sleeve in the album.

‘Last month my cousin died,’ she said. ‘Her family kept searching for one clear, recent photograph of her alone. In every photograph someone or other was with her. In the end they cropped her face out of a fifteen-year-old group photograph.’

Pankaj fell silent.

Shail continued, ‘I didn't like that. And it wasn't only about a photograph after death.’

Aniruddh looked at her.

Shail said, ‘I thought—if I go first, which face of mine will this man look at? The one from our wedding? The one from forty years ago?’

Aniruddh smiled gently. ‘In that photograph she wasn't even looking at me. She was looking at the camera.’

‘And in your old photograph you look so serious, as if you're angry with someone.’

Deepak could not suppress his laughter.

Aniruddh laughed too.

Shail Devi tapped the envelope in her hand. 'I want the face I have today. The face I see every day now. With the glasses. With the scar.'

Putting Shail Devi's envelope into his pocket, Aniruddh said, 'And I want this one with the lines under the eyes.'

Pankaj understood that the photographs were not being made for death, but to preserve the present form of life.

He asked, 'Won't you take one photograph together?'

Aniruddh said, 'We have plenty together.'

Shail added, 'We have very few separately. One day, when one of us is left, that person should have the other's face alone.'

For a few moments there was silence near the counter.

Outside, a tempo horn sounded. A student waiting to have a photograph taken peered into the shop.

Aniruddh took out his wallet.

Pankaj told him the charge.

Shail Devi took one of the four photographs and slipped it into the transparent pocket of her purse.

Aniruddh's face was immediately visible in the small rectangle.

Aniruddh placed one photograph of Shail Devi inside his old diary.

The remaining photographs would stay in the album at home.

They both stood up.

At the door, Shail Devi turned and asked, 'You wrote the date clearly on the photographs, didn't you?'

'Yes.'

'The date is important. Later people keep guessing the age.'

Pankaj said, 'It is written clearly.'

They left.

Deepak immediately asked, 'Bhaiya, have customers like that ever come before?'

Pankaj said, 'No.'

'Wasn't it a little sad?'

Pankaj turned towards the computer. 'Did it seem sad to you?'

Deepak thought. 'At first. Not afterwards.'

Pankaj did not reply.

Throughout the afternoon many people came. One student for an admit-card photograph, one woman for a bank account, two young men for job applications.

As he photographed each of them, Pankaj kept remembering Aniruddh and Shail Devi's words.

In the evening, while closing the shop, he looked at the old photographs kept beneath the counter glass.

In one corner was a photograph of his own parents.

It was about eighteen years old. His father's hair was half black then; his mother did not wear glasses.

Pankaj took the photograph out.

His father was now seventy-five. His mother seventy-two. Both lived at home, only two kilometres from the studio.

Pankaj photographed dozens of faces every day. He did not have a photograph of his own parents as they looked today.

There must have been many pictures on the mobile, of course. At someone's birthday, during worship, with the grandchildren. But a separate, direct portrait, without decoration—he did not know whether there was one.

That night at dinner Pankaj asked his mother, 'Are you free on Sunday?'

Serving dal, his mother asked, 'Why?'

'We'll go to the studio.'

His father looked up from the newspaper. 'Work even on Sunday?'

'Not work.'

'Then?'

Pankaj said, 'I'll photograph both of you.'

His father laughed. 'After so many years, you finally remembered?'

Pankaj laughed too. 'Yes. A little late.'

On Sunday morning Jyoti Photo Studio opened half an hour earlier than usual.

When Deepak arrived, he saw Pankaj's father seated on the stool in front of the white backdrop.

His mother stood near the counter adjusting her sari.

Deepak began to pick up the camera, but Pankaj said, 'Father alone first.'

His father asked, 'Not both together?'

Straightening the backdrop, Pankaj said, 'Together afterwards. Separately first.'

He set the camera.

His father began to remove his glasses.

Pankaj stopped him. 'Keep them on. Without the glasses, you don't look like yourself.'

His mother laughed from behind.

Pankaj raised the camera to his eye.

Through the glass, his father's present face was clear—white hair, spectacles, and all the lines on his forehead.

He clicked the shutter.

STORY 23

A Pair of Shoes

The women's college hostel was undergoing its year-end inspection.

The superintendent, Madhu Jha, was newly appointed. She had taken charge three months earlier, and this was the first time she was having a complete inventory made of the old storeroom, kitchen, study room, and the students' shared cupboards.

For two days Vimala Didi had been with her, reading out entries, taking out objects, and wiping away dust.

Vimala had worked as an attendant in the hostel for twenty-five years. Without consulting any register, she remembered whose bed had a loose leg, which window leaked during the rains, and which student did not drink milk at night.

After the thirtieth item, Madhu opened an old wooden cupboard.

On the upper shelf lay three umbrellas, a torn bag, two steel boxes, and a pair of black shoes.

Madhu stopped when she saw the shoes.

"Whose are these?"

Vimala bent to look. "Leave them where they are."

"Whose are they?"

"No one's."

Madhu read the line written in the inventory: "Black closed shoes, one pair, owner unknown."

"The rule says that property with an unknown owner is to be removed after six months," Madhu said. "These look much older than that."

The shoes were indeed old, though they did not look like something fit to be thrown away. The leather had softened in many places. A new black rubber piece had been fitted to the heel of the right shoe; the lace on the left was a slightly different shade. Even the inner soles were not the same colour.

Vimala said, "They are old, but they are not bad."

"The owner?"

"There is no name."

Madhu closed the register and looked at her. "There is no name, and there is no owner, are not the same thing."

Vimala smiled faintly. "With this pair, they are."

Madhu did not understand.

That evening a notice was pinned to the board:

"If the old black shoes kept in the hostel's shared cupboard are anyone's personal property, please contact the superintendent's office with proof by Friday. Thereafter they will be removed according to the rules."

A few students stopped to read the notice. Some laughed; some looked at one another. No one came to the office.

On Wednesday Madhu asked Vimala, "See? They belong to no one."

Vimala replied, "That is what I told you from the beginning."

"Then why object to removing them?"

"Wait until Friday."

At about seven on Thursday evening, quick footsteps sounded along the last veranda of the hostel. Nisha Jha, a third-year student, appeared at the office door carrying a transparent file.

"Ma'am, may I ask you something?"

"Ask."

Nisha hesitated. "The black shoes... have they been removed?"

Madhu pushed up her spectacles. "Are they yours?"

"No."

"Then?"

"I need them until Saturday."

"Why?"

"I have a scholarship interview in Darbhanga. The notice says: simple dress, closed shoes. I only have sandals. I called home, but they cannot send new shoes so quickly."

Madhu sat straighter in her chair. "How can I give you property whose owner is unknown?"

Nisha looked at Vimala, who was standing near the doorway holding a register.

Vimala said, "The owner is not unknown. The owner's house is simply very large."

Madhu frowned. "Another riddle?"

Nisha said softly, "Ma'am, these are not private shoes."

"Then why has the register said 'owner unknown' all these years?"

Vimala did not answer at once. She went to the cupboard and took out a small tin box that had been kept behind the shoes.

Inside the box were half a tin of black shoe polish, a small brush, two spare laces, and a thin notebook.

Madhu opened the notebook.

The first page was marked with the year 2014.

Below it were dates:

"12 August — taken."

"12 August evening — returned."

"3 November — taken."

"4 November — returned."

The next page was 2015. Then 2016. Some years had two entries, some five. There were almost no names anywhere.

"What is this?"

Vimala said, "The record of the shoes going out."

"To whom?"

"Whoever needed them."

Nisha stood silently.

Vimala pulled up a chair and sat down.

"Many years ago there was a student named Sulochana. In her final year she had to go to Patna for a job interview. For the first time in her life, she bought a pair of closed black shoes. She got the job. When she left the hostel, she did not take the shoes with her."

"Why?" Madhu asked.

"She said, 'There will be little occasion to wear them at home. Someone else here may need them next.' I told her to write her name on them. She refused. She said, 'If I write my name, people will think they are borrowed. Let them belong to everyone.'"

Madhu looked at the shoes.

Vimala continued, "In the first year two students wore them. Once a lace broke; the student brought them back with a new lace. Another time the heel wore down; someone had it repaired. Once the polish ran out, another student put in a new tin. Slowly a rule formed: take them, return them clean; if something breaks, get it repaired."

Madhu slipped her hand inside the left shoe. Along the edge of the sole were tiny stitches.

"This too?"

"The sole came loose one day before someone's interview. She had it stitched before returning them."

Nisha said softly, "I had heard about them from senior students. That's why I came to ask."

Madhu kept turning the pages of the notebook.

On one page, in red ink, there was only one sentence:

"Returning them is essential."

"Getting the job isn't essential?" Madhu asked.

Vimala laughed. “How would we enter that in the register?”

Madhu laughed too.

Then she became serious again. “But the rules?”

Vimala said, “If the rules require a name, write the hostel’s name.”

“Why wasn’t that done before?”

“No one asked before. The former superintendent understood the matter. The old line in the register simply remained.”

Madhu thought for a few moments. Then she turned to Nisha.

“Size?”

“Six.”

Vimala said at once, “The shoes are six too.”

Madhu opened the notebook and wrote a new line:

“Friday evening — Nisha Jha, for interview.”

Nisha looked surprised. “You’ll write my name?”

“This time we will. The item may be shared; the responsibility will not be unknown.”

Nisha nodded.

Vimala handed her the shoes. “Try them on.”

Nisha put them on at one side of the office. The left shoe was a little tight. She walked two steps, then turned back.

“They’re fine.”

“If they hurt your feet, don’t stuff them with paper and keep walking,” Vimala said. “There’s a thin insole in the box.”

Nisha laughed. “Didi, you remember every solution.”

“The shoes are old. The mistake need not be new.”

On Saturday morning Nisha left at half past six. The shoes had been polished. She wore a simple salwar-kurta and carried her file and a cloth bag.

Madhu watched from the veranda. At first Nisha’s steps were a little cautious; by the time she reached the gate, they had become natural.

Twice during the day Madhu opened the cupboard and looked at the empty space.

By afternoon she found her own behaviour ridiculous.

“It is only a pair of shoes,” she told herself.

But when Nisha had still not returned by seven in the evening, Madhu looked at the veranda clock three times.

At twenty past seven the gate opened. Nisha came in.

She carried the same transparent file in one hand and a paper bag containing the shoes under her arm. On her feet were her old sandals.

"The interview?" Madhu asked.

"It's done."

"How did it go?"

"The result will come later."

She placed the bag on the table.

"Why did you take the shoes off already?"

"There was water on the road after I got off the bus. I thought it better not to wear them through the wet street."

Vimala opened the bag. The shoes were clean.

Beside her name in the notebook, Nisha wrote: "Returned."

Then she took a small packet from her pocket.

"What is this?"

"New laces. The old ones are still usable, but one end is beginning to fray. Keep these."

Madhu kept looking at her.

"I do not yet know whether I'll get the scholarship," Nisha said, "but the shoes have come back."

Vimala looked at Madhu.

The red line in the notebook had proved true again.

On Monday the hostel had its annual inspection.

Reading down the inventory, the inspector stopped at item forty-seven.

"Black closed shoes, one pair — owner unknown?"

Madhu said, "That is an old entry. It was awaiting correction."

"Has the owner been found?"

"No."

The inspector's pen stopped.

Madhu opened the next register. A new entry had already been made:

"Shared interview material — black shoes, size 6, one pair."

In the owner column was written: "Hostel — shared use."

The inspector looked up slightly. "Shared shoes?"

Madhu opened the tin box and showed him the notebook.

The inspector read two or three pages. He said nothing. Then, in the old inventory, he drew a line through "owner unknown" and wrote: "Transferred to shared materials."

The inspection moved on.

That afternoon Madhu took down her old notice from the board—the one warning that the shoes would be removed.

In its place she pinned a smaller new notice:

"Black shoes, size 6 — available for interviews/formal requirements. Enter your name at the office. Return them clean after use. If the laces, sole or heel break, have them repaired if possible."

Below it, Vimala added one line in her own handwriting:

"Returning them is essential."

Madhu read the line and laughed.

That evening a first-year student reading the notice asked, "Ma'am, whose are these shoes, after all?"

Madhu thought for a moment before answering.

"The register says they belong to the hostel."

The student asked again, "And actually?"

Madhu looked towards the cupboard. Inside, the black shoes rested with their new laces. The leather was old, but the pair was ready again.

"Actually," she said, "they belong to whoever needs them, and after that, to the next person who does."

The student read the notice once more.

The cupboard was closed. Inside it was a pair of shoes that belonged privately to no one, yet was useless to no one.

STORY 24

Shared Shade

On the footpath east of Madhubani's old bus stand, Ramsagar's cart was number seventeen and Nasima Khatoon's cart was number eighteen.

After a municipal survey, the ground allotted to each had been measured and marked with a red rectangle. Ramsagar's rectangle was six cubits long and four cubits wide; Nasima's was almost the same. Between them, a narrow strip a cubit and a half wide had been left for pedestrians.

Ramsagar sold bael sherbet, sattu and lemon water. Nasima kept cucumbers, lemons and a few fruits according to the season.

By the second week of Jyeshtha, the afternoon heat had become so fierce that it was difficult to hold the iron handle of a cart without a cloth.

Nasima kept laying a wet sack over the cucumbers she had arranged in the morning.

Ramsagar watched his slab of ice melt away by half the day.

Each cart had its own small umbrella, but once the round shade covered the cart, the vendor himself remained half in the sun. If a customer stood there, the shade had to be divided yet again.

One Monday, four municipal employees arrived in the market carrying folded green mesh, bamboo poles and a receipt book.

The young man walking in front called out, "Heat-relief scheme. One shade net for every two registered vendors."

Ramsagar took out his card. "Seventeen."

Nasima showed hers. "Eighteen."

The employee looked at both cards together. "Fine. You two are a pair."

Taking the green net into her hands, Nasima asked, "Only one net?"

"One for two carts. Eight by six. Hang it between you. A photograph will be uploaded. It says shared use."

Ramsagar laughed. "Even shade comes in pairs now?"

The employee laughed too. "The net is large. It will cover both of you."

They were also given two bamboo poles, but the poles were short. The employees advised them to use two old posts so that the net could be stretched properly.

There was an electricity pole behind the carts, but it stood outside Ramsagar's red boundary.

Behind Nasima's cart was the tin post of a tea stall, but it stood almost two cubits beyond her rectangle.

Ramsagar said, “Let us tie the bamboo to our own carts and raise the net above them.”

Together they tied the ropes.

The green net stretched from one cart to the other.

Its shade also fell over the narrow pedestrian strip between them.

For the first time, both of them sat fully in the shade at noon.

Nasima removed the wet sack from the cucumbers. “They have given us something useful.”

Ramsagar looked at the ice box. “Today it will last half an hour longer.”

Two customers stood in the narrow strip between the carts and drank sherbet.

An elderly woman rested for a while beside Nasima’s cart.

Under the green light filtering through the shade net, the colours of the market seemed altered.

At half past twelve, two municipal workers arrived on a motorcycle.

One carried a measuring tape; the other held a mobile phone.

First they read the cart numbers, then looked at the red lines, then raised their eyes to the net.

“Whose rope is this?”

Ramsagar said, “Mine and Nasima Sister’s. The municipality gave us the net.”

Standing on the pedestrian strip, the worker said, “Nothing may be hung over the pedestrian passage.”

Nasima looked surprised. “There is nothing below. People are walking through.”

“The overhead extension is also outside your allotted boundary.”

Ramsagar pointed to a corner of the green net. “Your own people gave this to us today.”

The worker said, “That is from the relief section. We inspect vending boundaries.”

“But they gave one net for two carts. The carts are in separate rectangles. If one net has to cover both, it has to cross the space between.”

Pulling out the measuring tape, the worker said, “My papers say that no bamboo, rope, awning, net or goods may extend beyond the allotted line.”

He took a photograph with his phone.

Nasima asked quietly, “Then where are we supposed to hang a shared net?”

The worker replied, “Ask the relief section. I am here to record violations.”

The second employee wrote on a narrow slip: “17/18 — net beyond boundary.”

Below it was an instruction to remove it within twenty-four hours.

Ramsagar held the slip and looked at it for a while.

The municipal seal was printed at the top.

That evening, the two of them took the net down.

Nasima said, “Back to our own little umbrellas.”

Folding the net, Ramsagar said, “Something given for two people cannot be used by even one.”

The next morning the heat was harsher.

Ramsagar thought of a solution.

Instead of spreading the net fully, he folded it in half and tied it only within one allotted rectangle at a time.

“You keep it from ten to twelve,” he told Nasima. “I’ll take it from twelve to two. Then you again from two to four.”

Nasima laughed. “Will the shade move according to the clock?”

“The papers watch the clock. The sun does not.”

They began sliding the net back and forth by turns.

When it covered Nasima’s cart, Ramsagar’s ice melted faster.

When it covered Ramsagar’s cart, Nasima’s cucumbers began to soften.

At one in the afternoon the number of customers increased.

At that time it was Ramsagar’s turn to have the net.

Nasima tilted her small umbrella to cover the cucumbers and stood herself in the sun.

Ramsagar said, “Move the net towards your side.”

“No. It is your turn.”

“I can buy more ice. If the cucumbers soften, customers will not buy them.”

Nasima said nothing.

They shifted the net a little towards her.

Just then the relief team from the first day appeared at the eastern end of the market.

The young man took out his mobile phone from a distance and prepared to take a picture.

He stopped beside carts seventeen and eighteen.

“Why is the net only half spread?”

Ramsagar took out the notice. “If we spread it fully, it crosses the boundary.”

The young man read the notice. His face changed.

“But under the scheme we have to show shared use. In the photograph both carts should be under the shade.”

Nasima said, “If we hang it that way, there will be another photograph for this notice.”

The young man was silent for a few moments.

Then he said, “My mobile form has three options: in use, not in use, damaged.”

Ramsagar asked, “There is no fourth option — ‘If used, it breaks the rules’?”

The young man did not smile. “No.”

He entered something on his phone.

Nasima asked, “What did you write?”

“Shared use not verified.”

“But the net is here.”

“The net is here. But both of you are not under the shade together.”

Ramsagar placed the second slip behind the first one.

The relief team left.

Sales were low that day.

Ramsagar bought ice twice.

Five kilos of Nasima’s cucumbers remained unsold till evening; she took two kilos home.

The next day, both of them went to the municipal office.

A teenager named Bipin watched Ramsagar’s cart, while Nasima’s elder daughter watched hers.

The vending section was on the first floor of the office.

Ramsagar showed the notice about the net extending beyond the boundary.

The clerk opened a file and said, “No structure may extend beyond the marked line. This is an old instruction.”

Nasima handed him the second slip. “This says we must use the shared net.”

The clerk read it. “This is from the climate-relief cell. They sit downstairs in the new building.”

Ramsagar asked, “Aren’t both papers from the municipality?”

“They are. The sections are different.”

“Then which one are we supposed to obey?”

The clerk pushed his chair back. “Ask for written clarification.”

“From whom?”

“Submit an application to both sections.”

They bought plain paper from the photocopy shop downstairs.

Ramsagar wrote the application; Nasima signed her name.

The first section stamped it as received.

The second section said, “Bring the vending section’s remarks first.”

Ramsagar went upstairs again.

It was one in the afternoon.

Their two carts were operating in the market without their owners.

At last an assistant wrote in pencil at the corner of the application: “Joint site inspection required.”

“When?” Nasima asked.

“A team will be formed. You will receive a phone call.”

They returned to the market.

Ramsagar’s ice was almost gone.

Nasima’s daughter had been wetting cloth again and again to keep the cucumbers covered.

The green government net lay folded beneath the cart.

No call came for three days.

Nor on the fourth.

On the fifth day Ramsagar brought an old bamboo mat from home.

He tied it at an angle entirely within his red rectangle.

Nasima had her old blue umbrella reinforced.

The green government net remained folded.

At noon the narrow strip between the carts was once again in full sun.

Customers stood only briefly, moving from one cart to the other.

Nasima said, “The shared shade exists on paper now.”

Ramsagar replied, “On paper it will not cross the boundary.”

At the end of that week, a new municipal poster was pasted on the wall of the bus stand:

“Protect Yourself from the Heat: Shade, Water, Rest.”

Below the slogan was a photograph from the relief scheme showing two vendors smiling beneath a single green net.

Ramsagar looked at the poster, then at their folded net.

Nasima took the two notices out of her purse.

One said: “Remove net beyond boundary.”

The other said: “Shared use not verified.”

The same municipal emblem was printed at the top of both.

Nasima folded the slips again and put them back in her purse. “We’ll see when the phone call comes.”

Ramsagar kept stirring the sattu mixture.

The afternoon sun fell directly on the cubit-and-a-half strip between them.

The government net lay safely folded beneath the cart; according to the paperwork, it crossed no boundary and gave shade to no one.

STORY 25

The Other Door

From half past seven in the morning, two signboards stood in front of the main entrance of Asha Health Centre.

The first, in blue letters, said: “Regular Patients — Main Entrance.”

The second, in green, said: “Free Health Camp — Other Door.”

An arrow on the green board pointed towards a narrow lane along the right side of the building.

The lane curved around to the rear courtyard, where a temporary registration table, three benches and two medicine boxes had been set up.

It was the centre’s foundation day.

The local traders’ association had paid for the medicines, four doctors had agreed to conduct free examinations until two in the afternoon, and an advertisement had appeared in the newspaper: “Health for All.”

Neelam Jha arrived at seven as a volunteer.

She was an undergraduate student and the niece of Dr Prabhakar, the owner of the health centre.

Her job was to distribute camp slips, keep the queue orderly, and guide elderly patients to the correct room.

The first time Neelam read the board saying “Other Door,” she paused.

“Why from the back?” she asked the manager, Arun Babu.

Counting a bundle of papers, Arun Babu said, “The crowds must remain separate. The regular patients already have appointments in the main waiting room.”

“But the doctors are the same?”

“The doctors are the same. Registration is separate.”

“Water?”

“There is an earthen pot at the back.”

Neelam looked through the glass of the main hall.

Cool air moved inside, a digital queue number glowed on the wall, and a water cooler stood in one corner.

In the rear courtyard, half the shade came from a bamboo canopy.

Arun Babu understood her look.

“It is a one-day camp. Everyone will be examined and everyone will get medicine. That is what matters.”

By eight, people began arriving.

Sita Devi from Ratanpur came first. She had pain in her knees. Reading the green sign, she turned into the lane on the right.

Then came an elderly couple: the husband complaining of breathlessness, the wife needing an eye examination.

Neelam wrote serial numbers on the slips: 1, 2, 3…

By half past eight, the rear courtyard was full.

Twelve people could sit on the three benches. The rest stood along the wall.

Meanwhile regular patients kept arriving through the main entrance.

Some had prior appointments, some had come to show test reports.

At the main registration desk they received white slips; the camp patients received green ones.

Both kinds of slip bore the same name of the health centre.

The difference was only the colour and the box for the fee.

On the green slip, that box was blank.

At nine, the first doctor arrived: Dr Neha Mishra.

She entered through the main door, put down her bag, then went to the room assigned to the camp at the back.

The first ten patients were examined.

Blood pressure was measured. Some were sent to the laboratory in the main building for blood-sugar tests.

Neelam noticed that to reach the laboratory, a camp patient had to come out again through the same narrow lane and then enter the small corridor beside the main entrance.

“Why not go straight through the inside door?” Sita Devi asked.

Neelam searched for an answer.

An assistant said, “That is the regular section.”

Sita Devi said nothing.

Leaning on her walking stick, she took the lane again.

At ten the sun grew strong.

The shade of the canopy at the back began to shrink.

Neelam thought of bringing two plastic chairs from the main waiting room, but Arun Babu stopped her.

“Those chairs are for patients with appointments.”

“Elderly people are standing here.”

“Bring stools from the storeroom.”

There were five stools in the storeroom.

One had a shaky leg.

Neelam wiped them and set them out.

By eleven, the camp numbers had crossed seventy.

At that time only seven patients were sitting in the main waiting room.

Neelam looked once more through the glass.

Cool air. Empty chairs. Chilled water.

At the back, an elderly woman was wiping her face with a towel.

“Daughter, where is the water?”

Neelam pointed towards the earthen pot.

The water was finished.

She filled two bottles from the main hall and brought them out.

Arun Babu said nothing, though his face suggested that this was an exception, not the rule.

At half past eleven the sky suddenly turned grey.

Wind rose.

The two signboards in front of the main entrance began rocking back and forth.

Ramdin, who handled cleaning and small chores, ran over and picked them both up.

“It is going to rain,” he said. “I’ll keep them inside.”

Ten minutes later a few drops fell and then stopped.

Meanwhile Neelam had taken a patient to the laboratory.

Ramdin began mopping the main floor.

The job of putting the boards back outside fell to Rohit, a new volunteer.

He switched their positions.

The blue board now pointed towards the lane on the right: “Regular Patients — Main Entrance.”

The green board pointed directly towards the glass doors: “Free Health Camp — Other Door.”

The words “Other Door” now stood directly in front of the main entrance.

The arrow pointed straight inside.

Rohit did not notice the mistake.

His job was only to stand the boards up again.

For the first five minutes, nothing happened.

Then Saroja Devi from Bharwara read the green board and walked in through the main entrance.

She had the old advertisement for the free camp in her hand.

At the main registration desk she asked, “The free examination is here?”

Swati, who was sitting at the main desk, looked at the board for a moment.

Outside, the green arrow pointed inward.

"Do you have a slip?"

"No."

Swati looked for Neelam but could not see her.

Then she took out a green slip and wrote Saroja Devi's name on it.

Saroja Devi sat down in the glass-walled waiting room.

Four more people came in behind her.

Within ten minutes, eleven patients with green slips were sitting in the main hall.

Some drank water from the cooler. Some watched the digital queue display.

At that moment Manoj Agrawal, a cloth merchant from town, arrived for his regular check-up.

His appointment was for twelve.

Following the arrow on the blue sign, he turned into the lane on the right.

He reached the rear courtyard and looked for the registration desk.

"My appointment is at twelve," he said.

Volunteer Bablu looked at the white slip in his hand.

"You are a regular patient?"

"Yes."

"Then… the board points this way."

Manoj Agrawal looked around: bamboo canopy, stools, medicine boxes, a crowd holding green slips.

"Where is Dr Neha?"

"Inside, in the other room."

"Why have I been sent here?"

Before Bablu could answer, another regular patient, Jagdish Babu, a retired bank manager, came through the lane.

He too was holding a white slip.

The two men looked at each other.

Jagdish Babu said, "Is the main entrance closed?"

"No."

"Then why were we sent here?"

Bablu explained about the board.

Jagdish Babu became irritated.

"I paid and took an appointment, and now I am supposed to stand here in the sun?"

At that very moment Sita Devi, returning from the laboratory, heard the sentence.

She said nothing.

She only tightened her grip on her walking stick.

At five past twelve, Neelam returned to the main hall.

She stopped when she saw the scene.

People with green slips were inside the glass waiting room.

People with white slips were in the rear courtyard.

Arun Babu arrived too.

"What has happened here?"

Rohit ran outside.

The moment he saw the boards, his face fell.

"I switched their places."

Arun Babu said at once, "Put them right! Quickly!"

Neelam asked, "First, where do we send the patients who are already here?"

"Send everyone to the section they belong to."

"But the doctors are already seeing slips from both sides."

"The crowds have become mixed."

The crowds had indeed become mixed, but the examinations had not stopped.

Swati had already sent three patients with green slips to the doctor according to their numbers.

At the back, Bablu had already measured Manoj Agrawal's blood pressure.

No machine had failed.

No paper had been lost.

People had merely reached the correct work through the wrong door.

Arun Babu came into the main hall.

"Camp patients, please go to the back. Regular patients, sit here."

Saroja Devi stood up.

She was holding a small bottle of water, half full.

She asked Neelam, "Had I been sitting in the wrong place?"

Neelam said, "The board was wrong."

"But the chair was fine."

Neelam had no answer.

Returning towards the rear courtyard, Sita Devi passed Manoj Agrawal, who was now going towards an empty chair in the main waiting room.

Sita Devi asked softly, "Was the sun too strong there?"

Manoj looked at her.

There was no mockery in the question, only a direct inquiry.

He said, “Yes. A little.”

Sita Devi nodded.

“For me too.”

They went their separate ways.

The boards were put back in their old positions.

Green arrow to the right.

Blue arrow straight ahead.

But traces of the half-hour’s confusion remained.

Two green slips had been left on chairs in the main hall.

A white slip lay pressed beneath something on the rear table.

During the short lunch break, Dr Neha Mishra asked Arun Babu, “Why are two entrances necessary?”

Arun Babu said, “For orderly management.”

“For half an hour just now, everything ran in reverse. What broke?”

“The regular patients were inconvenienced.”

“And the camp patients?”

Arun Babu did not answer.

Neelam was beside them counting slips.

She did not raise her head.

After a while Arun Babu said, “The main waiting room has limited space. Paying patients come with appointments. We have to provide them comfort.”

Dr Neha asked, “And the camp patients do not give time?”

“They do not pay a fee.”

As soon as the sentence came out, Arun Babu fell silent.

The counting of slips in Neelam’s hands stopped at that point.

Dr Neha said nothing.

She closed her lunch box and walked towards the rear courtyard.

By one in the afternoon, the sun was even stronger.

Dr Neha asked for ten chairs from the main hall to be sent to the back.

The extra twenty bottles kept beside the water cooler were sent there too.

Arun Babu did not object.

With fewer chairs in the main hall, two regular patients had to stand.

Ten minutes later, empty chairs became available again.

The camp ended at two.

A total of one hundred and twenty-seven patients had been examined.

The regular department had continued running as well.

In the evening the staff were adding up the registration slips.

A representative of the traders' association arrived.

He wanted a photograph for the newspaper.

"A photograph with a crowd will look good," he said.

The photographer suggested that everyone stand together in front of the main glass entrance.

Arun Babu moved the blue signboard for the main entrance slightly aside so that the name of the health centre would be clearly visible in the photograph.

Neelam picked up the green board too.

"Where should I put this?"

"Outside the photograph," Arun Babu said.

The photographer arranged patients, doctors, volunteers and organizers together.

Some held green slips, some white; in the photograph the colours of the slips were not visible.

The next day the photograph appeared in the newspaper.

The caption read: "Equal healthcare for patients of all sections at Asha Health Centre."

Neelam cut out the newspaper item and pinned it to the office noticeboard.

Beside it hung the preparation list for the next month's camp.

The third line on the list said: "Place the Free Health Camp signboard in front of the other door on time."

Neelam stood for a long time looking at the two pieces of paper together.

Then, with her pen, she made a small question mark beside that line on the preparation list.

She did not tear the paper.

She did not erase the rule.

Only the question mark remained beside the line—exactly where, for half an hour the previous day, the difference between the two doors had disappeared.

STORY 26

The Seven-Minute Voice

At the top of the first page of Saurabh's notebook, in black ink, were the words: "Seven Minutes."

Below them were seven small circles.

Beside the first circle: "Did Ma eat?"

Beside the second: "Maths Question 37."

Beside the third: "Oil for Nani's knees."

Beside the fourth: "School excursion."

Beside the fifth: "My new shoes."

Beside the sixth: "Did it rain in Patna today?"

The seventh circle was blank.

Saurabh had made the notebook himself.

No teacher had told him to do it.

It was not homework.

It was simply that his mother, Rama Devi, usually spoke to him on the phone for about seven minutes.

Rama Devi worked in the accounts section of a book-distribution warehouse in Patna.

Her evening shift ended at eight.

It took five minutes to walk from the warehouse to the bus stop, and the bus towards the village usually arrived at eight twelve.

That short stretch between eight five and eight twelve had become the most solid part of Saurabh's day.

The phone rang at eight five, six, or seven.

"Yes, tell me."

That was all Rama Devi would say.

Saurabh began with the first circle.

"Did you eat?"

"I had flattened rice and curd at the warehouse. You?"

"Nani gave me rice."

Second circle.

"How do I do the division in Maths Question Thirty-seven?"

"I do not have the notebook in front of me. Divide first by the smaller number."

"That does not work."

"Then ask Master Saheb tomorrow. I will not guess from here."

Third circle.

"Nani said the oil is finished."

"Get it tomorrow from Ramnaresh's shop. There is money in the tin."

By the time they reached the fourth circle, the first horn of the bus could usually be heard on the other end of the call.

"Quickly, tell me. The bus has come."

Then Saurabh shortened his questions.

"Can I go on the excursion?"

"Where?"

"Rajnagar."

"How much money?"

"Two hundred."

"All right. Tell Nani to give it."

The fifth circle was often left out.

Sometimes the sixth too.

The seventh had remained blank from the beginning.

After the call ended, Saurabh drew a small arrow beside any question left unanswered and carried it over to the next day's page.

Some questions travelled for three days.

"Shoes" — Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday.

"Science chart" — Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday.

"Why did Deepak take my pen?" began on Wednesday's page, but by Friday Saurabh had worked out the answer himself.

Deepak had not stolen the pen.

During play, Saurabh himself had left it on Deepak's notebook.

That question was crossed out.

Rama Devi was pleased with this system of the notebook.

One night she said, "You write your questions down, so nothing gets missed on the phone."

Saurabh looked at the notebook and smiled.

In fact, a great deal was missed.

That day, on his way home from school, he had found an old brass-coloured button half-buried in the earth.

He wanted to know whether shirts from his mother's childhood had buttons like that.

But in which circle should he write the question?

Food, studies, Nani, money, school—where did a button belong among these?

Beside the seventh blank circle he wrote: “Button.”

When the call came, there were already four necessary things to discuss first.

The bus arrived earlier than expected.

“Tomorrow,” Rama Devi said.

The next day the button gave way to Nani’s medicine.

On the third day, the school fee.

On the fourth, Rama Devi herself said in a tired voice, “The warehouse count went wrong today and my head is aching. If there is something necessary, say it.”

Saurabh erased the arrow he had drawn beside “Button.”

He pressed the button between the pages of the notebook.

In this way the seventh circle slowly became a home for different things:

the string of a half-torn kite,

a yellow bird seen beside the pond,

two lines of dialogue he had been given in the school play,

a word from one of Nani’s old stories,

and the question of whether his mother truly liked tea without sugar, or drank it that way only to save money.

Sometimes he left the seventh circle blank.

Sometimes he wrote only one word beside it:

“Nothing.”

Rama Devi came home four or five times a year.

But this time she had been unable to come for five months in a row.

A new accounting system had started at the warehouse, two employees had left, and demand for books had risen before Diwali.

On the phone Rama Devi kept saying, “I will definitely come in the last week of Kartik.”

Saurabh wrote the date at the back of the notebook.

Until then he had counted only questions.

Now he began counting days as well.

A week before she was due to return, Rama Devi asked, “What should I bring when I come?”

Saurabh had a separate list for that in his notebook:

a geometry box,

blue socks,

a storybook,

a cord for Nani’s spectacles.

He read out the list.

Before ending the call, Rama Devi laughed and asked, “Anything else?”

Saurabh looked at the seventh circle.

Beside it was written: “Many things.”

“No,” he said. “That is all.”

Rama Devi reached home on Saturday afternoon.

When Saurabh returned from school, her iron trunk lay open in the courtyard.

Nani was taking out the clothes one by one and holding them to the sun.

Rama Devi sat on the veranda peeling potatoes.

Saurabh stood at the gate for two moments.

For so many days he had met his mother’s voice every day on the phone that the sudden sight of her body sitting before him seemed slightly unfamiliar.

As soon as Rama Devi saw him, she dropped the potato and stood up.

“Why have you become so thin?”

Saurabh laughed.

“You could not see me on the phone.”

Rama Devi touched his head.

“How was I supposed to see your head over the phone?”

Nani said, “Wash your hands and face first. The two of you have started your story right at the gate.”

Saurabh went inside.

That evening there was plenty of talk in the house:

neighbours, the warehouse, Patna, school, fields, uncle, Diwali, new clothes.

But Saurabh’s “many things” did not appear anywhere among those conversations.

After dinner he took his notebook and sat beside his mother.

“What is that?” Rama Devi asked.

“The Seven-Minute Notebook.”

“Let me see.”

Saurabh did not hand it over immediately.

“I will ask first.”

“Ask.”

He opened an old page.

“Did shirts in your childhood have brass-coloured buttons?”

For a moment Rama Devi looked at him.

“Why suddenly?”

Saurabh took the old button from between the pages.

"I found it on the road."

Rama Devi placed the button on her palm.

"Not on my shirts. But your Nana had a coat with buttons like this. I remember—"

Saurabh interrupted at once.

"Do you remember it clearly?"

Rama Devi laughed.

"Clearly? No. The memory is not clear. When Nana comes home, we will ask him."

Saurabh opened another old page.

"I saw a yellow bird. Long beak. What is it called?"

"Am I a bird book?"

"You know everything."

"Who told you that?"

Saurabh smiled.

Third question.

"Do you really like tea without sugar, or are you saving money?"

Rama Devi burst out laughing.

"You have kept this question for five months?"

"Three months."

"Answer: at first I was saving money. Now tea with sugar tastes too sweet."

Saurabh put a small mark in the notebook.

Rama Devi noticed.

"Are there so many old questions?"

"A lot."

"Will you ask all of them today?"

"Yes."

Ten minutes later Rama Devi leaned her back against the wall.

Twenty minutes later the pace of Saurabh's questions slowed.

After half an hour, three pages of the notebook had been crossed through.

"Now?" Rama Devi asked.

Saurabh turned a page.

"That is all."

"All?"

"For today."

Rama Devi looked at the clock.

"It is only nine."

On the phone, by nine o'clock they would both already have reached their own places.

Saurabh would have closed the notebook.

Rama Devi would have been looking for a seat on the bus.

Now time lay open.

No horn.

No "quickly, tell me."

Even so, both fell silent.

Nani was putting away utensils in the kitchen.

Outside, the wind moved through the bamboo leaves.

Rama Devi asked, "Everything all right at school?"

"Yes."

"No quarrel with Deepak?"

"No."

"Maths?"

"Fine."

"Then?"

"What?"

"Say something."

Saurabh laughed, but said nothing.

Rama Devi laughed too.

"On the phone you do not let me speak during those seven minutes."

"There is less time there."

"Here there is more."

Saurabh did not answer.

For two days the same thing returned in small forms.

In the morning Rama Devi sat with him over tea.

"What are you thinking?"

"Nothing."

At noon, while putting away his books, she asked, "Have you read this story?"

"Yes."

"How is it?"

"Fine."

In the evening they walked towards the fields.

“Is this embankment new?”

“Yes.”

“When was it made?”

“In Bhadav.”

Rama Devi said with mild irritation, “It was easier to talk to you on the phone.”

For the first time Saurabh looked directly at her.

“On the phone there were questions.”

“There are no questions here?”

“There are. But not every question is for asking.”

Rama Devi fell silent.

That night the electricity went out.

Nani lit a lantern and placed it on the veranda.

It was hot inside the house, so all three sat outdoors.

Rama Devi had a basket of pea pods in her lap.

She was shelling them for the next day’s vegetable.

Without being asked, Saurabh sat beside her and pulled over another empty plate.

For a while there was only the soft sound of pods splitting open.

One pod held five peas.

Another held two.

A third held three very small ones.

Saurabh placed one tiny pea on his palm and said, “If this is planted, will it grow into a plant?”

Rama Devi looked at the pea.

“It may. It may not. We would have to see whether it has dried out.”

Saurabh set it aside.

Silence again.

After a while the sound of a distant train came.

Rama Devi said, “At night, behind my room in Patna, I hear trains like that.”

Saurabh asked, “How many times?”

“I have never counted.”

“Why did you never tell me before?”

Rama Devi’s hands stopped.

“Where was the time on the phone to tell you about trains?”

Saurabh said nothing.

Rama Devi began shelling peas again.

"In the beginning, when I heard trains at night, they made me think of home," she said softly.

Saurabh's hands stopped too.

That sentence could not fit inside any of the circles in the Seven-Minute Notebook.

He did not ask, "Why home?"

He did not ask, "How much did you miss it?"

He did not ask, "Did you cry?"

He simply remained sitting beside her.

The distant sound of the train faded.

Nani lowered the lantern wick a little.

Rama Devi spoke again.

"One night the rain was so heavy I could not leave the warehouse. I missed the bus. I could not call you. The next day you told me you had fallen asleep."

Saurabh remembered.

That night he had watched the phone until half past nine.

In his notebook he had written: "Why no call?"

The next day Rama Devi had said only, "It was raining."

Saurabh thought of looking for that page in the notebook, then let the thought go.

"I fell asleep late," he said now.

Rama Devi looked at him.

"But you told me you had already gone to sleep."

"I did."

"Why?"

Saurabh kept breaking the stems from the pea pods.

"There were only seven minutes on the phone."

Rama Devi did not smile.

She only nodded.

A little later Saurabh went to his basket and brought out the old brass-coloured button.

By then the button no longer lived in the notebook; it stayed in his pencil box.

"Does this look like the button from Nana's coat?"

"I do not know."

"Then keep it."

"Why?"

"So there will be something from home in your room."

Rama Devi did not take the button.

"You keep it. My room is not short of things from home."

"What is there?"

"Your photograph, the tin of makhana Nani gave me, an old key from this house, and the paper boat you made last year."

Saurabh was surprised.

"You still have that boat?"

"Yes."

"It must have got wet."

"It does not rain inside my room."

Both laughed.

After a while all the pea pods were finished.

Still, neither of them got up.

The electricity had not yet returned.

There was the yellow light of the lantern on the veranda, darkness outside, and now and then the sound of crickets.

Saurabh suddenly understood that being silent was also something one could do.

On the phone, silence consumed time.

Here, silence made time.

During the next three days, Rama Devi and Saurabh did not have any great conversations.

They went to the market together.

One day, while hanging clothes to dry, Rama Devi told Saurabh about a strange habit of one of her colleagues at the warehouse.

Returning from school, Saurabh simply said—without first turning it into a question—that a crow had flown away from the playground carrying a red ribbon.

Rama Devi asked, "Where did it take it?"

"I do not know."

"Did you follow it?"

"A little way."

"Why?"

"To see."

That was all.

And the conversation was complete.

Rama Devi's leave was for seven days.

On the morning of the eighth day she had to return to Patna.

That night Saurabh opened his notebook.

For the previous seven days he had not made a single new "Seven Minutes" page.

On a blank page he wrote the date.

Below it he drew seven circles.

He left the first six blank.

Beside the seventh he wrote: "Silence."

Then, after thinking a little, he crossed out "Silence."

In its place he wrote: "Together."

In the morning Rama Devi left.

Two days later, at six minutes past eight in the evening, the phone rang.

Saurabh already had the notebook open.

"Yes, tell me," Rama Devi's voice said.

Behind her came the sounds of vehicles at the bus stop.

Saurabh looked at the first circle.

Blank.

The second.

Blank.

The third.

Blank.

"What happened?" Rama Devi asked. "No questions today?"

"There is one."

"Tell me."

"Did you hear the train today?"

For a few moments there was no answer from the other end of the phone.

Saurabh did not look at the clock.

Rama Devi did not speak at once either.

Somewhere in the distance a horn sounded.

Then Rama Devi said, "Not yet. But it may come."

Saurabh said, "All right."

Both remained silent for a while.

In that silence were the sounds of buses, Nani's cough on the village veranda, and one shared night stretched between two places farther than seven minutes could measure.

The horn sounded a second time.

Rama Devi said, “The bus has come.”

Saurabh replied, “Yes. Go.”

Before the call ended, Rama Devi said, “If I hear the train tomorrow, I’ll tell you.”

Saurabh drew no arrow in the seventh circle.

He left the page open.

STORY 27

The Unfinished Play

There were still eighteen days left before the annual theatre evening.

At one side of the school's largest room stood two bamboo poles, with an old white sheet stretched between them.

Seven students sat on a mat in front, each holding their own pages.

Malati Jha looked at the clock.

"Shall we begin?"

No one answered.

In the middle of the mat lay a thick notebook with a blue cover.

The notebook belonged to Shashank.

Until three days earlier, Shashank had been the loudest voice in that room.

He changed dialogues, showed how a character should walk, then crossed out lines he had written and wrote them again.

Today he was not in school.

He was no longer even in this town.

His father's work had suddenly been transferred to another town, and within two days the family had packed up and left.

Before leaving, Shashank had handed the notebook of the play to Malati Jha.

"Five scenes are complete," he had said. "I am writing the sixth."

"The ending?" Malati Jha had asked.

Shashank had laughed.

"That is exactly where I am stuck."

At the time everyone had taken it as an ordinary remark.

No one had imagined that three days later that stuck ending would occupy such a large space in the school.

The play was called "Evening at the Threshold."

The story was not very long.

Two sisters, an old house, the threshold between inside and outside, and the choice between leaving home to study in the city or staying in the village with their ageing mother.

The play moved around that decision.

Shashank had not turned the decision into a sermon.

One sister's wish to leave was not merely ambition; the other's wish to remain was not merely sacrifice.

Their work, fears, stubbornness and affection unfolded gradually through separate lines.

Jyoti played Anaya, the elder sister.

Ritu played Meera, the younger.

Deepak played the maternal uncle, who wanted the house sold.

Apoorv played the young neighbour who repeatedly brought news between the two sisters.

Neelima played the elderly mother.

And Renu handled the work behind the stage—chairs, lamp, curtain, entrance cues, everything.

The beginning of the sixth scene had also been written.

Evening.

A lamp on the veranda.

Meera inside.

Mother on the cot.

Anaya standing at the threshold with her bag beside her.

Apoorv enters from the path outside and says that the last bus to the city will leave in half an hour.

Up to this point everything was complete.

After that came five pages of dialogue.

The mother does not stop Anaya.

Meera does not ask her to stay, but places the household accounts notebook in her hand.

Anaya puts the notebook back on the table.

The uncle says that a decision made too late ceases to be a decision.

Apoorv says he can hear the bus horn outside.

Then came the final page.

On that page Shashank's handwriting was no longer as clear as before.

Two lines had been crossed out.

One line was only half written.

The last complete sentence was:

"Before crossing the threshold, Anaya turns back."

After that there were only three words:

"Meera looks at her..."

That was all.

Half the page below was blank.

The next page was blank too.

Everyone sitting on the mat kept looking at those three words.

Deepak broke the silence first.

"We can write from here."

Jyoti said at once, "Who will write it?"

"All of us."

"Inside Shashank's play?"

Deepak said, "Are we performing the play, or worshipping the notebook?"

Malati Jha said nothing.

Ritu pulled the notebook towards herself.

She read, "Meera looks at her. Then Anaya leaves to catch the bus. What is difficult about that?"

Jyoti looked at her.

"You think Anaya leaves?"

"Yes."

"I do not."

"You are playing Anaya, so you want her to stay."

Jyoti smiled.

"You are playing Meera, so you want her to leave?"

Ritu did not answer.

Deepak said, "Let us write two endings. We will keep whichever works better in rehearsal."

Renu was straightening the sheet used as the stage curtain.

From behind it she said, "Better for whom?"

Deepak turned.

"For everyone."

Renu said, "If everyone liked the same thing, we would not be arguing."

Apoorv laughed.

Malati Jha closed the notebook.

"Today we rehearse only up to Scene Five," she said.

"And Scene Six?" Deepak asked.

"Tomorrow."

"Will Shashank be back tomorrow?"

"No."

"Then?"

"Tomorrow, we will still be here."

That day rehearsal ended with the fifth scene.

On her way home, Jyoti looked once more at the blue notebook in Malati Jha's hand.

The notebook was closed, but she felt as though the half-page of blank space had spread beyond it.

The next day Malati Jha telephoned Shashank.

All the students were in the room.

They could not hear Shashank's voice, but they could hear Malati Jha's replies.

"Yes, I found the notebook."

"Yes, it is complete through the fifth."

"No, we have not added anything."

After a while she said, "Do you want to tell us the ending?"

There was a long silence.

Malati Jha only listened.

Then she said, "All right."

After she ended the call, Deepak asked, "What did he say?"

Malati Jha replied, "He had not settled on the ending either."

"Then we can write it."

"He did not say that."

"Then what?"

"He said: look for it on the stage. But do not add your lines to the pages I wrote and leave them under my name."

The room fell silent again.

Jyoti said softly, "That is fair."

Deepak was still dissatisfied.

"How are we supposed to look for it on the stage and not write it?"

While loosening the curtain rope, Renu said, "First let us walk it."

Malati Jha opened the blue notebook.

"Scene Six."

Everyone took their places.

The lamp was lit.

Neelima sat on the cot.

Ritu held the household notebook.

Jyoti stood at the threshold line with the bag beside her.

Apoorv acted as though he were entering from the road outside.

The dialogue began.

Line by line, up to the place everyone remembered.

"Before crossing the threshold, Anaya turns back."

Jyoti turned.

Ritu looked at her.

That was all.

Three moments.

Five moments.

From behind the stage Deepak whispered, “Go on.”

Jyoti asked, “What?”

“Do something.”

Jyoti picked up the bag.

She took one step outside.

Without thinking, Ritu stepped forward and caught her hand.

Jyoti stopped.

Malati Jha asked, “Would Meera do that?”

Ritu let go of the hand.

“I do not know.”

“Again.”

They played the scene again.

The final written sentence.

Jyoti turned back.

This time Ritu did not stand.

Jyoti put the bag down and sat beside the cot.

Deepak said, “That is it. That is the ending.”

Jyoti stood up at once.

“Why?”

“Anaya stayed.”

“Does sitting down mean she stayed?”

“Doesn’t it?”

“She could stand up again ten minutes later.”

Apoorv laughed.

Deepak became irritated.

“Then nothing is ever an ending.”

Malati Jha said, “Sometimes sitting on a stage is not a decision. It is only sitting.”

They played the scene a third time.

This time, after turning, Jyoti remained standing at the threshold.

Ritu put the notebook on the table.

Neelima closed her eyes.
Apoorv kept acting as though he were looking outside.
No one did anything.
From behind the stage Renu counted to five.
Then she dropped the curtain.
Deepak said, “But that remains unfinished.”
From behind the curtain Renu replied, “So does the notebook.”
The rehearsal did not end with that sentence.
Everyone began arguing again.
Apoorv wanted the sound of the bus fading into the distance in the last scene.
Ritu wanted the mother to speak Anaya’s name for the first time.
Deepak wanted Anaya to say clearly, “I am going,” or “I am staying.”
Jyoti tried saying both lines aloud.
Both sounded external to her.
“In the first five scenes Anaya never says anything this directly,” she said.
Malati Jha nodded in agreement.
“Then why suddenly give her the author’s command in Scene Six?”
Deepak replied, “The audience should understand.”
“Understand what?”
“The ending.”
Renu sat down on the mat.
“I think I understand one thing,” she said.
Everyone looked at her.
Renu rarely spoke much about the acting itself.
“Every time we get stuck, we return to the same sentence.”
“Which one?”
Renu opened the notebook and read:
“Before crossing the threshold, Anaya turns back.”
“And after that, something different happens every time.”
“So?” Deepak asked.
“So perhaps what we should show is not an ending, but the turning back.”
“Show the audience our rehearsal?”
“Not the whole rehearsal.”
Renu stood and went to the stage.
She stood on the threshold mark.

"The same sentence. Then the first time, one possibility for five breaths. Lights out. Then the same sentence again. Then a second possibility."

Apoorv asked, "How many?"

"Only as many as we genuinely found in rehearsal, and kept short."

Malati Jha asked, "And dialogue?"

Renu shook her head.

"No new dialogue. We will not invent Shashank's lines."

Jyoti smiled faintly.

"Only the body?"

"Body, distance, position."

Ritu said, "Then Meera says nothing?"

"Shashank wrote nothing for her there."

The sentence made everyone slightly uncomfortable.

Deepak said, "But this is our play too. We are performing it."

For the first time in the argument, Malati Jha spoke clearly.

"Yes. That is why the stage exercise is yours. The original text is Shashank's. They are not the same thing."

On the board she wrote two lines:

Original text.

Stage exercise.

"If they coincide, good. If they differ, record the difference."

Deepak kept looking at the board.

"Then in the programme?"

"Original play — Shashank Mishra."

Malati Jha wrote a second line.

"Final stage exercise — School Theatre Group."

Ritu asked, "Will Shashank like that?"

"I will ask him again. But first we need to make our own boundary clear."

For the next four days they rehearsed only movement in the final scene.

In the first sequence Jyoti crossed the threshold.

She turned back.

Ritu looked at her.

For a few moments they looked at one another.

Then Jyoti walked out.

Ritu did not follow.

Lights out.

In the second sequence, after turning back, Jyoti put the bag down.

But she did not sit.

Ritu too did not move from her place.

The threshold between them remained empty.

Lights out.

In the third sequence, Jyoti came to the threshold with the bag still in her hand, turned back, then placed the bag in the middle of the threshold—not towards Meera.

She did not return inside, nor did she go outside.

Ritu did not come forward to pick up the bag.

The light slowly dimmed.

Deepak liked the third sequence least.

"That is no decision at all."

Jyoti asked, "Are the first two decisions?"

"In the first she leaves."

"She could come back after the scene ends."

"In the second she stays."

"She could pick up the bag again."

Deepak sat down holding his head.

"Your Anaya will never decide anything."

Jyoti laughed.

"Not mine. Shashank's."

Then she paused and added, "And perhaps Shashank's Anaya does not decide either."

On the fifth day Malati Jha spoke with Shashank again by telephone.

This time the students were outside.

When they returned, she said only:

"He says the separate credit is fine. Add nothing to the original notebook."

Deepak asked, "The three sequences?"

"He has not seen them."

"Then permission?"

Malati Jha said, "He gave permission for stage exploration. We never asked him for permission to choose an ending."

That made Deepak think again.

On the sixth day the programme sheet was prepared.

The title of the play at the top.

Shashank's name below it.

Then the names of the actors.

At the very bottom, in small letters, it said:

"The original manuscript is unfinished in the middle of the final scene. After the written text ends, this performance will show three silent stage explorations developed by the group. These exploratory sequences should not be treated as text by the original author."

Deepak read the line and said, "Is it necessary to write all this?"

Renu said, "If it was not necessary, why did we spend five days arguing?"

On the day of the theatre evening the school was noisy from morning.

Someone shook out the mat.

Someone tied the curtain to the bamboo poles.

Someone counted chairs.

Renu asked for a separate table for the blue notebook.

Apoorv asked, "Will the notebook be on stage?"

"In the final part."

"Why?"

"Where the written text stops, it should be clear that what follows is not an accidental omission by us."

Malati Jha said, "Do not turn the notebook into an object for display. Use it only to mark the boundary of the text."

So the notebook was placed at one corner of the stage where the light did not fall directly upon it.

By evening every chair was filled.

Some people stood at the back.

The first five scenes went by without any major mistake.

Jyoti's voice trembled once, but Ritu delivered the next line on time.

Deepak reversed two words in one dialogue, but the audience noticed nothing.

At Apoorv's entrance the curtain caught slightly; Renu freed it by hand.

Scene Six began.

The lamp on the veranda.

The cot.

The bag.

The threshold.

All the dialogue proceeded exactly as it was written in the notebook.

Anaya reached the threshold.

Jyoti turned back.

Ritu looked at her.

At that point Renu came forward from the side of the stage carrying the notebook.

She did not look at the audience.

Looking at the notebook, she read:

"Here the written text of the original manuscript ends."

A faint rustle passed through the hall.

Renu closed the notebook.

"Now, three brief stage explorations by the group."

The lights went out.

Then came back.

The first sequence.

Jyoti turned.

Ritu looked at her.

Jyoti walked out.

Ritu did not come as far as the threshold.

Darkness.

A few people in the audience began to applaud, but the lights came on again immediately.

Renu read the same original sentence once more:

"Before crossing the threshold, Anaya turns back."

The second sequence.

Jyoti put down the bag.

Ritu remained in her place.

The threshold between them stayed empty.

Darkness.

This time there was no applause.

For the third time Renu read the original sentence.

Jyoti turned back.

She placed the bag in the middle of the threshold.

She did not stand as though one foot belonged outside and one inside; she simply remained beside the threshold.

Ritu looked at the bag, then at Jyoti.

No one moved.

The light slowly faded.

This time full darkness fell.

For a few moments the hall remained silent.

Then applause began.

First from two people in the front row.

Then from the back.

Then from almost everyone.

After the curtain fell, Deepak's first question was, "Which one felt like the ending?"

Renu burst out laughing.

"Starting again?"

Deepak laughed too.

"Now we'll ask the audience."

Malati Jha stopped him.

"The play is over. Let them take their own thoughts home."

Behind the curtain Jyoti was picking up the bag.

Ritu said to her, "I liked the first one best."

"You still want Anaya to leave?"

"Yes."

"I like the second."

"Staying?"

"No. Pausing."

Ritu thought for a moment.

"Pausing and staying are different?"

"Maybe."

Ritu smiled.

"Do not let Malati Jha hear that."

Both laughed.

The audience was leaving.

Some students were discussing the first sequence.

Some the third.

An elderly parent came up to Malati Jha.

"I did not understand the ending," he said.

Malati Jha asked evenly, "Where?"

"At the end."

"The original text stops there."

"Then why did you not complete it?"

Before Malati Jha could answer, Deepak, who was standing nearby, said:

"We completed it many times. Not once were we certain the author would have written that."

The elderly parent looked at Deepak.

"Then you left it unfinished?"

Deepak thought for a moment before replying.

"The notebook is unfinished. The stage was not empty."

Malati Jha looked at him.

Deepak himself seemed surprised by his own sentence.

The next day chairs from the programme were being removed from the school.

Renu took the blue notebook to deposit it in the library.

Malati Jha went with her.

The librarian opened the register.

"The play notebook?"

"Yes."

"Complete?"

Renu and Malati Jha looked at one another.

Renu said, "Complete as far as the author wrote it."

The librarian pushed her glasses up.

Malati Jha took out three thin sheets of paper.

At the top of the three were written:

"Stage Exercise 1."

"Stage Exercise 2."

"Stage Exercise 3."

There was no dialogue on the sheets.

Only movement, distance, the position of the bag, and cues for the light to fade.

The librarian asked, "Shall I attach these to the notebook?"

Renu said immediately, "No."

Malati Jha smiled.

"In a separate envelope."

"Why?"

"These are not Shashank's pages."

The librarian placed all three sheets in a separate envelope.

On it she wrote:

"School Theatre Group: Final Stage Exercises."

Only Shashank's name had been on the blue notebook from the beginning.

It remained that way.

One month later Shashank sent a letter to an old friend at the school.

The letter was short.

About the play he wrote only two lines.

"I received the programme sheet. I liked that you did not complete my unfinished page and leave the addition under my name."

The second line said:

"Which of the three sequences I like best, I will not say yet."

After reading the letter Deepak said, "See? He likes one of them too."

Jyoti said, "Did he say that?"

"No. But he will."

Renu folded the letter.

"Let him."

Before the term ended, the theatre group went to the library once more.

The following year's new students wanted to read the play from that notebook.

One student asked, "Why are these three pages separate after the final scene?"

Renu, who was now moving into the next class, took out the envelope.

"They are not the ending of the notebook. They were our rehearsal."

"Can we make a fourth?"

Deepak looked at the student at once.

The old Deepak might have said, "Choose one of these three first."

This time he said nothing.

Renu said, "You can."

"Add it to the notebook?"

"No. On your own page."

The student walked away holding the envelope.

The blue notebook remained on the table.

Its last written sentence was unchanged:

"Before crossing the threshold, Anaya turns back."

After that:

"Meera looks at her..."

Then blank space.

Malati Jha looked at the page once more.

There were still no new words in that blank space.

But around it, three earlier stage explorations and the path towards a new fourth possibility had already opened.

STORY 28

The Thirty-First Bed

On the gate of the night shelter built behind the bus stand, the words “Women’s Shelter—30 Beds” were painted in white.

Champa Devi did not remember those thirty beds by looking at their numbers on paper. She remembered the sounds the beds made.

The right leg of bed number one was a little loose; it went ting-ting when someone sat on it. Bed number five had the lump of an old weld in its frame. While sweeping beneath number eleven, the thin edge of the iron would brush her hand. The mattress on number twenty-seven was the heaviest of all, because the cotton inside it had gathered to one side.

At that shelter, Champa worked from seven in the evening until ten at night, and from four in the morning until six. On paper, the six hours in between did not belong to her.

The contract said: sweep and mop in the evening, clean the toilets, take out the rubbish, dry the wet floor, then do the same work again in the morning.

The paper did not say where Champa’s body was to be from ten at night until four in the morning.

On ordinary days there was no need for that question. Two lanes behind the shelter, Champa rented a small room with a tin roof. At ten at night she would lean the broom against the wall, wash her hands and feet, lock up, and go home. Before dawn, while it was still dark, she would return.

Bimla Devi, the shelter caretaker, would joke, “Your clock is better than mine.”

Champa would say, “It isn’t the clock. It’s the stomach. If I’m late, they’ll strike my name off next month.”

Bimla would laugh, but both of them knew it was not entirely a joke.

One evening in Paush, a drizzle began in the afternoon. By eight at night the wind had grown fierce. Rain rattled on the tin roof of the bus stand as though many small pebbles were falling all at once.

That night all thirty beds in the shelter were occupied.

Among the women who came in, one had spent the whole day carrying sacks at the vegetable market, one had come with a sick relative at the hospital, one had arrived to spend the night after missing her train, and one had been making that shelter her place for the night for months.

Bimla wrote names in the register, asked for identification where possible, and told each new arrival her bed number.

“Twenty-nine.”

“Thirty.”

When the last woman had been given number thirty, Bimla drew a thin line beneath the entries in the register.

At that moment Champa was pouring water over the toilet floor.

A little after nine, her neighbour called her mobile phone.

"Didi, the bamboo holding up your roof has fallen."

At first Champa did not understand.

"Which bamboo?"

"The one holding the tin. It has lifted in the wind. Water is getting inside. I've wedged a brick against the door from outside."

Champa set down the bucket in her hand where she stood.

"The trunk inside?"

"I put it up on the bed. But it would be difficult to sleep there now."

When the call ended, Champa stood for a few moments with the mobile phone still in her hand.

Bimla saw her face from a distance.

"Has something happened at home?"

Champa told her.

Bimla looked towards the gate. Outside, the rain was falling at a slant.

"The road will be bad too if you go now," Bimla said.

"Yes."

"Spend the night here."

The words came easily enough, but afterwards both their eyes went at once to the beds.

There was someone on every one of the thirty beds.

Bimla opened the register.

"The woman in number twelve has gone out for tea, but she'll come back. The woman in number twenty-four has left her bag on the bed. They're all occupied."

Champa said, "I don't need a bed. I'll spread a sheet in some corner."

Bimla looked up as though reading the rules board hanging on the wall beside the gate.

"The passage has to be kept clear. The fire-exit route must not be blocked."

"Then the storeroom?"

Both of them fell silent again.

The storeroom held an iron cupboard, brooms, mops, acidic cleaning fluid, boxes of soap, a can of phenyl, and an old broken chair.

Bimla said, "It isn't right to sleep in there."

Champa smiled. "I handle the things in that room all day. What will happen if I spend the night near them?"

"Holding them in your hands and sleeping with them beside your head are not the same thing."

By then Rampari Devi, who had bed number five, had heard them.

She sat up. "Champa, come here. The bed is wide. There's room for both of us."

Champa shook her head at once.

"No, Didi. You spend all day at the vegetable market. I won't take half your bed at night."

Rampari said, "What do I mind?"

"You may not mind. I do."

Rampari understood some of it and some she did not. She pulled the blanket over herself again.

At ten, Champa's evening shift ended on paper.

She washed her hands, wrung out the wet end of her sari, and sat on the narrow wooden bench beside the gate. During the day, the bench was used for visitors' bags.

Bimla said, "Shall I give you my chair?"

"You have to write in the register all night and watch the gate. The chair is yours."

Bimla gave her an old blanket.

Champa wrapped it around herself.

At eleven the wind grew stronger still. A thin stream of water was coming in beneath the door. Champa got up, folded a sack, and wedged it under the door.

At midnight someone went to the toilet. Champa got up again and wiped away the wet footprints.

Bimla said, "You're off duty now."

Wringing out the mop, Champa said, "If it stays wet, someone will fall."

"You're not an employee now. You're someone spending the night."

Champa laughed. "Which line of the register do I go in?"

Bimla did not answer.

At one in the morning, Champa dozed off sitting on the bench. Her legs hung halfway in the air. The blanket had slipped down to her knees.

Twice Bimla got up and adjusted the blanket. The third time she did not; she thought that if Champa woke, she would pick up the broom again.

At about half past three, a sharp smell came from the storeroom. The cap on a bottle of cleaning fluid had not been closed properly. Bimla set it upright.

Champa woke.

"What time is it?"

"Half an hour until your shift starts."

Champa stepped down from the bench. Her legs were numb. She held the wall and stood still for a moment.

"Skip the morning work today," Bimla said.

"If I skip it, the paper will mark me absent."

"I'll write that you were here all night."

Champa looked at her.

"Being here all night and being present for the morning shift are two different boxes."

Bimla said nothing.

At four, Champa picked up the broom.

By half past five the rain had stopped. The sky was grey. One by one, the women in the shelter began to rise. One folded her blanket, one searched for her mobile phone, one went outside for tea.

At six, just as Champa was sweeping one last time beneath the beds, a jeep stopped at the gate.

Bimla frowned. "So early?"

Three people came inside: a woman officer, a clerk, and a representative of the contracting agency.

The previous week there had been a complaint about wet blankets and a closed toilet at the night shelter. The inspection had been arranged without notice.

The officer asked first for the register.

"How many for the night?"

"Thirty," Bimla said.

"Beds?"

"Thirty."

"Staff?"

"Me, one night guard, and a cleaner in the evening and morning."

The officer turned a page.

"Where does the cleaner stay at night?"

Bimla opened her mouth to give the ordinary answer—"Home"—but after that night the word stuck.

At that moment Champa was picking up a wet piece of paper from beneath bed number twelve.

Bimla said, "On ordinary days she goes home."

"And last night?"

The contracting agency's representative spoke at once. "Her shift ends at ten."

The woman officer looked at him. "I didn't ask about her shift. I asked about the night."

There was silence for a few moments.

Bimla pointed to the bench.

"She spent the night there, sitting up. The roof of her room was damaged."

The officer went over to the bench. Directly behind it was the door to the storeroom. She looked at the bottles, the phenyl, the brooms inside.

"Here?"

Champa said, "All the beds were occupied."

"The floor?"

"We're not allowed to block the passage."

"The storeroom?"

"There are chemicals in there."

The contractor's representative said, "This was an unusual situation."

The officer said, "What do the rules provide for an unusual situation?"

No answer came.

She looked at the register again. There were thirty names on the residents' page. In the staff attendance register, Champa's evening signature was there, then a blank space for the morning signature. The six hours in between truly did not exist on paper.

The officer asked Champa, "Should your name have been entered in the residents' register?"

Champa said, "I didn't need a bed here. I needed a safe place for my body to be through the night."

"What is the difference?"

"A great deal. If I had taken a bed, there would have been one less for the person it was meant for. But if a worker has to remain here through the night, she needs a place too."

Rampari, who was folding the bedding on bed number five, called from behind, "I told her I'd give her half."

Without turning, Champa said, "Your whole bed is yours."

The officer looked once at Rampari, then wrote something in the register.

The contractor's representative asked, "What are you writing?"

The officer read it aloud. "Temporary staff rest beside cleaning-fluid storage—unsafe. No separate safe rest arrangement for staff at night."

The contractor's representative said, "But the cleaner is not night staff."

This time Champa looked at him.

The officer asked, "Was she inside the building last night?"

"Yes."

"Morning shift at four?"

"Yes."

"Then the question is not merely one of job title."

The inspection moved on. Blankets were opened, the toilets were examined, the fire-exit route was measured.

Champa returned to her broom.

By seven the officials had left.

Bimla was a little excited. "You'll see. Something will happen now."

Champa said, "Inspection papers see many things, and many things they don't."

"This time it has been written down."

"Let it stay written."

She set off for home.

The water in the lane was not up to her knees, but it reached her ankles. Half the tin roof of her room really had lifted away. Her neighbour had raised the trunk onto the bed.

For two days Champa slept on that neighbour's veranda. On the third day the bamboo was tied back into place.

At the shelter, the days began to run as before: thirty beds, thirty numbers, the evening broom, the morning broom.

The inspection was almost forgotten.

About twenty days later, one afternoon, a small handcart stopped at the shelter gate. Champa was not on shift then.

When she came in that evening, Bimla showed her something beside the gate.

An iron folding bed stood against the wall. It smelled of fresh paint.

Champa asked, "Where did this come from?"

"From the central store."

"For a resident?"

"No. The order says—for night staff or emergency staff rest. The number of residents remains thirty."

Champa unfolded the bed and looked at it. It was narrow, but sturdy.

On the side of one leg, a small number had been painted in white—31.

Champa touched the number with her finger.

"The thirty-first bed in a thirty-bed shelter."

Bimla laughed. "The inventory register won't accept anything without a number."

Champa said, "Then the bed has entered the count."

Bimla looked at her. “The person was already here.”

Champa said nothing.

She folded the bed again and set it against the wall. She moved the storeroom brooms, mops, and cleaning fluids two arm’s lengths away from it.

That night she did not need to sleep on bed 31.

At ten she locked up and went back to her room.

Behind her, inside the gate, stood the thirty residents’ beds, each with its own number. Against the wall stood one more folding bed, which had come not from anyone’s kindness, but because an omitted count had finally been noticed.

STORY 29

The Brick Mark

Two slanting lines marked the corner of a wet brick.

Kaushalya recognized the mark from a distance.

Last year Raghuni had drawn those same two lines on the damp body of each brick with a small piece of wood. A brick would come out of the clay, the mould would open, Kaushalya would set it in a row in the sun, and Raghuni would score two slanting lines into one corner.

"So that our batch can be distinguished when they are counted," he would say.

To Kaushalya, the mark had never been a name. It was only a small sign of work—a way of recognizing their row among the thousand or two thousand bricks made in a day.

This year Raghuni was not there.

In Phagun a fever came on; within two days his body had grown terribly weak. There was the village medicine shop, the block hospital, a borrowed vehicle—everything was tried. In the first week of Chait, Raghuni died.

Kaushalya had thought the kiln would now remain only a memory. But by Jeth the grain at home was finished, her younger daughter's school fee was still unpaid, and the accounts from the previous season had not been settled. The clerk, Navalkishor, sent word twice: "Come and settle the account. Raghuni's old debt is still outstanding."

Kaushalya came to the kiln after the third message.

The kiln was as it had always been—red dust, the smell of soot, rows of unbaked bricks, puddles of water here and there, and smoke rising in the distance. Only for her had something changed. Every place where Raghuni's body had been present the year before now seemed empty.

Under the clerk's thatched shelter, two thick ledgers lay on an old wooden table. Navalkishor pushed his spectacles up his nose and opened a page.

"Two lines," he said. "Raghuni's mark. Look—an advance of eighteen thousand four hundred. It could not all be recovered by the end of last season."

Kaushalya looked at the page. In the space for the name was written 'Raghuni–Kaushalya'. Beside it were two slanting lines. Below were figures, dates, deductions, then more figures. On some lines there were only numbers—no thumbprint, no signature.

"When was all this money taken?" Kaushalya asked.

Navalkishor ran a fingernail along the page. "If it is in the account, it must have been taken."

"I remember what I took. Five thousand in Jeth. Two thousand in Sawan for medicine. When were these three thousand taken?"

"Raghuni must have taken it."

"When?"

"The date is written."

"You wrote the date. Where is Raghuni's print?"

Navalkishor grew a little uncomfortable. "We do not take a print every time here. The mark itself is proof."

"These two lines?"

"Yes."

Kaushalya lifted her eyes from the page.

Just then a child came running in from outside and said, "Munshi-ji, please count Ramesar's row."

Navalkishor got up. Kaushalya too went outside.

The sun was fierce. Long rows of newly moulded wet bricks had been laid out. Ramesar and his wife, Panmati, were cutting clay and filling the moulds. Their two children were smoothing the earth around the raw bricks.

Kaushalya's gaze caught on one brick.

At its corner were two slanting lines.

Kaushalya looked at another brick. Two lines there as well. On a third too. The entire row bore the same mark.

She went over to Ramesar.

"Who puts this mark on them?"

Ramesar brushed the clay from his hands and said, "Munshi-ji gave us the old piece of wood. He said this would be the mark for this batch."

"The old piece of wood?"

Panmati picked up a small piece lying beside the raw bricks. Along one edge were two raised ridges. Pressed into the clay, they left the same sign.

Kaushalya took the piece of wood in her hand.

It was not the piece Raghuni had made. Someone must have made another after the earlier one broke. But the mark was the same.

Navalkishor was counting the row. "One thousand seven hundred and forty," he wrote in the child's notebook. "Two lines—Ramesar."

Kaushalya heard him.

"Munshi-ji," she said, "the two lines you just counted—whose are they?"

"Ramesar's."

"And in the ledger inside, whose are the two lines?"

Navalkishor looked at her. "In the old account, Raghuni's."

"Then how can the same mark sometimes be Ramesar and sometimes Raghuni?"

"The batch changes. The mark is only for identification."

Kaushalya said nothing. She handed the wooden piece back to Panmati.

She stayed at the kiln until noon. The clerk opened the ledger again.

"Look, the account has to be settled. If you work this season, it will gradually be deducted."

"Against which mark?" Kaushalya asked.

Navalkishor started.

"If I work, what mark will I get?"

"We'll give you a new one."

"The two lines belong to Ramesar now."

"Yes, this season."

"Then why does Raghuni's debt rest on those two lines?"

Navalkishor said nothing.

Kaushalya wiped the sweat from her forehead with the end of her sari. "When bricks are being counted, the mark belongs to this season's team. When money is being deducted, the same mark belongs to a dead man from last season. Why should one mark have two meanings?"

"That is how the accounts have always been kept."

"The accounts have always been kept that way—or the marks?"

Two labourers sitting nearby almost laughed, but when they saw Navalkishor's face they fell silent.

By evening the matter had spread through the kiln. It was nothing new to anyone that a family's account could continue with the family. What was new was that Kaushalya had seized upon the meaning of the mark.

She returned the next morning. This time she carried an old school notebook.

She sat beside the clerk's table and made two columns on the first page. On the left she wrote: "Work mark." On the right: "Money taken."

Navalkishor frowned. "What is this?"

"An attempt to understand your ledger."

In the left-hand column she wrote—

Two lines — previous season: Raghuni–Kaushalya.

Two lines — this season: Ramesar–Panmati.

Then in the right-hand column she wrote—

Five thousand — Kaushalya present.

Two thousand — for medicine.

Three thousand — no proof.

She put question marks before all the figures that followed.

"Erase the question marks," Navalkishor said.

"Show me the proof and I will erase them."

"You don't trust my ledger?"

"For me to trust a ledger, its meaning has to remain the same."

Navalkishor struck the table with his palm. "The kiln is not a court."

Kaushalya replied in an even voice, "Nor am I a court. I am only asking—are the two lines a person, or are they a batch?"

The owner, Jagmohan, happened to be at the kiln that day as well. He usually came in the evenings, but a trader was due to select a shipment of bricks. Navalkishor told him what had happened.

Jagmohan called Kaushalya over.

"Do you not have to pay the old debt?"

"I will pay what is mine. What Raghuni took, if there is proof, is a separate matter. But two lines are not a birthmark on my forehead."

Jagmohan tried to laugh. "Who said anything about a birthmark?"

"Then why are those lines on the new team's bricks?"

The owner's face grew somewhat serious. He looked at Navalkishor.

Navalkishor said, "The old mark was available, so I gave it to them. What difference does that make?"

Kaushalya answered at once, "Only this much: the people making the bricks have changed, but the person owing the debt has not. If the mark can change whenever it is convenient, how can it be proof of a debt?"

At that moment a man from the trader's party arrived while examining a row of bricks. The colour of one batch seemed slightly different to him.

"Who made these?" he asked.

Navalkishor pointed towards a distant row. "Two lines."

"What does two lines mean?"

Navalkishor paused for a moment. "Ramesar's team."

Kaushalya remained silent.

The trader's man asked, "Didn't the previous batch also have two lines?"

"That was last season."

"Then is the season written on the page?"

Navalkishor began turning the pages of the ledger. Some had dates; some did not.

For the first time, Jagmohan examined the ledger closely.

"Why is the same mark used again and again?"

"There are only so many marks," Navalkishor said. "Two lines, three dots, a circle, two crossed lines—that is about all. When a team changes, the marks are reused."

"Then add the date or batch number," the trader's man said matter-of-factly. "Otherwise, if a bad batch turns up, how will you know whom to hold responsible?"

Kaushalya watched the owner's face. The issue had moved now from a labourer's debt to the quality of an owner's goods. The question that had seemed light in her voice had suddenly acquired weight in its commercial form.

She did not find it funny. Nor did it make her sad. It only made an old truth clear again—the same fact does not weigh the same in everyone's hands.

That afternoon Jagmohan told Navalkishor to prepare four new pages.

First—season/batch number.

Second—production mark and the names of the current team.

Third—advance or money paid, with date.

Fourth—the recipient's signature or thumbprint.

Navalkishor said, "Who will write all this?"

Jagmohan replied, "You will. That is why you are the clerk."

The workers nearby laughed again. This time even Navalkishor smiled a little, though his smile showed more weariness at the extra work than defeat.

Kaushalya said, "And the old debt?"

Jagmohan pulled Raghuni's page towards him on the table. "Where there is a print, we will examine it. Where there are only figures, Navalkishor will explain the basis. Figures in Raghuni's name will not automatically be added to Kaushalya's new wages."

Navalkishor immediately said, "Malik—"

"If the ledger is clear, it is better for me as well."

Kaushalya did not feel as though she had won anything at that moment. Raghuni had not returned. The shortages at home had not ended. The genuine advances of five thousand and two thousand were still in the account. She still needed to work.

But one thing had changed—the two slanting lines were no longer stuck to her body.

She agreed to work at the kiln that season. Her new team consisted of herself and Dhanmanti, her nephew's wife. They were given a new mark—a small crescent. Beside it the batch number was written: "Jeth-3."

Taking the wooden marker in her hand, Kaushalya said, "If you give this mark to someone else next season, write the new season on the page."

Navalkishor said, "So now you'll become the clerk?"

"No. I'll only make bricks. The clerk will do the clerk's work properly."

Navalkishor laughed. "Your tongue has started running a great deal."

"Earlier my hands had more work to do in the clay."

Days passed. The rows of crescent-marked bricks grew longer. Each morning Kaushalya soaked the clay, filled the mould, smoothed the corners, and pressed in the little wooden marker. The sign was small, but now beside it there was a date, a batch number, and a current team.

Ramesar's two-line bricks dried as well. Often, as Kaushalya passed those rows, she would see the mark. For a moment she would remember Raghuni's hands. Then she would see Ramesar's bent back and Panmati's clay-smeared palms.

Slowly she understood: a mark could remain a memory, but it could not remain ownership.

At the end of the month the first new accounting was done. Navalkishor opened the production ledger.

"Jeth-3, crescent, Kaushalya–Dhanmanti—eighteen thousand two hundred bricks."

Then he opened the advance ledger.

"Kaushalya—two thousand, for school fees. Thumbprint."

Kaushalya listened as the entry was read out, then gave her print.

"The old account?" she asked.

Navalkishor opened another page. "Five thousand and two thousand—those two are accepted. No basis was found for the remaining three entries. The owner has struck them out."

Kaushalya remained silent for a few moments.

"What was genuinely Raghuni's will remain written?"

"It will. In his name. It will not enter your new wages automatically."

Kaushalya nodded. She did not hear complete justice in that answer. She heard only one clear line: this figure on this page belonged to this person, on this date. Another figure on another page belonged to another matter. Perhaps clear accounting began there.

Before the rains, a new storehouse was built at the kiln. Leftover bricks from different seasons were used in its lower wall.

One day Kaushalya stopped there to drink water. In the wall she saw a brick marked with two slanting lines. Beside it was another bearing a crescent.

The two marks were set into the same wall.

Kaushalya touched the brick with the two lines. She remembered Raghuni—squinting in the sun, brushing clay from his hands, saying, "So that our batch can be distinguished."

Her eyes filled with tears, but the mark no longer looked to her like a figure in a debt account.

It was only a sign of work from the previous season.

On another brick in the wall was the crescent—this season's.

Kaushalya did not touch it.

She knew that next year the crescent might pass into the hands of some other team.

The mark would remain on the brick.

But in the ledger, the date, the batch, and the person had to remain separate.

Otherwise, a small line in clay can slowly become such a shackle that an entire lifetime may be too little to break it.

STORY 30

Outside the Count

The floodwater had receded, but its height still remained marked on the walls.

In some houses there was a brown line up to the waist, on some doorways up to the chest.

On some walls the mud had dried and cracked.

On others there were marks from new brooms.

In the town's last ward, sand had collected here and there along the lanes.

Shoes sank into that sand.

Pull a foot free, and a wet print remained behind.

That morning, the enumeration team went through the whole ward for the first time.

There were four people in the team.

Junior engineer Prabhakar Jha examined walls, roofs, and foundations.

Clerk Harinarayan carried the register.

Local worker Sunita identified people's homes.

And the newly appointed enumerator, Mrinalini, walked with a bundle of papers and two pencils.

The printed form in Mrinalini's hand had, as its first field, house number.

Second—owner's name.

Third—damage to the roof.

Fourth—damage to the wall.

Fifth—habitable or not.

At the bottom, in small type, there were two lines for remarks.

The form was small.

The ward was large.

The first house had no door.

A bamboo screen leaned to one side.

Sunita said, “This is Ramlochan Sahu's house.”

Harinarayan wrote, “1. Ramlochan Sahu.”

Prabhakar measured the wall.

“A serious crack on the right side.”

Mrinalini looked at the roof.

Half the tiles had fallen.

Ramlochan Sahu was separating wheat from a soaked sack in the courtyard.

He said, “Look at the back room too.”

The team went to the back.

There was mud on the room's floor.

A waterline ran three feet up the wall.

A small iron stove lay overturned in one corner.

Near the doorway, two children's wet books had been spread out in the sun.

Mrinalini asked, “Who used to live in this room?”

Ramlochan said, “A tenant.”

“Name?”

“Ramesh Mandal.”

“How many people?”

“He, his wife, two children.”

“Where are they now?”

“On the school veranda.”

Harinarayan looked up from the register.

“The owner's name has been written. Next.”

Mrinalini looked at the form.

There was no field for Ramesh Mandal's name.

On the first remarks line she wrote, “Back room: Ramesh Mandal family, 4.”

Harinarayan said, “If you put this much in the remarks, the space will run out.”

Mrinalini smiled.

“There is space for now.”

Half the front wall of the second house had fallen.

The owner lived away.

An elderly woman was washing utensils at the doorway.

Sunita said, “This is Kamala Devi. The owner's sister.”

Harinarayan asked, “The owner's name?”

“Shivnarayan Chaudhary.”

“Where is he?”

“Surat.”

“Who lived in the house?” Mrinalini asked.

Kamala Devi shaded her eyes with her palm.

“I did. And two boys in the front room.”

“Two boys?”

“They work in a sweet shop. Their village is in another district.”

"Names?"

"One is Shambhu. The other, Mukesh or Mahesh... I don't know exactly."

A voice came from inside the doorway: "Mukesh."

A thin young man came out.

"I am Mukesh Paswan."

"The other?"

"Shambhu Yadav. He is drying his tools just now."

"Tools?"

"Not the shop's. My own bicycle-repair tools. I do another job at night."

Mukesh went inside and brought out a rusted spanner, a screwdriver, and a small hammer wrapped in cloth.

"All of these were submerged in the water."

Harinarayan said, "This survey is for recording damage to the house."

Mukesh fell silent.

He wrapped the tools in the cloth again.

Mrinalini asked, "Do you live in this house?"

"Yes."

"For how long?"

"Eight months."

On the second remarks line Mrinalini wrote, "Rented room: Mukesh Paswan, Shambhu Yadav; 2 residents."

The space was full.

When they reached the third house, Harinarayan laughed.

"Where will you write the remarks now?"

Mrinalini did not answer.

The owner's register listed the third house under the name of Manorama Devi.

The house had four rooms.

In one, Manorama Devi lived with her granddaughter.

In the second lived Naseema Khatoon, who did sewing work.

In the third lived Kailash and Phulo, a couple who carried bricks.

The fourth room had been empty before the flood.

On the night the water rose, five neighbours had taken shelter in the empty room.

Mrinalini began asking each name.

Harinarayan said quietly, "Those who took shelter are not residents of this house."

"Right."

"Then don't write them."

"We'll record the permanent residents separately."

Mrinalini took a blank sheet from her bag.

At the top she wrote, "House 3 — Residents there."

First line—Manorama Devi, granddaughter Rinku.

Second—Naseema Khatoon, daughter Gulnaz.

Third—Kailash Sada, Phulo Devi, one child.

Below that she wrote separately, "Temporary shelter on the night of the flood: 5; not included in this resident count."

Prabhakar returned after measuring the wall.

He saw the blank sheet.

"What form is this?"

"None."

"Then?"

"I am writing down how many families were living inside the house."

Prabhakar was silent for a few moments.

"Compensation will not be decided from this paper."

"I am not writing a decision."

"People will think that if their names are written, they will get money."

Mrinalini nodded.

"That is why we will tell everyone this is only an enumeration."

Manorama Devi had been listening from a distance.

She said, "I understand that writing my name does not mean I will get money. But if my name itself is not written, who will know where I am?"

No one answered.

The team moved on.

Lane after lane.

Door after door.

The number of houses on the forms kept growing.

So did Mrinalini's blank sheets.

House 4—one owner-family.

House 5—owner away; three tenant families.

House 6—shop below, owner upstairs; watchman's room at the back.

House 7—one widow, one student tenant.

House 8—two brothers as owners, but separate kitchens; with an elderly uncle.

House 9—four seasonal labourers in one room.

House 10—closed.

“Closed” was easy to write.

Mrinalini looked through the crack in the doorway.

An overturned bucket on the floor.

A clothesline on the wall.

An earthen stove in the corner.

Sunita asked the neighbour.

“Who used to live here?”

“Three sisters. They work as cleaners at the hospital.”

“Where have they gone?”

“To a relative's house after the water rose.”

“The owner?”

“In Darbhanga town.”

Harinarayan searched for the owner's name in his register.

“Jagdish Mishra.”

Mrinalini wrote, “House 10: three sisters residing; names to be verified.”

Harinarayan said, “What is the use of writing it without names?”

“At least we will not say the house was empty.”

By noon, twenty-six houses had been counted.

The team sat on the school veranda.

A relief kitchen was operating there.

Steam rose from the rice.

People stood in line holding plates.

Mrinalini spread her papers on the ground.

Harinarayan opened the main register.

“Twenty-six houses.”

Prabhakar said, “Eight severe, eleven moderate, seven light.”

Mrinalini counted her lines.

“Thirty-two families.”

Harinarayan looked startled.

“Thirty-two in twenty-six houses?”

“Yes.”

“People?”

“One hundred and four. Some names still need verification.”

Sunita said, “And we haven't even covered half the ward yet.”

Prabhakar kept drinking water.

Mrinalini lifted the main form.

“On these twenty-six pages, how many signs are there of those one hundred and four people?”

Harinarayan replied, “The form is not for counting people.”

“Right.”

“It is a structural-damage form.”

“Right.”

“Then why are we trying to read both things together?”

Mrinalini folded the paper.

“Because in the relief room, people ask the questions, not walls.”

Prabhakar smiled faintly.

“Don't say that sentence in front of an officer.”

“Why?”

“He will say—even walls, after all, are for people.”

Everyone laughed.

The laughter was brief.

The line for rice moved forward.

At that moment a child came and stood near Mrinalini's papers.

He had a soaked school identity card in his hand.

The photograph inside the plastic had blurred.

The child asked, “Is my name written?”

Mrinalini asked, “What's your name?”

“Sonu.”

“Full name?”

“Sonu Kumar.”

“Home?”

The child pointed toward the main road.

“The one with the red door.”

Sunita understood.

“House five.”

Mrinalini looked at the blank sheet.

House five listed three tenant families, but not the child's name.

Only the names of the heads of families and the number of members.

Mrinalini said, “Your family has been counted.”

The child asked again, “Me?”

Mrinalini paused for a moment.

"Yes, you too."

The child walked away.

At the top of the blank sheet, Mrinalini added a new heading: "Number of family members."

Not everyone's names.

The number clearly.

After noon, the team went to the lower part of the ward.

The water had receded later there.

The mud was still wet.

A piece of plastic was caught on a bamboo pole.

"12" had been written in white chalk on the door of one house.

Prabhakar said, "House twelve."

Sunita stopped him.

"No, twelve is the old municipal number. In our count this will now be twenty-seven."

Harinarayan laughed.

"One house, two numbers."

Mrinalini said, "And now we'll see how many counts are inside it."

The owner of the house was Vasudev Mahato.

He was shovelling mud out of his courtyard.

Prabhakar asked, "How high did the water rise?"

Vasudev put his hand on the wall.

"Up to here."

"The roof?"

"Fine."

"The foundation?"

"Settled a little at the back."

Harinarayan wrote the owner's name.

Mrinalini asked, "Who lived there?"

Vasudev began counting.

"Me, my wife, my younger son."

"And?"

"Sarita in the front room."

"Sarita?"

"She does domestic work. With two daughters."

"And?"

Vasudev looked toward the back.

"Ramvriksh used to live near the storehouse."

"Used to?"

"I haven't seen him since the night of the flood."

Mrinalini was not startled.

"Where did he go?"

"He is sometimes seen at the school. Perhaps in the relief camp."

"Family?"

"Alone."

"Work?"

"With a mason."

Mrinalini wrote.

House 27.

Owner-family—3.

Tenant Sarita Devi—3.

Resident Ramvriksh Sada—1, present location pending verification.

Total—7.

Vasudev looked at the paper.

"Ramvriksh too has been written down?"

"Yes."

"He has no papers or anything."

"We are not distributing identity cards right now."

"Then?"

"We are writing down who used to live here."

Vasudev rested the mud-filled shovel on the ground.

"That's right. His trunk is still there."

A thin tin trunk lay near the storehouse.

Mud had caked onto the lock.

On top of the trunk, the letters "Ra" could be seen in white paint.

Mrinalini did not open the trunk.

She only wrote, "Evidence of residence available."

Harinarayan was watching from a distance.

"Now even a trunk will become a witness?"

Mrinalini said, "Even if there is no name, at least there is some sign."

By the end of the day, thirty-seven houses had been counted.

The main register contained the names of thirty-seven owners.

Mrinalini's separate sheets listed sixty-one families.

A total of one hundred and seventy-three people.

The names or present locations of eleven people still awaited verification.

Seven families were in houses whose owners did not live in the ward.

Nine families were tenants.

Four groups were labourers sharing a single room.

Two elderly people were listed as part of an owner's family but kept separate kitchens.

Harinarayan counted the figures again.

“Thirty-seven houses. Sixty-one families.”

He scratched his head.

“If this register goes up to the office, it will raise a lot of questions.”

Mrinalini said, “If it doesn't, the people will become fewer.”

Prabhakar gathered the papers.

“Tomorrow there is a review at the block office. We'll see there.”

The next day, nine teams sat in the review room.

A map hung on the wall.

Tea on the table.

The smell of wet shoes.

Block officer Anil Kumar asked each team for its figures in turn.

“Ward one?”

“Forty-two structures.”

“Ward two?”

“Forty-nine.”

“Ward three?”

“Thirty-seven,” Prabhakar said.

Anil Kumar wrote it down.

“Severe?”

“Twelve.”

“Moderate?”

“Sixteen.”

“Light?”

“Nine.”

Then Prabhakar said, “There is one additional list.”

Anil Kumar looked up.

“What list?”

Mrinalini placed the bundle of blank sheets in front of him.

"Of the people who were living there."

The room fell silent.

Anil Kumar read the first page.

"This is not on the form."

"No."

"Why was it made?"

"Because in thirty-seven houses we found sixty-one families."

Two people in the room looked at each other.

Anil Kumar read the papers again.

"This cannot become a compensation-eligibility list."

"I haven't written that it is."

"Was that explained to the people?"

"Everyone who asked was told that this is only a resident count. No promise of money or eligibility."

Anil Kumar looked toward Harinarayan.

"You were present?"

"Yes."

"Were people confused?"

Harinarayan thought for a moment.

"Some people asked. But Mrinalini kept explaining it clearly."

Anil Kumar's finger stopped on one line of the paper.

"'Evidence of residence available'—what is this?"

Mrinalini told him about Ramvriksh's trunk.

"The person was not found. The owner says he lived there. His trunk is still there. It is marked as pending verification."

Anil Kumar turned the page.

"'Three sisters, names pending verification.'"

"Information from a neighbour."

"So the list is not fully reliable."

"That is why it says pending verification."

The room fell silent again.

Rekha Devi, supervisor of another team, said, "In my ward too, one house has five tenant families. The main form carried only the owner's name."

A member of a third team said, "I have a group of brick-kiln labourers. There is no owner's house, only huts. Which category do I put them in?"

Anil Kumar leaned back in his chair.

"We are mixing two things right now—structural damage and affected people."

Prabhakar said, "That is what it seems to me as well."

"But the form sent from above is for structures."

Mrinalini said, "Then let the structural form remain as it is. A separate supplementary register can be made."

"On what basis?"

"Information about residents. The level of verification can be marked separately."

Anil Kumar did not agree at once.

He picked up his tea.

After a sip, he looked at the papers again.

"If a separate register is made, three things must be clear."

Mrinalini picked up her pencil.

"First—this is not an approval of compensation."

She wrote it down.

"Second—this register will not decide the rights of either the house owner or the resident."

She wrote that down.

"Third—one person must not be counted in two places."

"Right."

Rekha Devi said, "One fourth point—people who took temporary shelter should not be mixed with permanent residents."

"Right."

Harinarayan said, "And if a name cannot be found?"

Anil Kumar said, "Write the number, write the source, write pending verification. Do not turn an estimate into a confirmed fact."

Mrinalini wrote four headings.

In the room, the old printed form lay beside the blank sheets.

Anil Kumar said, "By this evening, make a one-page supplementary format. Tomorrow all teams will try it."

Mrinalini asked, "Will it be sent upward?"

"First we'll look at the figures."

"And compensation?"

Anil Kumar answered plainly.

"That is a separate decision under the rules. This register does not promise it."

"Right."

"But we need to know the number of affected people."

That sentence was not written on the paper.

But everyone heard it.

That evening four people kept working on the layout of the supplementary page.

At the top, the heading: "Damaged Site: Resident Details."

First field—house number.

Second—name or identification of family/group.

Third—number of members.

Fourth—basis of residence: owner/tenant/service room/shared/other.

Fifth—present location.

Sixth—source of information.

Seventh—verified/pending verification.

At the bottom, in bold, they wrote, "These details do not in themselves create a right to compensation."

Harinarayan read it.

"Will people understand the word 'in themselves'?"

Sunita said, "In the field we will say it plainly."

Mrinalini added another line below: "Having a name recorded is not a promise of receiving money."

Harinarayan laughed.

"They will understand that."

On the third day, the team went back into the ward.

This time they had the supplementary page along with the main form.

At house one, Ramlochan Sahu was outside.

Ramesh Mandal had also returned from the relief school.

Mrinalini said, "Yesterday I wrote your name in the remarks. Today there is a separate resident register."

Ramesh asked, "Will I get anything from this?"

"I am not promising anything right now."

"Then why the name?"

"So that it is not recorded that only the owner of this house was affected."

Ramesh looked at Mrinalini for a few moments.

Then he said, "All right. Write four people."

"You, your wife, two children?"

"Yes."

"Where are you now?"

"School veranda. We probably won't sleep here tonight."

"Why?"

Ramlochan said from the side, "The back wall is still wet. It isn't fit to live in."

Prabhakar nodded.

"That is also written on the main form."

Mrinalini wrote the present location on the supplementary page.

Owner and tenant now appeared on separate lines beneath the same house number.

Ramlochan looked at the paper.

"Now it shows that I wasn't living in the house alone."

Ramesh smiled.

"You weren't living alone before the flood either."

Ramlochan laughed too.

The matter ended there.

The three sisters had returned to house ten.

Their names were Sangita, Rekha, and Pramila.

All three worked as cleaners at the hospital.

Pramila said, "Our belongings were lost in the water, but the house is not ours."

Mrinalini said, "Ownership of the house is one field. Residents are another."

"Money?"

"No promise."

"All right."

Sangita opened her wet iron trunk.

Inside were clothes, an old hospital identity card, a small image of a deity, and strips of medicine.

She said, "Do all these have to be written down?"

"No. Only that you lived here, the number of members, and your present location."

Sangita closed the trunk.

"Then that's fine."

Ramvriksh was found at house twenty-seven.

He was living under a tarpaulin in one corner of the school grounds.

Sunita brought him along.

As soon as Ramvriksh saw his tin trunk, he touched the lock.

"I thought the water had carried it away."

Vasudev said, "I lifted it and put it on bricks."

Ramvriksh said nothing.

Mrinalini asked, “How long have you been living here?”

“Two years.”

“Rent?”

“Not cash. I watch the storehouse at night, and get the room in return.”

Mrinalini looked at the field for basis of residence.

“Service room.”

Ramvriksh asked, “So I'm not a tenant?”

“We're writing the arrangement as you describe it. Is ‘service room’ right?”

“Right.”

“Where are you now?”

“School grounds.”

“Members?”

“One.”

Mrinalini marked him as verified.

Yesterday's “pending verification” was crossed out.

Ramvriksh asked, “How much damage did you write for my home?”

Prabhakar said, “The rear part of this house is in the moderate-damage category.”

“My room?”

Prabhakar looked at the paper.

“Not fit to live in until it dries and is inspected.”

Ramvriksh nodded.

He tried to open the lock on his trunk.

The lock was jammed with mud.

Vasudev went to fetch oil.

The team moved on.

For four days the supplementary register was filled in.

Ward one: forty-two structures, seventy families.

Ward two: forty-nine structures, seventy-four families.

Ward three: thirty-seven structures, sixty-one families.

Ward four: seventy-two structures, seventy-nine families.

In some wards the difference was small.

In some it was large.

Especially in lanes where rooms were rented out, labourers lived behind shops, or several kitchens operated within one courtyard.

At the block office, two figures were written beside the map.

"Damaged structures: 200."

"Recorded affected families/groups: 284."

Below them: "Preliminary; verification continuing."

In red ink Anil Kumar wrote, "Not a compensation list."

No one objected.

Because now the two numbers each had their own meaning.

A week later, an inspection team came from the district.

They examined the main forms.

The supplementary register too.

One officer asked, "On whose orders were these additional details collected?"

Anil Kumar said, "The need arose in the field."

"It isn't on the state form."

"The original form has not been changed."

"Then what is this used for?"

"To reconcile numbers for relief sites, temporary shelter, water, sanitation, and family contact."

The officer turned the pages.

"Compensation?"

"Separate rules."

"List of those eligible for assistance?"

"Separate verification."

"Then fine. Keep the heading clear."

Mrinalini was listening from a distance.

The matter ended there.

No grand order came.

No applause.

The supplementary register simply became one new page in the bundle of registers.

Two weeks after the flood, the water had dried completely.

The sand in the lanes was swept to the sides.

Some houses had begun to receive a coat of limewash.

Some doorways were still crooked.

On her final verification round, Mrinalini went to house five.

The red door was half open.

Sonu was outside drying his notebook.

The moment he saw Mrinalini, he asked, “Is my name written?”

Mrinalini laughed.

“Your family is written down. Four members.”

“Me?”

“You too, among those four.”

Sonu was not satisfied.

“Which one of the four am I?”

Mrinalini looked at the line bearing the head of the family's name.

“This register doesn't list every member by name.”

Sonu made a face.

Mrinalini took a small slip of paper from her pocket.

“Tell me your full name.”

“Sonu Kumar Paswan.”

On her personal work list she wrote, “House 5: child Sonu Kumar Paswan—member verification from school list.”

“Now?” Sonu asked.

“Now your name will appear in the verification.”

“Money?”

Mrinalini burst out laughing.

“You too with the same question?”

Sonu laughed as well.

“Everyone asks.”

“My answer is the same—no promise.”

Sonu turned the notebook over in the sun.

Mrinalini moved on.

In the ward's last lane, the wall of one house had been replastered.

The old waterline was hidden beneath the limewash.

The municipal chalk number still remained near the doorway.

“37.”

Five people in the owner's family lived in that house.

Two tenant students lived in the back room.

Under a small lean-to, a woman who did sewing work lived with her daughter.

The main form said, “House 37. Owner: Devkinandan Jha. Moderate damage.”

The supplementary page had three lines.

Owner-family—5.

Tenant students—2.

Service/work-room residents—2.

Total—9.

Mrinalini clipped the two pages together.

Harinarayan stood beside her.

He said, “So all thirty-seven houses are complete now?”

“Yes.”

“Anything still pending verification?”

“The present locations of two families. The names have been confirmed.”

Harinarayan closed the main register.

“On the first day I thought one name for one house was enough.”

Mrinalini said, “Perhaps it was enough for a structure.”

“Not for people.”

Mrinalini did not answer.

A relief vehicle passed outside the lane.

A thin layer of dust rose.

The chalked “37” on the wall blurred, then came into view again.

Mrinalini looked at the last line of her supplementary page.

“Total residents — 9.”

There were two counts for the same place.

Both were correct.

Both were different.

The flood had left its line on the wall.

The register was now leaving a line for the people who had lived within it as well.

FROM THE HUNDRED-STORY TRILOGY · VOLUME II

STORY 31

Beyond the Embankment

Fourteen years had passed since New Bahuara was settled.

On government maps it was called "Rehabilitation Sector–3," but people themselves called it New Bahuara.

Old Bahuara lay beyond the embankment.

In the rains, when the reservoir filled, it was hard even to look toward the old village.

In winter, as the water receded, a raised patch of earth appeared in the distance like an island, but the old path to it no longer existed.

The village shrine, too, had stood there.

Outsiders hearing "village shrine" imagined a large temple.

Old Bahuara had no such temple.

There was an old pakar tree, a mud platform beneath it, a small piece of black stone at the centre, and a single lamp burning at dusk.

That was all the shrine was.

There was no permanent priest.

The turn for lighting the lamp passed from house to house.

If one household ran short of oil, a neighbour supplied it.

If the family of a house was away, the next household lit the lamp, but in the register the turn remained recorded in the absent household's name.

Devkali Devi remembered this better than anyone.

She was seventy-two.

In New Bahuara her house stood at the end of the third row.

In front were two flowerpots, a tulsi altar, and an old wooden seat beneath the bamboo.

Most evenings Devkali sat there, looking toward the embankment.

Her grandson Chandan would ask, "Grandmother, what do you see over there?"

Devkali would say, "What can no longer be seen."

The answer never satisfied Chandan.

He had been born in New Bahuara itself.

Old Bahuara was a story to him.

One day a notice came from the panchayat.

A meeting would be held to decide how to use the public open ground in the middle of the rehabilitation settlement, lying vacant for years.

Sometimes children played gulli there, sometimes paddy was spread to dry, and sometimes rainwater pooled there during the monsoon.

At the meeting Raghunandan Jha proposed, “Let us build the village shrine.”

A few people agreed at once.

“The old shrine has gone under water,” someone said. “A new village is incomplete without a shrine.”

From the second row Lalan Mahato said, “If it is built, it should be in the middle. Why in front of the first row?”

Raghunandan replied, “This is the middle.”

“The patch in front of your house is the middle?”

Laughter rose, then died almost at once.

Some said the old shrine had stood near the Mahato quarter.

Others said its approach ran through the Brahmin quarter.

One elderly man claimed that the first lamp at the shrine had always been lit by members of his lineage.

At this Devkali spoke in the meeting for the first time.

“No. That is not right.”

Every eye turned toward her.

Devkali said softly, “The first lamp belonged to no single lineage. There was a turn.”

Raghunandan smiled. “Auntie, who can remember something that old?”

Devkali did not answer.

She rose and went home.

Chandan followed behind her.

At home Devkali brought down an old trunk kept atop the grain bin.

Inside were old marriage papers, two yellowing photographs, a copy of a field survey, and a thin register wrapped in cloth.

On its cover, in lampblack, were written the words: “Lamp Turns.”

Chandan read it and stared in surprise.

“This belongs to the shrine?”

“Yes, to the shrine.”

“How did it come to you?”

“Your grandfather kept the turn-list for five years. The day we left the village, all the papers were wet. He wrapped this book in that cloth and brought it with him.”

Chandan turned the pages.

There were names.

No amounts of money.

The first page listed the names of forty-two households in order.

Against each name there was only a small mark—whether the lamp had been lit or not.

In one place it said, “Oil given by Sukni.”

Elsewhere: “Household away—the next turn lit the lamp.”

Between the names of two households, one line read: “Rain. Path closed. Lamp in the morning.”

Chandan said, “There is no sign here that any lineage had the first right.”

Devkali looked at him.

“Ownership of the shrine did not lie in the lamp; it lay in the turn.”

The next day Chandan carried the register to the meeting.

Devkali did not go.

She said, “Show them the book. The rest is for all of you to decide.”

The register passed from hand to hand at the meeting.

Raghunandan read the first page.

His lineage stood seventh in the order.

Lalan Mahato’s grandfather was twelfth.

Sukni of the Musahar quarter was fourteenth, with three notes beside her name recording oil supplied for other households.

No donation amount appeared beside any name.

No honorific.

No “chief.”

Chandan said, “We can match the old turns with the numbers of the new houses.”

The meeting did not reach an answer at once.

Of the forty-two families, eight no longer lived in New Bahuara.

Some had moved to the city.

In one family only a daughter survived, and she lived in another village.

And New Bahuara now had seven families absent from the old village register—new households created by marriage, division of families, and later settlement.

Raghunandan said, “Then how can the old register work now?”

Chandan said, “The old register shows us the rule, not a final list of names.”

At that, a few people fell silent.

Madhubala Devi, who had married into the new settlement, asked, “Will my household have a turn or not?”

No one had an immediate answer.

Lalan Mahato said, “If new households are not added, this shrine will be a memory, not a village.”

This time Raghunandan did not object.

For three days Chandan and two school students matched the old names with the new house numbers.

They prepared a file.

First column—the name in the old register.

Second—the present family.

Third—the new house number.

Fourth—blank if the old family was no longer there.

Fifth—newly added family.

Devkali looked over the file.

She asked, “Why have you not struck out the names that are vacant?”

Chandan said, “They will remain for remembrance.”

“And the turns?”

“The turns will belong to the living households.”

Devkali nodded.

Then another dispute arose: should a masonry temple be built on the open ground, or only a platform?

Raghunandan wanted a proper structure.

His argument was that the new village needed a “proper shrine.”

Devkali asked, “What does proper mean?”

“A roof, a door, an idol, an enclosure.”

“Did the old one have an enclosure?”

“No.”

“A door?”

“No door either.”

“Then why should the first thing in the new one be an enclosure?”

Raghunandan said nothing.

In the end it was decided that a low platform would be built in the middle of the open ground.

Around it would be an earthen ledge where people could sit.

No plaque bearing any household’s name would be put up.

There would be no donors’ list.

There would be a small place for the lamp.

The rest of the ground would remain the panchayat’s public open space.

On the first day of construction, someone proposed bringing earth from the old village for the platform.

Devkali refused again.

“Let that soil remain there.”

“Then how will the memory come here?” Chandan asked.

Devkali said, “Memory does not arrive in sacks.”

The platform was made from the soil of New Bahuara.

A new Lamp-Turn Register was prepared.

At the top of the first page they wrote: “Old order preserved in remembrance; present turns belong to all living households.”

The old forty-two names were copied onto a separate page.

After that, turns were assigned to all forty-nine households of New Bahuara.

The first turn fell to Madhubala Devi’s house.

No one had deliberately put her name first.

The list had been arranged by house number, and hers happened to be the smallest.

Madhubala felt awkward.

“But I never even saw Old Bahuara.”

Devkali said, “Does that make your turn any less?”

At dusk Madhubala came with her daughter Rani.

Rani poured oil into the lamp.

Madhubala lit the wick.

No conch shell was blown that day.

There was no inauguration.

Raghunandan came too, but gave no speech.

Lalan Mahato sat at one corner of the platform.

Chandan made the first mark in the new register.

Devkali sat a little way off on her wooden seat.

The flame of the lamp was very small.

Whenever the wind rose, Rani cupped her palm around it.

After a while Chandan went over to Devkali.

“Grandmother, is this the same shrine now?”

Devkali looked toward the black line of the embankment.

“No. Not the one from there.”

Chandan was puzzled.

“Then what is this?”

Devkali pointed to the register.

"Its place is over there."
After a moment's silence, she added—
"Here, our turn goes on."

STORY 32

The Voice of the Land

The path from the Sada hamlet of Hariharpur to the main road was six cubits wide.

On paper, it had no name.

In the village everyone called it “the Middle Path.”

At dawn, women going to sell milk; by day, labourers bound for the fields; in the evening, children returning from school—all came and went along that path.

During the rains, when the pond overflowed, the path became even more important.

The low ground behind the hamlet would then lie knee-deep in water.

The Middle Path crossed the higher ground and led out to the main road.

One day in the month of Jeth, a pile of bricks appeared at the mouth of the path.

At first people assumed that someone was going to build a house.

The next day bamboo stakes were driven into the ground.

On the third day, mortar began to be mixed.

On the fourth, the mason stretched a line for raising a straight wall.

The owner of the land was Dhaneshwar Sah.

He had bought the adjoining field two years earlier.

After having a fresh survey carried out, he had been told that more than half of the Middle Path fell within his cadastral plot.

Dhaneshwar would say—

“I am enclosing my own land. I am not taking anyone else’s.”

The people of the hamlet would say—

“This land is a road.”

Dhaneshwar would reply—

“Show me the map.”

He had the map.

The hamlet had memory.

On the first day the wall rose only two cubits.

On the second day the women sat down in front of the bricks.

No one threw a brick.

No one spoiled the mortar.

They simply remained seated there.

The mason stopped work.

Dhaneshwar's younger brother Umakant said—

"It is not right to stop the work like this."

Jasoda Sada of the hamlet replied—

"If the path is stopped, our work will stop too."

Word reached the panchayat.

The village head said that before the quarrel grew worse, a hearing would be held at the spot itself.

The next morning the land surveyor, the panchayat secretary, people from both sides, and elderly residents from the surrounding area gathered there.

The surveyor unfolded the new map.

Its blue lines, red figures, and cadastral plot numbers were clear.

There was no separate marking for the Middle Path.

A photocopy of the old map had also been brought.

Its lines were faint.

The paper was torn in one place.

At the very point where the path curved, the colour on the map had also been rubbed away.

Dhaneshwar said—

"What more than this do you need?"

Jasoda said—

"Our feet."

A few people in the crowd laughed.

Jasoda did not.

The surveyor measured the land.

Four cubits of the path fell inside the line marked for the wall.

Only two cubits remained outside it.

Two people could pass one another through two cubits of space, but a bicycle, a load, or a cot carrying a sick person—none could pass with ease.

The panchayat secretary asked—

"Does anyone have any old evidence?"

No one did.

Then a frail voice came from the back of the crowd—

"Will no one ask about the well?"

Everyone turned.

Kusumi Sada stood there, leaning on a bamboo staff.

She was eighty-four.

Her hearing had weakened somewhat, but she spoke clearly.

Jasoda ran to bring a low wooden seat for her.

Kusumi did not sit.

She said—

"First I will look at the ground."

Slowly she walked up to the mason's line.

Then she left the line and went to the bend in the path.

There she began scratching the earth with the tip of her staff.

Dhaneshwar said—

"Grandmother, where is the well here now?"

Without looking at him, Kusumi replied—

"It is not here now. But it was."

The surveyor asked—

"How long ago?"

Kusumi said—

"When I came to this village as a bride, its parapet stood as high as my waist."

Someone exclaimed—

"That must have been sixty years ago!"

Kusumi said—

"Fifty-eight."

Laughter rose again.

This time Kusumi smiled too.

"Two months after my first daughter was born, I filled a water-pot at this well for the first time. My daughter is fifty-seven now."

The surveyor became more attentive.

He asked—

"What does the well have to do with the path?"

With her staff Kusumi drew a circle on the earth.

"The path was not straight before. It bent here to go around the well's parapet."

The new map showed no path, but the path on the ground did in fact make a slight curve at that very place.

The mason's line was straight.

The path was not.

Dhaneshwar said—

"Even if there was an old well here, that does not make the land public."

Kusumi looked at him.

"You are right. Not merely because of the well."

For the first time, she sat on the low seat.

She held her staff between her knees.

"There was a survey. I saw it."

The surveyor asked—

"Which survey?"

"When the northern stream changed its course. The field boundaries were marked out again."

"How many years ago?"

Kusumi closed her eyes for a moment.

"The winter after the great flood. One year before Ramdev's wedding. That wedding was the first time a Petromax lamp came to the village."

Old Rameshar Yadav, standing in the crowd, said—

"Nineteen seventy-nine. Ramdev was married in eighty."

Kusumi nodded.

"Yes, seventy-nine."

The surveyor asked—

"Were you here when the survey was done?"

"All day."

"Why?"

Kusumi narrowed her eyes slightly.

"I was working as a labourer. I held the stakes for the surveyors and stretched their measuring rope. They had hired me to carry water and mind the pegs."

The present surveyor fell silent.

The measuring tape in his hand slackened a little.

Kusumi continued—

"That day the dispute was over this very thing. The owner of the eastern field said the path had entered his land. The owner of the western field said his boundary ridge had been cut. The survey was halted."

Dhaneshwar's father had been a boy then.

His uncle, Ramlakhan Sah, was present in the crowd.

Looking at him, Kusumi asked—

"Ramlakhan, were you there or not?"

Ramlakhan Sah remained silent for a long time.

Then he said—

"I was little. I had come with Father."

Dhaneshwar turned towards him.

Ramlakhan lowered his eyes.

Kusumi said—

"It was decided that three cubits would be left from each field. The path would be six cubits wide. Because this was not merely a path to the fields. It carried people towards the well, the pond, the market, and the main road—towards all four directions."

The panchayat secretary asked—

"Was this decision written down?"

Kusumi said—

"I could neither read nor write. I do not know whether it was written. But after the land was measured, boundary markers were set in the ground."

The surveyor asked at once—

"Where are those markers?"

Kusumi stood up.

"They may not all have survived."

From the bend in the path, she walked seven paces east.

Then she stopped.

"There was one here."

A shallow trench had now been dug there for the foundation of the new brick wall.

A labourer's spade was brought.

After two or three spadefuls of earth were removed, fragments of old brick appeared.

Dhaneshwar said—

"Bricks can be found anywhere."

Kusumi replied—

"That is not the marker."

She walked another five paces south.

There was a thicket there.

It was cleared away.

The corner of a blackened stone showed beneath the earth.

The surveyor scraped the soil away with his hands.

An old boundary stone, about a cubit and a half long, emerged.

There were two chisel marks on its top.

One ran east-west.

The other north-south.

The crowd suddenly fell silent.

Kusumi was looking not at the stone, but at the path.

She said—

"The western side of this stone was the path. The eastern side was the field."

Dhaneshwar bent down and examined the stone.

His uncle Ramlakhan said softly—

"There was a stone like this at the corner of Father's field."

The surveyor unfolded the new map again.

He placed the old map beside it.

The measuring tape was stretched out.

The distance from the stone to the present boundary ridge was taken.

Then the other edge was measured.

The measurements matched.

The old width of six cubits for the path matched as well.

What the new map made appear to lie within a single cadastral plot in fact fell on the other side of the old boundary stone.

Dhaneshwar was silent.

Jasoda's eyes brightened, but she said nothing.

The surveyor asked Kusumi—

"Do you remember any other sign?"

Kusumi said—

"The well's parapet."

The earth was dug again at the bend in the path.

Not very deep.

About a foot below the surface, two old stones were found laid in a curve.

Black earth and lime still clung between them.

Ramlakhan Sah exclaimed—

"This must be part of that very well's parapet."

Kusumi looked at him.

"Your mother used to draw water from this well."

Ramlakhan's face changed.

"Yes."

Having said that much, he fell silent.

The panchayat secretary began writing something on a sheet of paper.

Kusumi did not stop his hand.

But she said—

"Do not believe what I say merely because I am old."

The surveyor looked up.

Kusumi said—

"Measure it. If what I have said is found in the earth, then believe it."

After that one sentence, the nature of the hearing changed.

Until then, the two sides had been cutting across one another's words.

Now everyone began looking at the earth, the bend, the stones, and the distances.

The surveyor compared the position of the stone with the faded line on the old map.

The circular mark in that faded place now seemed meaningful.

It might have marked the well.

The torn part of the map lay exactly along the old edge of the path.

A decision could not be made on conjecture.

So the surveyor asked that another old boundary marker be found.

This time Kusumi went west.

She stopped behind a house.

"There was a neem tree here. The tree was cut down, but the root should remain."

The owner of the house gave his consent.

When the earth was opened, a thick neem root was found.

To the east of the root, a small stone had been set into the ground.

It bore the same kind of chisel marks.

The surveyor stretched out a long measuring tape.

A line was drawn between the two old stones.

That line ran alongside the edge of the Middle Path.

No one laughed now.

At last Dhaneshwar said—

"The papers for the land I bought show the boundary on this side."

The surveyor replied—

"Your papers remain valid for examination. They will be checked separately. But at this spot both the old boundary and long-established usage are visible."

Dhaneshwar's voice was no longer harsh.

"And my loss?"

The village head said—

"Where the land is yours, your right over it will remain. But the path cannot be enclosed as though it were a field."

Sweat stood on Dhaneshwar's forehead.

He wiped it with his gamchha.

"I will accept whatever the survey establishes."

No one in the hamlet applauded.

Perhaps everyone was tired.

Everyone understood that the decision was not yet complete.

The surveyor began measuring again.

Kusumi sat on the low seat and watched.

At times she pointed towards a stone.

At times she indicated the direction of an old boundary ridge.

At times she said—

"Pigeon peas used to grow here."

The surveyor would reply—

"Not the crop. Tell me the boundary."

Laughing, Kusumi said—

"I remember the boundary by the crop."

By noon the measurements were complete.

The six-cubit path emerged almost along its old course.

At one place it measured five cubits and eight fingerbreadths.

At another, six cubits and two fingerbreadths.

At the bend around the old well, it was wider still.

The mason's line for the wall was removed.

The mason began shifting the pile of bricks two cubits east.

Dhaneshwar himself drove bamboo stakes along the new line.

Jasoda sat down beside Kusumi.

"Grandmother, how did you remember so much?"

Kusumi rested her chin on her staff.

"When people have no papers, they have to remember places and events."

Jasoda fell silent.

Kusumi added—

"But memory by itself can often deceive as well. That is why I said—dig the earth, measure it."

By evening the foundation for the wall had been laid along the new line.

The Middle Path remained open.

The first boy to pass through with a bicycle glanced at the newly exposed top of the boundary stone.

He asked—

“What is this?”
Jasoda said—
“A boundary.”
The boy asked again—
“And this path?”
Kusumi, who had risen to return home, answered—
“A path.”
The boy stood waiting, hoping to hear something more.
But Kusumi walked away.
Her staff touched the earth first.
Then her foot came down.
Along the open path, the two sounds moved forward in turn.

STORY 33

The Sewing Machine

The thin morning sunlight passed through the lattice of the window and made a square of light on the sewing table.

Leela had spread a piece of blue cloth in that light and was working.

A fine chalk line ran along the edge of the cloth.

The foot pedal moved in a steady rhythm.

Now and then the belt slipped a little.

Then Leela stopped her foot, lifted the belt back into place with her hand, and the needle began moving again.

Her husband, Harinarayan, stood at the doorway watching all this.

“You kept it running so late last night too.”

Leela did not take her eyes off the cloth.

“I have two kurtas to deliver tomorrow.”

“Doesn't your foot hurt?”

“A foot's work is to move; a mouth's work is to ask questions.”

Harinarayan laughed.

In a wooden box beneath the table lay the head of another old sewing machine.

That machine had not run for a year.

Its shuttle was broken.

Its wheel jammed.

The old machine head had come from Leela's parental home with the thought that “some part might come in useful someday.”

Harinarayan had cleaned it several times.

But not a single useful part had ever come out of it.

That morning Harinarayan looked once at the box.

Then he went out without saying anything.

It was Harinarayan's birthday that day.

He did not like any grand celebration of his birthday.

What Leela liked even less was the way he always brushed everything aside by saying, “I don't want anything.”

This time Leela had made up her mind.

A gamchha with a red border.

Two bowls of kheer.

Two friends in the evening.

That much celebration would be enough.

But there was little cash in the house tin.

Two customers from the previous week had postponed payment.

One had said he would pay after the paddy was sold.

There was a wedding in the other's house; payment would come later.

Leela counted the outstanding dues and smiled.

"If it were my birthday, I could celebrate by writing my name in chalk."

But she had already decided to buy the gamchha for Harinarayan.

Before noon, she stopped sewing.

She wrapped the unfinished piece of the blue kurta in cloth and put it aside.

She detached the machine head from the table.

The wooden table stood empty.

The workplace suddenly looked unfamiliar.

Leela called her neighbour Renuka.

"Will you come with me for a while?"

Renuka looked at the machine head.

"Where?"

"To the women's cooperative."

Renuka raised her eyebrows.

"How many days will it remain pledged?"

"Five or seven days. I'll redeem it as soon as the next payment comes."

Renuka said nothing.

Together they wrapped the machine head in cloth.

At the cooperative, an article offered as security was not weighed; it was inspected.

Half of the golden vine pattern was still visible on the black body of the machine.

The woman keeping the register turned the wheel to test it.

"Does it run?"

Leela said, "It was running until this morning."

"Seven hundred."

Leela thought for a moment.

"Seven hundred is acceptable."

A receipt was made out.

The machine went into the inner room.

Seven hundred rupees came into Leela's hands.

From that money she bought a gamchha for forty-five rupees.

She bought half a seer of milk, rice, jaggery, and cardamom.

The total expense came to one hundred and ten rupees.

She folded the remaining five hundred and ninety rupees and put them in an old red purse.

“This is the machine's money,” she told Renuka.

“Then what about the birthday?”

“Is one hundred and ten rupees too little for a birthday?”

Renuka laughed.

At that same time, Harinarayan was at Badri the mechanic's shop at the other end of the market.

Badri sold sewing-machine motors, belts, pedals, and old parts.

Leela's old, broken machine head lay on the table.

Badri turned its wheel.

The wheel made half a turn and jammed.

“This won't run.”

Harinarayan said, “Did I bring it to make it run?”

“Then why did you bring the machine?”

“For parts.”

Badri turned the machine over and examined it.

“Six hundred and twenty.”

Harinarayan did not agree at once.

“Seven hundred.”

“Six hundred and twenty.”

“Six hundred and fifty.”

Badri shrugged.

“Six hundred and twenty, and I'll give you the motor belt at half price.”

Harinarayan thought.

“All right. At that price.”

The old machine was sold.

Six hundred and twenty rupees came into his hands.

He placed five hundred rupees back in Badri's hand.

“Advance for a new motor.”

Badri wrote his name in the register.

“The motor will be here by tomorrow evening.”

“Not tomorrow. Five days later.”

"Why a delay of five days?"

"I have to arrange the rest of the money."

Badri wrote out a receipt.

Harinarayan folded it and put it in the inside pocket of his shirt.

One hundred and twenty rupees remained in his outer pocket.

He started home.

As soon as he reached home that evening, the first thing Harinarayan saw was the empty sewing table.

He stopped at the doorway.

The unfinished blue kurta lay on the table.

The chalk was there.

The scissors were there.

The machine was not.

"Leela?"

A voice came from inside, "Wash your hands and face. Don't ask yet."

"Where is the machine?"

"Hands and face first."

"Has the machine gone to wash its hands and face?"

Leela came out laughing.

In her hands was the gamchha with the red border.

"Happy birthday."

Harinarayan took the gamchha, but his eyes remained on the empty table.

"Did this gamchha cost the machine?"

"The gamchha cost forty-five."

"Then the machine?"

Leela took out the red purse.

And the pledge receipt.

"A guest for seven days."

Harinarayan read the receipt.

Then he looked at Leela's face.

Then at the receipt again.

"You pledged the machine?"

"I'll redeem it."

"When?"

"As soon as the two customers pay."

Harinarayan sat down on the cot.

For a few moments he said nothing.

Leela thought he would be angry.

But suddenly Harinarayan began to laugh.

Leela glared at him.

"What is so funny?"

Harinarayan took another receipt from the inside pocket of his shirt.

Leela read it.

'Motor - advance: five hundred.'

She turned the receipt over and read it again.

"Whose motor is this?"

"Your machine's."

Leela looked at the empty table.

Then at the receipt.

"A motor for a machine that isn't in the house?"

Harinarayan laughed again.

"That is exactly the question I am asking now."

Leela laid the receipt on the table.

"Where did you get five hundred?"

Harinarayan pointed with his eyes toward the empty box beneath the table.

Leela looked there too.

The head of the old broken machine was gone.

"You sold it?"

"If we call that a machine, machines themselves will be offended. It had been sleeping in the box for a year."

"How much did you get?"

"Six hundred and twenty."

"Five hundred into the motor?"

"One hundred and twenty is still in my pocket."

Leela fell silent for a moment.

Then she opened the red purse.

She placed five hundred and ninety rupees on the table.

"Five hundred and ninety."

Harinarayan added his one hundred and twenty.

Together they counted the money.

Seven hundred and ten.

Leela looked at the pledge receipt.

“It will take seven hundred and ten to redeem the machine.”

Harinarayan said, “Then the birthday accounts balance.”

Leela glared at him.

“The kheer hasn't even been made yet.”

“Kheer later. First the machine.”

It was almost closing time at the cooperative.

The two of them walked quickly.

Leela had draped the new red-bordered gamchha over Harinarayan's shoulder.

From time to time he wiped his sweat with it.

“The gift is useful,” he said.

“We'll know once the machine comes back.”

When they reached the cooperative, the gate was half closed.

The woman who kept the register was gathering the papers from outside.

Leela handed her the receipt.

“So soon?”

“The empty table didn't look right at home.”

The woman smiled.

Seven hundred and ten rupees were counted out.

The machine came out again, wrapped in cloth.

Harinarayan lifted it.

Leela said, “Careful. This is the post-birthday machine.”

Harinarayan said, “And the debt is from before the birthday.”

Back home, the machine was seated on the table again.

Leela fitted the belt.

She turned the wheel.

The needle went up and down twice.

The unfinished blue kurta was still there.

Harinarayan hung the gamchha on a peg.

“Will there be kheer or not?”

Leela looked at the clock.

“The two friends will be here soon.”

“Don't tell them the story of the machine.”

“Why not tell the story?”

“The kheer will grow cold.”

Leela laughed.

That night four bowls of kheer were made.

Two friends came.

They saw the gamchha.

They wished him a happy birthday.

No one knew about the empty box.

Leela put the motor receipt in the spice tin.

The pledge receipt went into the machine's small drawer.

Five days later Badri the mechanic arrived with the motor.

He fixed it to the right corner of the wooden table.

A new belt was fitted.

The wire ran up to the hook on the wall.

Leela paid the remaining amount from the sewing payments she had received over the previous three days.

Badri turned the wheel by hand.

Then he switched on the motor.

For the first time, the machine ran without the pedal.

Leela immediately slowed it down.

"Not so fast."

Harinarayan said, "Until yesterday your foot was hurting."

"My foot will rest. My hands won't."

Badri laughed.

"The machine survived, and so did the motor."

Leela said, "One old machine is gone."

Harinarayan added, "And one pledge has made a round trip."

Badri understood nothing.

He gathered his tools and left.

That evening Leela finished the remaining stitching on the blue kurta.

The soft hum of the motor filled the veranda.

Harinarayan sat on the cot, folding the red-bordered gamchha.

After a while a thin drop of oil appeared beneath the motor.

Leela took the gamchha down from the peg and was about to place it under the motor.

Harinarayan caught it at once.

"This is my birthday gift."

Leela stopped her hand.

"Does motor oil not observe birthdays, then?"

Harinarayan put the gamchha back on his shoulder.

He placed a piece of old cloth beneath the motor.
Leela opened the machine drawer.
The pledge receipt lay inside.
She brought the motor's advance receipt from the spice tin as well.
She folded both receipts together and placed them beneath the needle box.
Harinarayan asked, “Why keep all this?”
Leela turned the wheel gently.
“If we ever forget the accounts, we'll look at them.”
“Which account do we need to remember?”
Leela pressed the motor switch.
The needle began to move.
“The account of two machines and one birthday in a single day.”
Harinarayan laughed.
The red-bordered gamchha remained on his shoulder.
The old box beneath the table was empty.
On the table, the sewing machine was running.

STORY 34

Ten Kilos of Rice

The morning sun had not yet fully climbed the yellow wall of the school, but a queue had already formed in the courtyard. Rain had been falling on and off for two weeks; even though the paddy had been transplanted, the rice pots in many homes had grown light. A notice from the panchayat had come: selected families would receive ten kilos of rice each.

Malti Devi had come with her eight-year-old son, Chhotu. This was Chhotu's own school. On a holiday, it felt strange to him to see his classroom shut; today, instead of the blackboard, there were three tables on the veranda, a strip of red cloth and sacks of rice.

Chhotu was not counting the people in the queue. His eyes were on the scales. Iron weights, the balance, and a white sack. In thick green letters on the sack was written: '10 KILOS ASSISTANCE.' Its mouth was stitched with blue thread, and there was a small tear at the right-hand corner. Two or three grains were caught outside the tear.

'Ma, is this ten kilos?' Chhotu asked.

'The scales will tell us,' Malti said. 'You keep quiet.'

In the middle of the veranda, a panchayat employee sat on a chair with a file open before him. Beside him, two young men were checking slips. In front, a man with a camera kept changing his position—sometimes by the gate, sometimes behind the red cloth.

The first name was called—Sukni Devi.

Sukni stepped forward. One of the young men lifted the white sack and placed it in her hands. The sack was heavy; Sukni's elbow bent at once. The employee motioned to her to smile. The camera flashed.

'That's enough,' the young man said.

Sukni tucked the sack under her arm and turned. She had not taken even two steps when a voice came from behind: 'Mother, leave it here. Let everyone's photograph be taken first. It will be distributed afterwards.'

Sukni stood still for a moment. Then she put the sack back on the table. She was given a pink slip stamped 'RECEIVED.'

Chhotu's eyes remained on the blue thread.

The second name—Jagarnath Paswan.

The same sack was lifted again. It was placed in Jagarnath's hands. He looked towards the camera. The flash went off. The sack went back on the table. Another pink slip.

The third name. The fourth name.

The same sack. The same blue thread. The same tear in the right-hand corner.

Chhotu peered beneath the table. Two more sacks lay there, but they looked flattened, as though only half full. The door of the room behind was shut.

'Ma,' he said softly, 'why is everyone getting the same sack?'

Malti's queue moved forward. 'I told you, keep quiet.'

'But where did Sukni Kaki's rice go?'

Malti gripped his hand tightly. Her experience had taught her that asking questions in a queue brought no benefit. To have one's name on the slip, to stand in the queue, to put one's thumbprint at the proper time—that much itself was a great deal.

In a corner of the veranda, Chhotu saw a grain of rice. It had fallen through the tear as the sack was being lifted and set down. He bent and picked it up. Then another.

By the seventh family he had collected five grains.

Malti's name was called eighth.

'Malti Devi, wife of the late Nathuni Sadai.'

Malti stepped forward. Chhotu followed her.

The white sack came into her hands. Chhotu looked at it from very close—the knot in the blue thread was on the verge of coming undone. A grain of rice was half sticking out through the tear in the right-hand corner. Chhotu tried to push it back in with his finger. The young man brushed his hand away.

'Don't touch.'

'This is my mother's rice, isn't it?' Chhotu asked.

Two or three people in the queue laughed.

The employee said, 'Yes, yes, you'll get it. Photograph first.'

The flash went off.

For the first time, Malti tried to smile. The photograph was taken. The young man then took the sack out of her hands almost immediately.

'Leave it here for now. As soon as the supplies arrive by evening, everyone will be given theirs. Keep the slip safely.'

Malti took the pink slip. Chhotu kept looking at the sack.

'Ma, will they give this to someone else again?'

'Come.'

On the way home, Chhotu opened his fist. There were five grains. He could not tell whether the sixth grain had fallen somewhere on the road or whether he had counted wrongly in the first place.

All that day, until evening, Malti kept looking towards the school. No vehicle came. At night the rice-water on the hearth was made thinner. Chhotu tried to count the grains of rice in his bowl, then stopped halfway.

The elderly Janakdulari of the household sat on the veranda cutting betel nut. She asked, 'Didn't they give you the rice?'

Malti showed her the pink slip. 'They said they would give it in the evening. Evening has passed.'

Chhotu broke in, 'Grandmother, they gave everyone the same sack. First Sukni Kaki, then Jagarnath Kaka, then Ma. The flash went off, and then the sack went back.'

Janakdulari turned the slip over in her hand. 'Are we supposed to eat rice on paper?'

Malti grew irritated. 'I'll ask tomorrow. What was the use of quarrelling today?'

Chhotu put his five grains into a fold of an old piece of paper and tucked it beneath the head of the cot. As sleep came, the scene from that day kept returning to him—the sack changing hands, the flash, then empty hands. He could not understand how giving something and showing it being given could become two separate acts.

The next day Malti went back to the school with the pink slip. Chhotu went with her. The veranda was empty. The red cloth had been removed. The tables had been taken inside the classroom. Only the panchayat assistant was there, putting files away.

Malti held out the slip. 'Yesterday you said ten kilos of rice.'

The assistant opened the file and found her name. 'It shows received here.'

'Received where? They put it in my hands, took a photograph, and then took it back.'

The assistant showed her the mark of her thumb. 'Your thumbprint is here.'

Malti's voice hardened. 'I put my thumbprint for the slip. The sack never reached my home.'

By then Sukni Devi had also arrived. The same pink slip was in her hand. Then Jagarnath came. Then two more families. Every file said 'RECEIVED.' No one's home had received rice.

The assistant's expression changed. He said, 'I was given the list yesterday. The distribution was being handled by a separate team.'

'Where is the team?' Jagarnath asked.

There was no immediate answer.

Chhotu sat on the steps of the veranda. The five grains from the previous day were still in his pocket. He placed them one by one on the step. Five small white dots.

Ramanand Babu, a teacher at the school, was arriving just then. Although it was a holiday, he had come to take some papers from a cupboard in one of the classrooms. When he saw the gathering, he stopped.

Ramanand Babu asked, 'What happened here?' Five voices rose at once.

Ramanand heard everyone out. He gave no judgement. Sitting down beside Chhotu, he asked, 'Were you here yesterday?' Chhotu nodded. Ramanand looked into his eyes and asked again, 'What did you see?'

Chhotu pointed to the five grains. 'There was one sack. They gave that same one to everyone. Then they took it back. These fell from this tear.' Ramanand asked, 'The same sack?' Chhotu said, 'Blue thread. A tear here.' He pointed to the right-hand corner of his shirt. 'Here.' Ramanand said nothing.

By noon, the news had reached the block office. Two members of the relief-distribution team arrived. With them came the man who had taken the photographs the previous day. An argument began—the supplies had arrived late, the photographs had been taken first, distribution was to happen afterwards, the list had been closed by mistake, the 'RECEIVED' stamp had been put on the slips too early.

'Then where is the rice?' Malti asked. Many sentences came out in answer to that question, but no rice did.

The photographer began showing the previous day's pictures on the screen of his camera. The first photograph—Sukni holding the white sack. The second—Jagarnath. The third—another family. The eighth—Malti. Ramanand Babu studied the pictures carefully. In every picture the sack was turned the same way. The knot in the blue thread was identical. There was the same small dark mark in the right-hand corner.

'These are not proof of distribution,' Ramanand said quietly. 'They are proof of one sack going round and round.' No one laughed.

The senior employee who had come with the team asked for the records. The previous day's signature register, the store's issue register and the available sacks were counted. The figures did not tally. Five sacks were found in the room behind the school, seven in the panchayat building. The rest of the consignment had never arrived by vehicle at all, yet the list already recorded the entire distribution as complete.

No photographs were taken that day. First the file was reopened. The red 'RECEIVED' mark was struck out, and beside it was written: 'ACTUAL DISTRIBUTION PENDING.' The pink slips were checked again. The available rice was counted. As many families as could be given the full ten kilos that day received it; the rest were given the date of the next consignment in writing.

Malti's turn came towards evening. This time the sack was placed directly on the scales. The needle settled at ten. The employee wrote the weight on the slip. The sack was not placed in Malti's hands; it was lifted straight onto her head.

Chhotu walked behind her. As soon as they passed through the school gate, Malti stopped. 'It feels heavy.' Chhotu did not laugh. He took the five grains from the previous day out of his pocket and placed them on top of the sack. 'Let these five go home too.'

Malti looked at him. 'What will five grains do?' Chhotu thought for a moment. 'Yesterday they came back alone.' Malti began walking again. On the road, the sack really was heavy.

STORY 35

The Unfinished Song

The morning sun had reached only halfway across the veranda. Kaushalya Devi was picking pebbles out of an old winnowing tray of paddy. The grains clinked in the brass plate beside her, and from the room inside came the faint thud-thud of an unfamiliar rhythm.

At first she thought Mrinal was listening to some new music again. But three times, after that rhythm, a short melody rose—four notes climbed, one note paused, then an empty space. Kaushalya's fingers stopped among the grains.

The melody repeated.

This time she set the plate aside and rose.

The door to Mrinal's room was half open. Inside, she sat bent before the computer. Sheets of paper, two cables, a small speaker and an old red notebook lay spread across the table. From the speaker rose those same four notes once more.

Kaushalya stopped in the doorway.

'Where did you get that from?'

Mrinal turned. 'What?'

'What just played.'

'I made it.'

Kaushalya looked at her for a few moments. 'Play it again.'

Mrinal pressed a key. The rhythm began. First the clack-clack of a loom, then the thump of a bucket being filled with water, then the light ting of a bicycle bell. Above them all came Mrinal's humming—four notes, a pause, then an empty space.

Kaushalya said softly, 'You did not make that.'

Mrinal's eyebrows lifted slightly. 'I haven't heard it from anyone and written it down, Dadi.'

'Then you have heard it.'

'Where?'

Kaushalya did not answer. She sat on the cot. The fingers of her right hand began beating time on her knee—one, two, three, pause. Then a very thin note came from her throat.

'The transplanted row has turned, O…'

She stopped there.

Mrinal switched off the speaker.

'And then?'

Kaushalya tried to smile, but the smile did not quite form. 'What came next was not mine.'

'Whose was it, then?'

'Jhunki's.'

Mrinal had heard the name before. Jhunki Devi had been Kaushalya's childhood friend. On paddy-transplanting days the two worked in adjoining rows in the field. Kaushalya would raise the song; Jhunki would answer. Jhunki had died years ago. After that Kaushalya sang many songs, but this melody was never completed again.

'You don't remember the answer?' Mrinal asked.

Kaushalya shook her head. 'I remember fragments of words. Not the tune. Not the way Jhunki used to lift it.'

Mrinal turned over the papers on the table. 'I have to submit a new sound composition the day after tomorrow. The theme is the everyday sounds of the village. The loom, the bucket, the bell, the mortar… I took all of them from here. These four notes came into my head on their own. I didn't even realise they had been living somewhere already.'

Kaushalya said, 'Sometimes a tune enters not through the ear, but through the house.'

Mrinal fell silent.

She stopped working until noon. On the first page of the old red notebook she wrote: 'Source of the four notes?' Beneath it she paused before writing Kaushalya's name.

'Dadi, if this was the paddy-transplanting tune of all of you, how can I put my own name on it?'

Kaushalya pulled the winnowing tray towards herself again. 'Not in my name either. The song belonged to the field. Whoever's throat it entered, it became theirs; once it left that throat, it belonged to everyone again.'

'But you must have learnt it from someone.'

'From my mother. My mother from her aunt. Her aunt from whom—who knows?'

Mrinal wrote in the red notebook: 'Anonymous paddy-transplanting melody.' Then added: 'Heard from Kaushalya Devi.'

Kaushalya stopped her at once. 'Where is Jhunki's name?'

Mrinal looked at her.

Kaushalya began naming them one by one. 'Jhunki. Sudama Kaki. Parmesari. Chhotki Budhni. Sarju Mai…'

'So many people?'

'The song did not belong to one throat.'

Mrinal kept writing the names. At the fifth name Kaushalya stopped. Her eyes drifted towards the veranda. 'There were more. I don't remember all their names now.'

'We'll write as many as you remember.'

Mrinal asked, 'Why did you never sing this song again?'

Kaushalya picked a pebble from the tray and rolled it in her palm. 'The first transplanting season after Jhunki died, I raised it. The first line came out, but no answer came from anyone's throat. The other women caught up a different song. That day I understood that some melodies do not live by words alone; someone has to be standing opposite you as well.'

'So you gave it up?'

'One season at first. Then another. After that the field went out on sharecropping. Fewer people came for transplanting. The pace of the work changed. The song itself was left behind.'

Mrinal drew a short line along the margin of the red notebook. 'When I was little, did you used to hum this?'

Kaushalya thought. 'Possibly. When you wouldn't sleep, I used to turn the tune over without any words. I couldn't sing the words—they felt like Jhunki's share. Perhaps the melody remained.'

Mrinal looked at the marks she had made for her four notes. Suddenly she understood how often, while composing the melody, she had instinctively kept that same pause. She had not known why; the moment she removed the empty space, the whole rhythm felt unbalanced.

'So I learnt this from you, but didn't remember?'

'There is a difference between learning something and something settling inside you,' Kaushalya said. 'Some things are not taught. Living in a house, the body simply picks them up.'

That evening Mrinal opened her sound composition again. This time the empty space after the four notes began to trouble her. She tried to add a new note there—a flute-like sound once, a soft bell once, once a second line in her own voice. Everything sounded wrong.

Kaushalya was listening from outside.

'Leave it empty,' she said.

'Why?'

'That was where Jhunki used to come in.'

Mrinal's hand stopped. 'But in the composition the empty space will feel so long.'

'It felt long in the field too.'

Kaushalya came inside. 'While transplanting, we stayed bent low for one whole row. The first melody belonged to those bent bodies. Then came a pause

for one breath—the waist straightened, the foot moved forward. After that pause Jhunki would raise the answer. Without the pause, the second line could never begin.'

Mrinal stopped the rhythm. 'So the empty space is part of the song too?'

Kaushalya said, 'Sometimes it is the most important part.'

The next morning the two went to the edge of the pond. A light mist lay over the water. Kaushalya hoped the tune might return to her in the open air. Mrinal had brought no equipment, only the red notebook.

Kaushalya raised the first line.

'The transplanted row has turned, O…'

Then the empty space.

She closed her eyes.

Mrinal said nothing.

Far out in the water a heron stood with its wings folded. From across the pond came the thump-thump of someone working a pestle. Kaushalya's fingers found the old beat on her knee by themselves. One, two, three—pause.

Suddenly two notes came from her mouth. She herself startled. Then a third note. Then a long descent.

'Was it like that?' Mrinal asked softly.

Kaushalya did not answer at once. Then she sang it again. This time her voice trembled on the last note.

'I cannot say exactly,' she said. 'But this is the path my body is taking.'

Mrinal made her own notation for the notes in the red notebook, but did not write any words.

'The words?'

Kaushalya shook her head. 'If I don't remember them, we won't invent them from our own minds. Let it remain unfinished.'

Mrinal smiled. 'In my sound composition too?'

'Add whatever new thing is yours there. But don't put it forward in the old song's name.'

The two returned home.

Mrinal worked all afternoon. After the four notes of the old melody she left the empty space exactly as it was. After that, she did not add the notes Kaushalya had half remembered as if they were Jhunki's reply. Instead she changed the new rhythm—the loom's clack-clack slowly became like the cadence of feet in a transplanting field, the thump of the bucket receded into the distance, and at the end only one new line rose in Mrinal's own voice, with words she herself had written.

In the note above it she wrote: 'Opening melody: anonymous village paddy-transplanting tradition. From the memory of Kaushalya Devi. In remembrance

of Jhunki Devi, Sudama Devi, Parmesari Devi, Budhni Devi, Sarju Devi and the companions whose names are no longer remembered.'

Kaushalya read it and said, 'Why haven't you written "singer" beside my name?'

Mrinal laughed. 'You said yourself the song belonged to the field.'

Kaushalya laughed too.

Three days later Mrinal returned from college with no prize in her hand. There were only two lines of comment written by the teacher: 'A new composition has been created without claiming the old source as one's own. The use of empty space is effective.'

Kaushalya read the paper and asked, 'Did they understand the song?'

'Not all of it.'

'Then?'

'They all heard the empty space.'

Kaushalya folded the paper and placed it inside the red notebook.

That night after dinner Mrinal was gathering clothes from the courtyard when Kaushalya's voice rose from inside—

'The transplanted row has turned, O...'

Then the pause.

Mrinal stopped by the doorway. She did not know Jhunki's words. Nor did she sing the line from her own new composition. She only tapped the brass plate twice with her finger in the rhythm of that pause—ting, ting.

Inside, Kaushalya raised the next note.

The song was not completed.

But this time, she did not stop.

STORY 36

The Clay Flute

The morning sunlight had not yet reached the rear wall of the potters' quarter. Ramlochan was turning the wheel, while his twelve-year-old son Nilu was drying small clay tubes beside it.

Pitchers, surahis, lamps and cooking pots came from Ramlochan's hands. From Nilu's hands came, at times, a horse, at times a bird, and at times some object for which he himself thought of a name only afterwards.

That morning the fourth tube cracked as well.

Nilu held it near his ear and blew into it. Only air came out.

'Again?' Ramlochan asked without stopping the wheel.

'The mouth became a little too wide.'

'I have told you three times that clay shrinks in the fire.'

'It shrinks, but not every tube in the same way.'

Ramlochan laughed. 'Then ask the clay first before you make it.'

Nilu did not answer. He picked up the fifth tube. One end was flattened, and there were six small holes along the middle. Around the holes he had pressed marks with grains of rice so that his fingers would not slip on the unfired clay.

He blew into it. The first note came out thin, the second a little heavier; on the third, the air broke. Nilu changed his fingering. This time three notes sounded in succession. The fourth went crooked again.

Ramlochan stopped the wheel and listened.

'It sounds like a flute.'

'Not bamboo. Clay.'

'Then will its name change too?'

'Why should the name change? It is the air that gives the note.'

Ramlochan covered his mouth as he laughed. 'All right, then. The wind is your guru.'

Nilu ran a finger over the flute's holes. He did not like the word guru. The wind told him nothing; only, if a hole shifted a little this way or that, the note changed. He listened and guessed.

By noon five flutes had been set aside. Two were cracked, two were out of tune, and one, by Nilu's reckoning, was usable.

The next day Ramlochan arranged his wares for the weekly market. Nilu placed the usable flute on top of the basket.

'Will you sell it?' his father asked.

'If someone can play it.'

'What price will you ask?'

Nilu thought. 'I don't know the price.'

Ramlochan said, 'If you don't know the price, the market will know.'

At the market the flute first caught the children's eyes. One blew into it and laughed; another held it backwards. A boy offered five paise, but Nilu would not give it to him.

'Are five paise too little?' the boy asked.

'No. You didn't cover the third hole properly.'

'Am I buying it or sitting an examination?'

Nilu put the flute back on the basket.

By evening the pots had dwindled, but the flute was still there. As the market was breaking up, Ratinath, a dealer in earthenware who travelled towards town, bought Ramlochan's remaining lamps and surahis together. While the basket was being tied, the flute fell to the ground.

Ratinath picked it up and blew. A thin note came out.

'Will you give me this as well?'

Ramlochan looked at Nilu.

Nilu said, 'Take it. But give it into the hands of someone who can play.'

Ratinath laughed. 'In town I put every object into someone's hands.'

'No. Give this to someone who listens to notes.'

'Does anyone listen to notes with his eyes?'

Nilu remained serious. Ratinath put the flute into his bag.

Three days later, a middle-aged man stopped before Ratinath's shop in Darbhanga's old market. His name was Devvrat Jha. At the town music school he taught boys and girls the flute and vocal exercises. While buying two clay flowerpots for his wife, his eye fell on the clay tube peeping from the side of the bag.

'What is this?'

Ratinath said, 'A flute. But don't think of it as something for sale.'

Devvrat laughed. 'Something that comes to a shop is not for sale?'

'The boy who made it said it must be given to someone who listens to notes.'

Devvrat took the flute. He examined the holes, put it to his lips and blew gently. The first note came out clear. The second was a little low. The third climbed unexpectedly high. He stopped, then played again. This time he changed the pressure of his fingers and reduced the air. The third note rose to the same place again.

'The hole is wrong,' he said.

Ratinath shrugged. 'A boy made it.'

Devvrat turned the flute over and over. The holes were not in a straight line. Two had shifted slightly to the right, and one was small. The impressions of the rice grains could still be seen around their edges.

'How much is it?'

'The boy gave no price.'

Devvrat gave him five rupees. Ratinath tried to return two, but he stopped his hand.

'Can I meet the maker?'

'Ramlochan the potter comes to the next market.'

Devvrat took the flute home. After dinner that night he played it again. His daughter Shruti came from the next room and asked, 'A new flute?'

'Not new. Strange.'

'Why do you say that?'

Devvrat played the third note. 'If this hole were here instead, the note would sit properly.'

Shruti asked, 'Then enlarge the hole.'

Devvrat thought of heating a needle and enlarging the hole, but stopped when he looked at the clay. Fired clay was not easy to cut. Then another thing began to trouble him: the other holes too were not at classical intervals, yet two of the notes were unexpectedly sweet.

That night he did not alter the flute.

On the next market day Devvrat reached Ratinath's shop early. When Ramlochan arrived, Nilu was with him.

Ratinath called from a distance, 'This is the boy you were looking for.'

Devvrat looked at Nilu. He had expected to meet some young craftsman. Before him stood a thin-armed boy with clay under his fingernails.

'Did you make this?' Devvrat showed him the flute.

Nilu recognised it at once. 'Yes. The third note runs high, doesn't it?'

Devvrat was silent for a moment. 'You know?'

'I understood after it came out of the fire.'

'Then why did you send it to be sold?'

'If I had thrown it away because it was out of tune, why would I have made it?'

Devvrat placed the flute in Nilu's hands. 'Play.'

Nilu played the first two notes. On the third he half-opened the hole and blew slightly sideways. The note that climbed high in Devvrat's hands became, in Nilu's, a soft note in between.

Devvrat watched closely.

'Again.'

Nilu played it again.

'How did you learn that?'

'The hole came out wrong, so I changed the air.'

For the first time Devvrat smiled. 'You changed the air?'

'Fingers can't do everything.'

The market went on around them, but Devvrat sat for half an hour on Ramlochan's mat. He asked Nilu how many flutes he had made, what clay he used, how long he kept them in the fire. Nilu could not answer every question. Ramlochan supplied some of the answers.

At last Devvrat said, 'Can you come to town? I'll show you the intervals between notes.'

Nilu looked at his father.

Ramlochan asked, 'When?'

'On Sunday.'

Ramlochan shook his head. 'Sunday is when we open the kiln.'

Devvrat understood that this was not an answer of yes. He wrote his address on a piece of paper and gave it to Nilu. Nilu folded it and put it in his bag.

For two weeks Nilu did not go to town. In the third week Devvrat came to the potters' quarter himself.

That day Ramlochan was opening the kiln. The smell of hot ash hung in the air. Nilu was taking out the clay tubes one by one and laying them on straw. Some mouths had warped; some tubes had fine cracks.

Devvrat reached out to pick one up. Nilu stopped him at once.

'It is still hot.'

Devvrat drew his hand back.

'The lesson here today?' he asked with a laugh.

Nilu said, 'First let all these cool.'

Devvrat sat on the veranda until noon. Ramlochan showed him the wheel. Nilu made two unfired tubes. Devvrat took out his bamboo flute and measured the distance between its holes, then used a thread to mark the proportions on the clay tubes.

Nilu watched closely.

'If I make it like this, will the notes sit properly?'

'Very nearly.'

'After it shrinks in the fire?'

Devvrat stopped.

Nilu asked again, 'Is this distance for raw clay or for fired clay?'

Devvrat remained holding the thread. His measurements were for bamboo; he did not know how to calculate the clay's shrinkage.

Ramlochan, raising a new pot on the wheel, said, 'He has been troubling me with this question for three months.'

Devvrat laughed. 'Then let him trouble me too.'

That day the lesson was less about notes and more about measurements. Nilu marked five different spacings on five tubes. Ramlochan gave them clay from the same batch. Devvrat said they would measure them all again after firing.

Devvrat returned the following week. One of the five tubes had cracked. The other four had not shrunk equally. Nilu checked the measurements with the thread.

'The clay was thicker on this side, so the hole shifted slightly inward.'

Devvrat played them one by one. Two flutes produced almost the same sequence of notes. The third took its own path again.

'Useless?' Devvrat asked.

Nilu took the flute. 'No. Another tune will come from this one.'

Devvrat said, 'Will you make a new rule for every wrong thing?'

For the first time Nilu returned his question. 'Is every note that does not fit the rules necessarily wrong?'

Ramlochan burst out laughing from behind the wheel.

Devvrat laughed too, but did not answer at once.

After that, the arrangement of Sundays changed. Twice a month Devvrat came to the potters' quarter. On the other two Sundays Nilu went to town after the kiln had been opened at noon. In the small room of the music school, for the first time he learnt the names of notes, understood ascent and descent, and practised keeping the breath flowing steadily instead of holding it.

But things on Devvrat's table also began to change. Beside the bamboo flute there were now four clay tubes, thread, a small wooden ruler and a lump of raw clay given by Ramlochan.

One day the head of the school saw the clay in Devvrat's room and asked, 'Pottery along with music now?'

Devvrat said, 'I am learning how much a note shrinks in the fire.'

Whether the head understood him or not, he asked no further questions.

Six months later Nilu made a new flute. It was not as beautiful as the old flute. Finger impressions showed on its surface, and its colour was uneven. But all seven notes sounded clearly in sequence.

He took the flute to town to give it to Devvrat.

Devvrat played it. First note, second, third—each in its place. At the last note he stopped.

'This one is complete.'

Nilu said, ‘No.’

‘What is left?’

Nilu took the first old flute from his bag, the same one that had reached Devvrat through Ratinath.

‘In this one the third note runs high,’ Nilu said.

‘I know.’

‘But the breath I learnt for that note is not needed on the new flute. The new flute is easy.’

Devvrat placed the two flutes before him. One was close to the rules; the other held the memory of practice born from an error.

‘Which one will you keep?’ he asked.

Nilu said, ‘Both. From one I’ll learn the rules. From the other, the ear.’

Devvrat nodded slowly. Then he held out his old bamboo flute to Nilu.

‘Take this.’

Nilu did not take it. ‘It is yours.’

‘Consider it gurudakshina.’

Nilu asked in surprise, ‘Does the guru give the gurudakshina?’

Devvrat laughed. ‘Let someone change the rule today.’

Nilu took the flute, but did not put it straight into his bag. He placed the new clay flute in Devvrat’s hands and said, ‘Then you keep this. But on one condition.’

‘What is it?’

‘Next time we make the holes, you will not measure the thread.’

‘Then how?’

‘First the clay will measure. After it is fired, you will measure the notes.’

Devvrat turned the flute in his hand. ‘All right.’

That evening, after the music school closed, Devvrat placed the new clay flute beside the window. Next to it lay Nilu’s first flute with the crooked note. They were almost the same size, but the spacing of their holes was different.

The following Sunday Devvrat went again to the potters’ quarter. Nilu was not by the wheel; he was sifting clay behind the kiln. Devvrat sat down there quietly.

Nilu stopped the sieve and asked, ‘A lesson in notes today?’

Devvrat picked up a lump of raw clay.

‘Today, the clay lesson first.’

Nilu tested the lump’s moisture with a finger, then poured a little water into Devvrat’s palm.

‘This won’t become a flute yet,’ he said. ‘First let the clay rest a little.’

Devvrat put the lump back on the ground.

The two of them waited for it to rest.

STORY 37

The Open Door

A thin strip of morning sunlight was entering the courtyard beneath the gate. Rekha sat to one side of that strip. The gate was open, but she did not step outside.

It was her fifth day back home. Fourteen months earlier, she had been taken to the city on the promise of work in a garment factory. After that, the roads kept changing, the people kept changing, and her control over both her labour and her own body kept diminishing. She was freed along with several other young women in a police raid, spent three months in a shelter home, and only after the paperwork was completed was she able to return to her parents' house.

Since the day she returned, the gate of the house had remained open all day.

Her mother would say, "Let the air keep coming in."

Rekha understood—there was no need to open such a large gate merely for air.

On the first day her mother had held her tightly to her chest. Her father had stood by a pillar of the veranda, wiping his eyes again and again. Her younger sister Neelu had clung to her feet and cried. Her younger brother Chandan had watched from a distance.

From the second day, all the ordinary talk of the house began again—the price of paddy, Neelu's examination, the tyre of Chandan's bicycle, her father's knee, the leaking roof over the veranda.

Only Rekha's fourteen months were never spoken about.

Whenever she herself tried to say something, her mother would find some task or other to bring up.

"Eat first."

"You are very tired today."

"Leave what has passed behind."

Her father would turn the radio a little louder.

If Neelu began to ask something, her mother would stop her with a look.

Rekha could see that the house had made many preparations for her return—a new sheet, a washed pillow, a comb in her old brass box, clean curtains at the window. But no empty space had been prepared in the house for listening to her story.

On the third day, Malti Kaki came to the gate.

"Has Rekha come back?" Her voice carried into the courtyard.

Her mother immediately looked at Rekha.

"Go inside," she said softly.

Rekha stopped and asked, “Why?”

“People will have too many questions just now.”

Rekha got up and went into the room. Outside, her mother said, “Yes, she has come back. She is tired. She is resting.”

Malti Kaki asked, “May I see her?”

Her mother replied, “After a few days.”

From inside, Rekha kept looking at the open frame of the gate. The way stood open, but she herself was not allowed to be present upon it.

That evening Neelu quietly came into her room. She had a schoolbook in her hand.

“Didi, are you angry with me?”

Rekha said, “No.”

“Then why are you so quiet with me?”

Rekha tried to smile. “The silence was already here before I came. I am looking for a place for myself inside it.”

Neelu did not understand. She opened her book and sat down.

At dinner that night, her father said that the discussion of Neelu’s marriage would be taken up again the following month. Rekha kept mixing lentils into her rice.

Her mother said softly, “Until then, let as little as possible of the household matter go outside.”

Rekha stopped her spoon.

“Which household matter?”

No one answered across the plates.

“My coming back?” Rekha asked.

Her mother began wiping the rim of her plate.

Her father said, “People are not good.”

Rekha asked again, “What will people say?”

“Whatever comes into their minds.”

“And what will I say?”

This time Chandan raised his head, but when his father’s eyes fell on him, he looked down again.

Rekha ate her last mouthful of rice and got up.

A little later that night, she found Chandan by the courtyard well. He was pulling up a bucket with the rope. When Rekha stood there to take water, he said without looking at her, “Two boys in the market were asking about you today, using your name.”

Rekha took hold of the bucket handle. “What did you say?”

Chandan said, “Nothing.”

Rekha asked, “Why?”

For the first time Chandan looked at her. “Father said we should not talk to anyone.”

“What did you feel like saying?”

Chandan’s lips trembled slightly. “I felt like saying that Didi has come back. That’s all.”

Rekha filled the lota with water. “Then next time say exactly that.”

Chandan went on coiling the rope. “People will ask more.”

“You do not have to answer every question. But there is no need to hide the fact that I have come back either.”

Chandan said nothing, but he coiled the bucket rope more neatly than before. Rekha understood—the silence of the house had tied different knots over everyone’s mouth, not only hers.

The next morning she opened an old bamboo chest. Inside were a few half-made sikki-grass baskets, coloured thread, and two small fans. Before she had left home, she used to make sikki work with her mother. Malti Kaki helped them sell those things at the market.

Rekha took out a half-made basket and sat on the veranda. Her fingers did not move as quickly as before. The grass broke twice. On the third attempt, the knot sat properly.

At noon Malti Kaki came again. This time her mother had gone towards the pond.

“Rekha?” Kaki called from the gate itself.

Rekha got up, thinking she would go inside. Her foot turned for a moment, then stopped.

“I’m here,” she said.

Malti Kaki did not enter the courtyard. She remained standing by the gate.

“Good that you came back.”

That was all Kaki said.

Not “Where were you?”, not “What happened?”, not “Who did it?”

Seeing the half-made basket in Rekha’s hands reminded her of old times.

“You still make these?”

“My hands are learning again.”

“I need small baskets for my grandchild’s upanayan ceremony. Can you make four?”

For the first time in five days, Rekha answered without thinking, “I can.”

Malti Kaki said, “I won’t pay in advance. Otherwise your mother will say I am stealing work from you.”

Rekha laughed. It was a small laugh, but it was her own.

When her mother returned in the evening and heard about the four baskets, she fell silent.

"Why did you agree?"

"I know how to make them."

"But people will keep coming and going from the house."

"The gate is open anyway."

Her mother looked at her at that sentence.

It rained that night. The gate was closed. Inside, the darkness felt a little deeper.

Rekha sat in the same room with her mother. Neelu was asleep. Outside, water fell with a steady drip.

Rekha said, "At the shelter home there was a door that remained open from morning until evening."

For the first time, her mother did not interrupt her sentence.

"Could you go outside?"

"Not without permission."

"Then why was it open?"

"They said it was for air."

Her mother remained silent for a few moments. The rain grew heavier.

Rekha said, "The gate here also stays open. But when Malti Kaki came, I was sent inside."

Her mother's hands became still in her lap.

"I am trying to protect you."

"From whom?"

"From people's mouths."

"During those fourteen months there were very few ways to protect myself from the people I met. If, in my own house, I must again stay shut inside a room in order to protect myself from people's mouths, then where is the difference?"

Her mother could not answer.

Rekha went on, "I will not tell everything today. There may be things I never tell. But whatever I do want to say, I need a place where it can be heard."

The rain eased a little. Her mother got up to close the window. When she returned, she sat beside Rekha.

"I will listen," she said. "I will be afraid, but I will listen."

Rekha did not tell the whole story then. She said only this much: that the first city was not the city whose name they had been told; that on the first night the door had been locked from the outside; that one girl kept repeating her own

name again and again so she would not forget it; and that on the day the police came, Rekha could not believe the road outside truly led outside.

Her mother did not ask a single question in between.

At dawn her father was drinking tea on the veranda. Rekha placed the four unfinished basket circles in front of her.

"I'm going to the market today," she said.

Her father paused while lifting his cup. "With Malti?"

"First to her house. After that, on my own."

Many sentences came and went across her father's face. In the end he said, "If it starts raining on the way, stop by the shop near the peepal tree."

Her mother came out of the kitchen with a cloth in her hand. She moved to cover Rekha's head with it, then stopped her hand. She gave the cloth to Rekha instead.

"Wear it if you feel like it."

Rekha put the cloth into her bag.

Neelu came running. "Didi, bring me a black pen on your way back."

From the veranda Chandan called, "Will you take the bicycle?"

"I'll walk."

The gate was open. Rekha paused on the threshold for a moment. The lane outside was the same—mud, two goats, water on the leaves of the peepal tree, a vegetable seller's cry in the distance.

No one stopped her.

She walked slowly as far as Malti Kaki's house. Kaki examined the four baskets, turning one in her hand, and said, "Your knots are still as tight as ever."

Rekha said, "My hands are learning again."

At the market, two people recognised her. One woman looked at her for a little while, then merely began asking the price of vegetables. One man turned his eyes away. Rekha noticed both things, but she did not change the road by which she would return home.

In the evening, when she reached the gate, her mother was sorting paddy in the courtyard. As soon as Rekha stepped inside, her mother asked without looking up, "Did you bring the salt?" Rekha opened her bag. "I did."

"Neelu's pen?" Rekha laughed. "That too." Her mother then raised her head. "The baskets?" Rekha said, "Two were sold. The other two next week."

Her mother nodded, as though this were ordinary household accounting. Rekha took off her bag and placed it on the veranda. Behind her, the gate remained open.

STORY 38

Silent Testimony

Morning sunlight had yet to reach the third-floor veranda of the district court. A thin strip of light fell on the floor through the latticed window to the east, but it was somewhat darker in front of the testimony room. Above the door, in black letters, was written—"Closed Proceedings—Unauthorised Entry Prohibited."

Kusum sat on a wooden bench three paces from that door. Her mother, Devmaya, sat beside her; a woman constable was in front; and Suchitra, the support worker, stood to one side carrying a bag of papers. Kusum's hands were empty. With the nail of her right thumb, she kept touching a small white scar on her left palm.

Suchitra said softly to Devmaya, "She will not have to answer too many questions today. The judge will control the pace."

Devmaya immediately said, "She used to speak little even before. After the incident she became completely silent."

Kusum did not look at her mother. She only said, "I did not become silent."

Devmaya turned towards her in surprise.

"Then what happened?"

"People began speaking more in front of me."

The bag in Suchitra's hand slipped a little lower. She seemed about to say something, then stopped.

At the other end of the veranda, the public prosecutor, Arunesh Mishra, was speaking quietly with the police inspector. The inspector said, "She gives short answers. Better to ask in yes or no."

Arunesh said, "Let her say as much as she wishes."

Just then defence counsel came up the stairs as well. Two young men were with him. They looked at Kusum for a moment, then turned their eyes away. The woman constable shifted her chair a little farther in front of the bench. Nothing was said, yet the narrow passage of the veranda became narrower still.

Arunesh came over to Kusum and said in a very low voice, "Answer only what is asked. If you do not remember something, say 'I do not remember'. If you become tired, ask for a break."

Suchitra immediately added, "If you wish, you may take your time before answering."

Devmaya gave a third piece of advice in her own way. "Don't look too much at anyone. Say what happened, then we'll go home."

Kusum listened to all three. One piece of advice came from the law, one from support, one from her mother. Their intentions were not different, yet each

sentence had already begun to give her testimony a small shape of how it ought to be delivered.

She asked, "What if I do not understand the question properly?"

Arunesh said, "Ask for it to be put again."

"And if the question contains something I never said?"

This time Arunesh paused a little. "Then say clearly—those are not my words."

Kusum lowered her head and looked at her palm. Rubbing her thumb over the white scar, she seemed to be remembering not a sentence, but a right.

The bell inside rang.

Kusum stood up. Devmaya began to rise too, but the constable signalled with her hand—"Mother will remain outside."

Devmaya reached out as though to catch the end of Kusum's sari, then stopped her hand halfway. Kusum herself adjusted the sari over her shoulder and walked through the door.

The room was smaller than she had expected. The judge's seat was raised, but the chair kept for Kusum was ordinary. In front were the counsels' tables, to one side the recording clerk, and at the back only the necessary staff.

The first question was her name.

"Kusum Devi?"

"Yes, that is me."

"How old are you?"

Kusum told them.

"Have you come to give evidence of your own free will?"

Kusum paused.

"A summons came."

A brief silence spread through the room. The public prosecutor asked again, "But you are not objecting to giving evidence?"

"No. I will give evidence."

The recording clerk began to write.

She was asked the date of the incident. She was asked the place. Kusum kept answering. Sometimes one word, sometimes one sentence. When a question seemed unclear, she said, "Ask again." When a question contained two things at once, she said, "One at a time."

Once the public prosecutor said, "At that time you were very frightened?"

Kusum looked at him.

"At what time?"

"Immediately after the incident."

"I was trembling."

"Because you were afraid?"

"I was trembling—that is all I remember."

The recording clerk drew a thin line through the word he had first written and wrote the second sentence.

Kusum could see that thin line very clearly. When her statement had been written at the police post, she had never seen a word crossed out like that. There, the person writing would occasionally ask, "Shall I write it like this?" and Kusum, exhausted, would nod. Today she understood that nodding one's head and saying a sentence in one's own words were not the same thing.

Before the next question, the judge asked, "Would you like some water?"

Kusum said, "Not yet. Let the questions continue."

No one in the room attached any meaning to that small answer. Kusum found this strangely comforting.

Her eyes went again to the crossed-out line.

After a while, the defence questions began. The tone was courteous, but the edge of the questions was like a thin knife.

"Why did you not call out loudly for help at the time of the incident?"

Kusum said, "I did."

"That is not clearly stated in your first statement."

"I said it."

"Why was it not written?"

For the first time, Kusum looked directly into the counsel's eyes.

"Why are you asking me that?"

The judge intervened. "Reframe the question."

Defence counsel turned a page.

"Very well. When you gave your statement to the police, did you remain silent?"

"No. I answered."

"How much did you say?"

"As much as I was asked."

"Did you say everything?"

Kusum paused again.

"Can anyone say everything all at once?"

The room was quiet again.

The counsel moved on to another question.

A short break was taken before noon. When Kusum came outside, Devmaya held out a lota of water. Suchitra asked, "Are you all right?"

Kusum drank some water and said, “Yes.”

Devmaya said to the constable, “See? She is nervous inside, but she does not show it.”

Suchitra said softly, “Sometimes the body freezes by itself. It is a natural response of the body.”

Kusum handed the lota back to her mother.

“I am sleepy right now.”

Both women fell silent.

Kusum rested her head against the wall behind the bench. For five minutes she sat with her eyes closed. She did not fall asleep, but no one got the opportunity to explain the meaning of her silence.

After the break, the testimony resumed. This time there were questions about the medical examination, the time she reached home, and the first person to whom she had spoken about the matter.

The public prosecutor asked, “Why did you not tell your mother everything at first?”

Kusum said, “Mother had a fever that night.”

“So you wanted to protect her?”

“I said—Mother had a fever.”

“Meaning that you did not want to worry her?”

Kusum’s eyebrows lifted slightly.

“That is your sentence.”

Arunesh stopped.

The judge looked towards the recording clerk. “Record the witness’s own words.”

For the first time, Kusum looked towards the bench. There was no gratitude on her face, no relief—only attention.

In the second hour, the defence returned again to her silence that night.

“Your mother says that for two days you hardly spoke properly to anyone.”

“Mother was at home. I went out from time to time.”

“Where did you go?”

“The hospital. The police station. My aunt’s house.”

“So you spoke to people?”

“Whatever was necessary with each person.”

“But about the incident?”

Kusum rubbed her thumb over the white scar on her palm.

“Sometimes I spoke. Sometimes I did not.”

“Why was that?”

"Sometimes I could not find the words."

"Fear?"

"Sometimes."

"Shame?"

Kusum's thumb stopped.

"I did not use that word."

"Then the reason?"

Kusum looked at the counsel for a few moments. Then she said slowly, "Sometimes I was tired. Sometimes the person in front of me had already decided why I was silent. Then it seemed pointless to explain it to them."

The recording clerk's writing slowed slightly.

Defence counsel said, "Are you saying that people did not listen to you?"

Kusum shook her head.

"No. I am saying that people filled my silence with their own words as well."

For the first time in court, while her complete sentence was being written, no one interrupted.

Before the testimony ended, the judge asked, "Is there anything in the recorded statement that you wish to clarify?"

Kusum looked at the recording clerk.

"Read it aloud."

The recording clerk began reading the main portions from the beginning. Kusum stopped him twice. In one place it said "very frightened".

"Remove that. I said I was trembling."

In another place it said "did not tell her mother because of concern for her".

"Remove that too. Mother had a fever—that is all."

The recording clerk made the corrections.

The judge asked, "Anything else?"

Kusum said, "No. Let only as much remain as I said."

The proceedings ended. The door opened. Outside stood Devmaya, Suchitra, two constables and several people who were waiting. As soon as Kusum came out, a local reporter moved towards Suchitra.

"How did the testimony go today? Did she say anything?"

Out of habit, Suchitra opened her mouth to answer—"She spoke with great courage—"

Then she stopped.

She looked at Kusum.

The reporter turned the question to Kusum. "Would you like to say anything?"

Kusum said, “What I had to say today, I said inside.”

“Not outside?”

“No. Not about this outside.”

The reporter lowered his pen.

As they went down the stairs, Devmaya said softly, “People in the village will ask. What shall I tell them?”

Kusum went down three steps and stopped. In the courtyard below, the man selling lemon water was washing his glass tumblers.

“Say—what belongs to Kusum, Kusum will say.”

Devmaya said nothing.

At the last turn of the staircase, Kusum herself asked, “Mother, shall we have lemon water?”

Devmaya said, “Whatever you want.”

For the first time, a faint smile came to Kusum’s face.

“Then two glasses.”

STORY 39

Kurthi Lentils

It was the first week of Chait. A trace of winter chill still lingered in the morning air, but the earth in the courtyard dried as the day rose. Saraswati had set an earthen pot on the hearth and was boiling kurthi lentils. The lid trembled from time to time, steam escaped, and smoke caught in the rafters of the veranda.

Ramlochan took down the small bamboo measure hanging from a peg and went into the storeroom. He felt the sack kept in a corner with his hand. It was less than half full. He filled the measure with grain, then poured it back into the sack. He did this three times.

Looking towards the pot, Saraswati asked, “Will the measure change if you count it three times?”

Ramlochan did not answer. He dragged the sack outside. “About twenty-six seers.”

His mother, Jagmaya, sat on a cot on the veranda, wrapped in a blanket. For three weeks her body had been weak. She ate little, grew breathless quickly, and by evening her thighs and knees ached. Two days earlier the village health worker had told them not to delay taking her to the block hospital. There would be some cost for tests, travel besides, and perhaps medicines to be bought outside.

Jagmaya looked at the sack. “Will you sell all this?”

Ramlochan said, “Where will the money come from if we do not sell it? The wheat is still in the field. Whatever paddy we had was finished in Magh. There has been no wage work for two weeks.”

Saraswati added salt to the pot. “Not all of it. Six seers are set aside for seed.”

“What use is keeping seed if Mother lies ill at home?” Ramlochan’s voice was not harsh, only tired. “Yesterday at the haat, Nandu the trader said the price of kurthi has risen. In the city, well-off people now buy it calling it a health grain. If we give him twenty seers, the tests, medicines and travel will all be covered.”

Jagmaya laughed softly. “In the first Chait after my marriage, my mother-in-law told me—when paddy runs low, kurthi saves the household. Now the city folk have given it a grand name, so has its price become grand too?”

Saraswati took the pot off the hearth. The dal was thin, but the smell of garlic and cumin rose from it. Dividing it among three bowls, she placed Jagmaya’s bowl before her first.

Ramlochan rested a hand on the sack and said, “Whatever its name, we need money.”

The household accounts were visible not on paper but in utensils and sacks. The paddy bin was empty. The bottom showed in the lentil tin. Only two finger-widths of oil remained in the bottle. The sack of kurthi alone was something that, at a glance, showed Saraswati the next month’s cooking. She could soak

kurthi at night and boil it in the morning, grind it into a vegetable dish, or, if rice ran short, thicken its broth and fill their stomachs.

She dragged the sack inside. She brought out three bamboo baskets. Into the first she measured six seers. Into the second, twelve. Into the third, the remaining eight.

Ramlochan asked, “What is this?”

“The first is seed. The second is for the household to eat. The third is to sell.”

“Nandu will not take eight seers. He does not load anything under twenty seers onto his cart.”

Saraswati fell silent. The three baskets remained in a row on the veranda. Jagmaya looked at the first, then the second, then the third.

“Leave my tests,” she said.

Ramlochan replied at once, “Do not say that again.”

“Then leave the seed.”

This time Saraswati raised her face. “If we give up the seed, next Asadh we will be at the moneylender’s door again. If we give up the basket for food, in Baisakh we will buy dal from the market. What is cheap now, we will buy dear with that very money then. Cut away one of the three, and two days later a hole will open somewhere else.”

At noon Ramlochan put the eight seers from the basket into a sack and took it to Nandu the trader’s warehouse. Nandu was sitting by the scales. The moment he saw the sack he asked, “How much?”

“Eight seers.”

Nandu shook his head. “I told you before. Not less than twenty. I have to send it to the city. What will I do with little sacks?”

“Pay me two rupees less on the rate.”

“It is not about the rate. I need the quantity.”

Ramlochan stood there for a while. Inside the warehouse, five large sacks of kurthi were stacked one upon another. Outside, two labourers panted as they loaded maize onto a bullock cart. Nandu bent over his scales again.

“Bring twenty seers,” he said. “I’ll pay cash.”

Ramlochan tucked the sack under his arm and returned home. He stopped twice on the way: once at the pond ghat, once beside a dry bamboo thicket. Reaching home, he set the sack down on the veranda.

Saraswati did not ask what Nandu had said. The sight of the sack told her.

By evening Jagmaya’s fever had risen. Her forehead was hot, her hands cold. Ramlochan borrowed a neighbour’s bicycle and fetched the health worker. She checked Jagmaya’s pulse, asked a few questions, then said, “Take her to the hospital tomorrow morning. It is not right to keep her at home on guesswork.”

No fresh meal was cooked that night. The leftover kurthi dal from noon was reheated. Three bowls were shared among four people. Ramlochan's daughter Lalita, who had spent the day at her maternal uncle's house, quietly pushed her own bowl towards her grandmother. Jagmaya ate half a spoonful and pushed the bowl back. "Will you be able to study without eating?"

Lalita said nothing. She drew the bowl back to her place.

Ramlochan sat on the veranda until late that night. The three baskets were before him: seed, food for the household, and the portion to be sold. At last he rose and, not from the first basket but from the second, lifted twelve seers and added them to the third. The twenty seers for sale were now complete. The household's food basket was empty.

Saraswati had been watching from inside. She came out and sat beside the empty basket.

"What about tomorrow?" she asked.

"Tomorrow, first Mother's tests."

"And after that, how will the household run?"

Ramlochan searched for an answer, but did not find one at once. "The wheat harvest will begin. There will be wage work."

"There are twelve days until the harvest."

"We'll manage somehow."

As she tied the sack, Saraswati said, "We will not touch the seed."

Ramlochan nodded. That night, one of the three baskets stood empty.

In the morning Nandu weighed the twenty seers and paid cash. Ramlochan tied the money into an inner fold of his shirt and went with his mother to the block hospital. It was crowded. First the registration slip, then the tests, then the doctor. By the time they returned near evening, he had two packets of medicine in his hand, instructions about food and drink on a sheet of paper, and very little money left. But the doctor had said there was no immediate grave danger; she needed regular meals, rest and medicine, and should be brought back after seven days.

On reaching home, Jagmaya lay down on the cot, exhausted. Saraswati gave her the medicine with water. Then she went towards the hearth.

"What will we cook today?" Lalita asked.

Saraswati opened the grain bin. A handful of rice. A few potatoes. Salt. That was all.

That night they made a thin potato broth. Jagmaya could not eat more than two mouthfuls. The next day Ramlochan went to a landowner's house to ask for wage work; he was told there would be work in three days. On the third day the rice ran out. Saraswati did not go to a neighbour to borrow. She lifted the piece of sacking from the basket kept for seed. Six seers of kurthi lay there quietly.

She reached out to fill the measure, then stopped.

Jagmaya was watching from the cot. “Take some out.”

“This is seed.”

“The seed will go to the field, but only if people stay alive until the field.”

Saraswati took out half a measure. “Only this much.”

That day kurthi went into the pot again. The dal was thinner than before, but four bowls of hot steam rose in the house. Over the next five days, the seed basket lost one and a half seers. As soon as Ramlochan found the first harvesting work, he brought home two days’ wages. Some rice, salt and oil came into the house. From the third day onward, he remained in the fields continuously.

On the seventh day Jagmaya went to the hospital again. This time Saraswati went with Ramlochan. The doctor said her body was weak and that her meals should be kept regular. The empty basket rose unbidden in Saraswati’s mind, but she said nothing.

Baisakh passed. With the wages from the wheat harvest, the household hearth became regular again. Jagmaya slowly recovered her strength. But as soon as Asadh arrived, a new question stood before them: the time to sow kurthi.

Ramlochan took down the seed basket. A little more than four seers of grain remained. The previous year they had used six seers of seed. It was clear that they would have to reduce the field by two kathas.

“Shall I buy two seers from the market?” Ramlochan asked.

Saraswati asked the price. On hearing it she laughed, but there was no joy in the laughter. The same kurthi that had been sold in Chait to buy medicine would now have to be bought back as seed at twice the price.

“No,” she said. “Sow whatever we have. We’ll plant marua on the remaining strip.”

Ramlochan looked towards the field. “If there is less kurthi, what about next Chait?”

Saraswati was silent for a few moments. “We do not have the answer to next Chait today. Today the seed has survived, Mother is up and walking, and no new knot of debt has been tied around the household. That is not a small thing.”

On the morning of sowing day, Ramlochan and Saraswati reached the field. The soil was softer than the year before. Ramlochan took a handful of kurthi and began scattering it along the rows. The first two rows went at the usual spacing. At the third he stopped his hand. There was too little seed. Saraswati said, “Make it a little thinner. Spread what we have.”

By the time the day rose, four seers of seed could not fill the whole field. A strip on the western side remained empty. There Saraswati scattered marua seed.

When they returned home, Jagmaya was sitting on the veranda. Before her, in an earthen bowl, lay the last handful of kurthi—the broken and shrivelled grains that had been separated while sorting the seed.

Jagmaya spread those grains across her palm and looked at them. “These will go into the cooking.”

Saraswati laughed and asked, “Not into the seed?”

“What is not fit for the field may still be fit for the stomach.”

In the evening the earthen pot went onto the hearth again. This time there was little dal, with marua rotis beside it. Ramlochan took the first mouthful and said nothing. Outside, the western strip of the field was no longer empty; another seed had already been sown there.

Saraswati placed the three baskets back in the corner of the kitchen. One still awaited the new grain. The second was empty. In the third, two handfuls of broken kurthi remained. She covered the baskets.

Saraswati covered the embers of the hearth with ash. The fire was not entirely out; within, it remained red for the morning.

STORY 40

The Dream of One Bigha

In the Agahan sunlight, the field boundaries stood out clearly. The paddy had been harvested, and egrets settled here and there among the stubble. Shivanath was walking around Devanath Chaudhary's field with an old length of rope. The rope was twenty cubits long. He hooked one end around a bamboo peg driven into the boundary ridge, pulled the other end taut, and counted the knots.

Devanath stood at a distance, smiling. "Measure it. I won't short-change you on the land."

Shivanath smiled too, but his eyes stayed on the rope. He had cultivated this field on share for five years. He knew, as he knew his own courtyard, where water lingered longest, on which strip the wheat grew thin, where rats gnawed into the ridge to make their burrows. The only difference was that on the day the harvest was divided in half, the field became someone else's again.

One bigha. A full bigha.

Devanath's two sons lived in town. He needed money to repair the house, and so he had raised the question of selling this plot. Buyers from the market had come to look twice, but the field lay far from the main road, along a track that turned muddy in the rains. Devanath had told Shivanath, "You've been cultivating it for five years. If you want to buy it, I'll speak to you first."

Shivanath had not slept properly for three nights.

Inside the house, an old chest made by a blacksmith held thirty-nine thousand two hundred rupees. The money had not been gathered in a day. The proceeds from selling two goats, a little saved from his share of the wheat, five thousand given by his younger brother who had gone away for work, and two years of Manjula's sewing earnings - all of it had accumulated slowly in that chest. At first the money had no name. Later, whenever Shivanath opened the chest, he began calling it "the land money."

Devanath had said that if Shivanath paid an advance of thirty-five thousand, he would not sell the land to anyone else for three months. The balance could be paid in three instalments over two years. The deed would be executed on the final payment. The condition was hard, but it did not seem impossible to Shivanath. Once he had one bigha of his own, there would be no obligation to give away half the produce. For the first time, the future seemed visible in the shape of an account.

As he coiled the rope, he said, "I'll pay the advance by the day after tomorrow."

Devanath nodded. "By the evening of the day after tomorrow. After that the outside buyer is coming again."

When he returned home, Manjula was shaking paddy straw at the doorway. Shivanath hung the rope from a peg.

"Did you measure it?" she asked.

"A full bigha."

A faint smile came to Manjula's face. "The rope didn't come up short or long?"

"I've cultivated that field for five years. The rope may deceive me; my eyes won't."

That afternoon their daughter Rama arrived home from the district headquarters. She was in her second year at the government women's college and lived in the hostel. The short winter break had begun. In her bag, among her clothes, was a folded notice.

After the meal she placed the notice before her father. The fee for the next term, three months' hostel charges, and some laboratory materials came to twenty-two thousand four hundred rupees. Because the previous crop had been poor, the money set aside for her studies had already gone into household expenses and cultivation.

Shivanath read the notice again. "By the end of Paush?"

"Yes," Rama said. "After that they won't hold my hostel room. The arrears will show in the examination register too."

"Could you travel from home?"

"Even if I catch the first bus in the morning, I'll miss the first class. By the time I return in the evening, it'll be night."

Shivanath folded the notice and put it back in her hand. "We'll see."

Those two syllables - we'll see - hung in the house until evening.

After dinner that night, Manjula opened the chest. The money was tied in separate knots inside an old cloth bag. She took it all out and laid it on the cot. Rama was studying in the inner room. Their younger son, Mohan, was asleep.

When Manjula finished counting, she said, "Thirty-nine thousand two hundred."

Shivanath said, "I know."

"Thirty-five thousand for the land advance. Twenty-two thousand four hundred for Rama. And Bhola Sah?"

Shivanath remained silent.

The previous Asadh they had taken fertiliser, seed, and pesticide twice on credit from Bhola Sah. After selling their share of the paddy they had paid twelve thousand, but fourteen thousand eight hundred still remained. Sah had said that if they wanted supplies for the wheat in Magh, they must first reduce the old balance.

Manjula added the three amounts in her head and looked again at the pile of notes. "This money won't open all three doors."

Shivanath said quietly, "If the land slips from our hands, we may never get another chance like this."

"And if Rama's studies stop halfway?"

"She'll sit at home. Who knows when she'll ever return to it?"

Manjula said nothing. She tied the bag again.

Rama called from inside, "Ma, the lamp oil is running out."

Manjula got up. Sitting on the cot, Shivanath kept looking at three invisible piles of money – land, education, debt.

Early the next morning he went to Bhola Sah's shop. Sacks of fertiliser stood in a row by the entrance. Bhola opened his ledger.

"Fourteen thousand eight hundred," he said. "I'm ordering the next consignment. Pay something towards the old account, then I'll enter the wheat supplies."

Shivanath asked, "What if I pay half?"

Bhola shrugged. "If you pay half, I'll have half the confidence. But you need the full supplies, don't you? I don't get goods on credit either."

Shivanath stepped out of the shop. Across the way, the tea seller had a kettle on the stove. He did not drink tea. What had earlier been three separate worries had now become a single knot. Even after buying the land, he would need fertiliser and seed to cultivate it. If he left the old debt untouched and paid the land advance, he would have to borrow again before the first harvest. The first season on his own land would begin in someone else's ledger.

That afternoon he went to the sharecropped field. The owner's share had already been taken away. His own share of the straw lay in one corner. He sat on the ridge and began picking at the dry soil. He could not remember exactly how much produce had been halved over five years, but he remembered every scene of division – two piles, an empty strip between them, one sack this way, one sack that way.

On Devanath's one bigha, that scene would not happen. That was the dream.

In the evening Rama sat at the doorway covering her books for the next term. Shivanath sat down beside her.

"If we can't arrange the hostel and fee money this time, what will you do?"

Rama stopped her hands. "I'll stay at home and study from the books. I'll try again next term."

"Won't it hurt?"

"It will."

The answer was direct. Shivanath looked at his daughter. Rama went back to straightening the book cover.

After a while she said on her own, "Babu, don't give up the land. I can stay at home this term."

Shivanath asked, "Who told you to say that?"

"No one."

"Then who has just made the decision?"

Rama smiled. "I'm only saying it."

Shivanath stood up. He could not tell whether his daughter was trying to lighten his burden or hide her own fear. He made no decision about it that night.

On the third day Devanath was sitting in his courtyard with two buyers. When Shivanath arrived, they got up and left. Devanath asked, "Have you brought the advance?"

Shivanath had the cloth bag in his pocket. "I have. But not the full thirty-five."

Devanath's brow tightened slightly. "How much?"

"Ten thousand now. The remaining twenty-five by Phagun."

Devanath shook his head. "That wasn't the condition before. The outside buyer will pay the full advance."

"I know."

"Then?"

Shivanath was silent for a few moments. "An expense for education came up suddenly at home."

Devanath looked away. "I understand your difficulty, but work on my house is held up too. Land isn't sold out of pity."

Shivanath rested a hand on the bag in his pocket. "All right."

"If you can arrange thirty-five by this evening, the deal is still yours."

Shivanath did not say yes. He simply bowed in greeting and returned home.

On the way he could have turned towards a moneylender's house. There were two people in the village who could give him thirty-five thousand at once - at monthly interest. The advance on one bigha from his savings, Rama's next term on borrowed money, Bhola Sah's old debt pushed onto the next harvest. On paper the arithmetic worked. Only, in that arithmetic, the harvests of the next two years were already spent.

When he reached home, he opened the chest.

Manjula asked, "What happened?"

"Devanath wouldn't agree to ten thousand."

"Then?"

Shivanath counted the thirty-nine thousand two hundred again. First he set aside fourteen thousand eight hundred. Then twenty-two thousand four hundred. Only two thousand remained on the cot.

Manjula understood. But she did not say anything at once.

Shivanath said, "First we'll close Bhola Sah's account. We'll buy the wheat seed without tying a new knot of debt. The rest is for Rama's next term."

"The land?"

"Gone."

After saying the word, he looked for the first time at the empty bottom of the chest. Old newspaper lined it, dust gathered in the corners. Five years of savings would go in two directions in a single evening. Nothing would remain in his hand - neither a land deed nor a bag of rupees.

Manjula said softly, "Not the land. Rama will study."

Shivanath looked at her. "Don't preach to me now."

Manjula fell silent. A few moments later she said only, "All right. We'll go tomorrow morning."

The next day Shivanath cleared the old balance in Bhola Sah's ledger. Sah drew a red line against the amount. Shivanath watched that line, but the relief did not feel as great as he had imagined it would.

After that he went to the district town with Rama and Manjula. The queue at the college accounts window was long. By afternoon the fee, hostel charges, and laboratory amount had been paid. Rama put the receipt in her bag, came outside, and asked, "Babu, shall we have tea?"

Shivanath laughed. "I've got two thousand left now - more than enough for tea. We will."

The three of them drank tea at a roadside shop. They talked about the next term, books, the hostel bedding, and the sattu Rama would take from home. No one mentioned the land.

Four days later, a teacher from another village bought Devanath's one bigha. The news spread through the village in the ordinary way. Shivanath heard it, said, "All right," and walked towards the wheat field.

At the end of Paush, the new owner came to Shivanath's house. He worked in the city and was in no position to cultivate the field himself.

"You've been cultivating this field already," he said. "Will you take it on share this year as well?"

Shivanath was silent for a moment. In front of him, hanging from the peg, was the same twenty-cubit rope.

"What will the terms be?" he asked.

"Whatever is customary in the village."

Shivanath did not answer at once. The land he had dreamed for five years of making his own was before him again with the offer that he give away half its crop. Something tightened inside him, but the wheat season did not wait.

"I'll take it," he said at last, "but the seed and fertiliser costs will be half and half."

The new owner thought for a moment and agreed.

In the first week of Magh, Shivanath prepared to sow wheat on that one bigha. This time he bought the seed from Bhola Sah's shop for cash. The amount was small, but no new credit was entered in the ledger.

Rama had already gone back to the hostel. In a corner of the house, two old book covers lay on her empty cot. Now and then Manjula placed clothes there and then moved them away again.

Shivanath took the rope to the field. The new owner had asked him to straighten the boundary ridge a little. Shivanath drove in a peg and pulled the rope taut. It was the same rope with which he had measured the land in Agahan, before the planned purchase.

A labourer asked, "Measuring it again?"

Shivanath said, "No. This time I'm checking the line for sowing."

The rope remained stretched from ridge to ridge. The measure of one bigha had not changed. Only its meaning had.

Shivanath unfastened the rope, set it aside, and lifted the basket filled with seed. His hand moved along the first row. The wheat grains fell into the cold earth.

FROM THE HUNDRED-STORY TRILOGY · VOLUME III

STORY 41

The Empty Bag

It was a Wednesday in the month of Bhadra.

The morning sun had not yet properly risen.

Gopinath Sah took down an old cloth bag from a peg on the veranda.

Its mouth was tied with three knots.

One of the knots had grown old and hardened.

Sarojini Devi was sitting by the hearth.

She glanced once at the bag.

“Have you packed the rope?”

Gopinath Sah said, “Yes.”

“The ledger?”

“Yes.”

“The weights?”

“Yes.”

Sarojini Devi asked nothing more.

From an inner room, Gopinath Sah brought the ledger wrapped in a red cloth.

The corners of the ledger had worn away.

His father’s name was written at the top of the first page.

Beneath it was Gopinath Sah’s own name.

The yearly accounts began on the second page.

Several pages bore stains from lentils.

On others were small yellow marks of mustard oil.

He put the ledger into the bag.

He added the pointer of a small brass balance.

Four weights.

A strip of old cloth.

A handful of thin cord.

And two empty paper packets.

Sarojini Devi said, “Food?”

“I’ll eat something at the haat.”

“Take something from home.”

Gopinath Sah did not answer.
Sarojini Devi wrapped two rotis and a small box of salt and chillies in a cloth.
That too went into the bag.
Gopinath Sah stepped out through the doorway.
From behind him, Sarojini Devi said, “Don’t make it too heavy.”
He turned and looked back.
“How heavy can it be now?”
Whether Sarojini Devi smiled at that or not, Gopinath Sah did not see.
The haat was two kos from the village.
Earlier he used to go by bicycle.
Now he went on foot.
Half the road was unpaved.
The night’s rain had left mud in two places.
Gopinath Sah walked on with the bag tucked under his right arm.
Near Majhdhar Tola he met Kishun Mandal.
“Early today?”
“On market day, early is better.”
“How much seed is left?”
“We’ll see.”
Kishun Mandal said nothing to that answer.
By the time Gopinath Sah reached the haat, the sun had grown fierce.
From a distance he could see the blue tarpaulin stretched over bamboo slats.
It was Gopinath Sah’s old spot.
But that day the tarpaulin had already been put up.
Manju was there.
Manju was Gopinath Sah’s daughter.
For the past three months she had been coming at dawn on market days.
That day she had arrived before him.
Paper packets were arranged on the bamboo bench.
Mustard in one lot.
Lentils in another.
Peas in another.
Bottle-gourd, pumpkin and okra seeds in little packets.
With a piece of charcoal, Manju was writing the price on one packet.
Gopinath Sah stood in the shade of the tarpaulin.
Manju looked up.

"What took you so long?"
Gopinath Sah said, "There was mud on the road."
Manju laughed.
"There was mud yesterday too."
Gopinath Sah put the bag beneath the bench.
He did not sit down.
The first customer was an elderly farmer.
He said, "Two pao of mustard."
Manju picked up the balance.
She looked towards Gopinath Sah.
Gopinath Sah rested a hand on one corner of the bench.
He said nothing.
Manju weighed the seed.
The pointer tilted once to the right.
She removed two grains.
The pointer came to rest in the middle.
The elderly farmer looked at Gopinath Sah.
"Right?"
Gopinath Sah said, "The pointer is in the middle."
The farmer placed the money in Manju's hand.
Manju entered it in the ledger.
Gopinath Sah did not touch the ledger.
The next customer was a boy.
He asked for okra seed.
Manju told him the price.
The boy said, "Uncle used to charge less."
Manju replied, "That was a different batch of seed."
The boy looked at Gopinath Sah.
Gopinath Sah looked at the packet of seed.
"This is a new lot."
The boy quietly paid.
The crowd lasted until noon.
Now and then Gopinath Sah passed a packet forward.
Now and then he held out a blank sheet of paper.
Manju handled the rest of the accounts.
Twice she ran short of change.

Both times she opened the little cash box inside the bench.
Gopinath Sah did not tell her which compartment held the change.
Manju found it herself.
After noon the haat grew a little quieter.
Manju said, "Eat your roti."
Gopinath Sah opened the bag.
He took out the cloth in which the rotis were wrapped.
He set the little box of salt and chillies outside.
He sat down behind the bench.
Manju sat down too.
They ate half a roti each.
Gopinath Sah drank water.
Manju said, "Shall I take the ledger home today?"
Gopinath Sah kept chewing his roti.
After a while he said, "It would be better if it stayed at the haat."
Manju's hand stopped.
"At the haat?"
"In the box under the tarpaulin."
"It will get damp there."
"We'll put a brick on top."
Manju said nothing.
After they had eaten, Gopinath Sah opened the bag.
He took out the ledger wrapped in red cloth.
He opened it and looked at the last page that had been written on.
It was not yesterday's account, but the account from the previous market day.
His handwriting was at the bottom.
He held the ledger out towards Manju.
Manju did not extend her hand.
Gopinath Sah placed the ledger on the bench.
"Add today's account to this."
Manju slowly picked up the ledger.
She tied the red cloth around it again.
Gopinath Sah reached into the bag.
He took out all four brass weights.
One by one, he placed them beneath the bench.
He put the balance pointer there too.

Then the bundle of thin cord.
And the strip of old cloth.
Manju asked, "All this stays here?"
"It will be needed here."
"Next time?"
Gopinath Sah looked inside the bag.
Only the empty roti cloth and the little box of salt and chillies remained.
He wrapped the box in the cloth.
"Whatever is needed next time will be found here."
Manju kept looking at his face.
Gopinath Sah left the mouth of the bag open.
In the afternoon the customers began to come again.
A woman asked for lentils.
Manju weighed them.
Gopinath Sah glanced once at the pointer.
It stood in the middle.
He turned his eyes away.
A farmer asked for goods on credit.
Manju opened the ledger.
She searched for his name.
Gopinath Sah did not stop her.
Manju said, "Your previous credit is still unpaid."
The farmer looked at Gopinath Sah.
Gopinath Sah kept his eyes on the ground.
The farmer said, "All right, give me half."
Manju gave him half.
Towards evening the market thinned out.
Manju counted the packets that remained.
Gopinath Sah untied one corner of the tarpaulin.
Manju untied the other.
Together they folded the tarpaulin.
The box was put away inside.
The ledger was placed not on top of the box, but inside it.
Gopinath Sah picked up a brick.
Manju said, "I'll put it there."
Gopinath Sah handed the brick to her.

Manju placed it on the lid of the box.

Gopinath Sah picked up the bag.

It was suddenly light.

So light that his hand rose slightly with it.

Manju noticed.

She said nothing.

As he was leaving the haat, Ramdev the vegetable seller called out, "Uncle, potatoes?"

Gopinath Sah stopped.

He looked at the bag.

Then he said, "Not today."

"Going home empty-handed?"

"I have the bag."

Ramdev laughed.

Gopinath Sah did not.

Beyond the market the earthen road began.

The sun was sinking.

The empty bag under his arm puffed slightly in the wind.

He folded its mouth and pressed it down.

Near Majhdhar Tola he met Kishun Mandal again.

Kishun asked, "Sold everything?"

Gopinath Sah paused for a moment.

"Everything stayed there."

Kishun Mandal did not understand what he meant.

"All right."

The two went their separate ways.

By the time he reached home, evening had fallen.

Sarojini Devi was standing near the doorway.

She looked at Gopinath Sah's hand.

The bag hung low.

There was no shape inside it.

Sarojini Devi asked, "No vegetables?"

"No."

"Salt?"

"No."

"Oil?"

"No."
Gopinath Sah sat down on the veranda.
He placed the bag on the ground.
Sarojini Devi picked it up.
She opened its mouth.
Inside were the roti cloth and the little box.
She took them both out.
The bag truly was empty.
Sarojini Devi asked, "The ledger?"
"There."
"The weights?"
"There."
"The pointer?"
"There."
Sarojini Devi stood holding the bag in her hand.
"Everything?"
Gopinath Sah said, "Everything."
For a while there was silence on the veranda.
A bird drank from the water kept in one corner of the courtyard.
Sarojini Devi ran a hand inside the bag.
Two or three mustard seeds were caught at the bottom.
She shook them into her palm.
"These were left behind."
Gopinath Sah looked at the seeds.
"Let them be."
Sarojini Devi did not put them back into the bag.
She threw them onto the earth at the edge of the courtyard.
Then she shook out the bag.
She hung it on the peg.
It hung flatter than before.
That night Manju came at dinnertime.
She carried a small cloth sack in her hand.
Inside were potatoes, okra and a quarter-seer of salt.
Sarojini Devi said, "He was the one who went to the market."
Manju said, "I went too, this time."
Gopinath Sah kept eating his rice.

Manju looked at him.
"I put the ledger in the box."
Gopinath Sah nodded.
"The brick?"
"It's on top."
"Watch for damp."
"I will."
That was all they said.
Manju left.
At night Sarojini Devi looked towards the peg.
"Next Wednesday?"
Gopinath Sah was stretching out, preparing to sleep.
He asked, "What?"
"The market."
Gopinath Sah was silent for a while.
"We'll see in the morning."
The next Wednesday, Sarojini Devi rose at dawn.
Gopinath Sah rose too.
He washed his face.
He swept the veranda.
The bag hung from the peg.
Once, he reached out his hand.
His fingers touched a corner of the bag.
From outside came the sound of a bicycle bell.
Manju was at the doorway.
A bamboo basket was tied behind her bicycle.
Manju said, "Babu, where is the thick cord for tying the tarpaulin?"
Gopinath Sah went inside.
From the top of the old trunk, he took down the cord.
He placed it in Manju's hand.
"Pull both corners equally tight."
Manju said, "Yes."
She left.
The bicycle bell receded along the road.
Gopinath Sah came back and sat on the veranda.
The empty bag hung from the peg.

Whenever the breeze touched it, its mouth opened a little.
Gopinath Sah did not tie it shut.

STORY 42

The Boat Remained Tied

At dawn, the mist lay low over the river.

The bamboo mooring stake at the landing stood half-submerged in the water.

Raghunath Sahni was loosening the knot in the rope and tightening it again.

The boat had remained tied there all night.

Across the river, brightly coloured cloths could be seen hanging over the field.

Today was the fair.

The village school's annual function was being held there as well.

The first boatload arrived just as the sun was rising.

Three families.

Two children.

One old man.

Four baskets.

One drum.

Everyone was in a hurry.

Raghunath said nothing.

He had the baskets placed in the middle of the boat.

He seated the children on one side.

He settled the old man against the bamboo plank.

"Uncle, will you go and see the fair today too?"

One of the children asked.

Raghunath dipped the oar into the water.

"Let me get all of you across first."

The boat moved out into the current.

In the mist, the river did not seem very wide.

When they reached midstream, the sound of music from the far bank could be heard.

The drummer had one hand resting on his drum.

"Not yet," he said to himself.

Raghunath heard him.

He said nothing.

The boat came in on the sand of the far bank.

Everyone got off.

The children ran away.

The old man climbed up slowly.

Raghunath turned the boat around again.

"Why don't you stay here?" the old man said.

"There are still people on this side."

Raghunath replied.

The boat was empty.

The current turned an empty boat quickly.

Raghunath held the oar slightly at an angle.

On reaching this bank, he brought the boat alongside the bamboo stake again.

The second load was ready.

By noon he had found no time to count the trips.

Sometimes seven people.

Sometimes twelve.

Sometimes only two old people.

Once, four goats as well.

The faces of those going toward the fair were different.

No one was thinking about the return journey.

Everyone kept looking at the colours on the far bank.

Raghunath kept looking at the water.

The current had not risen.

But it was cutting into the sand on the southern side.

Whenever he brought the boat in on the far bank, he had to drive the bamboo pole into the sand again and again.

Near noon, his wife, Phoolo Devi, came to the landing with their daughter Sunita.

Sunita carried a blue cloth bag in her hand.

She was part of the school singing group.

Her white scarf was in the bag.

"Babu, our song is at three," Sunita said.

Raghunath was throwing two potfuls of water out of the bottom of the boat.

"Yes."

"At three."

"I heard you."

Phoolo Devi looked at Sunita.

Then at Raghunath.

"When there are fewer people, come over," she said.

Raghunath lifted the rope.
"We'll see."
Sunita sat down in the boat.
Phoolo Devi placed the girl's bag in her lap.
Seven other people climbed in as well.
The boat set off.
In midstream, Sunita kept looking toward the far bank.
Raghunath, toward this one.
When they reached the other side, everyone got off.
Sunita stepped out and paused.
"At three."
Raghunath had already turned the bow of the boat around.
"Go. You'll be late."
Sunita walked away.
Raghunath returned alone once more.
There were fewer people now on this bank.
The shade of the neem tree at the landing had grown small.
A tea seller was packing up his utensils, waiting to cross to the other side.
"Will anyone be left after you?" Raghunath asked.
The tea seller looked back along the path.
"People from two households are coming."
Raghunath sat down inside the boat.
He rested the oar across his knees.
The blisters on his palms were old.
Today they had grown a little red.
The tea seller said, "Uncle, won't you charge fare today?"
"Why not?"
"It's fair day."
"The river doesn't hold a fair."
The tea seller laughed.
Raghunath did not.
He kept looking at the worn place in the rope.
The two families arrived.
One woman carried a brass plate.
A young man was wheeling a bicycle.
It took time to get the bicycle into the boat.

Raghunath wedged its front wheel against a bamboo plank.

"On the far bank, take it down and wheel it straight ahead," he said.

The young man nodded.

The tea seller boarded last.

The boat was full.

Raghunath looked once toward the path on this bank.

No one.

Two empty earthen cups lay beneath the neem tree.

The dog from the landing too came up to the boat, wanting to follow the people to the far bank.

Raghunath let it aboard.

"That's everyone now," the tea seller said.

The boat pushed off.

This time there was no mist over the river.

Sunlight fell directly on the water.

The fair on the far bank could be seen clearly.

The Ferris wheel was turning.

Brightly coloured flags fluttered.

The school's name was being announced over the loudspeaker.

The boat came in on the far bank.

Everyone got off.

The dog jumped out first of all.

The tea seller unloaded his utensils and paused.

"Uncle, tie the boat here now and stay."

Raghunath probed the sand at the bank with the bamboo pole.

The pole sank half an arm's length.

"A knot won't hold here."

"There's a bamboo post by my stall. Tie it there."

"At night the current will turn."

"Then what?"

Raghunath said nothing.

The young man with the bicycle had also stopped.

"Everyone has come across. Who will you go back for now?"

Raghunath pushed the sand that had collected in the boat into one place with his foot.

Then he picked up the oar.

"The boat's landing is not on that bank."
The young man laughed.
"Stay here just for today."
Raghunath pushed the boat away.
"We'll see when it's time to come back tonight."
The boat entered the current.
The people on the far bank watched for a few moments.
Then they walked toward the fair.
Raghunath came back alone to this side once more.
The landing was empty.
As soon as the bow touched the earth, he stepped out.
He tied the rope to the old bamboo stake.
One knot.
Then another over it.
He tugged the rope to test it.
The boat moved a little.
The knot did not come loose.
Raghunath sat down beneath the neem tree.
There was no sound on this bank.
On the far bank there was every sound.
The announcement loudspeaker.
The drum.
Children shouting.
The creak of the iron Ferris wheel.
At times, applause.
Raghunath took some betel nut from his pocket.
He cut it with a small knife.
He put one piece in his mouth.
He folded the rest in paper and put it away.
He had no watch with him.
He looked at the sun.
It must have been around three.
The loudspeaker said something on the far bank.
The words broke apart while crossing the river.
"...school..."
Then came applause.

Raghunath raised his head.
For a few moments he listened.
Then he looked at the boat again.
A shapely leaf was caught in the bottom of the boat.
He took it out and placed it on the bank.
A song began on the far side.
Girls' voices together.
From that distance, the words could not be made out.
Only the tune reached him.
Raghunath kept chewing the betel nut.
Once, in the middle of the song, his hand stopped.
Then it moved again.
The song ended.
The sound of applause crossed the river and arrived faintly.
Raghunath leaned his back against the trunk of the neem tree.
Two crows flew across to this side.
One perched on the bow of the boat.
The other on the sand.
After a while, the first crow flew away too.
Raghunath stood up.
A strip of cloth was wrapped around the grip of the oar.
The cloth had loosened.
He untied the knot.
Then tied it tight again.
On one plank of the boat, a nail had risen slightly.
He hammered it down with a stone.
He checked the rope once more.
The fair continued on the far bank.
The path on this side remained empty.
The sun began to descend.
The neem tree's shadow stretched all the way to the river.
Raghunath went home once.
His house was five minutes from the landing.
The door was not shut.
The courtyard was empty.
The hearth was cold.

A plate lay overturned.
Phoolo Devi had left the morning rice covered.
Raghunath ate two mouthfuls.
He drank water.
Then he returned to the landing.
The boat was still there.
The rope was taut.
The current had grown a little stronger.
He pressed down the earth around the stake with his foot.
He brought another bamboo pole.
He drove it into the ground behind the first stake.
He looped one turn of the rope around that one as well.
Now the boat was tied between two bamboo stakes.
Across the river, the lights were slowly increasing.
The brightly coloured cloths of daytime were now less visible in the dark.
The rows of lamps could be seen clearly.
Raghunath sat down on the sand.
After a while, a lantern on the far bank moved up and down three times.
The old signal of the landing.
It was not yet time to return.
It was only a question—was the boat there?
Raghunath lit his own lantern.
He raised it twice.
The answer—yes.
The lantern on the far bank became still again.
Raghunath set his lantern beside the stake.
From far away, a man's voice came over the announcement loudspeaker.
The words were breaking apart again.
Then something like the sound of Sunita's laughter came across the water.
Raghunath raised his head.
There were many people on the far bank.
It was hard to tell who had laughed.
He looked at the rope again.
The knot was sound.
After a while, something like Phoolo Devi's red shawl moved near a light.
Raghunath narrowed his eyes a little.

He could not make it out clearly.
He did not get up.
He did not untie the boat.
Everyone was on the far bank.
On this bank, only the landing.
One boat.
Two bamboo stakes.
One lantern.
And Raghunath Sahni.
The current pulled the rope taut.
Then the rope slackened again.
Raghunath reached out and touched the knot.
There was applause again on the far bank.
The boat remained tied.

STORY 43

The Pond Keeper

On a Jeth evening, the pond water shone from afar like a thin sheet of metal.

On the western side of the village the fields had turned from yellow to grey, but in the pond's northern corner two or three clumps of reeds were still green.

Near those reeds, an egret stood on one leg.

Just behind the egret, Vanshi Mahato was pushing a slender bamboo rod into the water.

Small marks, cut long ago with a knife, ran along the rod.

Some marks had worn smooth; some were still sharp.

Vanshi Mahato turned the rod once to the right and examined it.

Then he bent towards the surface of the water.

"Another half an inch lower today," he said to himself.

The pond was called Kajraha.

No one in the village could now say whether the name had come from the colour of the water or from the dark grass that had once grown along the pond's edge.

For Vanshi Mahato, the question of the name did not matter.

He watched the water.

How much it had fallen and when, when it had risen at the same time as the well water, when the eastern drain had brought in silt—all this lived in his memory as separate years.

People in the village called him "the keeper of the pond."

It was not an official post.

He had neither an appointment letter nor a monthly wage.

Long ago, on the communal fishing day, he would be given five seers of fish.

Sometimes, after the paddy harvest, two paseris of grain.

Later, even that stopped.

But the name remained—the keeper.

That evening Vanshi was pulling the rod out when dust rose from the direction of the road.

First came a small truck.

Behind it came an excavator.

Last came Arun Thakur on a motorcycle.

Arun was not from this village.

He lived at the other end of the district and was the new contractor.

The panchayat had awarded the contract for the "restoration" of Kajraha pond.

On paper, the work was clear: remove silt, strengthen the banks, repair the paved ghat on the southern side, put up safety fencing all around, and clear the drainage before the rains.

The contract period was eighteen days.

On the first day, Arun walked all around the pond and inspected it.

With him were two labourers, the excavator driver, and Rajiv, the panchayat assistant.

Rajiv carried the measurement ledger.

Vanshi Mahato stood there with his bamboo rod.

Looking towards the northern bank, Arun said,

"If we dig from here, we'll get good silt."

The driver nodded.

Vanshi Mahato said,

"Don't remove silt from here."

For the first time, Arun looked at him properly.

"Why?"

"This is the silt basin."

Arun did not understand.

Vanshi pointed to the narrow drain on the northern side.

"In the rains, runoff from the fields comes here first. The soil settles here. The middle of the pond stays clear."

Arun did not laugh, but impatience was plain on his face.

"Uncle, on the plan this is part of the pond too."

"It is part of the pond. That is why it must be left."

Rajiv looked up from the ledger.

Arun said again,

"We'll deepen it. It will hold more water."

Vanshi rested the rod on the ground.

"The deep part is in the middle. The shallow edge has a different job."

"The work will be done according to the plan."

"Water doesn't read plans."

Rajiv gave a faint smile.

Arun did not.

He did not prolong the argument on the first day.

The labourers began cutting away the brush gathered near the southern ghat.

The excavator moved down to the western side.

Vanshi Mahato planted his bamboo rod in the northern corner and went home.

At dawn on the second day, the sound of the machine reached the village.

Earth rose in scoop after scoop and piled up on the bank.

Children stood at a distance and watched.

Vanshi Mahato arrived at around nine.

He had an old spade in his hand.

He went towards the eastern outlet.

Roots of kans grass and dry leaves were clogged there.

He began clearing them slowly.

Arun saw him from a distance.

“Uncle, the labourers will do that.”

Vanshi did not answer.

After a while Arun came over.

“The labourers are working on the western side right now.”

Vanshi said,

“Then who will open the eastern mouth?”

“We'll clear it tomorrow.”

“And if it rains tomorrow?”

The sky was completely clear.

Arun looked up.

“Rain today?”

“I'm not talking about rain. I'm talking about the mouth doing its job.”

This time Arun laughed.

“All right. Clear it.”

Vanshi Mahato kept working the spade.

By noon, the narrow eastern channel was clear.

Tiny snail shells gleamed along its edge.

Without picking up a single shell, Vanshi scraped the earth away from beside it.

On the third day, it was the turn of the shallow northern section.

The excavator reached it.

Vanshi Mahato was already standing there.

Arun stopped the vehicle.

“Uncle, move aside.”

Vanshi did not move.

“Leave this section.”

“If we leave it, the measurement will fall short.”

“You'll damage the pond just to make up the measurement?”

Arun's voice hardened.

“I haven't come here to damage the pond. I have a responsibility.”

Vanshi said,

“So do I.”

“Whose responsibility is on paper?”

The question hung in the air for a moment.

Vanshi Mahato looked at Arun's face.

Then at his own bamboo rod.

“On paper, yours.”

He said softly,

“In the water, mine.”

Arun signalled to the driver to switch off the machine.

“Rajiv!”

Rajiv came running.

Arun said,

“Call the panchayat head. Let this be decided today.”

By afternoon, the pond bank had turned into a small gathering.

The village head, Usha Devi, arrived.

With her came the ward member, two farmers, Ramdin the fisherman, and a few curious villagers.

Usha Devi first listened to Arun.

Opening a page of the measurement ledger, Arun said,

“The contract requires this much cubic earth to be removed. If we leave the northern section, the quantity will fall short. Then the accounts will get held up.”

Usha Devi looked at Vanshi.

“What do you say?”

With the edge of his spade, Vanshi Mahato drew a crescent in the soil.

“The drain releases water here.”

He drew a small line through the middle of the crescent.

“In the first hard rain, the silt spreads here.”

Then he pointed towards the middle of the pond.

"This bank catches the silt. If you dig it out, the soil from the first rains will go straight into the deep part."

Ramdin said,

"Fish fry live here too."

Arun immediately asked,

"What kind of fish?"

Ramdin fell silent.

He did not have a definite answer.

Vanshi Mahato did not come to Ramdin's rescue.

He said,

"Leave the fish aside. Talk about the silt."

Arun looked at the lines drawn in the earth.

"All this is guesswork."

"Yes."

Vanshi said it calmly.

"And some of it is what I have seen."

"Where is it written down?"

Vanshi lifted his bamboo rod.

"Here."

A few people laughed.

Usha Devi did not.

She took the bamboo rod in her hand.

"What are these marks?"

Touching each mark in turn, Vanshi said,

"This is Jeth from three years ago. This is Ashadh that year, when the pond filled in two nights. This is Bhadon last year. This is Kartik the year the water fell before its time."

"Dates?"

"There are no dates."

Arun said,

"That is exactly the problem."

Vanshi Mahato accepted it.

"Yes, that is the problem."

His agreement surprised Arun a little.

Vanshi continued,

"I could not write it down. But you can."

The gathering did not reach an immediate solution.

Usha Devi said work on the northern section should be stopped for two days.
Excavation could continue elsewhere.
Arun's face fell.
“I'll lose two days.”
“Work elsewhere.”
“And the measurement?”
“We'll look at the measurement again.”
The gathering dispersed.
Arun remained silent until evening.
Vanshi Mahato sat beside the eastern channel.
As the sun went down, the water turned yellow.
An egret landed in the shallow margin and took two steps.
Arun came over while gathering his papers.
“Uncle.”
Vanshi looked up.
“Do you think I'm your opponent?”
Vanshi thought for a moment.
“No.”
“Then why did you stand in front of the machine?”
“Because the machine did not know me.”
At first Arun did not understand.
Vanshi rested his hand on the handle of the spade.
“You know me. The machine doesn't.”
Arun said nothing.
He kept looking towards the middle of the pond.
After a while he asked,
“Do you object to the fence too?”
Vanshi said,
“To a complete fence.”
“Children can fall in.”
“Yes.”
“Then?”
“Leave two slopes for livestock. Leave one ghat. Put fencing around the rest.”
Arun looked at him in surprise.
“So you aren't against the fence?”
“I'm against closing off the pond.”

This time Arun smiled.

"There's a difference?"

"A great deal."

The wind changed during the night.

Lightning flashed far to the north.

It did not rain, but the smell of earth rose in the air.

The next morning Arun took Rajiv with him to inspect the northern drain.

Vanshi Mahato was already there.

This time Arun had brought a measuring tape.

He measured the width of the drain.

Then the shallow crescent-shaped section.

Then the depth in the middle of the pond.

Rajiv kept writing the figures in the measurement ledger.

Vanshi watched in silence.

Arun asked,

"How much of the silt basin should be left?"

Vanshi marked the boundary with his spade.

"From here to here."

"That much?"

"You can make it smaller."

Arun replied at once,

"Yesterday you were saying leave it."

"I said leave it. How much to leave can be measured."

Arun stretched the measuring tape across the ground.

He measured twice.

Then he said,

"If we leave this much, we'll have to remove a little more earth from the deep western section."

Vanshi asked,

"How far down is the old bed there?"

Instead of answering, Arun looked at Rajiv.

Rajiv turned the pages of the ledger.

"It hasn't been fully checked."

Vanshi said,

"Check that first."

This time Arun did not get irritated.

By noon, bamboo poles had been lowered at three places in the western section to test it.

There really was more silt there than in the middle.

The measurements were redrawn.

The required quantity could almost be met.

More than half of the northern silt basin could be saved.

Arun said,

"All right. The machine won't enter here."

Vanshi Mahato did not immediately thank him.

He asked,

"And the eastern outlet?"

Arun burst out laughing.

"Will you settle every account at once?"

"Rain falls everywhere at once."

Arun nodded.

"We'll look at that too."

The contract work picked up speed again.

Silt was removed from the western side.

Two broken steps at the southern ghat were rebuilt.

Posts were planted for the fence.

Vanshi Mahato came every day, but he no longer stood in front of the machine.

Sometimes he checked the distance of the fencing; sometimes he pulled out grass caught in the outlet.

Whenever Arun saw him, he would ask, "Uncle, what's left now?"

Most days Vanshi said nothing.

One day he said,

"Move this post two cubits back."

Arun put a hand to his head.

"Again?"

Vanshi pointed to old hoof marks in the earth along the bank.

"Cattle come down here."

Arun said,

"I'm already leaving two slopes."

"This is the third."

"I can't leave three."

Vanshi remained silent for a while.

Then he said,

"All right. Close this one. But make the eastern slope wider."

Arun looked at him.

"Don't you want to win every point?"

Vanshi Mahato laughed.

"Is the pond a wrestling match?"

The question stayed with Arun.

On the evening of the twelfth day, the first heavy rain fell.

The sky suddenly turned black.

The dust settled.

The unpaved paths began to shine.

Arun had gone out of the village that day.

Vanshi Mahato sat on his veranda and watched the rain.

When it grew heavier, he rose with his walking stick.

His daughter-in-law stopped him.

"Where are you going in this rain?"

"To the pond."

"Now?"

"Now is when it has to be seen."

He went out without taking an umbrella.

When he reached the pond, the eastern drain was not roaring, but it was running fast.

Muddy water from the northern fields was spreading across the shallow crescent-shaped section.

There, the current slowed.

The first thin layer of silt settled along the margin.

The water in the middle was still a little clearer than that.

Vanshi Mahato went to his bamboo rod.

The water had risen by two marks.

He did nothing.

He only watched.

That night it rained for three hours.

At dawn Arun came straight to the pond.

His clothes were smeared with mud up to the knees.

Vanshi was already there.

Arun looked at the northern section.

The new silt was plainly visible.

With the edge of the spade he checked its thickness.

“This much from one rain?”

Vanshi said,

“This was a small rain.”

Arun looked towards the middle of the pond.

“If we had dug this section out…”

Vanshi did not finish the sentence for him.

He only said,

“Then next monsoon you would have seen where the silt settled.”

Arun was silent for a while.

Then he called Rajiv.

“Bring the measurement ledger.”

Rajiv brought it.

Arun said,

“Write a note.”

“What?”

Arun looked towards the northern section.

“The shallow northern strip has been retained to trap silt entering with runoff.”

Rajiv wrote it down.

Arun continued,

“The eastern outlet is to be kept open.”

Rajiv wrote that too.

Vanshi Mahato kept looking at the page in the ledger.

There was no triumph on his face.

Suddenly he said,

“One thing is wrong.”

Arun looked startled.

“What?”

“Don't write that it was left because I said so.”

Arun looked at the ledger.

“I haven't written that.”

“Good.”

“Why?”

Vanshi planted the bamboo rod in the water.

“Tomorrow I may not be here. The ledger should contain the reason, not the name.”

Rajiv stopped in the middle of writing.

Arun said quietly,

“All right.”

The work was completed on the seventeenth day.

The fencing was installed, but the southern ghat and the wide livestock slope on the eastern side were left open.

The northern silt basin remained intact.

The western section was deepened.

At the mouth of the outlet, instead of an iron grille, a thick bamboo barrier like a removable lattice was fitted, so that leaves caught there could be cleared away.

At first Vanshi Mahato was doubtful about this.

Arun said,

“A fine iron grille would trap the leaves. You were right about that.”

Vanshi said,

“I wasn't against iron.”

“I know.”

“I was against a fine mouth.”

“I know that too.”

On the eighteenth day, the panchayat came for inspection.

Usha Devi walked all around.

She checked the accounts.

The measurements matched.

The work was declared complete.

People looked at the new ghat, the fencing, and the deep water.

No one paid special attention to the shallow northern section.

There, two small birds were pecking at the thin layer of muddy silt.

Vanshi Mahato sat at a distance in the shade of a peepal tree.

When the inspection was over, Arun came to him.

“Uncle, the contract is finished now.”

“Yes.”

“And your work?”

Vanshi looked at the pond.

“The contract is finished. The pond isn't.”

Arun laughed.

"You've started again."

Vanshi smiled too.

Arun took a new measuring rod out of his bag.

It was not an ordinary bamboo pole.

It was a slender iron rod, marked and numbered at every inch.

"This is for you."

Vanshi did not reach for it.

"Is there something wrong with my bamboo?"

"No."

"Then?"

"Keep both."

Vanshi took the new rod.

He planted it beside the old bamboo one.

The two rods stood side by side in the water.

The old bamboo carried no dates.

The new rod carried numbers.

Vanshi looked at both.

Then he said to Arun,

"When the next rain comes, you will write down the first mark."

Arun asked,

"Me?"

"In your ledger."

Arun was silent for a moment.

"I won't be here."

"Then Rajiv will write it."

"And if Rajiv isn't here either?"

Vanshi looked at the pond water.

"Then whoever is here will write it."

Evening was descending.

Sunlight broke through a gap in the clouds in the western sky.

The shadows of the new fence posts fell across the water.

Between those shadows, the old bamboo rod and the new measuring rod were both visible.

The rain-deposited silt along the edge was still soft.

Three slender egret footprints marked that soft silt.

Vanshi Mahato looked at the prints.

He did not measure them.
He simply kept them in his memory.

STORY 44

The Dom's Flute

On the last Wednesday of Kartik, a village festival was to be held in the grounds of the Belsandi Middle School.

For three days already, a bamboo gateway, cloth pennants, and rows of earthen lamps had been taking shape.

A long sheet of paper had been hung on the school veranda.

The programme schedule was written on it.

Welcome song at five in the evening.

Girls' dance at five twenty.

Panchayat address at six.

Performance by the visiting singers' troupe at six thirty.

Prizes at seven thirty.

Group song at eight.

At the bottom, in red ink, it said—Times may change according to circumstances.

Chandeshwar Dom stood beside that sheet twice.

The first time, he searched for his name.

The second time, he made sure that it truly was not there.

An old cotton bag was tucked under his arm.

There were three flutes in the bag.

One long.

One medium-sized.

One small.

The mouth of each was covered with a strip of cloth.

After reading the list, Chandeshwar went toward Pramod Jha's office.

Pramod Jha was secretary of the festival committee.

He sat amid papers, receipts, and the ledger of payments due.

Standing at the door, Chandeshwar asked, "Where have you put my time?"

Pramod Jha looked up.

"Whose?"

"The flute's."

Pramod Jha thought for a moment.

Then he said, "Was your name written down?"

Chandeshwar did not smile.

"The day before yesterday you yourself said you would keep ten minutes in between."

Pramod Jha turned the pages of the ledger.

"I said I would keep ten minutes. Nothing was said about printing your name."

"Where is anything printed? This is a sheet written by hand."

Pramod Jha did not look toward the sheet.

He said, "The schedule is very tight. The outside troupe should arrive by seven. If there is a gap in between, we will have you play."

Chandeshwar asked, "And if there is no gap?"

"Next time."

Chandeshwar adjusted the bag under his arm.

He went outside.

On the veranda, Rekha Teacher was writing down the children's names.

Seeing Chandeshwar, she asked, "Uncle, where is your performance?"

"Wherever an empty place turns up."

Rekha looked at the list.

She wanted to say something, but Chandeshwar had already gone down the steps.

A bamboo decoration was being built in the northern corner of the field.

Chandeshwar himself had supplied the twelve poles used in it.

The committee had already fixed the price of all twelve poles.

The poles had been counted.

A receipt had been written.

Payment would be made after the festival.

There was no receipt for the flute.

Chandeshwar's house stood half a kos west of the school.

A bamboo screen stood in front of the house.

Baskets and winnowing trays were kept on one side of the doorway.

On the other lay trimmed bamboo strips and hollow offcuts.

Between them, five half-made flutes rested on a narrow bench.

Chandeshwar's father too had made flutes.

He had also played them at fairs and village gatherings.

As a child, Chandeshwar had learned to recognise the smell of bamboo before he learned the names of notes.

Which bamboo was dry inside.

Which bamboo had a hairline crack in its body.

Which bamboo had to hang for six months after cutting.

All this he had learned through his hands.

But at festivals he was not invited to play for this knowledge.

He was asked to play when there was an empty stretch in the programme.

When the outside artists were late.

When the children's dance costumes were not ready.

When a speaker had not yet arrived.

He did not call his flute "time in between."

For him, it was complete time.

On the day of the festival, the field began filling from the afternoon onward.

Chandeshwar arrived at four.

He was given no identification badge.

The volunteer at the entrance said, "Uncle, you are one of us. Just go in."

Chandeshwar went inside.

He sat near the roots of the peepal tree behind the stage.

He placed the bag by his feet.

The sound-system men were joining wires.

Two large loudspeakers stood at the two corners of the stage.

A word spoken onstage carried all the way to the far end of the field.

Sometimes its echo came back.

Ramavatar was looking after the sound system.

Glancing at Chandeshwar's bag, he laughed and said, "Uncle, will your voice fight with my speakers today?"

Chandeshwar said, "My voice does not fight."

Pulling a wire, Ramavatar said, "Without all this, the back rows will not hear a thing."

Chandeshwar replied, "Then if the back rows want to hear, they can come forward."

Ramavatar burst out laughing.

"Where will so many people fit in front?"

Chandeshwar rested a hand on his bag.

"Then as many as hear, will hear."

At five, the welcome song began.

The amplified voice struck the school's tin roof and came back.

The girls' dance followed.

There was applause.

The panchayat speeches began.

The first speaker rose for ten minutes and spoke for twenty-five.

Instead of shortening his own turn, the second speaker began answering the first speaker's points.

Pramod Jha kept looking at his watch.

Chandeshwar remained seated by the peepal tree.

At six forty-five, the visiting singers' troupe had still not arrived.

Pramod Jha came over to him.

"Uncle, play for five minutes."

Chandeshwar asked, "Five?"

"Only until the troupe arrives."

Chandeshwar opened his bag.

Just then came the rumble of a vehicle from the south side of the school.

Pramod Jha turned to look.

It was the singers' troupe's vehicle.

He immediately said, "Leave it. They have arrived."

Chandeshwar put the flute back into the bag.

He said nothing.

The singers' troupe climbed onto the stage.

A loud beat burst from the speakers.

Young men in the front of the field began to dance.

Chandeshwar stayed seated at the roots of the peepal tree.

Rekha Teacher came to him.

"Uncle, aren't you going home?"

"The payment for the twelve bamboo poles is still due."

Rekha understood that this was not the whole answer.

She asked nothing more.

At seven thirty-five, the prize distribution began.

During the prizes, the electric lights flickered twice.

Ramavatar ran to the rear.

He checked the wires.

The lights steadied again.

The group song was to begin at eight five.

The children stood in a line behind the stage.

At that very moment, the entire field went dark.

The speakers fell silent.

The stage lights went silent.

The school veranda went silent.

For the first two moments, people simply stared into the darkness.

Then many voices rose at once.

"The power is gone!"

"Where are the children?"

"Move back!"

"Don't step on the wires!"

Ramavatar ran again.

In the light of his phone, Pramod Jha began looking at the programme sheet.

Someone said the joint in the main wire had come loose.

Someone said it might take half an hour.

Someone said it would be fixed in five minutes.

Between those five minutes and that half hour, the festival was stranded without a voice.

People began talking among themselves.

Some got up and started toward home.

Some children began laughing in the dark.

The chairs in front of the stage began scraping and shifting.

Pramod Jha came to Chandeshwar.

"Uncle."

Chandeshwar looked up.

"Play something until the power comes back."

Chandeshwar asked, "In this noise?"

Pramod Jha looked around.

"We'll quieten the people."

Chandeshwar said softly, "Will you quieten them first and then have me play, or have me play and then quieten them?"

Pramod Jha did not answer.

Rekha Teacher was listening.

She said, "First seat him on the stage."

There was no electric light.

A small oil lamp was placed on the stage.

In its glow, only half the chair could be seen.

Chandeshwar sat not at the centre of the stage, but at the right-hand corner.

From his bag he took out the medium flute.

He removed the strip of cloth.

He wiped the mouth of the flute with a finger.

Without a microphone, Pramod Jha shouted, "Please be quiet! Local artist Chandeshwar—"

He paused for a moment.

Then he said, "Chandeshwar Dom will play the flute."

Many people in the back rows did not hear.

Conversation continued.

Chandeshwar put the flute to his lips.

The first note was very soft.

So soft that even people in the front row could lose it in one another's talk.

The second note was a little longer than the first.

At the end of the third, the air left a faint rasp inside the bamboo body.

A child in the front row said to his mother, "Quiet."

The mother looked at him.

The child turned an ear toward the stage.

Two chairs behind him, someone stopped talking.

The person beside him stopped too.

The flute still had not grown louder.

To hear it, people had to lower their own voices.

That change travelled slowly from the front row toward the back.

Someone signalled with a hand.

Someone touched the person beside him with a knee.

Someone said no "hush," but simply turned an ear toward the stage.

The noise in the field began to fall, layer by layer.

First the scraping of chairs became audible.

Then that too diminished.

After that came the faint tinkling of a bell from a distant cattle shed.

The rustling of peepal leaves could be heard.

So could the sound of someone's foot brushing the dry Kartik grass.

Through all of it, the notes of the flute went on.

Chandeshwar was not playing any famous tune.

It was a walking tune his father used to blow in the evenings while shaving bamboo.

Four short notes.

A long pause.

Then two low notes.

The pause too was part of the melody.

For the first time, the people were listening to the pause.

The field grew so quiet that the sound of water being poured from an earthen pitcher behind the stage could be heard clearly.

Ramavatar was bent over the wires.

He raised his head and looked toward the stage.

A wire was in his hand, but he did not connect it.

Chandeshwar changed the tune.

This time he lifted the small flute.

Its voice was thin and clear.

Old Sudama Devi, seated near the front, suddenly took her granddaughter's hand.

The granddaughter asked, "What happened?"

Sudama Devi merely shook her head.

She did not want to say anything.

Two young men standing in the back row slowly moved forward.

They did not begin to dance.

They only shortened the distance from which they were listening.

Meanwhile, the electricity flickered back on in the school veranda.

One light came on.

Then another.

A faint hum rose inside the loudspeakers.

Ramavatar reached toward the switch.

Pramod Jha saw him.

He signalled with his hand for him to stop.

Ramavatar's hand halted where it was.

The lights had returned.

The sound system remained off.

Chandeshwar's flute continued.

Now the whole field could hear him, because the whole field was quiet.

Rekha Teacher stood by the stage steps, holding the programme sheet.

She looked at the blank space beneath the red writing.

In that space she wrote in pencil—Chandeshwar Dom—Flute.

She looked at her watch to write the time.

Eight eighteen.

She wrote 8:18.

She left the finishing time blank.

Chandeshwar lifted the long flute.

This flute had a deeper tone.

He played a short melody he had made while drying cut bamboo after the rains.

There was no festival cheer in the tune.

No name of any deity.

No fragment of any famous song.

There were only breath, bamboo, and pauses.

The final note was not long.

It slowly grew smaller.

Then it ended.

Chandeshwar lowered the flute from his lips.

For a few moments afterward, the field remained silent.

No one applauded at once.

For those two or three moments, Chandeshwar did not look ahead.

He ran a finger over the holes of the flute.

Then a clap rose from the front row.

Then another.

After that, the whole field filled with applause.

The loudspeakers were still off.

The sound of the clapping travelled far without amplification.

Chandeshwar did not stand and bow.

He simply wrapped the flute in cloth and put it into his bag.

Pramod Jha climbed onto the stage.

He said, “Very beautiful. Now the group song—”

Rekha Teacher said softly, “First write down the time.”

Pramod Jha looked at the list.

“How long was it?”

“From eight eighteen to eight thirty-eight.”

“Twenty minutes?”

Rekha said, “Yes.”

Pramod Jha looked at Chandeshwar for a moment.

An artist called for five minutes had played for twenty.

No one had been watching the clock.

The group song followed.

The festival ended at ten that night.

People began to go home.

Half the lamps by the bamboo gateway had already gone out.

Chandeshwar was picking up his bag near the peepal tree.

Pramod Jha called to him.

"Uncle, take the payment for the twelve bamboo poles."

He counted the amount from the ledger.

Chandeshwar counted it and put it inside his bag.

Pramod Jha said, "And thank you for the flute."

Chandeshwar remained standing.

He did not start to leave.

Pramod Jha asked, "Anything else?"

Chandeshwar said, "There were twelve bamboo poles."

"Yes."

"They were counted."

"Yes."

"Their price was written down."

"Yes."

Tying the mouth of his bag, Chandeshwar said, "The flute was twenty minutes."

Pramod Jha was silent.

He understood the point.

"Are you asking for a fee?"

Chandeshwar said, "If you called me an artist and had me play on the stage, will there be some entry for that in the ledger, or only a thank-you?"

Pramod Jha sat down on the chair again.

He opened the expenditure page of the ledger.

That page listed—Sound system.

Cloth decorations.

Visiting singers' troupe.

Oil for the lamps.

Prizes.

Bamboo decoration—Chandeshwar.

Pramod Jha looked at the next blank line.

"The committee had not fixed any payment for you."

Chandeshwar said, "It had not fixed one. That is true."

"Then how much should I write now?"

Chandeshwar did not immediately name a figure.

He looked out toward the field.

In front of the stage, Ramavatar was gathering the wires.

Rekha Teacher was collecting the things the children had left behind.

Chandeshwar said, "Write what you pay a local singing group for one performance."

Pramod Jha said, "There are four people in that group."

"I am one."

"Then one-fourth?"

Chandeshwar smiled.

"Was the song heard in four separate parts?"

Pramod Jha too smiled faintly.

"No."

He looked at the ledger again.

Rekha Teacher came inside.

She said, "Five hundred can be entered for a local solo performance. Two prize items are left over; there is money remaining under that head."

Pramod Jha said, "If we shift the budget head, it will have to be explained in the accounts."

Rekha said, "Write the explanation."

A few moments later, a new line was added to the ledger.

Local solo artist—Chandeshwar Dom—Flute—five hundred rupees.

Pramod Jha signed it.

Chandeshwar did not put a thumbprint; he wrote his name.

Slowly.

Chandeshwar Dom.

He counted the five hundred rupees.

Then he asked, "Who will make next year's list?"

Rekha said, "We will."

"In an empty slot?"

Rekha replied, "No. We will give you a time."

Chandeshwar made no promise in response.

He simply slung the bag under his arm.

Then he walked home.

The next morning, the festival field was half empty.

The bamboo pennants were being taken down.

Ramavatar was loading the loudspeakers onto a vehicle.
Yesterday's programme sheet still hung on the school veranda.
The wind fluttered one corner of it.
The pencilled name beside 8:18 was still clear.
Chandeshwar Dom—Flute.
A thin line had been drawn through to 8:38.
Rekha Teacher came to take down the sheet.
For a moment she looked at the name.
Then she did not fold the paper.
She placed it straight inside the ledger.
The wind moved through the peepal leaves in the field.
Their sound was very soft.
No one had to order anyone to be quiet in order to hear it.

STORY 45

The Register Beneath the Banyan

It was a Jeth afternoon. The banyan's shade was not round; it had stretched eastward. Dry leaves had gathered among the roots, and an old wooden bench stood over them.

Munilal sat on the bench. Before him lay open a thick register bound in cloth. The corners of the cover had worn white.

Everyone in the village called it 'the Banyan Register.'

It was called a register, but it was not an official one.

No one entered wedding dates in it, nor land holdings. What it recorded was when canal water arrived, how far it reached, whose field received its turn, whose turn was missed, and who exchanged a turn with someone else.

Munilal had once been a farmer. As he grew older, his son took over the fields. Twenty-five years earlier, two families had fought over canal water. After that, the practice began of sitting beneath the banyan and writing down the turns.

The first page had held only seven names.

Now it held the names of twenty-seven households.

That day Munilal was turning the pages when Sudha, a teacher at the school, came hurrying up.

'Uncle, people have come from the block office.'

Munilal pushed his spectacles up. 'What for?'

'To inspect the drought-relief claims.'

'There was no rain, and that needs inspection?'

Sudha could not smile. 'The papers say our village is irrigated.'

Munilal's hand stopped on the page.

'Irrigated?'

'The government canal register says water was released into this branch on eleven days between Jeth and Bhadav.'

Munilal said quietly, 'It may well have been released.'

'As far as the village?' Sudha asked.

Munilal turned the register toward her. 'Look at this.'

Sudha bent over it.

Jeth 12 - second watch of the night. Water as far as the first eastern bend.

Jeth 13 - dawn. Water stopped at Harigovind's field.

Ashadh 4 - midnight. Two hours.

Ashadh 19 - water entered the branch, did not reach the mouth of the village channel.

Sawan 7 - silt at the gate. No water.

Sawan 21 - held back in the upstream village.

Bhadav 3 - one hour at night, only five fields.

Bhadav 14 - branch dry.

Sudha kept turning the pages.

'Where are the eleven days?'

Munilal said, 'On paper.'

From beyond the banyan, Mahendra, who sold tea, called out, 'The government people are sitting in the panchayat house. They're asking all the farmers for their papers.'

Sudha lifted the register.

Munilal immediately put a hand on it. 'Where are you taking this?'

'To show them.'

'This is not a government document.'

'So?'

'So they will say: you people wrote this yourselves.'

Sudha did not close the register. 'We wrote it ourselves, yes. But the dates are not lies.'

Munilal remained silent.

Near the banyan roots, a tethered goat stretched its rope and sniffed at the dry leaves. Far away the canal embankment lay pale under the sun. There was no water there, only fine dust.

Two officials and a junior engineer were seated in the panchayat house. On the table lay government registers, measurement sheets, and a stack of applications.

The farmers went in one by one.

Ramvilas came out with his face drawn.

'What happened?' Sudha asked.

'They say my field falls in the irrigated category. Relief is only for unirrigated fields.'

'Did you get water?'

Ramvilas laughed. 'Water? I hired a private pump twice.'

Munilal came slowly, the register tucked under his arm.

The moment he saw him, Ramvilas said, 'Uncle, show them your register.'

The official inside heard the voice from outside. 'What register?'

Sudha said, 'The village canal-water register.'

The official held out his hand. 'Bring it.'

Before handing it over, Munilal asked, 'Will this document be accepted?'

The official looked at the page. 'It does not belong to the department.'

'Then?'

'We can look at it. Whether it counts as evidence is another matter.'

Munilal placed the register on the table.

The junior engineer turned the pages. 'Who writes this?'

'On a day when someone exchanges a turn, there is also a thumbprint or signature beside the name,' Munilal said. 'I write the rest.'

The engineer stopped at one page. 'It says here: Ashadh 4, midnight, two hours. How can the time be so exact?'

Munilal replied, 'That night Phulkumari's daughter-in-law was in labour. Someone had gone to bring a vehicle. We looked at the clock when the water was released because it was her field's turn. The vehicle arrived two hours later. The water was cut off then.'

From outside Phulkumari called, 'It is true.'

The official looked toward the door. 'Don't all speak at once.'

The engineer looked at another page. 'Bhadav 3 – one hour, five fields. Names?'

Munilal read out the five names.

Two of those five people were present in the panchayat house. Both raised their hands.

The official leaned back in his chair. 'Look, the departmental register records the days on which water was released from the main canal into the branch. Your register records whether it reached the village. Those are not the same thing.'

Sudha said at once, 'Then which one was used when the area was classified as irrigated?'

Before the official could answer, the engineer said, 'Water was released into the branch, so the area must have been treated as irrigated.'

'And if the water never reached the fields?' Ramvilas asked from outside.

The official said again, 'That is why an inspection is being conducted.'

Munilal ran a hand over the register. 'If the inspection happens at noon, the canal will look dry. How will you see the one hour of water that came at night?'

For a few moments the room was silent.

The engineer asked, 'Where is the gate?'

'A mile and a half upstream from here.'

'Where does the silt collect?'

'At the third bend.'

'Will you show me?'

Munilal closed the register. 'Now?'

'Now.'

The afternoon was beginning to decline when five people set out along the canal embankment: the engineer, the official, Sudha, Munilal and Ramvilas.

The mouth of the canal was wide. In two places upstream the grass was green, but toward the village the ground was cracked.

At the third bend there really was a high mound of silt.

The engineer pushed a bamboo measuring rod into it.

'How long has this been here?'

Ramvilas said, 'At least two years.'

Munilal corrected him. 'It has been this high since Bhadav last year. Before that it was half as high.'

'Is there a record?' the official asked.

Munilal opened the register.

Bhadav 27 – silt at the third bend after the water fell. Next turn blocked.

On the next page: Kartik 8 – five households cut away the silt together; half the passage opened.

Phagun 3 – filled again.

The engineer kept looking at the page.

'How did you remember all these dates?'

Munilal said, 'I did not remember them. That is why I wrote them down.'

At that sentence Sudha looked at Munilal.

People called the register beneath the banyan a memory, but Munilal regarded it as a way of escaping the unreliability of memory.

When they reached the last field in the village, Ramvilas pointed out the dry stubble of his paddy.

'Water came here on Bhadav 3,' Munilal said.

Ramvilas looked startled. 'Not as far as my field.'

'Your name is not among those five.'

Ramvilas quickly checked the register. It was true. The five names belonged to other fields.

He was silent for a few moments.

Sudha asked, 'Then why did you write in your application that you received canal water once?'

Ramvilas said awkwardly, 'It came into the village, so I wrote that I had received it too.'

The official smiled for the first time. 'See? The village register does not take everyone's side either.'

Munilal said, 'If a register takes sides, what kind of register is it?'

The inspection continued until evening.

The engineer wrote three things on his measurement sheet: water was released into the main branch; there is a silt obstruction at the third bend; regular delivery to the lower seventeen fields could not be verified.

The official said, 'This is today's inspection. I cannot say yet whether the relief will be approved.'

Ramvilas's face fell again.

Munilal remained calm. 'At least this much has now been written down. It was not there before.'

Back at the panchayat house, the official placed the Banyan Register on the table again.

'Uncle, we need a copy of this.'

Munilal said at once, 'Not the whole thing.'

'Why?'

'It does not contain only irrigation turns. People exchange seed, bamboo, bullocks and pumps with one another too. Not everything in it is a matter for a government file.'

The official thought for a moment. 'Then only the canal pages.'

Sudha said, 'I'll make photocopies.'

Munilal agreed.

The next day the bench was set beneath the banyan again. The register lay open. Sudha had photocopied the canal pages and tied them together with red string.

As Mahendra set down the tea, he asked, 'Uncle, will the government register accept what your register says now?' Munilal said, 'Whether it accepts it or not is its affair.' 'Then what was the use?'

Munilal opened a fresh page and wrote the date. 'The use is that today, for the first time, an official paper recorded that releasing water and water reaching the fields are two different things.' Sudha sat at the other end of the bench. 'And in your register?'

Munilal wrote: Today the third bend was measured again. Delivery to the lower seventeen fields was checked. Decision pending. He stopped his pen. 'My register will record that the decision is still pending.'

A dry leaf fell from the banyan onto the open page. Munilal did not remove it. When the breeze rose, the leaf slid on its own toward the edge of the register.

The canal was still dry. In the government register, water would remain recorded as having been released on eleven days. In the Banyan Register, it would remain recorded how many nights, how many bends and how many fields the water reached within those eleven days.

The two registers were not substitutes for one another. But now one had been placed before the other.

STORY 46

The Caste Chair

After the rains, the roof of the village community hall had been repaired once again.

Along with the new roof came twenty-eight blue chairs, all the same colour.

The chairs looked so alike that from a distance it was hard to tell which was old and which was new.

But all the chairs were new.

What was old was the way they were arranged.

On the day of the first meeting, Bhola Kaka opened the community hall early in the morning.

He was seventy-eight, but the key still hung from the old cord tied around his waist.

As soon as he opened the door, he swept the floor first, then carried the chairs outside and set them in the sun.

At half past eight, Nilu arrived.

Nilu was in Class Nine at the high school.

Her mathematics teacher had asked her to prepare a small register of the number, condition, and placement of the chairs that had come to the panchayat community hall.

The reason was that the school students were going to use the same hall for a science exhibition the following month.

Nilu opened her notebook.

"Kaka, shall I write numbers on the chairs?"

Bhola Kaka said, "Write them underneath. If you write them on top, people will ask why the number of their chair has changed."

Nilu burst out laughing.

"Whose chair? They all belong to the village."

Bhola Kaka looked at her, then gave a small smile.

"Yes, they belong to the village."

Turning the chairs over one by one, Nilu began painting plain numbers underneath them—1, 2, 3…28.

She was enjoying herself.

When she had finished numbering them, Bhola Kaka began arranging the chairs inside.

Nilu saw that he placed six chairs in the first row, eight in the second, eight in the third, and six against the back wall.

"If we put seven in each row, it will look more even," Nilu said.

Bhola Kaka shook his head.

"This is fine."

"Why?"

"People have always sat like this."

Nilu drew a small map of the chairs' positions in her notebook.

First row: 1–6.

Second: 7–14.

Third: 15–22.

Back: 23–28.

At half past nine, people began to arrive.

Mahendra Babu came first.

Bhola Kaka seated him on chair 2.

Then came Shivji, Amarnath, Sudama, Harilal, and Rameshwar.

No one looked at the numbers written beneath the chairs.

But Nilu kept watching.

Chairs 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, and 6 filled up.

The second row too filled gradually.

The six chairs at the back remained empty for a long time.

Then Mangal, Durga, Budhan, and Shambhu came from the southern hamlet.

At the doorway, all four first began taking off their sandals.

Bhola Kaka said, "There is no rule that sandals must be left outside."

Mangal said, "It is a habit."

All four came inside.

Two chairs in the second row were empty.

But they all went to the back.

Nilu wrote in her notebook—23, 24, 25, 26.

The meeting was about drain water and preventing soil erosion before the next monsoon.

On paper, the main issue was straightforward.

Where the drain needed deepening, where a small culvert was required, and near whose field the water should not be diverted.

But before the discussion could properly begin, the positions of people's bodies had already been settled.

Nilu noticed this for the first time.

Until then, she had thought only that whoever came early would sit in front and whoever came late would sit at the back.

Mangal had arrived late, so that made sense.

Durga too.

But Budhan had reached the doorway before Shivji.

He remained standing outside, talking to Bhola Kaka, until the chairs in the first row had filled.

Nilu drew a small question mark in her notebook.

In the middle of the meeting, the map of the drain was opened.

The village's three main roads, the pond, the school, the shrine, the southern hamlet, and the eastern fields were all marked on the paper.

Mangal stood and said, "If the water is diverted here, the courtyards of three houses near our hamlet will flood again."

Mahendra Babu could not see the map clearly.

He asked Mangal to come forward and show him.

Mangal came forward, but he did not sit on the empty chair 7.

He remained bent over the paper, pointing to it with his finger.

"Sit down," Nilu said without thinking.

Everyone's eyes turned towards her for a moment.

Nilu began looking at her notebook.

Mangal laughed and said, "I'm fine standing."

He remained standing for five minutes.

Then he returned to his chair at the back.

After the meeting ended, Nilu counted the chairs again.

Her mathematics assignment was complete.

But the question mark did not disappear.

The second meeting was two weeks later.

This time the subject was the repair of the community well and a new pulley for drawing water.

Nilu deliberately arranged the chairs in four rows of seven.

When Bhola Kaka arrived, he stopped short.

"What have you done?"

"It is easier to count."

"People will change them again."

"Then let them."

Bhola Kaka said nothing.

People arrived.

For the first five minutes, everything remained as it was.

Then Harilal dragged his chair two handspans forward.

Rameshwar turned the chair beside him.

No instruction was given.

No one told anyone where to sit.

But within ten minutes, the four even rows had taken the old form again—a short row in front, two wider rows in the middle, and six chairs clustered against the back wall.

Nilu looked at the numbers underneath.

This time chairs 1 through 6 were not in front.

The front row held 3, 8, 12, 16, 18, and 22.

The numbers had changed.

The pattern had not.

She drew a second map in her notebook.

After that, she wrote no names, only chair numbers.

After the meeting, she placed the two maps over each other and compared them.

The numbers were different, but the empty spaces, the distance between rows, and the direction people faced were almost the same.

At home, she copied the two maps onto paper in pencil.

Her mother asked, “What kind of lesson is this?”

Nilu said, “Mathematics too, perhaps history as well.”

Her mother looked at the maps.

After a while she said, “Do not write any names.”

“Why?”

“You are a child. People will draw their own conclusions.”

“I won’t write names. But even without names, the thing can still be seen.”

Her mother did not answer.

On the day of the third meeting, it rained heavily.

The community hall’s new roof was sound along the main side, but water began dripping through one joint in the back corner.

Exactly where the six chairs at the back usually stood.

Bhola Kaka placed a bucket there.

Chairs 23 through 28 had to be moved.

Nilu placed those six chairs in an empty space at the front left.

The meeting began.

Five people came from the southern hamlet.

They stopped near the doorway.

There was a bucket in their old place at the back.

There were six empty chairs in front.

Mangal moved towards one chair, then stopped.

Durga stood against the wall.

Bhola Kaka said, “Please sit down.”

Mangal said, “Here?”

“The chair is dry.”

“I’ll stand.”

This time Nilu said nothing.

The meeting went on.

After half an hour, Durga’s knee began to hurt.

He slowly leaned his weight against the wall.

Mahendra Babu noticed.

“There is an empty chair. Sit down.”

Durga said “no” again.

Mahendra Babu looked at Bhola Kaka with questioning eyes.

Bhola Kaka lowered his gaze.

The sound of the rain grew louder.

For a few moments, the discussion in the meeting stopped.

Nilu opened her notebook.

She had drawn the maps of all three meetings on a single page.

“May I show you something?”

Her voice was not very loud.

Mahendra Babu said, “Show us.”

Nilu placed the notebook in the middle.

“This is the first meeting. This is the second. This is today.”

No one immediately understood what it meant.

Mangal bent over to look.

“These are the chair numbers?”

“Yes.”

“Where are the names?”

“I have not written any names.”

Harilal said, “Then what does this show?”

Nilu turned the page.

On that page there were only square marks—six in front, rows in the middle, six at the back.

“The numbers kept changing, but this pattern did not.”

No one said anything.

Nilu continued, "Today water is falling at the back. Even so, these six chairs are empty and five people are standing."

Durga gave a faint laugh.

"Forget my knee. Look at your mathematics."

A few people laughed.

The laughter was brief, but the knot of tension in the room loosened a little.

Mahendra Babu looked at Durga.

"Truly, why did you not sit?"

Instead of answering directly, Durga said, "The place that feels like mine is where the water is falling."

"Who decided that place?"

"No one."

"Then?"

Durga looked at Bhola Kaka.

Bhola Kaka said, "Ever since I was given the key, this is how I have seen it."

Mangal said, "My father too used to sit like this."

Harilal said quietly, "My father too, in front."

After that short sentence, the sound of rain inside the hall suddenly seemed much clearer.

No one had made a rule.

Each had inherited a place from his father.

And that place was stronger than the number written beneath a chair.

The meeting was about the well, but the discussion came to a halt over the chairs.

Mahendra Babu said, "We will not abandon today's subject. A decision about the well is necessary."

Mangal said, "First those who are standing will sit. Then we will talk about the well."

Durga looked at him.

"You sit first."

Mangal sat down on the empty chair 24.

Today that chair stood at the front left.

When he sat, no one applauded.

No one made an announcement.

Only all four legs of the chair came to rest on the floor at once.

Durga sat on 25.

Shambhu on 27.

Budhan on 28.

The fifth man, Chhotelal, sat on the empty chair 26 and drew his feet in, as though his body were still asking where its old boundary lay.

The meeting began again.

There were two opinions about the well's pulley.

Those who were accustomed to speaking from the back now spoke from the front.

For those sitting in front, it was not as easy this time to cut them off mid-sentence.

Nilu did not write that in her notebook either.

She wrote only the decision—the old pulley would be removed, a new iron pulley installed, and the cost shared by all four hamlets.

When the meeting ended, people got up.

Durga began carrying his chair back to its old place at the rear.

Nilu said, "There is still water there."

Durga stopped.

Then he left the chair where he had been sitting.

The following week, the joint in the roof was repaired.

Bhola Kaka called Nilu.

"Finish the chair register. The school people will ask for it."

Beside each of the twenty-eight numbers, Nilu wrote—"Good."

She left the column for permanent location blank.

Bhola Kaka looked at it.

"You won't write the location?"

"The location will keep changing."

"Will it?"

Nilu said, "Let it."

The fourth meeting was held two months later.

This time Bhola Kaka did not arrange the chairs.

He unlocked the door and sat to one side.

As people arrived, each brought out a chair from the storeroom for himself.

For the first five minutes, the old pattern began forming again.

Then Mangal placed his chair beside Mahendra Babu's.

Because he had to show him the measurements for the new drain.

Durga sat near the doorway, because that was where the breeze was strongest.

Harilal went to the back, because he wanted to rest his back against the wall.

No new rule was made.

The old rule had never been written down, so no written order was issued to strike it out.

But for the first time, the chairs began to move according to the work at hand.

Nilu sat at the back and opened her notebook.

She could have drawn a new map.

But this time she did not.

At the top of a blank page she wrote—"Meeting 4."

Underneath she wrote one line—"Chairs: twenty-eight. Permanent location —none."

Then she closed the notebook.

There were twenty-eight blue chairs in the community hall.

All the same colour, the same height, the same price.

The only difference was that now, merely by looking at them, one could no longer tell whose place was whose.

STORY 47

The Tenant Girl

In that lane of Laheriasarai, the clink of the gate-chain at night could be heard more clearly than the daytime bell.

By day, rickshaws, vegetable sellers' calls, children's bicycles, and the whir of sewing machines blended all sound together. After ten at night, if the chain on the old blacksmith-made gate clinked even once, curtains stirred at the windows of three houses.

When Anamika Jha came to live as a tenant in that lane, Ram Pyari Devi showed her the gate on the very first day and said, "I fasten the chain at ten at night."

Anamika stood beneath the staircase with two trunks and a cloth bag beside her.

"I'm a nurse at the hospital," she said. "My shifts keep changing. Sometimes I'll return at midnight; sometimes I'll have to leave at five in the morning."

Ram Pyari Devi's hand stopped on the chain.

Her son Pramod had been showing Anamika the upstairs room. He came down and said, "It'll be difficult to keep opening the gate at all hours of the night."

Anamika said calmly, "If I can get a second key, I'll open and lock it myself."

Ram Pyari Devi did not answer at once. The upstairs room had been empty for three months. Her pension did not cover all the household expenses, and the income from Pramod's notebook-and-book shop rose and fell with the season.

At last she took out an old brass key and handed it to her.

"Don't ever leave the gate open."

"Never."

That second key became the lane's first piece of news.

That evening Lalita Kaki, who lived opposite, asked Sudha, "A separate key for the tenant girl?"

Sudha laughed. "Her work is like that."

"Work is work. But night is still night."

Sudha gave no reply to that sentence.

Anamika's routine matched no one else's.

Sometimes she came down the stairs at half past four in the morning, a small steel lunch box in her hand, a blue bag on her shoulder, her hair tied tightly back. Even the milkman had not arrived by then.

Sometimes she returned at one in the afternoon and slept through the evening.

Sometimes, at eleven at night, the hospital vehicle dropped her at the turn of the lane. She walked in and opened the gate with the brass key.

The clink of the chain became a clock for the households.

"She came at half past eleven last night."

"No, it was already midnight."

"My clock said eleven fifty-five."

They never agreed on the time, but there was always a discussion.

At first Anamika noticed none of this. Returning from the hospital, she would wash her hands and face, change her clothes, put rice on the small stove, and go to sleep.

Two weeks later she realized that even her sleep was a subject for the neighbourhood.

One afternoon she came downstairs to fill water. Lalita Kaki was there too.

"Slept this late today?"

Placing her bucket under the tap, Anamika said, "I was on night duty."

"I can never sleep in the daytime."

"You can after staying awake all night."

Lalita Kaki laughed, but the questioning did not end.

"Are there women at the hospital at night too?"

Anamika looked at her.

"Whether the patient is a woman or a man, the nurses have to be there."

She lifted the bucket and went upstairs.

The following week, one night, the hospital's small vehicle came all the way into the lane. It was raining hard. The driver opened an umbrella and escorted Anamika to the gate.

By morning, it was the driver's umbrella that had become the subject of discussion, not the rain.

"A man came all the way to the gate to drop her."

"It was the hospital vehicle," Sudha said.

"Does a man become a hospital just because 'hospital' is written on the vehicle?"

Sudha fell silent again.

That day Ram Pyari Devi went upstairs for the first time without any particular reason.

Anamika was not looking at a prescription on the table but at the printed schedule of her shifts.

Ram Pyari Devi stood at the door.

"Did you want to say something?" Anamika asked.

"No, only... it rained a lot last night, didn't it?"

"Yes."

"The vehicle came all the way in."

Anamika folded the schedule.

"The driver dropped me here. The road was under knee-deep water."

Ram Pyari Devi had her next sentence ready, but it did not come out.

She only said, "There are clothes spread out on the roof, and I can see clouds gathering again."

Anamika got up.

"I'll bring them down."

"No, you've been awake all night. I'll do it."

It was the first time Ram Pyari Devi had treated Anamika's daytime sleep not as laziness, but as sleep after work.

But the rest of the lane's clock kept ticking.

Customers began coming to Pramod's shop and asking for news of the tenant.

At first Pramod laughed it off. Then it began to make him uncomfortable.

One evening he said to his mother, "We could rent the room to someone else. All this coming and going at night isn't right."

Ram Pyari Devi was picking through rice.

"She pays the rent on time."

"It isn't about the rent."

"Then what is it about?"

Pramod searched for an answer.

"It's a neighbourhood. What will people say?"

Ram Pyari Devi picked a small stone from among the grains and set it aside.

"Will the people pay the rent?"

Pramod grew irritated.

"Ma, not everything is about money."

Ram Pyari Devi looked at him.

"Exactly. Then understand the hours of her work as work, not in terms of money."

Pramod said nothing.

Even so, the pressure did not end.

One day Shivnarayan Jha from the house opposite stopped Ram Pyari Devi near the gate.

"My daughter is grown up. This sort of coming and going at all hours of the night affects the conduct of the household."

Ram Pyari Devi asked, "Until what hour does a household's conduct remain proper?"

Shivnarayan Babu did not understand the question.

"I'm saying there ought to be a fixed time."

Ram Pyari Devi did not argue that day.

That night she called Anamika.

"What if the gate isn't opened after ten at night?"

Anamika was silent for a few moments.

"Then I won't be able to do night duty."

"Can't you change your shifts?"

"I can change one or two. Not every time. Everyone at the hospital has to do nights."

Ram Pyari Devi lowered her eyes.

Anamika said, "If it's difficult for you, give me a month. I'll find another place."

The sentence came more easily than Ram Pyari Devi had expected. She had thought Anamika would argue, become angry, list her rights.

She merely spoke of finding a new place.

For the next ten days, along with going to the hospital, Anamika also went looking for a room.

One landlord asked, "You'll live alone?"

"Yes."

"What time will you return at night?"

"Depends on the shift."

"Then it's difficult."

At another place she was told, "If you were a woman living with a family, that would be different."

At a third place the room was good, but the gate was locked at nine every night.

One day, sitting in the hospital rest room, Anamika crossed out three numbers.

Meanwhile, a letter arrived at Shivnarayan Babu's house.

His daughter Neelima, having completed her nursing training, had received a six-month appointment at a hospital in the city.

Her schedule for the first week included two night shifts.

Shivnarayan Babu read the paper three times.

"Night?"

"Yes, Babujee," Neelima said. "I did them during training too."

"That was in the hostel."

"The work is the same."

That evening, for the first time, the meaning of a time limit changed in Shivnarayan Babu's house.

When Neelima left for her first night shift, her father himself walked her to the turn of the lane.

As he returned, Anamika was leaving for the hospital.

Shivnarayan Babu stopped when he saw her.

"Your hospital vehicle drops employees home at night, doesn't it?"

Anamika stopped too.

"Our hospital vehicle does. Neelima's hospital may have a different arrangement. She should get the number from the hospital office."

"A reliable driver..."

"First find out what the hospital provides. An outside vehicle can come later."

Shivnarayan Babu nodded.

Anamika went on her way.

She neither reminded him of the old conversation nor smiled.

Two days later Neelima returned at a quarter past midnight.

The gate of the house opposite was already open. Shivnarayan Babu was sitting on the verandah.

That night Ram Pyari Devi was awake too.

Anamika was at the hospital then.

A vehicle stopped in the lane, Neelima got out, and the gate closed.

The curtain at Lalita Kaki's window stirred faintly.

In the morning she said to Sudha, "Neelima came home late last night."

Kneading flour, Sudha asked, "She was on duty, wasn't she?"

Lalita Kaki was silent for a moment.

"Yes, it was work."

It was the very sentence Sudha had once used for Anamika. This time no question followed it.

That day Ram Pyari Devi went upstairs.

In the room Anamika had set two empty boxes on a spread-out newspaper and was sorting her things into piles—things to keep, things to throw away, things to take with her.

"Found a place?" Ram Pyari Devi asked.

"I found one. It's far from the hospital, but there's no restriction on coming and going at night."

Ram Pyari Devi placed a hand on the doorframe.

"There'll be no restriction here now."

Anamika kept putting the books in her hand into the trunk.

"I understand."

"Then stay."

This time Anamika looked at Ram Pyari Devi.

"Maaji, the rule has changed—that is a good thing. But now, whenever the chain clinks, the first thing I wonder is which window will move. When I come back from work, before I remember my own room, I remember people's eyes."

Ram Pyari Devi remained silent.

Anamika continued, "At the new place, at least I'll be able to begin afresh."

There was sorrow on Ram Pyari Devi's face, but she did not invent another argument to stop her.

On the last Sunday of the month, Anamika's belongings were loaded onto a small tempo.

Pramod settled the final rent account. Sudha packed puris and vegetable curry into a box for her.

Ram Pyari Devi stood by the gate.

Anamika placed the brass key on her palm and handed it to her.

Looking at the key, Ram Pyari Devi said, "I had another copy made. You could have kept this one."

Anamika smiled.

"The key belongs to the house."

"It stays in the hand of whoever lives in the house."

"Someone else will live here now."

Ram Pyari Devi closed her fist around the key.

The tempo drove out of the lane.

For a few days, Ram Pyari Devi's gate remained silent after ten at night.

Out of habit, she sometimes woke at midnight. She would lie waiting for the sound of the chain, then smile at herself.

One night, at about half past one, there came a clear metallic clink.

Ram Pyari Devi sat up in bed.

For a moment she thought—Anamika has returned.

Then she realized that the sound had not come from her gate, but from Shivnarayan Babu's gate across the lane.

Neelima was returning from night duty.

Ram Pyari Devi did not go to the window.

She lay down again.

The chain clinked once more in the lane, and then the night returned to its old silence.

STORY 48

Secret Savings

Malati Devi's savings were not kept in any box.

Not inside the cupboard, not beneath the mattress, not knotted into an old sari.

Even if the people of the house had searched her room ten times, they would not have found even five hundred rupees together in one place.

Even so, Malati Devi was firmly certain that if a need arose, she had money.

That certainty lay scattered along her daily route.

In that small neighbourhood of Laheriasarai, on the one-and-a-half-kilometre road from her house to the market, her invisible savings lay in four places—Gopal Sahu's grocery shop, Shambhu the milkman's ledger, Savitri Pharmacy, and the torn red notebook of Revati, the vegetable seller.

Sometimes seven rupees.

Sometimes twenty-three.

Sometimes forty-two.

At times a full two hundred.

Malati Devi would buy something, settle the bill, and if the shopkeeper said, "I don't have change; take it next time," she would reply, "Write it under my name."

Even if change was available the next day, she did not immediately take it.

"Let it stay. Let it keep adding up."

At first Gopal Sahu used to laugh.

"Auntie, have you opened a bank?"

Malati Devi would say, "What is in the bank will come by the bank's route. This is money on the road."

Gopal Sahu did not understand what she meant by that answer, but on one page of his ledger he wrote "Malati Jha" and kept adding the small amounts.

At home, the matter was never discussed.

Jagdish Babu, Malati Devi's husband, worked in the accounts section of the electricity department. Accounts were his profession. On the first day of every month he gave Malati Devi the money for household expenses and took it for granted that the family's finances ran on his earnings and his bank account.

"Twelve thousand went on groceries and milk this month?"

He would say.

Malati Devi would answer, "Yes."

"Last month it was eleven thousand seven hundred."

"Mustard oil became more expensive this month."

Jagdish Babu would open the calculator, add two or four figures, shake his head, and the matter would end there.

He never asked why Gopal Sahu had charged thirty-five rupees less than the price printed on the tin of mustard oil, or how Malati Devi had compared prices at two shops for a five-kilo sack of rice and saved fifty-eight rupees.

Malati Devi did not tell him either.

To her, saving meant this: from a sum that was already destined to be spent, something should remain in her own hands as a choice she could make herself.

The money was small.

The choice was not.

There were two children in the house—twenty-three-year-old Pranav and nineteen-year-old Mansi. Pranav was preparing for competitive examinations, and Mansi was in her second year of college. Paying by phone, banking, QR codes, and the new ways of keeping accounts all came very naturally to them.

One day, while buying vegetables from Revati, Mansi heard her mother talking.

Revati said, "Didi, thirty-four from last time and sixteen from today—that makes fifty."

Malati Devi said, "Let it stay written down."

On the way home Mansi asked, "Ma, why did you leave fifty rupees there?"

"I didn't leave it. It's mine."

"Then bring it home."

"What do I need it for right now?"

Mansi laughed. "You're asking what fifty rupees is for? If money stays at home, will it go bad?"

Malati Devi laughed too. "Small money disappears fastest at home."

"Who takes it?"

"No one. The house takes it."

Mansi laughed again at that answer, but Malati Devi was serious.

No one stole the five-, ten-, or fifty-rupee notes in the house. Sometimes Pranav would say, "Ma, give me twenty for the auto." Sometimes Jagdish Babu would say, "Do you have change? The tea seller can't break five hundred." Sometimes an extra packet of milk would arrive. Sometimes the broom would break. Sometimes a guest would turn up without warning.

Small money, once it stayed at home, took the shape of the household.

Written in a market ledger, it retained its own name.

Malati Devi had not devised this method after a great deal of thought.

Years earlier, when Mansi was five, she had developed a high fever one night. Jagdish Babu was away on tour. There were one hundred and thirty-seven rupees in cash at home. The pharmacy was open at night, but the two medicines the doctor had prescribed cost two hundred and ten rupees.

That night Harinarayan, the owner of Savitri Pharmacy, had said, “Give me what you have. Pay the rest later.”

Malati Devi had never forgotten that sentence.

A few days later, when she paid the balance, she gave ten rupees extra. When Harinarayan tried to return it, she said, “Let it stay. Under my name.”

Those ten rupees later became forty-seven.

Then one hundred and twenty-two.

Slowly, a small sum began to remain under Malati Devi's name at Savitri Pharmacy.

The memory of that night's fear was not money, but the money became its form.

Malati Devi never added up the total of all four places at once.

She kept only a rough estimate in her mind.

Around two thousand, perhaps, with Gopal.

Less than a thousand in the milkman's ledger.

At the pharmacy, sometimes more and sometimes less—because the amount also went down whenever she bought medicines there.

Five or seven hundred with Revati.

Besides this, she deposited two hundred rupees a month in the neighbourhood women's savings group. The money was in her name, but there was a rule for withdrawing it—in an emergency, the signatures of three members were required.

Jagdish Babu knew about the women's group, not about the savings.

To him, those meetings were merely “neighbourhood gossip.”

“You all sit for two hours drinking tea,” he would joke.

Malati Devi would say, “We drink the tea with our own money.”

One Tuesday morning, Jagdish Babu's phone rang.

It was a message from the bank: because an unusual transaction had been attempted on the account, transactions had been temporarily blocked for security reasons.

At first Jagdish Babu assumed it was some ordinary technical problem.

He tried to pay the electricity bill by phone. It did not go through.

He went to an ATM. The card was declined.

At the branch he learned that during the night, two unsuccessful attempts had been made to transfer large sums from his account. The bank had frozen the

account. An application, identity documents, a written complaint, verification—the whole process had to be completed. The officer said, “It may take three to seven working days.”

“Seven days?” Jagdish Babu almost shouted.

“It is a security matter.”

“But all my salary money is in this account.”

“You will have access to everything once the block is lifted.”

That answer was sufficient for the bank. It was not sufficient for the household.

When Jagdish Babu returned home, his face had changed.

It was the eighteenth of the month.

There were one thousand three hundred and twenty rupees in cash at home.

The gas cylinder was on the verge of running out.

The last date for Pranav's examination application was four days away. The fee was eighteen hundred.

Mansi's college bus-pass renewal was due in two days.

There were three days' worth of Jagdish Babu's mother's blood-pressure and diabetes medicines left.

There was enough rice in the house for five days.

The milkman's account for the previous week also had to be paid—or so Jagdish Babu believed.

He sat down in the sitting room and spread papers out before him.

“First Pranav's form,” he said. “Can we delay the bus pass for two days?”

Mansi said, “If we delay it, there will be a fine.”

“Then whom do we borrow from?”

Pranav said quietly, “Mama?”

Jagdish Babu's face tightened.

Only the previous month they had borrowed ten thousand from Mama while buying the refrigerator, though it had been repaid within two weeks. Jagdish Babu did not like the thought of holding out his hand again.

“An advance from the office?” Malati Devi asked.

“The procedure takes at least five days.”

“And the bank account will take five to seven days.”

“Yes.”

For a few moments, everyone was silent.

Then Jagdish Babu said, “I'll take five thousand from Shambhunath. He'll give it.”

Malati Devi looked up at once.

Shambhunath was the man in the neighbourhood who lent money at interest. Five hundred a month on five thousand. If the date was missed, there was a separate penalty.

"No," Malati Devi said.

Jagdish Babu looked at her. "Then?"

"Wait until tonight."

"What will waiting change?"

"Let me see."

Irritation entered Jagdish Babu's voice. "Malati, this isn't a vegetable bill. We have to run the house for seven days."

Malati Devi did not answer.

In the afternoon she took her shopping bag and went out.

Mansi asked, "Where are you going?"

"To the market."

"With what money?"

"I have money."

The first stop was Gopal Sahu's shop.

Malati Devi said, "Gopal, how much is there under my name?"

Gopal Sahu took out his ledger and turned the pages.

"Two thousand seven hundred and twenty-six."

Malati Devi herself was surprised. Her estimate had been lower.

"Give me goods worth one thousand today. Leave the rest written down."

Gopal Sahu did not strike out her name. He wrote the new balance below—one thousand seven hundred and twenty-six.

Rice, lentils, oil, salt, potatoes, and soap went into the bag.

The second stop was Savitri Pharmacy.

"Harinarayan ji, how much is there under my name?"

"One thousand one hundred and seventy."

"Give me a full month's medicines for Maaji."

The medicines came to nine hundred and eighty.

"One hundred and ninety remains," Harinarayan said.

Malati Devi folded the slip and put it into her bag.

The third stop was Shambhu the milkman.

His ledger showed eight hundred and forty rupees deposited in Malati Devi's name.

"Deduct this week's milk from that," she said.

Shambhu laughed. "Auntie, you really do run a bank."

This time Malati Devi did not laugh.

"When the bank shuts, this bank stays open."

Shambhu too fell silent.

There were six hundred and twenty-five rupees with Revati. Malati Devi bought vegetables for three days, then told Revati, "Don't return the rest yet."

Revati asked, "Is there trouble?"

"A little."

"Then take all of it."

"No. Let the trouble remain little; that's why I won't take all of it."

When she returned home, Mansi was astonished by the weight of the bag.

"Ma, where did the money come from?"

"Mine."

"How much?"

For the first time, Malati Devi tried to add up in her mind what still remained at all four places.

Even after deducting the groceries and medicines, the total came to somewhere around five thousand.

When Jagdish Babu returned from the office, he saw the medicines, provisions, and milk slip on the table.

"Is all this on credit?"

"No."

"Then?"

"Money paid earlier."

Jagdish Babu picked up the slips one by one.

"Two thousand seven hundred and twenty-six with Gopal?"

"There was."

"Eight hundred and forty with the milkman?"

"There was."

"One thousand one hundred and seventy at the pharmacy?"

"There was."

The surprise in his voice slowly hardened into something like accusation.

"You were keeping all this money hidden from me?"

Malati Devi remained calm.

"Not from you. I was saving it out of the household expenses."

"Aren't those the same thing?"

"No."

Jagdish Babu was about to say something, but Malati Devi spoke first.

"If fifty rupees were lying at home, Pranav would ask for auto fare. You would ask for change. An extra packet of milk would come. It would be nobody's fault. The money would be spent. When it stays under my name at the shop, it still serves the household, but it doesn't dissolve away all at once."

Pranav kept looking at the slips on the table.

Mansi looked at her mother's face.

Jagdish Babu said, "But I should have known the accounts."

Malati Devi asked softly, "Why?"

It was not a loud question.

But everyone in the sitting room heard it.

Jagdish Babu did not answer at once.

Malati Devi continued, "You give me the money for the household provisions. Saving from it was part of my work. If there is a shortfall, you ask why. If there is a saving, does every right over that already belong to you as well?"

Jagdish Babu put the slips back on the table.

The conversation did not turn into a quarrel.

Because at that moment the problem had still not ended.

Pranav's examination fee was still unpaid.

So was Mansi's bus pass.

Malati Devi said, "The women's group meets tomorrow."

Jagdish Babu was startled again. "There too?"

"I deposit two hundred a month."

"How much has it become?"

"Seven thousand four hundred."

This time such silence spread through the sitting room that the bell of a rickshaw outside could be heard clearly.

Jagdish Babu sat upright in his chair.

"Seven thousand four hundred?"

"A little at a time, for three years."

"And I..."

Malati Devi did not interrupt him.

She waited for him to complete the sentence himself.

Jagdish Babu did not complete it.

The next day Malati Devi went to the women's group meeting. Under the group's rules, in an emergency a member could immediately withdraw part of her savings. Three members signed. Malati Devi withdrew four thousand.

From those four thousand, Pranav's examination fee was paid. Mansi's bus pass was renewed. A gas cylinder arrived.

Malati Devi left the remaining money in the group.

Jagdish Babu said, “If you had taken it all out, we would have been more comfortable.”

“Why?”

“What if the bank takes longer?”

“Then we'll see again.”

“It is better to see to it now.”

Malati Devi smiled. “I don't like keeping all the money in my hands at once.”

Jagdish Babu said nothing to that.

On the fifth day, the bank called. Verification was complete. The account had been unblocked.

Jagdish Babu went straight to the ATM. He withdrew money and brought it home.

The crisis could have ended there.

But afterward a new discomfort remained in the house—everyone now knew that Malati Devi's financial world was larger than the four walls within which the family had long regarded her merely as the person who spent the household money.

That evening Jagdish Babu placed a sheet of paper on the table.

“I was thinking,” he said, “we should open an emergency account. A joint one. We'll deposit a thousand every month.”

Pranav immediately said, “That's good.”

Mansi nodded too.

Malati Devi looked at the paper.

“Joint with whom?”

“You and me.”

“That will do.”

Jagdish Babu's face relaxed.

Then Malati Devi added, “But my small savings will remain separate.”

His expression faltered again for a moment.

“Why?”

“Because the emergency account will belong to the household. This is money I decide how to use.”

Before Jagdish Babu could answer, Mansi burst out laughing.

“Babu, you've started asking again.”

Jagdish Babu looked at his daughter, then at Malati Devi.

This time his smile came slowly.

“All right. But at least I'll know that something is there.”

Malati Devi said, “Knowing that much is enough.”

On the first day of the next month, Jagdish Babu gave Malati Devi the money for household expenses.

Along with it, he gave her a white envelope.

On it was written—“Emergency.”

Malati Devi did not open the envelope to look inside. She placed it on the upper shelf of the cupboard.

In the afternoon she went to the market. From Revati she bought okra, pumpkin, and coriander. The total came to one hundred and eighty-two rupees. Malati Devi gave her two hundred. Revati began to return eighteen rupees. Malati Devi looked at the two notes for a moment. “Write it under my name.” Revati opened the red notebook.

“Starting again?” Revati asked. Malati Devi said, “When did it ever stop?” Revati laughed. She wrote the date in the red notebook and entered the amount —eighteen. Malati Devi picked up her bag and started home.

Along the way stood Savitri Pharmacy, the milk cart, and Gopal Sahu's shop. At all four places, little numbers would begin gathering again. At home, the white envelope would remain in its place, and Malati Devi's savings would once again not be kept in any one place.

STORY 49

The Station Not on the Map

For Prabhakar Mishra, a train journey was not something to look at but something to count.

The time he left home at dawn, the time the train arrived at the little station, the time it crossed the bridge after Sakri, the time he reached Darbhanga and marked his attendance at the office—everything sat inside him like the hands of a clock.

He was a clerk in the district archives. He spent his days among old files, torn maps, and dates. So whenever something new appeared along the way, his eyes tried to place it, in his mind, somewhere within the old order.

He first saw Kadambbari station on a Monday.

He wrote the name in his notebook later. In that first instant, there had not even been time enough to read it.

The train was running at full speed between two familiar stations. Outside the window, paddy fields, two ponds, electric poles, and a small brick kiln went past in turn. Then, all at once, a platform with a yellow signboard filled the frame of the window.

In the middle of the platform, black letters on the yellow board read—Kadambbari.

A blue bench. An iron hand-pump. A small tin shelter. Beneath the shelter, an old man with a red gamchha over his shoulder.

The train did not slow down. No whistle sounded. No door opened.

Within eighteen or twenty seconds, everything had fallen behind.

Prabhakar looked at Shekhar Thakur, who was sitting beside him. Shekhar was reading a newspaper.

“Has a new station been built here?” Prabhakar asked.

Shekhar did not lift his eyes from the paper. “Where?”

“The one we just passed—Kadambbari.”

This time Shekhar looked outside. There were fields.

“You have spent so long looking through old files that now you have begun looking for files even on the railway tracks,” he said with a laugh.

Prabhakar laughed too. The matter ended there.

The next day Prabhakar deliberately took a seat by the window. His coach was almost the same one—the third general coach from the front, the fourth window on the left.

Between the two familiar stations he began counting electric poles. After the fourteenth pole came the pond, then the thicket, then the little culvert.

And then the yellow board again.

Kadambbari.

This time he read the name clearly. The old man from the previous day was not on the platform. A girl was working the handle of the hand-pump up and down. Three yellow canisters stood beside the bench.

Again the train went on without changing speed.

Prabhakar immediately took out his notebook and wrote: ‘Between two stations. Pond after the fourteenth pole. Name: Kadambbari. Train does not stop.’

On reaching the office, he found his archival habits useful for the first time. During lunch he searched for old district maps of the railway line. The archives did not hold every railway department file, but they did have old land-acquisition maps.

A straight line ran between the two stations. The little culvert was marked midway. Kadambbari was not marked.

He thought—it must be a new station. How could it appear on an old map?

That evening, at the enquiry window of his own station, he asked about the name.

The clerk turned the pages of the timetable. “Kadambbari?”

“Yes, in between.”

The clerk turned more pages. “There is no station by that name on this line.”

“A new halt?”

“No.”

“An old station that was closed?”

“Not that either.”

Prabhakar did not argue. It was not in his nature to argue with records about something that could not be found in the records.

On the third day he asked Shekhar to fold away his newspaper.

“Today just look out of the window. When I tell you.”

Shekhar smiled, but agreed.

As soon as the pond slipped behind them, Prabhakar said, “Now.”

Shekhar looked out through the fourth window.

The yellow board was in front of them.

“Kadambbari,” Shekhar said softly.

This time a goat was tethered on the platform. A thin strip of sunlight fell from the edge of the tin shelter. A woman in a green sari sat on the bench with a bundle of clothes in her lap.

After the station had gone by, Shekhar did not reopen his newspaper.

"I have travelled on this line for eight years," he said. "I have never heard of a station by this name."

"Neither had the enquiry clerk yesterday."

"Then what is this?"

Prabhakar did not answer. In his notebook he wrote a third line: 'Shekhar saw it too.'

The investigation began the next day.

Prabhakar left the fourth window and sat at the fifth. The same pond, the same thicket, the same culvert came into view. But Kadambbari did not. The fields continued without interruption.

He got up and moved toward the fourth window, but by then the train had already passed that stretch.

On the fifth day he sat at the fourth window again. Kadambbari was there.

On the sixth day he kept shifting his gaze between the three gaps formed by the iron bars of the window.

That was when he noticed the most unsettling thing of all.

Seen through the middle gap of the fourth window, the station was there. At the very same moment, if he moved his head two inches to the right and looked through the side gap, there was no station—only paddy fields.

Back to the middle gap—the yellow board, the pump, the bench.

Back to the side gap—the fields.

Both views existed at the same time in the same direction.

For the first time, a faint shiver ran through Prabhakar. More than fear, it was the kind of unease he felt when two different owners appeared against the same plot number in a file.

With his fingernail he made a small scratch on the window frame.

On the seventh day Shekhar was absent. Facing Prabhakar sat Manjula Kumari, a college student he often saw on this train.

For a long time Prabhakar said nothing. As the station drew near, he gave up his seat and said, "Would you look out through this window?"

Manjula looked at him questioningly, but changed places.

A few moments later she read the name herself. "Kadambbari?"

"What do you see?" Prabhakar asked.

"A small station. A child is peeping from behind the signboard."

Prabhakar looked through the middle gap. The child was indeed there.

"And through the side gap?"

Manjula shifted her head. Her brows drew together.

"Fields."

The station fell behind. Manjula remained silent for a long time.

"Will you tell anyone?" she asked.

Prabhakar closed his notebook. "Let me first understand it myself."

He could not understand it.

Through a clerk he knew in the railway office, he informally examined the records for the distance between the two stations. Distance posts, culverts, bends in the track, land acquisition—everything was recorded. The name Kadambbari was nowhere.

"There is hardly room for a station here either," the clerk said, running a finger over the map. "Fields on one side, low-lying land on the other. There was never even an old proposal."

Prabhakar asked, "Any temporary halt? During a fair?"

The clerk shook his head. "No. Where did you come across the name?"

"I heard it from someone."

As he gave that answer, Prabhakar felt that for the first time he was lying about Kadambbari.

On the eighth day he tried to take a photograph with his phone.

With his eye at the middle gap, the station was perfectly clear. When he held the phone screen in the same direction, there were only fields. He took the photograph. Later, when he looked at it, he saw paddy, a white egret, and a distant palm tree.

That day, after reaching home, he drew a small sketch of the station from memory: the yellow board, the blue bench, the hand-pump, the tin shelter. The drawing was still the same the next day.

On the ninth day the hand-pump was gone from the station. In its place, two labourers were digging the earth.

On the tenth day a new pump stood half-buried in the ground.

On the eleventh day the earth around it was wet.

Prabhakar understood that this was not some fixed image. Days passed there.

But he could not tell how much time passed there.

A week later the order of the coaches changed. The third coach from the front was new. The old fourth window was gone.

Prabhakar sat in the corresponding place. Between the two stations he saw the fields, the pond, the thicket, the culvert. Kadambbari did not appear.

That day he felt emptiness more than surprise. He could not prove that the place existed, yet its absence began to trouble him as well.

For three days the station did not appear.

On the fourth day Shekhar asked, "Where has your station gone?"

Prabhakar said, "Perhaps with the coach."

Shekhar tried to laugh, but the laugh did not quite come.

That evening, returning from the office, Prabhakar was crossing the footbridge beside the Darbhanga railway yard at a slow pace. Below him, several old coaches stood on separate tracks.

On the frame of one coach he saw the small scratch he had made with his fingernail.

He stopped.

It was the same coach.

In the railway yard, there should have been the wall of the goods shed behind that coach. From the bridge above, Prabhakar looked toward the middle gap of the fourth window.

There was no wall.

There was Kadambbari.

The yellow board stood in the sunlight. The earth beneath the new pump had dried now. On the blue bench sat not the same woman in the green sari, but an old man. A child was drawing a circle in chalk along the edge of the platform.

Prabhakar stood motionless on the bridge. The coach below was motionless too. Yet inside the station small movements continued—cloth fluttered, the child's hand rose and fell, a goat's ear twitched.

He took two steps to the right and looked through the next window of the same coach. The wall of the goods shed. Then through the middle gap of the fourth window—Kadambbari. This time a boy standing beside the yellow board raised his head and looked toward the bridge.

Prabhakar felt like raising his hand. He did not. He placed his notebook on the iron railing of the bridge and opened the page with the map. Between the two stations, where he had earlier made a dot for Kadambbari, he struck the dot out.

Instead, in the margin of the page, he drew a small rectangle—the shape of a window. Inside it he wrote: 'Kadambbari.' Below, in the railway yard, the coach stood perfectly still. There was still no place for the station on the map; but there was a place for the window.

STORY 50

An Unfamiliar Home of One's Own

Vinay Jha returned to his home in Darbhanga at half past nine at night after a three-day journey.

The lock on the main gate was the same.

The brass key caught in the same old notch and turned.

The veranda bulb gave the same flickering light, for which he had been meaning to call an electrician for three months.

Everything seemed his own.

As soon as he opened the door, the first thing that felt unfamiliar was not a smell, not a sound, not some strange object.

It was the arrangement.

The large table in the sitting room had moved over to the window.

Two cane chairs, which had always stood on either side of the table, now faced one another, with a small round stool between them.

The bookcase had moved from the western wall to the northern wall.

The radio, which always bore a layer of dust, had not been cleaned; but its place had changed.

It was now on the three-legged stand below the window.

Vinay did not go farther in.

First he looked at the whole room from the doorway.

Nothing seemed to have been stolen.

On the contrary, the idea that a thief would patiently move an old bookcase, books and all, was absurd.

He set his travel bag on the floor and went straight to the bookcase.

It was not locked; the bookcase was never locked.

History books on the top shelf.

Magazines on the second.

Old files below.

All of them were his.

He took out a book and examined it.

On the back cover was the same small blot of blue ink left when a pen had burst five years earlier.

It was his book.

He picked up the brass bell from the right-hand corner of the table.

That too was his.

When he rang it, the cracked sound inside gave the same ordinary rasp.

No one had replaced any of the objects.

Only all the objects were arranged differently.

Vinay's first thought was that Mira must have come.

Mira was his younger sister, who lived in Laheriasarai and had the second key to the house.

He took out his mobile phone and called her.

"Did you come to the house?"

Mira was startled.

"No. Why?"

"Nothing. The table has moved."

"Did the table walk there by itself?"

"Maybe the cleaner came."

"But you gave Budhiya Kaki leave for the whole trip."

Vinay remembered.

That was true.

"All right. I'll see tomorrow."

He ended the call and went toward the kitchen.

There the strangeness was more obvious.

The wooden spice box was not beside the stove but on the window ledge.

The plates were on the upper shelf, the bowls below.

The rice tin was in the left corner instead of the right.

The water pitcher stood by the door.

For a moment Vinay felt that he was not in his own house, but in some house where everything had been borrowed from his.

He opened every tin in the kitchen and looked inside.

The turmeric was the same.

The lid of the salt tin had the same small bend in it.

The back of the brass plate bore the same scratch.

The rim of an old glass had the same nick that made him always keep it away from guests.

Everything was his.

But the kitchen was arranged as though someone lived there whose hand naturally went to the left.

Vinay worked with his right hand.

So had his wife, Lata.

Lata had been gone for seven years.

Vinay's hand suddenly stopped on the rice tin.

When Lata was alive, she had once suggested rearranging the kitchen.

"Keep the tins on the left," she had said. "There is too much smoke by the stove."

Vinay had replied then, "Things are fine where they have stood for years."

The matter had ended there.

Now the tin was on the left.

That night Vinay began putting everything back in its old place.

The bookcase was hard to move.

He could not move it all the way by himself.

The table, chairs, radio, kitchen tins, plates—whatever he could, he restored to the old arrangement.

He left the bookcase alone.

"Tomorrow I'll call Ramsevak," he said to himself.

When he reached the bedroom, he saw that the head of the bed had also been changed.

The bed had formerly stood against the southern wall.

Now it faced east, where the morning light fell directly on the pillow.

Lata had liked the morning light.

Vinay did not.

For seven years he had kept the bed to the south.

Now he was tired.

Instead of moving the bed, he lay down facing east.

When he opened his eyes in the morning, the light was falling straight on his face.

For the first moment he wanted to blame Lata.

Then he remembered at once—Lata was not there.

He got up and went into the sitting room.

The table he had returned to its old place the night before was once again by the window.

The chairs were once again facing each other.

The radio was once again on the stand.

This time Vinay stood still in the middle of the room.

If anyone had come in during the night, the main door had been bolted from inside.

The back door was latched from inside.

The windows had iron bars.

And the bookcase, which he himself had not been able to move, was no longer against the northern wall.

It stood diagonally in the eastern corner.

That meant its place too had changed during the night.

Vinay went outside and looked around the house on all four sides.

The wall was intact.

The gate was intact.

There was no scratch anywhere.

There were no fresh drag marks in the earth.

Ramsevak the carpenter was called.

The moment Ramsevak saw the bookcase, he said, "How did this move by itself?"

"That is what I called you to ask."

"It would take four men."

Two labourers were brought.

The bookcase was put back against the western wall.

With chalk, Vinay made small marks around all four feet.

He did the same around the table legs.

And around the radio stand.

Ramsevak laughed.

"Getting ready to catch a thief?"

"To catch the objects."

Ramsevak looked at Vinay's face and stopped laughing.

Vinay did not leave the house that day.

Everything remained still until noon.

Until evening too.

After dinner, he sat in the sitting room reading a book.

At ten he turned off the light and went to the bedroom.

In the morning, all the chalk marks stood empty.

The bookcase had moved again.

This time it was not against the northern wall but to the left of the doorway.

The table was in the middle, with four chairs around it.

The radio was not on the stand.

It was in the small corner outside the kitchen where Lata used to cut vegetables in the evening.

Vinay touched the radio.

The same dust.

The same rasp.

But this time the arrangement was not like Lata's old proposal.

It was entirely different.

The four chairs around the table immediately brought one thing to Vinay's mind.

When his son Anshuman was small, meals in the house were always eaten on the kitchen floor.

Once Anshuman had said, "Why don't we all eat at the table?"

Vinay had answered, "That isn't the custom here."

Lata had laughed and said, "Customs are made."

But the table had never become a dining table.

Now the four chairs stood as though the family had been eating there for years.

Vinay examined the surface of the table.

In one corner was an old yellow stain, like turmeric.

He could not say for certain whether the stain had been there before.

He was about to take an old photograph from the bookcase, then stopped.

A photograph would not prove the arrangement.

The objects were all the same.

The question was not where the objects had come from.

The question was why they had been arranged this way.

He started a file.

On the first page he wrote, "Arrangement of the House."

The date.

Measurements of the sitting room.

The position of the table.

The direction of the chairs.

The wall against which the bookcase stood.

The order of the kitchen tins.

The head of the bed.

Day by day he began recording the measurements.

Gradually, certain rules began to emerge.

No new object ever appeared.

No old object disappeared.

Even the contents of closed boxes did not change.

Only the arrangement of objects left out in the open changed.

The walls, doors, windows and dimensions of the rooms remained fixed.

The changes took place at night.

But night alone was not enough.

One night Vinay stayed awake in the sitting room until dawn.

Nothing changed.

Another night he went to the bedroom but left the door open.

By morning, there had been a change.

So being watched was not the cause.

One night he locked all the small objects inside a box.

By morning the heavy furniture had moved, while the box remained exactly as it was.

That meant the house did not add objects; it made new arrangements out of whatever was available.

On the seventh day Mira came.

The moment she saw the sitting room she said, "So you finally moved the table?"

Vinay looked at her.

"Does this look right to you?"

"It's fine. The light is better by the window."

"How was it before?"

Mira answered readily, "Against the wall."

"And what about the way it is now?"

"You must have moved it."

"I didn't."

Mira was about to laugh again, but then she saw Vinay's file.

Ten pages of measurements, dates and diagrams.

She fell silent.

"Does someone get in at night?"

"Then why doesn't anything get stolen?"

"Aren't you frightened?"

Vinay thought for a moment and said, "At first I was. Now I'm more curious."

Mira went into the kitchen.

The spice box was now on the low wooden stool.

"Sister-in-law wanted to keep it this way," Mira said softly.

Vinay turned toward her at once.

"You remember?"

"She said it once. You wouldn't agree."

"And this table?"

Mira looked at the table.

"Wasn't this Anshuman's insistence? That everyone should eat together at the table."

Vinay's hand tightened sharply around the file.

"The bookcase by the doorway?"

Mira shook her head.

"No. I don't remember that."

No immediate conclusion emerged.

But from that night on, Vinay stopped merely measuring the arrangements and began writing down their possible causes.

One night the study desk moved into the bedroom.

He remembered that twenty years earlier he had considered leaving his job and writing from home.

Lata had said, "Put the desk inside. It will make a separate corner for work."

Vinay had not left his job.

The desk had never gone inside.

Another night the sewing machine stood in the well-lit part of the sitting room, with the clothes trunk beside it.

After their marriage, Lata had spoken of wanting to teach sewing to the girls of the neighbourhood.

Vinay had said, "The house will turn into a school."

The classes had never begun.

On the third night, Anshuman's old study board was on the veranda, with flowerpots around it and the radio nearby.

Before leaving for college, Anshuman had said, "Let's make the veranda an open place to study."

Vinay had answered, "Everything will get wet in the rain."

That too had never happened.

The arrangements the house created all resembled proposals from Vinay's life that had never been fulfilled.

But not all of them.

Some arrangements were things Vinay had no memory of at all.

One night two cane chairs stood outside the bedroom as though two people had sat there talking late into the night.

Vinay could remember no such proposal.

One day the books were arranged not by subject but in the order in which they had been read.

Vinay had never used such an order.

And yet, from the wear on the books, the sequence looked natural.

One night the dinner plates were arranged as though the table had been set for only two people—the plates had not actually been taken out of the cupboard; just two plates had been shifted to one side at the top of the stack.

Which two people?

Vinay could find no answer.

From this point on, the labels "Lata's proposal," "Anshuman's proposal," and "my unfinished idea" appeared less often in the file.

He made a new heading: "Unfamiliar Possibility."

Mira said, "Don't think about it so much. The things in the house move; let them move."

Vinay asked, "What if all these are arrangements from lives I never lived?"

Mira did not answer at once.

Then she said, "In that case, why would those lives arrange your house?"

Vinay did not write that question in the file.

It stayed in his mind.

A week later Anshuman came from Delhi.

The moment he saw his old room, he laughed.

"Babu, you finally put my desk by the window!"

Vinay was startled.

"You wanted it this way?"

"When I was at school. You used to say the sunlight would ruin the books."

Vinay could not remember.

Anshuman opened the desk drawer.

Inside were his old compass, two tickets, an unfinished letter, and a small wooden whistle.

All old things.

"Were all these already here?" Vinay asked.

"They were in the drawer. I don't remember the order."

Vinay understood that the house was not merely reading the catalogue of his memories.

At least some of its arrangements also matched the forgotten wishes of other people.

That night father and son stayed awake for a long time.

Anshuman was told all the rules.

"Shall I try an experiment?" he asked.

"What?"

"Today let's not touch anything. Let's see what happens by morning."

"I hardly touch anything now."

"No, I mean—let's accept things where they are. Don't put anything back in its old place."

Vinay agreed.

In the morning the sitting room had not changed.

The kitchen had not changed.

Anshuman's room had not changed either.

Vinay grew excited.

"See? If we don't change things, it stays still."

Before answering, Anshuman went into the bedroom.

There, the small bedside table had moved to the window.

Only one object had changed.

Anshuman said, "Not still. Slower."

For the next four days they did not return anything to its old place.

The changes in the house diminished.

Earlier, an entire room would change in a single night.

Now, one or two objects changed in a night.

Sometimes only the direction of a chair.

Sometimes a single flowerpot.

Sometimes the position of the clock.

Vinay felt as though the house were merely searching for whatever empty space was available.

On the fifth day Anshuman left for Delhi again.

Before leaving, he asked his father, "Why did you keep returning everything to its first place?"

"Because that was where it was."

"That answers where it was before. It doesn't answer why it was there."

Vinay grew irritated.

"You don't need to philosophize."

Anshuman laughed.

"All right. But the things in the house philosophize more than you do."

There was a train to catch. The matter ended in laughter.

After Anshuman left, the house grew quiet again.

Vinay read the file.

Thirty-three days.

Thirty-three arrangements.

Some familiar possibilities.

Some unfamiliar.

One thing had remained constant so far—no arrangement had repeated Vinay's actual present arrangement.

It was as though the house ignored "what is" and moved only among "what might have been."

As soon as he wrote that conclusion, Vinay stopped his pen.

"What might have been"—the phrase was too easy.

There was too little evidence.

He put a question mark on the page.

That night, for the first time, Vinay deliberately made a change that was not meant to restore an old arrangement.

He picked up one of the cane chairs in the sitting room and placed it in the eastern corner of the veranda.

A chair had never stood there.

Nor could he remember any old proposal to put one there.

He placed it there only for the evening breeze.

On the small stool beside the chair, he set the radio.

He had never before even thought of putting the radio there.

Then, deliberately, he took a stack of books and placed it behind the chair.

In the file he recorded this arrangement as: "Today's."

"Not old."

"Not anyone's unfinished proposal."

"I made it just now."

In the morning Vinay went straight to the veranda.

The chair was still there.

The radio was still there.

The stack of books was still there.

He was ready to smile.

Then he saw that opposite the chair, in the other corner of the veranda, a second chair had come from inside the house.

The same cane chair that had been in the sitting room the day before.

The two chairs faced each other.

A small empty space lay between them.

Vinay stood there for a long time.

He had not made this arrangement.

But it did not feel entirely old either.

One chair was his present decision.

The other was the house's answer.

That day, for the first time, he crossed out the words "Unfamiliar Possibility" in the file.

In their place he wrote, "Incomplete Arrangement."

Mira came that evening.

The moment she saw the two chairs on the veranda, she sat down on one of them.

"This was a good idea," she said.

Vinay sat in the other chair.

The radio was switched on.

After the old static, a Maithili song began on All India Radio.

Mira said, "If Sister-in-law were here, she would have liked sitting here."

Vinay did not answer.

After a while he got up and went inside.

He brought the file.

On the last page he drew a diagram of the veranda.

Two chairs.

The stool between them.

The radio.

He wrote the date.

He left the space for the reason blank.

At night Mira left.

Vinay locked the main door.

He did not draw chalk lines around the feet as before.

He took no measurements.

He returned no object to its old place.

In the morning the bookcase in the sitting room was against a third wall.

The order of the plates in the kitchen had changed.

In the bedroom, the bed had turned to face east.

The house was unfamiliar again.

Vinay looked at each object one by one.

Everything was his.

He placed the file on the table in the sitting room.

He turned the pages.

The measurements from the first day.

The diagram from the second.

Lata's possibility.

Anshuman's forgotten wish.

An unfamiliar order.

An incomplete arrangement.

The last page was blank.

Vinay picked up his pen.

His hand moved to write, "Today the house changed again."

Then it stopped.

He went out to the veranda.

The two cane chairs were still facing each other.

One chair was the one he himself had placed there the day before.

The other had been brought by the house.

Vinay sat not in the first chair, but in the second.

The chair opposite him remained empty.

The light of dawn was slowly falling across his back.

Inside the house, every object was his own.

He still did not know to which life the arrangement belonged.

But for the first time, he was in no hurry to decide how the house had stood before.

The radio was off.

On the veranda there was only the sound of birds.

After a while Vinay rose, moved the empty chair one finger's breadth forward, and sat down again.

FROM THREE STREAMS OF STORIES · VOLUME I

STORY 51

The Bell That Never Rang

At the doorway of the old house in Laheriasarai was a round brass button. The wood around it had been polished smooth as yesterday by years of touch, but the button itself was always dull. In the rains, green moss crept out around its rim; in winter it was cold as ice; and in summer a touch made the fingertip flinch. Yet one thing about it had not changed in all those years: no matter how often it was pressed, it never rang.

When Madhavi was a child, she would press and press the button until she tired of it. Her mother would open the door from inside and say, “Leave the bell alone; call out your name and ring.” Then Madhavi would rap on the door three times with her fist—knock, knock, knock—and her mother would come laughing from within. Time passed. Madhavi went away to study, found a job, married, had a daughter, was widowed, and finally settled in Pune. Her parents died, one after the other. The house remained—and, at its door, the same bell that never made a sound.

After the first anniversary of her mother’s death, Madhavi decided to sell the house. It was not a mansion, but without care it was slowly growing weary. The roof gutter had broken, a fine crack ran through a pillar of the rear veranda, and the tulsi altar in a corner of the courtyard had begun to lean. Her daughter, Ira, had taken leave and come with her. The expense of higher studies lay ahead; Madhavi still had a loan on her own flat. “Memories don’t pay taxes,” Madhavi had told Ira while working through the figures on paper. Ira had replied, “But while paying taxes, don’t sell every memory as well.”

Madhavi had laughed. At the time it had seemed merely a clever line from her daughter.

The first prospective buyers came on Sunday. The broker, Diwakar Jha, led the way, followed by a couple and their college-going son. Reaching the door, Diwakar pressed the bell button from sheer habit.

There was no sound.

He pressed it again.

“Doesn’t this work?” he asked, turning back.

Madhavi smiled. “It has hardly worked since I was born.”

“We’ll replace it. Such a big house, and the bell is mute!”

Everyone laughed at Diwakar’s remark. Madhavi did not. She herself did not know why. The moment she saw Diwakar’s finger pressing the button, something seemed to drop away inside her for an instant—as though a familiar

name had risen to the tip of her tongue and turned back before it could be spoken.

While they were being shown around, the woman who was considering buying the house noticed a white tile set upside down on the western wall of the kitchen. “Why is this one tile upside down?” she asked.

Madhavi stopped still.

She had seen that tile since childhood: pale blue flowers around the edges, smooth white at the centre. It was inverted—the stems of the blue flowers pointed upward. There had surely been a reason for it once. Nothing in that house had survived so many years without a reason.

“This…” Madhavi began, and then stopped.

Ira looked at the tile. “Did Nani have it put in like that deliberately?”

“Yes,” Madhavi said at once.

“Why?”

The question remained suspended there in the air.

After the buyers left, Madhavi went straight to Sukanya Kaki next door. Kaki was past eighty, yet her memory was astonishingly sharp. Madhavi brought up the tile.

Kaki burst out laughing. “You’ve forgotten even that?”

“What?”

“Your mother had a gas stove installed for the first time. The mason was setting the tiles. That day your father said every flower must be upright. Your mother deliberately had one fixed upside down. She said, ‘If everything in a house is perfectly straight, people will begin to think themselves gods.’”

Madhavi fell silent.

Kaki went on laughing. “Your father glared at that tile for three days.”

Madhavi could hear the sentence, but not see the scene. She remembered her mother in the kitchen, remembered her father, remembered the wall; but the incident of the inverted tile, which Sukanya Kaki narrated with such ease, stirred nothing inside her.

As soon as she returned home, she told Ira everything.

At first Ira thought it was fatigue. Then she looked at her mother’s face and fell quiet.

“Diwakar pressed it twice,” Madhavi said softly.

Ira looked towards the door. In the fading evening light, the dull button resembled a small eye.

“Twice,” Ira repeated. “If one memory went, what was the other?”

They did not find the answer that night.

In the morning, the answer presented itself.

Ira went to bathe in the old bathroom. Five minutes later she called her mother. A thick iron grab bar was fixed to the wall at waist height. Its paint had worn away, and in the middle the metal shone where hands had rubbed it smooth.

"This was installed for Nanaji, wasn't it?" Ira asked.

Madhavi answered immediately, "Yes."

"When?"

The word caught somewhere inside Madhavi.

She remembered the last two years of her father's life only in blurred fragments—medicines, hospital visits, his evening cough, the chair on the veranda. Ira had been in school then and spent several weeks each summer with her grandparents. But the day this bar was fixed in the bathroom, the first time her father used it to steady himself as he went in, her mother standing outside the door—nothing.

Ira stood holding the bar. "I remember this being here, but I don't remember when it was put in."

Madhavi called her aunt, who had stayed in the house for two months during her father's illness.

"That bar?" her aunt said. "It was installed while I was there. That very day Ira went to the market and chose a pair of rubber slippers for her grandfather."

Ira stood behind the phone, her face drained of colour.

Her aunt suddenly asked, "What has happened to you two?"

Madhavi made an excuse and ended the call.

Now it was no longer a coincidence.

Madhavi brought out a thick notebook. On the first page she wrote: "Memories of the House." Under it she began listing, in order, the incidents she remembered clearly: her mother drying mango pickle, her father listening to cricket on the radio, a quarrel over a severed kite on the roof, her mother's sewing machine in the hall, the brazier on winter nights, Grandmother's low wooden seat beneath the tree at the back, and the year of the flood when a tub in the courtyard had been turned into something like a boat.

Ira added her own memories—potatoes and pointed gourd cooked by Nani, doing homework on the veranda, evening walks with Nana, the red dress Nani had made for a school play, climbing the mango tree for the first time. Some events belonged to Madhavi's childhood, some to Ira's, some to both of them.

Ira photographed every page and sent the images to her friend Tanvi, who had never been to the house. She wrote: "Keep these pages. If I ask, read them back to me."

Ira looked at the button. "Shall we test it once?"

Madhavi was afraid, but alongside the fear was a strange stubbornness. If this was true, it seemed necessary to understand the rule.

“I won’t press it,” she said. “Maybe it affects only those who have lived in this house. Let someone from outside press it.”

At noon Vicky, the teenage milk boy, came. He belonged to a new generation and had no connection with the house’s old stories. Madhavi stopped him at the door. “Press this button once.”

Vicky laughed. “The bell doesn’t ring.”

“Press it anyway.”

He pressed it once.

Nothing happened.

Vicky handed over the milk and left.

Madhavi and Ira went inside and began reading their lists.

First line—Mother’s mango pickle. Clear.

Second—Father’s radio. Clear.

Third—the kite on the roof. Clear.

Fourth—Mother’s sewing machine in the hall.

Madhavi stopped.

The sewing machine stood in the room opposite—black iron, decorated with golden flowers, worked by a foot treadle. She knew her mother had sewn. Her frocks, pillowcases, curtains—everything had been made on it. But when she read the line “Mother’s sewing machine in the hall,” the scene that should have risen before her did not come.

Ira lifted the machine’s cover. Inside lay a reel of red thread and an old pillowcase, half finished.

“Mumma,” Ira said softly, “the red dress?”

Madhavi looked at her.

“No.”

Ira’s eyes filled. “Me neither.”

Together they called Tanvi. Ira said, “Read that line from the list—the school play.”

Tanvi read, “For Ira’s school play, Nani made a red dress. She got the waist measurement wrong twice, and Ira spun around on the stage three times to try it out.”

Ira held the red reel in her hand. “I can hear the words. I can’t see the scene.”

They ended the call.

Madhavi looked towards the doorbell as if it were not a button but someone’s sealed mouth.

“One press—one memory,” Ira said.

Madhavi corrected her. “One memory of the house. Nothing happened to Vicky.”

“But it happened to both of us.”

“Because both of us had lived that moment.”

They decided that no one would press the button again. Madhavi taped a note outside: “BELL OUT OF ORDER. PLEASE KNOCK.”

That night the rain began. Drops kept striking the wooden door. Madhavi could not sleep. How many memories did it take to make a house? Brick, timber, tiles, paint—those might be the body of a house; but what of the moments lived within it? If they were lifted away one by one, would the body left behind still be a house?

At about two in the morning, Ira came to the door of her mother’s room.

“Mumma.”

“Hmm?”

She came in and sat on the floor. In her hand was a photocopy of the list.

“Shall we test it once more?” she asked.

Madhavi shook her head at once. “No.”

“We’ll write everything down first. Tanvi will keep a copy. This time we’ll learn whether the bell erases only things that happened in this house or things from outside it too.”

“The price of finding out is a memory.”

“If we don’t understand the rule, how can we sell the house? Tomorrow some child may press it.”

Madhavi looked at the line in the notebook—Mother’s sewing machine in the hall. The words remained; the scene did not.

“Has the red dress come back to you?” she asked.

Ira was silent.

“Not to me either. Paper saved the event, not the lived moment.”

Ira folded the photocopy. “Then we’re not going to know everything?”

“We don’t need to know everything.”

“But what is this, why is it—”

“The more we press it out of the hunger to understand, the less of the house will remain.”

For a long time Ira stared at the floor. Outside, the rain softened. At last she rose.

“All right. Tomorrow I’ll cover the note with a transparent sheet.”

Madhavi watched her leave. For the first time she understood that preserving a house did not mean preserving only its walls; sometimes it also meant refusing to hunt down the answer to a question.

More people came to see the house the next day. Madhavi warned everyone in advance: “Don’t press the bell. Knock on the door.” Some laughed; some obeyed without asking why.

In the afternoon a woman arrived with her small son. The child was tired after being taken through the house. As everyone stood outside discussing the price, he slipped a finger beneath the paper notice and pressed the button.

Madhavi saw him.

“No!”

It was already too late.

The bell did not ring.

The frightened boy ran to his mother. The woman kept apologising. Madhavi could say nothing. Which memory had vanished from within her was not immediately clear.

The prospective buyers left.

Madhavi and Ira sat down with the notebook. They read it line by line. Everything seemed intact. Then Ira’s finger stopped at one entry.

“‘First letter.’”

Madhavi read it. “What?”

Ira said softly, “You wrote: ‘Madhavi’s first letter—Mother taught her to write it with rice in the courtyard.’ Nani told me this story too.”

Madhavi’s breath caught.

She knew her mother had taught her her letters. But the first letter? The courtyard? Rice? There was no scene.

Ira called Tanvi. “Read the line about the first letter.”

Tanvi read, “Mother drew the letter ‘M’ in a plate of rice. Madhavi traced it from the wrong side. Mother said, ‘A letter is not a road; it is like a house. Learn how to enter it.’”

Tears slipped from Madhavi’s eyes.

That might indeed have been her mother’s sentence—Tanvi was reading from the written page. Ira retained fragments of the story as something she had been told; but Madhavi had nothing: not her five-year-old hand, not the grains of rice, not her mother’s voice.

She began to cry—not loudly, but in silence. Ira sat beside her.

“Paper doesn’t bring a memory back,” Madhavi said.

Ira’s voice broke. “I know.”

“Words survive. Experience doesn’t.”

That evening they decided to remove the bell.

Ira brought a screwdriver. Two rusted screws held the round brass rim. The first came loose with difficulty. When she turned the second, the whole button slackened and came away into her hand.

They stared in astonishment.

There was no wire behind it.

There was not even a hole in the wall through which a wire could have passed.

There was only a round hollow in the wood, about a finger-joint deep. No dust inside it, no insect, no cobweb—as though that little portion had been cut out only yesterday.

"This is impossible," Ira whispered. "The bell was real. Nani used to say the electrician came again and again."

"His name?"

Ira shook her head. "I don't remember."

Madhavi searched for the name as well. Nothing.

Even the story of the bell's installation had now grown indistinct in her mind. Whether the bell itself had eaten that memory, or time had, was impossible to say.

Madhavi took the button in her hand. It was surprisingly heavy. The brass at the back was perfectly flat: no maker's name, no number. Only very fine scratches, visible when light struck at an angle. The marks resembled a count—one, a second, a third... but with breaks between them.

"Should we throw it away?" Ira asked.

Madhavi looked beyond the door towards the drain. Rainwater was moving slowly along it.

She could throw the button away. But fear stopped her. What if it still worked after being separated from the house? What if someone picked it up and pressed it? What if the cause was not the object at all, but simply that place on the door?

"Don't press it," she said. "We'll decide the rest tomorrow."

They put the button in an old steel box, packed cloth over it, and locked the box inside her mother's trunk.

A round empty hollow remained in the door.

The next morning, the first thing Madhavi did after waking was go to the door.

The hollow was gone.

The wood was smooth, as though no button had ever been fixed there.

Madhavi called Ira. Ira came running. Both touched the wood. There was no mark.

"The box," Ira said.

They opened her mother's trunk. The steel box was there. The cloth was inside.

The button was not.

They looked at each other.

Then came knock-knock-knock at the door.

Three times.

Sukanya Kaki stood outside with her walking stick. "Won't you have tea? You've been staring at the door since morning."

Madhavi invited her in. Kaki looked at the wood of the door.

"Oh! Where did the bell go?"

Madhavi and Ira turned towards her together.

"You remember the bell?" Madhavi asked.

"Why wouldn't I? Your father had it installed."

"When?"

Kaki narrowed her eyes. "When your grandmother's hearing had grown weak. He thought a louder bell would help. But once it was installed, it never rang at all. The electrician came five times. In the end your mother said, 'Leave it. Anyone who reaches this house can knock on the door.'"

"Who was the electrician?"

"Bisesar. He had a shop near the station."

The instant Madhavi heard the name, a faint light flickered in her mind—a thin man with a moustache, a coil of wire over his shoulder. The image appeared for a moment, then blurred again.

"Kaki," Madhavi asked, "when that bell was pressed... did anything happen?"

Kaki laughed. "No sound. That was all."

She drank her tea and left.

For a long time Madhavi and Ira said nothing.

Selling the house had become a question again. Ira said, "What if new people live here and the bell appears again?"

Madhavi said, "What am I supposed to tell them? That there is a bell at the door that eats memories?"

"The truth."

"Will they believe it?"

Ira did not answer.

They told Diwakar, the broker, that the old bell had been removed and a new one could be installed later. Nothing more. It was as much truth as the market could bear.

Three days later a family agreed to buy the house—a couple who were both teachers, their two children, and the husband's elderly father. They liked the courtyard, liked the mango tree, and liked the fact that although the house stood in the middle of the city, it was quiet within.

The day for signing the papers drew near.

Madhavi began dividing the belongings. She decided to take her mother's sewing machine with her. Her father's radio was set aside for Ira. The inverted tile stayed in the wall—it would break if they tried to remove it. The iron bar in the bathroom stayed too. Some things are not sold; they are simply left behind.

The notebook now contained twenty-three filled pages. Whenever another memory surfaced, Madhavi wrote it down. But she had already understood that written words were no insurance against forgetting. Paper could draw a boundary around an empty place; it could not restore the scene within it.

On the last evening before they were to leave the house, Ira used her phone to show it to her aunt far away. Madhavi walked from room to room naming things. "This was my room... Grandmother used to sit here... this is the upside-down tile..."

Her aunt asked, "Why was it upside down?"

Madhavi paused. She now knew the reason from Sukanya Kaki's story, not from her own memory.

"Mother had it put in deliberately," she said.

"Why?"

Madhavi smiled. "Kaki says Mother used to say that if everything in a house were perfectly straight, people would start thinking themselves gods."

Ira looked at her mother. Their eyes met for a moment. They both now understood how great a distance lay between "Kaki says" and "I remember."

On the final day all the belongings were loaded onto the vehicle. The new owners would move in two days later. Once the house was empty, its sound changed—the thud of footsteps carried in long echoes. Where a picture frame had been removed, the wall was lighter. A strand of thread clung to a corner of her mother's room. On the veranda were four round marks where the feet of her father's chair had stood.

Ira stepped forward to close the main door.

At that moment Madhavi saw the round dull button again on the wood.

Exactly where it had always been.

Both of them froze.

"This..." Ira's voice would not come.

The button sat there with such naturalness that it was as though everything that had happened between—unscrewing it, locking it in the box, its disappearance—had never happened at all.

Madhavi moved slowly closer. A film of dust lay on the button. Green moss edged its rim. The brass was cold.

Behind her Ira said, “Don’t touch it.”

Madhavi stopped her hand.

Outside the door, the new owner’s elderly father was standing near the gate. He had come to ask about something in the paperwork. When he reached the door, he lifted his hand towards the bell.

Madhavi immediately thrust her hand between them.

“Not this one,” she said.

The old man looked startled. “Is it broken?”

“Yes,” Madhavi said, “and let it stay broken.”

He smiled, perhaps taking it for one of the eccentricities of an old house. Then he raised his fist and knocked three times on the door—knock, knock, knock.

A tremor went through Madhavi’s body.

With those three sounds a scene returned with perfect clarity: she is five years old, rain outside, a paper boat in her hand; the door will not open; her mother calls from within, “Call your name and ring”; she knocks three times; the door opens; her mother wipes her wet hair.

Madhavi held her breath, trying to keep hold of the scene. This was not one of the memories erased by the bell; perhaps it was one that had survived. Perhaps the sound of knocking had opened some locked room inside her.

The old man said again, “There’s one signature left on the papers.”

Ira went outside.

Madhavi turned once and looked back at the house: the empty rooms, the inverted tile, the iron bar, the pale rectangles on the walls, and at the door, the bell that never rang.

She did not press it.

She laid her palm against the door, knocked softly three times—knock, knock, knock—and stepped outside.

STORY 52

The Road That Turned Back

Archana Jha worked at measuring roads, and for that reason she trusted them.

A map could be wrong, a milestone could be old, two villages could have bridges with the same name; but one quality of a road seemed beyond dispute to her—wherever you set out from, it would take you somewhere.

After the first heavy spell of monsoon rain, the district office assigned her to inspect three alternative roads. The waters of the Kamla and Bagmati were rising, one section of the main bridge was closed for repairs, and a new route sheet had to be prepared to show where ambulances, milk vans and school buses could pass in an emergency.

Archana's parents lived in an outlying neighbourhood of Benipur. The office had asked her to stay there that week and measure the roads in the surrounding area. For eight years her job had kept her moving between rented rooms in Patna and Darbhanga; now even five uninterrupted days in the old house felt almost like a holiday.

That afternoon, after lunch, her father said, "The clouds are gathering again. Measure it tomorrow."

Putting her survey notebook into her bag, Archana said, "The water will rise further tomorrow. Why waste today while it's still dry?"

From the veranda her mother called, "Be back before four."

Archana laughed. "I'm going to measure a road, not enter a jungle."

She reset the motorcycle's odometer to zero. On the first page of her survey notebook she had written: Route A: Benipur outer neighbourhood to Shivnagar turn, then along the old canal embankment; estimated total distance, 18.6 kilometres.

As soon as she left the gate, the road turned east. Two hundred metres farther stood a peepal tree, then the milk-collection centre, then a small culvert. Archana had known that sequence since childhood.

Nothing unusual happened during the first five kilometres.

At the sixth kilometre, water shone on both sides of the road. Archana slowed down. At the seventh she passed a new brick kiln. At the eighth, a thicket of bamboo. She entered everything in the survey notebook.

Near the tenth kilometre the road forked. To the right lay newly laid black asphalt; to the left, the old whitish-grey surface. According to the office map, the right-hand road led towards Shivnagar.

Archana turned right.

Three minutes later she felt that the air had suddenly brought her a familiar smell—not boiling makhana, not mud; it was the sharp pre-rain scent of leaves from the guava tree behind her house.

She laughed at herself. Smells had no maps.

The road curved once to the left, then to the right, and crossed a narrow bridge. A small red temple appeared ahead. Archana stopped the motorcycle.

That temple stood half a kilometre west of her house.

She looked in the rear-view mirror. The road behind her ran straight towards the milk-collection centre.

"Impossible," she said softly.

The odometer showed 13.4 kilometres. The normal distance from the house to the temple was 0.6 kilometres.

When Archana reached the gate, her father was sitting on the veranda reading the newspaper.

"Back so soon?"

"I haven't come back," Archana said.

Her father peered at her over his spectacles. "Then what is this?"

Archana did not switch off the motorcycle. "I took the wrong road. I'm going again."

This time she wrote in red ink on the survey page: First circuit, 13.4 km. End point: west gate of home.

The moment she wrote the word circuit, she struck it out. In its place she wrote: route error.

On the second attempt she left home and, at the first turn, went south instead of east. This road led to the market. From the middle of the market, a lane running north joined the canal embankment. It was a longer way, but there was less chance of a mistake.

Archana looked at her watch—3:47.

Fruit sellers, a tea stall, bicycle repair, the smell of vegetables, the cries of hawkers—everything in the market was ordinary. She stopped at one place and bought some lime. The shopkeeper asked, "Whitewashing a wall?"

"Remembering a road."

The shopkeeper laughed. "Is the road going to run away?"

Archana laughed too, though her own laughter tasted faintly bitter.

As she left the market, she marked the first electric pole with a small white circle of lime. At the second turn she drew two lines. Near the canal, three dots. If the route turned her around again, the marks would tell her where she had already been.

Four kilometres on, an old mustard-yellow granary stood by the roadside. At the fifth was a primary school. At the sixth, a broken culvert. The map was correct.

The sky had grown heavy now.

At the seventh kilometre Archana was riding parallel to the canal when a white circular mark flashed on a pole ahead.

She braked.

It was the first electric pole in the market—the one on which she had made the lime mark.

But why was that pole in front of her now?

Archana got down and touched it. The lime was still dry. On the wall of the shop beside it was the same soap advertisement in red letters. The shopkeeper came out and asked, "Come round again?"

"Did I leave from here?"

"Ten minutes ago."

"Which way?"

"Towards the canal."

"And which direction have I come from now?"

The shopkeeper looked down the road behind her. "From the canal."

Archana stared at his face for a moment. There was no curiosity in it. To him, it seemed, both ends of the road simply led towards the canal.

"Where's home?" the shopkeeper asked.

"The outer neighbourhood of Benipur."

"Then keep straight on. You'll be there in half an hour."

"I don't want to go home."

The shopkeeper laughed again. "What can you tell a road?"

Archana did not answer.

She set off marking the road for a third time. This time, instead of a circle, two lines and three dots, she wrote the Maithili numerals ১, ২ and ৩ in sequence. Distance, time, direction of each turn—she recorded everything in the survey notebook.

3:59—১.

4:04—২.

4:11—৩.

At 4:17 she found ১ again—but this time on the other side of the pole.

She parked the motorcycle at the roadside and studied the map for a long while. On paper the line was straight. On the ground the line was catching its own tail.

She opened the map on her phone. The blue dot placed her north of Shivnagar, though the market shop stood directly in front of her. The phone compass pointed north behind her. Archana switched the phone off.

"A machine can go wrong," she told herself. "The earth cannot."

She did not believe that sentence immediately.

Jitan Mian was sitting at the market tea stall. He drove a small goods vehicle and knew every road in the surrounding area by heart. Archana had known him since childhood.

"Jitan Kaka, will you take me to Shivnagar?"

"What about your motorcycle?"

"It can stay here. Take me in your vehicle."

Jitan Mian drained his cup and stood up. "Now?"

"Right now."

Archana left the motorcycle with the shopkeeper and took her survey notebook and the lime with her.

Jitan Mian drove north out of the market. "By the old canal embankment?"

"Yes. But one thing—you choose the road. Don't ask me."

"That is a driver's dream."

He took the first turn to the right, the second to the left. Archana said nothing. Five minutes later the vehicle reached the grain warehouse at Shivnagar. Archana looked at her watch. Everything was right.

Her body relaxed. "All right. Now take the district road."

At the next turn Jitan Mian swung the vehicle around. "Which district road? The eastern one or the station road?"

"The station road. Towards the main office."

Whether anything changed after that answer, Archana could not say. The road was the same. The paddy fields were the same. The betel shop, the peepal beside the pond, the dog, the milk cans on a bicycle—everything was ordinary.

But ten minutes later Jitan Mian pressed the brake.

Ahead stood the west gate of Archana's house.

On the veranda her father had folded his newspaper and risen to his feet.

Jitan Mian sat with both hands on the steering wheel and said nothing.

"Did you take a wrong turn?" Archana asked.

"Me?"

"Yes."

"I took the station road from Shivnagar. I did not miss a single turn on the way."

"Then?"

Jitan Mian looked at the gate and then into the rear-view mirror. “How did my vehicle come here?”

Her father came out onto the road. “What happened?”

Jitan Mian got out and looked around as though someone had lifted the house bodily and set it down in this place.

Archana opened the survey notebook. From Shivnagar to the house, the vehicle’s odometer had advanced 11.2 kilometres. The normal distance was 7.8.

“Let’s go again,” Archana said.

Jitan Mian looked at her. “Where?”

“The station.”

“No.”

“Kaka—”

“If a vehicle breaks down, we repair it. If a road is damaged, people can be told. But when a thing cannot even be understood, testing it again as night is falling is not wisdom.”

Irritation rose in Archana. “Are you frightened?”

“Yes,” Jitan Mian said plainly. “I am frightened. If you are not, perhaps that is your special quality.”

He turned the vehicle around. “I’m going to the market. Are you coming?”

Archana got in.

This time Jitan Mian himself named the destination—“The market.” The vehicle went straight to the market. No loop. No detour.

Archana got down. “Now go to the station by yourself.”

“Why?”

“Just go.”

Jitan Mian shook his head, but he went. Twenty minutes later he phoned. “I’ve reached the station.”

“The road was all right?”

“Perfectly.”

Archana ended the call.

The shopkeeper asked, “Home now?”

“No.”

“Then?”

Archana looked across the road at the paddy fields. From the market to the station there was an old footpath along the field embankments, not a motor road. In childhood people had used it to walk to the weekly market; now fewer people went that way.

She left the motorcycle with the shopkeeper and slung her bag over her shoulder.

"Where are you going?"

"To the station by the field path."

"It's going to rain."

"Let it."

Within the first five hundred metres, mud had climbed the sides of her shoes. The embankment was broad in places and no wider than two feet in others. Newly planted paddy trembled in the water. Lightning flashed in the distance.

Archana kept looking back. The market grew smaller. There was no sign of the house.

A kilometre later she crossed the canal. There was no bridge—only a bamboo footbridge. A motorcycle could not have crossed it.

Reaching the other side, she looked at her watch. In the survey notebook she wrote: 4:58, left the road; 5:23, crossed canal; direction stable.

Writing direction stable made her laugh.

The clouds broke open.

The rain came down so hard that she had to put the survey notebook inside her bag. She ran beneath a dry thatched shelter where two cowherd boys were already standing.

One of the boys asked, "Didi, why did you leave the road and come this way?"

Archana said, "Because the road won't leave me."

Both boys burst out laughing. Archana laughed too. This time the laughter came easily.

When the rain eased, she walked on. In the first darkness of evening she saw the station signboard. At five fifty-six she was standing on the platform.

By road, the station was nine kilometres from the house. Across the embankments and fields, it was roughly five.

Archana bought a ticket—to Darbhanga.

The ticket clerk asked, "Luggage?"

"Only this."

"Motorcycle?"

"It will find its way home," Archana said absently.

The passenger train arrived half an hour late. Archana sat by the window. When the train began to move, a strange relief came over her—as though the metal wheels had simply refused to acknowledge the road's enchantment.

The train passed the edge of the village. Through the window Archana looked towards her neighbourhood in the distance. Behind the curtain of rain, nothing was clear.

On reaching Darbhanga she telephoned her colleague Rashmi.

"I'm near the office. Can I stay in your room tonight?"

Rashmi was startled. "Weren't you in Benipur?"

"I was."

"How are you here?"

"By train."

"That doesn't answer the question."

"For now, that is the only answer I have."

That night in Rashmi's room, Archana spread out her survey notebook to dry. The wet pages had buckled into waves. The sequence of lime marks—1, 2, 3—was still legible. When she added up all the distances, the total came to 41.7 kilometres—and the result, three times, was home.

Rashmi laughed when she first heard the whole story, then stopped when Archana remained silent.

"You must have been tired," she said.

"Ask Jitan Kaka."

"Then both of you were tired."

"The odometer?"

"A machine."

"The lime marks?"

"The wrong pole."

Archana smiled. "Those were all my answers too."

Straightening a pillow, Rashmi asked, "So what will you do tomorrow?"

"Measure the road."

"Which road?"

"I'll go towards home. The road seems to behave properly in that direction."

The next morning Archana reached the office. The maps in the file were checked again. The assistant engineer said that a vehicle had travelled all three routes only the previous week. There had been no loop.

Archana said nothing. She took an office vehicle and told the driver to go to Benipur by way of Shivnagar.

The journey was entirely ordinary.

At half past nine she stood at the gate of her house. Her father's first question was, "Where is the motorcycle?"

"In the market."

Her mother's first question was, "Where were you last night?"

"At Rashmi's."

Their second question was the same—"Why?"

Archana said, “First, one test.”

The office vehicle stood outside the gate. The driver was drinking tea. Archana told him, “Now take me back to the office.”

The driver turned the vehicle around. Her father stood on the veranda watching.

The first kilometre was right. The second was right. At the third, Archana saw the peepal tree that stood near the temple west of the house.

She did not close her eyes.

At the fourth kilometre came the red temple. At the fifth, the gate.

The driver pressed the brake slowly. “Madam, isn’t this your house again?”

Archana looked at her watch. Nine fifty-six.

Her father was still standing on the veranda. There was no curiosity on his face now.

Archana got out of the vehicle.

“Do you understand now?” she asked her father.

Her father looked at the road. “Understand what?”

“Wherever I try to go, the road turns me back here.”

Her mother came as far as the doorway. “Since yesterday?”

“Yes.”

Her mother asked simply, “On foot?”

“On foot I reached the station by the field embankment.”

“Then the fault lies with the road, not with you.”

Archana wanted to laugh at that sentence, but did not.

Her father said, “Leave vehicles alone for a few days.”

“My work is to measure roads.”

“Then measure from somewhere else.”

The sentence was utterly simple. Archana had spent the whole night thinking in such complicated ways that the simple solution felt almost insulting.

Even so, she tried it.

From behind the house she followed the embankment between the fields for half a kos. There a dirt track joined the government road. Archana phoned the driver and called him to that spot.

The vehicle came. She got in.

“Office.”

The vehicle went straight to the office.

All day Archana tested roads from different starting points. Shivnagar to the station, the station to the canal, the canal to the market—every route behaved

normally. The problem arose only when the journey began at the gate of her house and the destination lay outside home.

That evening she defined the limits of the test.

She stepped from the gate onto the road and walked south for ten minutes—then found herself at the temple west of her house.

She walked south for ten minutes along the embankment behind the house—she was in the middle of the paddy fields, exactly where she ought to be.

She came out through the gate onto the road thinking only of going to the market—five minutes later she was home.

She came out through the gate intending to visit the neighbour's house—she reached it, because the neighbour lived only forty paces away on the other side of the road.

From there she set off towards the market—and returned home again.

Archana wrote in the survey notebook: The boundary is not distance. It is the act of 'going outside.'

She stared at the sentence for a long time after writing it. No survey notebook had any place for a statement like that.

For three days she worked alongside this private impossibility. In the morning she walked half a kos along the embankment behind the house, caught the office vehicle on the road, spent the day surveying, and returned home by vehicle in the evening. The return journey was normal every time.

On the fourth day the assistant engineer asked, "Why don't you have the vehicle come all the way to your house in the morning?"

Archana said, "I like walking on the dirt path."

It was not the whole truth, but neither was it a lie.

A week later the alternative-route sheet was ready. The distances of all three roads, the culverts, waterlogging, weak edges—everything had been recorded. Archana did not put the 41.7 kilometres of her first day into any official document.

Only on the last page of her survey notebook did she draw a separate figure: a small square house at the centre, three curved roads around it, every arrow pointing inward. Not one arrow pointed out.

The rains intensified. Twice the water rose over the road, then receded. Repairs to the main bridge were completed. The office work shifted to another area.

Archana decided to return to Darbhanga. She had only one bag of clothes and books. Her mother asked, "When will the vehicle come?"

"It won't come to the house."

Her mother no longer asked questions. She simply packed some fried tilkor leaves into a small box.

Her father reached for the bag to carry it. Archana did not hand it over. "It's only this much."

Outside the gate the road glittered in the sun. It had not rained for three days. There was no water anywhere on the surface. The road looked straight for a long distance—so straight that, for a moment, Archana considered trying once more.

Her motorcycle had been brought from the market and stood by the gate.

She turned the key. The engine came alive.

Her mother waved from the veranda. Her father said, "If you go by the embankment, what about the motorcycle?"

Archana did not answer.

She wheeled the motorcycle onto the road, closed the gate, and set off towards Darbhanga.

Past the first turn.

Past the peepal tree.

Past the milk-collection centre.

Past the small culvert.

Archana's breathing slowly eased. For a moment she thought—the episode is over. Water, exhaustion, direction, machines—perhaps together they had created some confusion which three days of fear had merely prolonged.

Three kilometres on, the road curved left.

Archana saw the red temple ahead.

She did not stop the motorcycle.

She passed the temple. Half a minute later the west gate of the house stood in front of her.

Her mother and father were still standing on the veranda.

Archana switched off the motorcycle. For a few moments no one spoke.

Then she herself began to laugh—a laughter that made her mother laugh too, and then her father. None of them knew what exactly was funny, but the impossibility of the past three days had suddenly become familiar, like an old member of the household.

Archana put the motorcycle inside. She slung the bag over her shoulder.

"Now?" her father asked.

"Now I won't take the road."

She opened the small door at the back of the house. Ahead lay the paddy fields, a narrow embankment running through them, the canal in the distance, and beyond it the dirt track.

Her mother said, "Call when you reach, by evening."

Archana stepped down onto the embankment.

From that day it became her rule. The road was for coming home. The embankment was for leaving home. Half a kos away, the road she joined behaved again like any other road. Whenever she had to go out, she began leaving the motorcycle at the house of an acquaintance in the market.

People asked, “Why walk so far?”

Archana gave different answers. Sometimes exercise, sometimes the need to inspect mud, sometimes convenience with the motorcycle. If she told the real answer, people would laugh, or become frightened, or hunt for an explanation. All three reactions seemed useless to her.

Months passed. The paddy ripened. The embankment dried and turned yellow. The water in the canal fell. Fresh white lines were painted on the road.

One day a new employee from the district office came to Archana’s house to get her signature on some papers. He rode his motorcycle straight to the gate, completed the work, and rode away again along the same road.

Archana watched from the veranda. For him, the road was straight.

That evening Archana had to return to Darbhanga. She lifted her bag, opened the back door, and stepped onto the embankment.

For a moment she turned and looked towards the front gate. Beyond it the road lay straight for a long distance in the last light of the sun. No bend was visible. No circle. No mark.

Even so, Archana knew that within that straight line, for her alone, a curve was hidden.

She walked on along the embankment.

Behind her, the road remained where it was, shining straight.

STORY 53

The Blank Notebook

Govindkant Jha had never been afraid of a blank notebook.

For thirty-eight years he had been looking at blank notebooks.

One had no name on the first page, another no subject, another the wrong date.

He would make a small mark in the margin with his red pen and say, “You can tell how the work will go from the very first page.”

Twelve years after his retirement, on that morning, a brand-new notebook of his own lay before him.

A blue cover, pale blue ruling inside, and a red margin on the left.

The shopkeeper had asked, “Master Sahib, is it for a child?”

He had replied, “No, for me.”

The shopkeeper had not laughed.

He had merely dusted the notebook and slipped it into a paper bag.

Now the notebook lay open on the dining table.

Govindkant sat with his spectacles resting a little low on his nose.

A blue pen in his right hand.

The school’s letter to his left.

Printed on it were the words: Centenary Year of the School’s Foundation.

Former teachers had been asked to contribute a two-page reminiscence.

A suggested subject had been given: “The First Day of My Life as a Teacher.”

Below it was the headmaster’s signature.

After the date, in brackets, were the words: “Please send within seven days.”

Govindkant had bought the notebook three days into those seven.

On the first day, he wrote his name on the cover.

On the second, he wrote the date at the top of the first page.

On the third, he drew a straight line parallel to the red margin.

Today was the fourth day.

The page was still blank.

He placed the point of the pen on the paper.

“The first day of my life as a teacher…”

That was all he said inwardly.

His hand did not move.

He lifted the pen.

Outside the window, two mynas were quarrelling in the guava tree.

Sudha's voice came from the kitchen: "The tea will get cold."

"I'm drinking it now."

"You said 'now' yesterday too."

Govindkant picked up the cup of tea.

The notebook remained open before him.

Sudha came and stood behind his chair.

"Not even one letter?"

"I'm thinking how to begin."

"Write about the first day."

"It is the first day itself that is not clear."

Sudha looked at his face.

"You taught for so many years and forgot the first day?"

Govindkant took off his spectacles and set them on the table.

"I have not forgotten the day. The question is which day was the first day."

Sudha did not understand.

She picked up the empty cup and went away.

Govindkant lifted the pen again.

This time he wrote, "Since childhood I had dreamed of becoming a teacher."

The moment the sentence was complete, his brow tightened.

He put down the blue pen and took out the red one.

Beside the sentence he wrote: "False."

The red word startled even him.

After many years, he was marking a sentence of his own.

He drew a short line beneath the red word.

Then he wrote a second sentence: "Circumstances made me a teacher."

The red pen rose.

"Incomplete."

A third sentence: "The school changed my life."

The red pen: "Easy to say; evidence?"

Govindkant pushed his chair back.

The first page was no longer blank.

Yet to him it seemed emptier than before.

Three blue sentences, three red judgments.

As though a student had copied out every question in an answer book and answered none of them.

He closed the notebook.

Until noon he busied himself with small household tasks.

He arranged the medicine box.

Folded the newspaper and put it away.

Hammered a loose nail into the veranda.

But the blank page kept moving about with him.

At lunch Sudha asked, "Will you go to the school?"

"Why?"

"To check the date. Who knows whether your appointment letter will turn up in the old trunk."

Govindkant stopped with a morsel in his hand.

"It will be in the school register."

"Then go and see."

"Is a reminiscence written by consulting a register?"

Sudha slid the bowl of dal toward him.

"If memory cannot be trusted, a register is not such a bad thing."

Govindkant did not answer.

After lunch he brought out his old cloth bag.

Inside it, the shawl given to him on the day of his retirement was still folded away.

Beneath the shawl he found an old diary.

The year on the first page was 1981.

His appointment had come two years before 1981.

Even so, he opened the diary.

Most of its pages were filled with students' names, examination dates, parent contacts, and household shopping accounts.

On one page he had written: "Mon—Class Seven—map. Wed—example of Mithila painting. Fri—essay again."

Govindkant smiled.

He remembered that lesson on maps.

But not his first day.

On a page near the back of the diary was Sudha's handwriting: "Bring oil in the evening."

He looked at that page for a long time.

How many days of a life remain preserved in such small instructions.

And how many great days pass without leaving behind a single word.

At three o'clock he set out for the school.

The road had changed.

There was now a chemist's shop at the old unpaved turning.

The peepal tree in front of the school was gone.

In its place stood an iron gate, with a cloth banner for the centenary year tied above it.

The watchman seated at the gate stood up at once on seeing him.

"Master Sahib! Pranam."

Govindkant raised a hand in blessing.

The gesture still came from within him without thought.

The headmaster, Niranjan Chaudhary, had not been his student; he was much younger.

Even so, he called him "Sir."

"We are waiting for your piece," Niranjan said.

Govindkant tried to smile.

"Is the piece waiting, or am I?"

Niranjan did not understand the question.

He sent for tea and asked an assistant to open the cupboard containing the old records.

Registers were stacked inside the cupboard.

The edges of some bindings bore the marks of rats' teeth.

Some were stained by damp.

The assistant placed three thick registers on the table.

"1979?"

"Yes."

The pages were turned.

Govindkant's name was found.

"Govindkant Jha—Assistant Teacher—assumed charge: 3 July 1979."

Niranjan said with satisfaction, "See, the first day has been found."

Govindkant kept looking at the date.

"No."

"What?"

"On the third of July I came to the school only to sign the papers."

"Then the fourth of July?"

Govindkant narrowed his eyes.

"Fourth of July… it was raining."

A scene rose from somewhere within him.

A wet courtyard.

Slippers outside the classroom.

Rainwater dripping onto a wooden desk.

A child standing by the window.

But the scene was incomplete.

"It may have been the fourth of July," he said, and at once felt dissatisfied with the sentence himself.

Niranjan turned more pages of the register.

"Attendance?"

In those days teachers' attendance was kept in a separate register.

That register could not be found.

The assistant searched another cupboard.

Old files were opened.

Nothing.

Govindkant felt a strange relief.

As though, in the absence of proof, the question had returned to his own hands.

Niranjan said, "Write the third of July. It is the official record."

Govindkant closed the register.

"Does an official record tell you the first day of a teacher, or the first day of a job?"

Niranjan smiled.

"You can put that question in the piece."

Govindkant remained silent.

On his way out of the school he went toward his old classroom.

The room where he had once taught was now the computer room.

Through the glass in the door he could see machines arranged on small tables.

A student was typing his name on a screen.

When the name was entered incorrectly, a red line appeared beneath it.

Govindkant stopped without meaning to.

The red line.

He remembered the words in his notebook: "False." "Incomplete." "Evidence?"

He crossed the veranda slowly.

An electric bell had replaced the old bell.

But in one corner of the wall an old wooden board still remained.

No one's name could be read in the faded scratches upon it.

Govindkant did not touch it.

Outside the gate was a bicycle-repair shop.

The shopkeeper saw him and said, “Master Sahib, do you recognise me?”

Govindkant stopped short.

The face seemed familiar, but not the name.

“I recognise the face.”

The shopkeeper laughed.

“So the name is gone—I understood that.”

“Tell me.”

“Devanand. I spent two years in Class Eight.”

Something opened inside Govindkant.

“Devanand Mandal?”

“Yes, that same one—the one whose notebook was almost always blank.”

They both laughed.

Pumping air into a bicycle tyre, Devanand said, “Do you still listen to every little thing so carefully?”

“It is a habit.”

“A good habit.”

Govindkant asked, “Do you remember why your notebook used to be blank?”

Devanand stopped pumping.

“I used to work.”

“Where?”

“Here, with my father. At night I would be exhausted.”

Govindkant did not remember this.

He remembered only the blank notebook.

He remembered the red zero.

“Did I ever ask?”

Devanand thought for a few moments.

“Once.”

Govindkant’s throat went dry.

“Then?”

“I told you I did not get the time.”

“What did I say?”

Devanand pressed the tyre again to test it.

“You said, ‘Bring three lines written. Not a whole page.’”

Govindkant held his breath.

“That was all?”

"That was all. For me, that much was a great deal."

A faint satisfaction appeared involuntarily on Govindkant's face.

Devanand noticed it.

"But I did not finish Class Nine," he said casually.

Govindkant's satisfaction stopped where it was.

"You left school?"

"My father fell ill. I had to look after the shop."

"I do not remember that."

"You came to our house twice."

Govindkant stared at Devanand's face.

"Did I try to stop you from leaving?"

"You did."

"Then?"

"The arithmetic at home was different, Master Sahib."

There was no complaint in Devanand's voice.

That made the words sink deeper into Govindkant.

Had he wished, he could have turned this meeting into proof that he had been a good teacher—the advice to write three lines, the journey to a student's house to look for him.

But Devanand stood before him—a school dropout, pumping air into bicycle tyres, managing his life well enough.

No story was giving clear testimony in Govindkant's favour.

Devanand began pumping again.

Govindkant heard no grand expression of gratitude.

No declaration that he had changed a life.

Only three lines.

Govindkant did not remember the incident.

Devanand did.

At that moment Govindkant understood that if he himself remembered every meaning of his life as a teacher, the life would become very small.

Some meanings lived in other people's memories.

Some in papers.

Some nowhere at all.

It was evening by the time he returned home.

Sudha was shelling peas on the veranda.

"Did you find the date?"

"Third of July."

"Then write it."

"That was the first day of the job."

"Of being a teacher?"

Govindkant looked at Sudha.

"You understood?"

"I understood from the beginning."

"Then why did you not say so?"

Sudha dropped an empty pea pod into the bowl.

"When you understand your own question yourself, the answer stays."

Govindkant wanted to take a red pen to that sentence.

But no comment formed in his mind.

After dinner he sat at the table again.

He opened the notebook.

The three blue sentences and three red judgments were still on the first page.

He did not tear the page out.

He capped the red pen and put it away in the drawer.

He took the blue pen in his hand.

He found the first blank line.

For a few moments he sat in silence.

Then he wrote: "On 3 July 1979 I joined this school as an employee."

He paused.

On the next line he wrote: "There is no date in the register for when I became a teacher."

His hand stopped again.

This time he did not look toward the red pen.

On the third line he wrote: "In my first year I knew many answers, but asked few questions."

After that he felt like writing Devanand's name.

Then he stopped himself.

This was not Devanand's story.

Nor was it an occasion for self-praise.

He wrote: "Many years later I understood that it is easy to give a zero when you see a blank notebook; to ask why it is blank is harder."

Govindkant read the sentence.

It seemed too clean to him as well.

Life had not been so clean.

With the blue pen he underlined the word "understood."

Then he added after it: "And I did not understand this all at once."

He leaned back in the chair.

His face was visible in the window glass.

White hair, thin cheeks, two shining frames of spectacles.

He tried to see himself not as Master Sahib, but simply as Govindkant.

It was difficult.

Over so many years, the title had endured more firmly than the name.

He began writing again.

The reason for taking the first appointment—household expenses.

He had accepted the job for three months.

Then he stayed until the next school term.

Then his father's illness.

Then his younger brother was studying.

Then marriage.

Then children.

Then the school's new building.

Then examinations.

Then the flood.

Then a student's admission.

Then another year.

Govindkant stopped in the middle of writing.

He could now see another form of the question.

If becoming a teacher had not been a decision made on the first day, did that mean all the days that followed had been mere compulsion?

He counted the years.

There was no single great moment at which he had declared, "Now I am a teacher."

But on thousands of mornings he had gone to school.

Many times while ill.

Many times in anger.

Many times when he did not feel like going.

Many times with enthusiasm.

On many days he taught well.

On many days badly.

He understood the words of many children.

And failed to understand many others.

He thought: some decisions in life do not happen on the day one signs a paper.

On the page he wrote: “Some decisions are not made on one day; they are made again and again.”

For this sentence he felt no need of the red pen.

Sudha came and set down a glass of water.

“How much have you written?”

“They asked for two pages. It has become five.”

“Then cut it.”

Govindkant laughed.

“For the first time in my life, I do not feel like cutting.”

Sudha laughed too.

“Master Sahib is improving.”

Govindkant stopped his pen.

“Call me Govindkant.”

Sudha looked at him.

“At this hour of the night?”

“Practise.”

Sudha said softly, “Govindkant, go to sleep now.”

Hearing his name felt strange.

As though the door of a very old room had opened.

He did not close the notebook.

He turned to the next page.

There was no separate box at the top for name, subject, or date.

There were only lines.

On the first line he wrote: “From today I will not give marks to my own answers.”

Reading it, he found the sentence a little theatrical.

The red pen was in the drawer.

He did not take it out.

With the blue pen alone, he drew a line through the sentence and crossed it out.

Below it he wrote: “I will read it again tomorrow.”

That was all.

In the morning Sudha found the notebook lying open on the table.

The first page was no longer blank.

But neither was it neat.

Blue, red, crossed out, added, halted—everything together.

Govindkant was sitting outside beneath the guava tree.

There was no newspaper in his hand.

Sudha took the notebook outside to him.

"Will you send this for the centenary volume?"

Govindkant took the pages.

He looked at them for a while.

"Not in this form."

"Then a clean copy?"

He looked at the red words on the first page—False. Incomplete. Evidence?

"No. In a clean copy all this will disappear."

"Then?"

Govindkant opened the notebook again.

He took out a small slip of paper and placed it on the first page.

The school's address was written on it.

"I'll give them this very notebook."

Sudha looked at him in surprise.

"The whole thing?"

"Yes. The headmaster asked for two pages. Let him print two pages. Whether he reads the rest or not is up to him."

"But the first page has been cut and corrected so much."

Govindkant touched the red margin with a finger.

"You can tell how the work will go from the very first page."

Sudha smiled.

Govindkant smiled too.

He closed the notebook, but this time his hand rested on its cover for a few moments.

His name was on the cover.

No class beneath it.

No subject.

Only the name.

For the first time, that blank space did not seem incomplete to him.

STORY 54

One Wrong Word

Vasudha Jha heard the wrong word leave her elder sister's mouth first; its meaning arrived afterward.

Lunch was over.

Saroj Didi was sitting on the chair by the window.

It had been five days since the cataract operation on her right eye.

The doctor had said—do not let direct sunlight fall on the eye, do not lift anything heavy, and do not stay alone for a few days.

So Saroj had left her own home in Madhubani and come to Vasudha's house in Darbhanga.

Vasudha did not think of this arrangement as an arrangement.

To her, Didi had come; that was all.

When Vasudha had been thirteen, Didi had taken her into her home then too.

There had been no doctor's prescription at that time.

There had been no particular day of which one could say—from this day onward, Saroj Didi became like a mother.

Their father died.

Their mother died two years later.

In the years between, Saroj Didi was twenty, but the household accepted her as the grown-up.

Vasudha was the younger one.

Being younger was a kind of right—the right to cry, sulk, study, and fail to understand a question.

For Saroj, being the elder one was not a right but a task.

Vasudha had thought about this many times.

But until today, her thinking had always ended at the same conclusion—Didi did a great deal for me.

There had been no thorn in that conclusion.

It was clean.

Like the steel bowl that shines after being scrubbed clean at the end of a meal.

That day too, Vasudha came out of the kitchen after washing two bowls.

Saroj Didi sat in the chair with her eyes half closed.

She had no kajal on her eyes.

The doctor had forbidden it after the operation.

Without kajal, her face looked to Vasudha like a photograph from childhood.

"Is it time for the medicine?" Saroj asked.

Vasudha looked at the clock.

"Ten minutes to go."

"Not now, just now," Saroj said, laughing.

Vasudha laughed too.

"Ten minutes to go."

"Half your Maithili still lives in the office."

"And half your Hindi still lives in the marketplace."

They both laughed.

This kind of teasing between them was old.

Saroj had married into a family in Samastipur.

After living there for years, many Hindi words had entered her everyday speech.

Vasudha, after spending half her life working in a bank, had spent years listening to the language of forms, branches, accounts, and customers.

Each corrected the other's language, but neither felt insulted.

Words were a game between them.

At least that was what Vasudha had believed until then.

Vasudha placed the small medicine bottle on the table.

"Didi, the doctor says you can go home after seven days, but I say stay for two weeks."

Saroj turned her face toward her.

"If I stay, your work will increase."

"What work?"

"Medicine, meals, drops in my eye, getting up at night to check on me—aren't these all work?"

"These are household things."

Saroj was silent for a few moments.

A vegetable seller's call came from the road outside.

A gate closed at someone's house.

The fan turned slowly.

Saroj stroked the arm of the chair with her fingers.

"For a long time, I have been living on your..."

She stopped.

Vasudha looked at her.

"What?"

Saroj began again.

"For a long time, I have been living on your debt."

The sentence came out naturally.

So naturally that it took Vasudha a moment to understand that it was wrong.

Saroj herself immediately frowned.

"Not debt—support."

She laughed.

"See what my mouth said! I meant support."

Vasudha tried to smile too.

"Yes."

Saroj moved on.

"Support. Now with my eyes, my knees, all this—I have to depend on you."

But Vasudha remained caught inside the first sentence.

Debt.

The word was small.

Only four letters in Maithili.

Not even very far from support.

Change the first vowel and the meaning changed.

Vasudha thought—it was a slip of the tongue.

That was all.

It would be foolish to search for meaning in it.

The ten minutes until the medicine had by then become seven.

She picked up the bottle.

She put the drops into Saroj's eye.

Saroj closed her eyelids.

"Don't open your eye for two minutes," Vasudha said.

"Did the doctor say that, or you?"

"The doctor."

"Then I'll obey."

Vasudha smiled again.

But the word 'debt' did not close its eyes inside her mind.

That night, while cooking dinner, she thought for the first time—when Didi paid my school fees, was that a debt?

The question seemed so indecent that she immediately grew angry with herself.

Didi had paid the fees because there had been no one else in the house.

That was all.

At the time, Saroj had sold two of her glass bangles.

Vasudha had learned this much later, not from her mother but from a neighbour auntie.

Saroj herself had never mentioned it.

Would someone who keeps accounts of debts hide the story of selling her bangles?

Vasudha added salt to the lentils.

The answer seemed clear.

No.

But in the next moment another memory came.

In the month of Vasudha's first salary, Saroj had asked for a sari.

Jokingly she had said, "Now the little one earns; my account will be settled."

Everyone had laughed.

Vasudha too.

Had that been only a joke?

The lentils began to boil over.

Vasudha lowered the flame.

She felt ashamed of her question.

It was not right to change the meaning of thirty-year-old laughter because of one wrong word.

She decided—tonight I will not think about this again.

Ten minutes later she was thinking about it again.

When Saroj's son Raghav had studied engineering in Darbhanga, he had lived in Vasudha's house for two years.

Vasudha had kept him like her own son.

His food, clothes, fee dates, fever—she had attended to everything.

Saroj would often say, "You have taken half my work upon yourself."

At the time Vasudha had felt proud.

Today an invisible account opened behind that sentence.

Two years of meals in exchange for two bangles?

Raghav's room in exchange for school fees?

Drops in Saroj's eye in exchange for the nights Saroj stayed awake during their mother's final illness?

Vasudha stopped while serving the plates.

The arithmetic was repulsive.

And, though repulsive, very simple.

That simplicity frightened her.

"What happened?" her husband Naresh asked.

"Nothing."

"Too much salt?"

"No."

Naresh tasted the lentils.

"They're fine."

Saroj was eating slowly.

Since the operation, bright light troubled her.

Vasudha switched off the main light and lit the smaller lamp.

Saroj said, "You remember everything."

Vasudha's hand stopped for a moment.

Everything?

Even the debt?

She said nothing.

After dinner Vasudha opened her household expense book.

The habit came from her bank job.

Milk, vegetables, electricity, medicines, domestic help—everything was written down.

After Saroj's operation she had opened a new page.

At the top she had written—"Didi—medicines/check-ups."

Below were five entries.

Medicine 1,280.

Dark glasses for the eye 350.

Car 600.

Two consultation fees.

Until then those amounts had meant only expenses.

Today the heading 'Didi' looked like an account.

Vasudha closed the book.

That night she did not fall asleep for a long time.

Naresh asked, "Didi's eye is all right, isn't it?"

"Yes."

"Then?"

"Nothing."

Naresh turned over.

Vasudha kept looking at the ceiling in the dark.

It seemed to her that after a wrong word, silence too becomes a word.

The next morning, while drinking tea, Saroj said, "There's less sugar today."

Vasudha started.

"Less?"

"Yes, but it's fine."

Saroj's voice was ordinary.

Vasudha wanted to laugh at herself.

In a single day she had begun weighing every sentence Didi spoke.

"Where is the medicine kept?"

Was that dependence?

"You've grown tired?"

Was that guilt?

"Did Raghav call?"

Was that accounting?

Once language falls under suspicion, even ordinary questions begin to look like documents.

Vasudha was troubled by this.

She left the kitchen work and went to the veranda.

Saroj was sitting there in the shade, out of the sunlight.

An old woollen shawl lay in her lap.

She was pushing a loose thread at its corner back in with her finger.

Vasudha remembered—Saroj had given her this shawl at her wedding.

She had said then, "It isn't expensive, but it will keep you warm."

Vasudha had said, "Why such a large shawl for me?"

Saroj had answered, "In your husband's home, your own covering should never be too small."

The sentence had been humorous then.

Today Vasudha wondered—had Didi known the price of the things she gave?

At once she thought—of course she had.

Whoever buys a thing knows its price.

Knowing a price is not the same as keeping an account.

It took Vasudha half a day to arrive at that small distinction.

In the afternoon Raghav called.

Saroj put the phone on speaker so everyone could hear.

"Ma, are you taking your medicines on time?" Raghav asked.

"Your aunt has turned me into a child."

"Be one. For a few days."

"Yes, now I am a burden on everyone..."

Saroj stopped.

Vasudha's ears sharpened slightly.

"Not a burden," Saroj corrected herself, "I meant dependent."

Raghav laughed.

"Ma, your tongue slips a lot these days."

Saroj laughed too.

"Effect of age."

Vasudha did not laugh.

After the call ended she asked, "Didi, do your words really slip this much?"

Saroj looked over her glasses.

"What?"

"Yesterday you said debt instead of support. Today you almost said burden."

Saroj said casually, "It's a mouth. It makes mistakes."

"Yes."

Vasudha wanted the question to end there.

It did not.

Saroj kept looking at her face.

"You've been stuck on this since yesterday?"

Vasudha was silent.

The smile left Saroj's face.

"Oh, I meant support."

"I know."

"Then?"

Suddenly Vasudha felt thirteen years old again.

At that age too she used to fall silent like this before asking Didi a difficult question.

"Didi, did you ever feel that I owed you a great deal?"

Saroj's fingers became still on the loose thread of the shawl.

She did not answer at once.

At that delay, something sank inside Vasudha.

Saroj asked, "What do you mean by 'owe'?"

"That you did so much for me. Later I kept Raghav with me, I run around for your treatment... as though all of it were an account."

Saroj slowly folded the shawl.

"You made this account?"

The question came back at her.

Vasudha was startled.

"Me?"

"Yes. Yesterday I only said one wrong word. You spent the whole night making a ledger out of it?"

Vasudha grew irritated.

"Don't make fun of me."

"I'm not making fun of you."

Saroj's voice was gentle.

"You remembered the school fees?"

Vasudha did not answer.

"The bangles?"

Vasudha looked at her.

"How did you know?"

"Auntie told you. I knew she had."

At those few words, the old story changed again for Vasudha.

Didi had known that Vasudha knew about the bangles.

Then Didi's silence was not necessarily the silence of sacrifice; it could have been a decision not to repeat the story again and again.

Saroj said, "What I did then was what the house needed then."

Vasudha said, "But you left your studies."

"Yes."

"For me."

Saroj lowered her eyes.

"For you too. For the house too. And because of my own fear too."

"Fear?"

"I myself didn't know what I would do by going to college. After Babuji died, I lost the courage to leave the house."

Vasudha sat stunned.

The story she had carried all her life was—Didi gave up her studies for her younger sister.

Saroj was now saying—the reason had not been one thing.

This answer did not make the sacrifice smaller.

But the clean line blurred.

Vasudha was uncomfortable with such blurring.

In a bank, money is either a deposit or a withdrawal.

At home, the same amount can carry many names.

Saroj said, "You kept Raghav for two years. Was that to repay what you owed me?"

"No."

The answer came at once.

"Then?"

"He was a child. He was studying. It was convenient for him to stay with me."

"That's all."

Saroj pushed the loose thread of the shawl in again.

"For me too, at that time, there was what was convenient, what was responsibility, what was love—it was all mixed together."

Vasudha said nothing.

Saroj added, "Some love is not pure. Work, fear, habit, responsibility—everything stays mixed into it."

The sentence felt heavy to Vasudha.

She wanted Didi to say—'No, there is no debt at all.'

A clean answer.

Saroj did not give that answer.

The afternoon passed.

In the evening Vasudha opened the expense book again.

At the top it said—"Didi—medicines/check-ups."

She picked up her pen.

For a few moments the nib rested on the word 'Didi.'

She did not cross it out.

Below it she wrote a new entry—"Eye drops—480."

Then she closed the book.

She understood that crossing out a heading would not erase the accounting inside it.

Even acting against accounting can become another form of accounting.

Over the next two days Saroj's eye improved.

She began walking from the veranda to the courtyard without support.

Vasudha watched from a distance.

As before, she felt the urge to hurry over and take her hand.

Twice she restrained herself.

The third time Saroj herself said, "Give me your hand."

Vasudha gave it.

That small incident made something new visible to her.

It seemed to Vasudha that when Saroj asked for her hand, the meaning of the hand she held was different from the hand Vasudha had stopped herself from offering the first two times.

She did not feel the need to name that difference.

She simply kept the difference in mind.

After that she continued watching Saroj's steps, but did not immediately extend a hand.

On the seventh day the doctor said, "The wound is healing well. She can go home after two more days."

Saroj was pleased.

Vasudha said, "After two days?"

"Yes."

A small emptiness rose inside her.

She did not again insist that Saroj stay two weeks.

On the morning of her return, Saroj packed her clothes.

She folded the shawl.

She put the medicine bottle in a separate bag.

She put on the dark glasses.

Vasudha was in the kitchen wrapping parathas for the journey.

From inside Saroj called, "Little one, this medicine is three times a day, right?"

"Yes."

"And the one with the red cap at night?"

"Yes."

"Write it down."

Vasudha wrote it on a piece of paper.

Saroj folded the paper and put it in the bag.

Then she said, "You are so much my..."

Vasudha looked toward her instinctively.

Saroj smiled.

"Don't worry. This time I'll think before I choose the word."

Vasudha laughed too.

Saroj said slowly, "You are my support."

The word was correct.

The pronunciation was clear.

The meaning too ought to have been clear.

Yet strangely, to Vasudha that sentence felt smaller than yesterday's 'debt.'

Perhaps the wrong word had opened more rooms than the right one.

She said, “Didi, a house rests on support. But a house is not only its support.”

Saroj raised an eyebrow.

“Is that bank language or philosophy?”

Vasudha laughed.

“I don’t know.”

“Then leave it.”

They both laughed again.

The car arrived.

Naresh loaded the luggage.

Saroj sat inside.

Vasudha stood at the gate.

The car turned away.

The house suddenly became quiet.

Vasudha went inside.

The chair was empty.

There was half a glass of water on the table.

One of Saroj’s hairs was caught on the back of the chair like a thread from the shawl.

Vasudha removed it.

In the afternoon she opened the expense book.

The page headed ‘Didi—medicines/check-ups’ was before her again.

She could have totalled it.

Adding five amounts was not difficult for a bank employee.

She did not add them.

Nor did she tear out the page.

She closed the book and put it in the cupboard.

Three days later Saroj called.

“Little one, I can see clearly now.”

“Very good.”

“I’m taking the medicine on time.”

“Good.”

“And listen.”

“Yes?”

“Yesterday Raghav was saying—Ma, when will we repay what we owe Mausi?”

Vasudha’s body tightened slightly.

Saroj laughed.

"I scolded him. I told him, from now on think before using that word in this house."

Vasudha was silent.

Saroj's laughter slowly faded.

"You've started thinking again?"

Vasudha looked toward the window.

Clothes were drying outside.

"Yes, but not as before."

"What are you thinking?"

Vasudha searched for an answer.

A week earlier she would have said—nothing.

Today she said, "I think a wrong word sometimes opens the wrong place."

Saroj was silent.

"And the right word?"

Vasudha said, "It may sometimes close the door."

At the other end of the phone Saroj laughed softly.

"You've begun thinking too much."

"You said one wrong word."

"My fault."

"No."

Vasudha said this 'no' slowly.

She understood that to search for fault would be to open the ledger again.

"Didi?"

"Yes?"

"When you paid my school fees, were you afraid then?"

There was silence on the phone for a few moments.

"Very," Saroj said.

"Of what?"

"That the next month I wouldn't know where the money would come from."

For the first time Vasudha imagined that answer.

In memory she kept looking at the bangles.

Earlier, the bangles had been a sign of sacrifice.

Now fear existed inside them too.

Adding fear did not reduce the love.

It made it more human.

Vasudha said, “I understood nothing then.”

“You were a child.”

“And now?”

Saroj laughed.

“Even now, you understand a great many things only partly.”

Vasudha laughed too.

After ending the call she stood by the window.

She remembered yesterday’s correct word—support.

Then the wrong word—debt.

The two words no longer cancelled each other out.

There was some open space between them.

In that space were school fees, bangles, Raghav’s two years, eye medicine, fear, convenience, habit, love.

So many things could not fit into a single word.

Vasudha went to the kitchen.

The expense book lay on the table.

She opened it.

It was time to begin the page for a new month.

She wrote the date at the top.

Then the first item—milk.

The second—vegetables.

The third—medicine.

She did not create a separate heading called ‘Didi.’

Nor did she alter the old page.

She let both remain truths of their own time.

She capped the pen.

The phone rang again from outside.

Vasudha paused for a moment before getting up.

She did not know whether Didi was on the other end or someone else.

This time she did not guess.

She answered the phone.

“Yes, tell me.”

STORY 55

Before the Lamp Went Out

The first day, the white line drawn across the middle of the courtyard seemed very thin to Kusum Jha.

The mason had dipped a string in limewash, stretched it taut between two ends, and snapped it against the ground.

For an instant, the string trembled.

Then a straight white mark appeared on the red-brick floor.

“From here?” Kusum had asked.

Rolling up his measuring tape, the mason had said, “This is where it is on the papers.”

This is where it is on the papers.

After those five words, the courtyard had split into two parts.

The portion on the left belonged to Kusum’s husband, Naresh.

The portion on the right belonged to his younger brother, Mahesh.

The house was old.

The walls were thick.

The veranda was long.

The courtyard in the middle was square.

Naresh and Mahesh’s father had inherited this house from his own father.

For years, the shares had been recorded on paper, but there had been no line on the ground.

As long as Babuji was alive, no one had even raised the matter of drawing one.

For two years after his death, too, everything went on as before.

Then the two brothers sat down to calculate the education of their sons and daughters, loans, repairs, taxes, and the future.

The matter had not begun with a quarrel.

It had begun with clarity.

“What belongs to whom should remain clear,” Naresh had said.

Mahesh had agreed.

Kusum, too, had agreed.

Meenakshi—Mahesh’s wife—had been the first to say, “If everything stays clear, there will be no questions among the children later.”

The papers were taken out.

The old measurements were checked again.

For two days, the record-keeper came.

One day, the mason came.

Then came the lime line.

After the line was drawn, Kusum's first surprise was how quickly the places in the house that had seemed to her like one thing could become two.

Before, there had been "the tap."

Now there were "our tap" and "their tap."

Before, there had been "the veranda."

Now there were "this side of the veranda" and "that side of the veranda."

Before, there had been "the clothesline."

Now there were two clotheslines.

Before, the pickle jars were placed wherever the sunlight was best.

Now, before setting down a jar, one looked at the line.

The line was very thin.

But the language of the house kept making it thicker.

In the first week, Kusum left her slippers on the wrong side three times.

"Auntie, these are your slippers!" Mahesh's daughter Tanvi had said, laughing.

Kusum had laughed too.

After that, she began leaving her slippers beside the pillar of her own veranda.

Once, Meenakshi's brass lota wandered over to this side of the line.

Kusum picked it up and placed it back on the other side.

Meenakshi said, "Let it stay there. What harm does it do?"

Kusum had replied, "Now that things have been decided this way, let them remain this way."

There was no anger in that answer.

There was order.

Kusum liked order.

She liked clothes folded neatly.

She liked the grain tins labeled by name.

She liked keys on their own hooks.

Spices in their own containers.

Money in its own purse.

Work at its proper time.

The line did not oppose this temperament; it seemed almost an extension of it.

And yet, in some places, the line snagged against daily life.

The courtyard drain ran diagonally.

Rainwater flowed from the right-hand corner toward the drain by the left gate.

The old tap stood a hand and a half on the other side of the line.

The tulsi altar stood on this side.

But the little brass bowl used for filling water at the altar had for years remained beside the tap.

"Whose is this?" Tanvi once asked jokingly.

Kusum had tapped her lightly on the head.

"Whose can water for tulsi be?"

Tanvi burst out laughing.

"Look at the papers."

Everyone laughed.

Some things could still make a joke of the papers.

But gradually the jokes became fewer.

There had already been two separate kitchens, because Naresh's work hours and Mahesh's shop hours were different.

Now even the movement between the two kitchens diminished.

Before, if Meenakshi ran out of salt, she would take a pinch from Kusum's jar without asking.

Now she stood at the doorway and asked.

Before, if Kusum saw the lentils boiling on Meenakshi's stove, she would lower the flame.

Now she stopped her hand.

"That is her work."

With that sentence, many small hands began to stop.

Whether Kusum liked this or not, she herself could not say clearly.

Often, she felt relief.

Why should every task be hers?

At other times, an emptiness.

If a task was not hers, why should her eyes go there either?

Eight months passed.

The lime line was wiped away many times.

Then drawn again.

In the rains, half of it vanished.

Naresh mixed lime and straightened it himself.

"Once the wall is built, we won't have to keep drawing the line again and again," he had said.

The wall had been part of the plan from the beginning.

It was to be built when enough money had been saved.

A wall three hands high.

Low enough for air and light to pass across the courtyard, but high enough to keep the division clear.

Kusum agreed with this too.

"A low wall is fine," she had said.

Meenakshi said, "Should there be a small gate in the middle?"

Naresh had immediately replied, "Why a gate? Then it will become the same coming and going again."

Mahesh had remained silent.

Kusum too had said nothing.

Meenakshi changed the subject.

The day for building the wall was fixed—the last Monday of Kartik.

Two evenings before that, the electricity had begun going off repeatedly.

Whenever the power failed in the old house, a brass lamp was brought out.

It was not a ritual lamp.

It was simply the house's old source of light.

When Kusum's mother-in-law had first come to this house as a new bride, the lamp had already been there.

A thick, round belly.

A broad rim.

On one side, a spout-like groove for holding the wick.

A cotton wick in mustard oil.

When the electricity went, the lamp was placed beside the pillar between the veranda and the courtyard.

From there, a little light reached both sides.

Once battery lamps arrived, the brass lamp was needed less often.

Even so, during long cuts, Kusum still took it out.

The battery ran the fan.

And a small bulb.

But Naresh would say, "It is good to keep the old lamp. You cannot trust the electricity."

Kusum kept the lamp clean.

It had no glass, so there was little soot.

She trimmed the wick.

The oil tin was kept separately.

And the little lid used for putting the lamp out had its own place.

She never blew out the flame.

She simply lowered the small round brass lid over it.
Within two breaths, the flame shrank.
Then darkness.
That Saturday evening, the electricity went out at seven.
Within half an hour, the battery began giving its warning beep.
“The battery has grown weak,” Naresh said.
Mahesh lit a small battery lamp on his side.
Kusum brought out the brass lamp.
She set it on the little platform beside the old pillar near the line.
The pillar stood on this side.
So did the lamp.
But its light did not obey the line.
The yellow circle fell over both portions.
Tanvi brought her book to the light.
“Auntie, may I study here for five minutes?”
Kusum said, “Sit.”
Tanvi placed her low stool on her own side of the line and sat down.
The lamp was in the middle.
Her brother Neel came too.
“I have writing to do.”
From the doorway, Meenakshi said, “You have your own light, don’t you!”
Neel replied, “That light hurts my eyes.”
Kusum laughed.
Naresh arrived with the newspaper.
“The letters are still clearer in the light of this lamp,” he said.
“Then why are you wearing spectacles?” Kusum asked.
Naresh laughed.
Mahesh arrived a little later as well.
Four people were sitting on both sides of the line.
The lamp was making a pool of light in the middle.
For a moment, the scene looked to Kusum as it had in the old days.
Then her eyes dropped.
In the yellow light, the lime line looked even whiter.
As though the lamp were not erasing it but bringing it into sharper relief.
Tanvi closed her book.
“Auntie, the wall will start going up on Monday, won’t it?”

"Yes."

"Then I won't be able to sit here and study?"

Kusum replied naturally, "You'll sit on your own side."

Tanvi said nothing.

Neel said, "Then there will be separate light on each side."

Mahesh gave him a light tap on the head.

"You understand too much."

Kusum did not laugh at that sentence.

She began watching the lamp's wick.

At nine, the electricity had still not returned.

Dinner was cooked separately in the two kitchens.

Even so, the lamp in the courtyard kept burning.

At ten, Tanvi went back to her side.

Neel had already gone to sleep.

Mahesh went to his room with the shop accounts.

Meenakshi began washing the dishes.

Kusum put her own kitchen in order.

She gave Naresh his medicine.

She checked the doors.

She closed the oil tin.

Now only the lamp remained in the courtyard.

Power-cut darkness altered the old architecture of the house.

The veranda pillars looked thicker.

The doorways deeper.

The corners of the courtyard farther away.

The lime line shone in one place in the yellow light and disappeared into shadow in another.

Kusum pulled over a low stool and sat beside the lamp.

She wanted to think about Monday's wall.

But her thoughts did not move in a straight line.

She remembered that on the first day after the line was drawn, Meenakshi had forgotten her broom on this side.

The broom had lain in Kusum's veranda for three days.

No one noticed.

Then one day Kusum had picked it up and placed it on the other side.

She remembered that last Phagun, Tanvi had fallen ill.

In the middle of the night Meenakshi had knocked at Kusum's door looking for medicine.

The line had been there that night.

But Kusum, running over with the medicine, had not even looked at it.

Then she remembered that two months earlier Meenakshi had placed a pickle jar on this side to turn it into the sun.

That day Kusum had stopped her.

"Look at the line."

Meenakshi had picked up the jar.

Kusum wondered: why was the line invisible on the night of a sick child?

And why was it visible on an afternoon with a pickle jar?

No answer came at once.

The lamp flame leaned slightly.

Kusum looked at the wick.

The oil was low.

She thought, I won't add any more now.

Everyone is going to bed.

I'll put the lamp out.

She stood up.

The brass lid was kept in the niche in the pillar.

She reached for it.

Just then she heard the tap dripping on the other side.

It seemed Meenakshi had not shut it completely.

Drip.

Drip.

Drip.

At first Kusum thought, "It is their tap."

Then she thought, if it drips all night, water will collect and keep the drain wet.

She thought of calling Meenakshi.

"Meenakshi!"

The call had risen only halfway up her throat.

Just then the lamp flame became very small.

Kusum was about to reach for the lid.

The flame turned blue once.

Then thin and yellow.

Then, without wind and without breath, it went out on its own.

Darkness came so quickly that Kusum's raised hand remained suspended in the air.

For an instant she could not even see her own palm.

The smell of hot lamp oil remained.

The drip of the tap sounded clearer.

Kusum stood still.

She knew where the matches were.

On the kitchen wall, above the small box.

The phone was inside too.

She could call Naresh.

But Kusum did nothing.

Drip.

Drip.

Drip.

She began walking toward the tap.

Her first step avoided the edge of the pillar's little platform.

Her second fell on the crack where, years earlier, one brick had sunk slightly.

Her third crossed the narrow run of the drain.

Kusum was not thinking.

Her body was walking.

Her hand stretched forward.

It found the cold iron mouth of the tap.

She turned it shut.

The dripping stopped.

In the darkness, the silence suddenly became enormous.

Kusum's hand was still on the tap.

Then she realized—she was standing on the other side of the line.

Even after that thought came, the line itself was invisible on the ground.

Kusum did not try to find it with her foot.

She simply stood there.

She realized that on the way to the tap, her body had not hesitated even once.

The line existed in memory.

But not in the map of her feet.

Her feet were still walking through the courtyard they had known before the lime line.

One pillar.

One sunken brick.

One drain.

One tap.

One path.

The papers said there were two shares.

The body was still reading a single courtyard.

Something became clear to Kusum not all at once, but very slowly.

She was not against the wall.

She liked the shares to be clear.

She understood that for the future of Naresh's and Mahesh's children, the papers needed to be unambiguous.

But for the last eight months she had also been doing something else—trying to carry the paper's line fully into her memory, her hands, her voice, and her gaze.

Even where the papers said nothing.

The tap was "theirs."

The jar was "theirs."

The flame under the lentils was "theirs."

The child's book was "theirs."

The sunlight on the veranda was "ours."

The pillar's shadow was "ours."

She understood that creating order and cutting through history were not the same act.

She had mistaken them for one.

The darkness had made that distinction clearer than light.

Kusum removed her hand from the tap.

At that moment, the door to Meenakshi's kitchen opened.

"Who is it?"

Meenakshi's voice was heavy with sleep.

Kusum said, "It's me. The tap was dripping."

"You're over there?"

Kusum paused for two moments before answering.

"Yes."

Meenakshi switched on the small light of her phone.

A faint white glow spread across the courtyard.

The lime line became visible again.

Kusum really was standing on the other side.

Her right foot was nearly two hands inside the line.

Meenakshi looked at her.

Kusum looked at the line.

Neither of them said "the wrong side."

Meenakshi only asked, "Did the lamp go out?"

"The oil ran out."

"Shall I give you a light?"

Kusum said, "No. I know the way."

With that she turned.

The phone light remained in Meenakshi's hand.

Kusum deliberately did not look toward it.

She returned in the same three steps.

The drain.

The sunken brick.

The pillar.

This time the line was visible, but Kusum did not pause her foot while crossing it.

Back on her side, she touched the brass body of the lamp.

It was still warm.

The lid was no longer needed.

She left it where it was.

From inside, Naresh asked, "Did you put the lamp out?"

Kusum said, "It went out by itself."

"You should have checked the oil."

Ordinarily Kusum would have replied, "I'll fill it tomorrow."

But she only said, "Yes."

That night, as he was falling asleep, Naresh said, "The mason will come at seven on Monday."

"Yes."

"We'll have to mark the line clearly again. Half of it has faded."

Kusum lay looking at the ceiling in the dark.

"Won't he understand the line from the papers?"

"He will, but having the mark on the ground will make it easier."

Kusum said nothing.

Soon Naresh fell asleep.

Kusum had no grand decision in mind.

She was not thinking of stopping the wall.

Nor of erasing the line.

Nor of once again borrowing salt from Meenakshi as in the old days.

She understood only that in eight months she had given a thin line far too many additional meanings.

A boundary of ownership.

A boundary of work.

A boundary of memory.

A boundary of sympathy.

A boundary of sight.

She had laid them all on the same line.

In the darkness, her body had refused to carry that burden.

The next morning, Kusum cleaned the lamp.

She trimmed the charred end of the wick.

She filled it with oil.

She wiped its brass belly with a cloth.

Then she put the lamp back in its old niche.

In the morning light, the lime line looked pale.

While drinking tea, Naresh said, "We'll have to bring lime today."

Kusum said, "Bring it."

At that moment Meenakshi was filling a bucket at the tap.

When the bucket was full, she shut the tap completely.

Without thinking, Kusum looked toward the tap.

Meenakshi looked toward her too.

Whether either of them smiled was difficult to say.

Their eyes simply met.

On Monday, the mason arrived.

Sand.

Mortar.

Bricks.

Measuring tape.

Naresh and Mahesh both stood in the courtyard.

The mason looked at the old line.

"The wall goes on this?"

Naresh said, "Yes."

The mason took out his string.

Kusum stood at the doorway of her kitchen.

Meenakshi stood on her side.

The string was pulled taut.

Straight from the tap to the gate.

Then the mason stopped.

"There's one thing," he said.

"What?" Mahesh asked.

"This drain runs diagonally through here. If the wall is closed all the way down, it will be hard to clean. We'll have to leave an opening at the bottom."

Naresh said, "Put in a small pipe."

The mason looked at the ground.

"Rubbish will get stuck in a pipe. Better to leave it wide enough for a hand to go through."

Mahesh said, "Then leave it."

Naresh thought for a moment.

"How much?"

The mason showed the measure with his hand.

"This much. We'll leave out two bricks."

Kusum came out of the kitchen.

"Leave a little more," she said.

Everyone looked at her.

Kusum pointed toward the drain.

"So a broom can go through by hand. The drain fills up often."

Naresh said, "Four bricks?"

"Three are enough."

The mason nodded.

"All right."

That was all.

No one called it a symbol.

No one said the house had become one again.

By afternoon, half the wall had risen.

Three hands high.

Near the drain, an opening three bricks wide.

A person could not pass through that opening.

A hand could.

A broom could.

Water could.

After the mason left in the evening, Kusum stood beside the wall.

The courtyard now truly looked like two parts.

The line had become a wall.

Whether she felt sorrow, she could not tell at once.

But one thing was clear—the words on the papers had now acquired a body of brick.

Tanvi peered over from the other side.

"Auntie!"

The three-hand-high wall came just below her chin.

"What?"

"Can I sit here and study?"

Kusum looked at the top of the wall.

"You can put your book on it."

Tanvi tried setting the book there.

It was thick enough.

"It has made a good table."

Kusum laughed.

That night the electricity went out again.

Kusum brought out the brass lamp.

The old pillar's platform now lay on this side of the wall.

She placed the lamp there as before.

The flame caught.

The yellow light climbed to the top of the wall.

On the other side, the edge of Tanvi's book gleamed.

The sound of Meenakshi's dishes came across.

Naresh was searching for the newspaper.

Mahesh was speaking to a customer on the phone.

The house went on doing its separate work in its two halves.

Kusum checked the oil in the lamp.

This time there was enough.

At ten, the house grew quiet.

Kusum lifted the lid to put the lamp out.

Before lowering it over the flame, her eyes went to the three-brick opening at the bottom of the wall.

Through it, a thin piece of darkness from the other side was visible on this side.

A little water shone in the drain.

Kusum slowly lowered the lid over the lamp.

The flame grew small.

The wall's shadow deepened.

The yellow light contracted.

Then the lamp went out.

This time the darkness was not unexpected.

Kusum stood still.

She could not see the tap.

Nor the drain.

The line had now become a wall.

But she knew where everything was.

She turned toward her own side.

Her feet found the right path.

Behind her, through the three-brick opening, came the faintest sound of water.

Kusum did not feel any need to stop it.

STORY 56

The Night Boat

After evening fell, the colour of the water could no longer be made out. After a day of rain, the Kamla River had merged fields, footpaths, and courtyard boundaries into a single muddy sheet. From the high bamboo platform in Mahua Tola, people could see only two or four lamps flickering in the distance, marking where houses stood amid the water.

Jagrnath Mallah ran his hand along the belly of his small boat. Made from old bamboo planks, it had already carried people in three trips to the high road that day. A strip of cloth had been stuffed into one split, where water kept seeping in. His son Deepak continued bailing it out with a bowl.

"We are not going again," Jagrnath said. "It is getting darker. The current is stronger too."

Deepak nodded in agreement. The exhaustion of the day trembled in his arms. Fifteen or twenty people were on the platform. Some had houses completely submerged, some half; someone had left a cow tied behind, someone sacks of paddy. But by evening everyone had understood that taking a boat out at night was not merely taking out a boat—it was weighing lives.

Just then a voice came from the east—unclear at first, then again.

"Hey, Jagrnath!"

Someone raised a lamp below the bamboo platform. The voice came again. "The elder daughter-in-law's labour pains have started!"

Whispers began through the hamlet. The voice was coming from Ramcharan's house. His home stood below the embankment, near the river's old channel. Ramcharan had come to the platform during the day, but his pregnant daughter-in-law Sunita had refused to leave the house. She had said, "The water will go down in two days."

Jagrnath closed his eyes and listened for a few moments. The voice broke apart in the wind. Then a woman's groan came through clearly.

Deepak said softly, "Babu, we have to go."

Jagrnath did not answer at once. His eyes went to the boat. "No more than four people. And not through the middle of the current—we'll take the side route."

Suresh Mandal, the mukhiya's representative sitting on the platform, stood up. "I'll go. There's an old date palm near Ramcharan's house. We can hold the boat there."

Harinarayan Sahu rose as well. His shop was at the bend in the road, and his wife and two children were stranded on the roof of their house. All day he had kept saying that his family should be brought first on the next trip. Now he came

to Jagrnath and said, “I’ll go too, but first to my house. It’s on the same way. The children are on the roof.”

Suresh looked at him. “Sunita’s labour pains have started.”

Harinarayan’s voice hardened. “Are my children not lives? They’ve been sitting on the roof for three hours.”

Silence spread across the platform.

Untying the boat, Jagrnath said, “The boat will decide the route. We’ll go where the current allows. But at one time this boat can hold only one crisis.”

Deepak picked up the oar. Suresh put in a lantern, a blanket, and a long bamboo pole. Harinarayan took two empty sacks and a rope. The boat pushed off.

For the first fifty cubits the water was calm. The boat slid over submerged paddy fields. Here and there the tops of plants broke through the surface. Jagrnath kept sounding the depth with the end of the oar.

Ahead, the water spun in circles at one spot. By day there had been an unpaved road there. Now the road had been cut away, and the river’s main current was forcing itself through the breach.

“Straight ahead will be faster,” Harinarayan said. “You can see the roof of my house on the other side.”

Jagrnath lowered the lantern light toward the water. Small pieces of debris were racing in one direction. “Straight ahead will get us to the river faster,” he said. “We turn right.”

Harinarayan said nothing. The boat turned right. On that curve, Ramcharan’s house came first.

A little farther on, they found a bamboo thicket half-bent into the water. Its branches blocked the way. Deepak pushed them aside one by one with the pole. One branch brushed the lantern glass. Suresh caught it at once.

“If the light goes out, we’ll all be guessing in the dark,” he said.

The parapet of Ramcharan’s house came into view. He stood on the roof in water up to his knees. His wife was by an inside window. Sunita’s groans were now clear.

“It’s late,” Ramcharan said. “Even lifting her is difficult.”

The boat could not reach the doorway; a thick neem branch had fallen in front of it. Jagrnath tried to bring the boat alongside a window. Deepak held onto bamboo to keep the boat steady. Suresh and Ramcharan went inside.

Harinarayan sat in the boat staring toward his own house. Far away, a small light flickered into view now and then, then vanished behind the bamboo.

“My younger boy has a fever,” he said quietly.

Jagrnath heard him but did not answer.

After a while Suresh came out and said, “Sunita can’t walk. Even the cot won’t come out.”

Jagrnath measured the width of the window. “Leave the cot. Make a sling from the blanket.”

Ropes were tied to the four corners of the blanket. Sunita was slowly brought to the window. Her mother-in-law was gathering a small bottle of oil, a cloth, and an old piece of dhoti kept for the newborn.

“Ma, nothing else,” Sunita groaned. “Just hold me.”

At last Sunita was laid in the boat. Her mother-in-law climbed in too. Ramcharan tried to board, but Jagrnath stopped him with a hand. “The boat is full now. You stay here. We’ll come back.”

Ramcharan’s face fell. “My daughter-in-law…”

“Suresh is with her. Deepak is here. I am here. Stay on the roof and keep the lamp high.”

The boat turned.

Harinarayan suddenly said, “My house?”

Jagrnath looked at the water rising in the bottom of the boat. Sunita groaned. Her mother-in-law stroked her head.

“The platform first,” Jagrnath said.

Harinarayan sprang up. The boat rocked. “No! My house is only two bends away now. Will the children stay on the roof all night?”

Deepak said sharply, “Sit down! The boat will overturn.”

Harinarayan sat, but his breathing was rapid. “To all of you she is one daughter-in-law. To me there are three people on that roof.”

Suresh opened his mouth to say something, then fell silent.

Jagrnath kept the boat straight. The water was now striking the left side hard. Turning right toward the platform was safe; Harinarayan’s house lay to the left, but the fierce current at the breach stood between them.

Sunita opened her eyes and looked at Harinarayan. Her voice was barely audible. “Sahuji, you go. They’ll get me to the platform.”

Harinarayan did not understand her. “Where am I supposed to go after leaving the boat?”

“I’m saying… drop me there, then go.”

At that moment Sunita’s mother-in-law caught her hand. “Child, keep quiet.”

Harinarayan’s face changed again. He looked at the wet blanket spread near Sunita’s feet. Then at the tiny light of his house far away.

“How long to the platform?” he asked.

“Fifteen minutes, if the current doesn’t rise,” Jagrnath said.

“And then my house?”

“In this boat?” Jagrnath paused for a moment. “If the water rises farther, coming back may be difficult.”

After that answer, only the sound of the oars remained in the boat.

Ahead, the crown of a submerged mango tree appeared. Someone had tied a red gamchha to one thick branch—a marker for the safe route made during the day. Jagrnath turned the boat toward it.

Just then a sharp cry came from behind—from the direction of Harinarayan’s house.

“Babu!”

Harinarayan sprang up like lightning. “That’s my daughter!”

Jagrnath heard it too. No second cry came.

“Turn the boat!” Harinarayan said.

Deepak looked at his father. Suresh looked at Sunita’s mother-in-law. No one had an answer on his face.

Jagrnath stopped rowing. The boat began drifting slowly in the current. He knew: the platform was to the right, Harinarayan’s house to the left. On one side a woman in labour; on the other a feverish child and a family stranded on a roof. The small boat had no room to take everyone at once. Whatever decision was made, some part of it could later seem wrong.

He asked Harinarayan, “Can you swim?”

“Yes, but not in this current.”

“As far as the mango tree?”

Harinarayan looked at the water. The distance was not more than twenty cubits, but no one knew where the ridges of the fields lay below.

Jagrnath opened his spare rope. “I’ll hold the boat beside the tree. You climb onto it. I’ll get Sunita to the platform and come back at once. From there you can hear your house and keep watching the light. If anything changes, untie the red gamchha and wave it.”

Harinarayan stared at him in disbelief. “Alone here?”

“If we turn left, everyone is at risk. If we go all the way to the platform, your mind will not rest. This is the middle course.”

Suresh said, “I’ll stay on the tree with him.”

Jagrnath shook his head. “Then we’ll be short two hands for getting Sunita onto the platform.”

Harinarayan looked once more toward the distant roof. He looked once at Sunita’s face. Then without another word he tied the rope around his waist.

The boat reached the mango tree. Deepak caught a branch. Harinarayan carefully climbed onto it. Jagrnath tied the other end of the rope to the tree so he could find the place in the dark when he returned.

“I’ll come back,” Jagrnath said.

Harinarayan said only, “Quickly.”

The boat moved again.

The platform was no longer far, but Sunita’s pain intensified. Her mother-in-law placed Sunita’s head in her lap. Suresh kept probing the water with the bamboo pole. Deepak’s hands were trembling, but he did not let go of the oar.

As soon as they reached the platform, the women climbed down to meet them. Two men held the boat steady with ropes. Sunita was lifted up in the blanket sling.

Asha Didi, who was there, immediately took her into a corner enclosed with bamboo.

Jagrnath picked up the bowl to bail the water that had collected in the boat.

Deepak said, “Babu, sit for two minutes.”

“Harinarayan is on the tree.”

Someone on the platform said, “Don’t go out again tonight. The water is rising.”

Jagrnath did not answer. He remembered his own words—We are not going again. Only half an hour earlier.

He tightened the cloth stuffed into the split in the boat. Suresh began climbing in.

“You stay,” Jagrnath said.

“He is sitting on that tree partly because of me too,” Suresh replied.

Deepak was already in the boat. The three set out.

On the return journey the wind was against them. The lantern flame kept shrinking. The red gamchha on the mango tree could not be seen.

“It hasn’t washed away, has it?” Deepak asked.

Jagrnath’s oar stopped for a moment. “The tree won’t have washed away.”

A little farther on, a dark shape moved on a branch. It was Harinarayan. He was not waving the gamchha.

“Why not?” Suresh asked when the boat came close.

Climbing down, Harinarayan said, “The light at the house is still there. No one called again.”

He sat in the boat, but this time he did not immediately insist on going to the house. He only said, “You know how strong the current is at the breach.”

Jagrnath answered, “I know.”

For a few moments all four remained still beside the tree.

Then the light at Harinarayan’s house swung rapidly three times.

“That is a signal,” Harinarayan said. “My wife swings the lamp three times like that when she needs help.”

Jagrnath turned the boat left.

This time no one argued over the decision. Sunita had reached the platform safely. The boat was lighter. The danger remained, but its meaning had changed.

At the breach Jagrnath used the bamboo pole instead of the oar. Deepak kept the rope ready. Suresh leaned forward watching for submerged shrubs. Twice the current tried to spin the boat. The roof of Harinarayan's house was now close.

On the roof were his wife Kamla, his daughter Rani, and eight-year-old Sonu. Sonu was wrapped in a blanket, burning with fever.

"Why did you wave the lamp three times?" Harinarayan asked as they reached the roof.

Kamla replied, "The rear wall behind the thatch has fallen. Water is coming inside."

Sonu was taken down first. Then Rani. Kamla climbed in last. For five adults, two children, and their belongings, the boat was too small.

Jagrnath said, "Harinarayan, you stay here. I'll take the family to the platform and come back."

This time Harinarayan did not protest. He sat down on the roof. "Leave the rope."

Jagrnath left the rope with him.

As Rani sat in the boat, she asked, "Babu isn't coming?"

Kamla pulled her into her lap. "Babu will come later."

Jagrnath heard her. The word "will" floated across the night water.

The second journey to the platform was harder than the first, but no one raised their voice. Sonu kept whimpering with fever. Deepak dipped his wet gamchha in the water and placed it on the boy's forehead. Kamla kept looking back.

As soon as they reached the platform, people surrounded the child. Someone looked for warm water, someone for dry clothes, someone for medicine.

Jagrnath turned the boat for the third time. Now only he, Deepak, and Suresh were aboard.

"Tonight it isn't a boat moving—it's decisions," Suresh said softly.

Jagrnath stopped him. "Don't say that. A boat has wood, rope, water, and weight. Calling it a decision does not make the current weaker."

Suresh fell silent.

Harinarayan was found on the roof exactly where they had left him. One section of the wall had indeed collapsed. He had brought out a small iron box from inside the house.

"Not that," Jagrnath said. "No extra weight in the boat."

Harinarayan placed a hand on the box. "The shop accounts, land papers, the children's certificates—everything is in this."

Deepak looked down into the belly of the boat.

For a few moments Harinarayan held the box. Then he opened it, took out the papers on top, put them into an old oilskin pouch, and left the box on the roof.

“If the house remains, I’ll find the box,” he said. “If the house doesn’t remain, what will I do with the box?”

The boat moved toward the platform again.

After midnight the rain eased. On the platform Sunita gave birth to a daughter. In the light of an old lantern, Asha Didi wrapped the baby in cloth. No one felt like celebrating loudly; the exhausted people simply looked at one another. Far away, Ramcharan kept a lamp burning on his roof. There was still no way to send him the news.

Harinarayan sat beside his family. Sonu’s fever had come down a little. Rani had fallen asleep. Kamla was drying her wet hair.

Jagrnath tightened the boat rope around a bamboo post of the platform. Deepak sat beside him.

“Babu,” Deepak asked, “was it right to bring Sunita first, or should we have gone to Sahuji’s house?”

Jagrnath did not answer for a long time.

“People see right and wrong clearly afterward,” he said at last. “In night water, all you can see is who is in the boat at that moment, where the current is strongest, and whether another trip is possible.”

Deepak remained silent.

At dawn the water became steadier. The boat went again to Ramcharan’s roof. He was found alive, exhausted, and silent. When he was told he had a granddaughter, he said nothing at first. Only after sitting in the boat did he ask, “Is Sunita all right?”

“She is all right,” Jagrnath said.

The iron box from Harinarayan’s house was found on the roof two days later. Water had got inside. The ink in the account books had run, but the papers he had removed into the oilskin pouch had survived.

A week later, when the flood receded, the people of Mahua Tola returned to their homes. Some called Jagrnath a hero, some asked why he had not gone to Harinarayan’s house on the first trip, some said the boat should never have been taken out at night at all. Everyone had the light of hindsight.

Jagrnath spoke little in those discussions. He turned the boat upside down and let it dry in the sun. He removed the cloth stuffed into the split and fitted a new strip.

Deepak found a small piece of red thread inside the boat. It had probably torn from the edge of the gamchha tied to the mango tree and caught in the boat.

He showed the thread to Jagrnath.

Jagrnath did not throw it away. He tied it to the front bamboo peg of the boat.

“As a marker?” Deepak asked.

“No,” Jagrnath said, “not for memory. So that next time, in the dark, we can find the end of the rope quickly.”

Deepak smiled.

By evening the boat was ready again. The river was returning to its channel. The platform was empty. In the distance a new lamp burned near Ramcharan’s house. Harinarayan was lowering the wet iron box from his roof.

Jagrnath left the boat at the bank and walked home. The short journey through the night had ended, but no decision inside him had been carved into stone. There remained only a few faces, the sound of water, the mango tree, the red gamchha, and the weight of a boat—a weight that had kept changing again and again through that night.

STORY 57

Not a Leader Who Forgets Names, but a Teacher

After rainwater seeped into the old records room at Belahi Middle School, eighteen files had become soaked.

The papers were dried, but the ink had run in several student registers from 1990 to 1994.

In some places half a letter of a name remained, in others a father's name, and elsewhere only a roll number.

Headmaster Arun Kumar had said, “Reconstruct verified copies as far as possible. Do not fill in names by guesswork.”

The task was assigned to Neelam, a newly appointed teacher.

Neelam gathered the old examination forms, fee receipts, library lending register, and prize lists in one place.

Even then, many entries would not match.

At that point someone suggested, “Call Shivnarayan Jha. He taught here in those years.”

Shivnarayan Jha was eighty-five years old.

He had taught at the school for thirty-two years.

When he arrived, he carried an old cloth bag, a walking stick, and a pen tucked behind his ear.

Neelam placed the first register before him.

“Guruji, Class Seven, 1991. The name here has been half washed away.”

Shivnarayan Jha narrowed his eyes at the page.

“This... Ramesh?”

The assistant sitting by the door laughed. “Ramesh runs a seed shop now. This was Mahesh.”

“Mahesh?”

“Yes.”

Shivnarayan Jha shook his head.

“All right. But was he the one who once hung the geography map upside down?”

The assistant laughed again. “That was Ramesh.”

Neelam stopped her pen.

“Then, Guruji, we cannot rely on you for the names.”

Shivnarayan Jha said without a trace of offence, “That is precisely what I came to tell you.”

Just then Ramesh himself came to the school to deliver a sack of seed.

Hearing the conversation, he joked, “Guruji has become a leader now—he has forgotten everyone's name.”

Shivnarayan Jha answered at once, “Not a leader, a teacher. Let the register be trusted for names; I shall give you clues.”

Neelam's interest was stirred.

“What kind of clues?”

“The kind that help you find the paper.”

On the first blurred line, only ‘...resh Ku...’ remained.

At the end of the father's name, ‘...dev’ could still be seen.

Neelam said, “Could it be Suresh Kumar?”

Shivnarayan Jha said, “There were two Sureshes in this class. One had tied a bamboo pen-holder to the window frame. The other carried two spare nibs on examination days.”

Neelam asked, “How will that help us find the name?”

“The father of the boy who made the pen-holder worked with bamboo. His occupation should be written on the fee receipt.”

They searched the old fee receipts.

On one receipt was written: ‘Father: Ramdev Paswan; occupation: bamboo work.’

The roll number matched the number on the washed-out line in the old register.

Neelam recorded the first match.

“Memory cue—bamboo pen-holder. Documentary match—fee receipt.”

Shivnarayan Jha said, “Work this way. What I tell you is not proof; it is a path.”

Ramesh put down the sack and sat there himself.

“Let us see how many names our Guruji gets wrong.”

On the second line the name was clear—‘Meera Devi.’

The father's name had been washed away.

Shivnarayan Jha said, “This is the same Meera who used to bring her exercise book wrapped in a reed mat on rainy days.”

Neelam looked through an old prize list.

‘Cleanest Notebook Prize—Meera Devi, father Harinandan Mandal.’

She completed the name.

Ramesh said, “That could still be a coincidence.”

Neelam agreed. “We need another document.”

In the library register, Meera Devi's name appeared with the same father's name.

Neelam did not put a tick; she wrote, “Two sources matched.”

Shivnarayan Jha laughed.

“I would not be able to get away with copying in this teacher's class either.”

The third line was difficult.

The beginning of the name looked like ‘Di’, the end like ‘sh’.

Shivnarayan Jha said at once, “Ganesh.”

Ramesh said, “Guruji, it must be Dinesh.”

Shivnarayan Jha looked up at the ceiling.

“The boy who never plucked mangoes, but counted the fallen ones and divided them equally?”

“Dinesh,” Ramesh said. “He runs a fruit shop now.”

Neelam said, “What Rameshji says is not proof either.”

They opened the old examination forms.

The roll number matched—Dinesh Sah.

Neelam laughed. “Guruji, you missed the name again, but the mango clue was right.”

Shivnarayan Jha twirled the pen between his fingers. “That is why I am not filling in the names.”

By noon, seven lines had been restored.

The same rule was followed in every case.

First, Shivnarayan Jha gave only a memory cue.

Then Neelam searched for at least two documentary sources.

Without two sources, the name was left blank.

Ramesh, after mocking the rule for a while, began searching old files himself.

On one line only ‘Ku…’ remained.

Shivnarayan Jha described the student almost as if painting a picture. “Quick with answers in mathematics, but never wrote out the steps in between.”

Ramesh said at once, “Kusum!”

Neelam asked, “The document?”

The prize list contained the name Kusum Jha, but no roll number.

The library register contained three Kusums.

Neelam left the line blank.

Ramesh grew impatient. “Everyone remembers that it was Kusum.”

“Remembering and verifying are two different things,” Neelam said.

Shivnarayan Jha said softly, “She is right.”

Toward evening Kusum herself arrived at the school.

Having heard about the old records, she had brought her Class Eight certificate from home.

The roll number matched.

Only then did Neelam fill in the name.

Kusum laughed and asked, “Guruji, did you remember my name?”

Shivnarayan Jha told the truth. “No. But you never wrote the working in between.”

Kusum said, “Now I keep accounts. If I leave out even one line, the owner asks about it.”

Ramesh said, “Guruji's teaching took effect rather late.”

The work began again the next day.

This time Shivnarayan Jha was wrong even about one of his clues.

He said, “This student did not do his homework for three days because the calf at home was ill.”

Headmaster Arun Kumar smiled.

“Guruji, that was me.”

Shivnarayan Jha said, “Yes, Arun.”

But when the old daily register was opened, it turned out that it was Arun's younger brother Anil who had been absent for three days because of the calf.

Shivnarayan Jha fell silent.

For the first time, Ramesh made no joke.

Neelam wrote against the line: “Memory cue unverified; not used.”

Shivnarayan Jha himself said, “Draw a red line through it.”

Neelam drew the red line.

“Guruji, did that hurt?”

“Why should it? Memory is not a register. If an error is not caught, tomorrow it becomes a lie.”

From that day, a third rule was added: “A teacher's memory may also be struck out.”

Ramesh wrote the three rules on the board.

“One—no name by guesswork.”

“Two—memory is only a clue for the search.”

“Three—no line is complete without two independent documentary matches.”

Shivnarayan Jha read them and said, “Add a fourth.”

“What?”

“Even if Guruji says it, check it.”

Everyone burst out laughing.

On the third day of the work, they found a curious line.

The name had vanished completely, but one remark remained: 'School play: Gatekeeper.'

Shivnarayan Jha looked straight at Ramesh.

"This is you."

Ramesh was startled. "You forgot the name, but remembered the gatekeeper?"

"The king had four pages of dialogue. You chose the gatekeeper's role with two lines."

"And?"

"You forgot one of the two lines."

Ramesh folded his hands. "It would be better if no documentary proof of that survived."

Neelam searched for the old expense sheet for the play.

It contained the names of the performers.

'Gatekeeper—Ramesh Yadav.'

The second source was the annual report, which also listed the cast of the play.

The name matched.

Neelam filled in the line.

Ramesh said, "Now I understand. Guruji does not recognise me by my name, but by my laziness."

Shivnarayan Jha corrected him. "Not laziness—a talent for the shortest route."

By the fourth day, eighteen of the twenty-two blurred lines had been verified.

Four lines remained blank.

The headmaster asked, "Guruji, does anything come back to you?"

Shivnarayan Jha studied all four lines.

"There are a few hazy memories, but I cannot see a path to any document."

"Then?"

"Leave them blank."

The headmaster said, "The copy will remain incomplete."

Neelam replied, "An incomplete true copy is better than a completed lie."

Shivnarayan Jha smiled.

Under the fourth rule on the board, Ramesh wrote a fifth: "A blank space is also information."

When the work was finished, Neelam added a note at the end of the new copy.

"In reconstructing illegible entries, oral memory was used only as a search cue; final names are based on independent archival corroboration."

Ramesh read it and said, “Will Guruji understand that sentence?”

Shivnarayan Jha replied, “I do not need to understand it. The person who opens the register next time should.”

Neelam also made a separate little notebook.

On the cover she wrote: “Memory Cues: Not Evidence.”

In that notebook they recorded such clues as the bamboo pen-holder, two spare nibs, the reed mat, fallen mangoes, omitted workings, and the gatekeeper's two lines.

In red ink they also recorded the mistake involving Anil and Arun.

Shivnarayan Jha looked at that red line.

“Why keep this?”

Neelam said, “So that the next person understands that your memory was useful, not infallible.”

“You did well.”

Ramesh asked, “Guruji, do you remember Neelamji's name now?”

Shivnarayan Jha looked at Neelam.

He remained silent for a few moments.

“The name… Neelam.”

Neelam clapped.

Shivnarayan Jha immediately added, “But I may forget the name again.”

“Then how will you remember me?”

“The two-witness teacher.”

Everyone roared with laughter.

Ramesh said, “The title still has to be the same—Not a Leader Who Forgets Names, but a Teacher.”

Shivnarayan Jha asked, “Why ‘leader’ again?”

Ramesh said, “The joke from the first day.”

Shivnarayan Jha scratched his head.

“I have forgotten that joke.”

Neelam opened the little notebook and showed him the first page.

It read: “First day: Guruji got five names wrong; he himself said—let the register be trusted for names, I shall give the clues.”

Shivnarayan Jha read it and laughed.

“See? That is the virtue of the written word—it remembers better than I do.”

As he was leaving, Ramesh called from behind, “Guruji, who am I?”

Without turning around, Shivnarayan Jha replied, “The gatekeeper. You forgot one of your two lines.”

Ramesh said, “My name?”

Shivnarayan Jha stopped.

“That is why we made the register.”

STORY 58

The River's Paper

The Kamla River flowed a little east of Garhiya Tola.

Twenty years earlier, it had not been here.

Back then the river ran farther east, and a settlement called Garhiya Tola existed only on people's lips, not on paper.

Ramcharit Sahni had built the first house.

His old home had been washed away in a flood.

He had driven bamboo poles into the sand and raised a hut.

After him came two families.

Then five.

Then the river's old channel kept retreating, and houses kept multiplying along the bank.

Now Garhiya Tola had thirty-seven households.

Some houses were thatched, some made of mud and brick, some half-pucca.

There were two wells.

There was one community hand pump.

In a small courtyard, children studied in the evenings.

Whenever the river rose, sacks of grain were the first things carried up into that courtyard.

To the people, Garhiya Tola was a settlement.

On the revenue map, it was a blue-and-white strip.

Beside that strip were the words: "River zone, zero habitation."

Champa Sahni first saw that sentence at the block office.

She had gone there to have her address certified on her daughter Poonam's scholarship papers.

The clerk opened the map and asked, "What is the plot number of your house?"

Champa said, "My house has no plot number. The tola is written there."

"Where is the tola?"

"On the western riverbank."

The clerk moved a finger over the map.

"There's nothing here."

Champa thought: it was easy to see an empty place on a map.

The map did not know how many hearths burned there each night.

The clerk handed back the scholarship papers.

"Get the address certified by the panchayat."

Champa gathered up the papers.

As she was leaving, she looked once more at the map.

On that blue strip, her entire settlement did not amount to a single dot.

Two weeks later, four corners were marked with white lime along the riverbank.

The first corner lay in front of Champa's house.

The second was inside Bhola Mukhiya's bamboo enclosure.

The third was near the community hand pump.

The fourth touched the edge of the courtyard where the children studied.

A member of the construction team said, "Stone will be stored here."

"How much stone?" Champa asked.

"It's embankment work. A lot."

"In front of the houses?"

"On the map, this is vacant land designated for storing materials."

Again Champa caught on that one word—vacant.

Ramcharit was no longer alive.

But if the first bamboo stake he had driven into the ground still survived somewhere beneath the soil, the papers would have called that place vacant too.

The next day, the construction team painted red numbers on twelve houses.

They were not house numbers.

They marked the order in which the houses were to be removed.

A 1 appeared on one wall.

A 2 on another.

Champa's house was marked 7.

Poonam returned from school and saw the 7 on the wall.

"What does this number mean?"

Champa said, "They say there is no house here."

Poonam did not laugh.

She opened her schoolbag.

She took out her school identity card.

The address read: Garhiya Tola, western riverbank.

"If there is no house, where will this address go?"

Champa had no answer.

That evening, people from the whole tola gathered.

Some said, what harm would it do if stones were stored there; they could put up with it for a few days.

Others said, first the stones, then the machines, and then the houses would go.

An old woman said, “My name is in the ration register. Why is my house not on the papers?”

Bhola said, “Ration papers are not land papers.”

“Then I am not asking about the land. I am asking whether I exist,” the old woman said.

The meeting fell silent at that.

The next day Champa went to the panchayat office.

There she found an old flood-relief register.

The names of twenty-four families from Garhiya Tola had been entered in it during a flood three years earlier.

At the top of the register were the words: “Riverbank settlement.”

Champa asked for a copy.

The clerk said, “This is a relief register, not a land record.”

Champa said, “I am not asking you to declare us owners of the land. First write down that people live there.”

The clerk kept looking at her.

Then he gave her the copy.

That evening Poonam opened an old tin trunk.

The family’s papers were kept inside.

A vaccination slip.

A school certificate.

A ration-distribution receipt.

A list of families taken aboard the flood-rescue boat.

A copy of an application for repairing the hand pump.

And an electricity-bill receipt where, beneath the address, the same words appeared again—Garhiya Tola.

Poonam said, “One office says we exist. Another says we do not.”

Champa said, “Keep all the papers together.”

For the next three days, the whole tola searched for papers.

Someone had a maternity-assistance slip.

Someone had a notice of an old-age payment.

Someone had a child’s school-enrolment paper.

Someone had a receipt from a livestock vaccination camp.

Someone had the serial number under which the family had been entered on the river-crossing rescue-boat list.

Some papers were torn.

On some, the ink had run.

Of some, only half remained.

But every one bore some government stamp or another.

Poonam did not sort the papers by household.

She arranged them by year.

The oldest slip was fourteen years old.

It was in Ramcharit's name.

Place—Garhiya Tola.

Champa stared at that slip for a long time.

When Ramcharit had driven in the first bamboo stake, how could he have known that one day the ink on a slip would have to survive in order to prove that he had existed there?

Poonam made a list of the houses in a thick notebook.

Not House 1, House 2.

By name.

Jamuna Devi.

Bhola Sahni.

Rahim Mian.

Champa Sahni.

Saryu Khatun.

Devnarayan Mallah.

Against each name she wrote which office's document was available.

From which year.

What address it carried.

Of the thirty-seven households, thirty-two had some government paper or another.

Five households had none.

Those five were new.

Champa said, "Do not strike out their names."

Poonam said, "I won't. I'll write beside them—seen on site."

The tola decided that the notebook would make no claim to ownership of the land.

It would record only how many people lived there, how long they had lived there, and which offices had used that address.

Champa said, "Do not add anything that is not true."

Bhola laughed and said, "So now we have become more careful than government papers."

No one laughed.

On the fourth day, the construction team fastened a notice to a stake giving the date when the stones would arrive.

Materials would begin to be stored there in six days.

Champa went to the panchayat secretary.

"Come and inspect the site."

The secretary said, "This is a revenue matter."

The revenue clerk said, "This is a construction-department matter."

The construction official said, "We work according to the map."

Three offices.

Three answers.

The same vacant strip.

Poonam said, "Call all of them on the same day."

"Who will call them?" Champa asked.

"The office whose papers all of them use—the panchayat."

At first the secretary would not agree.

Then Champa placed the copy of the relief register in front of him.

"Is this your office's stamp?"

"Yes, it belongs to our office."

"Where do the people under this stamp live on the map?"

The secretary said nothing.

At last, a date was fixed for a joint site inspection.

On the day of the inspection, there was no procession through the tola.

No slogans were raised.

Poonam drove a small bamboo stake in front of every house and tied a strip of paper to each one.

The strips carried no household names, only the year and office of a government document.

"2014—Vaccination Camp."

"2016—Flood Relief."

"2018—School Enrolment."

"2021—Hand-Pump Repair Application."

"2023—Ration Distribution."

From a distance, the entire settlement looked filled with little paper flags.

The revenue clerk arrived carrying the map.

The construction engineer was with him.

So was the panchayat secretary.

The engineer looked at the first square outlined in white lime.

It was Champa's courtyard.

"On the map, this is open land."

Champa said, "On the ground, this is my courtyard."

"Do you have ownership papers?"

"No."

"Then what you are saying—"

Champa did not interrupt him.

Poonam opened the notebook.

"We have made no claim of ownership. Your plan says zero habitation. Check that claim."

For the first time, the revenue clerk took the notebook.

He turned the pages.

He looked at documents from different government offices carrying the same address.

"None of these documents establishes ownership."

Poonam said, "Our notebook does not say that either."

The engineer moved on.

The second white square covered half of the hand pump.

The third lay in the middle of the courtyard where the children studied in the evenings.

The fourth lay across the narrow path leading to the river.

That was the path where the boat came in during floods.

The engineer asked his assistant, "If materials are stored here, will this path be blocked?"

"Yes."

"An alternative path?"

The assistant looked at the map.

The path was not on the map either.

In Poonam's notebook, an entire page was devoted to it.

The flood-relief boat list.

Boarding point—Garhiya Tola western path.

The engineer read the list.

Champa said nothing.

She only kept looking toward the river.

The inspection continued past noon.

Thirty-seven households were counted.

Government papers were examined for thirty-two households.

Five newer households were recorded on site.

Two wells.

One hand pump.

One community courtyard.

One boat path.

The revenue clerk added a new page to his file.

At the top he wrote: "Site Verification."

Below it he wrote: "Map records zero habitation; thirty-seven households found on site."

He paused.

Then he added: "Ownership status to be examined separately."

Champa read the page.

This time she did not ask for a single word to be changed.

The engineer shifted the material-storage site a little farther north on the construction map.

There lay an old sandy stretch of the riverbed, with no houses on it.

"Suspend the numbering of houses for removal until the boundary survey is completed," he told his assistant.

The red *7* was still on Champa's wall.

No one erased it that day.

Three days later, it rained.

The red paint ran a little.

One edge of the *7* blurred.

Poonam did not whitewash over it.

She said, "Leave it. This too is evidence, like a paper."

Champa laughed.

"A wall is not a paper."

Poonam said, "And if a paper cannot see the place, what makes it so much better than a wall?"

This time Champa did not try to silence her.

A month later, two surveyors from the revenue department arrived.

They carried a newly printed map.

The blue strip was still empty.

But along its edge, in small letters, were the words: "Habitation—site verification pending."

The first surveyor asked, "Where should we start counting the households?"

Champa looked toward the river.

Then toward the place where the old map had shown nothing.

“Start where the paper is blank.”

The surveyor drove in the first stake.

It stood in front of where Ramcharit’s old house had been.

STORY 59

The Sand Ghat

At this bend of the Kamla River lay a village called Sonbarsa, but the villagers simply called the pale strip across the river the Sand Ghat.

In winter the river grew gentle. A long tongue of sand emerged in the middle, while thin streams of water ran along both sides.

Sonbarsa's three old wells lived by the rhythm of this river. As the rains receded, the water level fell, then stayed steady from Kartik through Paush.

The oldest well stood behind the school. Its water was used for the midday meal, people from five nearby houses drew from it, and every morning Haripriya, who sold tea, filled two pitchers there.

Haripriya did not measure the depth of the water, but her hands knew the length of the rope.

'If it reaches this knot, the bucket will come up full,' she would tell her daughter Manju.

There were seven knots in the rope.

The first five were old, the sixth had been tied by Haripriya's husband, and Manju had added the seventh the previous monsoon.

In the first week of Phagun, three heavy trucks arrived at the Sand Ghat.

Two days later, a yellow machine arrived.

A notice was posted on the panchayat building stating that sand would be lifted from a designated strip of the river. The permit was for three months.

The villagers read the notice. Some spoke of a bridge, some of a road, some of work.

For Haripriya, the first change was dust.

Whenever the trucks left the ghat and took the main road, pale dust settled over the benches at her tea stall.

She swept them twice a day.

'It is business,' people said. 'A little dust has to be endured.'

Haripriya kept enduring it.

A week later, the rope at the well dropped as far as the sixth knot.

She filled the bucket and drew it up.

The water was clear.

Two days later, the rope went down to the seventh knot.

Manju laughed. 'We need an eighth knot.'

Haripriya did not laugh.

That evening she went toward the river.

Where a thin stream had once hugged the village side of the Sand Ghat, there was now a broad track for the trucks to descend. Sand had been cut away to lower the track.

Four deep pits gleamed in the middle of the riverbed.

The excavated sand lay heaped to one side.

Haripriya did not know how to read a river, but one thing was immediately plain to her.

The water no longer curved around the old bend.

A thin stream had been drawn from the lower part of the truck track straight toward the pits.

She returned home.

The next morning Vimla Devi, the school cook, said, 'The bucket is touching the bottom of the well.'

That day, water for the children's meal was brought from another hamlet.

A panchayat meeting was held.

Manoj Sah, the sand contractor, said, 'The water in the river has fallen. It would not be right to say our work is the cause.'

The mukhiya also said, 'There was less rain this winter.'

Haripriya listened in silence.

At the end of the meeting she asked, 'How far are you permitted to dig the track for the trucks to descend?'

Manoj Sah showed her the papers.

The paper marked the four corners of the sand-lifting area. There was no separate mention of a track for the trucks.

'How will the trucks get there without a track?' he said.

Haripriya said nothing more.

That night Manju began tying an eighth knot in the rope.

Haripriya stopped her.

'Do not add another knot.'

'Then how will we draw water?'

'First we will see where the water has gone.'

The next day Haripriya called Ramji, the boatman.

Ramji had been rowing boats on the river for forty years.

He looked at the river and then said, 'The mouth of the channel has shifted.'

'Because of the sand lifting?'

Ramji did not say yes at once.

He went to the truck track and planted his staff in the sand. Then he walked toward the bend of the old channel.

'It is not only the pits,' he said. 'This track has been cut lower. Water takes the lower path.'

Haripriya asked, 'How can that be shown on paper?'

Ramji smiled.

'Write the water into a register.'

For the next seven days, a small exercise began.

Three schoolchildren went to the river at six each morning.

Ramji showed them three places.

The first was the old channel on the village side.

The second was the cut made for the trucks to descend.

The third was the mouth of the sand-extraction pit.

The water depth was measured with bamboo rods of the same length.

Manju wrote down the figures.

Haripriya counted the knots on the school well's rope.

Before cooking the meal, Vimla Devi recorded the well's water level.

The pages filled with seven days of entries.

In the old channel, the water fell day by day.

In the cut track, it rose day by day.

At the well, the rope had to go past the eighth knot.

On the eighth night, there was a light rain.

Haripriya thought the water in the well would rise now.

But by morning there was very little difference.

Ramji said, 'The soil does not hold water by itself. Where the river's current exerts pressure matters too.'

Haripriya understood it in her own way: a river does not flow only over the surface; its water also breathes through the earth along its banks.

On the ninth day, the water in another village well turned grey.

Fine sand from the bottom began coming up in the bucket.

This time the panchayat met again.

Haripriya placed the seven days of records on the table.

Manoj Sah did not laugh.

He looked through the pages.

'This is not an official survey,' he said.

'No,' Haripriya replied. 'That is why you should have an official survey done.'

After that one sentence, the meeting fell silent for a while.

The mukhiya sent word to the block office.

Two days later, Junior Engineer Navalkishore arrived.

He examined the permit, the map of the mining area, and the ghat.

First, the distances between the four marked corners were measured.

The main sand-extraction pits were within the permitted area.

Manoj Sah's face relaxed a little.

Then Haripriya showed him the truck track.

Navalkishore measured its bed.

The cut track crossed the boundary of the designated sand strip and ran as far as the bend of the old channel.

'This is not part of the mining area,' he said.

Manoj Sah replied at once, 'It is only an access track.'

Navalkishore said, 'But the riverbed was cut while making it. Its effect is like mining.'

Ramji showed him the bamboo-rod measurements from the three places.

The engineer measured again with his own instrument.

The figures were not identical, but they pointed in the same direction.

The old channel was shallower.

The cut made for the trucks was deeper.

Small cuts linked the pits to one another.

Navalkishore drew a line on the map with a pencil.

'These are no longer three separate pits,' he said. 'They are becoming a new course for the water.'

Manoj Sah fell silent.

Sand extraction was not halted that day.

Haripriya had not demanded that either.

It was decided that the lowered truck track would be filled back in, an unbroken strip of sand would be left at the bend of the old channel, and the cuts connecting the pits would be closed.

No trucks ran for three days.

The workers filled the cut track with sand again.

Manju watched from a distance.

She asked, 'They are filling it again with the same sand they lifted?'

Haripriya said, 'Sometimes filling in the wrong path is work too.'

On the fourth day, water began flowing close to the old bend again.

There was no instant miracle.

At the school well, the rope still went down to the eighth knot.

On the sixth day, the bucket touched water between the seventh and eighth knots.

On the tenth day, it touched at the seventh knot.

Vimla Devi wrote in the register: 'Water clear again.'

Haripriya read that page and did not put it away separately.

She tied it together with the records from the first seven days.

Manoj Sah resumed sand extraction.

This time the truck track ran over the higher sandbar, where the riverbed had not been cut.

Stakes were driven into the ground at the four corners.

Manju saw that one stake bore the words in red: 'Not beyond this point.'

She told Haripriya, 'Now the boundary can be seen.'

Haripriya replied, 'The boundary was there before. It just could not be seen.'

A month passed.

Trucks still came and went at the Sand Ghat.

Dust still rose.

Haripriya still swept the benches twice a day.

But the rope at the school well kept stopping around the seventh knot.

On the day the permit expired, a final survey was conducted at the panchayat.

Navalkishore looked again at the old records.

He said, 'Keep all of these.'

Haripriya asked, 'Will they become official papers?'

'They are not official papers,' he said, 'but at the next survey they will show where the question first arose.'

Haripriya liked that answer.

She went home and looked at the rope.

Manju had not cut off the eighth knot.

'Shall I remove it?' Manju asked.

Haripriya shook her head.

'Let it stay.'

'Why keep the eighth knot then?'

Rolling up the rope, Haripriya said, 'The river may change again. One knot should remain for memory.'

By evening, the Sand Ghat lay white.

There were no trucks.

The old channel flowed beside the village with a faint sound.

Haripriya filled the bucket at the well.

The rope went taut at the seventh knot.

She drew it up.

The water in the bucket was clear.
She looked at the water, then at the eighth knot in the rope.
For her, the two were no longer separate things.

STORY 60

The Power of a Signature

The meeting of the ‘Anjor Women’s Savings Group’ in Sonbarsa village was held on the second Tuesday of every month.

There were twelve women.

Some had been able to write their names for years; some, until two years earlier, had still been putting down thumbprints.

Now all of them wrote their names.

They were proud of that.

But one day Chandrakala Devi said, ‘We have learned to write our names. Now let us learn to read what is written above them.’

Everyone laughed.

Phulo Devi asked, ‘Is it necessary to read everything above?’

Chandrakala said, ‘The signature goes below. The responsibility is written above.’

After that sentence, the manner of their meetings changed.

Along with the additions and subtractions in the savings ledger, they began practising how to read a document.

Sometimes it was a bank receipt, sometimes the quantity printed on a sack of seed, sometimes a notice from the panchayat.

They did not understand every word.

Whatever they did not understand, they circled.

At the next meeting, they looked for its meaning.

Meanwhile, four community paddy-drying platforms were built behind the panchayat building.

The idea was that when the rains ended and paddy began coming in from the fields, the village women could spread it there to dry.

Earlier, paddy had been dried wherever space could be found—in courtyards, beside the road, under thatched roofs.

The sight of the new platforms pleased everyone.

All four were paved.

They stood raised above the ground.

A small drain was to run along the edge so that rainwater would not remain standing.

For the first month, two of the platforms worked well.

A thin crack appeared across the middle of the third.

On one side of the fourth, the outlet for the water had never been made at all.

When it rained, water stood in a corner of the platform.

Sweeping the water away, Phulo Devi said, ‘Before we can dry anything here, we have to dry the drying platform itself.’

Everyone laughed, but the water remained in that corner for three days.

A month later, word came from the panchayat that the members of the Anjor Women’s Savings Group had to sign a form.

Madan Babu brought the form to their meeting.

He had a single sheet in his hand.

Across the top, in bold letters, were the words: ‘User Group Satisfaction Certificate.’

Below were twelve lines.

Madan Babu said, ‘Each of you write your name here. The work is complete. This is the paper for the final payment.’

Neelam Devi picked up the pen.

Chandrakala drew the page towards herself.

‘Read the line at the top first.’

Madan Babu smiled.

‘What is there to read? You have seen the work yourselves.’

Chandrakala read the first line slowly.

‘We… the users… certify…’

She stopped.

Phulo read the next word: ‘work…’

Neelam added, ‘complete…’

Then all three were held up by one word.

Madan Babu said, ‘Defect-free.’

Chandrakala read the whole line again.

‘The work has been found complete and defect-free.’

The room fell silent.

Phulo said, ‘Is the crack in the third platform not a defect?’

‘That is a small matter,’ Madan Babu said.

‘And the water on the fourth?’

‘That depends on how it is used.’

Chandrakala turned the sheet over.

The back was blank.

She asked, ‘Where are the rest of the papers?’

‘What rest?’

‘The work order. The measurements. What exactly was to be built. How long the responsibility for repairs lasts.’

Madan Babu stared at her.

‘What do you need with all that?’

Neelam said quietly, ‘Our signatures are being asked for at the end of all that.’

This time Madan Babu had no answer.

He said the complete file was at the panchayat office.

Chandrakala pushed the sheet back to him.

‘Then we will sign after we have seen the complete file.’

Madan Babu went away with the blank sheet.

The next day two women went to the panchayat building.

Then four.

In the end, eight women arrived.

The panchayat secretary said, ‘The file is bulky. It will be difficult for everyone to understand it.’

Chandrakala said, ‘We do not need to understand everything. We will understand as much as our signatures are meant to stand behind.’

The file was placed on the table.

It contained seventeen pages.

The first page gave the name of the work.

The second gave the cost.

From the third onward came the measurements and details of the materials.

On a separate sheet, the women wrote five words: ‘work, measurement, period, defect, responsibility.’

They began looking for those five words in the file.

Many lines went over their heads.

Whenever they did not understand a word, they asked the secretary again.

The sixth page contained the measurements of the four platforms.

The eighth described the drainage along their edges.

For the fourth platform, it said clearly that the slope was to run towards the drain at the back.

Phulo said, ‘There is not even an outlet to the drain there.’

The secretary put his finger on the line.

‘This was supposed to have been built.’

On the eleventh page, one line was circled in red ink.

‘Defect-correction period—twelve months.’

Neelam read it three times.

‘Twelve months.’

Chandrakala asked, ‘How many days has it been since the work was declared complete?’

The secretary checked the date.

‘Fifty-six days.’

Phulo did not laugh.

She only said, ‘So in fifty-six days the defect became ours. And who is responsible for the twelve months?’

The secretary sat straighter in his chair.

The file also contained a column for the security deposit.

That amount was not to be released in full before the defect-correction period ended.

The women did not argue about the amount.

Their question was something else.

‘If the correction period is still running, why is there already a sheet saying “defect-free”?’

The secretary said this was the normal procedure.

Chandrakala asked, ‘Does the file say anywhere that this is the normal procedure?’

The secretary fell silent.

Two days later, Nandkishore Sah, the contractor for the work, came to the village himself.

He inspected the platforms.

He bent over the crack in the third.

‘This is only a fine surface line,’ he said.

Phulo replied, ‘That may be so. The file says that if a defect is seen, it should be reported.’

‘Are you an engineer?’

‘I am not an engineer.’

‘Then who will judge how deep the crack is?’

‘The engineer will. I will only write that a crack can be seen.’

Nandkishore Sah went over to the fourth platform.

There was no water standing there then, but a thin green strip of moss was visible.

Chandrakala said, ‘Water collects here. The outlet is shown in the file, but it is not here.’

Nandkishore Sah said, ‘That can be fixed easily.’

‘Then we will write “defect-free” after it is fixed,’ Neelam said.

Nandkishore Sah's voice hardened.

'The final payment is being held up.'

Chandrakala replied, 'My signature is not meant to hold up a payment. But if I sign against what I have just read, the lie will be in my own writing.'

At that, Madan Babu looked at Chandrakala.

Until then he had thought the women's group signatures were only a formality.

Now the page lay on the table without a single name on it.

The following Monday, the junior engineer came.

He examined the crack.

He took measurements.

He checked the slope of the fourth platform.

He measured the unfinished drainage outlet.

He wrote that the upper layer of the third platform should be filled again and levelled.

The outlet of the fourth should be completed.

The work continued for five days.

The crack in the third platform was cut open and filled.

The drainage outlet behind the fourth was opened.

Not once during those days did the women ask to sign anything.

On the sixth day it rained.

The next morning, Chandrakala deliberately went to inspect the platforms.

There was no water in the corner of the fourth.

With her big toe, Phulo nudged a little water towards the slope.

The water ran into the drain.

The repaired strip on the third platform was still a different colour.

The women did not spread paddy on it.

The engineer had said it should be left unused for three days.

Three days later, the group met again.

This time Madan Babu opened the seventeen-page file at the final form.

The sheet was not separate.

The file lay open above it.

The signature lines were below.

Chandrakala read the first line.

'Joint inspection by the user group…'

Phulo read the next line.

Neelam read the date.

Madan Babu said, ‘If you want to add anything, write it here.’

Chandrakala looked at the secretary.

‘Was this line here before?’

The secretary said, ‘No. It has been added now.’

Phulo smiled.

She could write, but not long sentences.

Chandrakala asked her what they should write.

Phulo spoke slowly.

‘We saw that the crack in the third platform had been repaired. We saw that the drainage outlet of the fourth had been opened. We will begin using them after three days.’

Chandrakala wrote exactly that.

Below it, all twelve women wrote their names.

Nandkishore Sah was there as well.

He looked carefully at the page.

He said nothing.

Madan Babu put the form back into the file.

That day’s meeting did not end with the savings ledger.

Neelam took out an old bank receipt of her own.

She asked, ‘My signature is on this, but I never read the line above it.’

Phulo said, ‘We cannot change an old signature.’

Chandrakala replied, ‘We can change the next one.’

After that, the group made a small rule.

No member would sign a blank sheet.

No one would sign a detached final page if the meaning of what came before it was not visible.

Any line they did not understand would be read aloud and explained.

They would not certify anything they had not seen.

The rule was written on the last page of the ledger.

The twelve names were written beneath it again.

This time no one was in a hurry.

Two months later, a form arrived for renewing the group’s savings account.

Madan Babu was not there.

Nandkishore Sah was not there.

There was no contract involved.

It was only an ordinary bank form.

Neelam picked up the pen.

The signature line was in front of her.
First she turned the top part of the page towards herself.
Then she began to read.
The other eleven women waited in silence.

FROM THREE STREAMS OF STORIES · VOLUME II

STORY 61

Night on the Watch Platform

By the time Aghan was well underway, the paddy in the eastern tract of Majhaul village had turned yellow.

Four fields lay so close to one another that, seen from a distance, the ridges between them looked like little more than thin lines.

At one corner near the middle stood a bamboo watch platform.

The platform belonged to no single field.

Two bamboos had come from Ramlochan, four old planks from Kishori Mandal, the tiles from Jagdish, and two days of labour from Budhan.

Once it was built, the villagers began calling it the ‘four-field platform.’

The last twenty days before the paddy ripened were considered the hardest time for those four fields.

Birds descended by day, stray cattle wandered in at dusk, and at night nilgai or wild boar prowled along the field edges.

The four households had divided the night watches among themselves.

One night was Ramlochan’s, the next Kishori’s, the third Jagdish’s, the fourth Budhan’s.

Then the same order began again.

A piece cut from an old fertiliser sack hung from one post of the platform.

Dates and names were written on it in charcoal.

Beside the name of whoever had the watch that night, a circle was drawn.

At dawn, a tick was placed inside the circle.

The arrangement was so simple that for three weeks no one had called it a rule.

It was merely a custom.

Budhan was the only one of the four whose field was not his own.

He cultivated one and a half bighas belonging to Ramdas Chaudhary on a sharecropping arrangement.

On the watch roster, Budhan’s name was written instead of the landowner’s, because Budhan was the one who spent the night there.

Ramdas Chaudhary lived in town with his son.

He invariably came at harvest time for his half of the paddy, but the night watch on the platform was not part of his share.

Budhan had never questioned this.

The land was not his, but his labour was in the crop.

If the crop survived, half of it would reach his household too.

That was why the watch was his as well.

Budhan's house stood about half a kos behind the fields.

He lived there with his wife, Phulo, their twelve-year-old daughter Chandni, and his elderly mother, Sukni Devi.

Sukni Devi's knees had troubled her for years, but she was not a woman who would stop working and sit idle.

On days when paddy was dried, she could still turn the grain in a basket.

But for the past month, her breathing had grown a little heavy after dusk.

Twice Budhan had brought tablets from the village medicine shop.

Sukni would say, 'It is old age. How many medicines can I go on taking?'

Phulo would answer, 'Old age is one thing, breathlessness another.'

That Wednesday was Budhan's turn on watch.

He had remembered it since morning.

In the afternoon he went to the platform and inspected the southern corner of the thorn fence.

Three days earlier, a dry karil branch had fallen in the wind.

Budhan raised two branches and propped them upright again, but the soil underneath was loose.

He told Ramlochan, 'This corner ought to be tied up today.'

Ramlochan, rubbing a paddy ear between his fingers, said, 'We'll see to it by evening.'

Kishori was there too.

He said, 'First open the northern drain, otherwise the water will stand.'

The small jobs of the four fields kept pushing one another to the back of the queue all day long.

Budhan drove two stakes into the ridge of his field and returned home.

He intended to eat early and go to the platform.

After sunset, Phulo was taking the rice off the hearth.

Chandni brought water.

Sukni Devi sat by the courtyard wall, rubbing mustard oil into her knees.

Suddenly she began to cough.

Twice at first.

Then without stopping.

Phulo held out a lota of water.

Sukni tried to drink, but after half a sip she set the lota down.

Her breaths had become short and shallow.

Budhan left the morsel in his hand on his plate and sprang up.

'Ma?'

Sukni raised a hand as if to say it was nothing.

But her chest was rising and falling rapidly.

Phulo stopped what she was doing and rubbed her back.

'Not the medicine shop this time,' she said. 'Take her to the health centre.'

The primary health centre was three kos from the village.

Transport was hard to find after dusk.

Budhan ran to borrow a neighbour's bicycle.

Only then did he remember his turn on the platform.

He went towards Ramlochan's house.

Ramlochan was not there.

His daughter-in-law said, 'Kaka has gone to the market. He hasn't returned yet.'

Budhan said, 'When he comes, tell him that tonight is my watch, but I am taking my mother to the health centre.'

'All right.'

Budhan then turned towards Kishori's house.

Kishori's door was closed.

His younger brother opened it.

'Kishori bhaiya?'

'He has gone to our maternal uncle's house. He'll be back by nine.'

Budhan said, 'As soon as he comes, tell him someone must reach the platform. My mother is ill.'

The boy nodded.

Budhan thought of going to Jagdish's house as well, but from home came Phulo's voice.

'Don't waste time!'

He ran back.

It was not easy to seat Sukni Devi on a bicycle.

In the end Ramsevak lent them his old handcart.

They spread a sack over it and seated Sukni there.

Budhan and Phulo pulled the cart together as far as the main road.

Chandni stayed with a neighbour.

After half an hour on the road they found an empty milk van.

The driver took Sukni to the health centre.

Budhan's mobile phone had very little charge left.

He dialled Ramlochan's number.

It rang once, then the phone died.

Budhan put it back in his pocket.

The health centre was not crowded, but the doctor was seeing another patient.

It took time before Sukni was taken inside.

It was eight o'clock at night.

The watch platform kept entering and leaving Budhan's thoughts.

He said to Phulo, 'Should I go back?'

Phulo looked at him as though the answer to the question had already been obvious.

'Leaving Ma here?'

Budhan fell silent.

The doctor said phlegm had accumulated in her chest; they would give her medicine and steam, and watch her breathing through the night.

There was no great danger at present, but sending her straight home would not be wise.

Budhan sat down in the veranda.

There, the first watch of his night passed.

Meanwhile, the fertiliser sack on the platform flapped in the wind.

The circle beside Budhan's name was empty.

Ramlochan returned from the market at about half past eight.

When he reached home, his daughter-in-law gave him Budhan's message.

Ramlochan was tired.

As he untied his gamchha, he asked, 'Does Kishori know?'

'Budhan said he had told them there too.'

Ramlochan assumed Kishori must already have gone.

Kishori returned from his maternal uncle's house a little after nine.

His younger brother was asleep by then.

Budhan's message never reached him.

Jagdish was stitching up sacks of paddy in his courtyard.

His watch was the following night.

A little after ten, he put the sack aside and washed his hands.

From the direction of the distant fields came the sound of a metal plate being struck once.

Then silence.

Jagdish paused.

Whoever stayed on the four-field platform would strike the plate now and then to make his presence known.

Tonight it had sounded only once.

He thought Budhan must have arrived.

A little later his dog began barking towards the fields.

Jagdish stepped out to the doorway and stared into the darkness.

Nothing could be made out from that distance.

He took a torch and walked towards the fields.

The platform was empty.

The sack hanging from the post moved in the wind.

The metal plate lay on the ground.

Jagdish climbed up and swept his torchlight across all four fields.

At the southern corner, the karil fence looked pressed down.

He climbed down and went there.

There were fresh hoofprints in the soil.

Two nilgai had forced their way in through the gap in the fence.

One still stood near the ridge of Ramlochan's field.

The other was two or three paces inside the paddy field Budhan cultivated.

Jagdish shouted at the top of his voice.

'Hut! Haa!'

He picked up the metal plate and beat it with a stick.

The sound carried as far as Ramlochan's house.

Kishori heard it too.

Within ten minutes all three were in the fields.

The nilgai fled.

Some paddy plants had been flattened.

The gap in the southern fence had opened still wider.

Ramlochan's first question was, 'Where is Budhan?'

Jagdish said, 'The platform is empty.'

Only then did Kishori remember what his younger brother had been trying to tell him.

He went home and woke the boy.

Rubbing his eyes, the boy said, 'Budhan Kaka said his mother was ill.'

Kishori slapped a hand to his forehead.

'Why didn't you tell me earlier?'

'You weren't at home.'

‘And when I came back?’

The boy said nothing.

Ramlochan said, ‘Leave the blame there for now. First close the gap.’

Together the three men stood the karil branches up again.

Jagdish brought a slender bamboo from his field.

Kishori brought rope.

By about eleven the fence was closed again.

Ramlochan said, ‘Someone will have to stay now.’

Jagdish climbed onto the platform.

‘I’ll stay. Tomorrow was my turn anyway. Count this as one day early.’

Kishori said, ‘Then tomorrow?’

‘We’ll see tomorrow.’

Ramlochan stayed with him until midnight, then went home.

No animal came again that night.

At dawn, Jagdish did not put a tick inside Budhan’s circle on the fertiliser sack.

He drew only a short line beside it.

After sunrise, the four cultivators gathered again.

Kishori began counting the flattened plants.

‘Twenty-two here.’

Ramlochan looked at another row.

‘Eleven here.’

Jagdish said, ‘Some of them will stand up again.’

Ramlochan said, ‘The paddy is ripe. What is broken is broken.’

The discussion moved at once from plants to money.

Kishori estimated, ‘As much as one paseri lost.’

Jagdish laughed.

‘One paseri from twenty-two plants?’

Kishori was not offended.

‘I said it was an estimate.’

Ramlochan said, ‘And who will compensate on the basis of an estimate?’

Both men looked towards Budhan’s field.

Jagdish said, ‘First let Budhan come back.’

Budhan returned from the health centre at about nine.

Sukni Devi had been advised two days of medicine and steam inhalation.

Phulo took her home.

Budhan went straight to the field.

Seeing the platform empty, he first read the fertiliser sack.

He saw the line beside his name.

Then he saw the newly tied rope at the southern corner.

Ramlochan said, ‘Animals got in last night.’

Budhan’s face tightened.

‘How many?’

‘Two were seen.’

‘The paddy?’

Kishori showed him the flattened rows.

Budhan bent down and began lifting the plants.

Some ears were pressed into the soil; some stalks were merely bent.

He straightened them one by one.

Kishori said, ‘The question for all of us is that the watch was missed.’

Budhan stood up.

‘It was missed - I accept that.’

Ramlochan said, ‘Then there must also be some accounting for the loss.’

Budhan did not answer at once.

He went to the southern fence.

He scraped the soil beneath the newly tied bamboo.

‘This gap was there yesterday afternoon too.’

Ramlochan said, ‘A little. The animals pushed it down at night.’

‘I had said it should be tied.’

‘You did. I went to the market.’

‘Kishori bhaiya was busy with the northern drain.’

Kishori remained silent.

Budhan looked again at the hoofprints.

‘The animals did not come by way of the platform. They came through the gap.’

Ramlochan’s voice hardened.

‘If a watchman had been here, he would have driven them off as soon as they entered.’

‘That is also true.’

Budhan’s reply was brief.

‘Then?’

Budhan said, ‘I did not complete the work of my watch. Whatever work is decided in its place, I will do. But why should the price of twenty-two or thirty-three plants be put on my head by guesswork?’

Kishori said, ‘Because it was your night.’

Budhan looked towards the platform.

‘The night was mine. Whose fence was it?’

No one answered immediately.

The southern fence of the four-field platform actually began along the outer edge of Ramlochan’s field and ran to the corner of the field Budhan cultivated on shares.

When the fence was first made, Ramlochan had supplied the bamboo, Jagdish had cut the karil, and Budhan had done the work of driving it into the ground.

On paper, it belonged to no one.

By custom, it belonged to all.

Jagdish said, ‘The fence belongs to all, the watch belongs to all.’

Kishori said, ‘But the turns belong to one person at a time.’

Budhan nodded.

‘All right. Then let me make good my turn.’

Ramlochan asked, ‘How?’

‘I will spend the whole day today finishing this southern fence. And on one of the next seven nights, whichever watch is weakest, I will stay from two in the morning until dawn as an extra man.’

Kishori said at once, ‘How can a day’s fence work equal a night’s watch?’

‘I am not saying it is equal. I will do both.’

‘And the loss?’

Budhan looked at the flattened plants.

‘Count the ones that are broken. After harvest, see how many ears actually fail to fill. To call it one paseri now is not an account.’

Ramlochan fell silent.

Whether he fully liked Budhan’s answer or not was hard to tell.

But the words ‘one paseri’ had begun to feel heavy even to him.

Jagdish took the old fertiliser sack down from the platform and spread it on the ground.

‘Come, first let us look at the previous watches.’

They all sat around it.

It was hardly worthy of being called a register, but the dates and names were all there.

Jagdish asked, ‘Ramlochan Kaka, last Monday night was your watch?’

‘Yes.’

‘Until what time?’

Ramlochan thought.

‘The pump men came at two. I went home, then returned at dawn.’

Kishori laughed.

‘Then from two till dawn?’

‘No animal came.’

Jagdish said, ‘Is that an answer?’

Ramlochan’s face changed.

‘I am saying there were circumstances.’

Budhan said nothing.

Jagdish looked at the next date.

‘Kishori, it rained on your watch.’

‘I was on the platform.’

‘You went home after midnight.’

‘It was raining heavily. Where would animals have come from?’

‘Then you too had circumstances.’

Kishori began folding the fertiliser sack.

The matter was no longer about Budhan’s night alone.

All four were beginning to see that the old custom recorded only presence with a tick; it had no language for a lapse.

One man stayed the whole night, another half; someone sent a brother in his place; someone arrived late because of work at home.

As long as there had been no damage, no one had asked for an accounting.

The moment damage appeared, the old ticks suddenly became a rigid rule.

Ramlochan said, ‘Then make a rule. Otherwise we will quarrel until harvest.’

Kishori drew three lines in the soil with a stick.

First - night watch.

Second - fence/ridge.

Third - emergency.

Jagdish asked, ‘What happens in an emergency?’

Budhan said, ‘If before evening you know you cannot go, exchange the watch with another household and write it down.’

Ramlochan said, ‘And if it is sudden?’

Thinking of his mother, Budhan paused for a moment.

‘Then whatever the reason, say so in the morning. That night will be marked vacant. In return for a vacant night: one day’s work on the shared ridge or fence, and one extra late watch.’

Kishori asked, ‘How late a watch?’

‘From two until dawn.’

Jagdish said, ‘That is the difficult watch too.’

Ramlochan nodded.

‘Fine. But what if someone is only making excuses?’

Budhan said, ‘Everyone can hear the reason and decide. On the paper, write only “emergency,” not the whole story of the illness.’

Jagdish looked at him.

‘Why?’

‘Why should the platform register record how many times my mother coughed?’

This time Kishori nodded silently.

Ramlochan ran the stick once more along the third line in the earth.

‘And the damage?’

Jagdish said, ‘If an animal came through a gap in the fence, inspect the gap first. If the watchman was found asleep, that is different.’

Kishori added, ‘If a field was left open, its loss should not fall on everyone.’

Budhan said, ‘Write down what can actually be seen. No sacks of guesswork.’

Ramlochan laughed.

‘That one paseri has really offended you.’

Budhan laughed too.

‘I have nothing against a paseri of paddy. I object to a paseri that was never weighed.’

The tension eased a little.

That day, though he had returned exhausted from the health centre, Budhan worked on the southern fence until afternoon.

Jagdish joined him for an hour.

Two new bamboos were driven into the ground.

The karil branches were tied not only at the top but also at the bottom.

Where the soil was loose, mud was packed onto the ridge.

Kishori came in the evening to inspect it.

He said, ‘If this work had been done four days ago, there would have been no meeting today.’

Ramlochan replied, ‘There would have been no meeting, and no rule either.’

Kishori smiled.

Jagdish replaced the old fertiliser sack on the platform with a sheet of stout paper.

At the top he wrote: ‘Watch Register.’

Below it he drew four columns - date, name, night, shared work.

Kishori said, ‘Emergency?’

Jagdish added a fifth column.

‘Do we write the reason?’

Budhan said, ‘If necessary, only “emergency.”’

Ramlochan said, ‘Agreed by all?’

All four nodded.

That night was supposed to be Jagdish’s first regular turn, but he had already stayed the previous night in Budhan’s place.

The first test of the new rule arrived immediately.

Kishori said, ‘I will stay tonight. Jagdish can take my next turn.’

Jagdish said, ‘All right.’

For the first time, an exchange of watches was written in the register.

No merely spoken assurance.

An arrow between two names.

Three days passed quietly.

Sukni Devi’s breathing gradually returned to normal.

She began sitting in the courtyard sunshine again.

When Budhan left for the fields she would ask, ‘Did the paddy survive?’

Budhan would say, ‘The paddy and the platform both.’

Sukni would laugh.

‘There was a quarrel because of me, wasn’t there?’

‘Not because of you. Because of an empty watch.’

‘I don’t understand.’

‘Don’t. That is better.’

On the fifth night it was Ramlochan’s turn.

At dusk his small grandson developed a high fever.

There was only one bicycle in the house, and Ramlochan had to go to the market for medicine.

He went to the platform and said to Jagdish, ‘Can we exchange watches tonight?’

Jagdish had no work at home.

He agreed.

Another arrow was drawn in the register.

Kishori sat on the platform watching this.

He said softly, 'The rule was made because of Budhan, and Kaka is the first to use it.'

Ramlochan laughed.

'If a rule is for only one man, what kind of rule is it?'

Budhan was not there that night, but when he saw the register the next morning, he smiled.

His extra late watch was fixed for the seventh night.

It was Kishori's turn.

At two in the morning Budhan left home.

Sukni Devi was awake.

'The platform again?'

'Half the night.'

'Is it your turn tonight?'

'The part left over from the old turn.'

Whether Sukni understood or not, she said nothing.

She only brought out an old shawl from inside and gave it to him.

Budhan draped the shawl over his shoulders and left.

Kishori was waiting for him on the platform.

He climbed down.

'I'm not sleepy. If you want, shall I stay with you?'

Budhan said, 'The turn has to be made good, not shared.'

Kishori laughed.

'All right, owner.'

'The word "owner" does not suit me.'

Both laughed.

Kishori went home.

Budhan was alone on the platform, but this solitude was not like the solitude planned for his original watch.

He knew now that if a watch stood empty, the register had a name for that condition.

The night was somewhat cold, though the wind was not strong.

Wrapping the shawl around himself, he looked over the four fields.

The paddy ears did not shine alike in the faint moonlight.

One field lay a little lower, another higher.

One ridge was thick, another thin.

The platform was one.

At about three there was a rustling at the southern fence.

Budhan climbed down at once.

He swept the torchlight there.

Two goats outside were eating the karil leaves.

He drove them away.

This time the fence did not bend.

He tested the bamboo knot with his hand.

It was firm.

Towards dawn the sky began to whiten.

Budhan untied the register from the post of the platform.

He found the old date beside his name.

There the word ‘emergency’ had been written.

In the shared-work column opposite it was written: ‘southern fence.’

The space for the date of the extra watch was still blank.

Budhan picked up the charcoal.

He wrote the date.

Then he put a small tick beside it.

He did not fill in the empty circle from the old night.

The circle remained empty.

Beside it now stood two marks - one for a day’s work, one for a night’s watch.

By sunrise Ramlochan reached the field.

He looked at the register.

‘Account settled?’

Climbing down from the platform, Budhan said, ‘The account for the work I missed is settled. Not the account of my mother falling ill.’

Ramlochan was silent for a moment.

Then he looked towards the southern fence.

‘The rope hasn’t loosened?’

‘No.’

The two walked along the ridge.

Most of the paddy plants that had been flattened were standing upright again.

Where the stalks had broken, the ears were beginning to dry.

Ramlochan took one ear in his hand.

‘Not one paseri.’

Budhan smiled.

‘We’ll say after it is weighed.’

Ramlochan laughed too.

Behind them, the register on the platform post moved in the wind.

One night on that page was still empty.

But opposite that empty night, both the daytime fence work and the late-night watch were now recorded.

STORY 62

The Turning Seal

By five in the evening, the veranda of the Bisnapur Panchayat Office was usually almost empty.

In the rainy season that emptiness felt even denser.

Water kept drumming on the tin roof, and inside, the smell of old papers mingled with damp walls to create a peculiar odour.

Harinath Jha had been a clerk in this office for twenty-seven years.

His daily routine was divided down to the corner of the desk, the bunch of keys, and the order of the files.

The object he touched least was the old round seal.

A thick wooden handle.

A circular rubber face below.

Around it the words:

"GRAM PANCHAYAT BISNAPUR."

And in the centre, a small lotus.

After a new seal had been made, the old one was hardly used.

Even so, Harinath kept it on a sheet of white paper at the right-hand corner of his desk.

There was no rule behind that position.

Only habit.

One Monday evening, while closing the office, he lightly drew a pencil square around the seal.

He did it without thinking.

The next morning the square was empty.

The seal had moved three finger-widths to the left.

At first Harinath thought Phulo, who swept the office, must have touched it.

But Phulo had been cleaning the office for ten years, and before touching anything official on the desk she always called Harinath.

That day Phulo said, "I swept under the desk, not on top."

Harinath laughed.

"The wood must have shifted."

Phulo laughed too.

But nothing inside Harinath laughed.

On the white paper beneath the seal was half of a circular blue mark.

It was exactly the size of the outer ring of the seal.

Not a full impression.

As though the seal had not been pressed upright onto the paper, but had dragged along it on one edge.

Harinath folded the paper and put it into the drawer.

Until noon, his eyes kept returning to that drawer.

There had been blue ink like this thirteen years earlier too.

That monsoon had also been severe.

River water had reached two hamlets, and papers in dozens of houses had been soaked and destroyed.

The panchayat office had been crowded with requests for residence and family-verification certificates.

The then panchayat secretary, Devkinandan Babu, had said in haste, “If verification is complete, do not hold up the papers.”

Harinath had written day and night.

One evening eighteen blank forms had been stamped in advance so that the verified names could be filled in the next morning and the certificates handed out quickly.

It was not the proper procedure.

Harinath knew that.

There was no electricity that night.

The veranda was crowded.

Wet clothes.

Mud.

Crying.

Desperation.

Everything together.

In the morning, seventeen forms were found.

One was missing.

Devkinandan Babu had said, “It must have been torn in the crowd. Do not make an issue of it.”

Harinath entered seventeen instead of eighteen in the register.

He had not forgotten that single line in thirteen years.

A few months later whispers spread through the village that an outsider had shown a Bisnapur certificate to obtain flood relief.

Harinath never learned the name.

He never had the chance to see the paper.

But his mind had accepted one thing:

the missing form was still alive.

And one day it might return.

Now the seal was turning.

On Wednesday morning Harinath saw that the seal had moved two finger-widths forward from its place.

This time he had not drawn a pencil square.

Instead, he had left a small circle of dust beneath it on the wood of the desk.

The circle was broken.

On the paper there was again a half-round blue mark.

This one curved in the opposite direction from the first.

Harinath lifted the seal.

The wood was not cold.

It was slightly damp.

The round piece of wood holding the rubber beneath the handle seemed swollen on one side.

He brought it close to his nose.

The wood smelled of dampness.

Fine moisture from the wall above the desk crept downward in the rains, though no water dripped.

"This is the wood playing tricks," Harinath told himself.

But the ink?

The seal was no longer used.

The ink pad stayed locked in the drawer.

He opened the drawer.

The lid of the pad was firmly closed.

Then he remembered the new employee, Rachna Kumari.

Rachna had joined the office two months earlier.

Around thirty.

Quiet-spoken.

Patient with papers.

Where others sneezed at the sight of old files and hurried away, Rachna dusted them and matched page numbers.

The district office had given her one assignment:

prepare a verification list of old certificate files.

Not make copies.

Only match serial number, date, signature, and seal.

Harinath had thought the work ordinary.

Now it did not seem ordinary.

That afternoon Rachna sat before the old cupboard.

Bent over a page, she was examining an impression of the seal with a magnifying glass.

Harinath watched from a distance.

"What are you looking for?"

Rachna raised her head.

"The impressions of the old round seal are not all alike."

Harinath's throat dried.

"Old rubber wears down."

"That may be so."

Rachna looked back at the paper.

"But in some impressions the outer ring is thick, in others thin. In some, the vowel mark in 'Bi' is broken, in others complete."

Harinath sat down in his chair.

"So?"

"Nothing yet. First I will match the sequence."

There was no accusation in her voice.

That made Harinath more uneasy.

If Rachna had accused him, he could have prepared an answer.

A silent investigation was harder to answer.

That evening, before closing the office, Harinath placed the old seal upright on a thick sheet of paper.

He drew lines around the sheet.

He pushed a folded paper beneath the left leg of the desk to try to level it.

He put the ink pad into the drawer and locked it.

The key went into his own shoulder bag.

In the morning the seal was still inside the outline.

Harinath's chest lightened.

But beside it was a new half-round stain.

The colour was a very pale blue.

He lifted the paper.

The ring was dark on the right and almost invisible on the left.

As though ink had touched it from one direction.

Harinath examined the rubber face of the seal.

There was blueness on the outer edge.

"The pad was locked," he thought.

"Then where did this blue come from?"

Watchman Batuknath appeared at the door.

He placed the night key register on Harinath's desk.

The panchayat office had two sets of the main keys.

One remained in Harinath's charge.

The other was locked at night in a box in the watchman's room.

If any employee entered the office after closing, the name and time had to be entered in the register.

Trying to appear casual, Harinath turned the pages.

Monday:

Rachna, 6:10 p.m. to 6:38 p.m.

Tuesday:

Rachna, 5:55 p.m. to 6:22 p.m.

Wednesday:

no name.

Harinath stopped his finger on Wednesday's line.

The seal had left a stain on Wednesday night too.

So Rachna alone was not moving it.

But why had Rachna come into the office on Monday and Tuesday evenings?

"She said she had files to examine," Batuknath explained. "There was written permission from the secretary."

"How many times?"

"Twice. Not yesterday."

Harinath closed the register.

That day he worked less and observed more.

In the afternoon the rain intensified.

Water collected on the floor beside the right leg of the desk.

Phulo dried it with a cloth.

Suddenly Harinath placed a drop of water on the surface of the desk.

The drop moved very slowly from left to right.

The desk was not level.

He removed the folded paper he had pushed beneath its leg.

The drop moved faster.

The old wooden top sagged slightly in the middle.

He carefully tilted the seal onto one edge.

Its round base and swollen wooden handle made it rest on two points.

With a gentle push, it rolled half a turn.

Harinath's palm grew cold.

Not a ghost.

Something else.

But the question of the half-round blue stains remained.

He called Rachna.

"Did you use the old seal?"

Rachna answered directly.

"Yes."

Harinath had not been prepared for such an easy admission.

"On documents?"

"On old waste paper. Not on certificates."

"Why?"

Rachna took three white sheets from her bag.

Each bore an impression of the old seal.

One complete.

One faint.

One half-pressed.

"For comparison."

"Permission?"

"I am authorised to take seal samples for verification. But I did not take the old papers outside. I made the samples here."

"At night?"

"During the day there are too many people. When the old files are open, everyone asks questions. The secretary said I could work for half an hour after closing."

"And why is the wooden handle damp?"

For the first time Rachna looked surprised.

"I did not wash it."

She took the seal in her hand.

She noticed the dampness beneath the handle.

"This is from the wall. The paper it was lying on yesterday was damp too."

Harinath looked at the three sample impressions.

In all three, the blue ink was darker on the right side of the outer ring.

"Why is the ink heavier on this side?"

Rachna said, "One side of the rubber is recessed. The pressure is uneven."

"And on the old certificates?"

Rachna did not answer.

She brought a file from the cupboard.

“This is why I am verifying them.”

The file was dated from the monsoon thirteen years earlier.

Harinath’s eyes stopped on the year.

Rachna placed five certificate copies before him.

On four, the vowel mark in ‘Bi’ was broken in the middle.

On the fifth, it was complete.

On four, the left petal of the lotus was thin.

On the fifth, thick.

On four, a small segment of the outer ring was missing.

On the fifth, the circle was perfectly clear.

“This fifth certificate is not in your register,” Rachna said.

The sound of rain suddenly seemed very far away to Harinath.

“The name?”

Rachna did not turn the paper towards him.

“First understand the seal.”

With the blunt end of a pencil, she pointed to one place on the old rubber face.

“Look here. Where the vowel mark in ‘Bi’ is broken, the rubber itself is split.”

“How long has it been split?”

“At least since the time of the first four certificates in this file, because all four carry the same break.”

“So the fifth?”

“This fifth certificate was not stamped with this seal.”

For a long time Harinath stared at the paper.

The shape of the suspicion that had lain like a stone inside him for thirteen years was changing.

The missing blank form had already been stamped with the old seal.

If that form had been used, its impression should have contained the broken vowel mark.

This certificate had been made with another seal.

“Then my missing paper?” Harinath asked softly.

Rachna looked at his face.

“What missing paper?”

The words had already escaped Harinath’s mouth.

He sat away from the back of his chair.

Outside, the rain was easing.

Phulo was tipping buckets of water off the veranda.

Harinath told Rachna about the eighteen pre-stamped blank forms from thirteen years earlier.

He also told her that he had written seventeen in the register.

He mentioned Devkinandan Babu's instruction, but did not hide behind it.

"I could have written that one form was missing," he said. "I did not."

Rachna listened in silence.

"I was afraid the paper had gone outside. Then I heard the whispers. Since then I have kept thinking that one day this seal would catch me."

Rachna wiped the moisture from the wooden handle with a dry cloth.

"A seal catches no one," she said. "Papers do. Time does. Sometimes a mistake does."

Harinath said nothing.

Rachna showed him the name on the fifth certificate.

Harinath had never heard it.

The certificate was dated not thirteen years earlier, but ten years earlier.

Three years after the blank form had gone missing.

"This forged certificate is a separate matter," Rachna said. "It carries a copied seal. That is why I was taking samples from the original old seal."

"Why did you not tell me?"

"You are the old hand in this office. If I had told you first, your memory might have shaped the direction of my inquiry. I wanted to look at the papers first."

There was no accusation in the answer.

But there was distance.

Harinath felt that distance was justified.

He opened the key register again.

The times of Rachna's two evening visits were clear.

"You did not come on Wednesday night. Yet the seal moved."

Rachna examined the desk.

From one file she took a small round glass paperweight and placed it on the tabletop.

The ball slowly rolled to the right.

"The desk slopes."

Rachna laid the seal on one side.

"The wood has swollen with dampness. If it is left upright, nothing happens. If it rests on its side, it can roll."

"But I always leave it upright."

“Yesterday?”

Harinath tried to remember.

Yesterday he had lifted the seal, examined the rubber, and then put it down in a hurry.

Perhaps not fully upright.

Rachna looked at the sheet carrying the half-round stain.

“See this. It is not an impression. It is abrasion.”

She turned the paper.

The darker portion lay in the direction of the desk’s slope.

“Residual ink on the edge of the rubber touched the paper while it rolled.”

“But the pad was locked.”

“In this damp weather, ink does not dry completely in a single day.”

Harinath counted the days on which Rachna had taken the sample impressions.

Monday and Tuesday.

By Wednesday the rubber edge could still have remained blue.

The connection was ordinary.

Fear had made it extraordinary.

In the afternoon the secretary came to the office.

Rachna showed him the fifth certificate, the sample impressions, and the verification list.

Harinath told his own story as well.

The secretary remained silent for a long time.

He was not from Devkinandan Babu’s time.

For him the crowd of thirteen years earlier was history.

For Harinath it was smell and sound.

“Can we now mention that one of the eighteen forms was missing?” the secretary asked.

Rachna said, “Do not erase the original line. Add a delayed note beside it. Use today’s date.”

A knot tightened in Harinath’s stomach.

“Then questions will arise.”

“They will,” the secretary said.

Harinath looked out the window.

The rain had stopped.

Water dripped from the mango leaves.

He asked for the register.

The page from thirteen years earlier had yellowed.

The line carried the number seventeen.

Harinath's own handwriting.

There was very little empty space beside it.

Rachna gave him a narrow strip of paper on which a note could be added and assigned a serial reference.

Harinath wrote:

"On the original working day, a total of eighteen pre-stamped forms were prepared; at the time of distribution, seventeen were available. One form remained unavailable. This fact could not be entered in the register at the time. The record is being completed through this delayed note."

He stopped after writing "could not be entered."

Then he did not strike it out.

Beside it he added in smaller words:

"was not entered."

The sentence changed.

The lapse was no longer the weather's.

It belonged to a person.

Harinath signed.

The secretary signed too.

Rachna entered the forged certificate separately in the verification list.

Its seal did not match the genuine old office seal.

That matter would be sent onward for investigation.

But Harinath's thirteen-year-old question about the missing form would remain separate.

Separate—

but not ended.

That evening, when closing the office, Harinath did not leave the old seal on the desk.

He asked for a small dry box.

Thick paper below.

Cotton cloth above.

The seal was cleaned and placed upright.

The ink pad was kept separately.

The date was written on the box.

Rachna said, "Now it will not turn."

Harinath smiled faintly.

"Have the desk levelled too."

The next day a carpenter came.

He nailed a thin wooden strip beneath the right leg of the desk.

The desk became level.

Harinath took the old paper with the half-round blue stain from the drawer.

He did not tear it.

Nor did he put it in the verification file.

He kept it among his private papers.

A few days later a letter arrived from the district.

The seal on the forged certificate had been found not to be the genuine office seal.

Further inquiry would proceed separately.

Harinath could have felt greatly relieved after reading the letter.

But he did not feel completely light.

There was still no answer about the missing form.

Perhaps it had never been used.

Perhaps it had.

Between those two possibilities there was now one difference:

it was written in the register.

Silence was no longer part of the official record.

A week later it rained again.

The office walls grew damp.

Water drummed on the tin roof.

Phulo swept the floor.

Batuknath placed the key register on the desk.

Rachna sat down and opened an old file.

Harinath opened the box and looked at the seal.

It was exactly where it had been placed.

He closed the box.

There was no new half-round blue mark on the desk.

Yet the shape of the old stain remained clear in Harinath's memory—

not a full circle.

Only half.

It seemed to him that some truths also arrive first as half a circle.

The remaining half has to be completed not by paper, but by a human being.

STORY 63

Chair Number Zero in the Waiting Room

When the district hospital's new outpatient building opened, during the first week people talked less about doctors, medicines, or examination rooms than they did about the chairs.

In the old veranda people had sat with their backs against the wall, on steps, on window ledges, sometimes on the floor.

In the waiting hall of the new building, forty-eight identical grey chairs had been placed in two rows, and white numbers from 1 to 48 were painted on their backs.

The numbers were for the convenience of the staff.

So the cleaner could identify which chair in which row was loose.

So the repair worker could know which screw needed replacing.

So the inspector could know whether all forty-eight purchased items were present.

The numbers had nothing to do with the patients' order.

But in a hospital, a thing that is perfectly clear on paper often acquires a second meaning by the time it reaches the other side of the wall.

In the right-hand corner of the waiting hall, beside the drinking-water vessel, stood one old iron chair.

Its back was higher than the others.

It was painted blue.

And in the middle, in thick red paint, was the number "0."

One arm bore the mark of an old strip.

The lower right leg was slightly bent.

Why this chair was in the new building was a question for which different staff members had different answers.

Jagdish Babu, the store-room in-charge, said,

"It is an item removed from the old inventory."

Watchman Rambabu said,

"There is no order to throw it out."

Budhni, the cleaner, said,

"If it is kept outside, someone will carry it away."

And Neelam, who wrote the outpatient register, said,

"It was put wherever there was space."

The chair offered no explanation of its own.

Only the zero remained written on its back.

For the first two days no one sat on it.

People filled chairs 1 through 48, then stood against the wall.

They would notice Zero, pause for two moments, then move elsewhere.

In a hospital, a written number often looks like an instruction.

No one understood what instruction "0" was giving.

On the third afternoon, seventy-two-year-old Sheetal Paswan arrived with his grandson Manoj.

He was short of breath.

Manoj took a queue slip from the registration desk, but the crowd was so large that their turn to reach the doctor was still far away.

Sheetal Babu stood for five minutes.

Then his knees began to tremble.

"Sit somewhere," Manoj said.

Every chair was occupied.

Zero, beside the water vessel, was empty.

Without even looking at the number, Sheetal Babu sat down there.

Five minutes later Nurse Rama came to fetch water.

Her eyes fell on Sheetal Babu's lips.

They looked unusually blue.

Rama bent down, checked his pulse, listened to his chest, and said to Manoj,

"Show me the queue slip."

With trembling hands Manoj gave her the paper.

Rama wrote something on it and took Sheetal Babu inside immediately.

The entire incident lasted no more than three minutes.

But the thirty-seven people sitting in the waiting hall saw it in thirty-seven different ways.

One person saw the nurse come directly from a distance to Chair Zero.

Another thought Manoj had shown some special mark.

Someone thought they heard Rama say "first."

An hour later Sheetal Babu was in the observation room on oxygen.

By then Chair Number Zero had already been promoted in the waiting hall.

"It is for serious patients," one woman told another.

"For the elderly," the second replied.

"No, for getting an earlier number," a third person said.

Watchman Rambabu heard them.

"It is nothing special. It is an old chair."

All three looked at him with the kind of kindly expression people use for an employee who does not understand the rules.

The next morning before the hospital opened, a man had placed his towel on Chair Zero to reserve it.

He himself was standing in line at the registration desk.

Behind him stood an elderly woman.

Rambabu picked up the towel and handed it back.

"You cannot reserve a place here."

"My patient is coming."

"Then let the patient sit when they come."

"This is the special chair, isn't it?"

"Nothing special about it."

The man read the nameplate on Rambabu's chest, as though collecting evidence for a later complaint against this statement.

By half past nine, a small line had formed in front of Zero.

Five people stood in it.

Seven of the forty-eight ordinary chairs were empty.

Neelam came out from the registration desk.

"Please sit down."

One woman said,

"I need Zero."

"Why?"

"My husband is very dizzy."

"Then show him to the nurse."

"He will sit on Zero first, then the nurse will see him."

Neelam paused before answering.

Official hospital procedure said that critically ill patients were to receive primary screening at a small table to the left of the entrance.

But that day the table was short one nurse.

People often entered the waiting hall directly.

The rumour about Chair Zero was foolish.

But inside that foolishness, a real weakness in the hospital had found a place for itself.

Neelam said quietly to Rambabu,

"If someone genuinely looks very unwell, send them to Rama Didi."

Rambabu replied,

"People will say I am distributing Zero."

"Then do not distribute Zero. Look at the patient."

"That is not in my job."

Neelam did not smile.

"Then look after the chair. Is that in your job?"

For two moments Rambabu looked at the chair.

In government service, many things are neither within one's post nor entirely outside one's responsibility.

Within a week, Chair Number Zero had become a small hospital legend.

Some said sitting there made the doctor notice you sooner.

Some said it was the "emergency chair."

Some said the District Officer had sat there during an inspection and therefore it was prestigious.

The last story was entirely invented.

Because it sounded the most respectable, it spread the fastest.

Some people went over merely to look at the chair.

Some asked for "0" to be written on their queue slips.

One day Neelam saw the words "Chair-0" written in red ink beside a patient's name on a slip.

"Who wrote this?"

The patient's son said,

"The babu outside."

"Which babu?"

"The one who is telling everyone."

There was no babu outside.

A young tea seller, answering so many people's questions, had gradually appointed himself an information clerk.

He charged five rupees for tea.

The information was free.

Free information is often the most expensive.

Neelam struck out the red "Chair-0."

Five minutes later the patient's blood pressure was found to be dangerously low.

He was sent inside quickly.

His son came back out and told everyone,

"See? Zero was written there."

Neelam's cancellation line became proof of the rumour.

The matter reached the hospital administration when two contradictory letters appeared in the complaint box on the same day.

The first said:

"Influential people seize the special Zero chair and poor patients do not benefit."

The second said:

"The Chair Number Zero arrangement is excellent. A similar chair should be provided in the women's ward."

Superintendent Dr. Pramod Mishra read both letters.

Then he called Store In-Charge Jagdish Babu.

"What is this Chair Zero?"

Jagdish Babu brought not a file but a register.

"Sir, officially, it is nothing."

"Then why is it in the hospital?"

"Because officially it was never removed either."

"Explain."

Jagdish Babu opened the old furniture inventory.

Against Chair Number 73 it read:

"Paint peeled, arm damaged, declared unserviceable."

On the next page a note in blue ink said:

"Proposed for inclusion in auction list."

There was no order after that.

"Why is Zero painted on its back?"

"Perhaps someone marked it during the auction process."

"Perhaps?"

"The old employee has retired."

"Then remove it."

Jagdish Babu fell silent.

"What is it?" the Superintendent asked.

"To remove it, we need an item number."

"Seventy-three, isn't it?"

"Seventy-three is not in the new building inventory.

It exists in the old auction proposal, but the auction order never came.

If I remove it as 73, there is no such item in the current inventory.

If I write 0, then Chair 0 does not exist in the government register."

The Superintendent took off his spectacles and placed them on the desk.

"So the most famous chair in the hospital does not exist on paper?"

"Yes, sir."

"And because it does not exist on paper, it cannot be removed?"

Jagdish Babu answered carefully,

"It can be removed, but later someone may ask which item was removed."

A small meeting began right there over that question.

The Superintendent called Mahesh Babu from Accounts.

The moment he saw the register, Mahesh Babu said,

"Zero is a number, but not an asset number.

If we treat it as an asset number, it comes before one.

Then the purchase sequence is disturbed."

Nurse Rama, who happened to enter on another matter, said,

"A patient can also arrive before one, if their breathing is stopping."

Mahesh Babu looked at her.

"I am talking about the chair sequence, not the patient sequence."

"That is exactly the problem," Rama said.

"People are mistaking the chair sequence for the patient sequence."

The Superintendent asked,

"Then write that the two are unrelated."

Neelam, standing there with the complaint letters, said quietly,

"People read only half of what is written, sir."

Mahesh Babu said,

"Then it is their responsibility to read the whole thing."

Neelam replied,

"People do not come to a hospital after taking training in how to read rulebooks while ill."

The meeting had been called for five minutes.

It lasted forty-five.

In the end everyone agreed that the chair was not "special."

But they could not agree whether it was "extra," "unserviceable," "unlisted," or "pending verification."

Each of the four words belonged to a different branch.

The Superintendent put his spectacles back on.

"In this country an object is destroyed first, and its existence is proved later."

Jagdish Babu did not laugh.

He understood that the remark could also be applied to his own department.

The next day an order was issued:

“Chair Number 0 shall be removed immediately from the waiting hall and kept safely in stores. Disposal procedure shall be undertaken after verification of item status.”

Rambabu read the order and tried to lift the chair.

Three patients objected at once.

“Why are you removing it?”

“Orders.”

“Where will the serious patients sit?”

“On any chair.”

“Then why was there a Zero?”

Rambabu stood there with the chair half lifted.

No one had given him a written answer to that question.

At that moment a thin woman entered holding the hand of her ten-year-old daughter.

The child’s forehead was hot.

Her eyes were half closed.

Seeing the crowd, the mother panicked.

Chair Zero was half in the air.

“Babu, may my child sit here?” the woman asked.

Rambabu looked at the order.

Then at the child.

Then he placed the chair back on the floor.

“Sit her down. I will call the nurse.”

The child was examined.

She had a high fever but was not in immediate danger.

She remained in the normal queue.

The mother breathed with relief.

Sitting on Zero did not move the child forward.

But no one clearly explained that outside that day.

People saw only that the child sat on Zero and the nurse came.

The order could not be implemented by evening.

The next day the administration tried a different solution.

A white notice was fixed to the wall above the chair:

“CHAIR 0 IS NOT A SPECIAL PRIORITY CHAIR. PATIENT PRIORITY IS DETERMINED BY MEDICAL SCREENING.”

Within fifteen minutes, a line again formed in front of Zero.

Rambabu held his head.

"Now what?"

The young tea seller explained with complete confidence,

"It is written on the notice itself—'special priority chair.' People are not reading the whole sentence."

Neelam came outside.

Indeed, four people were standing there after seeing the large words "SPECIAL PRIORITY CHAIR."

The word "NOT" in the middle looked small.

She had the notice taken down.

Meanwhile Nurse Rama wrote a short proposal.

A clearly marked primary-screening desk at the entrance.

Two designated chairs before it.

Training for the watchman.

The proposal was medical, but to implement it required approval from three branches:

Building.

Staffing.

Stores.

The file began circulating through all three.

Chair Zero remained in place.

Two weeks later a district inspection took place.

The inspector entered the waiting hall and counted the chairs.

Numbers 1 through 48 were all there.

Then his eyes fell on Zero.

"Is this on the inventory?"

Jagdish Babu replied,

"Pending verification."

"Use?"

Rambabu opened his mouth.

Neelam spoke first.

"For sitting."

The inspector placed a hand on the chair.

"Then why is the number zero on it?"

No one had a certain answer.

The inspector wrote in his notes:

"One additional chair available; include in inventory."

A week later the new stores register arrived.

After the forty-eight grey chairs, the final line read:

"Chair, iron, blue, old—1 unit."

It was assigned item number:

49.

Jagdish Babu breathed with relief.

"Now it can be removed."

But by then Nurse Rama's proposal had been approved.

Two chairs were needed at the entrance for primary screening.

To avoid a new purchase, the Stores Branch wrote:

"Use available extra old chair."

The following Monday, Chair Zero was lifted from the right-hand corner of the waiting hall and placed beside the primary-screening desk at the entrance.

The red "0" was still on its back.

In the register its number had become 49.

People now saw it and asked,

"Is the Zero chair for serious patients?"

Rama would say,

"No. Sit for screening."

Most people heard "screening."

The "no" was lost again.

A few months later the red zero had worn partly away.

Old iron began showing beneath the blue paint.

New patients kept arriving at the hospital.

New queue slips kept being issued.

New rules kept being hung on the walls.

In the stores register, Chair 49 became an ordinary regular item.

But in people's speech it remained Chair Number Zero—

the chair that had never possessed any official authority, but because of which the hospital had finally been forced to create a real system of primary screening.

STORY 64

The Empty Date Field

That year, the old assembly hall of the Block Office had been turned into a flood-relief room.

A faded notice about marriage registration still hung on the wall.

Below it, a new sheet had been pasted:

“Application for Complete House Damage: Form 6-A.”

In the veranda, long bamboo platforms had replaced benches because the floor had remained under water until two weeks earlier.

People sat on the platforms drying their papers, waiting for their names to be called, and from time to time looking towards the river.

Junior Assistant Kumud Jha had been assigned the digital-entry work.

Before her stood an old computer larger than a mobile phone, a small printer, and two batches of papers.

The fields on the screen opened one after another:

Name.

Father or husband.

Village.

Family number.

Type of house.

Category of damage.

Bank account number.

And finally, a field enclosed by a red border:

“Exact Date of Damage.”

The word “exact” had troubled Kumud from the first day.

A name could be exact.

A bank account number could be exact.

But how could there be an exact date for a house taken by a river when the river first took the courtyard, then a wall, then the hearth, then the room?

The screen did not ask that question.

If she left the field blank, red text flashed:

“Date required.”

For the first two days, most people simply gave one date.

“Night of the fourteenth.”

“Morning of the fifteenth.”

“Afternoon of the sixteenth.”

Kumud kept entering them.

On the third day, Janaki Devi arrived.

She was close to seventy.

Her white hair clung to her head as if still wet.

In her hand was a blue cloth bag.

Her granddaughter Renu was with her, carrying all the documents in a transparent folder.

Kumud asked the name.

Renu opened the papers one by one and answered.

Village:

Kharihani Tola.

House:

mixed mud-and-brick.

Ownership:

Janaki Devi.

Family members:

three.

The site-inspection slip said:

"Complete damage."

Kumud continued filling the screen.

Then came the final field.

"When did the damage occur?"

Janaki Devi looked at Kumud's face.

"Which damage?"

"When did the house go?"

"When did the whole house go at once?"

Kumud stopped with her hands on the keyboard.

Janaki Devi said,

"The first night the vegetable plot behind the house was cut away.

The second night the wall of the kitchen fell.

The third night half the room where I slept went into the river.

By morning the roof had sagged down on its own.

You tell me—

when did the house go?"

Renu added softly,

"We had been sleeping on the neighbour's veranda since the first night."

Kumud looked again at the site-inspection slip.

The inspection date was 18 August.

The field for date of damage was blank.

"Which dates were those three nights?"

Renu said,

"10, 11, and 12 August."

Below the form on Kumud's screen, one line from the district notification glowed:

"Notified flood-damage period: 11 August 00:00 to 13 August 24:00."

An event on 10 August was not eligible under Form 6-A.

Events on 11 and 12 August were.

Janaki Devi did not understand the significance of the line.

She only said,

"Write all three days."

"It accepts only one."

"Then leave it blank."

"It will not accept a blank."

Janaki Devi looked at the screen as though some stubborn employee were sitting inside it.

"Tell the machine the river took three nights."

Kumud wanted to smile faintly.

She did not.

Twenty-five people were waiting on the bamboo platform behind her.

At the neighbouring table, Revenue employee Prabhakar Babu was examining papers.

Kumud called to him.

"In this case the damage occurred over three days.

Which date should I enter?"

Without raising his head, Prabhakar Babu said,

"The day the whole house went."

Janaki Devi replied at once,

"It has not entirely gone even now.

One corner of brick is still standing."

Prabhakar Babu looked up.

"The day it became unfit to live in."

Renu said,

"We had been staying outside since the first night."

“Then 10 August.”
Kumud said quietly,
“If I enter the tenth, the system shows it outside the notified period.”
Prabhakar Babu’s hand stopped.
He looked at the screen.
Then at Janaki Devi.
“When did the kitchen fall?”
“On the eleventh.”
“The main room?”
“On the twelfth.”
Prabhakar Babu thought for a few moments.
“Enter the twelfth.
Treat that as the day of complete damage.”
Janaki Devi asked,
“What does ‘treat’ mean?”
“For the paper.”
“And for the house?”
Prabhakar Babu picked up another file.
“The river knows about the house.”
Kumud entered:
12-08.
The red border turned green.
The screen moved on.
Janaki Devi’s application was accepted.
The printed receipt clearly said:
“Date of Damage: 12 August.”
Janaki Devi looked at the paper.
“The twelfth?”
Kumud said,
“Yes.
On the form.”
Janaki Devi put the paper in her bag.
Renu thanked her.
They left.
The next person sat down at Kumud’s desk.
Ramvriksh Yadav.

The rear part of his house had been cut away on the night of the thirteenth.

The main wall fell on the morning of the fourteenth.

He himself said,

"Write the thirteenth."

Kumud asked,

"When did the complete damage occur?"

Ramvriksh replied,

"On the fourteenth."

"Then the fourteenth?"

At once he said,

"No, no.

We had emptied the house from the night of the thirteenth.

Treat it as the thirteenth."

Kumud looked at the district period.

The thirteenth was eligible.

The fourteenth was not.

"You just said the main wall fell on the fourteenth."

Ramvriksh lowered his voice.

"Didi, did the river cut the house by looking at a clock?

Half before midnight, half after.

Which hour should I write?"

His question was no different from Janaki Devi's.

But the stakes in the answer were different.

Kumud stopped the form.

"Show me the site-inspection slip."

The Revenue employee had written:

"House unfit for habitation; family displaced from night of 13 August."

Kumud entered 13 August.

The red border turned green.

Ramvriksh breathed in relief.

By noon that day, the "exact date" had become the hardest question in the room.

One person's house had begun collapsing on the morning of 12 August, but he slept under a tree that night.

Another roof fell on the morning of the fourteenth, but the family had left the house on the evening of the thirteenth.

In another case, the first wall fell within the notified period and the second outside it.

Employees began creating informal definitions.

Some said:

"The day the roof went."

Some:

"The day the hearth stopped."

Some:

"The day the family slept elsewhere."

The Stores Assistant joked,

"The day a man put the key to his own house in his pocket and slept on someone else's veranda—that is the date of damage."

Prabhakar Babu stopped him.

"Do not joke.

There will be an audit later."

The joke stopped.

The definitions did not.

The next day Block Development Officer Archana Singh came to inspect the relief room.

She looked at the crowd, registers, bank numbers, and site-inspection papers.

Kumud raised the problem of the "exact date."

Archana Singh first gave a simple answer.

"Enter the actual date."

Kumud showed her Janaki Devi's case.

"There is no single actual date."

Archana Singh read the slip.

"Then the inspecting employee should write one."

Prabhakar Babu said,

"Even during inspection we choose one day.

There is no rule telling us why that day should be chosen."

Archana Singh sat down.

The screen with its red field was before her.

She clicked open the date field.

A calendar appeared:

choose one day.

There was no way to choose two days together.

No separate remarks field.

"Write to the district," she said.

Kumud asked,

"Until then, should we stop the applications?"

The queue on the veranda had reached the wall.

Archana Singh looked outside.

"No.

Make an interim criterion.

In writing."

A meeting was held that same evening.

The subject:

"Determination of Damage Date in Progressive River Erosion."

The faded marriage-registration notice still hung on the assembly-hall wall.

Beneath it, employees were trying to decide the death date of a house.

Prabhakar Babu wrote three proposals:

First structural damage.

Displacement of the family.

Complete collapse.

The Accounts Assistant said,

"If we use first damage, many cases will fall outside the notified period."

Archana Singh replied,

"We cannot define the rule by looking at eligibility."

"If we use complete collapse, some houses are still incomplete even today," Kumud said.

"One piece of wall may remain standing, though no one can live there."

Prabhakar Babu struck out the third line.

At last they wrote:

"In cases of progressive erosion, the date of damage shall be the date on which, according to site inspection, the dwelling first became unfit for habitation or the family left the house for safety, whichever occurred earlier."

"Left permanently?" the Stores Assistant asked.

"If people return three days later to collect belongings?"

The wording was cut.

"Permanently" was removed.

It became:

"left for night residence."

The Accounts Assistant asked,

"Why night?

What if the house falls during the day?”

Again the wording was cut.

After five rounds of revision, the sentence became:

“The day on which the house became unsuitable for safe habitation and the family was compelled to stay elsewhere.”

Archana Singh signed it.

“If the district replies, we will change it.”

Kumud asked,

“What about the forms already entered?”

“If they match this criterion, leave them.

If not, correct them.”

Kumud reviewed sixty-four forms late into the evening.

In thirteen, the date appeared to require correction.

In five cases, changing the date would alter eligibility.

One of those five was Ramvriksh’s.

His site-inspection paper clearly said:

“Family displaced from night of 13 August.”

The thirteenth remained unchanged.

Another was Raghuni Sah’s.

His roof fell on the night of the thirteenth.

But the family left the house on the morning of the fourteenth.

The inspection remark said:

“One room usable on night of 13 August.”

Under the new criterion:

14 August.

Outside the notified period.

Kumud kept her hand on the file for a long time.

Correcting the date would automatically mark Raghuni Sah’s form “outside period.”

His relief would stop.

Not correcting it would make Kumud herself the first person to violate the written criterion.

Raghuni Sah was called the next morning.

He was a thin man of about fifty-five.

He did small tailoring work in a cloth shop.

His sewing machine had also been damaged in the flood.

Kumud asked,

"Did you sleep in the house on the night of the thirteenth?"

Raghuni Sah said,

"I did not.

I had sent my wife and children to my sister's house.

I stayed behind to move the belongings."

"Where did you sleep that night?"

"On the dry part of the veranda.

Until midnight.

When the water rose, I went to the school."

Prabhakar Babu asked,

"Then was the house safe enough to live in?"

Raghuni Sah remained silent for a moment.

"Safe?

If it had been safe, why would I have sent the children away?"

Kumud read the new criterion aloud:

"The day on which the house became unsuitable for safe habitation and the family was compelled to stay elsewhere."

Raghuni Sah said,

"The family went elsewhere on the thirteenth.

I was the fool who stayed to save things.

Did my staying behind become proof that the house was safe?"

No one in the room answered immediately.

Prabhakar Babu said softly,

"The family did go elsewhere on the thirteenth.

On that basis the thirteenth can remain."

Kumud asked,

"What if it had been a person living alone?"

Prabhakar Babu looked at the paper.

"Then the question would arise again."

Raghuni Sah gathered his receipt.

"You people find the date.

I could not save the house."

He stood up.

There was bitterness in the sentence.

His voice was tired.

The district's reply came five days later.

The essential point in the two-page letter was one line:

"Entry of a single date on the digital platform is mandatory; on the basis of local inspection records, the competent authority shall determine an appropriate date."

Kumud read the letter three times.

The word "appropriate" did not solve the problem.

It merely promoted it to a higher office.

Archana Singh read the letter.

"Our criterion will continue."

Meanwhile, people in the relief room learned new ways of remembering dates.

Someone would say:

"It was a Monday."

The staff checked a calendar.

Someone:

"The school closed that day."

The school register was checked.

Someone:

"My eldest granddaughter had fever."

A medicine slip was searched for.

Someone:

"The moon was half."

At that, Prabhakar Babu said,

"Do not add the moon to the records."

One elderly woman said,

"I do not remember the day, but that morning the mosque loudspeaker was silent."

Another employee asked,

"Why?"

"Water had entered."

To find the date, they telephoned the mosque caretaker.

He could not remember the date either.

He only said,

"The day the electricity transformer was shut down."

The date was found from the electricity office register.

Gradually the relief room became less a place for examining house damage than a room for investigating dates.

On Kumud's desk accumulated a small calendar, the school closure register, electricity-disconnection lists, boat-operation slips, and dates of medicine distribution from the health centre.

For an event in someone's life to become a government date, it had to seek support from another document.

Kumud began to feel a certain satisfaction in this work.

Evidence was better than guesswork.

But she also understood that evidence was not equal for everyone.

A household with a mobile phone could produce the date from a photograph.

A family with a child in school could remember the day the school closed.

A person with no papers at all had only memory.

And memory could not be uploaded onto the digital platform.

Janaki Devi came again.

This time Renu was not with her.

She carried the same blue bag.

"My paper says the twelfth, doesn't it?"

"Yes."

"People in the village say that if the tenth had been written, I would not have received the money."

Kumud did not conceal the truth.

"The tenth was outside the notified period."

Janaki Devi sat down.

"I had left the house from the night of the tenth.

Then did I get a lie written?"

Kumud said,

"The main room went on the twelfth.

The site inspection says complete damage.

I entered it on that basis."

"But you had asked:

when did the house go?"

"The question on the form is not right."

Janaki Devi seemed a little calmer after hearing this.

"If the question is wrong, does the answer become a lie?"

Kumud had the rule sheet before her.

She had no answer to that question.

From the blue bag, Janaki Devi took out an old calendar, water-stained and damp.

The page was August.

The corners of the tenth, eleventh, and twelfth were grey with mud.

Later, Renu had written in red ink:

10 — “vegetable plot.”

11 — “hearth.”

12 — “room.”

“These are the three days of the house,” Janaki Devi said.

“Renu wrote them down.

Your paper has one day.

No harm.

If the money needs one day, let it have one day.

But my granddaughter will remember all three.”

Kumud kept looking at the calendar.

“Shall I place a photocopy of this in the file?”

Janaki Devi laughed.

“A paper with three days beside a field for one?”

“It will remain as a note in the file.”

“Keep it.”

Kumud had the calendar photocopied.

The three mud-grey dates did not reproduce clearly.

But Renu’s red writing appeared black.

She attached the copy to the file.

The digital platform still carried only one date:

12 August.

Two weeks later, the first batch of relief was approved.

Janaki Devi’s name was on the list.

So was Raghuni Sah’s.

Some families remained ineligible because their determined date fell outside the notified period.

They filed objections.

The first field on the objection form read:

“Disputed Date of Damage.”

Looking at the paper, Prabhakar Babu said,

“Now there is a separate form for the date problem.”

Kumud asked,

“Does this form have room to write a period?”

Prabhakar Babu turned the page.

“No.

One date here too.”

For a few moments both remained silent.

Outside, the river had receded far away.

A white strip of sand shone towards the villages as though no house had ever stood there.

At the end of the month, the relief room began to be dismantled.

The bamboo platforms were removed.

Registers were tied into bundles.

The computer was sent back to the regular office.

On the final day, Kumud was counting the pending files.

Janaki Devi’s file came into her hands.

On top:

“Date of Damage: 12 August.”

Inside:

the photocopy of Renu’s calendar—

10,

11,

12.

Kumud looked at the two papers together.

On one, the date was clear.

On the other, the event was clear.

She closed the file.

A few days later, Kumud met Janaki Devi in the market.

Janaki Devi was explaining to another woman how to fill the relief form.

The woman said,

“I do not remember exactly when the house went.”

Janaki Devi replied casually,

“Say the day the paper accepts.

My house went on 12 August.”

Kumud stood two steps away, listening.

She remembered the vegetable plot on the night of the tenth.

The hearth on the eleventh.

The room on the twelfth.

Janaki Devi adjusted her bag and moved into the market crowd.

Kumud felt an impulse to stop her and remind her of all three days from the calendar.

Then she stopped herself.

The government date had finished its official work.

Now it was being entered not only into the form—

but into memory as well.

STORY 65

The Original Page of the Correction Register

The rule for opening the old master registers of the District Land Records Branch was simple—nothing written in the original register was to be struck out. If an error was found, a small red dot was placed beside it, and the full correction was entered in a separate "Correction Register." The original page remained exactly as it was.

Suresh Mishra had been a clerk in the branch for the past eighteen years. He was proud of this rule. He would often say, "What was written is history; what was corrected is the next line of history."

There were three thick master registers in the office. One was for land accounts, one for boundary demarcation, and one for changes of ownership. The Correction Register had once been a thin volume. By now it had grown into five volumes.

With time, the master registers were opened less and less. People came with applications, employees consulted the Correction Register, and the final position could usually be found there. The master registers were heavy, their bindings weak. The corner of one page had broken away; on another, old ink had spread.

On her first day, the new employee Neha Jha had asked, "If the final position is in the Correction Register, why open the master register at all?"

Suresh Babu had smiled. "Because to understand what a correction corrected, you have to see the original."

A few months later Neha herself understood that, in practice, people looked first at the Correction Register. The master register was opened only in a dispute, an inquiry, or when an old date had to be established.

Meanwhile, a case arrived—Account 482, Mauza Kataiya. The applicant was Ramvriksh Yadav. His request seemed simple: a certificate of landholding for farmers' assistance.

Against Account 482, the Correction Register stated—"Owner: Ramvriksh Yadav. Correction Order No. 37/2018."

Neha began preparing the certificate. Then the digital system displayed a warning drawn from the copy of the old master register—"Original entry: Sita Devi."

Neha called Suresh Babu.

"This is normal," Suresh Babu said. "Sita Devi would have been his mother. After her death, the mutation must have been made."

"Then shall we look at the correction order?"

The file was brought out according to the reference in the Correction Register. The order was clear—after Sita Devi's death certificate, family consent, and heir verification in 2018, Ramvriksh's name was to be entered.

"Then the certificate can be issued," Neha said.

Suresh Babu agreed.

Just then an elderly woman called from outside, "Is Ramvriksh's paper here?"

Everyone looked towards the doorway. A woman of about seventy stood there in a white sari, an old cloth bag in her hand.

She said, "I am Sita Devi."

The room fell silent for a few moments.

Ramvriksh, who had been sitting on the veranda, came inside. His face fell.

"Ma, why have you come here?"

Sita Devi put the bag on the table. "I heard your certificate was being prepared. I have only now learned that the land has been removed from my name."

Neha looked at Ramvriksh. Suresh Babu opened the file again. The death certificate carried the name—Sita Devi. Father/Husband—Late Bhuvaneshwar Yadav. Village—Kataiya. Age—sixty-eight years.

The woman seated before them handed over her voter slip. Name, husband, village—everything matched.

"Whose death certificate is this?" Suresh Babu asked.

Ramvriksh said softly, "My aunt was also named Sita Devi. She was my father's younger brother's wife. Her husband too was named Bhuvaneshwar—Bhuvaneshwar Prasad Yadav. While the paper was being made, 'Prasad' may have been left out..."

Suresh Babu stopped him at once. "No assumptions. We will see the file."

The old file contained a copy of the family tree. There, two Sita Devis were recorded in separate branches. One was Ramvriksh's mother, the other his aunt. The death certificate belonged to the aunt.

In the 2018 inquiry paper, someone had omitted "Prasad" from "Bhuvaneshwar Prasad." The village, caste, and age were nearly the same. The mutation order had been applied to the land of Ramvriksh's mother.

Neha said softly, "Then the Correction Register is wrong."

Suresh Babu said, "What we see now is an error. But the Correction Register is an accurate record of the order the office issued in 2018."

Sita Devi was dissatisfied. "I am alive. What more than that do you need?"

"Being alive is the greatest fact," Suresh Babu said, "but to correct the register we need the proper sequence."

A new proceeding was opened. The correction in the Correction Register had itself to be corrected. The rule said—the old correction was not to be struck out; the new correction was to be added under the next serial number.

Neha asked, “Then where will the final truth remain?”

“In the next line,” Suresh Babu said.

The inquiry began. Sita Devi’s proof of being alive, family register, tax receipts, land revenue records, and neighbours’ statements were all collected. Ramvriksh too stated that the land actually belonged to his mother; he had needed the certificate for farmers’ assistance and had no intention of taking away her ownership.

Three weeks later an order was passed—the 2018 correction order was not validly applicable to Account 482; the name of the original owner, Sita Devi, was to become effective again.

Neha opened the Correction Register. The old line could not be erased. Beneath it she wrote—“Order 12/2026: Previous correction applied to wrong person; owner Sita Devi restored as effective.”

Suresh Babu wrote the new serial number beside the red dot.

The matter seemed finished. But the next day a letter arrived from the bank.

In 2021, Ramvriksh had taken an agricultural loan on the basis of this land. The bank asked—“According to the valid record on the date the loan was sanctioned, who was the owner?”

Neha said immediately, “Sita Devi. Because the 2018 correction was an error.”

Suresh Babu remained silent.

The bank’s question was read again—“According to the valid record on the date the loan was sanctioned.”

In 2021, the Correction Register showed Ramvriksh’s name. The office certificate had also been issued on that basis. At that time, the 2018 order had not yet been cancelled.

Neha said, “But now we know that it was wrong.”

Suresh Babu said, “We know it now. The office in 2021 did not know it.”

“Then was Ramvriksh the owner in 2021?”

“The question of the actual right in the land is one thing. The state of the official record is another.”

Neha found the answer uncomfortable. “Two truths for the same land?”

Suresh Babu spread the master register, the old Correction Register, and the new order before her.

“No. Three times of the same fact.”

A reply was prepared for the bank—“On the date of sanction of the loan, Ramvriksh Yadav was shown in the department’s then-effective record; a later inquiry found that the said entry resulted from an order concerning the wrong person; the currently effective owner is Sita Devi.”

Neha read the letter and said, “In this answer no one is completely right, and no one completely wrong.”

Suresh Babu said, “Records are not always so clean.”

A few days later, a district inspection took place. The inspector looked at the Correction Register and immediately asked, “Why are there three positions against the same account?”

Neha explained the entire matter. The inspector said, “If the old correction is cancelled, strike it through with a red line.”

Suresh Babu opened the rule book. “Neither the original nor a corrected entry is to be erased or made illegible. The reason for cancellation and the subsequent order are to be added.”

The inspector grew a little irritated. “Then how is an employee supposed to identify the final position?”

Neha said at once, “That is the problem here.”

She showed him the five volumes of Correction Registers. In some places one correction was followed by another, elsewhere by a third. Many employees looked only at the last line, but sometimes the effective date of an older order was what mattered.

The inspection team suggested creating a new “Status Summary Page,” on which the currently effective entry would be shown separately and clearly, with the serial numbers and periods of effect of all previous corrections listed below.

Work began. Account 482 became the first sample.

Three lines were entered on the Status Summary Page—

“Original entry: Sita Devi — from the beginning until 2018.”

“Correction Order 37/2018: Ramvriksh Yadav — departmentally effective record from 2018 until Order 12/2026.”

“Order 12/2026: Sita Devi — currently effective position.”

Neha looked at the page. “Now it is clear.”

Suresh Babu said, “It is clear because time has been added.”

The following week another case arrived. In the old master register, pond land stood in the name of the panchayat; in the 1998 Correction Register it stood in the school’s name; in a 2012 correction it returned to the panchayat. The question was—under whose authority had permission for construction of the school building been granted in 2005?

Earlier, employees would have looked at the “current position” and answered. This time Neha checked the period of effect. In 2005, the school’s name was effective in the departmental record.

She understood that Account 482 had exposed more than a single mistake; the very structure of the registers had been concealing time.

It was impossible to create Status Summary Pages for all active accounts within three months. So a rule was made—wherever there was more than one

correction, checking the “effective date” would be compulsory before preparing a certificate.

The employees’ work increased. Some complained that earlier one register was enough to finish the task; now three pages had to be checked.

Neha would say, “Earlier we got an answer quickly; now we will get the answer for the correct time.”

One evening, before the office closed, Sita Devi came again. This time there was no dispute. She had come to collect the new certificate.

Neha handed her the certificate. Name—Sita Devi. Current owner.

Sita Devi read the paper and put it into her bag. “So am I alive again now?”

Neha smiled. “You were never dead. The register understood it late.”

Sita Devi left.

Suresh Babu was closing the master register. Neha looked towards the five volumes of the Correction Register.

“You used to say—the original is history, and the correction is the next line of history.”

“Yes.”

“Now it seems the next line sometimes begins doing more work than the original.”

Suresh Babu ran his hand over the binding. “Then that too has to be read as history, not as an order.”

Neha opened the Status Summary Page for Account 482 once more. Beside the same name were three times. For the first time, the register seemed to her not like static paper but like moving time—to understand what is true today, yesterday’s truth and the day-before-yesterday’s error both have to remain preserved.

STORY 66

Three Empty Chairs

Janardan Mishra moved the three chairs away from the wall and placed them at the far end of the dining row.

The chairs were not new. White paint had been scraped from the back of one; the right arm of another was slightly loose; the four legs of the third were uneven. Janardan Mishra slipped a folded piece of paper beneath the third chair.

"Why here?" Abhay asked.

Janardan Mishra measured the space between the chairs with his eyes. "This is fine."

"The row is over there."

"This too is part of the row."

Abhay said nothing. He held the guest register in his hand. At the top, written in red ink, was the number—four hundred and forty-two.

On the northern side of the courtyard, the cooking was under way. Steam rose from a large cauldron of pulao. The smell of ghee, cumin, and smoke drifted with the air towards the dining area.

It was Archana's wedding. The wedding procession had arrived. The ceremonies at the mandap were in progress. There was still a little time before the feast began.

Abhay had come from the city three days earlier. Numbers, leaf plates, glasses, sweets, water—every calculation was in his notebook. Janardan Mishra never looked at the notebook.

"These three extra chairs are not written down," Abhay said.

"Are chairs written down?"

"Everything hired is counted."

Janardan Mishra did not laugh. "Then count them."

Abhay added nothing to the register.

As the afternoon declined, the first row sat down to eat. Children first. Then guests from far away. Dal in brass-coloured buckets, vegetables in tin buckets, and puris in baskets began moving along the row.

The three chairs remained empty.

An elderly guest moved towards the last chair. Janardan Mishra folded his hands and said, "Kaka, please sit here." He seated him on an empty chair farther forward.

Abhay watched from a distance.

"Are these being kept for someone?" he asked when he came near.

"Yes."

"For whom?"

"For those who are still working."

Abhay looked towards the cooking area. Ten or fifteen people were running about there. "A lot of people are working."

Janardan Mishra only said, "Yes."

The second row filled up.

Ramcharit, the cook, lifted the lid from a hot cauldron and let out the steam. The corner of his dhoti was tucked up to his knees. From time to time he washed his hands, then opened a box of spices.

Phulo Kaki was counting leaf plates. Whenever she saw a torn plate, she replaced it with another. If a child reached for sweets, she would say, "Eat your rice first."

Nandu was filling water. Between two large drums and four jugs, his feet never stopped.

The three chairs remained empty.

In Abhay's register were estimates for the first row, the second row, the third row. Again and again he crossed out numbers and wrote them afresh.

"Has Ramcharit Kaka eaten?" Janardan Mishra asked.

"Not yet," Abhay said. "He is in the cooking area."

"Phulo?"

"Looking after the leaf plates."

"Nandu?"

"Water."

Janardan Mishra nodded.

Abhay looked at his face. "Are these three for them?"

Before answering, Janardan Mishra saw a boy climbing onto the arm of one chair. "Baua, not there."

The boy climbed down.

"Yes," Janardan Mishra said.

Abhay folded the register. "They eat at the end."

"Why?"

Abhay paused a little. "Because they are working."

"After the work is over?"

"Then they eat."

Janardan Mishra looked at the three chairs. "They will sit here."

Abhay said nothing.

The third row rose. Water, curd, and grains of rice lay scattered on the ground. Two boys tried to sweep, but the next row arrived.

Nandu came running with two jugs in one hand. Janardan Mishra stopped him.

"Sit down for a while."

Nandu laughed. "Now?"

"Yes. Five minutes."

"Who will serve the water?"

"Someone else."

Nandu looked towards the rear drum. "That drum is only half full. Let me fill it, then I will sit."

He went away.

Abhay said, "See?"

Janardan Mishra did not answer.

A little later Phulo Kaki passed carrying a stack of leaf plates. Janardan Mishra pointed towards the chairs.

"Kaki, your place."

The moment Phulo Kaki saw the chair, she laughed. "Mine?"

"Yes."

"If I sit here, who will count the leaf plates?"

"Someone will."

"If someone else counts, they will hand out two plates at a time."

She walked on again.

Janardan Mishra watched her go.

Abhay said softly, "Babu, you want to stop the work so that people can eat."

"Not eat. Sit."

"What is the difference?"

Janardan Mishra looked at him. "You do not understand?"

Abhay did not answer.

A conch sounded from the mandap. Some women left the feast and rose to go that way. The empty places filled again.

Archana appeared once at the edge of the courtyard. A veil covered her head and flowers hung at her neck. Two cousins were with her. She quickly went inside.

Janardan Mishra looked that way for a moment, then towards the three chairs.

"If Ma were here, all of this would have been on her head," Abhay said.

Janardan Mishra's fingers stopped on the back of a chair. "Yes."

"She would have had so much work at Archana's wedding."

"Yes."

Abhay wanted to say something more, but did not.

Ramcharit, the cook, came out wiping his face, wet with steam. Janardan Mishra called to him.

"Ramcharit!"

"What happened?"

"Sit down."

Ramcharit looked at the three chairs. "The fish still has to come off the fire."

"The fish will not run away in ten minutes."

Ramcharit smiled. "The fish will not run away, but the people will eat it."

"Let them eat."

Ramcharit wiped the sweat from his face with his gamchha. "I will eat later, in peace."

"Here."

Ramcharit looked at Janardan Mishra for a moment. "Here?"

"Yes."

Ramcharit's smile faded slightly. "Guests sit here."

"What are you?"

Ramcharit placed the gamchha over his shoulder. "I am the cook."

"That is your work."

"Today, I am the work."

He turned and walked back towards the cooking area.

Abhay no longer held the register. He had placed the notebook on the sill by the window.

"Babu," he said, "will putting out chairs change anything?"

Janardan Mishra pushed the paper farther beneath the third chair. "I do not know."

"Then?"

"I will not remove them while they are empty."

Abhay fell silent.

Night deepened. The strings of electric lights flickered off and came on again. The crowd at the feast thinned. Guests from far away began taking leave.

The dining rows became smaller now. Four people, six people, then ten.

The three chairs remained empty.

Phulo Kaki gathered the last leaf plates and went towards the cooking area. Nandu poured the remaining water from the drum towards the drain. Ramcharit scraped the rice left at the bottom of the cauldron into a small vessel.

Janardan Mishra asked for three plates.

Abhay set the plates down.

"Shall I call them now?"

"Yes."

Abhay called Nandu first. Nandu washed his hands and came over. He stopped in front of the chairs.

"Sit," Abhay said.

Nandu looked towards Phulo Kaki.

Phulo Kaki arrived. Her hands had been washed with soap, but turmeric still clung around her fingernails.

Ramcharit came too.

All three stood in front of the three chairs.

For a few moments no one spoke.

Janardan Mishra lifted the covers from the plates. "Sit."

Phulo Kaki said softly, "I will eat in the cooking shed."

"What is wrong with here?"

"What could be wrong?"

"Then?"

Phulo Kaki gave no answer.

Nandu wiped his wet palms on his dhoti. "I too will feel better over there."

Ramcharit touched the arm of a chair, then withdrew his hand. "Babu, I understand that you want us to sit."

Janardan Mishra looked at him.

Ramcharit continued, "But if I sit here today, people will say—the cook left the kitchen and sat down at the feast."

"The people have gone now."

Ramcharit looked around. Truly, most people had left.

"My own mind is still in the kitchen," he said.

Phulo Kaki laughed. "And my plate is already there."

"Since when?" Abhay asked.

"Since the first row began. I have been saving a little at a time."

Abhay kept looking at Phulo Kaki.

Nandu said, "They have kept the fish head for me."

Ramcharit said, "This boy will never leave a fish head."

All three laughed.

Janardan Mishra did not.

Phulo Kaki ran her hand along the back of one chair. “Keep these. We will sit next time.”

“Next time?” Janardan Mishra asked.

“Will there not be another wedding in the house?”

Abhay laughed for the first time. “Mine?”

Phulo Kaki said, “Is it written in your register or not?”

Abhay shook his head.

The three picked up their own plates and walked towards the cooking shed.

Janardan Mishra did not stop them.

The courtyard was almost empty. In the distance, the ceremony at the mandap was still under way. Fragments of the mantras came on the wind.

Abhay stood in front of the three chairs.

“Shall I remove them?” he asked.

Janardan Mishra said, “Not yet.”

“Why?”

“Let them stay.”

Abhay placed a hand on one chair, but did not move it.

A little later laughter came from the cooking shed. Nandu had said something. Phulo Kaki’s loud laughter rang out, followed by Ramcharit’s quieter voice.

Janardan Mishra looked that way.

Abhay did too.

The plates still rested on the three chairs. No steam rose from the rice. Beside one plate, a small drop of curd had fallen and was beginning to dry.

“Shall I pick up the plates?” Abhay asked.

This time Janardan Mishra nodded.

Abhay picked up the plates and carried them towards the cooking shed.

The chairs remained where they were.

The last guest of the night also left. The courtyard was swept. Water was sprinkled. Grains of rice, scraps of leaf plates, and flower petals were washed to one side.

The seats of the three chairs were clean.

The folded paper beneath the third chair had become wet. The chair now stood level.

Abhay bent down and pulled out the paper. He opened it and looked. It was an old torn page from the guest register. No one’s name was written at the top.

He folded the page and placed it beneath the chair leg again.

Janardan Mishra said nothing.

The three chairs remained empty to the end.

STORY 67

The Verandah Bulb

The evening sunlight had already slipped down from the veranda wall.

A little water had collected near the tulsi altar in the courtyard. The afternoon rain had not lasted long, but even now, from time to time, a single drop fell from the edge of the roof.

Ramprasad Jha sat in his old bamboo chair.

In front of him, a bulb hung in the middle of the veranda.

The light was on.

It flickered once.

Then steadied.

Ramprasad looked up.

Two minutes later the bulb flickered again.

This time three times.

Then it went out.

The veranda did not become dark all at once. Light was coming from the window of the house on the west. From the kitchen doorway on the east as well.

Only the bulb in the middle had gone out.

Ramprasad kept looking at it for a few moments.

Then he said, “Change the bulb.”

Whom he was speaking to was not clear.

Surendra appeared at the western doorway.

Naresh too appeared at the eastern doorway.

Both looked at their father.

Not at each other.

Ramprasad looked up again.

“It has gone out.”

Surendra turned back inside.

So did Naresh.

Ramprasad kept running his palm along the arm of the chair.

The two doorways opened again at almost the same moment.

Surendra held a small cardboard box.

Naresh too had a bulb in his hand, without a box.

Surendra placed his bulb on the wooden stool.

Naresh kept his bulb in his hand.

Ramprasad looked at both bulbs.

"Only one is needed," he said.

Neither replied.

There was a wooden stool in the left corner of the veranda.

The stool used to stand in the middle.

After the house was divided, Surendra had moved it towards his own wall.

Ramprasad pointed towards the stool.

"Climb on this."

Surendra bent to lift it.

Naresh too stepped forward.

Their hands fell on two different ends of the stool.

Both immediately withdrew their hands.

Ramprasad sat in his chair and watched.

Surendra brought the stool to the middle by himself.

Naresh moved a little away.

"Is the switch off?" Surendra asked.

The question was directed at their father.

Ramprasad looked towards the eastern wall.

The switch for the veranda bulb was beside Naresh's doorway.

That switch had been there long before the house was divided.

Without saying anything, Naresh switched it off.

"Off," he said.

Surendra climbed onto the stool.

As he touched the old bulb, he pulled his hand back.

"It is hot."

Ramprasad said, "Let it cool a little."

All three remained silent.

A drop fell into the water in the courtyard.

A circle formed.

Then vanished.

From the western house came the sound of a plate being set down.

In the eastern house a child was reciting a lesson—the sound of counting reached as far as the veranda.

Ramprasad looked towards the box in Surendra's hand.

"How many watts?"

"Nine."

Then towards the bulb in Naresh's hand.
"Yours?"
"Twelve."
Ramprasad nodded.
"Nine is more than enough."
Naresh slowly placed his bulb on the threshold of his doorway.
Surendra opened the box.
He took the bulb out.
There were now two bulbs in the veranda.
One on the stool.
One on the threshold.
The old bulb hung above.
Ramprasad narrowed his eyes.
"It must have cooled now."
Surendra climbed onto the stool again.
This time he grasped the bulb.
He turned it slowly.
The bulb came out.
He looked inside the empty holder.
"It has blackened."
Naresh looked up.
"The holder?"
Surendra did not reply.
Ramprasad said, "He is asking whether the holder has blackened."
"A little."
Naresh left the threshold and came a little forward.
"What if the wire is loose?"
Surendra was fitting the new bulb into the holder.
"Let us see this first."
Ramprasad looked towards Naresh.
Naresh stopped where he was again.
The bulb was tightened into place.
Surendra climbed down from the stool.
"Switch it on."
Ramprasad did not feel it necessary to tell Naresh that.
Naresh pushed the switch up.

Nothing happened.

The veranda was still half dark.

Surendra looked up.

Naresh pushed the switch down and up again.

The bulb did not light.

Ramprasad sat a little straighter in his chair.

"There is electricity, isn't there?"

Surendra looked towards his own house. The light in the western window was on.

Naresh looked towards the eastern doorway. There was light there too.

"There is," both said almost at the same time.

Both fell silent for a moment.

Surendra climbed onto the stool again.

He placed a finger beneath the holder, but did not put his hand inside.

"Switch it off."

Naresh switched it off.

Surendra unscrewed the bulb and tightened it again.

"Now."

Naresh switched it on.

Nothing.

Surendra removed the bulb and held it in his hand.

He examined the glass and the metal at the base.

Then he put it back in its box.

Naresh picked up the twelve-watt bulb from the threshold.

He extended it slightly forward.

Surendra looked at him.

Naresh stopped his hand midway.

Ramprasad said, "Try the other one."

Surendra did not take the bulb from Naresh's hand.

He held out his palm.

Naresh placed the bulb on that palm.

Their fingers did not touch.

Surendra climbed up again.

He tightened the twelve-watt bulb into place.

Naresh switched it on.

Nothing happened.

“The fault is not in the bulb,” Naresh said.

Still standing on the stool, Surendra said, “So it seems.”

After four days, this was the first sentence either of them had spoken directly to the other.

Ramprasad lowered his head and ran a finger along the arm of the chair.

Surendra climbed down.

“We will have to check the wire.”

Naresh went inside and brought a screwdriver to open the switch plate.

Surendra shifted slightly the slippers he had left beneath the stool.

Naresh bent his knees and sat near the switch.

“Is it off?” Surendra asked.

“I will cut the main switch.”

Naresh went inside.

The light in the eastern kitchen went out.

A few moments later he returned.

He opened the switch plate with the screwdriver.

There were two old wires inside.

One was wrapped with cloth tape.

“One of these is loose,” Naresh said.

Surendra bent to look.

“Not here. It must be above.”

“How?”

“This wire has tension.”

Naresh pulled the wire gently.

It did not move.

Surendra looked towards the ceiling of the veranda.

The wire ran westward along an old bamboo strip.

In the middle was a patch of newer plaster.

The wire disappeared beneath that plaster.

Ramprasad looked up too.

“When was this plaster done?”

No one answered.

Surendra moved the stool towards that spot.

This time, without being asked, Naresh caught the other end.

Together they shifted the stool.

The wood made a small scraping sound on the floor.

Surendra climbed up.

He tapped the edge of the plaster with a finger.

At one spot it sounded hollow.

"There used to be a joint here."

Naresh said from below, "Earlier?"

"Yes."

"Whose wire?"

Surendra climbed down.

Ramprasad answered, "The house's."

Naresh looked at his father.

Ramprasad said again, "At that time there was only one house."

For a while, the only sound in the veranda was the dripping from the roof.

Surendra asked for the screwdriver.

Naresh handed it to him.

Surendra scraped a little at the edge of the plaster.

White powder fell onto the stool.

Inside, the old wire joint became visible.

One end of the joint had blackened.

Beside it was the edge of a newer brick.

Four years earlier, when the middle room was divided, a half wall had been raised here.

The wall was below.

The wire above.

The wire had not been divided.

Only its joint had been covered with plaster.

Surendra climbed down.

"It needs a new joint."

Naresh said, "The wire will fall short."

"We will add a small piece."

"Who has some?"

Both fell silent.

Ramprasad pointed towards the small cupboard at the back.

"Look in the upper compartment."

Surendra opened the cupboard.

In the compartment were old nails, a lock, two candles, some jute string, and a small coil of wire.

He took the wire out.

Naresh looked at its end.

"This is very thin."

Surendra said, "It will do for a bulb."

"The joint will have to be covered."

"Do you have tape?"

Naresh looked towards the old cloth tape wrapped inside his switch.

"Not this."

He went inside the house.

A few moments later he returned with black electrical tape.

Surendra cleaned the end of the wire.

Naresh held the bulb wire.

Their heads were bent at almost the same height.

Ramprasad moved his chair slightly back so that he could see better.

"Tighten it," Naresh said.

Surendra twisted the wire.

"This much?"

"A little more."

Surendra twisted it again.

Naresh handed him the tape.

Surendra covered the joint.

No one spoke of the old wall.

No one spoke of the land papers.

No one said that four years earlier, when the half wall was being raised, both of them had stood right there.

Ramprasad did not either.

The joint was ready.

Surendra climbed onto the stool and pushed the wire back up.

The broken edge of the plaster remained open for now.

"Do not close it yet," Naresh said.

"Let us test it first."

Surendra climbed down.

Naresh went inside to turn the main switch back on.

The light in the eastern kitchen came on again.

He returned to the veranda switch.

He placed his hand on it.

Surendra looked at the bulb.
So did Ramprasad.
Naresh pressed the switch.
The twelve-watt bulb lit up.
The veranda turned bright.
In the light, the old chalk line across the middle of the floor became visible.
The line was now very faint.
In some places footsteps had rubbed it away.
In some places it was still white.
Ramprasad did not look at it.
He looked at the bulb.
"It is too bright."
Naresh said, "It is twelve watts."
Surendra picked up his box.
"The nine-watt one is fine. The fault was in the wire."
Naresh looked at the bulb.
"Shall we change it?"
Surendra paused for a moment.
"Let it stay."
Ramprasad said, "Wasn't nine more than enough?"
Suppressing a faint smile, Naresh said, "Let twelve stay now."
A faint line appeared on Surendra's face too, then vanished at once.
He lifted the stool.
Naresh again moved to take the other end.
This time Surendra did not withdraw his hand.
Together they carried the stool towards the middle.
When they reached there, they stopped.
On whose side should the stool be placed?
Ramprasad said, "Leave it here."
The two left the stool in the middle of the veranda.
Surendra took his box and walked towards the western doorway.
Naresh picked up the screwdriver and tape and turned east.
At the doorway, Naresh looked back.
The open patch of plaster was still visible.
"I will put mortar on it tomorrow," he said.
Surendra stopped at his own doorway.

"I have some cement."

Naresh nodded.

That was all.

Both went into their own houses.

Ramprasad remained sitting alone in the veranda.

The twelve-watt light fell on his chair, the stool in the middle, the faded chalk line, and the new joint above.

After a while the western doorway closed from inside.

Then the eastern one.

The bulb remained lit.

Ramprasad stood up.

He moved the chair against the wall.

The switch was on the eastern wall.

He walked over to it.

He placed his hand on the switch.

He paused for a moment.

Then he turned off the light.

The veranda went dark.

A little light came from the western window.

And from beneath the eastern doorway as well.

The stool in the middle still remained in the middle, in the darkness.

STORY 68

One Cup of Tea Less

Every morning, before opening the shop, Harinath Sah made tea.

For years, he had made three cups.

Since this month, there were only two.

One for him.

One for Pawan.

The third cup lay upside down on the shelf.

The cup was not broken.

Its rim was intact.

Only its use had changed.

Earlier, Sumitra Devi used to drink tea from that cup.

The shop shutter would remain half raised.

She would sit on the bench inside and open the ledger.

Harinath Sah would shift the sacks.

Pawan would sweep.

Sumitra Devi would reconcile the previous day's credit.

The tea of all three would grow cold at the same time.

Now Sumitra Devi left home at dawn.

She had found work keeping the register at the village milk collection centre.

The centre opened before five forty-five.

The milk suppliers began arriving while it was still dark.

Measurements, fat content, quantity, names, and payments had to be entered.

Sumitra Devi's handwriting was clear.

For twenty years, the shop ledger had run in that hand.

Harinath Sah would say, "I can write it."

And he did write.

But among the accounts, Sumitra Devi noticed many small things.

Whose credit belonged to the household.

Whose to the field.

Whose payment would come by next Monday.

Which name belonged to one of two men in the village with the same name.

These things were written not in the margins of the ledger, but in her mind.

One day the cooperative president came to the shop to collect milk.

He saw the ledger.

He asked, “Whose handwriting is this?”
Harinath Sah said, “Sumitra’s.”
Two weeks later, Sumitra Devi began sitting at the milk collection centre.
On the first day, Harinath Sah had made three cups of tea.
Pawan had asked, “Kaki?”
Harinath Sah had looked at the cup.
Then he poured a little extra tea into his own cup.
The second cup went to Pawan.
The tea meant for the third cup remained in the kettle.
From that day, the measure changed.
Now, water for two cups.
Milk for two cups.
Two pinches of tea leaves.
Two small spoonfuls of sugar.
Harinath Sah did not get the quantities wrong.
By seven, customers began to arrive.
The first customer was Ramsevak.
He bought half a kilo of oil and two bars of soap.
While paying, he said, “Write the rest in the ledger.”
Harinath Sah opened the ledger.
There were three entries under the name Ramsevak.
One Ramsevak Yadav.
One Ramsevak Mahato.
One simply Ramsevak.
Harinath Sah asked, “How much of your previous balance remains?”
Ramsevak said, “Kaki knew.”
Harinath Sah looked at him.
Ramsevak immediately said, “I do not remember.”
Harinath Sah turned back through the old pages.
There was a small mark beside one entry.
Half a circle in red pencil.
Sumitra Devi used to make that mark.
Harinath Sah understood.
He wrote down the new credit.
Ramsevak left.
Pawan said, “You understood the mark?”

Harinath Sah said, “This was Ramsevak from the fields.”

“How?”

“There was a circle.”

Pawan nodded.

“All circles look the same to me.”

Harinath Sah did not reply.

By noon, the ledger had been opened five times.

Twice, Harinath Sah found the correct page immediately.

Three times, he had to search.

A woman buying salt said, “I will pay next month when my daughter comes.”

Harinath Sah wrote down her name.

Then he stopped.

He asked, “On what date?”

The woman laughed.

“Kaki never asked the date.”

“She knew.”

“Yes.”

Harinath Sah wrote ‘next month’ on the page.

Not the exact date.

At ten, Sumitra Devi returned.

She carried a blue cloth bag.

The centre’s new ledger was not inside it.

That ledger remained there.

In the bag were a small steel box and a bottle of water.

Sumitra Devi stopped in front of the shop.

Harinath Sah was weighing rice.

He said, “Late today?”

“Two milk vehicles arrived at the same time.”

“How much?”

“Two hundred and thirty-seven litres.”

Harinath Sah nodded.

Pawan asked, “Kaki, do they give you tea there?”

Sumitra Devi looked at him.

“They give me work.”

Pawan laughed.

Harinath Sah smiled a little too.

Sumitra Devi looked at the cup lying upside down on the shelf.
She said nothing.
She pulled the ledger towards herself.
"Did Ramsevak come?"
Harinath Sah said, "He came."
"Oil?"
"And soap."
"Written down?"
"Written."
Sumitra Devi looked at the page.
She put a small dot slightly above the entry.
Harinath Sah asked, "What is that?"
"He will receive money from the field this week."
"Did he say so?"
"His daughter-in-law said it yesterday."
Harinath Sah pulled the ledger back towards himself.
He looked at the dot.
Then closed the page.
Sumitra Devi went home.
At noon, Pawan brought the lunch box from the house.
Earlier, Sumitra Devi used to bring it herself.
Pawan opened the box.
Three rotis for Harinath Sah.
Four for Pawan.
The vegetable was in one shared container.
Pawan asked, "Now that Kaki is not at home, who cooks the meal?"
Harinath Sah said, "She makes it at dawn."
"So early?"
"She has always been used to waking early."
Pawan broke a piece of roti.
After a while he said, "Does the centre pay well?"
Harinath Sah took some vegetable.
"It is pay for work."
"Monthly?"
"Yes."
"Good."

Harinath Sah said nothing.

In the afternoon, the wholesale trader came.

He unloaded five sacks of sugar.

Harinath Sah wrote down the account.

The trader asked about the previous balance.

Harinath Sah looked at the ledger.

The figures were clear.

So was the date.

But at one place Sumitra Devi had written—"Two crates to be returned."

Harinath Sah counted the crates.

There was only one.

Pawan said, "The other must be in the back room."

They searched.

It was not found.

The trader waited.

Harinath Sah took out his mobile phone.

He called Sumitra Devi.

"Where is one of those two crates?"

Her voice came from the other end, "On the upper shelf to the right. Behind the sacks."

Pawan ran.

The crate was found.

Harinath Sah said, "Found it."

Sumitra Devi asked, "Is it not written in the ledger?"

Harinath Sah said, "It is."

There was silence for a few moments.

Then he said, "It does not say which shelf."

From the other end Sumitra Devi said, "Write it now."

Harinath Sah ended the call.

In the margin of the ledger he wrote—"Upper shelf on the right."

Pawan watched.

"Does this have to be written too?"

Harinath Sah said, "It does now."

In the evening, two schoolchildren came to buy notebooks.

One child was five rupees short.

Harinath Sah said, "Give it tomorrow."

The child said, "Ma said not to put anything on credit."
Harinath Sah kept the ledger closed.
"Then bring the money tomorrow."
The child put the notebook down.
Then went as far as the doorway.
He turned back.
Harinath Sah held out the notebook towards him.
"Take it."
"Five rupees?"
"Tomorrow."
The child took the notebook and left.
Pawan asked, "You will not write it in the ledger?"
Harinath Sah thought for a moment.
Then he wrote the child's name on a small piece of paper.
He placed the paper inside the ledger.
"Did Kaki do it this way?"
"No."
"Then?"
"I will do it this way."
Pawan said nothing.
At seven, Sumitra Devi came to the shop again.
This time her hands were empty.
She sat on the bench by the doorway.
The same bench where she had once drunk her morning tea.
Harinath Sah had lowered one half of the shutter.
Pawan had already gone home.
Sumitra Devi asked, "Did the sugar arrive?"
"It did."
"Five sacks?"
"Yes."
"Did you find both crates?"
"Found them."
"There is an inspection at the milk centre tomorrow."
Harinath Sah said, "So you will leave even earlier?"
"At five."
"Sleep?"

"It will happen."

Harinath Sah wiped the shelf.

The upside-down cup came into his hand.

He went outside to wash it.

Sumitra Devi opened the ledger.

She looked at Ramsevak's page.

Harinath Sah returned.

He placed the cup upside down on the shelf again.

Sumitra Devi saw the small paper with the child's name.

"What is this?"

Harinath Sah said, "Five rupees."

"Whose?"

"The boy's."

"Why not in the ledger?"

Harinath Sah said, "He will give it tomorrow. If he does not, then I will write it."

Sumitra Devi put the paper back where it had been.

"All right."

Harinath Sah closed the shutter.

He put on the lock.

The two walked towards home.

On the road, Sumitra Devi walked ahead.

Harinath Sah behind her.

After some distance, Harinath Sah asked, "How is the ledger at the centre?"

"Clean."

"Many names?"

"Twenty-seven."

"Have you memorized them all?"

Sumitra Devi laughed.

"Not yet."

Harinath Sah said, "You will."

The next dawn, Sumitra Devi left at five.

Harinath Sah came to the shop a little later.

Pawan had not yet arrived.

He raised the shutter halfway.

He lit the stove.

Into the kettle he measured water for two cups.
Milk for two cups.
Two pinches of tea leaves.
Two small spoonfuls of sugar.
The tea kept boiling.
Harinath Sah opened the ledger.
He looked at the previous day's margin.
"Upper shelf on the right."
He turned the page.
At the top of a fresh page, he wrote the date.
Below it, he made three small columns.
Name.
Balance.
When payment will come.
Pawan bent beneath the half-open shutter and came inside.
"Tea?"
Harinath Sah took the kettle off the stove.
He filled two cups.
He gave one to Pawan.
He kept one for himself.
Pawan looked at the ledger.
"These new columns?"
Harinath Sah said, "From now on, we will write it this way."
Pawan raised the cup to his lips.
The third cup lay upside down on the shelf.
The morning light fell across it.
Harinath Sah did not turn it upright.
He pulled the ledger towards himself.
He began waiting for the first customer.

STORY 69

The Bamboo Bridge

It had rained all night.

By dawn, the water of the large pond had begun flowing towards the drain.

By afternoon, the drain looked like a river.

The unpaved road leading to the western hamlet of the village had been cut through in the middle.

Across that breach stood a bamboo bridge.

Six thick bamboo poles lay lengthwise.

Thin slats were tied across them at intervals.

Earth supports stood on both sides.

There was no railing.

When the rain eased a little, Hariprasad came towards the bridge.

He carried a long bamboo pole in his hand.

An old gamchha was tucked under his arm.

He stood on this side of the bridge and looked at the water.

The water was rushing swiftly beneath the bamboo.

Water hyacinth, straw, and tree branches had become lodged under the belly of the bridge.

The current struck against that blockage.

The bridge trembled lightly.

Hariprasad lowered the tip of the pole.

At that very moment, a man appeared on the other side.

It was Ramjatan.

Ramjatan too had a bamboo pole in his hand.

A little shorter.

The two looked at each other.

There was no greeting.

For twelve years, they had not spoken to each other.

The reason had not been a large one.

There was a footpath three hands wide.

The footpath ran between their two fields.

On the day of the survey, a stake had been driven a hand and a half to this side.

Hariprasad had said—the stake has shifted.

Ramjatan had said—the stake is in the right place.

The matter had begun with the footpath.

Then it went to the field ridge.

Then to the two families.

Then as far as the police station and the court.

The papers grew tired later.

The two men did not.

When passing in front of each other's houses, they would turn their eyes away.

If a bullock entered the other man's field, they would send a child.

If they had to sit in the same row at a wedding or a funeral feast, one of them would get up.

Today the two stood on opposite sides of the bridge.

Between them was the surging water.

Ramjatan pointed his bamboo towards the straw trapped below.

Hariprasad raised his long pole a little.

That was all.

Hariprasad stood near the mouth of the bridge.

Ramjatan examined the earth on his side.

The support on Ramjatan's side had sunk halfway.

He wedged his shorter bamboo beneath the support.

He took the other end of the bamboo onto his shoulder.

The bridge lifted a little.

Hariprasad pushed his long pole beneath the bridge.

The first thrust struck the straw.

The second struck the water hyacinth.

A thick branch was jammed in the middle.

Hariprasad worked the pole beneath it.

Ramjatan kept the support raised on his shoulder.

"More."

After twelve years, the first word from Ramjatan's mouth to Hariprasad came out.

Hariprasad did not reply.

He pushed the pole farther in.

The branch shifted a little.

Water rushed in at once.

One part of the straw broke free.

The current carried it away.

The bridge shook hard.

The support pressed down on Ramjatan's shoulder.

He clenched his teeth.

Hariprasad pulled out the pole and laid it across the bridge.

He stepped two paces forward.

One thin slat was loose.

The moment his foot came down on it, it lifted.

Hariprasad's heel became trapped between the slats.

The bridge tilted.

Hariprasad's body leaned to one side.

Ramjatan could not release the support from his shoulder.

He slid his shorter bamboo forward.

The end of the bamboo reached Hariprasad's chest.

Hariprasad caught it with both hands.

Ramjatan pulled the bamboo towards himself.

Hariprasad managed to free his heel from between the slats.

He remained lying on his stomach on the bridge.

The water roared below.

Ramjatan did not let go of the bamboo.

Hariprasad sat up.

The skin on his heel had been scraped.

He wiped it with the gamchha.

Ramjatan took the support onto his shoulder again.

Hariprasad turned back.

This time he did not climb onto the bridge.

He worked the long pole from the bank.

With his shorter bamboo, Ramjatan pressed against the other side of the branch.

Their two bamboo poles bore against opposite sides of the branch.

Hariprasad pushed.

Ramjatan lifted upward.

The branch turned.

The thick clump of water hyacinth split apart.

Half the debris flowed away with the current.

Space opened beneath the bridge.

The water rushed out swiftly.
The bridge still trembled, but less than before.
Ramjatan pulled out the shorter bamboo.
The support began sinking again.
He looked at the earth.
Something was needed to hold the earth in place.
Hariprasad saw two thin bamboo poles lying on his side.
He pushed one into the water.
The current carried the bamboo towards Ramjatan.
Ramjatan caught it.
He broke it into two pieces.
He wedged one beneath the support.
He braced the other crosswise against it.
The support became steady.
Hariprasad looked at the water again.
The thick branch was still trapped.
One end of it was on Ramjatan's side.
Ramjatan understood.
He set a foot on the bridge.
Hariprasad watched the way he walked.
Because of an old injury, Ramjatan's left leg did not bend fully.
On dry days, it was not noticeable.
On wet bamboo, it was.
He advanced one step at a time.
On reaching the loose slat in the middle, he stopped.
Hariprasad laid his long pole crosswise over the bridge.
One end was in his hand.
The other reached Ramjatan.
Ramjatan took hold of it.
The pole was now like a temporary railing.
Keeping one hand on the pole, Ramjatan moved forward.
From his side, Hariprasad held the pole firmly.
Ramjatan reached the branch.
He drew a small sickle from his waist.
He began cutting the thin twigs trapped around the branch.
One.

Two.
Three.
The twig came free.
The thick branch bent a little lower.
The current climbed over it.
Ramjatan tried to step back.
At that moment, the loose slat turned.
His left foot slipped.
Ramjatan's body leaned towards the side of the bridge.
His right hand was on the long pole.
Hariprasad pulled the pole tight against his chest.
He planted his feet in the earth.
Ramjatan did not hang from the pole.
Using it as a support, he brought his foot back onto the bamboo.
Hariprasad slowly pulled the pole back.
Ramjatan took one step backward.
Then another.
He returned as far as the middle.
Neither said anything.
The thick branch suddenly turned.
The water pulled it out from beneath the bridge and carried it away.
Along with it went the straw, the water hyacinth, and two smaller branches.
The current opened.
The bridge sprang upward once.
Then settled down.
Ramjatan returned to his side.
Hariprasad lifted the long pole.
The two stood on their respective banks.
The bridge between them.
Clear-flowing water below.
The rain began again.
First in large drops.
Then heavily.
Hariprasad tied the gamchha around his heel.
Ramjatan straightened his left leg.
Both were about to turn towards home.

At that moment, three children appeared from the direction of the western hamlet.

They had spent the night in the high school building.

An elderly woman was with them.

She carried a small bundle in her hand.

The children stopped the moment they saw the bridge.

Ramjatan stood at that end of the bridge.

Hariprasad at this end.

The first child set a foot on the bridge.

The bridge moved.

Hariprasad extended the long pole crosswise above the bridge.

Ramjatan caught the other end.

Between the two of them, a taut bamboo support formed.

"Keep your hand on this."

Holding the pole, the child crossed.

The second one too.

The third one too.

Before stepping onto the bridge, the elderly woman handed her bundle to Ramjatan.

She came slowly.

In the middle, her feet trembled.

Hariprasad raised the pole.

Ramjatan gripped it firmly from his side.

Holding the pole, the elderly woman crossed.

She looked at both of them.

"May God bless you."

Neither said anything.

The elderly woman walked towards the village with the children.

The rain had thinned now.

Ramjatan looked at the bridge support.

Hariprasad looked at the loose slat.

Ramjatan said—

"This slat will have to be replaced tomorrow."

Hariprasad said—

"The support too."

Both fell silent again.

The account of twelve years had not ended there.
The stake was still where it had been.
The footpath was still where it had been.
The old court papers were still at home.
But that evening, the bridge had survived.
The two went home by separate paths.
It rained again at night.
At dawn, people from the village came to look at the bridge.
The bridge was still standing.
One slat was still loose.
One support was still temporary.
Hariprasad arrived first.
He carried a new sickle and one thick bamboo pole.
A little later, Ramjatan appeared on the other side.
He too had a bamboo pole on his shoulder.
The two stopped at the mouths of the bridge.
Hariprasad put his bamboo down.
Ramjatan put his bamboo down.
One bamboo was right for the support.
The other for a railing.
No one decided which bamboo should go where.
Ramjatan pointed towards the support.
Hariprasad picked up his bamboo.
Hariprasad pointed towards the loose slat.
Ramjatan picked up his bamboo.
The two climbed onto the bridge.
One from this side.
One from the other.
They reached the middle.
The loose slat was there.
Hariprasad straightened it with his foot.
Ramjatan untied a length of hemp cord.
Both bent down.
Over the same slat.

STORY 70

The Washed-Away Ridge

On the third night of Ashadh, the rain fell hard.

By dawn, the eastern fields of the village were gleaming with water.

When Devanath Jha reached his field, he did not look first at the paddy.

He looked at the ridge.

The ridge between his field and Raghunath Yadav's had been washed away in three places.

The earth had been carried down by the water and deposited below.

At one place the gap was so wide that the water in the two fields seemed to be of one colour.

Devanath stood there for a while.

Raghunath was already on the other side.

He had a spade in his hand.

The two looked at each other.

Neither said Ram-Ram.

Devanath climbed onto the ridge.

Raghunath began scraping up the earth that had washed down below.

Three years earlier, this ridge had not been so high.

In those days, people from both families would cross it freely into each other's fields.

A child from Devanath's house would bring milk from Raghunath's cattle yard.

If a guest came to Raghunath's house, a cot would be carried over from Devanath's veranda.

If labourers fell short during paddy transplanting, no one counted whose field was whose.

Whoever was free would step into the other's field.

In those days the ridge stopped only water.

Not people.

Three years earlier, one night in Sawan, something had happened over a turn of water.

Too much water had entered Devanath's seedbed.

By morning, half the seedbed lay flattened like paste.

Raghunath had said that he had not opened the mouth of the channel before his own turn.

Devanath had said—

"Then did the water come on its own?"

Raghunath had replied—

"Ask the water."

That was all.

A few days later, fresh earth was piled onto the ridge.

After that, two bamboo stakes were driven into it.

After that, people too began walking only on their own sides.

Milk stopped coming from Raghunath's house.

Devanath's cot remained on his own veranda.

Invitations still reached for weddings and family ceremonies, but people arrived late.

They sat separately.

They returned separately.

For the first few days, the children tried to understand.

Then they too learned the rule, like the ridge itself.

Today that same ridge had been washed away in three places.

Devanath drove his spade into the earth.

The first gap was small.

He began cutting earth from his side of the field and filling it.

Raghunath began adding earth from the other side.

The earth from both sides met in the middle.

Their hands did not.

After a while Devanath's son Naval arrived.

He carried two baskets on a shoulder pole.

Raghunath's daughter Chanda came behind him carrying a pan of earth.

Naval stopped on the ridge.

Chanda stopped too.

The two could not pass through the gap at the same time.

Naval stepped down.

"Go."

Chanda said nothing.

She passed with the basket.

Raghunath looked up once.

So did Devanath.

Then both began cutting earth again.

The second gap was deep.
There the spade struck something hard inside the earth.
There was a knock.
Raghunath cleared the earth away with his hand.
An old earthen pipe emerged.
Half broken.
The mouth of the pipe opened towards both fields.
Naval asked—
"What is this?"
Raghunath lifted the pipe.
He brushed the earth from it with his hand.
Devanath said—
"The old outlet for releasing water."
Naval asked again—
"Here?"
This time no one answered at once.
Chanda put down the basket and began looking at the pipe.
Raghunath said—
"My father made it."
Devanath added—
"With my father."
Naval took the broken piece of pipe in his hand.
"Shall we put it back?"
Devanath remained silent.
So did Raghunath.
Rain clouds were gathering again in the east.
Thunder sounded in the distance.
Raghunath took the pipe from Naval's hand.
One side of it was cracked.
"This will not hold now."
Devanath climbed down from the ridge and went towards his side of the field.
Some pieces of dry bamboo lay there.
He picked up a hollow piece and brought it back.
He placed it beside the pipe.
"This will hold."
Raghunath looked through the bamboo.

"The opening is too wide."

"We will bury half of it in earth."

"What if the water runs hard?"

Devanath tapped the bamboo with the handle of his spade.

"We will put a stone on top."

For the first time in three years, the two men were speaking more than five sentences about the same piece of work.

Naval did not count them.

Neither did Chanda.

They simply kept bringing earth.

The piece of bamboo was laid beneath the ridge.

One mouth towards Devanath's field.

The other towards Raghunath's.

Earth from both sides was piled over it.

Raghunath pressed the earth down with his foot.

Devanath tamped it with the back of the spade.

The opening remained clear.

Chanda asked—

"Won't you close it?"

Raghunath said—

"Not now."

Devanath said nothing.

The third gap was the largest of all.

There the ridge had almost disappeared.

The two families' fields seemed to have run into each other.

There had once been a small footpath at that spot.

People from the village used to walk along this ridge towards the pond.

After the quarrel, both households had piled earth there and erased the footpath.

People began taking the longer way around.

Today the rain had lowered that place again.

Devanath said—

"We need more earth here."

Raghunath said—

"There is sand below."

"Cut some heavy clay from the side."

Raghunath went towards a corner of his field.

The soil there was heavy.

Devanath followed him.

For the first time in three years, he set foot in Raghunath's field.

Nothing happened.

The soil was still there.

The transplanted paddy was still there.

Raghunath's spade was still there.

Devanath cut two spadefuls of earth.

Raghunath filled the basket.

The two returned towards the ridge.

Sarju Kaka was passing along the village path.

He stopped.

He looked from a distance.

"The ridge washed away?"

Devanath said—

"Yes."

Sarju Kaka looked towards Raghunath.

"How much?"

Raghunath said—

"A little more than what you can see."

Sarju Kaka did not laugh.

He went on.

By afternoon, all three gaps had been filled.

The ridge stood again.

But the bamboo opening in the middle remained clear.

Naval placed a leaf over it.

The leaf fell through.

Chanda pulled it out from the other side.

"It works."

Naval said.

Raghunath said—

"We will know when the water comes."

The sky had grown darker still.

Devanath's wife, Sharda Devi, came from a distance carrying two lotas of water.

She stopped a little away from the ridge.
She gave one lota to Devanath.
She held the other out towards Naval.
Naval said—
"Babu, you drink first."
Devanath drank half the water and put the lota down.
At that moment Raghunath's wife, Kamla Devi, also reached the field.
She had a small container of sattu in her hand.
The two women looked at each other.
Sharda Devi's lota stood on the ridge.
Kamla Devi put the container of sattu down on her side.
After a while, the first large drop of rain fell.
Sharda Devi picked up one lota.
She left the other where it was.
Kamla Devi picked up the container.
She placed that lota in the middle of the ridge.
No one said anything.
Everyone started towards home.
It rained hard again at night.
Devanath did not sleep for a long time.
From the veranda, nothing could be seen towards the fields.
There was only the sound of water.
Once he got up and went as far as the doorway.
Sharda Devi asked—
"Will you go to the field?"
"Not now."
"The ridge?"
After a while Devanath said—
"We will see in the morning."
At dawn the rain stopped.
Devanath went towards the field.
Raghunath was already there.
The ridge stood.
Both fields were full of water.
Devanath's field was a little higher.
Raghunath's a little lower.

Leaves and grass were caught in the mouth of the bamboo.
The water had stopped.
Raghunath held out the spade.
Devanath stopped him with his hand.
He knelt down.
He removed the leaves by hand.
First a thin stream came through.
Then water began flowing towards Raghunath's field.
The two watched the stream for a while.
Raghunath said—
"If it becomes too much, we will pack in some earth."
Devanath said—
"If it becomes too little, we will take some out."
Raghunath nodded.
The two walked farther along the ridge.
At the place of the third gap, the earth had sunk a little.
Devanath drove his spade into the ground there.
Raghunath turned to bring earth from his own field.
Devanath said—
"There is some heavy clay left on my side."
Raghunath stopped.
"Then cut it from there."
Both climbed down into Devanath's field.
In the distance, Naval and Chanda could be seen going to school.
They reached the place where the old footpath had been.
Naval stopped.
Chanda stopped too.
This time Naval did not climb down.
He moved to one side on the ridge.
Chanda passed beside him.
Then both went ahead along the same path.
Devanath looked that way.
So did Raghunath.
Neither told them to take the longer way around.
After a while, both men were back on the ridge.
Earth was filled in.

It was tamped down with the spades.
The old footpath was not fully restored.
But the ridge was left a little wider there.
By afternoon, the water had gone down.
The stream through the bamboo opening had grown thin.
Raghunath placed his spade on his shoulder.
So did Devanath.
The two turned towards their separate homes.
After ten paces, Raghunath stopped.
“We will look at the outlet again this evening.”
Devanath stopped too.
“Yes.”
The two went on towards their respective homes.
The ridge stood.
There was also a place in the middle for the water to pass.

FROM THREE STREAMS OF STORIES · VOLUME III

STORY 71

School Shoes

✦ ✦ ✦

The first rain of Ashadh had fallen through the night. By morning, mud had gathered on the unpaved village road, and water dripping from the thatch had made little pools beside the veranda. Moti Paswan rose before dawn and ran a hand over the spade lying at the edge of the courtyard. The soil in the fields was soft today; on a day like this, seed settled readily into the earth.

At the other end of the veranda, his daughter Sarita was drying her school shoes. The black cloth shoes were now less black than the colour of mud. The sole of the left shoe had come loose at the toe, so Sarita had tied it twice around with twine. Inside the right shoe she had placed a piece of cardboard; without it, her heel would have touched the ground.

Moti looked at the shoes but said nothing.

Sarita asked, “Babu, will you get your wages today?”

“The munshi said yesterday that I would.”

“Then will you go to the market?”

Moti picked up the spade. “Let the money come into my hands first.”

Sarita said nothing more. She tightened the twine around the shoe, put her books into a cloth bag, and set off for school, picking her way around the mud.

Moti’s last three months had passed in ordinary day labour: unloading sacks of paddy one day, carrying bricks another, cutting field ridges on a third. He had no land of his own. Behind the house there were four dhurs of kitchen ground, where Kamli grew greens and vegetables. That year Nihal Yadav had offered him six kathas of fallow land on a half-share. The terms were simple: plough and oxen Nihal’s, labour Moti’s, seed Moti’s; the crop to be divided equally.

To Moti those six kathas were not merely a field. In a life measured out in days of hired labour, it was the first place where something sown by his own hands might bring a certain share of grain into his own house.

Seed would cost seven hundred and eighty rupees. Moti was owed one thousand three hundred and twenty rupees in wages. Sarita’s shoes would cost at least six hundred and fifty in the market—he had learned that the previous week.

The two things could not be done together.

By noon Moti and the other labourers were fixing sheets of tin onto the roof of a warehouse. The air was heavy after the rain. The sharp edge of the tin could slice a hand, and everyone worked with care.

At the meal break, the munshi took notes out of an old bag and began calling names.

“Moti Paswan.”

Moti stepped forward. The munshi counted out one thousand three hundred and twenty rupees into his palm.

“That settles the account.”

Moti folded the notes and knotted them into the corner of his gamchha. The word settled pleased him for a moment, but at once the image of Sarita’s loosened sole rose before his eyes.

When work ended, he went straight to the market. He stopped first at the seed shop. Tulsi Sah opened a sack of maize seed and showed him the kernels.

“Take eight kilos of this. Enough for six kathas.”

“How much for eight kilos?”

“Seven hundred and eighty.”

Moti took a few kernels into his palm. They were yellow and smooth, almost identical in size. He thought of Nihal’s field—the rain-darkened soil, ready to take the plough before evening.

“What if I take six kilos?”

Tulsi Sah shook his head. “I can give you six. But will you leave patches of the field empty? If you sow thin and the yield is poor later, don’t blame me.”

Moti let the kernels fall back into the sack.

Tulsi Sah asked, “Short of money?”

“There is another expense.”

“If you want it on credit, I’ll put your name in the book.”

Moti’s hand stopped over the sack. “Against the harvest?”

“Against the harvest. Like everyone else.”

Moti knew what that ‘like everyone else’ meant. As soon as the crop was cut, the price of the seed would be recovered first, then the higher charge laid on top of it, then the merchant’s share. Even his half of a sharecrop would carry the teeth of debt. Before his first cultivation had properly begun, he would already be caught in someone else’s ledger.

“Not now,” Moti said.

He crossed the market and reached the shoe shop. Shoes of many kinds hung from bamboo posts. The shopkeeper, seated inside, turned Sarita’s old shoe over in his hand. Moti had brought it with him.

“Put the sole back on,” Moti said.

The shopkeeper pressed the cloth near the toe with his thumb. It tore at once.

“If I fit a new sole to this, it won’t last even two weeks. The upper has rotted through.”

"Can you stitch it?"

"The stitches won't hold."

Moti was silent.

The shopkeeper drew out a pair of black shoes from below. "Take these. Seven hundred and twenty."

"The ones for six hundred and fifty?"

"That size is too small. How old is your daughter?"

"Thirteen."

The shopkeeper brought out another pair. "These are six hundred and seventy. I won't promise they'll last a very long time, but they'll see her through the rains."

Moti held the shoes in his hands and bent the soles. They were only this much weight, yet they would swallow more than half the notes knotted into his gamchha.

He walked out without buying them.

In the middle of the market, beside Teli Pond, stood a peepal tree. Moti sat beneath it. In front of him people bought vegetables, salt, oil, rope, sickles. No one else's expense seemed to be the enemy of another expense; only his rupees seemed to be pulled in two directions at once.

If the seed was not bought by evening, Nihal would give the field to someone else. If the shoes were not bought, Sarita would walk four kos again tomorrow in the same shoes bound with twine.

Moti looked down at his own feet. One strap of his rubber sandal was fastened with wire. It was good enough for going to work. For a moment he wondered—were shoes truly so necessary? One studied with the head, not with the feet.

Then he remembered the morning: Sarita adjusting the cardboard inside her shoe. She had never once said, 'I won't go.' The torn shoe had not become her excuse; it had become one more task she performed every day.

Moti rose and started home. The school lay on the way. Classes had ended. Near the gate, two children came out wheeling bicycles. Then Sarita appeared from behind them. Her pace was slower than usual.

"What happened?" Moti asked.

Sarita tried to smile. "Nothing."

"Show me your foot."

"Babu—"

"Show me."

Sarita sat at the roadside and took off the shoe. The skin on her right heel had been rubbed raw and red. The cardboard had soaked up water and gone soft, and mud had worked its way inside the sole.

Moti asked, "Will you go in these tomorrow?"

Putting the shoe back on, Sarita said, “I can manage two more days. You buy the seed. Nihal Kaka will give the field to someone else.”

Moti looked at her. “Who told you that?”

“Ma told me.”

“Your ma says too many things.”

“I understand it too. If we get six kathas, maize will come into the house.”

For some distance Moti walked beside his daughter without speaking. Whenever Sarita stepped into the mud, she lifted her right foot a little, so that less pressure fell on the heel.

At home Kamli was blowing on the hearth. Moti untied the corner of his gamchha and laid the notes on the cot.

Kamli asked, “Did you bring the seed?”

“I didn’t bring the seed.”

“Then the shoes?”

“Not yet.”

She watched his face for a few moments. “Then?”

Moti said, “I’m going back to the market now.”

Kamli looked at Sarita’s foot. Without a word she rubbed turmeric and oil onto the chafed heel.

By the time Moti reached the market again, darkness was coming down. The seed shop was half packed away. From a distance Tulsi Sah called, “Taking it?”

Moti shook his head and walked on.

The shoe seller was untying the bamboo post. Moti asked for the pair that cost six hundred and seventy rupees. The shopkeeper wrapped it in paper. As he paid, Moti counted out a five-hundred-rupee note, hundred-rupee notes and smaller notes separately. Six hundred and fifty rupees remained in his hand.

On his way home he stopped at Nihal Yadav’s courtyard.

“I couldn’t arrange the seed,” Moti said.

Nihal watched him for a few moments. “Then the field?”

“Give it to whoever you need to.”

“I can hold it until tomorrow.”

Moti touched the knot in his gamchha. “The seed will not appear by tomorrow.”

Nihal said, “All right. I’ll speak to Ram Bali in the morning.”

Moti bowed and left. Saying the decision aloud did not make the burden lighter; it only gave the burden a clear shape.

That night Sarita tried on the new shoes. She rose from the cot, walked as far as the veranda, and came back.

"Not loose?"

"They fit properly."

"Not cutting your heel?"

"Not now."

Kamli said, "Before you wear them tomorrow, I'll tuck some dry cloth inside. They'll get wet in the rain."

Sarita took the shoes off and set them side by side beneath the cot. Moti kept looking at them. He thought of Nihal's six kathas, where seed should have gone into the earth that day.

The next morning Ram Bali ploughed that field. Moti went to work in another field. Nihal's land lay along the way. Furrows were being drawn across the freshly turned soil for maize. Moti stopped for two moments, then walked on.

Sarita wore her new shoes to school. The monsoon mud swallowed their shine on the very first day.

By the end of Sawan, Ram Bali's maize had grown above the knee. From time to time Moti passed the field. He looked at the spacing of the rows, at the colour of the plants, but said nothing to anyone.

In Bhadon there was less work. The household tightened again around its expenses. Kamli planted pigeon pea and kodo in one corner of the kitchen plot. Whenever Moti was paid a few seers of grain instead of wages, it all went into the household store.

In Kartik, on the day Nihal's maize was harvested, Moti too went there as a hired labourer. Ram Bali was the sharecropper; Moti was a labourer. From morning onward they broke off cobs and piled them in heaps.

At noon Ram Bali said, "The yield is good this year. I caught the first rain, that's why."

Moti said, "Yes."

In the evening the labourers were paid. Nihal gave Moti some money and two paseris of maize as well, because some workers had chosen part of their wages in grain. Moti carried his sack home.

Kamli spread a bamboo mat to dry the maize. While emptying the sack, Moti set aside a few well-filled, healthy cobs.

Kamli asked, "Why are those separate?"

"For seed."

"There isn't much maize in the house."

"Let these five cobs remain."

Kamli said nothing. She picked up all five and tied them to a rafter above the veranda, where the smoke would reach them and insects would be less likely to spoil them.

By then Sarita's new shoes were no longer new. The toes were scuffed and the laces had been replaced once, but the soles were sound. She continued going to school every day.

One evening in Agahan, Sarita sat studying on the veranda. Above her, the five cobs tied to the rafter swayed lightly in the moving air. She asked her father, "Aren't we going to eat those?"

Moti said, "No. Next rains, we'll put them into the earth."

Sarita looked up, then down at her shoes. A faint line of dried mud marked the black cloth.

She opened her book again.

Leaning against a post of the veranda, Moti counted the cobs tied to the rafter —one, two, three, four, five.

This time the count was small, but the seed belonged to the house.

STORY 72

The Panchayat Hand Pump

✦ ✦ ✦

It was an evening in Jeth. Four women were returning from the western hamlet with water pots balanced on their heads. The sun had gone down, but the dust was still warm. Malati's little daughter Gudiya followed behind carrying an empty lota. It was empty because, in the crowd at the distant well, she had not found a chance to fill it.

When they reached the hamlet, Malati lowered her pot onto the veranda. The ring of cloth on her head was soaked with sweat. Her mother-in-law asked, "Why so late this time?"

"The water in the well has gone down. We had to lower the rope twice over."

That same evening word came that the panchayat had sanctioned a new hand pump for the western hamlet. The boring would be done the following week. As soon as the news spread, the women first began talking about where the pump would be installed. In the middle of the hamlet, behind the pipal tree, there was an empty strip of public land where four paths met. Everyone assumed the pump would be placed there.

But on the day the boring vehicle arrived, it did not stop by the pipal tree. It drove through the gate of Navalkishore Singh's house.

Navalkishore's house stood at the edge of the hamlet: a plastered boundary wall, an iron gate, two cows, a bullock cart, and a large courtyard within. In the village, whether the matter was fertiliser bought on credit, fields given on share, or panchayat elections, people listened to his opinion on many things.

Malati and Shanti went as far as the gate. Inside, in the right-hand corner of the courtyard, the boring equipment had been set up.

Malati asked, "The hand pump will be here?"

Navalkishore said, "The soil near the pipal is loose. We'll get better water here. The gate will remain open. A panchayat hand pump will remain the panchayat's."

Shanti looked at the boundary wall. "The gate will remain yours."

Navalkishore laughed. "A gate cannot stop water."

For the first week, it truly did not. From morning till evening, the women went in, worked the pump, filled their pots, and came out. The pump yielded a strong flow. What had taken two hours at the distant well could now be done in half an hour.

In the second week, rules began.

First it was said that the gate would not open before five in the morning. Then it was said that from one to three in the afternoon the women of the household

rested, so there should be no crowd at that hour. Then, after evening, the gate began to be chained.

If someone needed one extra pot of water, the servant would ask, “What will you do with so much water?”

The first time Malati heard this, she replied, “What one does with water.”

The servant laughed. Malati did not.

A few days later, Shanti’s daughter-in-law returned late from the fields. There was no water left in the house. At eight that night she went to the gate. A voice from inside called, “Come tomorrow now.”

She walked to the distant well. In the dark, while lowering the rope, she scraped the skin from her palm.

The next morning, showing the wound, she said, “By day the panchayat hand pump belongs to the panchayat; by night it belongs to the house.”

At that sentence, everyone fell silent.

That evening nine women sat on Malati’s veranda. No one made a speech. No one took out a sheet of paper. One by one they simply told what had happened to them—who had found the gate closed and when, who had been made to wait and for how long, whom the servant had questioned.

Shanti said, “We go separately, so we are given separate answers.”

Malati asked, “Then?”

Renu said, “If one household is stopped, all of us must understand that all of us have been stopped.”

Everyone liked that. From that day they made a rule of their own: if anyone was stopped at the gate, she would not quietly turn back. She would send word through the hamlet. Then four or five women would go back with her. No one would use kinship, wage work, or personal acquaintance to obtain a separate privilege.

The first test came two days later.

Kamli went to fetch water at half past four in the morning. She was told to wait until five. Kamli turned back and went to Malati’s house. Within ten minutes, five women were standing at the gate.

Navalkishore himself came out. “Why are all of you here so early?”

Malati said, “If the water of one household is stopped, our water is stopped.”

“Fill your pots from five.”

Shanti asked, “What about those who leave for wage work at four?”

Navalkishore said, “Then fill your water at night and keep it ready.”

Kamli showed him her scraped palm. “The gate is closed at night.”

Irritation came over Navalkishore’s face. “This is a house, not an inn.”

Malati answered quietly, “We too have houses. The hand pump belongs to the panchayat.”

The matter stopped there. At five the gate opened. Everyone filled her water and went home.

Over the next few days there was no open clash, but the rules did not change. The women did not abandon their rule either. Whenever one of them was stopped, a group formed. Those inside the gate understood that telling one woman, “Come tomorrow,” could now turn into questions from five women.

On the day the first clouds of Ashadh gathered, it was time to pull up the mung crop in Navalkishore’s field. The crop was ready. As he watched the clouds, his worry grew. If rain came, the dry pods in the field could get wet and turn black.

He needed many hands the next morning. The women of the western hamlet knew well how to pull up mung and bind it into bundles. That evening Navalkishore’s servant came with a message: “Reach the field at four in the morning. You will receive the full wage.”

Malati asked, “At four?”

“Yes. There are clouds.”

Shanti, who was sitting there too, said, “And water for the house before four?”

The servant said nothing.

Malati said, “Tell Naval Babu—first water, then the field.”

A little later Navalkishore came himself. “Tomorrow, for one day, the gate will open at half past three. All of you fill your water and come to the field at four.”

Renu asked, “And the day after tomorrow?”

Navalkishore understood where the question was leading. “The day after tomorrow, the usual hours again.”

Malati said, “Then opening it tomorrow is not our right. It is a convenience for your crop.”

Navalkishore’s voice hardened. “Do you want the wages or not?”

Shanti replied, “We do. Do you want labourers or not?”

For two moments no one spoke.

Thunder sounded in the distance.

Navalkishore asked, “What is it that all of you want?”

Malati gave the answer she had already thought through. “Once the hand pump is here, there should be no restriction on the time when the gate may be used. Anyone who comes as far as the pump should not have to ask anyone’s permission. Your house is farther inside; we will not go into it. We ourselves will keep the place around the pump clean.”

“Open at night too?”

"At night too. Thirst does not look at the hour before it comes."

Navalkishore looked toward the boundary wall. The hand pump was not very far inside the gate. To the right was the cowshed, to the left the veranda. The women of his household objected mainly because strangers moved through the courtyard all day.

His wife Vimla had been listening from the veranda. She did not come outside, but called from within, "If a bamboo screen is put up between the pump and the veranda, the inner part of the house will be hidden."

Navalkishore turned and looked inside. "A screen?"

"The old bamboo from the cowshed is lying there."

Malati said nothing. This was a solution the household itself had offered.

Navalkishore looked at the women again. "The ground around a hand pump turns muddy. Who will keep it clean?"

Renu said, "We will. One of the seven households each day. But the chain will not be put on."

"If the gate remains open, the cows will get out."

Shanti said, "Tie the cows separately in the cowshed. A panchayat hand pump is not there to guard cows."

Vimla's laughter came from inside. Navalkishore looked toward her, then toward the clouds.

"All right," he said at last. "From tomorrow the corner with the hand pump will remain open. The inner veranda will be screened off with bamboo. No one is to go beyond the screen."

Malati replied, "We will go as far as the hand pump for water. What business would we have beyond the screen?"

The next morning the gate opened at half past three. This time, however, it was not merely for one day. A new bamboo screen stood beside the cowshed. From the hand pump, the inner veranda could no longer be seen. The chain of the gate had been hung on a nail above it.

The women filled their water quickly. By four o'clock, twelve women were walking toward Navalkishore's field.

The rain came after noon. By then much of the mung had already been pulled up and tied into bundles. Some of it got wet, but not the whole crop.

That day, when the wages were paid, Navalkishore paid the ordinary rate. No one raised the matter of the hand pump. The women too counted their wages and went home. In the first week, the new arrangement was tested twice. One night a guest arrived late at Kamli's house; at nine she went to fetch water. The gate was open. The next afternoon Rekha's daughter filled two extra pots to wash clothes. No one asked, "Why so much water?" The women kept their turns for cleaning. Mud around the pump was removed, broken bricks were laid down, and whenever the handle grew loose it was tightened in time. Sometimes Vimla too

would leave the sweepings from inside outside to be taken away; around the hand pump now, the rhythms of the household and the hamlet had begun to fit together.

A month later Malati came at dawn to fetch water. The old iron chain of the gate still hung from the same nail above. A light film of rust had begun to form on it. As Gudiya worked the handle, she asked, “Ma, why don’t they use this chain anymore?” Malati steadied the pot and said, “If they use it, it will have to be opened again.” Gudiya did not fully understand what the answer meant. She pressed the handle once more. Water came from the pump. On the other side of the bamboo screen, the household’s morning was beginning; on this side, the hamlet was filling its pots. The chain hung silently on the nail.

STORY 73

Wages

✦ ✦ ✦

At dawn in Phagun, the earth at the brick kiln was still damp with the night's dew. To the east, a long plume of smoke rose and dissolved into the pale sky. In the grey light, the rows of unbaked bricks looked as though enormous rectangular grids had been drawn upon the ground.

Ramphal Sada pressed the wooden mould into the clay and lifted it away. His wife, Jasoda, packed in the wet earth. Their fourteen-year-old son, Bhola, picked up the bricks released from the mould and laid them in rows. Twelve-year-old Chanda had once helped with the same work, but for the past three weeks she had begun attending a temporary school that ran for two hours every evening beside the kiln.

That morning Chanda was not carrying bricks. In her hand were half a broken pencil and an old slate. She sat at the head of the rows, counting the bricks twenty at a time.

"Five rows done?" Ramphal asked.

"Five rows make one hundred," Chanda said. "It is four hundred and eighty now."

Bhola burst out laughing. "Are we here to make bricks, or to sit your examination?"

Chanda wrote 480 on the slate. "Both."

Ramphal laughed too, but Jasoda did not. She was pleased that Chanda went to the evening school. During their first month at the kiln, Chanda had carried clay all day. Then, one day, a teacher from the nearby primary school had come to the kiln. She had said that for children unable to attend school during the day, there would be evening classes in letters and numbers. Ramphal had initially brushed the idea aside. Jasoda had said, "She will carry less clay for two hours, but she will learn something."

In three weeks Chanda had moved beyond addition and subtraction and was learning multiplication. Numbers felt like a game to her—especially zero. The teacher had explained that when the place value changed, one added a zero: zero was nothing in itself, yet by changing its place it could change the value. Chanda had liked that thought very much.

At the kiln, wages were paid by the thousand bricks. At the beginning of the work period, the contractor had told Ramphal: lay one thousand unbaked bricks and the payment would be six hundred rupees. The work of the whole family would be counted together. Advances, grain and oil taken on credit would be deducted in the final settlement.

Ramphal understood “six hundred.” He understood “one thousand” as well. But when the bricks made through the day, the broken bricks, advances, ration credit and weekly payments were all entered together in the ledger, his eyes grew tired. Every evening Harinarayan, who kept the accounts, took small wooden tokens from a red cloth pouch. One token stood for one thousand bricks.

That evening Harinarayan came to Ramphal’s section. He looked over the rows of unbaked bricks, measured the spacing at two or three places with his foot, and said, “One thousand complete. The rest tomorrow.”

He gave Ramphal one token.

Chanda looked at her slate. It said 1,360.

“Three hundred and sixty?” she asked.

Harinarayan looked at her. “The rest will be added tomorrow.”

Below 1,360, Chanda wrote in small letters: “Token 1, remainder 360.”

The next day they made 1,420 bricks. In the evening, again, there was one token.

Chanda asked, “Yesterday’s three hundred and sixty plus today’s four hundred and twenty makes seven hundred and eighty. Where is that written?”

Harinarayan laughed. “Girl, mind your lessons. This is the kiln’s accounting.”

Ramphal said at once, “Be quiet, Chanda. The people who run the work know the accounts.”

Chanda fell silent. On the slate she wrote: “Remainder 780?”

She had only recently learned the question mark.

On the third day there was a light shower. The family hurried to cover the rows with straw so the unbaked bricks would be saved. They made 1,380 bricks that day. Harinarayan again gave one token.

Chanda asked nothing. She only added: 780 and 380—1,160.

By her reckoning, another full thousand had now been completed, with one hundred and sixty left over.

But there were only three wooden tokens.

That night Jasoda sat by the hearth baking rotis. Chanda placed the slate before her.

“Ma, look at this.”

Jasoda could recognise the numerals, but she could not add them. “What am I supposed to see?”

Chanda showed her the entries for the three days. “We have made four thousand one hundred and sixty bricks. The tokens account for three thousand.”

Ramphal heard from outside and came in. “Broken bricks are deducted.”

Chanda said, “The broken ones are in a separate heap. I have not counted them.”

"Then they must know."

"Shouldn't we know too?"

Ramphal picked up the slate and looked at it. To him the numerals were signs whose meaning he did not fully command. It was easier to trust Harinarayan's ledger than Chanda's small slate. The ledger was thick, bound in covers, and Harinarayan walked about with a pen tucked behind his ear. One corner of Chanda's slate was broken.

Ramphal handed the slate back. "Count again tomorrow. But do not quarrel with anyone."

For the next four days Chanda did not quarrel. She only counted.

1,540. 1,290. 1,480. 1,000.

The seven-day total came to 9,470.

Tokens—7.

This time Chanda took her slate to her teacher, Neelam. Neelam checked the addition once more.

"Your addition is correct."

"Then where did two thousand four hundred and seventy bricks go?"

Neelam did not answer at once. She asked, "How did you count these numbers?"

Chanda explained the arrangement of the rows—twenty in one row, five rows to one hundred; broken bricks separated after they were made. Neelam said, "Look only at your own family's account. Do not draw conclusions about anyone else. And do not call anyone a thief without proof."

Chanda had not used the word "thief," but her face grew hot.

The next day she said to Ramphal, "Will you agree to one thing today?"

"Say it. What is it?"

"After one thousand is complete, let us keep the leftover bricks in a separate row."

Ramphal scratched his head. "That will take space."

"For one day."

Jasoda said, "Let her do it."

That day the family made 1,260 bricks. The first thousand were laid in the usual rows. Chanda placed the remaining 260 in two short rows apart from the rest. On the corner of the first brick she made a small circular mark with her finger.

In the evening Harinarayan gave them one token.

"These two hundred and sixty tomorrow?" Chanda asked.

"Yes, tomorrow."

The next day the family made 1,480 bricks. Chanda combined the previous day's 260 with the first 740 of the new day and said to Ramphal, "This is one thousand complete."

This time Ramphal counted them himself. Twenty to a row. Five rows to one hundred. One hundred ten times. Exactly one thousand.

The remaining 740 from the new day stayed separate.

In the evening Harinarayan came. He counted the new day's rows and gave one token.

Ramphal asked, "And the token for this separate thousand?"

Harinarayan's eyes went to the brick with the circular mark. "That was yesterday's remainder."

"Yesterday you said it would be added today."

"It must have been added."

"Where is it written?"

Harinarayan opened the ledger. Beside Ramphal's name were seven short strokes. He had just drawn the eighth.

"See? Everything is written."

Chanda did not bend over the ledger. She pointed instead to the separate thousand bricks on the ground. "Which stroke is for this thousand?"

Harinarayan's voice hardened. "Will a child teach me accounts?"

Ramphal would normally have silenced her, but this time he had counted that separate thousand himself. He said, "Not the child. I counted these bricks."

Two families working nearby stopped and began listening. Jasoda said quietly, "Ask about our account first, not theirs."

Ramphal did just that. "Today we need two tokens. One for the new thousand, and one for the thousand completed by combining yesterday's and today's remainder. Seven hundred and four ten—" He stopped.

Chanda corrected him softly, "Seven hundred and forty."

Ramphal repeated, "Seven hundred and forty will remain for tomorrow."

Harinarayan shut the ledger. "Speak to the owner."

The kiln owner arrived after dusk. His name was Shivkant Chaudhary. He first heard Harinarayan, then Ramphal. At last he looked at Chanda's slate—the numbers for seven days, the number of tokens, and the total written below.

"Are the bricks for all those days still separately identifiable?" he asked.

Chanda said, "Not for the first seven days. Today's and yesterday's are."

Shivkant had the separate thousand counted again. This time Harinarayan did not count them; two labourers did. The full thousand was there.

Harinarayan said, "If we keep every day's remainder separate, the whole yard will fill up."

For the first time Chanda spoke in front of the owner. “There is no need to keep them separate. Write the remainder on paper. Add it the next day.”

Harinarayan looked at her.

Shivkant asked, “Where did you learn this?”

“At the evening school.”

“Multiplication too?”

“I am learning it now.”

Shivkant did not smile. He turned to Ramphal. “The heaps from the previous seven days have been mixed. A complete verification is difficult now.”

Ramphal’s face tightened.

“But the thousand from yesterday and today is clear,” Shivkant continued. “Give them its token. From now on, the remainder will be entered in the ledger.”

“And the old amount?” Jasoda asked.

Shivkant was silent for a moment. “Whatever can be proved with certainty will be added. I will not reopen the previous month merely on someone’s word.”

It was not complete justice. Ramphal understood that. Jasoda did too. Chanda understood it most clearly of all—9,470 still stood on her slate, but the bricks from those first seven days had already been mixed among the rows of other families, and the proof was gone.

That night eight families from the kiln gathered outside Ramphal’s hut, bringing their wooden tokens and whatever estimates they had of the day’s work. Chanda did not make anyone’s account for them. She only kept asking, “How many full thousands today? What was the remainder?” Where someone did not know, she left a blank beside the name.

The next morning, before beginning work, all eight families said that the remainder must first be written down.

For half an hour the moulds lay empty.

The clay was ready. The carts had already unloaded earth. The sun was climbing. If the prepared clay lay too long, its moisture would change. Shivkant came again.

This time the new arrangement was simple. Beside Ramphal’s name in the ledger, two columns were made: “Full thousands” and “Remainder.” The wooden tokens remained as before, but at the end of each day the remainder was spoken aloud and entered in front of the labourer. The next day’s first count began from that same remainder.

On the first day under the new system, Ramphal’s ledger read: full thousands 1, remainder 740.

On the second new day they made 1,310 bricks. Add 740 and the total was 2,050. They received two tokens. Remainder 50.

Ramphal stood for a long while looking at the tokens in his hand. Then he gave them to Chanda.

“Count.”

Chanda counted the two tokens. “Two.”

“What is the remainder?”

“Fifty.”

Ramphal looked at Harinarayan. “Is fifty written?”

Harinarayan turned the ledger around and showed him. 50 was written there.

At the end of that week, the wages for the clearly verified thousand from the two disputed days were added separately. The full discrepancy from the old seven days was never recovered. Shivkant added the money corresponding to the two days for which there was clear proof; about the rest he said, “There is no count.”

Ramphal argued, but after half an hour he fell silent. He knew that some of the money had again been buried in the clay. But this time he knew where the clay was.

At the evening school, Neelam looked at Chanda’s slate. The old line, 9,470, was still there. Beneath it Chanda had written the new calculation:

740 + 1,310 = 2,0502 thousandRemainder 50

Neelam asked, “Now do you understand how zero changes place?”

Chanda smiled. “Not zero. The remainder changes.”

On the way home she put the slate into her cloth bag. At the kiln, Ramphal and Jasoda were covering the clay for the next day. Bhola was washing the empty moulds.

In the distance Harinarayan sat at his table closing the ledger. Beside Ramphal’s name, the words “Remainder 50” remained written.

Chanda read the number once. Fifty was not a very large number. But for the first time, it had not disappeared anywhere.

STORY 74

The Little Teacher

✦ ✦ ✦

In the western hamlet of Sirsiya village stood an old oil press. The circular track where the bullock once walked had long ago been filled with earth, but the veranda remained—three bamboo posts, a tiled roof, and one thin wall. Every evening at five, eleven children spread mats on that veranda and sat down. Upendra sat before them.

Upendra was a graduate. He had earned his degree three years earlier, and since then, wherever an application had opened—in the district offices, the block, the railways, the postal department, a cooperative institution—he had kept applying. In some written examinations his name reached the first list; in others, it did not. Once he made it as far as an interview, but no job came of it.

The village respected his education, but noticed his unemployment even more.

"The big masters are at the school," someone would say at the crossroads. "This little master looks after children in the evenings."

The name had begun as a joke. Slowly, it stuck.

Upendra did not object. The agreed monthly fee was thirty rupees per child, but the full amount rarely came in. One child's father worked for daily wages, another's mother laboured in the fields; in some homes there was money one month and none the next. Upendra kept no ledger. On the first day he had written down only the children's names and classes; after that, the matter of fees remained a spoken understanding.

Of the eleven children, Gauri was the quietest.

She was in Class Seven. She could read a lesson, and if an answer could be found in the book, she could write it down too. But if someone said, "Explain it in your own words," her eyes would come to rest on the page.

During the first week, Upendra one day had her close the book.

"Now tell me in one sentence what you have just read."

Gauri was silent.

"Do not open the book."

Her fingers rested on the cover.

"Say the first word that comes to mind."

After a long while she said, "Seed."

"Good. What happened to the seed?"

"A sprout came out."

"Why?"

Gauri fell silent again.

Chhotan, sitting behind her, began to laugh. Upendra did not rebuke him. He merely asked, “Do you know the answer?”

Chhotan went quiet at once.

Upendra had brought a small earthen bowl of chickpeas that he had soaked two days earlier. He placed it before Gauri.

“Look at this. Not the sentence in the book. Tell me what you can see.”

Gauri picked up one chickpea. A tiny white root had emerged from it.

“It has burst open from inside.”

“That is enough. Now a second sentence.”

That was how Upendra’s evening lessons went. He had made one rule: before the lesson ended, for ten minutes one child would explain to another one thing learned that day. Whoever could not explain it would ask again. There was no punishment and no applause.

At first, the children waited for those ten minutes chiefly because they expected a chance to laugh. After a few weeks, the laughter lessened. The child who laughed at someone today knew that tomorrow his own turn would come.

Gauri’s father, Sahdev Mandal, was not greatly impressed by these lessons.

He worked as an agricultural labourer and grew vegetables in the half-katha patch beside his courtyard. He had two younger sons. When Gauri returned home, she helped her mother with the evening meal and then looked through her little brothers’ books.

Two months later, Sahdev came to Upendra’s veranda.

“Master, Gauri’s marks have not gone up.”

Upendra asked, “How many did she get?”

“Forty-one last time. Forty-three this time.”

“They went up by two.”

“Thirty rupees a month for two marks?”

Upendra remained silent.

Sahdev said, “I am not saying that she should stop studying. She will keep going to school. But there is work at home in the evenings too.”

Gauri was sitting on the mat. Her eyes were lowered.

Upendra said quietly, “Give it one more month. I cannot promise you marks.”

“Then what can you promise?”

“Nothing. After one month, you can see for yourself.”

A faint displeasure crossed Sahdev’s face. “You sit for job examinations too, don’t you?”

“I do.”

"Have you passed one?"

The question was direct. Upendra answered just as directly. "Not yet."

Sahdev said, "Hm," and left.

That night Upendra sat for a long time with a copy of an application form before him. The following week there was a district-level clerical examination. On the lesson veranda he told the children, "Say it in your own words." Yet in what words he himself would explain his own life was not clear to him.

There was no evening lesson on the day of the examination.

The next day the children asked, "How did it go?"

Upendra said, "I answered the questions I understood. The ones I did not understand, I left."

Chhotan asked, "You leave questions too?"

"Yes."

For the first time, Gauri smiled faintly.

Two weeks later the result came. Upendra's name was not on the list.

The news reached the crossroads before it reached his home. Four young men had applied; one was selected, three were not. But Upendra taught children, so his failure was more visible to people.

That evening, someone at the tea stall joked, "Now the Little Master can at least make the little children pass their examinations."

Upendra heard him. He did not stop.

That day Gauri was already seated on the veranda. Beside her was her younger brother Manoj, who usually stayed at home.

"Why is he here?" Upendra asked.

Gauri said, "Mother has gone to the fields. He could not be left alone at home."

"Then let him sit."

That day's lesson was fractions: one-half, one-fourth, three-fourths.

Upendra drew a circle on the ground like a round roti. Then he divided it into four parts.

"If three parts are coloured, how much is that?"

Chhotan answered at once, "Three-fourths."

"Why?"

Chhotan stopped.

Gauri said slowly, "The whole thing has been divided into four equal parts. Three of those parts have been taken."

Upendra did not interrupt her.

"And two parts?"

"One-half. Because two out of four are equal to half."

Upendra said only, "Yes."

Manoj, who was younger than the children in that class, began drawing four sections in the earth with his finger.

In the final ten minutes that day, it was Gauri's turn. She had to explain fractions to Chhotan. At first she tried to open the book, then closed it herself.

"Four rotis were made in your house," she said. "You ate two. What part did you eat?"

Chhotan said, "Half."

"Why?"

Chhotan laughed. "Now I understand."

Three days before the month was complete, Sahdev, returning from the fields, stopped near the veranda. He did not come inside. He stood behind a bamboo post and listened.

At that moment Gauri was explaining the difference between a river and a pond to Sita, who was in Class Five. Her sentences were not from the book. Now and then she stopped, searched for another word, and continued. Sita asked a question. Gauri explained again.

Sahdev said nothing. He quietly went home.

The next morning, Gauri's mother Sarita came to Upendra's house. In her hands were a bottle gourd and a small bag of peas.

"We could not collect the full money this month," she said. "Keep these."

Upendra did not take the bag. "Pay whenever it comes together."

Sarita set the bag down on the veranda. "This is not the fee. It is from the field. We have more at home."

She turned to leave, then stopped.

"Sahdev says Gauri will not stop the evening lessons."

Upendra only nodded.

"Did her marks go up?"

Sarita laughed. "He did not say anything about that."

She left.

The following week, Ramapati Babu, the language teacher at the school, met Upendra at the market. The two already knew each other.

Ramapati Babu said, "Gauri studies with you, doesn't she?"

"Yes."

"Earlier she memorised answers, but if you questioned her she fell silent. Now, even when her answer is wrong, she explains her reason. That is a good change."

Without thinking, Upendra asked, "Her marks?"

Ramapati Babu laughed. “You worry about marks too?”

They went their separate ways.

In Phagun there was a wedding in the village. Two appointed teachers from the school were seated on chairs near the raised platform. Upendra was with the young men of his own age, helping lay out leaf plates for the meal.

Someone called to him from a distance, “Little Master, put these four wooden stools over there.”

He carried the stools over and arranged them.

As evening fell, he found Gauri, Chhotan, and Sita in an empty veranda behind the wedding house. All three had books in their hands.

Upendra was surprised. “There is no lesson today.”

Chhotan said, “We know.”

“Then why the books?”

Gauri said, “We gave three different answers to yesterday’s question. We thought we would ask you.”

Upendra sat down on the corner of a wooden stool. In the distance, the elders were talking near the platform, the rows for the meal were forming, and at any moment someone might call him again to bring a bundle of leaf plates.

He listened to the children’s question.

He did not answer at once.

First he asked, “What did each of you think?”

One by one, all three began to explain their ideas.

Amid the noise of the wedding, four people bent together in that small veranda, listening to three answers to the same question.

STORY 75

Seven Steps

✦ ✦ ✦

My printing press usually closes at about half past ten at night. All day it is filled with the rumble of machines, the rustle of paper, the clink of type, and the voices of people; but the moment the last worker crosses the gate, the building suddenly begins to show its age. Wooden beams creak, old iron sounds in a tired voice, and the smell of damp from the basement at the back rises all the way upstairs.

There are seven steps down to the basement.

I knew that number very well. Before locking up at night, I had to go down and check the valve on the main water line. During the rains, if it was left loose, water could rise through the wall and ruin the paper. For twenty years this had been part of my routine.

But from that week in Sawan onward, another sound began to come after the seventh step.

The first night I paid no attention to it.

I shut down the machine, put the files into the cabinet, checked the rear door, and went downstairs carrying a lantern. The electricity had been out since evening. As I descended, the sound of my sandals on the steps was distinct.

One.

Two.

Three.

Four.

Five.

Six.

Seven.

My foot came down on the level brick floor.

Immediately afterward, behind me, there was a thak.

I turned. I raised the lantern. All seven steps were empty. In the doorway above there was only darkness.

I thought a wooden plank must have shifted. I tightened the water-line valve and went back upstairs.

The same thing happened the second night.

This time I had not been counting. My mind was elsewhere: the next day five thousand copies of a wedding invitation had to be delivered, and the red ink was running low. I reached the bottom and bent beside the pipe. Then, from above, came one clear thak.

As though someone behind me had just stepped down from the final stair.

I straightened. I listened. Nothing.

On the third night I took Sudhir with me. He had been running the press machine for ten years and laughed immediately at things like this.

I said, “You go down first.”

He descended the seven steps and stood below. There was no extra sound.

“Did you hear anything?”

“No. Nothing.”

I followed him down.

From one to seven, my footsteps sounded. I reached the floor.

Thak.

Sudhir lifted the lantern and looked upward. “What was that?”

I felt some relief that the sound was not something invented by my ears alone.

“You heard it?”

“Yes. But why did it sound like a footstep?”

For half an hour the two of us searched around the basement. To the left of the stairway was a thick brick wall; on the right, an old wooden brace. When we struck the brace, it gave a hollow sound, but not the same thak. We shook the beam above. We opened and closed the water line. We dragged the iron chest aside. The sound did not come again.

The next day I wrote the numbers one through seven in chalk along the edges of the steps.

Sudhir joked, “If we find an eighth, shall we give that one a number too?”

I did not scold him. I only said, “We will see tonight.”

The matter stayed in my mind throughout the day. The machine kept running, paper kept being cut, the red borders of the wedding invitations kept printing, but every now and then I saw those seven chalk numbers before me.

That evening an old compositor named Hiralal came by. His eyesight had weakened now, but once he had set type in this very press. He belonged to my father’s time. He lived on his small plot of land and his son’s earnings, and from old attachment he sometimes came to look in on the press.

I showed him the staircase.

“Hira Kaka, were there always only seven?”

At first he did not understand the question. Then he looked down.

“Seven.”

“Are you certain?”

“I have walked these steps for forty years. Seven.”

I said, “I seem to remember eight when I was a boy.”

Hiralal laughed. "You boys used to make up stories about the eighth one."

Something inside me shivered.

"What story?"

He looked at me. "Have you forgotten? You used to tell the younger boys that after the seventh, an eighth step appears in the dark."

I kept staring at the chalked number seven.

With that sentence, a night from very long ago opened in my mind.

I had been sixteen then. My father ran the press. My maternal cousin Gopal had come to stay with us for two months. He was an average student, but quick with his hands. He had learnt to lift the cases of lead type, count paper, and spread out printed sheets.

Gopal was not afraid of the dark. If anything, he was braver than I was.

That irritated something small inside me.

Only later does one understand how trivial the causes of childhood jealousy can be. My father praised Gopal's work: "The boy learns as soon as he sees a hand do it." It seemed to me that someone was proving himself better than I was inside my own house.

One night there was a large wedding job. The size-twelve lead type was stored downstairs. My father told Gopal to bring up two cases. I went with him carrying the lantern.

At the bottom, Gopal lifted one case in each hand. I took the lantern and started climbing ahead of him. On the fourth step, some foolish impulse seized me. I turned the wick down. The light became very dim.

Gopal said, "Raise it. The type will spill."

I said, "Are you frightened?"

He laughed. "You are."

The answer stung.

I put the lantern out completely.

The basement sank into absolute darkness.

Gopal stopped. He had heavy cases in both hands. He said, "Naval, give me light."

I stood on the upper steps laughing.

Then I said, "There is an eighth after the seventh. Mind your foot there."

It was a lie I had told younger boys before—the eighth step that appeared only in darkness.

Gopal became serious. He kept climbing slowly.

Five.

Six.

Seven.

The moment he passed the seventh, he had already reached the level floor above. But my words were in his mind. Carrying the heavy cases, he lifted one more high step—a step under which a stair was supposed to be, but was not.

His body tipped backward.

Both cases fell clattering down the steps. Gopal's left wrist struck the corner of the doorway.

He did not scream loudly. He simply sat down.

I lit the lantern.

Lead letters were scattered all over the stairs. Gopal was holding his wrist. There were tears in his eyes, but he did not cry.

My father came running. The wrist had swollen. Gopal was taken to the vaidya. The bone was not broken, but the sprain was severe. For nearly twenty days he could not work in the press.

No one ever learnt that I had deliberately put out the lantern or that I had invented the eighth step.

Gopal did not tell anyone either.

Once I asked him, "Why did you not tell them?"

Eating with his right hand, he said, "What would I have said? That you did something stupid?"

He even laughed.

Perhaps that laugh saved me. Slowly the incident turned into an ordinary accident. Years passed. Gopal finished his studies and went away to other work. In my memory the swelling of his wrist faded.

But the words "eighth step" never went anywhere.

That night, while we were closing the press, Sudhir said, "Tonight I will check the water line."

I answered at once, "No. I will go."

He shrugged and went home.

I locked the rear door alone. The electricity was on. There was no need for the lantern this time. A bulb burned above the staircase, and another small light below. All seven steps were clearly visible.

I placed my foot on the first.

The chalked numbers had half rubbed away.

One.

Two.

Three.

Four.

Five.

Six.

Seven.

I reached the bottom.

No sound came.

I checked the water-line valve. Then I looked up. Empty steps. White light. No shadow.

A faint laugh rose in my mind. Darkness, rain, an old memory—human beings add their own fear to such things.

I turned and was picking up the cloth kept beside the pipe when, behind me, there came a thak.

Perfectly clear.

My hand stopped.

This time the sound seemed to come from the old wooden brace beside the right edge of the seventh step.

The next morning I called Shyamkant, the son of Ramlakhan the carpenter. He climbed and descended the staircase again and again. Nothing happened under his weight. Then I went down.

As soon as I passed the seventh step—thak.

Shyamkant crouched below and felt the wooden brace. In the right corner of the seventh step, an old iron spike had worked half loose. When my weight came down, the wood compressed slightly; a moment after my foot left it, the brace returned to its position and the spike struck the brick.

He smiled. “We found the eighth step.”

I did not laugh.

Shyamkant removed the spike, fitted a new one, and tightened the wooden brace. I went down five times to test it. After the seventh step there was no thak.

The extra sound was never heard again.

The cause was known now—wood, an iron spike, weight, and a moment’s delay.

But knowing the cause did not erase the memory.

Sometimes, after the machine has stopped, a piece of wood gives a sound and my ears pause for an instant. Sometimes the upper door moves in the wind and I remember the eighth step. But now I do not run to investigate.

One thing has changed.

At night, when I descend to the basement, I have stopped counting the steps.

Even after my foot lands on the seventh, my body sometimes pauses for a moment, as though some old counting inside me has not yet finished.

Then I place my foot firmly on the level floor, look toward the light, and go on with my work without counting.

STORY 76

Autobiography of the File

✦ ✦ ✦

I was not born on a writer's desk. I was born in the Copy Section of the Biraul Block Office, between two sheets of red cardboard, when twenty-seven people of Piprahi Tola put their thumb impressions and signatures on a petition.

The petition was brief. The old wooden footbridge over the irrigation channel had broken. In the rains, children going to school, people carrying milk to the market, and labourers heading for the fields had to wade through knee-deep water. All they asked for was two strong bamboo poles and four planks.

In the beginning I had seven pages.

The first was the petition. The second carried twenty-seven names. The third held the mukhiya's recommendation. On the fourth were two photographs of the broken bridge. The fifth contained a mason's estimate. The sixth gave the width of the channel. And the seventh was a red slip marked: "Urgent."

At that time I found the word "Urgent" very impressive.

Later I learnt that in a government file the word is often like the name printed at the top of a wedding invitation: conspicuous above everyone else, but with no separate place reserved for it when the meal is served.

At the first desk sat Junior Clerk Bhola Jha.

One leg of his desk was shorter than the others; beneath it lay the torn cover of an old register as a prop.

He read me, nodded, and wrote: "The matter appears to pertain to the Rural Works Section."

I liked the word "appears."

It was the kind of word by which a person could accept a thing without quite admitting it, and reject it without quite denying it.

I reached the second desk.

That desk was two fingers higher than the first.

Assistant Clerk Shivkant Babu sat there.

He seemed to like Bhola Jha's blue ink more than my seven pages.

He wrote: "The irrigation channel may fall under the Irrigation Department. Verification of ownership required."

I was sent to the third desk.

The third desk had a sheet of glass over it.

The babu there did not place tea on top of me; a separate circular stain had already been reserved for his glass.

He called for a map of the channel.

When the map arrived, the channel was not on it at all.

The reason was simple: when the map had been made, the place where the channel now ran had still been a field.

Then arose the question: if the channel did not exist on the map, which department should repair the bridge built over it?

In the search for an answer, my pages grew from seven to thirteen.

For the first time my thread was replaced with a thicker one.

I was pleased.

I thought becoming larger meant making progress.

A week later I reached the desk of the Block Engineer.

He opened me and looked at the first photograph.

Two children stood beside the channel. One held his slippers in his hand; the other was scraping mud with his foot.

The engineer said, "This is not a bridge. It is a temporary crossing."

The land surveyor sitting beside him said, "How can a temporary structure receive permanent repairs?"

Both laughed.

It was then that I first understood the hierarchy of human beings.

A question travelling from below to above is called serious.

An answer travelling from above to below is called an order.

And a matter moving round and round on the same desk is called deliberation.

The engineer wrote: "Site inspection required."

I returned to Bhola Jha's desk, because the letter for the site inspection had to issue from there.

Seeing me, Bhola said, "You again?"

Had I been allowed to speak, I would have said: "Not I. It is everything you people have written that has come back."

But a file has no right to speak.

Its only right is to grow more pages.

A date was fixed for inspection.

It rained that day.

A second date was fixed.

The jeep had gone elsewhere on official work.

On the third date the engineer fell ill.

By the fourth date the water in the channel had gone down.

When the inspection team finally arrived, the children were crossing easily, hitching their clothes above the shallow water.

The report stated: “Passage currently possible; difficulty likely during the rains.”

That sentence made me want to laugh.

When the difficulty existed, inspection had not been possible.

When inspection became possible, the difficulty could no longer be seen.

Human intelligence on paper is highly disciplined by the weather.

Meanwhile, Subhadra Devi of Piprahi came to the office three times.

The first time she asked Bhola Jha, “What happened to our bridge?”

Bhola said, “The file has gone up.”

The second time Shivkant Babu said, “The file is with the engineer.”

The third time the engineer’s clerk said, “The file has gone down again.”

Subhadra Devi looked up at the sky and said, “The bridge is in the same place. Why does the file keep going up and down?”

No one answered.

I knew the answer.

Human beings measure the height of their posts by the journey of paper.

Two months later I went to the Subdivisional Office.

The peon carrying me held me tight against his chest on the bus.

For the first time I saw beyond the walls of the block office.

At the subdivision I was welcomed by a new page: “The financial limit applicable to the matter is unclear.”

My estimated cost was only three thousand eight hundred rupees, yet clarification of the financial limit required opinions from two branches.

The Accounts Section circled passages in me with red pencil.

The Planning Section added a green slip.

The Rural Works Section added a yellow one.

My red cover began to look too small for what I had become.

I now had thirty-four pages.

To find the original petition, half my body had to be turned over.

One day an Assistant Officer read only the slip on top without opening me and wrote: “Guidance of the higher authority required.”

I reached the District Office.

There the desks were much wider, the chairs much more heavily cushioned, and the hands that touched me much fewer.

One employee opened me, another marked me, a third tied me shut again.

The officer's pen gave me only thirteen words: "The matter shall be disposed of at the local level in accordance with rules."

I returned to the subdivision, then the block office, then the engineer, then Bhola Jha.

My journey was circular, but every note said "forwarded."

I came to understand that word in my own way: return to the very place from which you started, but because you touched several desks on the way, let each of them believe you have moved forward.

By the next rainy season, the people of Piprahi had stopped waiting.

They cut two thick palm trunks and laid them across the channel, tied bamboo over them, and packed earth at both ends.

The children began going to school again without removing their slippers.

Subhadra Devi contributed old bamboo from her house.

Parsu Yadav, who sold milk, gave rope.

Vinod the mason worked for two days without taking wages.

News of this reached me in the form of a new photograph.

The land surveyor who went for site verification attached it and wrote: "Temporary crossing presently available."

I thought perhaps the matter would now be considered finished.

But in a human office, whatever becomes complete on the ground often becomes a new question on paper.

The Accounts Section asked: "Under which budget head was the said temporary structure constructed?"

The Panchayat replied: "Community contribution."

Then came the second question: "If passage is available through community contribution, what is the immediate necessity for government expenditure?"

Inside me, the first page of the original petition seemed to tremble faintly.

That page said that in heavy rain the bamboo was washed away, and that the children needed a permanent bridge.

But by then, before anyone could reach the first page, they had to pass through thirty-seven notes, nine opinions, five inspection slips, and two reports.

Subhadra Devi came again.

This time she brought with her the boy who had stood in the first photograph holding his slippers.

He had grown tall now and was studying in Class Eight.

Seeing his old photograph on my open page, he laughed.

"Is that me?"

Bhola Jha said, "Yes. This file is still moving because of you."

The boy asked, “But now I cross without taking off my slippers.”

Bhola smiled. “Files take time.”

Again I wanted to laugh.

Time did not happen to me.

Wherever I was placed, I simply lay there.

Time happened to human beings—waiting for one another’s signatures, sliding their own responsibility into the shadow of the next desk.

Eventually I had fifty-nine pages. A new decision arrived: instead of building a permanent bridge, there would be a safety inspection of the temporary structure. The engineer visited the site. The palm trunks were solid, and the bamboo had recently been replaced. He wrote: “No immediate danger; reinspection advisable before the next rainy season.”

After that sentence, no desk sent me upward again. I was placed in an iron cupboard in the record room. A number was painted on my spine in white ink. Around me lay files concerning land disputes, old-age assistance, a broken hand pump, and warehouse rent. Each had its own journey. At night, when the office fell silent, dust slowly settled over us.

A few months later Bhola Jha opened the cupboard while looking for another file. He saw me and pulled me out. My thread had loosened, so he opened me to retie it. The first page appeared before him—the twenty-seven names, the broken bridge, the photograph of the two children. For some time Bhola looked at the picture. Then he read the last page: “Reinspection advisable before the next rainy season.” Whether he laughed or sighed, I could not tell.

Just then a new peon appeared at the doorway. In his hand was a thin new file. On its cover was written: “Piprahi Tola—petition regarding repair of the temporary crossing constructed through community contribution.”

Bhola Jha placed the new file on top of me. It was very light—only five pages. I remembered my own childhood of seven pages. I could tell it nothing. I only thought this much: human beings create hierarchies so that paper may climb upward; paper travels so that responsibility may descend downward. In between, the channel keeps flowing with its own water.

STORY 77

Boundary

✦ ✦ ✦

In Sirkharia village of Rahika Block, a boundary had once meant only the ridge between fields. Where Ramlochan Yadav's paddy ended, Nandlal Mahato's arhar began. The bamboo screen around a courtyard, the edge of a pond, the platform of a well—each had its own visible marker. But the boundary that descended into the middle of the village one Monday morning had no ridge, stake, colour, or rope.

A table was placed beneath the neem tree at the crossroads. On it were two registers, slips in three colours, and a board that read: "Administrative Boundary Assistance Point." Beneath that, in smaller letters: "Area A / Area B."

Devnarayan Mahato was cycling toward the market with a milk can tied to his bicycle. Madan Mishra, the clerk at the table, raised a hand and stopped him.

"Where are you going?"

"To the milk cooperative."

"That is in Area B."

"What difference does that make?"

"You are coming from Area A. You need a transit slip."

Devnarayan looked at both sides of the road. There was no line anywhere.

"Where is the boundary?"

Madan Mishra placed a thumb on the map spread over the table. "From this point to this point."

"On the ground?"

"It has not yet been marked on the ground."

"Then when did I cross it?"

Madan Mishra studied the map again. "From behind the neem tree."

Devnarayan looked back. His house stood on one side of that very neem tree, the milk cooperative on the other. Between them ran the road he had crossed several times a day since childhood.

The rules on the first day were described as simple. An adult travelling from Area A to Area B would have his name, father's or husband's name, house number, and purpose of journey entered, and would receive a yellow slip. On returning, the slip would be surrendered. By evening a queue had formed beneath the neem tree. Someone was going to buy fertiliser, someone medicine, someone to the flour mill, someone to his maternal uncle's house.

Devnarayan's difficulty was that his own house lay in both colours on the map. The main door was in Area A, the kitchen in Area A, but the rear courtyard,

cowshed, and handpump were in Area B. To milk the cow in the morning he had to carry a slip inside his own house.

His wife Malti laughed the first time. “Permission from outside even to live in one’s own house?”

“Not to live. To cross.”

“Show me the boundary.”

Devnarayan said nothing.

On Tuesday a new clarification arrived. Local ration-card holders were exempted from slips for essential work. The villagers were pleased. But in the afternoon another notice came: the exemption applied only when the essential work was within one’s own area. The first rule still applied when the boundary was crossed.

On Wednesday schoolchildren were exempted. Devnarayan’s daughter Sarita attended the higher secondary school in Area B and left without a slip. But her younger brother Manoj’s school was in Area A while his bookshop was in Area B. Madan Mishra gave him a slip for buying books, but wrote on it: “School purpose, one time.”

“If I need another book tomorrow?” Manoj asked.

“Tomorrow’s rule will be seen tomorrow,” Madan Mishra said.

On Thursday a separate arrangement was introduced for goods. Milk, paddy, straw, bamboo, bricks, and vegetables were classified as “goods transit.” Devnarayan filled a green slip for the milk can. His own slip was yellow; the milk’s was green.

“The bicycle?” he asked.

Madan Mishra scratched his head. “The bicycle travels with the person.”

“The can?”

“Goods.”

“And the milk?”

“Inside the can.”

“The cow?”

Before answering, Madan Mishra turned a page of the register. “Separate instructions for livestock have not yet arrived.”

That evening a calf broke loose from the cowshed and ran across the road. Malti ran after it. The assistant seated beneath the neem tree rose to stop her, but by then the calf had already crossed from Area B back into Area A.

Panting, Malti said, “Make a slip for it.”

The assistant did not laugh. “We will ask about livestock tomorrow.”

On Friday the livestock rule actually arrived. Between six and eight in the morning and five and seven in the evening, movement would be allowed without a slip. At other times the owner’s name would be entered.

Hearing the order, Malti said, “Will the cow look at the clock?”

This time Devnarayan laughed, but the laughter stopped when he reached the neem tree.

Three new employees had arrived there—an inspection team from the district. The map was opened. The inspector expressed a desire to see the boundary.

Madan Mishra stood at one point on the road and said, “Approximately here.”

“Why approximately?”

“The map uses the ‘old western channel’ as its reference.”

The inspector looked around. “Where is the channel?”

Durganand Jha, an elderly villager, was called. He said that years ago rainwater had flowed along the left side of the road. Ramlochan Yadav said, “No, it was on the right.” Nandlal Mahato said that before the road was widened, the channel had run down the middle.

The inspector wrote down all three statements and continued staring at the line on the map.

Meanwhile Sarita returned from school and reached the neem tree. Her mathematics exercise book was in her hand. She saw her father and stopped.

“Babuji, which slip today?”

“None for you.”

“Yesterday Teacher said that after Saturday’s holiday a new identity slip will be made.”

The inspector heard her. “Has anyone stopped the children?”

“No,” Madan Mishra said. “The rules keep changing.”

The inspector frowned. “Rules do not change; they become clearer.”

Madan Mishra immediately wrote the substance of that sentence into the register.

On Saturday a special provision arrived for “joint households.” Any house lying on the boundary could apply for a one-month joint-movement pass. Devnarayan was the first to apply.

The form asked: “In which area is the applicant’s principal residence?” He wrote: Area A. The second question: “Livestock/storage in which area?” He wrote: Area B. Third: “Usual family entrance?” Area A. Fourth: “Water source?” Area B.

The fifth asked: “Latrine?” Devnarayan stopped his pen. It had been built near the boundary, but the map showed no mark for it.

“What should I write in this box?” he asked Madan Mishra.

“It will be decided after site verification.”

“Then the pass?”

“After verification.”

“When the officer goes to the house for verification, will he cross the boundary?”

Madan Mishra looked at Devnarayan for a few moments, then said quietly, “The inspection team will be on official duty.”

“Their slip?”

Madan Mishra did not answer.

On Monday the site-verification team arrived: an amin, a Panchayat worker, and an assistant. The amin carried a measuring tape, but before measuring could begin another problem arose—the exact position of the old western channel could not be established.

Devnarayan showed them the rear courtyard. The ground was slightly lower in one corner. Durganand Jha said, “The channel must have been here.” Ramlochan called from outside, “No. That is a rainwater hollow.”

The amin measured twice, then rolled up the tape. “Classification of the joint household is difficult without permanent boundary demarcation.”

The Panchayat worker asked, “Then what for now?”

The amin said, “Temporarily, recognise the existing practice.”

“What is the existing practice?”

Everyone looked at Devnarayan.

Devnarayan said, “In the morning I go to the cowshed, then carry the milk across the neem tree to the cooperative. At noon I go to the field. In the evening I return to the cowshed. Malti moves between both sides of the courtyard all day. The children cross according to the school and the shops.”

The amin wrote in the register: “Movement customary according to local practice.”

The assistant asked, “Is this to be treated as permission?”

The amin said, “This is a fact.”

“The rule?”

“Seek clarification from above.”

This time Madan Mishra did not smile either.

Three days later a new order came from the Block Office. The boundary remained where it was, but “ordinary activities of daily life” were exempted from slips. Which activity counted as ordinary would be decided by the Assistance Point.

The queue beneath the neem tree became shorter. Milk, school, water, livestock, and fields were all treated as ordinary. But whether attending a wedding was ordinary or special was debated for two hours. One man wanted to go to a feast at his sister’s house; Madan Mishra finally issued a yellow slip.

Devnarayan now filled fewer slips. But the old yellow, green, and blue slips remained tied together with thread on a nail in his house. Malti wanted to throw them away. He said, “Keep them for now. The rules may become clearer again.”

The rains came. Water dripped from the neem leaves. The table at the Assistance Point was moved under the veranda. Water flowed along the road. No one could say where the old western channel had been; the new water found the low ground and flowed where it would.

One evening Devnarayan was returning home with the empty milk can. Madan Mishra sat alone beneath the neem tree, drying the pages of the register. Out of habit, Devnarayan slowed down.

“Slip?”

Madan Mishra raised his head. He thought for a moment, then said, “Ordinary today.”

Devnarayan crossed the road and walked toward his house. Beneath his feet, the water kept flowing between the two areas without stopping.

STORY 78

The Verandah Bulb

✦ ✦ ✦

In the Benta neighbourhood of Darbhanga, the verandah of Anima Jha's house opened toward the road. An old iron grille, a wooden bench, a sewing machine set against the wall, and a milky-white bulb hanging overhead—these few things gave the verandah its character. By day vegetables were sorted there, clothes were dried, and the children's shoes lay scattered about; when evening fell, Anima would open the cover of the machine and sit down in that same place.

It was half past nine that night. Inside the house Madhukant was adding up the next day's accounts. He had a small grocery shop where he spent the day selling oil, lentils, soap, and spices. Their son Nachiket was in the next room preparing for a technical entrance examination. Their daughter Ragini had finished putting away the kitchen utensils and gone to study. On the verandah Anima was shortening the sleeve of their neighbour Usha's blouse.

"I need it tomorrow morning, Didi," Usha had said that evening when she left the blouse. "I have to go to a wedding. Just shorten these sleeves by two fingers."

Out of habit Anima had said, "Leave it here." There had been no discussion of payment. For years people in the neighbourhood had been leaving small alterations with her. Someone's salwar was loose, someone's petticoat torn, someone's child's kurta too long. Anima kept doing them. Sometimes people brought a spool of thread, sometimes they did not. She herself had never asked for an account.

As she threaded the needle again, the bulb flickered twice. Anima looked up. The yellowish light brightened for a moment, then dimmed.

"Ragini," she called toward the inside, "did you tell Babu about this bulb?"

A voice came from within. "I did. Babu said he would bring one tomorrow."

Madhukant heard too. "I forgot while closing the shop. Remind me in the morning."

Anima started the machine again. She had not made even two stitches when the bulb blinked once and went out. The verandah fell completely dark. The light coming from the inner room grew thin by the time it reached the grille. It was difficult to see the needle of the machine.

Anima took her foot off the pedal.

"Is there a candle?" Madhukant asked from inside.

"There may be one in the kitchen."

"Then leave it for today. Do it in the morning."

Anima did not answer. She had promised to return the blouse in the morning. She began feeling under the bench for the small box where extra thread, buttons, measuring tape, and needles were kept. Her hand found two empty spools, then an old measuring tape. No bulb.

Ragini came outside holding a torch. “Ma, take this.”

“Your studies?”

“The battery will not die in ten minutes.”

Ragini held the beam over the machine. Anima began sewing again, but the light would not stay fixed in one place. Her daughter kept changing hands. After five minutes Anima stopped the machine.

“Go and study. I will finish it in the morning.”

When Ragini went back inside, the verandah was dark again. Light from the electric pole on the road cast the square shadow of the grille onto the wall. Anima remained seated in front of the machine. She felt no hurry to go inside.

In that darkness the shape of the machine was not very clear, but her hands knew every part of it. Her mother had given her this machine when she married. Before marriage, Anima had spent two years in Madhubani learning sewing. Her mother had said, “You will do household work anyway, but keep a skill of your own in your hands.”

During the first five or seven years of marriage, Anima had earned a little by sewing clothes for people in the neighbourhood. Then Nachiket was small, her mother-in-law fell ill, and the household work increased. The cover of the machine began to remain closed for months at a time.

After her mother-in-law died, people slowly began bringing clothes again. Even then Anima had thought—this time I will make it regular. She would put up a wooden sign on the verandah, write down fixed hours, keep a separate account for thread and buttons. But that year the roof of the house needed repair. The next year came Nachiket’s examination. Then Ragini had a long fever. Then Madhukant changed shops. Saying “after this time” again and again, seven years passed.

Her sewing had not stopped in the meantime; only it had never acquired the name of work. Clothes for the family, clothes for relatives, small alterations for neighbours—everything kept coming. Asking for payment embarrassed her. When someone voluntarily gave ten or twenty rupees, she put the money in the thread box. Sometimes she bought needles with it, sometimes coriander and chillies for the house.

Sitting in the darkness, she remembered something from that afternoon. Before leaving the blouse, Usha had been talking about her younger sister-in-law.

“She had the sleeves shortened in the market,” Usha had said. “They charged eighty rupees. I told her Anima Didi would do it.”

Anima had laughed then. The conversation had ended there. Now, in the dark, that figure—eighty rupees—returned to her mind. Shortening sleeves took

ten minutes. The thread was hers. The machine was hers. The electricity was from her house. The time was hers.

It was not that she had never understood this arithmetic before. She had. But after doing the calculation she always placed some other thought beside it—Usha is a neighbour; Kusum's husband knows Madhukant; it is a child's garment; how can I ask money for such a small job? Each reason seemed right on its own. Put together, all those reasons left her entire work without a name.

From inside Madhukant called, "Anima, are you not coming to sleep?"

"I am coming."

She stood up but did not cover the machine. Turning the needle wheel by hand, she raised the needle and took out the blouse, folding it carefully. Just then two young women passed outside the grille. Both carried bundles of cloth. One was saying to the other, "Come tomorrow at three. Madam will teach us how to take measurements."

Their voices moved away.

Anima stood by the grille. Three lanes behind the neighbourhood, a woman taught sewing. Two years earlier Ragini had said that she too would learn during the holidays. Anima had replied, "Learn from me." But no time was ever fixed. The holidays passed.

The thought did not wound her. It simply raised a straightforward question: if no time is fixed for something, when will it ever happen?

She went inside. Madhukant was closing the account book.

"Bring a bulb tomorrow," Anima said.

"Yes, first thing in the morning."

"Bring two. One extra."

Madhukant looked at her. "All right."

Anima stood there for a few moments, then said, "And I need a wooden board."

"What board?"

"To put up on the verandah."

"Why?"

"I will write the sewing hours on it."

Madhukant's hand stopped over the account book. "Hours?"

"Three in the afternoon to six in the evening. Whoever brings clothes should come in that time."

"All right," Madhukant said easily. Then, after thinking for a moment, he added, "Will it fit with the housework?"

Earlier, to a question like that, Anima would have said—let us see, if there is time. This time she opened the day inside her mind. Morning cooking, Nachiket's meal, the tiffin for Madhukant's shop, the afternoon dishes, evening

tea. Not every task had to be done by the same pair of hands. Ragini could make the evening tea. Nachiket could bring milk from the market.

"It will," Anima said. "Some work will have to be shared."

Madhukant took a little time before answering. Then he said, "I will tell Ragini. Nachiket can go to the market too."

That was all. No announcement. No argument. Anima went to sleep, but before sleep came, for the first time she could see the shape of her decision in three hours of the day—three to six. For years she had needed "sometime." Now she had three numbers.

Usha came very early the next morning. Anima had not yet finished the blouse.

She said plainly, "Sit for ten minutes. The bulb went out last night."

Usha sat on the bench. On his way to the market, Madhukant had left two bulbs and a narrow wooden board. Nachiket set up a ladder and screwed in the new bulb. It was not particularly needed in daylight, but Anima pressed the switch to test it. Milky-white light fell over the machine.

She finished Usha's blouse. Usha tried it on and was pleased.

"How much should I give?" she asked naturally.

Earlier Anima would have answered such a question with, "Leave it." This time she added up the thread and the time in her mind.

"Fifty rupees."

Without surprise, Usha handed her a fifty-rupee note. "It came out better than the market one. And could you make this neckline a little tighter too?"

Taking the note, Anima said, "Yes. But bring it after three in the evening."

"Why, are you going somewhere?"

"No. From now on my sewing hours will be three to six."

Usha looked at her for a moment, then smiled. "Then I will come at three."

After Usha left, Anima did not put the note into the thread box. She took out an old exercise book and wrote the date on the first page: "Sleeves shortened—50." Under it she wrote five rupees as the cost of thread. As she wrote, her handwriting looked slightly awkward to her; after so long, she was keeping a separate account of her sewing.

When Ragini returned from college in the afternoon, the wooden board was lying on the verandah.

"What should I write on this?" she asked.

Anima said, "Write clearly: 'Sewing and Alterations. Hours: Three to Six.' That is all."

"No prices?"

"I will tell the price after seeing the work."

Ragini began painting the letters in black. Nachiket passed by, read the board, and laughed. “Ma’s shop!”

Anima kept threading the machine. “Not a shop. Working hours.”

There were still twenty minutes before three. The new bulb on the verandah was off; daylight was enough. The old dead bulb lay in one corner of the bench. Ragini picked it up to throw it away.

Anima looked at the dead bulb for a moment and said, “Throw it.”

Ragini went toward the rubbish bin outside. Anima lifted the wooden board. The paint was still a little wet. She rested the board inside the grille so that the air could reach it.

At three o’clock, she would hang it up.

STORY 79

The Endless Register

✦ ✦ ✦

In the southern quarter of Saurath, two houses beyond an old mango tree, Vachaspati Jha had a small workroom. From outside it looked like no remarkable place—earth-coloured walls, two wooden cupboards, a low cot, and a low table against the wall. Yet because of the panji books wrapped in red cloth and kept on the table, people stepped more softly when they entered the room.

Vachaspati had learned to read the panjis from his father. His father used to say, “Reading the names is easy. Reading the blank spaces between the names is difficult.” As a child Vachaspati had not understood this. Now, at fifty-two, when people came during the marriage season to check genealogical lines, trace old relationships, and have certified copies made, he understood that a panji carried not only the weight of written lines, but of missing lines as well.

That year, continuous rain through Sawan had made the roof of the old storeroom leak. The edges of five panji volumes had become wet, and some pages had stuck together. Members of the local conservation committee asked Vachaspati to prepare a clean copy of whatever could still be read. He would be paid by the page. For the household accounts, the work was not insignificant. His wife, Sharda, was already adding and subtracting the costs of medicine, oil, grain, and their little granddaughter’s school fees.

For three days Vachaspati did nothing but dry the pages. To press wet paper meant lifting the letters off with it. He placed thin cotton cloth between pages, raised corners with slender bamboo tweezers, and carried the books indoors whenever the sunlight grew harsh. On the fourth day one thick panji opened. The year written on its outer strip was almost erased, but the writing inside was clear.

The first pages followed the familiar pattern—lineage, branch, village, father, son, marriage link. Vachaspati recognised some names from memory. Beside some were small marks his father used to point out in older copies. He went on making the copy. In his mind he counted the payment: if he finished this many pages, it would cover two months of oil and salt for the household.

Near midday, his hand stopped on one page.

That page contained his own branch of the lineage.

Grandfather, father, Vachaspati—the three names appeared in the correct order. Beneath Vachaspati was the name of his son, Nachiketa. That was not impossible; the entry could have been made sometime after Nachiketa’s birth. But beneath Nachiketa was another name: “Ishan.”

Nachiketa had no child. He had married three years earlier, and his wife Mrinal was now pregnant. No name had yet been settled upon in the household.

Vachaspati brought the page close to his nose. The smell of the ink did not reveal its age. The lettering resembled the same hand that had written the lines above. After Ishan came three more names—“Vedika,” “Neel,” “Archis.” After that, the branch divided in two directions.

He closed the page again.

“Won’t you eat?” Sharda asked from the doorway.

“Not now. A little later.”

“You’ve been sitting since morning.”

“One page is stuck.”

Sharda laughed. “Is the page stuck, or are you?”

Vachaspati did not answer.

In the afternoon he opened the panji again. This time he left his own branch and looked three pages farther ahead. There was the line of a family from Belahi. Vachaspati knew the names up to the present generation because he had checked that household’s marriage link the previous year. But beneath the current names were five more names. Beside one of them was written the name of a village with which that family had no connection at present.

For the first time Vachaspati felt not fear but anger. Someone had inserted later writing into an old book—that was his first conclusion. He took a magnifying glass and examined the ink. The stroke, pressure, the slant of the letters—all matched the older lines. The yellowing of the paper had settled over the writing in exactly the same way.

That evening Nachiketa returned from his shop. He sold bicycle parts, and after a day’s fatigue went straight into the courtyard to wash his hands and face. Vachaspati could have called him. He could have uttered the name “Ishan” just once and asked, “Do you like this name?” But he remained silent.

At night Mrinal was talking with Sharda about measurements for the baby’s clothes. She said, “We’ll make the list of names later. First let us decide whether Dadi’s suggestions will prevail or Babuji’s.”

Sharda burst out laughing. The glass in Vachaspati’s hand became still.

The next day he copied only up to the present from the old panji. He left out the lines containing future names. But the thought that the copy for the committee would remain incomplete unsettled him. The rule of the work was: copy whatever can be read; omit nothing for your own convenience.

At midday a visitor came. His name was Sudhanshu Thakur. He had come to have his daughter’s marriage-line genealogy checked. Vachaspati matched the older entries. The work was ordinary. At the end Sudhanshu said softly, “They say a very old panji has come into your hands. How many generations of names does it contain?”

Vachaspati started. “As many as are written.”

“And those ahead?”

"What do you mean, ahead?"

Sudhanshu smiled. "Does news take long to fly through a village?"

Vachaspati understood that some young man from the committee who had helped open the wet volumes must have seen something.

"A panji is an account of relationships that have already taken place," Vachaspati said.

"But what if the names ahead are truly written there?"

"Then they are names. Not events."

Sudhanshu remained silent for a few moments. Then he asked, "May I see the names ahead in my own family?"

For the first time Vachaspati answered plainly, "No."

After that one word, an unusual silence filled the room. Sudhanshu was dissatisfied, but he did not argue. He paid the fee and left.

All day Vachaspati thought about his answer. It seemed to him that perhaps he was not protecting the book, but protecting his own fear. If people saw names from the future, they would build stories around them. Marriages would be arranged, marriages would be broken, unborn children would be named in advance, families would treat a future line as a command governing present decisions. A few letters could become causes in people's lives.

That evening he tried an experiment. The first future name written in the Belahi branch was "Raghav." On a separate sheet he wrote only the name—Raghav. Then he remembered three families in the village where children had been given that name within the past five years. A name by itself was not the future. It became the future only when people attached it to the person they thought it belonged to.

But the name "Ishan" in his own branch would not leave him.

Three weeks later Mrinal gave birth to a son. Joyful bustle filled the household. Nachiketa returned from the hospital and came into his father's room. His eyes were red from a night without sleep, but the happiness in his voice could not be hidden.

"Have you thought of a name?" Vachaspati asked.

"Mrinal says let the child come home first. Then we'll all think together."

"Anything in your own mind?"

Nachiketa laughed. "For now we are just calling him Chhotu."

For the first time Vachaspati breathed easily. The name "Ishan" in the book was still only in the book.

That night he opened the panji. Ishan, Vedika, Neel, Archis—all the names were exactly as before. No letter had increased or disappeared. The page was ordinary. Its endlessness lay not in the number of pages but in people's hunger to

give them meaning—the thought came to him, but he did not write it down as a sentence.

The next morning, while completing the copy for the conservation committee, he copied the future lines too, but above them he added a note: “The date and period of the entries beyond this point are unverified; they are not valid as evidence for present decisions.”

A young man from the committee asked, “Then are all these wrong?”

Vachaspati said, “I did not say that.”

“Then they are right?”

“I cannot say that either, not yet.”

The young man kept looking at his face.

Vachaspati closed the panji. “Why this hurry to call something right or wrong when it has not even happened yet?”

When he returned home, Sharda raised the question of the baby’s name. Dadi’s list had Govind, Nachiketa’s had Arya, and Mrinal’s list had two other names. In the end everyone looked at Vachaspati.

“Your suggestion?” Nachiketa asked.

“Ishan” rose clearly in Vachaspati’s mind. He saw the panji page, the ink, the slant of the old handwriting. Then he looked at the newborn’s fist, which was complete even without any name.

“Let us watch him for a few days first,” he said. “We can name him later.”

In the courtyard everyone began repeating their suggestions again. Vachaspati quietly went into his room. He wrapped the panji in red cloth and placed it in the cupboard. He made no attempt to look for the book’s last page. For now it was enough to know this much: the next name might already be written, but the next life had not yet been written.

STORY 80

The Library of Mithila

✦ ✦ ✦

For three days in Darbhanga's old book market, Ishan Mishra had been searching for the same title—North Mithila's Ponds and Village Memories. The title belonged to his own proposed book, but where had the book been written yet? For seven months he had travelled from district to district, taking down the accounts of ponds, ahars, old ghats, boatmen, fishers, potters, and cultivators. The publisher wanted the manuscript by Paush. Half of the advance had already gone into household expenses, and the remaining half was dissolving into travel fares, copies, and photocopies of old papers.

Then an elderly bookseller—no, seller of pothis—Binod Chaudhary, pointed him toward the end of a narrow lane and said, "What you are looking for may perhaps be found there."

There was no signboard at the end of the lane. Only a wooden door on which someone had written in ink: "The Library of Mithila." The letters were neither very old nor entirely new. Ishan pushed the door open.

Inside there was no smell of dust, but rather of dried paper, hemp cord, and a faint trace of mustard oil. Cupboards lined the walls, and behind the cupboards were more cupboards. In the middle, a thin old man was wiping the edges of books with a cloth.

"Membership?" Ishan asked. Without raising his head, the old man said, "There is no membership here. There are questions." Ishan laughed. "Then the question is this—I need some material on the ponds of North Mithila and the memories of its villages." For the first time the old man looked at him. "Material, not books?" "Both." "How much?" "As much as is useful." An expression came over the old man's face as though the question itself were not quite right. He rang no bell and opened no register. He merely pointed with his right hand toward a corridor at the back. "Come."

At the first turn was written "Ponds." At the second, "Memory." At the third, Ishan rubbed his eyes. On the cupboard in front of him was written the title he himself had proposed—North Mithila's Ponds and Village Memories. Beneath it were not one but hundreds of volumes. Some thick, some thin, some bound in red, some in black, some wrapped in hemp cloth.

"This is impossible," Ishan said. "The meaning of the word possible is different here from what it is outside," the old man replied.

Ishan opened the first book. Author: Ishan Mishra. Publication year: the following year. The first chapter began with the same village he had visited two months earlier. The first five lines matched his notes. The sixth line was entirely

unfamiliar: the western ghat of the pond had been built in the 1950s by a widow who had sold her jewellery. Nothing like this was in Ishan's notes.

He opened a second volume. The same chapter, the same village, but the builder of the western ghat was a wealthy moneylender. In a third, the ghat had never been completed at all. In a fourth, the pond itself was declared imaginary. In a fifth, the same pond was described as the centre of a state archive. All the writing was smooth, plausible, and furnished with references.

Ishan's palms grew damp. "Which of these is true?" The old man shrugged. "Your question is small again." "Small?" "Ask instead—what is the basis by which you recognise truth?"

Ishan grew irritated. He needed sources, not riddles. Time was short. Two days earlier the publisher had sent a message: "Send the final draft soon." At home his wife Neelima had told him to look at the creditors' accounts before extending this journey again. He had no leisure for the library's philosophical games.

He picked up one volume and placed it in front of the old man. "Here there is a reference—Madhubani District Records, File Number Eighteen." "Then check it." "The records are here too?" "Every possible book written about Mithila is here. Possible copies of the records as well."

The old man pointed to another corridor. There, indeed, were dozens of versions of File Number Eighteen. In one, the ghat was mentioned; in another, it was not. In a third, the page was torn. In a fourth, the official's signature was different. In a fifth, the entire file concerned a subject that had nothing to do with the pond.

Ishan slowly closed the volume. Anger now rose in him more than fear. "Then nothing here is evidence." "I did not say that." "To keep every possible version and then say that something among them must be true—this is not evidence. It is noise." The old man smiled faintly. "There are many versions of that sentence here." Ishan's anger rose further. "I did not come here to hear jokes." "Nor did I."

They moved on. One room contained only titles: "Books That Could Have Been Written but Were Not." Another: "Books That Were Written but Did Not Survive." A third: "Things People Kept Saying but Never Wrote Down." Ishan stopped. On the last cupboard, in small letters, was written: "Authors Who Were More Certain Than Their Sources."

The old man said, "There are many of your books in this section."

Ishan did not reply. He pulled out a volume. Chapter Seven—"The Southern Quarter of Bisfi." In that chapter an elderly woman, Sharda Devi, said that her father had given thirty days of unpaid labour in the digging of a pond. Ishan remembered the statement. In the actual interview Sharda Devi had said, "I have heard that my father went too, but for how many days, I do not know." In his draft Ishan had written: "According to Sharda Devi, her father was forced into thirty consecutive days of unpaid labour." Where had the figure of thirty days

come from? Perhaps from an interview in another village. Perhaps while combining his notes.

He turned the page. In the next version it was fifteen days. In the third, seven. In the fourth there was no mention of unpaid labour at all. In the fifth, Sharda Devi's name had become Saraswati.

Ishan's anger suddenly gave way to fatigue. The library was not giving him wrong answers; it was enlarging the weakness in his certainty until he could see it.

"Do you make all these?" he asked the old man. "I wipe the dust from the bindings." "Then who makes them?" "The one who asks the question, perhaps. The one who writes, perhaps. The one who reads, perhaps. There are separate books here for all three answers."

Ishan fell silent. Somewhere in the distance came the sound of paper sliding. There was no clock, but he remembered his own time: Paush. The publisher. The advance. The creditors. The unfinished chapter.

"Show me my finished book," he said. The old man asked, "Which finished book?" "The one I will actually send." "That is still your work. Not the library's." For the first time Ishan laughed, though there was weariness in the laugh. "Then what use is there in all these possible books being here?"

The old man lifted one volume, then put it back. "Perhaps to understand that possibility and evidence are not the same thing." Ishan wanted to keep that sentence in his mind, then immediately grew wary—what if this too was only a beautiful sentence from one of the endless books? He looked at the old man. The old man was again wiping a binding with his cloth. As Ishan left, he turned to look back. The corridor did not seem as long as before. Perhaps the light had changed. Perhaps he himself was in a hurry. Before closing the door, his eyes fell on a thin volume: The Library of Mithila: A Story. He pulled the door shut before reading the author's name. The next day he sat in the ordinary reading room of the district archive. A fan rattled on the wall. An employee brought him three real files—one incomplete, one faded, and one without the information he wanted. For the first time Ishan was not irritated by these deficiencies. He listened again to the original recording of Sharda Devi's interview. Her sentence was clear: "For how many days, I do not know." Ishan crossed out "thirty days" in his draft. Then he rewrote the entire sentence: "Sharda Devi recalled a family memory connecting her father with labour in the digging of the pond, but she could not state the duration with certainty."

The sentence seemed less vivid than the earlier version. But on paper it felt more durable. By evening he had cut five pages. He marked off three beautiful episodes whose basis was only one person's retelling of another person's account. Returning home, he told Neelima, "The manuscript may not be finished by Paush." Neelima looked up from the account notebook. "Then?" "Then it will be late. I may have to return part of the advance." "And the book?"

Ishan thought for a moment. “It may be thinner.” Neelima bent back over the accounts. “A thinner book is lighter to carry.” Ishan smiled. He made no attempt to draw any philosophical meaning from the sentence. That night, at the end of his manuscript, he added a new page: “Where Sources Do Not Agree.” On that page he gave no verdict; he only recorded the differing statements, dates, memories, and the limits of the records. After that, for a long while, he did not think of the extraordinary library. Before him there were only three files, four audio notes, two old maps, and one unfinished question. For the first time, the insufficiency seemed enough.

FROM NEW WINGS

STORY 81

Life on Crutches

The morning sunlight was settling over the college grounds. An entrance examination for engineering was being held, and the gate was crowded with parents and students. Some checked their admit cards over and over, some counted their pens, and others repeated formulas one last time. A student on his way to the examination hall asked an employee standing near the noticeboard, “When will the college reopen after the summer holidays?”

Without raising his head, the employee said, “It’s written on the noticeboard. Read it.”

Hearing this brief exchange, two men standing in the shade of the veranda looked at each other and suddenly burst out laughing.

“Remember that, Gundev?” the first asked.

“How could I forget?” said the second. “He thought the noticeboard was his own forehead!”

They laughed again. Eighteen years of separation melted away in a moment. The first was Ratish; the second was Phool. They had studied together at school and college, after which life had carried them down different roads. Today, by coincidence, each had brought his son to this very college to take the entrance examination.

The examination would last three hours. Their sons went inside, leaving the two old friends three hours in which to open the doors of memory.

“Do you remember our reed pens?” Ratish asked.

Phool’s face lit up. “We used to dissolve ink tablets in hot water and put the mixture in inkpots. If the reed wasn’t cut properly, the letters came out badly.”

“Even then your handwriting was like flowers,” Ratish said.

“My very name was Phool—Flower. My handwriting had to live up to it!”

They laughed once more. Their school’s earthen courtyard, the walk to high school, science practical notebooks, examinations and results—all came back, one by one, in their conversation. Ratish had continued his studies and entered engineering. Phool had taken a job at the post office. Employment had been followed by marriage, family and transfers. Time had carried them so far apart that they had scarcely had a chance to meet.

“What news of your family after that?” Ratish asked. “I couldn’t even attend your wedding.”

Phool was silent for a little while. Looking towards the sunlit field before them, he said, “That isn’t a short story.”

His younger brother had been unable to use one hand fully since birth. He learned to write with the other hand, studied, took examinations and eventually found work in a government office. Phool said, "In our house we worried more about how people looked at him than about his hand. Some villagers addressed him by his bodily difference instead of his name. My brother would hear them and remain silent, but it hurt our mother."

"People often laugh at what they don't understand," Ratish said quietly.

"Yes," said Phool, "and sometimes pity can feel like an insult too. My younger brother used to say, 'Give me work, not sympathy.'"

A few years later Phool's mother went to stay with him. A Maithil family came to visit, and marriage came up in their conversation. Their daughter, too, walked with a slight limp because of a difference in the structure of her leg. Both families began by listing what they considered deficiencies in their children's bodies.

Phool laughed. "Mother said to me afterwards, 'What kind of way is that to proceed? Were we discussing a marriage between two capable human beings or keeping accounts of two bodies' defects?'"

Ratish grew serious.

"We discussed it again at home," Phool continued. "My younger brother said plainly, 'First I'll speak to her. If I am to marry, it will be a life partner I marry, not an object of pity.' The young woman said much the same: 'I want a husband, not a protector.' That was enough. The way towards their marriage opened."

They married. Both went on with their jobs, looked after their home, laughed, talked and built a life together. Difficulties came as well. For several years they could not have a child who survived. Relatives worried; there were visits to doctors; time passed between hope and disappointment. Phool told this part very slowly.

"One day my younger brother said to me," Phool recalled, "'Life doesn't give everyone the same measure. But whatever we are given, we must live it fully.'"

Many years later a son was born to them. There was such joy in the house that all the hard days seemed to recede. But the baby was very delicate. After a spell of severe cold, his health suddenly deteriorated, and he did not survive.

The smile vanished from Ratish's face. "That must have been terribly hard..."

Phool nodded. "Yes. But the strangest thing about grief is that it stays in the house, while every morning people must still get up and work. The post office opens, the bell rings at school, the hearth is lit. Life waits for no one."

After some time, his younger brother and sister-in-law gathered their lives together again. This time they had a son who grew up healthy, lively and fond of studying. Phool smiled. "Now he runs faster than any of us. He says he wants to be an engineer."

Ratish breathed a sigh of relief. "That is very good news."

Time moved slowly across the clock tower. Some people in the grounds were drinking tea, others reading newspapers or looking at their mobile phones. The two friends' conversation turned again to their own children.

"What does your son like to study?" Phool asked.

"He's very interested in mathematics. He takes machines apart and puts them back together. Sometimes two screws are left over, and he says, 'Those were extra!'" Ratish laughed.

"Then he has all the signs of a future engineer," said Phool.

"And your son?"

Phool paused a moment before answering. "He likes science too. But he enjoys asking questions more than taking examinations. He says, 'Before finding the right answer, you need to find the right question.'"

"He sounds like an intelligent boy," Ratish said with pleasure.

"Whether intelligent or stubborn, his results will tell," Phool laughed.

Just then the bell rang inside the examination building. The people waiting on the veranda all became alert. Some moved towards the gate, others stepped out of the shade. A few minutes later students began emerging in groups: delight on some faces, worry on others; some were arguing about the answers.

Ratish saw his son from a distance. He was coming out with his friends. Ratish raised a hand to signal to him. His son waved back, but remained there for a little while, caught up in a friend's question.

"Where is your son?" Ratish asked.

"Here he comes," Phool said, looking into the crowd.

A teenager appeared among the students. A bag hung from his back, perspiration covered his face, and his eyes shone. With crutches tucked under both arms he was moving forward swiftly. On the final step he stopped briefly, found his balance, then came smiling to stand before Phool.

"Babu, the questions were good," he said enthusiastically. "One mathematics problem took too long, but I solved it in the end. I'm unsure about one answer in physics."

There was such pride on Phool's face that Ratish could say nothing for a few moments. Only now did he understand that this was Phool's son.

Phool introduced them in his usual easy manner. "This is my old friend, your Ratish Kaka. We went to school together."

The boy greeted him respectfully. Ratish returned the greeting, but his eyes went involuntarily to the crutches. The boy noticed the glance, without any embarrassment showing on his face.

"Two years ago an accident badly damaged the nerves in his leg," Phool said calmly, as though talking about the weather. "He underwent a great deal of treatment. Now he walks with crutches. The doctors say further improvement may still be possible."

The boy interrupted with a laugh. “But engineering problems have to be solved with my head, not my legs.”

Ratish laughed too. “Well said!”

The boy took out his question paper and began showing it to Phool. “Look here. At first I went in the wrong direction. Then, in the final five minutes, I understood.”

Phool bent over the paper with complete attention. There was neither excessive anxiety nor affected pity in his manner: only a father listening to his son talk about an examination.

The stories Phool had told earlier passed together through Ratish’s mind: a younger brother with limited use of one hand, a sister-in-law whose leg was different, a family’s apprehensions, the scrutiny of others, the untimely death of a child, and then the birth of another, healthy child. And now Phool’s own son stood on crutches, dreaming of becoming an engineer.

For a moment Ratish felt that life was no straight line. One person had a strong body and a weary mind; another had weak legs and a fierce will. One person’s path was level, another’s full of steps. But the right to reach a destination belonged equally to all.

“Are you tired?” Phool asked his son.

“Not a bit. But I’m hungry.”

“Then food first, and the court of the question paper afterwards.”

Ratish’s son had arrived too. The four of them set off together towards the gate. Phool’s son placed his crutches ahead of him, lifted himself and took the next step. Each step demanded a little extra effort, but he did not slow down.

Near the gate a small child watched him curiously. Perhaps he had never seen crutches so close before. The teenager smiled at him. The child smiled back. The unspoken question came to an end.

“After telling me so much,” Ratish whispered in Phool’s ear, “why didn’t you mention your own son’s difficulty earlier?”

Phool looked at him in mild surprise, then replied, “Why would I? I was telling you about him: he likes science, asks questions, and wants to become an engineer. His crutches are one part of who he is, not his whole identity.”

Ratish said nothing. He had found the answer to his question.

The four began crossing the road. There was a restaurant ahead. The boys walked on, debating the examination, with Ratish and Phool behind them.

Ratish looked once more at the boy’s steps—crutches, feet, then crutches again—but the boy’s gaze was fixed on the far side of the road.

Then a sentence arose in Ratish’s mind: a life may be lived on crutches; a dream need not be.

STORY 82

The Book Saved in the Flood

It was the last week of Sawan. For three days the clouds had seemed to hang directly over the village. Rain fell night and day, and the river to the north began to leave its old banks and spread across the fields.

Ishan, a student in Class Eight, rose in the morning and looked out from the veranda. Water had reached ankle height in the courtyard. Bamboo leaves floated on its surface, and the voice of a calf came from the cowshed.

“Son, you won’t go to school today,” his mother told him. “The headmaster has sent word: the school stands on high ground, so people will shelter there if necessary.”

Ishan immediately thought of the village’s old library. On the way back from school he and his friends Arpita, Neeraj and Sonali often visited it. The building was old, but inside wooden cupboards held many books, handwritten pages, old magazines and records of the village.

An elderly man, Vidyabhushan Jha, cared for the library. All the village children called him Pothi Baba, the Book Grandfather. He used to say, “Books are not merely letters. They are people’s memory. If that memory drowns, the village forgets half its identity.”

“Will the water have reached Pothi Baba’s house?” Ishan asked his mother.

Looking out of the window, she replied, “There is more water in that neighbourhood. Don’t leave the house yet. Let the adults assess the situation first.”

A little later the panchayat bell rang. People assembled on the raised square. The river had overflowed the edge of the old pond and was advancing towards the southern neighbourhood. Two families had already taken their essential belongings and gone to the school.

There Ishan saw Arpita, Neeraj and Sonali. The same question was in all four pairs of eyes: what about the library?

Pothi Baba himself reached the square. His clothes were wet, he carried a bamboo staff, and worry was written on his face.

“The water has come up to the back of my house,” he said. “It may enter the lower room of the library. We have moved as much as we could onto the upper shelves, but some trunks are heavy.”

“What is in those trunks?” Arpita asked at once.

“The old village register, two handwritten books, and accounts of earlier floods,” Pothi Baba replied. “The oldest pages are probably more than a hundred years old.”

Neeraj's eyes widened. "Accounts of earlier floods? Might they say something about a flood like this?"

"They might," said Pothi Baba, "but this is not the time to read them. It is the time to save them."

The panchayat head declared that no teenager should go alone towards that neighbourhood. Two boats were prepared, one to carry people to safety, the other to fetch essential supplies.

Ishan's father was a boatman. Hearing the four friends' request, he said, "You may come with me, but you will follow my rules. Do exactly as I tell you. Water is not a game."

All four agreed. Rope, dry sacks, two wooden planks and thick cloth were put into the boat. Pothi Baba came with them.

The boat moved slowly through the flooded lane. Where bicycles had sped along only yesterday, water now shimmered. Only the tops of the bamboo fences could be seen. Here and there a courtyard stool floated past, or a bundle of paddy.

"The village looks as if someone has painted a different colour over a familiar picture," Sonali whispered.

"Floods change the shape of a village," Pothi Baba said, "but as long as people stay together, a village does not come to an end."

When they reached the library, they saw that the water had risen faster than expected. It was knee-deep on the veranda. The lower parts of the wooden furniture in the first room were already wet.

Ishan's father showed everyone where to stand. One end of the rope was tied to the neem tree outside, and the other was taken indoors.

Pothi Baba took out a key and opened the inner room. Old pictures hung on the walls, and books wrapped in cloth lay on the shelves. Near the floor stood a heavy wooden trunk, whose bottom the water was beginning to touch.

"The register is in this one," Pothi Baba said.

Neeraj and Ishan tried to lift the trunk, but it did not move. Inside were metal vessels and heavy books.

"It'll be hard to lift," Arpita said, looking around. "We could raise it onto the planks and slide it."

"That is why I brought the planks," Ishan's father said with a smile.

The two planks were pushed slowly beneath the trunk. Rope was fastened around it. Two people pulled from outside while Ishan and Neeraj pushed from within. Sonali and Arpita wrapped the wet books separately in cloth and kept putting them on higher shelves.

At one point the trunk jammed. The water rose a little more. Ishan's foot slipped, but he held on to the rope. His father immediately grasped his shoulder and steadied him.

"Carefully," his father said. "Save the books, but no book is worth more than your life."

Ishan nodded. Everyone resumed their positions. This time the trunk climbed onto the planks. The rope tightened, and slowly the trunk came out onto the veranda.

After the trunk had been placed in the boat, Pothi Baba drew a long breath. But his eyes stopped at a corner inside the room.

"There used to be a book wrapped in red cloth," he said, "beneath the shelf."

Arpita moved the beam of her torch around the room. In one corner she saw a piece of red cloth half-submerged in the water. She reached for it, but it was too far away.

Sonali held out the bamboo staff. Arpita caught the cloth with its tip and pulled it towards her. Inside lay a thick, wet manuscript. Some pages at the edges were soaked, but the middle was safe.

Pothi Baba's eyes filled with tears. "My great-grandfather wrote this account of floods. It records which year the water reached which places in this village, which ponds filled, which banks broke—everything."

"Then it isn't just an old story," Ishan asked. "It could also be a guide for the future?"

"You understand it well," Pothi Baba said. "Sometimes the memory of the past protects the future."

The boat returned towards the school. The rain had slackened a little. People had already spread mats across the school veranda. One room had been left empty for dry supplies. The books were laid out there.

Arpita suggested that they should not try to separate the wet pages all at once. The school science teacher was there too. "We must be patient," he said. "The pages could tear if we pull them apart. First absorb the excess water with clean, dry cloth, then let them dry in an airy place out of direct sunlight."

The four friends worked for hours. Some pages carried names from genealogies, others old field boundaries, songs or descriptions of high-water marks from past floods.

Reading a page, Neeraj stopped. "It says that during an old flood the water reached the roots of the peepal tree. That tree is near the panchayat office now, isn't it?"

"Yes," said Pothi Baba. "Yesterday the water was two handspans below those roots. By now it may be almost level with them."

Ishan's father told the panchayat head. People immediately went to inspect the water level at the peepal tree and compared it with the old account. The residents of houses on low ground were brought to the school without delay.

By evening the water had risen still further, but all the village families had reached safety. That night lamps burned on the school veranda. Outside was the

floodwater; inside were quiet conversations, children's laughter, the clatter of utensils, and in one room the drying pages of books.

"I thought we were saving the books," Sonali said softly. "But the books were saving us too."

No one needed to answer. The four friends looked towards Pothi Baba. He was smiling silently.

Three days later the river began to recede. People went back to their homes. A dark waterline remained on the library walls, but most of the collection had survived.

The village's young people decided that books would no longer be stored near the ground. With the panchayat's help, high wooden shelves were built in the library. Copies were made of important pages, and a list was prepared showing where every book was kept and who was responsible for it.

Ishan and Neeraj read Pothi Baba's old flood account and began marking historic high-water levels on a village map. Arpita and Sonali listened to the elders' memories of earlier floods and wrote them down.

A small exhibition called "Our Village's Water Memory" was held at the school. It displayed not only pictures but also years, water levels, safe places, old drains, raised paths and the experiences of local people.

"Preserving writing does not simply mean keeping books dry," Pothi Baba said at the opening. "It also means understanding what they contain and putting that knowledge to use in life."

Ishan was placing the red-wrapped manuscript in a new, dry cover. Some of its outer pages still bore the stains of the flood.

"Won't those stains come off?" Arpita asked.

"Let them remain," Pothi Baba replied. "Some stains do more than mark damage; they also keep memory alive."

Outside the window, the river had returned to its course. Sunshine glittered on the water. On the library's new high shelves, the books stood in orderly rows.

Ishan gently closed the red manuscript. He understood that on that day, in the flood, more than a single book had been saved. The village's old memory had passed into the hands of a new generation.

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